

# The Odyssey

*a line-for-line translation*

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FROM THE GREEK OF

Homer

TRANSLATED BY

Claude (Fable 5)

EDITED AND PRODUCED BY

Chris Duffy

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The text of this edition, in digital form, is at [theclaudyssey.com](http://theclaudyssey.com).

ἄνδρα μοι ἔννεπε, μοῦσα, πολύτροπον

*Tell me the man, Muse — the man of many turnings*

## A NOTE ON THE TEXT

The Greek is A. T. Murray's text from the Loeb Classical Library edition of 1919, as digitized by the Perseus Digital Library from the polytonic vulgate. The English translation is original to this project; each of the 12,107 English lines is keyed one-to-one to its Greek line, so a citation to the Greek finds the same line here.

Line numbers are printed in the margin every fifth line. Where a verse runs past the measure of the page, the continuation is indented, so an indented line is always the tail of the verse above it and never a new verse.

The scholarly apparatus — 1,260 notes across the poem — is printed as endnotes at the close of each book. A raised numeral in the verse marks a note; the notes are numbered through each book, and each note also gives the line it belongs to (*l.* 337), which is how it should be cited.

Two quirks of Murray's text are kept faithfully. Lines 3.304–305 and 14.63–64 are printed in the transposed order he gives them, with the traditional numbering retained. Lines 10.456, 16.101, and 23.49, which he athetizes as interpolations, are absent, and the numbering skips them.

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## Odyssey — Book 1

*Athena comes to Ithaca; Telemachus resolves to seek his father.*

- Tell me the man, Muse — the man of many turnings, who was driven<sup>1</sup>  
 wandering far, once he had sacked Troy's holy citadel:  
 many were the cities of men he saw, and he learned their minds,  
 many the griefs he suffered at heart on the open sea,  
 5 striving to win his own life and his companions' homecoming.  
 Even so he could not save them, hard though he strove:  
 they perished by their own recklessness,  
 fools, who ate the cattle of Helios Hyperion,  
 and the god took from them their day of homecoming.  
 10 Begin where you will, goddess, daughter of Zeus — tell us, too, the tale.<sup>2</sup>
- By then all the others, all who had escaped sheer ruin,  
 were home, safely past the war and past the sea.  
 Him alone — aching for homecoming and his wife —  
 the queenly nymph Calypso, shining among goddesses, held back<sup>3</sup>  
 15 in her hollow caves, hungry to make him her husband.  
 But when the year came, in the wheeling round of seasons,  
 in which the gods had spun the thread of his return home  
 to Ithaca — not even there was he free of trials,  
 even among his own. And the gods pitied him,  
 20 all but Poseidon: he raged without rest  
 against godlike Odysseus, until the day he reached his own land.
- But now Poseidon was gone among the far-off Ethiopians —  
 the Ethiopians, sundered in two, remotest of mankind,  
 half where Hyperion sets and half where he rises —  
 25 to receive a hecatomb of bulls and rams,  
 and there he sat at the feast, delighting. But the other gods  
 were gathered together in the halls of Olympian Zeus,  
 and among them the father of men and gods began to speak,  
 for his heart was remembering blameless Aegisthus,<sup>4</sup>  
 30 whom Agamemnon's son, far-famed Orestes, killed.  
 Remembering him, he spoke among the immortals:

"Shameful! — how mortals lay their blame upon the gods.  
 From us, they say, all evils come — while they themselves,  
 by their own recklessness, earn griefs beyond their portion:<sup>5</sup>  
 35 as Aegisthus now, beyond his portion, took to wife  
 the wedded bride of Atreus' son, and killed the man at his  
 homecoming,  
 knowing it meant sheer ruin — for we told him beforehand,  
 sending Hermes down, the sharp-eyed slayer of Argus,<sup>6</sup>  
 not to kill the man and not to court his wife:  
 40 for vengeance for the son of Atreus would come from Orestes  
 the day he came of age and longed for his own land.  
 So Hermes spoke, meaning him well — but the mind of Aegisthus  
 he could not turn. Now he has paid for everything at once."

Then the goddess answered him, gray-eyed Athena:<sup>7</sup>  
 45 "Father of us all, son of Cronos, highest of the mighty,  
 that man, yes, lies in a ruin he richly earned —  
 so may any other perish who does such things.  
 But my heart is on fire for battle-wise Odysseus,<sup>8</sup>  
 ill-starred man, who far from his own people suffers long  
 50 on a sea-ringed island, at the navel of the sea.  
 A wooded island; a goddess has her dwelling there,  
 the daughter of Atlas the deadly-minded, he who knows  
 the depths of every sea, and himself grips the pillars,  
 the tall ones, that hold earth and heaven apart.  
 55 It is his daughter who keeps that broken, grieving man,  
 and always with soft words, with winding, coaxing words,  
 she charms him to forget Ithaca. But Odysseus,  
 who would be glad to see even the smoke go leaping up  
 from his own country, aches to die. And your heart  
 60 does not turn for it, Olympian. Did Odysseus never  
 please you, offering sacrifice beside the Argive ships  
 in wide Troy? Why so at odds with Odysseus, Zeus?"<sup>9</sup>

Then Zeus who gathers the clouds answered her:  
 "My child, what a word has slipped the fence of your teeth!<sup>10</sup>  
 65 How could I ever forget godlike Odysseus,  
 who is beyond all mortals in mind, and beyond all others gave



- offerings to the deathless gods who hold wide heaven?  
 No: it is Poseidon who holds the earth, in anger  
 unbending, always, for the Cyclops, whose one eye Odysseus blinded —  
 70 godlike Polyphemus, whose power is greatest  
 among all the Cyclopes. The nymph Thoösa bore him,  
 daughter of Phorcys, a lord of the barren salt sea,  
 when in her hollow caves she lay with Poseidon.  
 Ever since, Poseidon the shaker of earth does not kill  
 75 Odysseus, but drives him wandering from his father's land.  
 But come, let all of us here take careful thought together  
 for his homecoming — how he shall come. Poseidon will let go  
 his anger. He cannot, against us all,  
 wrangle alone in the teeth of the deathless gods."
- 80 Then the goddess answered him, gray-eyed Athena:  
 "Father of us all, son of Cronos, highest of the mighty,  
 if this now truly pleases the blessed gods,  
 that Odysseus of the many designs come home to his own house,  
 then let us dispatch Hermes, the guide, the slayer of Argus,  
 85 to the island Ogygia, so that with all speed  
 he may tell the nymph of the lovely braids our fixed decree:  
 the homecoming of enduring-hearted Odysseus — that he shall return.  
 And I will go to Ithaca, to stir his son  
 the more, and set strength of purpose in his heart  
 90 to call the long-haired Achaeans into assembly  
 and speak out to all the suitors, who day upon day  
 slaughter his thronging flocks and his shambling crook-horned cattle.<sup>11</sup>  
 And I will send him to Sparta and to sandy Pylos  
 to ask after his dear father's homecoming, if he may hear of it —  
 95 and so that good report among men may be his."
- So she spoke, and bound beneath her feet the beautiful sandals,  
 ambrosial, golden, that carry her over the water  
 and over the boundless earth with the breath of the wind;  
 and she took up her strong spear, edged with sharp bronze,  
 100 heavy, huge, and solid, with which she breaks the ranks of men,  
 of heroes, when the daughter of the mighty Father is angered.  
 Down she went, darting from the peaks of Olympus,

and stood in the land of Ithaca at Odysseus' doorway,  
 on the courtyard's threshold, the bronze spear in her palm,  
 105 in the likeness of a stranger: Mentes, leader of the Taphians.<sup>12</sup>

There she found the lordly suitors. They were pleasing  
 their hearts with counters, out in front of the doors,<sup>13</sup>  
 sitting on hides of oxen they themselves had slaughtered,  
 with heralds and quick serving-men among them:  
 110 some were mixing wine and water in the great bowls,  
 and some were wiping the tables down with porous sponges  
 and setting them out, and some carved meat in plenty.

Godlike Telemachus saw her far the first,  
 for he sat among the suitors, sore at heart,  
 115 seeing his noble father in his mind's eye: if only he would come  
 from somewhere, and make a scattering of the suitors through the  
 house,  
 and take back his honor, and be lord of his own possessions.  
 So he brooded, sitting among the suitors — and he saw Athena.

He went straight for the porch, indignant at heart  
 120 that a stranger be left standing at the door; and standing near her  
 he took her right hand, and relieved her of the bronze spear,  
 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to her:<sup>14</sup>  
 "Welcome, stranger. Here you will find kindness — and afterward,  
 when you have tasted supper, you shall tell us what you need."  
 125 So saying he led the way, and Pallas Athena followed.

And when they were inside the high-roofed house,  
 he carried the spear to the tall pillar and set it upright  
 inside the polished spear-rack, where already other  
 spears stood in numbers, enduring-hearted Odysseus' own;  
 130 and he led her to a high seat, spreading linen beneath her,  
 a beautiful seat, cunningly worked, with a footstool for her feet.  
 For himself he set a painted bench beside her, apart from the others,  
 the suitors, for fear the stranger, sickened by the din,  
 might lose all taste for supper, fallen among bullies —  
 135 and so that he might ask him about his absent father.  
 A handmaid brought water for their hands in a pitcher,<sup>15</sup>

a beautiful golden one, and poured it over a silver basin  
 for them to wash, and drew up a polished table beside them.  
 The grave housekeeper brought bread and set it before them,  
 140 laying out delicacies in plenty, giving gladly of her store;  
 a carver lifted platters of meat of every kind  
 and set them down, and placed gold cups beside them,  
 and a herald kept coming round to them, pouring the wine.

In came the lordly suitors, and they took their seats  
 145 in order on the benches and the high-backed chairs.  
 Heralds poured water over their hands,  
 slave-women heaped bread in baskets at their sides,<sup>16</sup>  
 and young men crowned the mixing-bowls with drink,  
 and their hands went out to the good things spread before them.  
 150 But when they had put away desire for food and drink,  
 the suitors — other things now filled their hearts:  
 song and dance, for these are the ornaments of a feast.  
 A herald put the beautiful lyre into the hands  
 of Phemius, who sang for the suitors under compulsion,<sup>17</sup>  
 155 and he swept the strings and struck up his lovely singing.

But Telemachus spoke to gray-eyed Athena,  
 leaning his head close, so that the others might not hear:  
 "Dear stranger, will you take offense at what I say?  
 These men care only for such things — the lyre and song —  
 160 and easily, since unpunished they devour another man's living:  
 a man whose white bones rot somewhere in the rain,  
 lying on a mainland shore, or the salt wave rolls them.  
 But if they saw him once come home to Ithaca,  
 every man of them would pray to be quicker on his feet  
 165 rather than richer in gold and fine clothes.  
 But no — he has perished by an evil doom, and for us there is  
 no comfort left, not though some man upon the earth  
 should say he is coming still: his day of homecoming is lost.  
 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:  
 170 What man are you, and from where? Where are your city and your  
 parents?<sup>18</sup>  
 On what kind of ship did you come? And how did sailors

- bring you to Ithaca? Who did they claim to be?  
 For I hardly think you came here on foot.  
 And tell me this too, honestly, so that I may know it:  
 175 is this your first coming here, or are you from of old  
 my father's guest-friend? For many were the men who came  
 to our house — since he, too, went much among mankind."
- Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-eyed Athena:  
 "Then I will tell you all of it, and truly.  
 180 I declare myself Mentès, son of wise Anchialus,  
 and I am lord of the oar-loving Taphians.  
 Now I have put in here with my ship and my companions,  
 sailing the wine-dark sea toward men of alien speech,  
 to Temese, after copper; the cargo I carry is gleaming iron.<sup>19</sup>  
 185 My ship stands off in the fields, away from the city,  
 in the harbor of Rheithron, under wooded Neion.  
 Guest-friends of each other's houses we declare ourselves  
 from the beginning — only go and ask the old man,  
 the hero Laertes, who they say comes no more  
 190 to the city, but far out in the fields endures his sorrows  
 with one old serving-woman, who sets his food and drink  
 before him whenever weariness takes hold of his limbs  
 as he creeps along the rise of his terraced vineyard.  
 And now I have come. They said he was here among his people —  
 195 your father. But no: the gods are thwarting his road.  
 For noble Odysseus has not yet died anywhere on earth;  
 he lives still, held back somewhere on the wide sea,  
 on a sea-ringed island, and hard men have him,  
 savages, who hold him there, I think, against his will.  
 200 And now I will prophesy to you, as the immortals  
 cast it into my heart, and as I believe it will be —  
 though I am no prophet, no sure reader of birds.  
 He will not now be long away from his own dear country,  
 no, not if iron chains should hold him:  
 205 he will find a way to come home, for he is a man of many devices.  
 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:  
 whether you, grown so tall, are the son of Odysseus himself.  
 The likeness is uncanny — the head, the fine eyes.

We were often in each other's company, he and I,  
 210 before he went up into Troy, where the others also,  
 the best of the Argives, went in the hollow ships.  
 Since that day I have not seen Odysseus, nor he me."

Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:<sup>20</sup>  
 "Then I will tell you, stranger, all of it, and truly.  
 215 My mother says I am his. For myself, I cannot know:  
 no man yet has been witness to his own begetting.<sup>21</sup>  
 Would that I had been the son of some blessed man  
 whom old age overtook among his own possessions!  
 Instead, the man born unluckiest of mortal men —  
 220 his son, they say, I am. Since you ask me this."

Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-eyed Athena:  
 "The gods have not appointed your line to be nameless  
 in time to come: Penelope has borne too fine a son.  
 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:  
 225 What feast is this, what gathering? What is your part in it?  
 A banquet? A wedding? For plainly no man here brought his own  
 share:<sup>22</sup>  
 so overweening, so past all bounds they seem to me,  
 feasting through the house. A man would burn with anger,  
 seeing shame upon shame — any man of sense who entered."

230 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:  
 "Stranger — since you ask me this and press the question —  
 there was a time this house promised to be rich and honored,  
 while that man was still here among his people.  
 Now the gods have willed otherwise, plotting evil:  
 235 they have made him vanish as no other man has vanished,  
 no man on earth. For I would not grieve so even for his death  
 had he gone down among his companions in the Trojans' country,  
 or in the arms of his friends, once he had wound the war to its end.  
 Then the whole Achaean people would have built him a tomb,  
 240 and he would have won great fame in time to come for his son as well.  
 Instead the whirlwinds have snatched him away without glory;<sup>23</sup>  
 he is gone — unseen, unheard-of — and to me he has left  
 anguish and lament. Nor is he all I have to mourn

- and groan for: the gods have made me other bitter cares.  
 245 All the great men who hold power among the islands —  
 Dulichium and Same and wooded Zacynthus —  
 and all who lord it through rocky Ithaca:  
 so many woo my mother, and wear this house away.  
 And she neither refuses the marriage she loathes, nor can she  
 250 bring it to an end. And they eat on, wasting  
 my house. Soon they will tear me to pieces too."
- Then, stung to anger, Pallas Athena spoke to him:  
 "Shame on it! Great indeed is your need of the vanished Odysseus,  
 to lay his two hands on these shameless suitors.  
 255 If only he came now and stood at the outer doors  
 of the house, with helmet and shield and a pair of spears,  
 the man he was the first time I set eyes on him  
 in our own house, drinking and glad at heart,  
 up from Ephyra, from Ilus son of Mermerus —  
 260 for Odysseus went there too, in his fast ship,  
 in search of a man-killing poison, so he might have it  
 to smear on his bronze-shod arrows. Ilus would not<sup>24</sup>  
 give it, for he feared the undying gods' displeasure;  
 but my father gave it him, for he loved him terribly —  
 265 the man he was then! Let that Odysseus close with the suitors:  
 quick would their fates be then, and bitter their weddings.  
 But surely these things lie on the knees of the gods:<sup>25</sup>  
 whether he comes home and takes repayment, or does not,  
 here in his own halls. As for you, I charge you: consider  
 270 how you will thrust the suitors from the hall.  
 Come then, mark me now, and take my words to heart.  
 Tomorrow call the Achaean heroes into assembly  
 and speak your word to all, and let the gods stand witness.  
 Command the suitors to scatter, each to his own,  
 275 and your mother — if her heart is stirred toward marriage,  
 let her go back to the hall of her father, that powerful man:  
 there they will make the marriage and set out the bride-gifts,  
 very many, all that should follow a beloved child.  
 To you yourself my advice is close and shrewd, if you will hear it.  
 280 Man a ship with twenty oars, the best there is,

- and go out asking after your long-gone father.  
 Some mortal man may tell you — or you may hear the Rumor  
 that comes from Zeus, which most of all carries word among men.<sup>26</sup>  
 Go first to Pylos, and question noble Nestor;  
 285 from there to Sparta, to fair-haired Menelaus,  
 for of the bronze-shirted Achaeans he came home last.  
 If you hear your father is alive and homeward bound,  
 then, ground down as you are, hold out one more year.  
 But if you hear that he is dead, that he is no more,  
 290 then come back to your own dear fatherland  
 and heap his burial mound, and over it pay the death-rites,  
 very many, as is fitting, and give your mother to a husband.  
 Then, when you have made an end of all this and done it,  
 take counsel in your mind and in your heart  
 295 how in your halls you are to kill the suitors,  
 whether by guile or in the open. It is no longer for you<sup>27</sup>  
 to hold to childish things: you are past that age.  
 Or have you not heard what fame noble Orestes took<sup>28</sup>  
 among all mankind, when he killed his father's killer,  
 300 Aegisthus of the crooked counsels, who cut down his famous father?  
 You too, my friend — and I see how tall and fine you are —  
 be brave, so that men not yet born will speak well of you.  
 But now I will go down to my fast ship  
 and my companions, who I think grow restless with waiting.  
 305 Let this be your own care. Take my words to heart."
- Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:  
 "Stranger, you say these things out of a kind heart,  
 as a father to his son, and I will never forget them.  
 But come now, stay a while, though you are eager for the road,  
 310 so that bathed first, your own heart gladdened,  
 you may go to your ship with a gift, rejoicing in spirit —  
 a costly thing, and beautiful, to be your treasure  
 from me: such things as dear guest-friends give their guests."
- Then the goddess answered him, gray-eyed Athena:  
 315 "Hold me back no longer; I long for the road.  
 The gift — whatever your own heart bids you give me —

give it when I come again, for carrying home,  
and choose one truly beautiful. It will bring you its match in return."

So gray-eyed Athena spoke, and she was gone,  
320 flown up and away like a bird. And in his heart<sup>29</sup>  
she had set strength and courage, and brought his father to his mind  
more even than before. And when he sensed it in his mind,  
he was awed at heart, for he guessed she was a god.  
And at once he went back among the suitors, a man like a god himself.

325 For them the famous singer was singing, and they in silence  
sat and listened. He sang the Achaeans' homecoming,  
the bitter one, that Pallas Athena laid on them out of Troy.

From her upper room she took into her heart the god-filled song:  
Icarius' daughter, watchful-minded Penelope.<sup>30</sup>

330 She came down the steep stairway of her house,  
not alone: two handmaids came attending her.  
And when she reached the suitors, shining among women,  
she stood beside the pillar of the close-built roof,  
holding her glistening veil before her cheeks,  
335 a trusted handmaid standing on either side,  
and in tears she spoke to the godlike singer:  
"Phemius, you know many other spells for mortal ears,<sup>31</sup>  
deeds of men and gods, that singers make renowned.  
Sit and sing them one of those, and let them drink  
340 their wine in silence. But break off this song,  
this bitter song that forever wears away the heart  
in my breast — for on me above all has fallen grief past forgetting.  
So dear a face I long for, remembering always,  
the man whose fame goes wide through Hellas and the heart of Argos."

345 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:  
"Mother, why grudge the trusted singer his right  
to please us however his mind is moved? Singers are not  
to blame: Zeus, surely, is to blame, who gives  
to men who eat bread whatever he wills, to each man singly.  
350 There is no fault in him for singing the Danaans' hard doom:  
men will always give their louder praise to the song<sup>32</sup>



- that comes to its hearers newest on the air.  
 Let your heart and spirit steel themselves to hear it.  
 Odysseus was not the only one to lose his day of homecoming  
 355 at Troy: many other men were lost as well.  
 Go into the house and see to your own work,  
 the loom and the distaff, and command your handmaids  
 to go about their work. The word belongs to men —<sup>33</sup>  
 to all men, and to me above all: mine is the power in this house."
- 360 In wonder, she went back into the house,  
 for she laid her son's clear-headed word to heart.  
 Climbing to her upper room with her serving-women,  
 she wept there for Odysseus, her dear husband, until  
 gray-eyed Athena cast sweet sleep upon her eyelids.
- 365 But the suitors broke into uproar through the shadowy halls,  
 and every man of them prayed to lie beside her in bed.  
 And clear-headed Telemachus began to speak among them:  
 "Suitors of my mother, insolent past all bearing,  
 for now let us feast and take our pleasure — but with no more  
 370 shouting, since it is a fine thing to listen to a singer  
 such as this man is, with a voice like the gods'.  
 But at dawn let us go and take our seats in assembly,  
 all of us, so I may declare my word to you outright:  
 get out of my halls. Go busy yourselves with other feasts,  
 375 eating your own goods, moving from house to house.  
 But if this seems to you the better thing, the more profitable,  
 that one man's living be destroyed and nothing paid,  
 then carve away. And I will cry to the gods who live forever,  
 in hope that Zeus may grant deeds of requital come to pass:  
 380 then you would die inside this house, and nothing paid for you."
- So he spoke, and all of them bit hard into their lips,  
 marveling at Telemachus, that he spoke so boldly.  
 Then Antinous spoke to him, Eupeithes' son:<sup>34</sup>  
 "Telemachus, surely the gods themselves are teaching you  
 385 to talk so high and speak with so much daring.  
 May the son of Cronos never make you king in sea-circled  
 Ithaca — though by blood it is your inheritance."<sup>35</sup>

Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:

"Antinous, will you take offense at what I say?

- 390 Even that I would be willing to take, if Zeus should give it.  
Do you say kingship is the worst thing that can befall a man?  
It is no bad thing to be king: at once a man's house  
grows rich, and the man himself more honored.  
But there are other kings enough among the Achaeans  
395 in sea-circled Ithaca, young men and old:  
let one of them have it, since noble Odysseus is dead.  
But I will be lord of our own house  
and of the slaves that noble Odysseus won for me."

Then Eurymachus, Polybus' son, answered him:

- 400 "Telemachus, truly these things lie on the knees of the gods:  
which of the Achaeans will be king in sea-circled Ithaca.  
Your goods you may keep, and be lord in your own house;  
may the man never come who would strip your goods from you  
by force, against your will, while Ithaca is yet lived in.  
405 But I would ask you, best of men, about the stranger:  
where does that man come from? What country does he claim  
for his own? Where are his kin, the plowlands of his fathers?  
Does he bring some message of your father's coming,  
or did he arrive here pressing a need of his own?  
410 How he leapt up and vanished in a moment! He did not wait  
to be known — and yet his face was in no way base."

Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:

"Eurymachus, my father's homecoming is lost.

- I put no more trust in messages, wherever they come from,  
415 nor give heed to any prophecy my mother  
may seek, calling some diviner into the hall.  
As for the stranger — a guest-friend of my father's house, from Taphos;  
he declares himself Mentès, son of wise Anchialus,  
and he is lord of the oar-loving Taphians."  
420 So spoke Telemachus. But in his heart he knew the deathless goddess.

And they turned to dancing and the loveliness of song  
and took their pleasure, and waited for evening to come on;  
and while they took their pleasure the black evening came.

Then they went home to bed, each man to his own house.

- 425 But Telemachus — where his bedroom was built high  
off the beautiful courtyard, in a place with a clear view all around —  
went up to bed, turning many things over in his mind.  
Beside him, bearing blazing torches, walked one whose thoughts were  
loyal:  
Eurycleia, daughter of Ops, Peisenor's son.
- 430 Laertes had bought her long ago with his own goods,  
when she was still in her first youth, at the price of twenty oxen,<sup>36</sup>  
and honored her in his halls as he honored his faithful wife —  
but never took her to his bed: he shunned his wife's anger.  
She it was who carried the blazing torches beside him, and of all
- 435 the house-slaves she loved him most: she had nursed him when he was  
small.  
He opened the doors of the close-built room,  
sat down on the bed, and pulled his soft tunic off,  
and dropped it into the shrewd old woman's hands.  
She folded the tunic and smoothed it out,
- 440 hung it on a peg beside the corded bedstead,  
and went out of the room, drawing the door shut  
by its silver handle, and slid the bolt home with its strap.  
There all night long, wrapped in the choice fleece of the sheep,  
he pondered in his heart the road Athena had shown him.

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 1

- 1 l. 1 πολύτροπον (*polytrophon*), the poem's first epithet for its still-unnamed hero, means both "of many turnings" — much-traveled, much-buffedet — and "of many turns" — wily, shifty, hard to pin. Translators usually must pick one; "the man of many turnings" is an attempt to keep the road and the mind inside a single word, as the Greek does. The man himself is not named until line 21.
- 2 l. 10 ἀμόθεν, "from somewhere in these things": the poet asks the Muse to choose the entry point, and she chooses the end — the story opens in the tenth year of wandering, with everything prior delivered later in flashback. This line is the poem's license for its in-medias-res structure.
- 3 l. 14 Calypso's name is transparent in Greek: καλύπτειν means "to cover, to conceal." The Concealer holds Odysseus in a hidden place off every map — which is why the gods' plan must begin with simply locating him.
- 4 l. 29 "Blameless Aegisthus" is a famous scandal: Aegisthus is an adulterer and a murderer, yet he receives the honorific epithet ἀμύμων. In oral verse, epithets belong to names and meter, not to moral bookkeeping. I keep the collision rather than smooth it away.
- 5 l. 34 "By their own recklessness" (σφῆσιν ἀτασθαλίῃσιν) repeats exactly the phrase used of Odysseus' crew in line 7. The first speech of the poem is a theodicy — Zeus insists mortals earn ruin "beyond their portion" — and the proem has already offered the crew as Exhibit A. The poem states its moral frame twice in its first forty lines.
- 6 l. 38 ἀργεῖφόντης, traditionally "slayer of Argus" (the hundred-eyed watchman set over Io), though the word was already opaque in antiquity; "shining one" has also been proposed. I keep the traditional story.
- 7 l. 44 γλαυκῶπις, rendered "gray-eyed" throughout: the word hovers between "gleaming-eyed" and "owl-eyed" (γλαύξ is the little owl, Athena's bird). It is her fixed formula, and I keep it fixed — in this translation the recurring formulas recur verbatim, because the repetitions are the poem's architecture, not padding to be varied away.
- 8 l. 48 The Greek plays sound against sense: δαῖφρονι δαίεται — "for battle-wise (*daiphron*) Odysseus my heart is kindled (*daietai*)." "My heart is on fire for battle-wise Odysseus" keeps at least the heat and the pairing.
- 9 l. 62 An untranslatable pun, and a load-bearing one: ὠδύσσο ("you are filled with wrath against") echoes Ὀδυσσεύς. His grandfather Autolycus names him from this verb at 19.407–409 — the man of wrath, given and received. "At odds with Odysseus" is my shadow of it.
- 10 l. 64 "The fence of your teeth" (ἔρκος ὀδόντων) is formulaic: words are imagined as living things that escape past a barrier and cannot be called back.

- 11 l. 92 Both epithets of the cattle — εἰλίποδας ("rolling-footed"? "shambling"? ) and ἔλικας ("crumple-horned"? "black"? ) — were already disputed in antiquity. "Shambling crook-horned" follows the traditional guesses.
- 12 l. 105 Mentes of Taphos is Athena's first disguise; in Book 2 she takes the near-twin name Mentor. The Taphians were known as seafarers and slave-raiders — a plausibly worldly guest for her purposes.
- 13 l. 107 πεσσοί: a board game played with stones, "counters." The suitors' idleness is staged before any of them says a word.
- 14 l. 122 ἔπεα πτερόεντα, "winged words," kept in its traditional form: the formula marks direct speech launched at a hearer, and it will recur throughout the poem.
- 15 l. 136 Lines 136–143 are a hospitality *type-scene* — pitcher, silver basin, bread, carved meat, circulating wine — recurring nearly verbatim across the poem. Guest-friendship (*xenia*) is the Odyssey's central social institution and its central test; the scene's formality is the point, so I translate it formally each time it returns.
- 16 l. 147 δμῳαί I render "slave-women," and δμῶες "slaves," here and throughout: the Homeric great house runs on chattel slavery, and softer conventions ("maids," "servants") hide it. ἀμφίπολος, an attendant of vaguer status, I render "handmaid." Eurycleia's purchase price is given at 430–431.
- 17 l. 154 ἀνάγκη, "under compulsion": Phemius sings for the suitors because he must. The poem remembers this detail — in Book 22 he pleads for his life on exactly this ground, and is spared.
- 18 l. 170 "What man are you, and from where?" — the formal interrogation owed to a stranger *after* he has been fed, never before. Telemachus performs *xenia* in the correct order; the suitors, by contrast, never earn a single meal they eat.
- 19 l. 184 Temese, a copper port, was placed by ancient readers variously in Cyprus or southern Italy; nobody knows. The trade run — iron out, copper in — is a rare glimpse of the poet's own Iron Age poking through the poem's Bronze Age setting.
- 20 l. 213 πεπνυμένος, "clear-headed" — Telemachus' fixed epithet, recurring in the same answering formula seven times in this book alone. The word suggests sense, discretion, breath under control: the quality the Telemachy will test.
- 21 l. 216 Telemachus' first characteristic utterance — wry, guarded, a little bitter. The coming books are the story of this speaker growing into his father's plainer confidence.
- 22 l. 226 Athena runs through the recognized categories of feast: εἰλαπίνη (a great banquet), γάμος (a wedding feast), ἔρανος (a meal to which every guest contributes a share). The barb hides in the third: whatever this is, no one here is paying his share.
- 23 l. 241 ἄρπυιαι, "whirlwinds" — snatching storm-spirits, the later Harpies. To vanish at sea is to die without tomb and therefore without κλέος, fame: this is why Telemachus says outright that a battlefield death would have been a comfort.
- 24 l. 262 A startling detail, unique in Homer: Odysseus once traveled abroad seeking poison for his arrowheads, and the pious Ilus refused him. The story arrives casually, in a stranger's reminiscence — and quietly foreshadows the bow, and the arrows, of Book 22.

- 25 l. 267 "On the knees of the gods": a formula for what is undecided. Eurymachus will hand the same phrase back at line 400 — an irony, since a god is standing in the room deciding it.
- 26 l. 283 ῥῶσα is Rumor personified: news that travels with no visible carrier and is therefore assumed to come from Zeus.
- 27 l. 296 The plot of the poem's second half — killing the suitors "by guile or in the open" — is stated here for the first time, and by Athena. The revenge is a divine assignment before it is ever a human decision.
- 28 l. 298 Orestes, avenger of Agamemnon, is held up as Telemachus' model throughout the early books. Zeus' Aegisthus speech (32–43) thus frames the whole poem: Telemachus is being invited to step into the exemplary story the gods have just finished telling each other.
- 29 l. 320 ἀνόπαια, describing Athena's exit, is one of the book's genuinely unknown words: "up through the smoke-vent," "unseen," and a species of bird have all been proposed since antiquity. "Up and away like a bird" commits only to the visible minimum.
- 30 l. 329 περίφρων, "watchful-minded" — Penelope's fixed epithet, as constant as Athena's "gray-eyed." The word means thinking-all-around: circumspect, unsurprisable. Her first act in the poem is to try to change what song is sung in her house; her son's first act of authority is to overrule her.
- 31 l. 337 θελκήρια, "spells": song in this poem is literal enchantment — the same root describes Calypso charming Odysseus at line 57, and later the Sirens. Penelope does not ask the singer to stop; she asks him to cast a different spell.
- 32 l. 351 The audience's taste for "the newest song" is the poem winking at itself: in the fictional world the bitter homecomings from Troy are the newest repertoire — and the Odyssey is, in ours, the newest song about them.
- 33 l. 358 μῦθος here is not "myth" but authoritative public speech — "the word." Telemachus' claim to it, and to κράτος ("power") in the house, adapts Hector's farewell to Andromache (*Iliad* 6.490–493: "war shall be men's concern") with speech standing where war stood. The moment is harsh to modern ears and is meant to be a threshold: it is the first thing Telemachus does with the courage Athena has just put in him, and Penelope's silent wonder (360) registers that her son has, abruptly, come of age.
- 34 l. 383 Antinous and Eurymachus (399) are the suitors' two leaders, introduced here in the pairing they keep to the end: Antinous openly hostile, Eurymachus smooth. They will die in that order in Book 22.
- 35 l. 387 Kingship in Ithaca is evidently not automatic inheritance: Antinous can pray Telemachus never be king without absurdity, and Telemachus himself concedes (394–396) that others might take it. The Homeric βασιλεύς is nearer a paramount chief whose standing must be held than a crowned successor.
- 36 l. 431 Twenty oxen is an enormous price — standard slaves in Homer are valued at four. Eurycleia also receives a two-generation genealogy (father and grandfather, line 429), an

## ODYSSEY — BOOK 1

honor the poem otherwise reserves for heroes. It dignifies her exactly while stating plainly that she was bought.





## Odyssey — Book 2

*The assembly at Ithaca; Penelope's web; Telemachus sails by night.*

- When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,<sup>1</sup>  
 the dear son of Odysseus rose up from his bed,  
 put on his clothes, slung his sharp sword about his shoulder,  
 bound the beautiful sandals beneath his shining feet,  
 5 and came out of his bedroom looking like a god.  
 At once he ordered the clear-voiced heralds  
 to cry the long-haired Achaeans into assembly.  
 The heralds cried the summons, and the men gathered quickly.  
 And when they were assembled, all in one gathering,  
 10 he went to the assembly, the bronze spear in his palm,  
 not alone: two swift dogs followed with him,  
 and Athena poured a wondrous grace upon him.  
 All the people gazed at him in wonder as he came;  
 he sat in his father's seat, and the elders gave way.<sup>2</sup>
- 15 Then the hero Aegyptius was first to speak among them,<sup>3</sup>  
 a man bent with age, who knew things past numbering.  
 His own dear son had gone with godlike Odysseus  
 in the hollow ships to Ilium of the fine horses —  
 Antiphus the spearman; the savage Cyclops killed him  
 20 in his hollow cave, and made of him his last supper.  
 Three other sons he had: one kept company with the suitors —  
 Eurynomus — and two worked their father's lands always.  
 Even so, he could not forget the one: grieving, mourning him.  
 In tears for him, he now addressed the assembly:
- 25 "Hear me now, men of Ithaca, hear what I say.<sup>4</sup>  
 Never once has our assembly met, has our council sat,  
 since noble Odysseus went away in the hollow ships.  
 Who has gathered us now? On whom has need come down so hard,  
 whether among the young men or the elder-born?  
 30 Has he heard some news of the army coming home  
 which he might tell us plainly, having learned of it first?

Or is there some other public matter he would open and argue?  
A good man he seems to me, a blessed one. May Zeus  
accomplish for him some good — whatever his heart desires."

35 So he spoke, and the dear son of Odysseus rejoiced at the omen of the  
word,<sup>5</sup>

and sat no longer: desire took him to speak.

He stood in the middle of the assembly, and the scepter was put in his  
hand<sup>6</sup>

by the herald Peisenor, a man of clear-headed counsel.

Then he spoke, turning first to the old man:

40 "Old sir, that man is not far off — you shall see for yourself —  
who called the people: it is I; grief comes down hardest on me.  
I have heard no news of the army coming home  
which I might tell you plainly, having learned of it first,  
nor is there other public matter I would open and argue:

45 it is my own need, the evils fallen on my house —  
twofold. I have lost my noble father, who once was king  
among you here, and he was gentle as a father;  
and now something far greater, which will soon tear apart  
my whole house utterly and destroy my living altogether.

50 Suitors have set upon my mother — against her will —  
the own dear sons of the men who here are noblest,  
and they shrink from going to the house of her father  
Icarius, so that he might set his daughter's bride-terms himself<sup>7</sup>  
and give her to whom he will, whoever comes and pleases her.

55 Instead they haunt our house day after day,  
slaughtering our oxen and our sheep and our fat goats,  
feasting and drinking the fire-bright wine  
with no reckoning. And the most of it is wasted. For there is no man  
here

such as Odysseus was, to beat ruin away from the house.

60 We are not the men to beat it back — believe me, ever after  
we would be pitiable men, and unschooled in fighting.  
Beat it back I would, if only the strength were in me!  
For what is done here is past all bearing; past all decency  
my house is ruined. Feel the outrage yourselves;

- 65 feel shame before the peoples who are our neighbors,  
 those who dwell around us; and dread the wrath of the gods,  
 lest in fury at evil deeds they turn them back on your heads.  
 I beg you — by Olympian Zeus, and by Themis,<sup>8</sup>  
 who dissolves the assemblies of men and seats them —
- 70 hold off, friends! Leave me alone to waste away  
 in my bitter grief. Unless perhaps my father, good Odysseus,  
 in malice did the strong-greaved Achaeans harm,  
 and in requital you do me harm in malice,  
 egging these men on. Better for me by far
- 75 if it were you yourselves devouring my treasures and my herds:  
 were you the ones eating, there might one day be repayment,  
 for then we would go up and down the town pressing our claim,  
 demanding our goods back, until all was given over.  
 Instead you heap on my heart pains past any remedy."
- 80 So he spoke in anger, and dashed the scepter to the ground,<sup>9</sup>  
 bursting into tears. And pity took hold of all the people.  
 Then all the rest stayed silent, and no one dared  
 to answer Telemachus with hard words;  
 Antinous alone made him this answer:
- 85 "Telemachus, high talker, temper past restraining — what a thing you  
 have said,<sup>10</sup>  
 smearing us with shame! You would love to hang the blame on us.  
 But it is not the Achaean suitors who are at fault:  
 it is your own dear mother, whose cunning has no equal.  
 For it is the third year now, and the fourth soon coming,
- 90 that she has cheated the heart in the Achaeans' breasts.  
 She gives hope to all, and makes promises to every man,  
 sending out messages — while her mind wills otherwise.  
 And here is another trick her heart devised:<sup>11</sup>  
 she set up a great loom in the halls and wove at it,
- 95 fine-threaded, beyond all measure wide, and told us straightway:  
 'Young men, my suitors — since noble Odysseus is dead,  
 wait, though you burn for my wedding, till I finish  
 this cloth — let my spinning not be wasted on the wind —  
 a shroud for the hero Laertes, against the day

- 100 the ruinous doom of death that lays men low will take him:  
 let no Achaean woman in the land hold it against me  
 that a man who won so much should lie without his winding-sheet.<sup>112</sup>  
 So she spoke, and our proud hearts were persuaded.  
 Then every day she wove at the great loom,  
 105 and every night she unwove it by torchlight.  
 Three years her trick escaped us, and she kept the Achaeans persuaded;  
 but when the fourth year came, as the seasons rolled on,  
 then one of her women, who knew it all, told us,  
 and we caught her unweaving the shining web.  
 110 So she finished it — against her will, under force.  
 Now the suitors give you this answer, so that you may know it  
 in your own heart, and all the Achaeans know it:  
 send your mother away. Command her to marry  
 whichever man her father bids, and who pleases her.  
 115 But if she goes on tormenting the sons of the Achaeans —  
 minding in her heart the gifts Athena gave her beyond all women,  
 skill in beautiful work, and a noble mind,  
 and cunning past anything we hear of even in the women of old,  
 the fair-braided Achaean women of the time before,  
 120 Tyro and Alcmene and Mycene of the lovely crown:<sup>13</sup>  
 not one of them had thoughts to match Penelope's —  
 yet this one thought of hers was not well thought.  
 For just so long will men devour your living and your goods  
 as she holds to this purpose the gods are setting  
 125 now in her breast. Great fame she is making  
 for herself — and for you, the ache of a squandered living.  
 We are not going to our estates, or anywhere else,  
 before she marries whichever Achaean she will."  
 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 130 "Antinous, there is no way I can thrust out of the house, unwilling,  
 the one who bore me, who raised me — while my father, somewhere on  
 earth,  
 lives or is dead. And it would go hard with me to pay back  
 Icarius so much, if of my own accord I send my mother home.  
 From her father I would suffer evil; and heaven would add  
 135 more, since my mother, leaving the house, would call down

the loathed Furies; and the blame of men would be<sup>14</sup>  
upon me. No: I will never speak that word.  
As for you — if your own hearts feel any shame at it,  
get out of my halls. Go busy yourselves with other feasts,  
140 eating your own goods, moving from house to house.  
But if this seems to you the better thing, the more profitable,  
that one man's living be destroyed and nothing paid,  
then carve away. And I will cry to the gods who live forever,  
in hope that Zeus may grant deeds of requital come to pass:  
145 then you would die inside this house, and nothing paid for you."<sup>15</sup>

So spoke Telemachus. And Zeus of the wide voice sent him two eagles,<sup>16</sup>  
flying from on high, from a mountain peak.  
For a while the two flew on with the breath of the wind,  
close by one another, wings at full stretch;  
150 but when they came dead over the many-voiced assembly,<sup>17</sup>  
they wheeled there, beating their wings thick and fast,  
and glared down on all their heads, and death was in their gaze;  
then they ripped with their talons at each other's cheeks and throats  
and shot away rightward, over the houses and the town.  
155 The men were astonished at the birds their eyes had seen,  
and turned over in their hearts what this would bring to pass.

And among them spoke the old hero Halitherses,  
Mastor's son, who surpassed all men of his day  
in reading birds and speaking what fate intends.  
160 With good will toward them he spoke to the assembly:

"Hear me now, men of Ithaca, hear what I say —  
though to the suitors above all I declare it:  
on them a great wave of ruin is rolling. For Odysseus  
will not be long parted from his people; already, somewhere  
165 near, he is planting death and slaughter for these men,  
every one; and evil will come on many of the rest of us  
who live in clear-skied Ithaca. Long before that,  
let us think how to stop them — or let them stop  
themselves: the sooner the better, for their own sake.  
170 I prophesy as no novice; I know my art.  
And for that man too I say it is all coming home,

- all I told him when the Argives went up into Ilium  
and Odysseus of the many designs went with them.  
I said that after long suffering, his companions all lost,  
175 unknown to everyone, in the twentieth year<sup>18</sup>  
he would come home. And now it is all being accomplished."
- Then Eurymachus, Polybus' son, answered him:  
"Old man, off with you — go home and prophesy to your children,  
lest some evil overtake them in days to come.  
180 In this I am a far better prophet than you.  
Plenty of birds go back and forth beneath the rays of the sun,<sup>19</sup>  
and not all of them are fate. As for Odysseus:  
he is dead, far away — and how I wish that you had perished with him.  
You would not then be spouting all this prophecy,  
185 or whetting the anger of Telemachus —  
angling for some gift for your household, should he offer one.  
But I will tell you this, and it will be accomplished:  
if you, who know so many things grown old with you,  
talk a younger man around with words and stir him to fury,  
190 for the man himself, first, it will go the harder,  
and in any case he will accomplish nothing for all these words;  
and on you, old man, we will lay a fine that in the paying  
will gall your heart: and the pain of it will be hard.  
And to Telemachus, before you all, my own advice is this:  
195 let him command his mother to go back to her father's house.  
There they will make the marriage and set out the bride-gifts,  
very many, all that should follow a beloved child.  
Not before, I think, will the sons of the Achaeans quit  
their courting — a grinding courtship. We fear no one, not at all;  
200 no, not Telemachus, for all his stream of words;  
nor do we care a whit for prophecy, old man, that you  
mouth to no accomplishment — it only makes you the more hated.  
His goods will be devoured as badly as ever, and never made good,  
so long as she puts the Achaeans off about  
205 her marriage. And we, waiting all our days,  
rival one another for her excellence, and do not go after  
other women, fit brides for any of us."

- Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 "Eurymachus, and all you other haughty suitors:  
 210 I plead with you no further; I say no more of this.  
 The gods know it now, and all the Achaeans.  
 But come, give me a fast ship and twenty companions  
 to carry me on a journey there and back again.  
 For I am going to Sparta and to sandy Pylos  
 215 to ask after the homecoming of my long-gone father,  
 in hope some mortal man will tell me, or I may hear the Rumor  
 that comes from Zeus, which most of all carries word among men.<sup>20</sup>  
 If I hear my father is alive and homeward bound,  
 then, ground down as I am, I could hold out one more year;  
 220 but if I hear that he is dead, that he is no more,  
 then I will come back to my own dear fatherland  
 and heap his burial mound, and over it pay the death-rites,  
 very many, as is fitting, and give my mother to a husband."
- So he spoke, and sat down. And there rose among them  
 225 Mentor, the companion of blameless Odysseus,<sup>21</sup>  
 to whom, going aboard his ships, he had entrusted his whole house —  
 that all should obey the old man, and he keep everything safe.  
 With good will toward them he spoke to the assembly:
- "Hear me now, men of Ithaca, hear what I say.  
 230 Let no sceptered king ever again be willingly  
 kind and gentle, or know the right way in his heart;  
 let him rather be harsh always, and act outrage —  
 since no one remembers godlike Odysseus  
 among the people he ruled, and he was gentle as a father.  
 235 It is not the lordly suitors I begrudge, not really,  
 for their deeds of violence woven in an evil-scheming mind:  
 they lay their own heads on the wager when they devour<sup>22</sup>  
 by violence the house of Odysseus, saying he will come home no more.  
 It is the rest of the people I am angry at — the way you all  
 240 sit there dumb, and never fasten on them with words  
 and stop them: the suitors few, and you so many."

Then Leocritus, Evenor's son, answered him:  
 "Mentor, wrecker, brain gone wandering — what a thing you have said,

- urging them to stop us. It is heavy work  
 245 to fight with men over a feast — men who outnumber you at that.  
 Why, if Ithacan Odysseus himself came in on us  
 and found the lordly suitors feasting in his house  
 and set his heart on driving them out of the hall,  
 his wife would have no joy of his coming, however  
 250 she has ached for him: right there he would meet an ugly death,<sup>23</sup>  
 if he fought men who outnumbered him. What you have said misses the  
 mark.  
 Come now — people, scatter, each man to his own work.  
 As for this one, Mentor and Halitherses can speed his journey,  
 being companions of his father's house from the beginning.  
 255 Though I think he will sit here a long while yet, gathering his news  
 in Ithaca; that voyage he will never make."
- So he spoke, and dissolved the assembly on the instant.  
 They scattered, each man to his own house,  
 and the suitors went off to the house of godlike Odysseus.
- 260 But Telemachus walked apart, to the sand-beach of the sea,  
 washed his hands in the gray salt water, and prayed to Athena:  
 "Hear me, you who came yesterday, a god, into our house,  
 and bade me go by ship over the misted sea  
 to ask after the homecoming of my long-gone father.  
 265 All of it the Achaeans grind to a halt —  
 the suitors most of all, in their evil overbearing pride."
- So he prayed, and Athena came to him, close at hand,  
 in the likeness of Mentor, both his body and his voice,  
 and lifting her voice she spoke winged words to him:  
 270 "Telemachus, you will be no coward from this day, and no fool,  
 if any of your father's brave force is instilled in you —  
 such a man he was for making good both deed and word.  
 Then this journey of yours will be no idle errand, and not  
 unaccomplished.  
 But if you are not his son, his and Penelope's,  
 275 then I have no hope you will accomplish what you set your heart on.  
 Few sons, in truth, turn out the equals of their fathers:<sup>24</sup>  
 the most are worse; a few are better men than their fathers.



But since you will be no coward from this day, and no fool,  
 and the cunning of Odysseus has not wholly failed in you,  
 280 there is every hope you will accomplish this work.  
 So now let the suitors' plotting and scheming go —  
 mindless men, with neither sense nor justice in them:  
 they know nothing of the death and the black doom  
 that stands close by them, to destroy them all in a day.  
 285 The journey you have set your heart on will not be long delayed —  
 such a companion am I, out of your father's house:  
 I will fit out a fast ship for you, and come along myself.  
 You go back to the house now, and move among the suitors;  
 make ready provisions, and stow them all in vessels —  
 290 wine in two-handled jars, and barley meal, the marrow of men,<sup>25</sup>  
 in tight-sewn skins. And I, through the town,  
 will gather willing companions, and quickly. There are ships  
 in plenty in sea-circled Ithaca, new ships and old:  
 I will look them over for you and choose the best,  
 295 and we will rig her fast and launch her on the wide sea."

So spoke Athena, daughter of Zeus. And no longer then  
 did Telemachus linger, once he had heard the voice of the god.  
 He went on his way to the house, his heart heavy within him,  
 and found the lordly suitors there in the halls,  
 300 skinning goats and singeing fat hogs in the courtyard.  
 Antinous came laughing straight at Telemachus,  
 clamped a hand on his, and spoke a word, and named him:  
 "Telemachus, high talker, temper past restraining — let no other  
 evil trouble your breast, no other deed or word.  
 305 Just eat with me, and drink, the way it used to be.  
 The Achaeans will see to all those things of yours —  
 a ship and picked oarsmen — so you may come the sooner  
 to holy Pylos, after news of your proud father."

Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 310 "Antinous, there is no way, among you in your insolence,  
 to eat my supper quietly and take my ease in peace.  
 Is it not enough that all this while, suitors, you carved up  
 my goods, so many and so fine, while I was still a child?

Now — when I am grown, and hear the talk of other men  
 315 and understand it, and the spirit swells inside me —  
 I will try to hurl an evil doom upon you,  
 whether I go to Pylos or stay here in this land.  
 But go I will, and the journey I speak of will be no idle errand —  
 a passenger on another's ship, since master of ship or oarsmen<sup>26</sup>  
 320 I am not to be. That, no doubt, seemed the more profitable to you."

He spoke, and wrenched his hand from Antinous' hand,  
 easily. And through the house the suitors busied themselves with the  
 feast,  
 and they mocked him and needled him with words.  
 And thus would one of the arrogant young men say:  
 325 "No question — Telemachus is planning our murder!  
 He will bring back avengers from sandy Pylos,  
 or else from Sparta, since he is so terribly set on it.  
 Or maybe he means to go to Ephyra, that rich plowland,<sup>27</sup>  
 to fetch home poisons that eat the life away,  
 330 and drop them in the wine-bowl, and destroy us all."

And thus would another of the arrogant young men say:  
 "Who knows? Maybe he too, once aboard the hollow ship,  
 will wander far from his people and be lost — just like Odysseus.  
 And that would double our work, wouldn't it:  
 335 we would have to divide all his goods among us, and the house itself  
 hand over to his mother — hers, and the man who marries her."<sup>28</sup>

So they talked. But he went down to his father's storeroom,  
 high-ceilinged and broad, where gold and bronze lay piled,  
 and clothing in chests, and fragrant oil in plenty;  
 340 and there stood great jars of old wine, sweet to drink,  
 holding the unmixed divine drink within them,  
 ranged in order along the wall — against the day Odysseus  
 might come home even after all his pains.<sup>29</sup>  
 Doors were on it, close-fitted, bolted fast,  
 345 double doors; and a woman-steward was there night and day  
 who guarded it all with her mind's deep knowledge:  
 Eurycleia, daughter of Ops, Peisenor's son.  
 Telemachus called her into the storeroom and spoke to her:

"Nurse, come — draw me off wine in two-handled jars,<sup>30</sup>  
 350 the sweet wine, the finest-tasting after that  
 which you keep, thinking of him — the luckless one — if from  
 somewhere he should come:  
 Zeus-born Odysseus, having slipped past death and the dooms.  
 Fill twelve, and fit them all with lids.  
 And pour me barley meal into well-sewn skins:  
 355 twenty measures of mill-crushed barley grain.  
 Keep this to yourself. And let it all stand gathered:  
 in the evening I will fetch it, when at last  
 my mother climbs to her upper room and thinks of sleep.  
 For I am going to Sparta and to sandy Pylos  
 360 to ask after my dear father's homecoming, if I may hear of it."

So he spoke, and his dear nurse Eurycleia wailed aloud,  
 and grieving she spoke winged words to him:  
 "Why, dear child, why has this thought come into  
 your mind? Where would you go across the wide earth,  
 365 an only son, and beloved? He is dead far from home —  
 Zeus-born Odysseus, in some strangers' country.  
 And these men, the moment you are gone, will plot evils behind you,  
 to kill you by treachery and divide all this among themselves.  
 Stay here instead, sitting on what is yours. There is no need  
 370 to suffer evils on the barren sea, and go wandering."

Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:  
 "Take heart, nurse. This plan is not without a god.<sup>31</sup>  
 But swear you will not breathe a word to my dear mother  
 before the eleventh day has come, or the twelfth,  
 375 or she misses me herself and hears that I am gone —  
 so she will not mar her lovely skin with weeping."

So he spoke, and the old woman swore the great oath of the gods.  
 And when she had sworn and made an end of the oath,  
 straightway she drew off wine for him in two-handled jars  
 380 and poured him barley meal into well-sewn skins;  
 and Telemachus went back to the hall to move among the suitors.  
 Then the goddess thought of one thing more, gray-eyed Athena.

In the likeness of Telemachus she went everywhere through the town,<sup>32</sup>  
 and standing beside each man she spoke her word,  
 385 bidding them gather at evening by the fast ship.  
 Then she asked Noemon, the shining son of Phronius,  
 for a fast ship; and he promised it gladly.

The sun went down, and all the ways grew dark.<sup>33</sup>  
 Then she hauled the fast ship down to the sea, and stowed in her  
 390 all the gear that well-benched ships carry,  
 and moored her at the harbor's edge. Around her the brave  
 companions  
 gathered in a body, and the goddess set each man's heart on fire.

Then the goddess thought of one thing more, gray-eyed Athena.  
 She went on her way to the house of godlike Odysseus,  
 395 and there she poured sweet sleep over the suitors,  
 addled them as they drank, and knocked the cups from their hands.  
 They stumbled off to sleep through the town, and sat no longer,  
 for sleep was falling on their eyelids.

But to Telemachus gray-eyed Athena spoke,  
 400 calling him out in front of the well-settled halls,  
 in the likeness of Mentor, both his body and his voice:  
 "Telemachus, your strong-greaved companions are already  
 sitting at the oars, waiting on your word to start.  
 Come, let us go; let us not hold the journey long."

405 So speaking, Pallas Athena led the way  
 swiftly, and he followed in the footsteps of the god.  
 And when they had come down to the ship and the sea,  
 they found the long-haired companions on the beach,  
 and the sacred strength of Telemachus spoke among them.<sup>34</sup>  
 410 "Come, friends, let us fetch the provisions: everything now  
 stands gathered in the hall. My mother has heard nothing,  
 nor the slave-women either; one alone was told."

So speaking he led the way, and they went with him.  
 They carried everything down and stowed it in the well-benched ship  
 415 as the dear son of Odysseus commanded.  
 Then Telemachus went aboard, Athena going before him;

she sat down in the stern of the ship, and close beside her  
 sat Telemachus. And the men cast off the stern-lines  
 and came aboard themselves and took their places at the oarlocks.  
 420 And gray-eyed Athena sent them a following wind,  
 a fresh West Wind, singing over the wine-dark sea.  
 Telemachus shouted to his companions, commanding them  
 to lay hands on the rigging, and they heard his urging:  
 they raised the pine mast and stepped it inside the hollow mast-box,  
 425 set it up and made it fast with the forestays,  
 and hauled up the white sails by the well-twisted ox-hide ropes.  
 The wind bellied out the middle of the sail, and the wave  
 hissed dark and loud around the keel as the ship went on,  
 and she ran down the waves, making her way.  
 430 Then, when they had lashed the tackle down the fast black ship,  
 they set up mixing-bowls crowned brim-full with wine  
 and poured to the deathless gods who are forever,  
 and beyond all others to the gray-eyed daughter of Zeus.  
 All night long, and into the dawn, the ship cut her way.<sup>35</sup>

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 2

- 1    *l. 1* ἦμος δ' ἠριγένεια φάνη ροδοδάκτυλος Ἥως — the most famous recurring line in Homer, appearing over twenty times in the *Odyssey*. My fixed rendering, "When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose," will return verbatim at every occurrence: the line is the poem's clock, and it should chime the same way each time it strikes.
- 2    *l. 14* A quiet coronation image: Telemachus takes his father's seat, and the old men yield it. No one has sat there in twenty years. The book's whole arc — the boy claiming public, adult space — is compressed into this one gesture before a word is spoken.
- 3    *l. 15* Aegyptius ("the Egyptian" — the name is odd and unexplained) opens the assembly not knowing his son Antiphos is already dead, eaten last in the Cyclops' cave. The audience knows the Cyclops story; the poet knows it; nobody in Ithaca does. This is the poem's first taste of the dramatic irony that will saturate its second half.
- 4    *l. 25* "Hear me now, men of Ithaca, hear what I say" — the assembly-speech formula, recurring three times in this book (25, 161, 229) from three speakers. As with the epithets, I keep it verbatim: the sameness of the opening throws the difference of the speakers into relief.
- 5    *l. 35* φήμη: a chance word taken as an omen (a *kledon*). Aegyptius meant only a courteous blessing; Telemachus receives it as a sign, which is itself a Homeric habit of mind — the world is always possibly speaking.
- 6    *l. 37* The scepter is the speaking-staff, passed to whoever holds the floor. When Telemachus dashes it to the ground in tears (80), he is breaking assembly decorum with grief — the same gesture as Achilles at *Iliad* 1.245. The allusion measures him: Achilles' scepter-throw launched the *Iliad*'s wrath; the boy's launches only pity.
- 7    *l. 53* The marriage economics are contested even within the poem: here the suitors ought to approach Icarius, who would set the bride-terms (ἔεδνα can be gifts *from* the suitor's side); at 196–197 the family "sets out the bride-gifts" with the daughter. The poem's practices are a palimpsest of different customs, and I translate each passage as it stands rather than harmonize them.
- 8    *l. 68* Themis is invoked in her precise capacity — the goddess of assemblies as institutions, who "seats and dissolves" them. Telemachus swears by due process itself.
- 9    *l. 80* See note on 37. The detail that pity took "all the people" — and yet none of them acts, as Mentor will bitterly observe at 239–241 — is the book's political diagnosis: sympathy without civic courage.
- 10    *l. 85* ὑψαγόρη, "high talker": Antinous throws Book 1's taunt (1.385) into a fixed insult-formula, repeated when he accosts Telemachus again at 303. The suitors' mockery has its own formulas, as the gods and heroes have theirs.

- 11 *l. 93* The web. The poem's most famous trick is told first here — by an enemy, as an accusation. It will be retold by Penelope herself at 19.137ff. and by a suitor's ghost at 24.128ff., each telling angled differently. Note what Antinous concedes while complaining: her weaving-and-unweaving wins her "great fame" (κλέος, 125) — the currency of heroes — and that her intelligence outdoes the legendary women of old. The enemy's indictment is the poem's first full portrait of Penelope, and it is a portrait of a match for Odysseus.
- 12 *l. 102* The clinching argument of Penelope's ruse is shame-culture logic: a great lord lying without a winding-sheet would disgrace *her* before the women of the land. She weaponizes the very propriety the suitors cannot publicly deny.
- 13 *l. 120* Tyro (loved by Poseidon), Alcmena (mother of Heracles), Mycene (eponym of the city): a miniature catalogue of legendary heroines, of the kind Odysseus will see at length in the underworld in Book 11 — where Tyro and Alcmena duly appear.
- 14 *l. 135* The Erinyes (Furies) enforce curses within the family, above all a parent's curse. Telemachus' refusal is not only sentiment: expelling his mother would expose him to her father's vengeance, her Furies, and public blame — a triple bind he lays out like a lawyer.
- 15 *l. 145* Lines 139–145 repeat 1.374–380 verbatim in the Greek, and verbatim in this translation: the private ultimatum of last night is now sworn in public with the gods as witnesses. The repetition is escalation.
- 16 *l. 146* The first omen of the poem: two eagles that fly *as a pair*, tear at each other's cheeks and throats, and veer off to the right (the lucky side) — over the town, implicating everyone. Interpreters ancient and modern have worried over the pair (Odysseus and Telemachus? the two facing parties?) and the self-tearing; Halitherses reads only the essential: destruction is near.
- 17 *l. 150* πολύφημον, "many-voiced" assembly — the same adjective that is elsewhere the name Polyphemus. With the Cyclops invoked twenty lines earlier (19–20), the echo is hard to call an accident: the man-devourer's name hovers over a town full of devourers.
- 18 *l. 175* "In the twentieth year": Halitherses' old prophecy matches the poem's actual chronology exactly — ten years of war, ten of wandering. The seer's numbers are the narrator's numbers; prophecy in the Odyssey is never wrong, only disbelieved.
- 19 *l. 181* "Plenty of birds go back and forth beneath the rays of the sun, / and not all of them are fate": the most quotable statement of omen-skepticism in Homer — placed in the mouth of a man the birds have just marked for death. The poem lets rationalism speak beautifully, and be wrong.
- 20 *l. 217* Lines 214–223 rerun Athena's instructions from 1.281–292 nearly word for word, shifted to the first person; my translation repeats itself accordingly. Telemachus has learned the speech by heart — literally. A young man's first plan is always someone else's words, and the poem knows it.
- 21 *l. 225* The real Mentor, at last: Odysseus' steward-companion, whose likeness Athena borrows at 268 and 401 and through much of the poem. Every later use of English "mentor" descends from this disguise — the teacher who is really a goddess wearing a friend.

- 22 l. 237 "They lay their own heads on the wager": Mentor's gambling image concedes the suitors' logic — they eat the house *because* they judge Odysseus dead, and their lives are the stake if they are wrong. The poem keeps insisting the suitors chose their risk; it is Zeus' doctrine from 1.32–43 working itself out.
- 23 l. 249 Leocritus' taunt — Odysseus himself would die if he tried to clear his own hall against superior numbers — is a precise, unwitting prophecy of Book 22, down to the detail that his wife's longing would not save him. Every clause will be refuted in blood; Leocritus himself falls to Telemachus' spear (22.294).
- 24 l. 276 "Few sons are the equals of their fathers": Athena states the Telemachy's central anxiety as a general law — then exempts Telemachus from it conditionally. The whole journey to Pylos and Sparta is engineered to let him test the exemption.
- 25 l. 290 ἄλφιτα, μυελὸν ἀνδρῶν — "barley meal, the marrow of men." The startling kenning is Homer's, not mine: staple food as the inside of the human frame.
- 26 l. 319 ἔμπορος; in later Greek "merchant," but here still "one who travels on another's ship" — a passenger. The sting is in the word: the heir of Odysseus must beg passage like a man with no ship of his own, and he says so to the men who arranged it.
- 27 l. 328 The suitors' sneer unknowingly repeats a true story: Odysseus really did sail to Ephyra for arrow-poison (1.259–262, from Athena-as-Mentes). What they toss off as slander — poison in the wine-bowl, all of us destroyed — is nearly the shape of their actual deaths. The poem lets its victims write their own epitaphs as jokes.
- 28 l. 332 The second mocker's fantasy — Telemachus lost at sea, the goods divided, the house handed to whoever marries the widow — is the suitors' real program spoken aloud, and it hardens into the ambush plotted at the end of Book 4. Idle talk in this poem has a way of becoming policy.
- 29 l. 342 The storeroom is a shrine of deferred hope: the best wine stands "ranged in order along the wall" for a return nobody will name except conditionally. The economy of the house has been holding its breath for twenty years.
- 30 l. 349 μᾶϊα, "Nurse" — the affectionate address for an old family slave-woman. This scene quietly answers Book 1's: the same Eurycleia who carried the torches now becomes the sole human keeper of the plan; the boy's first conspiracy is with the woman who nursed him.
- 31 l. 372 "This plan is not without a god" — a litotes that is also simply accurate: Telemachus knows his visitor was divine (1.420). His confidence is not bravado but inference.
- 32 l. 383 Athena spends the evening in two shapes: as Telemachus she recruits his crew and borrows the ship from Noemon, and as Mentor she collects the boy. The recruiting-double is uncanny if you pause on it — the town sees Telemachus everywhere that night, asking for help and even for a ship; in a sense the goddess is teaching Ithaca to see him as a man who commands.
- 33 l. 388 "The sun went down, and all the ways grew dark" — another fixed formula-line, the poem's evening bell, kept identical at each return like the dawn line at 1.



- 34 *l. 409* *ἱερὴ ἰς Τηλεμάχοιο*, "the sacred strength of Telemachus" — an epic periphrasis (like "the strength of Heracles") that names the man by his force. The poem grants it to him for the first time on the night of his first command; the elevation is the point, and I keep the strangeness rather than flatten it to "Telemachus."
- 35 *l. 434* The book ends in open water, mid-journey, the ship "cutting her way" toward dawn and Pylos — narrative enjambment: Book 3 begins with the sun rising on the same run. It is the first time in twenty years that anyone from Ithaca has gone out to meet the world instead of waiting for it.



## Odyssey — Book 3

*Pylos: Nestor's tales of the returns; Telemachus rides for Sparta.*

- And the sun leapt up, leaving the beautiful water,<sup>1</sup>  
 into the bronze-bright heaven, to shine for the immortals  
 and for mortal men across the grain-giving plowland;  
 and they came in to Pylos, the strong-built city of Neleus.
- 5 There on the beach of the sea the people were offering victims,  
 bulls all black, to the earth-shaker with the blue-black hair.<sup>2</sup>  
 Nine tiers of seats there were, five hundred sitting in each,<sup>3</sup>  
 and before each company nine bulls were held ready.  
 They had just tasted the innards, and were burning thigh-cuts for the  
 god,
- 10 when the ship came straight in: they brailed the sails of the trim vessel,  
 furled them aloft, moored her, and stepped ashore themselves;  
 and Telemachus stepped from the ship, Athena going before him.  
 The goddess spoke to him first, gray-eyed Athena:  
 "Telemachus, no more need of shyness now, not a scrap of it:<sup>4</sup>
- 15 this is why you have sailed the sea — to learn news  
 of your father: where the earth hides him, what doom he met.  
 Come then, go straight to Nestor, breaker of horses:  
 let us see what counsel he keeps hidden in his breast.  
 Beg him yourself, so that he speaks unerring truth.
- 20 He will tell you no lie: he is clear-headed beyond most men."<sup>5</sup>
- Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:  
 "Mentor, how am I to go up? How greet him?  
 I have no practice yet in close-woven speech —  
 and a young man is shy of questioning his elder."
- 25 Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-eyed Athena:  
 "Telemachus, some of it your own heart will see,<sup>6</sup>  
 and some a god will prompt. For I do not think  
 you were born and raised without the gods' good will."
- So speaking, Pallas Athena led the way  
 30 swiftly, and he followed in the footsteps of the god.

- They came to the gathering-place of the men of Pylos, the rows of seats,  
 where Nestor sat with his sons, and around them companions  
 were readying the feast, roasting meats and skewering others.  
 But when they saw the strangers they came all in a crowd,  
 35 clasped their hands in welcome, and bade them be seated.  
 First Peisistratus, Nestor's son, coming near,  
 took the hands of both, and settled them at the feast  
 on soft fleeces over the sand of the sea,  
 beside his brother Thrasymedes and his father;  
 40 and he gave them portions of the innards, and poured wine  
 into a golden cup, and pledging her he addressed  
 Pallas Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus:  
 "Pray now, stranger, to the lord Poseidon,  
 for his is the feast you have found in coming here.  
 45 And when you have poured and prayed, as is right and custom,  
 give this man too the cup of honey-sweet wine  
 to pour, since he also, I think, prays to the deathless ones:  
 all men have need of the gods.  
 But he is the younger, my own age to the year,  
 50 and so to you first I give the golden cup."
- With that he set in her hand the cup of sweet wine;  
 and Athena rejoiced in the man — clear-headed, just —<sup>7</sup>  
 because to her first he gave the golden cup;  
 and at once she prayed at length to the lord Poseidon:  
 55 "Hear me, Poseidon who hold the earth, and do not grudge  
 us who pray the accomplishment of these works.  
 To Nestor first of all, and to his sons, grant glory,  
 and then to all the rest give gracious recompense,  
 to all the Pylians, for this splendid hecatomb.  
 60 And grant besides that Telemachus and I sail home with the thing  
 accomplished  
 we came here for, in our fast black ship."  
 So she prayed — and she herself was accomplishing it all.<sup>8</sup>  
 Then she gave Telemachus the beautiful two-handled cup,  
 and the dear son of Odysseus prayed the same.

- 65 And when they had roasted the outer meats and drawn them off,  
they divided the portions and feasted the glorious feast.  
But when they had put away desire for food and drink,  
Gerenian Nestor the horseman began to speak among them:<sup>9</sup>  
"Now is the fairer time to inquire and ask  
70 our guests who they are, now they have had their joy of food.  
Strangers, who are you? From where do you sail the watery ways?<sup>10</sup>  
Is it on some business — or do you rove at random,  
the way sea-raiders do, who wander  
staking their own lives, bearing evil to strangers?"
- 75 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him,  
emboldened: Athena herself had set courage in his heart,  
so that he might ask about his absent father  
and so that good report among men might be his:  
"Nestor, son of Neleus, great glory of the Achaeans,  
80 you ask from where we are, and I will tell you.  
We have come from Ithaca, under Mount Neion;  
and the business I speak of is private, not the people's.  
I follow the wide fame of my father, in hope I may hear of him:  
noble, enduring-hearted Odysseus, who once, they say,  
85 fought at your side when you sacked the Trojans' city.  
All the others, all who warred against the Trojans,  
we have had word of — where each man died his bitter death;  
but his death the son of Cronos has left past finding:  
no one can say for certain where he perished,  
90 whether he went down on the mainland at enemy hands  
or on the deep, under the waves of Amphitrite.  
That is why I come now to your knees: in hope you will consent  
to tell his bitter death — whether you saw it  
with your own eyes, or heard the tale of him from another  
95 wanderer. Beyond all men his mother bore him for sorrow.  
Do not soften anything from courtesy or pity:<sup>11</sup>  
tell me fully whatever sight you came upon.  
I beg you — if ever my father, good Odysseus,  
promised you word or work and made it good  
100 in the Trojans' country, where you Achaeans suffered your pains,  
remember it for me now: tell me the unerring truth."

- Then Gerenian Nestor the horseman answered him:  
 "Dear boy — since you bring back the misery we endured  
 in that country, we headstrong sons of the Achaeans,  
 105 all our roving in ships across the misted sea  
 chasing plunder wherever Achilles led,  
 and all our fighting around the great city of lord Priam —  
 there, in those years, our best were killed.  
 There lies Ajax, dear to the war-god; there Achilles;<sup>12</sup>  
 110 there Patroclus, a counselor the equal of the gods;  
 there my own dear son, strong and without fault,  
 Antilochus — surpassing swift of foot, and a fighter.  
 And many other evils we suffered besides: who among  
 mortal men could tell them all?  
 115 Not if you stayed five years — six years —  
 asking all the evils the noble Achaeans suffered there:  
 you would go home to your own country worn out first.  
 Nine years we stitched evils around them, plotting<sup>13</sup>  
 with every kind of cunning — and the son of Cronos barely brought it  
 to an end.  
 120 And there no man would set his wits against him openly —  
 willing, that is — for noble Odysseus won by far,  
 in every kind of cunning: your father — if truly  
 you are his blood. Awe takes me, looking at you.  
 Your speech, at least, is his: you would not think  
 125 a younger man could speak so like him.  
 In all that time, I and noble Odysseus  
 never spoke on opposite sides in assembly or in council:  
 one heart between us — with sense and considered counsel  
 we planned for the Argives how the best might come about.  
 130 But when we had sacked Priam's steep city,<sup>14</sup>  
 and gone to our ships, and a god scattered the Achaeans,  
 then, then Zeus devised in his heart a bitter homecoming  
 for the Argives — since not all of us were men of sense  
 or of justice. So many of them came to an evil end  
 135 through the ruinous wrath of the gray-eyed daughter of the mighty  
 Father —<sup>15</sup>  
 who set strife between the two sons of Atreus.

The two of them called the Achaeans all to assembly —  
 rashly, in no due order, at the setting of the sun,  
 and the sons of the Achaeans came heavy with wine —  
 140 and they spoke out the reason they had gathered the army.  
 There Menelaus urged all the Achaeans  
 to remember homecoming across the broad back of the sea;  
 and it did not please Agamemnon, not at all: he wanted  
 to hold the army back, and offer holy hecatombs  
 145 to heal the terrible anger of Athena —  
 the fool. He did not know she was not to be persuaded:<sup>16</sup>  
 the mind of the gods who are forever does not turn so fast.  
 So the two of them stood trading hard words;  
 and the strong-greaved Achaeans sprang up  
 150 with a huge din, and the counsel split them two ways.  
 That night we lay on our anger, brooding hard thoughts  
 against each other — for Zeus was readying the stroke of evil —  
 and at dawn half of us hauled our ships to the bright salt water  
 and loaded our goods aboard, and the deep-girdled women.  
 155 Half the army held back, staying  
 there with Atreus' son Agamemnon, shepherd of the people;  
 and half of us embarked and rowed. And the ships ran fast,  
 for a god smoothed the sea over its monstrous deeps.  
 Coming to Tenedos, we offered victims to the gods,  
 160 aching for home. But Zeus had no thought yet of homecoming —  
 iron-hearted, he stirred up evil strife a second time.  
 Some turned their curved ships around and went back —  
 those with Odysseus, the battle-wise lord, the man of shifting counsels  
 —  
 carrying favor once again to Atreus' son Agamemnon.  
 165 But I, with the ships that followed me gathered close,  
 fled on, for I knew the god was devising evils.  
 And the warlike son of Tydeus fled, and roused his companions.  
 Late upon our track came fair-haired Menelaus,  
 and caught us at Lesbos debating the long crossing:  
 170 whether to sail above rugged Chios,  
 by the isle of Psyria, keeping Chios on our left,  
 or under Chios, past windy Mimas.

We asked the god to show a sign, and he showed one,<sup>17</sup>  
 and bade us cut across the middle sea to Euboea,  
 175 to run out from under the evil quickest.  
 A whistling wind sprang up astern, and the ships ran fast  
 down the fish-filled ways, and to Geraestus  
 they came in by night. And to Poseidon we laid many  
 bulls' thighs on the fire, having measured the great gulf.  
 180 It was the fourth day when in Argos the companions  
 of Diomedes, breaker of horses, moored their trim ships;  
 but I held on for Pylos, and the wind never failed  
 from the day the god first sent it blowing.  
 So I came home, dear child, knowing nothing — I cannot tell you  
 185 who of the Achaeans were saved and who were lost.  
 But all I hear, sitting here in our halls,  
 you shall learn, as is right; I will hide nothing.  
 The Myrmidons, they say, those furious spearmen, came home safe,  
 led by the shining son of great-hearted Achilles;  
 190 safe too Philoctetes, Poias' splendid son;  
 and Idomeneus brought all his companions to Crete,  
 all who escaped the war: the sea took none from him.  
 And Atreus' son — you have heard yourselves, far off as you live,<sup>18</sup>  
 how he came home, and how Aegisthus plotted his bitter death.  
 195 But that man paid for it — grimly, in full.  
 How good a thing it is, that a son of the dead man be left!  
 For that son took vengeance on the killer of his father,  
 Aegisthus of the crooked counsels, who cut down his famous father.  
 You too, my friend — and I see how tall and fine you are —<sup>19</sup>  
 200 be brave, so that men not yet born will speak well of you."

Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 "Nestor, son of Neleus, great glory of the Achaeans,  
 yes — that man took his vengeance in full, and the Achaeans  
 will carry his fame wide, a thing for men to come to hear of.  
 205 If only the gods would clothe me in strength like that,  
 to pay the suitors back for their galling trespass —  
 the insolent men who scheme their reckless outrage against me!  
 But the gods have spun no such happiness for me —  
 not for my father, not for me. Now, come what may, I must endure."



- 210 Then Gerenian Nestor the horseman answered him:  
 "Dear boy — since you say it yourself and bring it to my mind —  
 they tell me many suitors for your mother's sake  
 fill your halls against your will, devising evils.  
 Tell me: do you bow to it willingly, or do the people  
 215 through the land hate you, following the voice of a god?  
 Who knows whether one day he will come and repay their violence —  
 alone, it may be, or all the Achaeans with him?  
 If only gray-eyed Athena chose to love you  
 the way she cared in those days for glorious Odysseus  
 220 in the Trojans' country, where we Achaeans suffered our pains —  
 never have I seen the gods love a man so openly  
 as Pallas Athena stood by him, in the open —  
 if she chose to love you like that, and care for you in her heart,  
 then more than one of those men would forget about marriage for  
 good."
- 225 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 "Old sir, I do not think that word will ever be accomplished.  
 What you say is too great. Awe holds me. I could not  
 hope for it to happen — not if the gods themselves willed it."
- Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-eyed Athena:  
 230 "Telemachus, what a word has slipped the fence of your teeth!<sup>20</sup>  
 Easily, if he wills it, a god brings a man safe home — even from far away.  
 And I would rather suffer pains in plenty first  
 and then come home, and look on my day of homecoming,  
 than come and die at my own hearth, as Agamemnon  
 235 died, by the treachery of Aegisthus and of his own wife.<sup>21</sup>  
 But death — the death common to all — not even the gods  
 can beat away from a man they love, once the day comes  
 when the ruinous doom of death that lays men low takes hold."
- Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:  
 240 "Mentor, let us speak of it no longer, grieved though we are.  
 For him no homecoming is real any more: long since  
 the deathless ones have plotted his death and black doom.  
 Now there is another word I want to ask,  
 of Nestor — since beyond other men he knows judgments and wisdom;

- 245 three generations of men, they say, he has ruled as king,<sup>22</sup>  
 and to my eyes he seems like one of the deathless ones.  
 Nestor, son of Neleus: tell me the truth of it —  
 how did Atreus' son die, wide-ruling Agamemnon?  
 Where was Menelaus? What death did the schemer plot for him,  
 250 Aegisthus of the crooked counsels — since the man he killed was far the  
 better?  
 Was Menelaus not in Achaean Argos — was he wandering  
 somewhere among men, that the other took heart and killed?"
- Then Gerenian Nestor the horseman answered him:  
 "Then I will tell you, child, the whole truth of it.
- 255 You have guessed yourself how it would have gone,  
 if Atreus' son, fair-haired Menelaus, coming from Troy,  
 had found Aegisthus alive in the halls:  
 no man would have heaped the mounded earth over his dead body —  
 dogs and birds would have torn him
- 260 as he lay on the plain far from the city, and not one  
 of the Achaean women would have wept him: too monstrous the thing  
 he schemed.
- For we were over there, winning our many contests —  
 and he, at his ease in a fold of horse-grazing Argos,  
 worked all the while at Agamemnon's wife with charming words.
- 265 At first she pushed the shameful thing away —  
 shining Clytemnestra — for her mind was still sound;  
 and beside her, too, there was a singer, whom Atreus' son<sup>23</sup>  
 strictly charged, when he left for Troy, to guard his wife.  
 But when the doom of the gods bound her to her undoing,  
 270 then Aegisthus led that singer to a desert island  
 and left him there, spoil and carrion for the birds,  
 and led her — he willing, she willing — home to his own house.<sup>24</sup>  
 Many thigh-cuts he burned on the gods' holy altars,  
 many offerings he hung up, woven things and gold,  
 275 having accomplished the enormity his heart had never hoped for.  
 Now we had sailed together on the way from Troy,  
 Atreus' son and I, in all friendship;  
 but when we reached holy Sunium, the headland of Athens,  
 there Phoebus Apollo came with his gentle arrows<sup>25</sup>

- 280 and killed the helmsman of Menelaus,  
the steering-oar of the running ship still in his hands:  
Phrontis, Onetor's son, who outdid all the tribes of men  
at steering a ship when the storm-winds drive.  
So Menelaus was held there, pressed though he was for the road,  
285 to bury his companion and pay the death-rites over him.  
But when he too, going on over the wine-dark sea  
in the hollow ships, came at a run to the steep height  
of Malea, then wide-voiced Zeus devised for him  
a hateful road: he poured on the breath of screaming winds  
290 and monstrous waves, swollen huge as mountains.  
There he split the fleet, and part he drove on Crete,  
where the Cydonians lived around the streams of Iardanus.  
There is a bare cliff, sheer to the salt water,  
at the edge of Gortyn on the misted sea,  
295 where the South Wind shoves the great swell on the left headland,  
toward Phaestus, and a little stone holds back the great sea.  
There part of them came in, and the men escaped destruction  
barely, but the waves smashed the ships on the reefs;  
and the other five ships with their dark-blue prows  
300 the wind and the water carried and beached on Egypt.  
So Menelaus, gathering much substance and gold,  
roved with his ships among men of alien speech —  
and in that very time Aegisthus schemed those horrors at home.  
305 Seven years he reigned over Mycenae rich in gold,<sup>26</sup>  
having killed Atreus' son, and the people were broken under him;  
but in the eighth his evil came on him: noble Orestes,  
back from Athens, cut down his father's killer —  
Aegisthus of the crooked counsels, who cut down his famous father.  
The killing done, he gave the Argives a funeral feast<sup>27</sup>  
310 for his hateful mother and for spineless Aegisthus;  
and on that same day Menelaus of the great war-cry reached him,  
bringing home treasure, all the freight his ships could bear.  
You too, my friend: do not wander long and far from home,  
leaving your goods behind and men in your house  
315 of such overbearing insolence — or they will devour it all,  
dividing your goods among them, and your journey come to nothing.

- But to Menelaus I bid you go — I urge it:  
 he is newly home from foreign parts,  
 from among peoples no man would hope in his heart  
 320 to return from, once the storm-winds had driven him astray  
 into a sea so vast that not even the birds  
 can cross it in a year — so vast it is, and terrible.  
 Go now, with your own ship and your companions;  
 or if you would rather go by land, chariot and horses are here,  
 325 and here are my sons, who will be your escorts  
 to shining Lacedaemon, where fair-haired Menelaus is.  
 Beg him yourself, so that he speaks unerring truth.  
 He will tell you no lie: he is clear-headed beyond most men."
- So he spoke; and the sun went down, and the dusk came on.  
 330 And among them spoke the goddess, gray-eyed Athena:  
 "Old sir, all this you have told rightly, in due measure.  
 But come — cut up the tongues now, and mix the wine,<sup>28</sup>  
 so that we may pour to Poseidon and the other immortals  
 and then think of sleep. It is the hour for it:  
 335 the light is gone already under the western gloom, and it is not fitting  
 to sit long at the feast of the gods, but to go home."  
 So spoke the daughter of Zeus, and they heard her voice.  
 Heralds poured water over their hands,  
 and young men crowned the mixing-bowls with drink  
 340 and served all, pouring first drops in each cup for the gods;  
 and they threw the tongues in the fire, and stood, and poured above  
 them.  
 But when they had poured, and drunk what their hearts would have,  
 then Athena and godlike Telemachus  
 both made to go back to the hollow ship.  
 345 But Nestor held them back, catching at them with his words:  
 "Zeus forbid it — and the other deathless gods —  
 that you should go from my house to your fast ship  
 as if from some man utterly cloakless and poor,  
 who has no cloaks, no plenty of blankets in his house,  
 350 no soft sleeping for himself or for his guests!  
 I have cloaks and beautiful blankets in plenty.  
 Never, while I live, shall the dear son of this man Odysseus

lie down on a ship's deck-planks — nor after,  
while sons of mine are left in the halls  
355 to host whatever guest arrives at my doors."

Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-eyed Athena:  
"Well said, dear old friend — and it is fitting  
that Telemachus obey you: far better so.  
Let him go with you now, then, and sleep  
360 in your halls. But I will go to the black ship  
to hearten the companions and give them all their orders.  
For I may claim to be the only elder among them:  
the rest are younger men who follow out of friendship,  
all of an age with great-hearted Telemachus.  
365 There let me lie down tonight, by the black hollow ship;  
and in the morning I go on to the great-hearted Cauconians,  
where a debt is owed me — no new thing  
and no small one. But this man, since he has come to your house,  
send on with a chariot and a son of yours; and give him horses,  
370 your lightest runners, your strongest."

So speaking, gray-eyed Athena went away  
in the likeness of a sea-eagle; and amazement took all who saw,<sup>29</sup>  
and the old man marveled, when his eyes had seen it.  
He took Telemachus' hand, and spoke a word, and named him:  
375 "Dear friend, I have no fear you will prove base or spineless,  
if the gods walk with you so, escorts, and you so young!  
For this was none other of those who hold Olympus  
than the daughter of Zeus, most glorious Tritogeneia,<sup>30</sup>  
she who honored your noble father too among the Argives.  
380 Queen, be gracious! Grant me good fame —  
to me, to my children, to my honored wife —  
and I in turn will offer you a yearling heifer, broad of brow,<sup>31</sup>  
unbroken, that no man has ever led under the yoke:  
her I will offer to you, with gold poured round her horns."  
385 So he spoke in prayer, and Pallas Athena heard him.

Then Gerenian Nestor the horseman led them —  
his sons and his daughters' husbands — to his beautiful house.  
And when they reached the lord's famous house,

- they sat in order on the benches and the high-backed chairs,  
 390 and for their coming the old man mixed a bowl  
 of sweet-drinking wine, eleven years old,  
 which the woman-steward opened, loosening the sealing cap.  
 Of this the old man mixed a bowl, and to Athena  
 he prayed long, pouring, to the daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus.  
 395 But when they had poured, and drunk what their hearts would have,  
 the others went home to sleep, each man to his own house,  
 but Gerenian Nestor the horseman laid him down there —  
 Telemachus, dear son of godlike Odysseus —  
 on a corded bedstead under the echoing porch,  
 400 and beside him Peisistratus of the good ash spear, leader of men,  
 the one son in his halls still unwed;  
 and he himself slept in the inner room of the high house,  
 where the lady his wife made ready his bed and his rest.
- When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,  
 405 Gerenian Nestor the horseman rose up from his bed,  
 and came out, and took his seat on the polished stones  
 that stood before his high doors,  
 white, gleaming as if with oil. On these, in the old days,<sup>32</sup>  
 Neleus used to sit, a counselor the equal of the gods;  
 410 but he long since had gone down to Hades, broken by fate,  
 and now Gerenian Nestor sat there in his turn, warder of the Achaeans,  
 holding the scepter. Around him his sons gathered in a body,  
 coming from their rooms: Echephron and Stratius,  
 Perseus and Aretus and godlike Thrasymedes;  
 415 and sixth came the hero Peisistratus to join them,  
 and they led godlike Telemachus and seated him beside them.  
 And Gerenian Nestor the horseman began to speak among them:  
 "Quickly, dear children, work my wish for me,  
 so that first of all the gods I may propitiate Athena,  
 420 who came to me in visible presence at the god's rich feast.  
 Come then: one of you to the plain for a heifer, fast as may be,  
 and let the cowherd drive her in;  
 one go down to great-hearted Telemachus' black ship  
 and bring up all his companions — leave two men only;  
 425 one bid the goldsmith Laerces come here

to pour gold round the heifer's horns.

The rest of you stay here together; and tell the slave-women inside to make ready a feast through the famous house — seats, and firewood round about, and shining water."

- 430 So he spoke, and they all fell to bustling. The heifer came up from the plain; from the fast trim ship came great-hearted Telemachus' companions; the smith came with his bronze tools in his hands, the instruments of his art, anvil and hammer and the well-made fire-tongs
- 435 he worked the gold with; and Athena came to receive her offering. And the old horseman Nestor gave gold, and the smith worked it and poured it round the heifer's horns, so the goddess might see the glory and be glad. Stratius and noble Echephron led her by the horns;
- 440 Aretus came from the storeroom carrying lustral water<sup>33</sup> in a flowered basin, and in his other hand the barley-grains in a basket; and Thrasymedes, steadfast in battle, stood by with a sharp axe in his hand, to strike the heifer down; Perseus held the blood-bowl. And the old horseman Nestor
- 445 began with the hand-water and the barley-grains, and long to Athena he prayed, making first offering, casting hairs from the head into the fire.

And when they had prayed and thrown the scattering barley, straightway Nestor's son, high-spirited Thrasymedes, stood close and struck: the axe cut through the tendons

- 450 of the neck, and undid the heifer's strength. And the women cried aloud —<sup>34</sup>

the daughters and the sons' wives and the honored wife of Nestor, Eurydice, eldest of the daughters of Clymenus. Then the men lifted her up from the wide-wayed earth and held her, and Peisistratus, leader of men, cut the throat.

- 455 And when the black blood had run out, and the life had left the bones, quickly they broke her apart, and at once cut out the thigh-pieces all in due order, and wrapped them deep in fat, folding it double, and laid raw flesh upon them. The old man burned them on the split wood, and poured the fire-bright wine

460 over; and the young men beside him held the five-tined forks.  
 And when the thighs were burned through, and they had tasted the innards,  
 they carved up the rest and threaded it on spits  
 and roasted it, holding the sharp spits in their hands.

Meanwhile beautiful Polycaste had bathed Telemachus —<sup>35</sup>  
 465 the youngest daughter of Nestor, Neleus' son.  
 And when she had bathed him and rubbed him richly with oil,  
 she threw a beautiful mantle around him, and a tunic,  
 and he stepped from the bath with the body of an immortal,  
 and went and sat down beside Nestor, shepherd of the people.

470 And when they had roasted the outer meats and drawn them off,  
 they sat and feasted; and good men waited on them,  
 pouring wine into cups of gold.

But when they had put away desire for food and drink,  
 Gerenian Nestor the horseman began to speak among them:  
 475 "My sons, come — yoke the fine-maned horses for Telemachus,  
 lead them under the chariot, so he may be making his way."

So he spoke, and they listened well and obeyed:  
 quickly they yoked the swift horses under the chariot,  
 and the woman-steward put in bread and wine  
 480 and cooked meats, such things as Zeus-nurtured kings eat.  
 Then Telemachus mounted the beautiful chariot,  
 and beside him Peisistratus, Nestor's son, leader of men,  
 mounted the chariot and took the reins in his hands,  
 and whipped them to a run; and the pair flew on, nothing loath,

485 into the plain, and left the steep city of Pylos behind.  
 All day long they shook the yoke they bore between them.<sup>36</sup>  
 The sun went down, and all the ways grew dark,  
 and they came to Pherae, to the house of Diocles,  
 son of Ortilochus, whom Alpheus fathered.

490 There they slept the night, and he set guest-gifts before them.

When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,  
 they yoked the horses and mounted the inlaid chariot  
 and drove out of the gateway and the echoing porch;  
 and he whipped them to a run, and the pair flew on, nothing loath.



495 They came to the wheat-bearing plain, and there they pressed  
to the journey's end: so well the swift horses carried them.  
The sun went down, and all the ways grew dark.<sup>37</sup>

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 3

- 1    *l. 1* Book 3 opens not with the dawn formula but with a sunrise — the sun climbing out of the "beautiful water" into a heaven of bronze — because the night belonged to Book 2's sea-run: the ship sailed all night, and the sun rises on arrival. The books are stitched together by the same continuous journey.
- 2    *l. 6* Black victims for Poseidon (chthonic and marine powers take dark animals), offered by the sea itself; *κυανοχαίτης*, "with the blue-black hair," is his fixed epithet. Telemachus lands in the middle of a festival for precisely the god who hates his father.
- 3    *l. 7* Nine companies of five hundred men, nine bulls each: 4,500 participants and eighty-one bulls. The staggering arithmetic is the point — Pylos is the most pious place in the poem, and its piety is civic and enormous.
- 4    *l. 14* αἰδώς — the shyness, shame, and deference proper to the young — is the emotion this whole episode is built to overcome. Athena names it, tells him to drop it, and twenty lines later (24) he confesses it anyway. The Telemachy is a course in when *aidōs* serves a man and when it starves him.
- 5    *l. 20* "He will tell you no lie: he is clear-headed (πεπνυμένος) beyond most men." The line recurs verbatim at 328 — said first of Nestor by Athena, then of Menelaus by Nestor — and the epithet is the same one fixed to Telemachus himself. The poem quietly places the boy in a chain of clear-headed men who tell the truth.
- 6    *l. 26* "Some of it your own heart will see, and some a god will prompt": the cleanest statement in the poem of Homeric double motivation — human intention and divine prompting as two descriptions of one event, not rivals.
- 7    *l. 52* A small comedy of disguise: the goddess is delighted because the young man's protocol happens to give *her* the cup first — at a feast held in honor of Poseidon, her defeated rival in other stories and her opposite in this poem. Piety done right pleases gods the pious cannot see.
- 8    *l. 62* "So she prayed — and she herself was accomplishing it all." The narrator's wink: the prayer is addressed to Poseidon, but its fulfillment is already in the hands of the praying goddess. Prayer, in this scene, is a circle with Athena at both ends.
- 9    *l. 68* Γερήνιος ἱππότης Νέστωρ — "Gerenian Nestor the horseman," his unvarying formula (Gerenia was the town where, in legend, he was raised while Heracles sacked Pylos). Like all the fixed epithets in this translation, it returns identically every time.
- 10    *l. 71* The piracy question — "who are you, trader or raider?" — is asked *after* the guests have eaten, which is the correct order of hospitality; the same verses recur when the Cyclops asks them of Odysseus (9.252–255) *before* offering anything, which is how the poem marks a monster. Note that the question treats sea-raiding as an ordinary profession, asked about politely.

- 11 l. 96 "Do not soften anything from courtesy or pity": Telemachus asks to be treated as an adult — bad news unvarnished — in his first formal speech to a great man of his father's generation. Nestor's answering awe (123–125) confirms the request landed.
- 12 l. 109 The catalogue of graves: Ajax, Achilles, Patroclus — and then "my own dear son." Nestor names Antilochus last, gives him two lines of praise, and moves on. The restraint is the grief; the poem lets a father's economy of speech say what elaboration would cheapen.
- 13 l. 118 "We stitched evils around them" — *ράπτομεν*, the verb of sewing. Plotting is stitchwork in Greek (the same image gives us "rhapsode," the song-stitcher); Penelope's loom in Book 2 and the war-craft here are the same skill in different threads.
- 14 l. 130 Lines 130–198 are our oldest surviving account of the Returns — the story told at length in the lost cyclic epic *Nostoi*: the quarrel of the Atreidae, the drunken twilight assembly, the fleet splitting apart by stages. Homer's audience knew the full story; the poem gives it as a veteran's compressed, first-person memory.
- 15 l. 135 Athena's "ruinous wrath" against the returning fleet had a famous cause — the sacrilege of Ajax son of Oileus, who dragged Cassandra from Athena's altar. Nestor does not name it, and the discretion has a dramatic edge: the wrathful goddess in question is sitting beside him disguised as an old family friend.
- 16 l. 146 *νήπιος*, "the fool" — the narrator's (here Nestor's) pitiless word for a man who acts not knowing what the audience knows; it was Zeus' word for the crew in the proem (1.8). "The mind of the gods does not turn so fast"; Agamemnon's hecatombs cannot hurry forgiveness, a rare statement of divine emotional inertia.
- 17 l. 173 The choice at Lesbos is between coast-hugging routes and the open-water run to Euboea — blue-water sailing, done only with a god's explicit sanction. The itinerary (Lesbos, Psyria, Chios, Mimas, Geraestus) is real Aegean pilotage, and the fear of the open sea in it is real too.
- 18 l. 193 The Aegisthus story is now told for the third time in three books — by Zeus (1.32–43), by Athena (1.298–300), and by Nestor here, expanded at 254–312. Each telling is angled at Telemachus more directly than the last. The poem uses the house of Atreus as a mirror held up to the house of Odysseus: same absent king, same courted wife, same son who must choose.
- 19 l. 199 Lines 199–200 repeat Athena's exhortation from 1.301–302 word for word — now in Nestor's mouth. Goddess and elder statesman, independently, say the same sentence to the boy. When the world repeats itself like that in Homer, it is fate talking.
- 20 l. 230 Athena borrows Zeus' rebuke to her from 1.64 — "what a word has slipped the fence of your teeth!" — and turns it on Telemachus. The formula travels down the hierarchy: father to daughter, goddess to boy.
- 21 l. 235 "By the treachery of Aegisthus *and of his own wife*": Clytemnestra enters the poem's version of the story here, and Nestor's fuller account (264–272) is strikingly gentle with her — her mind "still sound" at first, her fall a matter of the gods' binding doom, her consent given only at the end ("he willing, she willing"). Homer's Clytemnestra is a

woman worked on, not tragedy's axe-wielder — which makes her a darker mirror for the besieged Penelope.

- 22 l. 245 Nestor's proverbial age: he has ruled through three generations of men. His function in both epics is to be memory itself — which is exactly what Telemachus, a boy with no memories of his father, has come to borrow.
- 23 l. 267 The nameless singer whom Agamemnon left to guard his wife — and whom Aegisthus marooned to die on a desert island — appears only here in all Greek literature. It is a bard's professional aside: in this poem's moral world, song is a guardian of faithfulness, and the seducer's first necessary crime is to silence the singer. Compare Phemius, singing for the suitors "under compulsion" (1.154).
- 24 l. 272 "He willing, she willing" — ἐθέλων ἐθέλουσαν, two words that carry the whole moral weight of the fall. After years of resistance and a divine doom, the Greek grants Clytemnestra exactly one word of agency, and it is enough to hang the story on.
- 25 l. 279 Death "by the gentle arrows" of Apollo is the Homeric idiom for sudden, unexplained natural death (Artemis' arrows for women). Phrontis the helmsman dies at the tiller in fair passage — the sea claims even the best pilot alive, at the exact headland where Athena's temple would later stand.
- 26 l. 305 Here the translation follows Murray's text, which prints line 305 before 304 (keeping the traditional numbers): the sense runs "Aegisthus schemed at home; seven years he reigned in Mycenae, having killed Atreus' son..." — the transposition smooths the sequence of thought.
- 27 l. 309 Orestes "gave the Argives a funeral feast for his hateful mother and for spineless Aegisthus." The *Odyssey* passes over the matricide in a single adjective and a shared grave-feast — no Furies, no trial, no torment. The poem needs Orestes as a clean model for Telemachus, so the tragic machinery that Aeschylus will build is simply not here.
- 28 l. 332 The tongues of the victims, cut out and burned with a final libation, are the traditional last act of the sacrificial evening — the feast's closing signature. Athena the guest is the one who reminds her hosts of the god's due, which is both in character and quietly funny.
- 29 l. 372 Athena departs as a φήνη — a sea-eagle or bearded vulture. This is the second bird-exit in the poem (1.320), and the first read *precisely*: Telemachus in Ithaca sensed a god and no more, but Nestor names Athena on the spot and answers her. In *Pylos* the machinery of piety works entire — sign, recognition, vow, sacrifice, all in order.
- 30 l. 378 Τριτογένεια, "Tritogeneia" — an ancient cult title of Athena, already opaque to the poet's audience (born by Lake Tritonis? from Zeus' head beside the river Triton?). I transliterate rather than guess.
- 31 l. 382 The vow is precise votive economics: an unworked animal (never yoked), its horns sheathed in gold "so the goddess might see the glory and be glad" (438). The god must be *shown* the honor. The vow made here at evening is paid at dawn — the fastest-honored promise in the poem.

- 32 l. 408 The polished white stones "gleaming as if with oil" are the seat of kings before the high doors — Neleus sat on them, now Nestor does. Authority in this poem has furniture, and the furniture outlasts the men; the one-line obituary of Neleus in the middle is the *Odyssey's* whole theology of succession.
- 33 l. 440 Lines 440–463 are the fullest description of Greek animal sacrifice anywhere in Homer — lustral water, barley grains, the hair of the victim's head cast in the fire as first offering, the axe-blow, the blood-bowl, thigh-pieces wrapped in double fat with raw flesh laid on, wine poured over the burning. Classicists mine this passage as a primary document of the rite; the poem offers it as Pylos simply being Pylos.
- 34 l. 450 *ὀλόλυξαν* — the *ololygē*, the high ritual cry raised by women at the instant of the kill. It is not a scream of horror but a formal acclamation: the moment of death belongs to the women's voices, as the axe belongs to the men's hands.
- 35 l. 464 Polycaste, Nestor's youngest daughter, bathes and dresses the guest — the peak of honor a host's house can pay, and he rises from her bath "with the body of an immortal." Later tradition (a Hesiodic genealogy) married Polycaste to Telemachus; the poem plants only this one luminous, courteous scene.
- 36 l. 486 "All day long they shook the yoke they bore between them" — a whole day's driving in a single line of horses' bodies. The Homeric camera does not always linger; sometimes it cuts.
- 37 l. 497 The book closes on the sunset formula for the second time in eleven lines — day-line, night-stop, day-line — the rhythm of overland travel. Two sunsets bracket the leg from Pylos to the edge of Sparta, where Book 4 opens on Menelaus' feast.



## Odyssey — Book 4

*Sparta: Helen and Menelaus remember Troy; Proteus; the suitors set their ambush.*

- And they came to hollow Lacedaemon, land of ravines,<sup>1</sup>  
 and drove to the house of glorious Menelaus.  
 They found him giving a wedding-feast to his many kinsmen<sup>2</sup>  
 for his son and his blameless daughter, in his own house.
- 5 The daughter he was sending to the son of Achilles, breaker of ranks:  
 in Troy long ago he had promised her, had bowed his head  
 to give her, and now the gods were bringing the marriage to pass.  
 So now with horses and chariots he was sending her forth  
 to the famous city of the Myrmidons, whom that man ruled.
- 10 For his son he was bringing home Alector's daughter out of Sparta —  
 the son born to him in his strength, well-loved Megapenthes,  
 out of a slave-woman. For to Helen the gods showed no more children  
 after the first time, when she bore her lovely daughter  
 Hermione, who had the beauty of golden Aphrodite.
- 15 So they were feasting through the great high-roofed house,  
 the neighbors and kinsmen of glorious Menelaus,  
 taking their pleasure; and among them a godlike singer sang  
 to the lyre, and two tumblers among them,  
 as he led the song, went spinning through their midst.
- 20 And the two of them halted at the gateway of the house, themselves  
 and their horses — the hero Telemachus and Nestor's shining son.  
 Lord Eteoneus came out and saw them,  
 the busy henchman of glorious Menelaus,  
 and went through the house to bring the news to the shepherd of the  
 people;
- 25 standing close he spoke winged words to him:  
 "Two strangers here, Menelaus, nurtured of Zeus —  
 two men, and they look like the stock of great Zeus.  
 Tell me: do we unyoke their swift horses for them,  
 or send them on to another man, who may welcome them?"
- 30 Then fair-haired Menelaus, greatly stirred, replied:<sup>3</sup>

- "You were no fool before, Eteoneus, son of Boethous —  
 but now you are babbling nonsense like a child.  
 The two of us ate plenty of strangers' bread,  
 you and I, on the road home, hoping Zeus might someday  
 35 give us rest from misery. Unyoke the strangers' horses,  
 and bring the men themselves in, to share the feast."  
 So he spoke, and the man dashed back through the hall, and called the  
 other  
 busy henchmen to come along with him.  
 They loosed the sweating horses from under the yoke  
 40 and tied them up at the mangers of the horses,  
 and threw them spelt, and mixed white barley in with it,  
 and leaned the chariot against the gleaming entrance-wall,  
 and led the men into the godlike house. And they stared  
 in wonder through the house of the Zeus-nurtured king:  
 45 for there was a sheen as of the sun or the moon<sup>4</sup>  
 through the high-roofed house of glorious Menelaus.  
 And when they had had their joy of gazing,  
 they stepped into the polished baths and bathed.  
 And when the slave-women had bathed them and rubbed them with  
 oil,  
 50 and thrown about them fleecy cloaks and tunics,  
 they sat down on high seats beside Menelaus, Atreus' son.  
 A handmaid brought water for their hands in a pitcher,  
 a beautiful golden one, and poured it over a silver basin  
 for them to wash, and drew up a polished table beside them.  
 55 The grave housekeeper brought bread and set it before them,  
 laying out delicacies in plenty, giving gladly of her store;  
 a carver lifted platters of meat of every kind  
 and set them down, and placed gold cups beside them.  
 And fair-haired Menelaus greeted them with a wave of the hand:  
 60 "Take of the bread, and be welcome. And afterward,  
 when you have tasted supper, we will ask what men  
 you are: for the stock of your parents is not lost in you —  
 you are of the stock of scepter-bearing kings,  
 nurtured of Zeus. No base men could father such sons."  
 65 So he spoke, and set before them the fat roast chine of an ox,



- lifting it in his hands — the portion of honor they had set for him.  
 And their hands went out to the good things spread before them.  
 But when they had put away desire for food and drink,  
 then Telemachus spoke to the son of Nestor,
- 70 leaning his head close, so that the others might not hear:  
 "Look, son of Nestor, delight of my heart —<sup>5</sup>  
 the lightning of bronze through these echoing halls,  
 the gold and the amber, the silver and the ivory!  
 Such, I think, is the court of Olympian Zeus within:
- 75 all this here, past speaking! Awe takes me, looking at it."  
 But fair-haired Menelaus caught what he was saying,  
 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to them:  
 "Dear children, with Zeus no mortal man could vie:  
 his halls and his possessions are deathless things.
- 80 Among men, another may match me in wealth — or may not.  
 Much I suffered for it, and far I wandered  
 to bring it home in my ships: eight years gone before I came,  
 driven wandering to Cyprus and Phoenicia and the Egyptians;  
 I reached the Ethiopians, the Sidonians, the Erembi,
- 85 and Libya, where the lambs come horned from the birth,  
 for the ewes bear three times in the full round of the year.  
 There no lord and no shepherd goes wanting  
 for cheese and meat and sweet milk:  
 the flocks give milk for the milking all the year round.
- 90 But while I roamed those countries gathering  
 much substance, another man killed my brother —  
 by stealth, off guard, through the treachery of his cursed wife.<sup>6</sup>  
 So I take no joy in being lord of all this wealth.  
 You will have heard it from your fathers, whoever they are:
- 95 I have suffered much, and I lost a house  
 well lived-in, full of many splendid things.  
 Would I lived here with a third part only of all this,  
 and the men were alive who died in those years  
 in wide Troy, far from horse-grazing Argos!
- 100 And yet — though I mourn them all, and grieve,  
 often, sitting here in our halls,  
 and one hour ease my heart with weeping, and the next

- leave off, for men are quickly sated of cold lament —  
 for all of them together I do not mourn so much,  
 105 grieved though I am, as for one man, who makes sleep hateful to me,  
 and food, when I remember: for no Achaean labored  
 as Odysseus labored and endured. And the end of it was  
 sorrow for him, and for me a grief never to be forgotten —  
 that he is gone so long, and we know nothing,  
 110 whether he lives or is dead. They must be mourning him now,  
 old Laertes, and steady-hearted Penelope,  
 and Telemachus, whom he left new-born in the house."  
 So he spoke, and stirred in the boy the ache to weep for his father:  
 tears fell from his eyelids to the ground at his father's name,  
 115 and he lifted the purple cloak before his eyes  
 with both hands. And Menelaus noticed him,  
 and pondered then in his mind and in his heart  
 whether to leave it to him to name his father,  
 or to question him first and test him point by point.
- 120 While he was turning this over in his mind and in his heart,  
 out of her fragrant high-roofed chamber came Helen,<sup>7</sup>  
 looking like Artemis of the golden distaff;  
 and with her Adreste set out her well-made reclining chair,  
 Alcippe brought a rug of soft wool,  
 125 and Phylo brought her silver basket, given her  
 by Alcandre, wife of Polybus, who lived in Thebes  
 of Egypt, where the greatest wealth lies stored in houses:  
 he gave Menelaus two silver baths  
 and a pair of tripods and ten talents of gold;  
 130 and apart from these his wife gave Helen beautiful gifts of her own —  
 a golden distaff she gave, and a basket on wheels,  
 silver, its rims finished off in gold.  
 This the handmaid Phylo brought and set beside her,  
 stuffed with fine-spun yarn, and across it  
 135 lay the distaff, wound with wool of violet darkness.  
 She sat down on the chair, with a footstool for her feet,  
 and at once began asking her husband about everything:  
 "Do we know yet, Menelaus, nurtured of Zeus, who these men  
 declare themselves to be, who have come to our house?

- 140 Shall I lie, or speak the truth? My heart bids me speak.<sup>8</sup>  
 For never yet, I say, have I seen such a likeness,  
 in man or woman — awe takes me, looking at him —  
 as this boy is like the son of great-hearted Odysseus:  
 Telemachus, whom that man left new-born in the house
- 145 when for my sake — bitch-faced that I was — you Achaeans<sup>9</sup>  
 came up under Troy, with bold war in your hearts."  
 Then fair-haired Menelaus answered her:  
 "I too see it now, wife, just as you liken him:  
 those were the very feet of the man, the very hands,  
 150 the glance of his eyes, the head, the hair above.  
 And just now, remembering Odysseus,  
 I was telling of all he labored and endured  
 for my sake — and the boy shed a bitter tear from under his brows,  
 holding the purple cloak up before his eyes."
- 155 Then Peisistratus, Nestor's son, answered him:  
 "Menelaus, son of Atreus, Zeus-nurtured, leader of peoples,  
 this is indeed that man's son, as you say.  
 But he is modest, and his heart is shy  
 of splashing forth big words on a first arrival
- 160 in front of you, whose voice delights us both like a god's.  
 Gerenian Nestor the horseman sent me out  
 to come with him as escort: he longed to see you,  
 in hope you might set some word or work before him.  
 For a son has many sorrows in the house
- 165 when his father is gone and no other helpers stand by him —  
 as now with Telemachus: the father gone, and no others  
 in all the land to beat trouble away."  
 Then fair-haired Menelaus answered him:  
 "Well now! Truly the son of a beloved man is in my house,  
 170 a man who fought through many trials for my sake;  
 and I used to say that when he came I would welcome him beyond all  
 the other Argives — if Olympian Zeus of the wide voice  
 gave the two of us a homecoming over the sea in our fast ships.  
 I would have settled him a city in Argos, and built him a house,<sup>10</sup>  
 175 and brought him out of Ithaca with his goods and his son  
 and all his people — emptying out one town

of those that lie around and own me as their lord.  
 Being here, we would have mingled often; and nothing  
 would have parted us then, loving and delighting in each other,  
 180 until death's black cloud came folding round us.  
 But such things, I suppose, the god himself must have grudged,  
 who made that unlucky man — him alone — the man who never came  
 home."  
 So he spoke, and stirred in them all the ache of lament.  
 Argive Helen wept, the daughter of Zeus,  
 185 and Telemachus wept, and Menelaus, Atreus' son,  
 nor could the son of Nestor keep his eyes dry:  
 for his heart remembered blameless Antilochus,<sup>11</sup>  
 whom the shining son of bright Dawn had killed.  
 Remembering him, he spoke winged words:  
 190 "Son of Atreus, old Nestor always said  
 you were clear-headed beyond other mortals, whenever we  
 remembered you  
 in his halls, and questioned one another.  
 So now, if it may be, listen to me. I take  
 no pleasure in weeping after supper — and dawn  
 195 will come, early-born, soon enough. Not that I grudge  
 lament for any mortal who dies and meets his doom:  
 this is the only honor left to miserable mortals,<sup>12</sup>  
 to cut a lock of hair and let a tear fall down the cheek.  
 For my brother died too — hardly the meanest  
 200 of the Argives. You would know him. I myself never  
 met him, never saw him. But beyond other men, they say,  
 Antilochus was surpassing swift of foot, and a fighter."  
 Then fair-haired Menelaus answered him:  
 "Dear friend — you have said all a clear-headed man  
 205 could say or do, even a man older than you.  
 From such a father you come; hence your clear-headed speech.  
 Easily known is the seed of a man for whom the son of Cronos  
 spins out happiness at his marriage and his begetting —  
 as now he has granted Nestor, through all his days,  
 210 to grow old sleek in his own halls,  
 and his sons to be wise and the best of spearmen.

So we will let the weeping go, which came on us before,  
and think again of supper. Let them pour water  
over our hands. And at dawn there will be tales again  
215 for Telemachus and me to tell through to each other."  
So he spoke, and Asphalion poured water over their hands,  
the busy henchman of glorious Menelaus,  
and their hands went out to the good things spread before them.

Then Helen, daughter of Zeus, thought of one thing more:  
220 into the wine they were drinking she straightway cast a drug<sup>13</sup>  
that undoes grief and anger and brings forgetfulness of every evil.  
Whoever swallowed it down, once mixed in the bowl,  
would let no tear fall down his cheeks that day,  
not though his mother and his father lay there dead,  
225 not though before his face men put his brother or his own son  
to the bronze, and his own eyes saw it.  
Such were the subtle drugs the daughter of Zeus possessed,  
good drugs, given her by Polydamna, wife of Thon,  
the Egyptian — for there the grain-giving plowland bears  
230 drugs in greatest plenty, many good in the mixing, many baneful;  
and every man there is a healer beyond all  
humankind: for they are of the race of Paeon.  
When she had cast it in, and bidden the wine be poured,  
she took up the talk again, and said:  
235 "Menelaus, son of Atreus, nurtured of Zeus — and you,<sup>14</sup>  
sons of good men. To this man and that Zeus gives  
good and evil, now one, now another: for he can do all things.  
So now — feast where you sit in the halls  
and take your pleasure in tales. And I will tell one that fits the hour.  
240 All of it I could not tell, could not so much as number —  
all the trials of enduring-hearted Odysseus;  
but here is one thing that mighty man did and dared<sup>15</sup>  
in the Trojans' country, where you Achaeans suffered your pains.  
He beat his own body with disfiguring blows,  
245 threw a foul rag over his shoulders, and like a house-slave  
he slipped into the wide-wayed city of his enemies —  
hiding himself, in the likeness of another man,  
a beggar: he who was nothing of the kind by the Achaean ships.

In that shape he slipped into the Trojans' city, and all of them  
 250 were taken in. I alone knew him for what he was,  
 and questioned him; and he in his cunning kept slipping away.  
 But when at last I was bathing him and rubbing him with oil,  
 and had put clothes on him, and sworn a strong oath  
 not to reveal Odysseus to the Trojans  
 255 before he reached the fast ships and the huts,  
 then at last he told me all the Achaeans had in mind.  
 And he killed many Trojans with the long-edged bronze  
 on his way back to the Argives, and brought back a harvest of  
 knowledge.  
 Then the other women of Troy wailed shrill. But my heart  
 260 rejoiced — for my heart had turned already toward going  
 home again, and I mourned too late the madness Aphrodite  
 gave me, when she led me there from my own dear country,  
 forsaking my child, my bridal chamber, and a husband  
 lacking nothing, in mind or in beauty."  
 265 Then fair-haired Menelaus answered her:  
 "Yes, wife: all this you have told rightly, in due measure.  
 By now I have learned the counsel and the mind  
 of many heroes, and traveled over much of the earth,  
 but never yet have my eyes looked on such a one  
 270 as the heart of enduring-hearted Odysseus.  
 Here is one more thing that mighty man did and dared  
 inside the carved horse, where we sat, all the best  
 of the Argives, carrying death and doom to the Trojans.  
 Then you came there — some spirit must have moved you,<sup>16</sup>  
 275 one that willed to hand glory to the Trojans —  
 and godlike Deiphobus came following after you.  
 Three times you circled the hollow ambush, stroking it,  
 and you called by name the best of the Danaans,  
 making your voice the voice of each Argive's wife.  
 280 And I and the son of Tydeus and noble Odysseus,  
 sitting in the middle of them, heard you calling;  
 and the two of us were wild to spring up  
 and come out, or answer at once from within.  
 But Odysseus held us down, and checked us for all our longing.

- 285 Then all the other sons of the Achaeans kept silence;<sup>17</sup>  
 Anticlus alone was bent on giving you an answer —  
 but Odysseus clamped his great hands over his mouth  
 and held them there, unyielding, and saved all the Achaeans:  
 he held him so until Pallas Athena led you away."
- 290 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 "Menelaus, son of Atreus, Zeus-nurtured, leader of peoples —  
 the more grief: for none of this kept bitter death from him,  
 not though the heart inside him had been iron.  
 But come — send us to bed now, so that at last  
 295 we may lie down and take our joy of sweet sleep."  
 So he spoke; and Argive Helen ordered the slave-women  
 to set out bedsteads under the porch, and to lay on them  
 beautiful purple blankets, and spread rugs above,  
 and fleecy cloaks on top of all, for cover.
- 300 Out of the hall they went with torches in their hands  
 and made the beds; and a herald led the guests out.  
 So they slept there in the forecourt of the house,  
 the hero Telemachus and Nestor's shining son;  
 but Atreus' son slept in the inner room of the high house,  
 305 and beside him lay long-robed Helen, shining among women.
- When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,  
 Menelaus of the great war-cry rose up from his bed,  
 put on his clothes, slung his sharp sword about his shoulder,  
 bound the beautiful sandals beneath his shining feet,  
 310 and came out of his bedroom looking like a god.  
 He sat down beside Telemachus, and spoke a word, and named him:  
 "What need has brought you here, hero Telemachus,  
 to shining Lacedaemon, over the broad back of the sea?  
 A public matter or private? Tell me the plain truth of it."
- 315 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 "Menelaus, son of Atreus, Zeus-nurtured, leader of peoples,  
 I came in hope you might tell me some word of my father.  
 My house is being eaten; my rich fields are ruined;  
 the house is packed with enemies, who day upon day  
 320 slaughter my thronging flocks and my shambling crook-horned cattle  
 —

my mother's suitors, with their overweening insolence.  
 That is why I come now to your knees: in hope you will consent<sup>18</sup>  
 to tell his bitter death — whether you saw it  
 with your own eyes, or heard the tale of him from another  
 325 wanderer. Beyond all men his mother bore him for sorrow.  
 Do not soften anything from courtesy or pity:  
 tell me fully whatever sight you came upon.  
 I beg you — if ever my father, good Odysseus,  
 promised you word or work and made it good  
 330 in the Trojans' country, where you Achaeans suffered your pains,  
 remember it for me now: tell me the unerring truth."  
 Then fair-haired Menelaus, greatly stirred, replied:  
 "Shame on them! Truly in the bed of a strong-hearted man  
 they want to lie — the spineless creatures that they are!  
 335 As when a deer beds down her newborn suckling fawns<sup>19</sup>  
 in the thicket-lair of a mighty lion,  
 and goes questing the spurs and grassy hollows,  
 grazing — and then the lion comes back to his own bed  
 and lets an ugly doom loose on them both:  
 340 so Odysseus will let an ugly doom loose on those men.  
 If only — father Zeus, Athena, Apollo! —  
 the man he was long ago in strong-founded Lesbos,  
 when he rose on a challenge and wrestled Philomeleides  
 and threw him hard, and all the Achaeans cheered:  
 345 such as he was then, let that Odysseus close with the suitors:  
 quick would their fates be then, and bitter their weddings.  
 As for what you ask of me and beg me: I will not  
 talk around it, swerving aside, and I will not deceive you.  
 What the unerring Old Man of the Sea told me,<sup>20</sup>  
 350 not one word of it will I hide or cover from you.  
 In Egypt the gods still held me, hungry as I was for home,  
 because I had not offered them their full hecatombs —  
 and the gods will always have their commandments remembered.  
 Now there is an island in the much-surging sea  
 355 off the mouth of Egypt — Pharos, men call it,<sup>21</sup>  
 as far out as a hollow ship runs in a whole day  
 with a whistling wind astern of her —



- and in it a harbor, good anchorage, from which men launch  
their trim ships to sea, once they have drawn black water.
- 360 There the gods held me twenty days: never once the sea-winds  
blowing fair, that speed ships  
over the broad back of the sea.
- And now all our stores would have been spent, and the men's strength,  
had not one of the gods pitied me and saved me:
- 365 the daughter of mighty Proteus, the Old Man of the Sea —  
Eidothea. For I stirred her heart beyond the rest<sup>22</sup>  
when she met me wandering alone, apart from my companions —  
for they were forever roving round the island, fishing  
with bent hooks, their bellies pinched with hunger.
- 370 She stood close by me and spoke, and said:  
'Are you a fool, stranger — so slack, so loose of wit?  
Or do you slacken by choice, and enjoy your suffering?  
So long you are held on the island, and can find  
no ending of it, while your companions' hearts grow small.'
- 375 So she spoke, and I answered her:  
'I will say this straight, whichever of the goddesses you are:  
I am not held here by any will of mine. I must have sinned  
against the deathless ones who hold wide heaven.  
But tell me — for the gods know all things —
- 380 which of the immortals shackles me here and has bound my road,  
and my homecoming — how I shall go over the fish-filled sea.'  
So I spoke, and the shining goddess answered at once:  
'Then I will tell you, stranger, and tell you truly.  
There haunts this place an unerring Old Man of the Sea,
- 385 deathless Proteus of Egypt, who knows the depths  
of every sea — Poseidon's under-servant.<sup>23</sup>  
He, they say, is my father, who begot me.  
If you could somehow set an ambush and take hold of him,  
he would tell you the road, and the measures of your journey,
- 390 and your homecoming — how you shall go over the fish-filled sea.  
And he would tell you too, Zeus-nurtured, if you wish,  
whatever evil and good have been done in your halls  
while you have been gone on your long and grinding road.'  
So she spoke, and I answered her:

- 395 'Devise the ambush yourself, for this old god —  
 or he will see me first, or know beforehand, and escape me.  
 A god is hard for a mortal man to master.'  
 So I spoke, and the shining goddess answered at once:  
 'Then I will tell you, stranger, and tell you truly.
- 400 When the sun bestrides the middle of heaven,  
 then the unerring Old Man of the Sea comes out of the water  
 under the West Wind's breath, hidden in the dark shiver of the sea,  
 and coming out he beds down under the hollow caves;  
 and around him seals, the brood of the sea's lovely daughter,<sup>24</sup>
- 405 sleep in a crowd, come up out of the gray salt water,  
 breathing out the sharp smell of the deep brine.  
 There I will bring you at the showing of dawn  
 and bed you down in the row. Choose well three companions,  
 the best you have by the well-benched ships.
- 410 And I will tell you all the old man's tricks.  
 First he will count his seals, and go over them;  
 and when he has told them off by fives and seen them all,  
 he will lie down in their midst, like a herdsman in his flocks.  
 The moment you see him settled down,
- 415 then let strength and force be all your thought:  
 hold him there for all his struggling, however he strains to escape.  
 He will make trial of everything, turning into all things<sup>25</sup>  
 that creep upon the earth — into water, into god-kindled fire;  
 but hold him unshakably, and press him the harder.
- 420 And when at last he questions you with words himself,  
 in the same shape you saw him settle to sleep,  
 then leave off your force, hero: set the old man loose,  
 and ask him which of the gods bears hard on you,  
 and your homecoming — how you shall go over the fish-filled sea.'
- 425 So speaking she plunged under the surging sea.  
 And I went to the ships where they stood in the sand,  
 and my heart ran dark with many things as I went.  
 And when I had come down to the ship and the sea,  
 we made our supper, and ambrosial night came on,
- 430 and we lay down to sleep on the surf-line of the sea.  
 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,

- I set out along the shore of the wide-wayed sea,  
 praying hard to the gods; and I took three companions,  
 the three I trusted most for every venture.
- 435 She meanwhile had slipped under the wide gulf of the sea  
 and brought up out of the deep four sealskins,  
 all fresh-flayed: she was plotting an ambush against her own father.  
 She had scooped out beds in the sea-sand  
 and sat there waiting. And we came up close beside her,
- 440 and she bedded us down in the row, and threw a skin over each.  
 There our ambush would have been most horrible: the deadly<sup>26</sup>  
 stench of the salt-bred seals ground us down horribly —  
 who would lay himself down beside a beast of the sea? —  
 but she herself saved us; she devised a great relief:
- 445 she brought ambrosia and set it under each man's nose,  
 breathing sweetness, and it killed the stench of the beast.  
 All the morning we waited, with enduring hearts,  
 and the seals came crowding up out of the sea, and then  
 lay down in rows along the surf-line of the sea;
- 450 and at midday the old man came out of the sea, and found his fat  
 seals, and went over them all, and counted the number —  
 and among the beasts he counted us the first, his heart  
 never guessing the trick. Then he too lay down.  
 Then we rushed him with a shout, and threw our arms
- 455 around him; and the old man did not forget his cunning art,  
 but first he turned to a great-bearded lion,  
 and then to a serpent, a leopard, a huge boar;  
 he turned to running water, to a tree in towering leaf;  
 and we held on unshakably, with enduring hearts.
- 460 But when at last the old man wearied, for all his tricks,  
 then he questioned me with words, and said:  
 'Which of the gods, son of Atreus, laid the plan with you  
 to take me by ambush against my will? What do you need?'  
 So he spoke, and I answered him:
- 465 'You know, old man — why ask me sideways? —  
 how long I am held on this island, and can find  
 no ending of it, and the heart inside me grows small.  
 But tell me — for the gods know all things —

- which of the immortals shackles me here and has bound my road,  
 470 and my homecoming — how I shall go over the fish-filled sea.'  
 So I spoke, and he answered me at once:  
 'But you should have offered fair victims to Zeus and the other  
 gods before embarking, to come most quickly  
 to your own country, sailing the wine-dark sea.  
 475 For it is not your portion to see your own people, to reach  
 your well-built house and your own fatherland,  
 before you go back again to the waters of Egypt,  
 the river fallen from Zeus, and offer holy hecatombs<sup>27</sup>  
 to the deathless gods who hold wide heaven.  
 480 Then the gods will give you the road you long for.'  
 So he spoke, and my heart broke within me,  
 because he sent me back over the misted sea  
 to Egypt again — the long and grinding road.  
 Even so I answered him and said:  
 485 'All this I will do, old man, just as you command.  
 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:  
 did all the Achaeans come home unharmed in their ships,  
 all whom Nestor and I left behind when we sailed from Troy?  
 Or did any die a bitter death aboard his ship,  
 490 or in the arms of his friends, once he had wound the war to its end?'  
 So I spoke, and he answered me at once:  
 'Son of Atreus, why ask me this? You have no need  
 to know, no need to learn my mind. Not long, I tell you,  
 will you keep from tears, once you have heard the whole of it.  
 495 Many of them were broken, and many were left;  
 but of the leaders of the bronze-shirted Achaeans, two  
 alone died on the homeward way — the fighting you saw yourself —  
 and one, still living somewhere, is held back on the wide sea.  
 Ajax was broken among his long-oared ships.<sup>28</sup>  
 500 Poseidon drove him first against the great rocks  
 of Gyrae — and yet he saved him from the sea;  
 and he would have escaped his doom, though Athena hated him,  
 had he not flung out an overweening word in his great blindness:  
 he said it was in the gods' despite he had escaped the great gulf of the  
 sea.

505 Poseidon heard his loud boasting,  
 and straightway took his trident in his massive hands  
 and struck the rock of Gyrae, and split it apart:  
 one part held its place, but the broken piece fell in the sea —  
 the piece where Ajax sat when the great blindness took him —  
 510 and it carried him down into the boundless surging deep.  
 So he died there, when he had drunk the salt water.  
 But your brother somehow slipped the fates, escaped them  
 in his hollow ships: the lady Hera saved him.  
 Yet when he was all but come to the steep height  
 515 of Malea, then a storm-wind snatched him up  
 and carried him, groaning heavily, over the fish-filled sea  
 to the border of the country where Thyestes once  
 had his house, and now Thyestes' son Aegisthus lived.  
 But when from there too a safe homecoming showed,  
 520 and the gods turned the wind fair, and they reached home —  
 oh, rejoicing he set foot on his fathers' land,<sup>29</sup>  
 and touched his country and kissed it: the hot tears  
 streamed from him, so glad he was to see his land.  
 But from a lookout a watchman saw him — posted there  
 525 by Aegisthus of the crooked counsels, who had promised him  
 two talents of gold for wages: a full year he had watched,  
 so the king might not slip past unseen and remember his fighting  
 strength.  
 The man went with his news to the house, to the shepherd of the  
 people,  
 and at once Aegisthus laid his treacherous craft:  
 530 he picked the twenty best men in the land  
 and set an ambush, and across the hall he ordered a feast made ready;  
 and then he went to summon Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,  
 with horses and chariots — and unspeakable things in his mind.  
 He led him up unwitting of his death, and killed him  
 535 at the dinner — as a man cuts down an ox at the manger.<sup>30</sup>  
 Not one of the companions of Atreus' son was left, who followed him,  
 and not one of Aegisthus' men: they were killed in the halls.'  
 So he spoke, and my heart broke within me,  
 and I wept, sitting there in the sand; my heart

- 540 had no more will to live and see the light of the sun.  
 But when I had had my fill of weeping and writhing,  
 then the unerring Old Man of the Sea said to me:  
 'No more now, son of Atreus, this long unbending  
 weeping: we shall find no cure in it. Quick as you can,  
 545 try how you may come back to your own fatherland.  
 Either you will find him alive — or Orestes  
 has already killed him first, and you may come in time for the burying.'  
 So he spoke; and the heart and the proud spirit in my breast,  
 for all my grieving, were warmed again,  
 550 and lifting my voice I spoke winged words to him:  
 'These men I now know of. But name the third man:  
 the one still living, held back on the wide sea —  
 or dead. Grieved as I am, I want to hear it.'  
 So I spoke, and he answered me at once:  
 555 'The son of Laertes, whose home is in Ithaca.<sup>31</sup>  
 I saw him on an island, letting the big tears fall,  
 in the halls of the nymph Calypso, who holds him there  
 by force; and he cannot come to his own fatherland,  
 for he has no ships at hand, no oars, no companions  
 560 to carry him over the broad back of the sea.  
 But for you, Zeus-nurtured Menelaus, it is not fated<sup>32</sup>  
 to die in horse-grazing Argos and meet your doom:  
 the deathless ones will carry you to the Elysian plain  
 and the ends of the earth — where fair-haired Rhadamanthus is,  
 565 where life is easiest of all for men:  
 no snow, no heavy winter, never rain,  
 but always Ocean sends up the breath of the singing West Wind  
 to bring men coolness —  
 because Helen is yours, and you are son-in-law to Zeus.'  
 570 So speaking he plunged under the surging sea.  
 And I went to the ships with my godlike companions,  
 and my heart ran dark with many things as I went.  
 And when we had come down to the ship and the sea,  
 we made our supper, and ambrosial night came on,  
 575 and we lay down to sleep on the surf-line of the sea.  
 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,

- first of all we hauled our ships down to the bright salt water  
and set the masts and the sails in the trim ships,  
and the men came aboard and took their places at the oarlocks,  
580 and sitting in order they struck the gray salt water with their oars.  
Back to Egypt I brought the ships, to the river  
fallen from Zeus, and I offered the full hecatombs;  
and when I had put to rest the anger of the gods who are forever,  
I heaped a mound for Agamemnon, that his fame might never be  
quenched.<sup>33</sup>
- 585 That done, I sailed for home, and the immortals gave me  
a wind, and brought me quickly to my own dear country.  
But come now — stay on in my halls  
until the eleventh day, or the twelfth;  
then I will send you off with honor, and give you shining gifts:  
590 three horses and a polished chariot; and besides  
I will give you a beautiful cup, so that you may pour  
to the deathless gods and remember me all your days."  
Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
"Son of Atreus, do not hold me here for long.  
595 A year I could gladly sit here at your side  
and no ache for home or parents would take me:  
such strange delight I have in hearing your tales  
and your words. But my companions chafe already  
in holy Pylos, and you would hold me long here.  
600 As for the gift you would give me — let it be some treasure.  
The horses I will not take to Ithaca: I will leave them here<sup>34</sup>  
for you, for your own glory. For you are lord of a wide plain,  
where lotus grows in plenty, and galingale,  
and wheat and spelt and broad white barley.  
605 In Ithaca there are no wide courses, no meadowland at all:  
goat-pasture — and lovelier to me than horse-pasture.  
Not one of the islands that lean on the sea is fit for driving horses,  
or rich in meadows — and Ithaca beyond them all."  
So he spoke; and Menelaus of the great war-cry smiled,<sup>35</sup>  
610 and stroked him with his hand, and spoke a word, and named him:  
"You are of good blood, dear child — such things you say!  
Then I will change the gifts for you; well I can.

- Of all the treasures lying stored in my house  
 I will give you the most beautiful, the most honored:
- 615 I will give you a wrought mixing-bowl — all silver  
 it is, and its rims are finished off in gold —  
 the work of Hephaestus. The hero Phaedimus gave it,<sup>36</sup>  
 king of the Sidonians, when his house sheltered me  
 on my way home there. This I would send with you."
- 620 So the two of them spoke such things to one another,  
 while the feasters came up to the godlike king's house,  
 driving sheep before them, carrying wine that puts heart in men,<sup>37</sup>  
 and their fair-veiled wives sent bread along with them.  
 So they labored at the feast in the halls.
- 625 But the suitors, in front of Odysseus' hall,  
 were amusing themselves with discus and javelin throws  
 on the leveled ground, insolent as ever, where they always played.  
 There Antinous sat, and godlike Eurymachus,  
 chiefs of the suitors, in prowess far the best of them all.
- 630 To them Noemon, Phronius' son, came up  
 and questioned Antinous, and said:  
 "Antinous, do we know at all — or not —  
 when Telemachus comes back from sandy Pylos?  
 He went off with my ship, and now I need her
- 635 to cross to Elis of the wide dancing-grounds, where I keep twelve  
 brood mares, with hard-working mules at the teat,  
 unbroken: I would drive one off and break him in."  
 So he spoke, and their hearts were astonished: they had never thought  
 he had gone to Neleian Pylos — surely he was somewhere near,
- 640 out at the farms with the flocks, or with the swineherd.  
 Then Antinous, Eupeithes' son, answered him:  
 "Tell me the truth of it: when did he go, and what young men  
 went with him? Picked men of Ithaca — or his own  
 hired hands and slaves? He could manage even that!
- 645 And tell me this too, honestly, so that I may know it:  
 did he take the black ship from you by force, against your will,  
 or did you give it freely, because he begged you with fine words?"  
 Then Noemon, Phronius' son, answered him:



- "I gave it freely, myself. What would any man do  
 650 when such a man, with cares heavy on his heart,  
 asked? It would be hard to refuse the gift.  
 The young men who went with him are the best in the land  
 after ourselves. And for their leader I marked  
 Mentor going aboard — or a god, the very image of him.<sup>38</sup>  
 655 But here is what I wonder at: I saw noble Mentor  
 yesterday at dawn, right here — and he had boarded the ship for  
 Pylos."  
 So he spoke, and went away to his father's house.  
 And the proud hearts of the two of them were stunned.  
 They sat the suitors down in a body and stopped their games,  
 660 and among them spoke Antinous, Eupheithes' son,  
 in anger: his black-brimming heart was hugely  
 filled with fury, and his eyes were like blazing fire:  
 "Damn it all — a great work insolently accomplished,  
 this voyage of Telemachus! And we said it would come to nothing.  
 665 In the teeth of all of us, a mere boy has simply gone:  
 hauled down a ship, and picked the best men in the land.  
 He will begin to be our ruin, and soon. May Zeus  
 destroy his strength before he reaches the measure of manhood!  
 But come, give me a fast ship and twenty companions,<sup>39</sup>  
 670 so I may watch for him and ambush him on his way home,  
 in the strait between Ithaca and rugged Samos —  
 so this sailing after his father may cost him grim and dear."  
 So he spoke, and they all approved it and urged it on.  
 They rose at once and went into the house of Odysseus.  
 675 Nor was Penelope long in ignorance  
 of the schemes the suitors were brewing deep in their hearts:  
 for the herald Medon told her, who had overheard their plans,  
 standing outside the court while they wove their plot within.  
 He went through the house to bring the news to Penelope,  
 680 and as he crossed the threshold Penelope said to him:  
 "Herald, why have the lordly suitors sent you in?  
 To tell the slave-women of godlike Odysseus  
 to leave their work and make the feast ready for them?  
 May they never woo again, never gather anywhere else —

- 685 may this be the last supper they ever eat here,  
 they who swarm in day after day and shear away the living,  
 the substance of clear-headed Telemachus! Did you never hear,  
 in years gone by, when you were children, from your fathers,  
 what kind of man Odysseus was among your parents' generation?
- 690 Never a deed out of measure, never an unjust word<sup>40</sup>  
 in all the land — though that is the way of godlike kings:  
 one mortal a king will hate, another he may love;  
 but that man never did outrage to a single soul.  
 No — your hearts are on show, and your ugly works:  
 695 there is no gratitude left, afterward, for good deeds done."  
 Then Medon answered her, a man of clear-headed sense:  
 "Would to god, my queen, that this were the worst of it.  
 A greater evil by far, and harder to bear,  
 the suitors are plotting now — may the son of Cronos never accomplish  
 it:
- 700 they are bent on cutting Telemachus down with the sharp bronze  
 on his way home. He went for news of his father  
 to holy Pylos and to shining Lacedaemon."  
 So he spoke, and there where she stood her knees went loose, and her  
 heart;  
 for a long time speechlessness held her words; her eyes  
 705 filled up with tears; the flower of her voice was stopped.<sup>41</sup>  
 At long last she found words to answer him:  
 "Herald, why is my child gone? There was no need  
 to board the fast-running ships, that are men's horses<sup>42</sup>  
 of the salt water, and cross the great wet waste.
- 710 Is it so that not even his name should be left among men?"  
 Then Medon answered her, a man of clear-headed sense:  
 "I do not know whether some god stirred him, or whether his own  
 heart drove him to go to Pylos, to learn  
 either his father's homecoming, or what doom he met."  
 715 So he spoke, and went away down through the house of Odysseus.  
 And heart-eating anguish poured around her; she could no longer  
 bear to sit on a chair, though the house was full of them,  
 but sank down on the threshold of her richly-worked chamber,  
 moaning pitiably; and around her whimpered the slave-women,

- 720 all of them, young and old, that the house held.  
 And sobbing hard, Penelope said among them:  
 "Hear me, dear women. The Olympian has given me sorrows  
 beyond all the women who were bred and born beside me.  
 Long ago I lost my noble husband, the lion-hearted,<sup>43</sup>  
 725 graced among the Danaans with every excellence,  
 that noble man, whose fame goes wide through Hellas and the heart of  
 Argos.  
 And now again the storm-winds have snatched my beloved son,  
 without glory, out of these halls, and I never heard him go.  
 Hard-hearted! Not even you — not one of you — thought  
 730 to wake me from my bed, though your hearts knew well  
 the hour he went down to the black hollow ship.  
 If I had learned that he was pondering this journey,  
 then either he would have stayed, for all his hunger for the road,  
 or he would have left me dead in these halls behind him.  
 735 But now let someone run and call old Dolius,<sup>44</sup>  
 my slave, whom my father gave me when I first came here,  
 who keeps my orchard of many trees — so that quickly  
 he may go sit beside Laertes and tell him all of it.  
 Perhaps Laertes may weave some plan in his heart,  
 740 and come out and weep before the people, who are bent  
 on destroying his line and the line of godlike Odysseus."  
 Then the dear nurse Eurycleia said to her:  
 "Dear bride — kill me with the pitiless bronze<sup>45</sup>  
 or leave me in the house, but I will not hide the story from you.  
 745 I knew all of it. I gave him what he ordered,  
 bread and sweet wine. And he took a great oath from me  
 not to tell you before the twelfth day came,  
 or you missed him yourself and heard that he was gone —  
 so you would not mar your lovely skin with weeping.  
 750 Now bathe, and take clean clothing for your body,  
 and go up to your upper room with your attendant women,  
 and pray to Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus:  
 she may yet save him, even out of death itself.  
 And do not grieve a grieving old man more. I cannot think  
 755 the blessed gods have wholly hated the line

- of Arceisius' son: someone will yet be left to hold<sup>46</sup>  
the high-roofed house and the fat fields far around."  
So she spoke, and lulled her lament, and stayed her eyes from weeping.  
And she bathed, and took clean clothing for her body,  
760 and went up to her upper room with her attendant women,  
and set the barley-grains in a basket, and prayed to Athena:<sup>47</sup>  
"Hear me, child of aegis-bearing Zeus, Unwearied One.  
If ever Odysseus of the many designs, in these halls,  
burned fat thigh-cuts of ox or sheep for you,  
765 remember them for me now: save my dear son,  
and beat away the suitors in their evil overbearing pride."  
So she cried the ritual cry; and the goddess heard her prayer.  
But the suitors broke into uproar through the shadowy halls,  
and thus would one of the arrogant young men say:  
770 "So the much-courted queen is making ready a marriage  
for one of us — and knows nothing of the death prepared for her son."  
So they would say — knowing nothing of what was prepared.<sup>48</sup>  
And Antinous addressed them all, and said:  
"Fools! Keep clear of overweening talk of any kind —  
775 or someone may carry the word inside.  
Up now, in silence, and let us accomplish  
the plan that pleased us all in our hearts."  
So he spoke, and picked the twenty best men,  
and they went down to the fast ship and the sand-beach of the sea.  
780 First of all they hauled the ship down to deep water,  
and set the mast and the sails in the black ship,  
and fitted the oars into their leather slings,  
all in due order, and spread the white sails open;  
and high-spirited henchmen carried down their arms.  
785 They moored her well out in the water, and came ashore,  
and there they took their supper, and waited for evening to come.  
But she in her upper room, watchful-minded Penelope,  
lay fasting, tasting neither food nor drink,  
turning it over: whether her blameless son would escape death,  
790 or be broken under the overweening suitors.  
As a lion turns and turns amid a crowd of men,<sup>49</sup>  
in dread, as they draw the treacherous circle round him,

so she was turning when the deep sleep came upon her;  
and she sank back and slept, and all her joints went loose.

795 Then the goddess thought of one thing more, gray-eyed Athena.  
She made a phantom, fashioned in the likeness of a woman —<sup>50</sup>

Iphthime, daughter of great-hearted Icarius,  
wed to Eumelus, whose home was in Pherae —  
and sent it to the house of godlike Odysseus,

800 so that it might bring Penelope, weeping and mourning,  
some pause from lamentation and tear-filled grief.  
Into the chamber it came, past the strap of the bolt,  
and stood above her head, and said to her:

"Do you sleep, Penelope, your heart worn with grief?

805 No — the gods who live at ease will not have you  
weep and be anguished: for your son has his homecoming  
still; he is no sinner in the sight of the gods."

Then watchful-minded Penelope answered her —  
slumbering very sweetly at the gates of dream:<sup>51</sup>

810 "Why have you come here, sister? You have not been  
used to come before: your home is far away.  
And you bid me leave off my misery and all the pains  
that crowd my mind and heart.

Long ago I lost my noble husband, the lion-hearted,  
815 graced among the Danaans with every excellence,  
that noble man, whose fame goes wide through Hellas and the heart of  
Argos.

And now again my beloved son has gone in a hollow ship,  
a mere boy, unpracticed in hardships and the meetings of men.  
It is for him I mourn even more than for that other;

820 for him I tremble, for him I fear, that something may strike him,  
whether among the men of the land he has gone to, or on the sea.  
For many enemies are scheming against him,  
hungry to kill him before he comes back to his own country."

And the dim phantom answered her:

825 "Take heart. Do not fear too greatly in your mind.

Such an escort goes with him as other men  
have prayed to have stand beside them — for she has power —  
Pallas Athena. And she pities you your grieving:

it is she who sent me now to tell you this."

830 Then watchful-minded Penelope said to her:

"If you are truly a god, and have heard the voice of a god,  
then come — tell me also of that other, that man of sorrow:  
does he live still somewhere, and see the light of the sun,  
or is he dead already, down in the house of Hades?"

835 And the dim phantom answered her:

"Of him I will not tell the story through —  
whether he lives or is dead. It is evil to speak words empty as wind."<sup>52</sup>  
So speaking it slipped away by the doorpost bolt  
into the breath of the winds. And the daughter of Icarius  
840 started up out of sleep, and her heart was warmed:  
so vivid a dream had rushed upon her in the dark hour of the night.

But the suitors had embarked, and were sailing the watery ways,  
turning over in their hearts sheer murder for Telemachus.

There is a rocky island in the middle of the sea,

845 midway between Ithaca and rugged Samos —

Asteris, no great place; but there are harbors in it  
fit for ships to lurk in, open at either end. There the Achaeans waited in  
ambush.<sup>53</sup>

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 4

- 1    *l. 1* κητώεσσον, "land of ravines" — an old puzzle-word: "full of hollows" (from the ravined Laconian landscape), or "full of sea-monsters" (κητος), which fits the sea, not inland Sparta. I take the ravines; the strangeness was already ancient.
- 2    *l. 3* The double wedding: Hermione is sent to Achilles' son Neoptolemus (a marriage promised at Troy — tragedy later made it disastrous), while the home-wedding is for Megapenthes, Menelaus' son by a slave-woman. Two facts are placed without comment: the gods gave Helen no child after Hermione, and Megapenthes' name means "Great-Grief" — a son named for the sorrow of the years his father was winning Helen back.
- 3    *l. 30* Menelaus' first act is to snap at his own herald for even *asking* whether to receive strangers — "we two ate plenty of strangers' bread." Hospitality here is autobiography: the wanderer feeds wanderers. The scene is a deliberate foil to Ithaca, where the uninvited eat the host.
- 4    *l. 45* "A sheen as of the sun or the moon" — the same line used of Alcinous' fairy-tale palace at 7.84. Sparta glows like Phaeacia; Telemachus has stepped out of his broken house into the two most luminous courts in the poem, one after the other.
- 5    *l. 71* Telemachus' whisper of awe (σέβας μ' ἔχει, "awe takes me") is answered at 142 by Helen using the identical phrase about *him*. The guest marvels at the house; the hostess marvels at the guest. It is the book's first hint of its master theme: recognition.
- 6    *l. 92* "Another man killed my brother... through the treachery of his cursed wife." The Agamemnon story keeps arriving before Odysseus' story can be told — here as the poison in Menelaus' wealth. Note that Menelaus blames the wife more directly than Nestor did; every speaker in the poem calibrates Clytemnestra differently.
- 7    *l. 121* Helen's entrance is staged like an epiphany — "like Artemis of the golden distaff" — with a full inventory of her equipment, all of it Egyptian luxury: the silver basket on wheels, the distaff wound with violet-dark wool. The woman who caused the war enters as the image of chaste domesticity (Artemis! wool-work!), and the poem lets the irony stand without a word.
- 8    *l. 140* "Shall I lie, or speak the truth? My heart bids me speak." The question is formulaic — Nestor asks it nearly word for word at *Iliad* 10.534 — and what it prefaces here is an identification, not a tale. But from Helen, weighing falsehood aloud in the act of performing sincerity, it can be heard as the key in which the whole evening's storytelling is set.
- 9    *l. 145* κυνώπιδος, "bitch-faced that I was": Helen's savage word for herself (as at *Iliad* 3.180). Whether it is real remorse or the performance of remorse — charming, disarming, unanswerable — is exactly what the poem declines to settle.
- 10    *l. 174* Menelaus' fantasy for Odysseus: he would have *emptied a city* of its inhabitants to resettle his friend next door. The casualness of "emptying out one town" is a king's love-

language — and a measure of the power Telemachus is standing in front of.

- 11 l. 187 Antilochus, Nestor's son, was killed by Memnon, "the shining son of bright Dawn" — a story from the lost *Aethiopsis*, alluded to as known. Peisistratus weeps for a brother he was too young to meet (200–201): grief at one remove, the Telemachy's signature emotion.
- 12 l. 197 "This is the only honor left to miserable mortals, / to cut a lock of hair and let a tear fall down the cheek." Peisistratus' definition of mourning is the poem's most compact statement of what the living owe the dead — and why denying Odysseus a funeral (he is neither alive nor buried) is an open wound.
- 13 l. 220 The famous *νηπενθές*, "nepenthes" — the drug "that undoes grief and anger and brings forgetfulness of every evil," Egyptian, from Polydamna wife of Thon. The specification is chilling if read slowly: you could watch your brother butchered before your face and not weep *that day*. Helen administers chemical composure so that Troy can be discussed at dinner — the hostess drugging her guests into painless memory. Everything told for the next seventy lines is told under its influence.
- 14 l. 235 Note who commands the room: Helen proposes the evening's entertainment, tells the first tale, and names its genre ("one that fits the hour"). Menelaus answers, seconds, and caps her. The marriage runs on her stage-management, and the poem lets us watch it run.
- 15 l. 242 "Here is one thing that mighty man did and dared" — the frame-line Helen and Menelaus each use (242, 271) to introduce their tales, and the hinge of the book's central irony. Helen's story: Odysseus came disguised as a beggar; *I alone* recognized him, helped him, kept his secret; my heart had already turned home. Menelaus' story, immediately after: you circled the horse imitating our wives' voices to lure us to our deaths — with your *new* Trojan husband Deiphobus at your side. Two Helens, mutually annihilating, told back to back over drugged wine, in perfect courtesy. The poem's deepest lesson in how memory is made — and it is also a preview: an Odysseus disguised in a beggar's rags, recognized only by a discerning woman, is the plot of Books 17–23.
- 16 l. 274 "Some spirit must have moved you" — Menelaus offers his wife the divine-agency excuse even while telling the story that damns her; courtesy and accusation in one clause. Deiphobus, named at 276, was the Trojan who married Helen after Paris' death: the detail quietly dates her "heart had already turned home" claim.
- 17 l. 285 The Anticlus episode (285–289) was suspected already in antiquity as an import from the epic cycle — Aristarchus athetized the lines. Genuine or grafted, the image earns its place: Odysseus saving the army by clamping a man's mouth shut with his bare hands is endurance-cunning at its most physical.
- 18 l. 322 Lines 322–331 repeat Telemachus' plea to Nestor (3.92–101) verbatim, and the translation repeats itself verbatim: the boy has a set speech for great men now, and the poem lets us hear him reuse it — a young envoy's professionalism, learned in a week.
- 19 l. 335 The deer who beds her fawns in the lion's lair: the suitors' simile of doom, repeated later word for word when Telemachus reports this conversation to Penelope (17.124–



- 131). The fawns are "newborn" and "suckling" — the pathos is with the doomed, and the poem does not flinch from it: that is what the lion's homecoming means.
- 20 l. 349 γέρων ἄλιος νημερτής, "the unerring Old Man of the Sea" — Proteus' fixed formula. His epithet is *truthfulness*; the shapeshifter is the poem's most reliable informant. Forms lie; the voice, once you hold on long enough, cannot.
- 21 l. 355 Pharos — the island of the later lighthouse — is in fact a bowshot off the Egyptian coast, not "a whole day's sail." Poetic geography: the poem needs an island prison, so the map stretches.
- 22 l. 366 Eidothea betrays her own father's resting-hour and provides the disguise, the ambrosia, everything — and the poem never says why. She is the first of the poem's chain of women who rescue a stranded hero — goddesses like Calypso under orders and Ino with her veil, and, mortal in the same office, Nausicaa at the river; the folk-tale does not require her motive, and Homer, unusually, does not invent one.
- 23 l. 386 Proteus is "Poseidon's under-servant" (ὑποδμῶς) — the seal-herd of the hostile god, milked for intelligence behind his master's back. Menelaus' salvation runs through the enemy's own household, as Odysseus' will.
- 24 l. 404 "The brood of the sea's lovely daughter" — Halosydne, "sea-born one," a title of the sea-goddess (elsewhere of Thetis). The seals are her nursery; the Old Man counts them "by fives" like a herdsman tallying — the sea as a pastoral economy, complete with flocks, folds, and noon rest.
- 25 l. 417 The catalogue — lion, serpent, leopard, boar, running water, flowering tree — is the source of the word "protean." Note the instruction: the shapes are endured, not fought; you win against transformation by gripping and waiting. It is hard not to read the poem's own method in it: hold on through every disguise until the thing speaks in its true form.
- 26 l. 441 Epic comedy, rare and precious: four heroes gagging under fresh-flayed sealskins ("who would lay himself down beside a beast of the sea?"), saved by a goddess dabbling ambrosia under each nose. The *Iliad* puts ambrosia to solemn practical work — preserving Patroclus' body (19.38–39), staying Achilles' hunger — but only here is it a peg for the nose.
- 27 l. 477 The Nile is "the river fallen from Zeus" (διηπετέος) — rain-fed from heaven, the standard Homeric epithet for rivers, but applied to Egypt it carries the old Greek wonder at a river whose flood comes without rain.
- 28 l. 499 The death of the Oilean Ajax, in eleven lines: Poseidon saves him from the wreck Athena sent, and kills him only for the boast "I escaped in the gods' despite." The word ἄασθη — the blindness, the ruinous folly — tolls twice (503, 509). It is Zeus' complaint from 1.32–43 played out to the letter: suffering beyond his portion, and Ajax himself handed the god the instrument.
- 29 l. 521 Agamemnon's homecoming compressed to its cruelest arc: the kiss on home soil, the hot tears of joy — and the watchman already paid a year's wages of gold to see him do it. Surveillance hired against joy itself.

- 30 l. 535 "As a man cuts down an ox at the manger" — the poem's definitive line for Agamemnon's death, repeated by his own ghost at 11.411. The king is slaughtered not as a warrior but as a stalled animal, at dinner — the perversion of the feast that the whole Odyssey is built to avenge in its own hall.
- 31 l. 555 The third man, at last: eight lines, and the poem's first eyewitness image of its hero *as he now is* — not Helen's and Menelaus' remembered Odysseus inside Troy, but Odysseus on Calypso's island "letting the big tears fall," shipless, oarless, companionless. Telemachus came for exactly this: his father is alive, weeping, and held. Book 5 opens from this image.
- 32 l. 561 The Elysian plain: the earliest appearance of Elysium in Greek literature — no snow, no winter, no rain, Ocean's singing West Wind forever. And the reason Menelaus is exempted from death is stated with shocking frankness: not virtue, not valor, but marriage — "because Helen is yours, and you are son-in-law to Zeus." Immortality by in-law.
- 33 l. 584 Menelaus heaps an empty mound (a cenotaph) for Agamemnon in Egypt "that his fame might never be quenched" — the exact honor Telemachus said he would perform for Odysseus if confirmed dead (2.222). Fame requires a marker; the poem keeps insisting on the architecture of memory.
- 34 l. 601 Telemachus' refusal of the horses is his diplomatic coming-of-age: he declines a king's gift, praises the giver's plain, and turns his own island's poverty into a boast — "goat-pasture, and lovelier to me than horse-pasture." It is the poem's love-song for thin soil, and Odysseus will sing the same key about Ithaca at 9.27 ("rough ground, but a good nurse of men").
- 35 l. 609 Menelaus *smiles* — the first smile in the Odyssey — and strokes the boy's hand: "You are of good blood, dear child." The gift is upgraded, not withdrawn: the silver bowl by Hephaestus, from the king of Sidon. It will reach Ithaca in Book 15 and pass into the house's treasury: the visit's one durable object.
- 36 l. 617 The bowl's pedigree is recited like a lineage: made by Hephaestus, given by Phaedimus king of Sidon, now passed to Telemachus. Great objects in Homer travel through chains of guest-friendship, and their history is their value — each gift carries the names of everyone who honored someone with it.
- 37 l. 622 A glimpse of how a great feast is provisioned: the guests drive the sheep and carry the wine, their wives send the bread. The Spartan feast is a contribution-feast (an *eranos*) — precisely the institution Athena said the suitors' feasting was *not* (1.226).
- 38 l. 654 Noemon's puzzle — he saw Mentor here at dawn *and* boarding the ship — is a mortal noticing the seam in a divine disguise. He shrugs it off ("or a god, the very image of him"), which is exactly how the poem's ordinary people survive their brushes with the uncanny: by not pressing the question.
- 39 l. 669 "But come, give me a fast ship and twenty companions" — Antinous plots the murder in the *identical line* with which Telemachus asked for his voyage (2.212), and the translation repeats it word for word. The ambusher speaks in his victim's formula; twenty men to kill the boy who asked for twenty oars.

- 40 *l. 690* Penelope's ideal-king speech: a king may hate one man and love another — favoritism is royal prerogative — "but that man never did outrage to a single soul." It matches Mentor's bitter assembly-speech (2.230–234) almost thought for thought. Husband and wife keep the same political theology without having spoken in twenty years.
- 41 *l. 705* "The flower of her voice was stopped" — θαλερή φωνή, literally her "blooming" voice choked off. The Greek gives grief a botany; I kept it.
- 42 *l. 708* Ships as "men's horses of the salt water" — Penelope's kenning, and a mother's: to her the sea is a place her child has been carried off to by animals she never learned to ride.
- 43 *l. 724* Lines 724–726 return verbatim at 814–816, in the dream: Penelope's lament for the lion-hearted husband has hardened into a formula of her own — grief so long practiced it has fixed wording.
- 44 *l. 735* Dolius, the old orchard-slave who came with Penelope's dowry, will still be tending trees beside Laertes in Book 24, where he and his sons arm for the poem's last fight. The household's memory runs through its slaves; the poem keeps their genealogies as carefully as the kings'.
- 45 *l. 743* νύμφα φίλη, "dear bride": Eurycleia addresses the gray-haired queen with the word for a young newlywed. For the nurse, time stopped the day the marriage was whole. One vocative carries thirty years.
- 46 *l. 755* "The line of Arceisius' son": Arceisius fathered Laertes — the poem counts the endangered dynasty in its full four generations, one thread of it now asleep in Sparta and twenty ambushers waiting in the strait.
- 47 *l. 761* Penelope's prayer is a sacrifice with no victim: barley-grains in a basket — the rite's opening gesture (cf. 3.445) offered by itself, with no victim behind it — and then the ὀλολυγή, the women's ritual cry that in Book 3 crowned the killing of the heifer (3.450). She performs the frame of sacrifice around an empty center. Athena hears her anyway.
- 48 *l. 772* "So they would say — knowing nothing of what was prepared": the mockers think death is prepared for Telemachus; the narrator's line quietly reads both ways. What has been "prepared," two books deep and building, is theirs.
- 49 *l. 791* The lion at bay — ringed by the hunters' "treacherous circle" — is Penelope: Homer's boldest reassignment of his most masculine simile. She is not the lion rampaging (that was Odysseus at 4.335–340); she is the lion surrounded, magnificent and cornered. The pair of lion similes, set at opposite ends of the book, are the marriage in absentia: same animal, opposite predicaments.
- 50 *l. 796* The εἶδωλον — a breathing phantom in the likeness of Penelope's sister Iphthime, sent by Athena, entering "past the strap of the bolt" like drift of air. Dream-physics in Homer is precise: dreams are manufactured objects, delivered through the keyhole, with authorized scripts — note that the phantom answers the Odysseus question with a flat refusal (836–837). Comfort is rationed exactly.

- 51 l. 809 "At the gates of dream" — ἐν ὄνειρείησι πύλῃσιν: the dream-world has an architecture with gates, which Penelope herself will map in her famous speech on the gates of horn and ivory (19.562–567). The image is planted here first, in her sleep.
- 52 l. 837 "It is evil to speak words empty as wind" — ἀνεμώλια, wind-words. The phantom that is itself made of wind (it exits "into the breath of the winds," 839) refuses to speak wind-words about Odysseus: even Athena's fabrications observe a strict economy of truth. Penelope wakes *warmed* — a mercy beyond the sweet sleep Athena has poured on her weeping before (1.363–364).
- 53 l. 847 The Telemachy closes not on the boy but on the trap: Asteris, the two-mouthed harbor, the picked twenty waiting. Four books have built a world where a feast can be an ambush and a strait can be a noose — and the poem now leaves everyone suspended there, and cuts, at last, to Olympus and Calypso's island: Book 5, and Odysseus himself.

## Odyssey — Book 5

*Calypso's island: the raft, Poseidon's storm, the landing on Scheria.*

- And Dawn rose from her bed beside lordly Tithonus<sup>1</sup>  
 to carry light to the immortals and to mortals;  
 and the gods were sitting down in council, among them  
 Zeus who thunders on high, whose power is greatest.
- 5 And Athena was telling over the many cares of Odysseus,  
 remembering: it galled her that he was still in the nymph's house:  
 "Father Zeus, and you other blessed gods who are forever:  
 let no sceptered king ever again be willingly<sup>2</sup>  
 kind and gentle, or know the right way in his heart;
- 10 let him rather be harsh always, and act outrage —  
 since no one remembers godlike Odysseus  
 among the people he ruled, and he was gentle as a father.  
 No — he lies on an island suffering strong pains  
 in the halls of the nymph Calypso, who holds him there
- 15 by force; and he cannot come to his own fatherland,  
 for he has no ships at hand, no oars, no companions  
 to carry him over the broad back of the sea.  
 And now, besides, men are bent on killing his beloved son  
 on his way home: he went for news of his father
- 20 to holy Pylos and to shining Lacedaemon."  
 Then Zeus who gathers the clouds answered her:  
 "My child, what a word has slipped the fence of your teeth!  
 Was it not you who framed this plan yourself —<sup>3</sup>  
 that Odysseus should come home and take vengeance on those men?
- 25 As for Telemachus: guide him with your skill — you have the power —  
 so that he reaches his own fatherland untouched,  
 and the suitors come back in their ship with nothing done."  
 He spoke, and turned to Hermes, his dear son:  
 "Hermes — you are our messenger in all things else:
- 30 tell the nymph of the lovely braids our fixed decree:  
 the homecoming of enduring-hearted Odysseus — that he shall return  
 with no escort of gods and none of mortal men:

- on a raft bound plank to plank, and suffering pains,  
on the twentieth day he shall reach rich-soiled Scheria,<sup>4</sup>
- 35 the land of the Phaeacians, who are born close kin to the gods.  
They will honor him with all their hearts, like a god,  
and send him in a ship to his own dear fatherland,  
giving him bronze and gold and clothing in plenty,  
more than Odysseus would ever have carried out of Troy
- 40 had he come home untouched with his fair share of the spoils.  
For so it is his portion: to see his own people and come  
to his high-roofed house and his own fatherland."  
So he spoke, and the guide, the slayer of Argus, did not disobey.  
At once he bound beneath his feet the beautiful sandals,
- 45 ambrosial, golden, that carry him over the water  
and over the boundless earth with the breath of the wind;  
and he took up the rod with which he charms men's eyes<sup>5</sup>  
to sleep, whose eyes he wills, and wakes others from their slumber.  
With this in his hands the strong slayer of Argus flew.
- 50 He stepped down on Pieria, then dropped from the high air to the sea  
and skimmed along the waves like a shearwater,<sup>6</sup>  
the bird that down the terrible troughs of the barren sea  
hunts fish, and wets its beating wings in the brine:  
like that bird Hermes rode the crowding waves.
- 55 But when he reached the island, far away,  
he stepped from the violet sea onto dry land  
and went on till he came to the great cave where the nymph  
of the lovely braids was living; he found her within.  
A great fire was burning on the hearth, and the smell<sup>7</sup>
- 60 of split cedar and citron-wood burning carried far,  
all over the island. Inside, she was singing in a beautiful voice,  
moving to and fro at the loom, weaving with a golden shuttle.  
And around the cave a wood grew tall and flourishing:  
alder and black poplar and sweet-smelling cypress,
- 65 where long-winged birds made their roosts,  
little owls and hawks and long-tongued crows  
of the sea, whose business is the waters.  
And there, trained over the hollow of the cave, spread  
a garden vine in its prime, heavy with clusters;

- 70 and four springs in a row ran with bright water,  
close by one another, turned each its own way;  
and around them soft meadows of violet and wild celery  
were blooming. There even a deathless one, arriving,  
would gaze in wonder at the sight and be gladdened at heart.
- 75 There the guide, the slayer of Argus, stood gazing.  
And when his heart had wondered at it all,  
he went straight into the wide cave. Nor did Calypso,  
shining among goddesses, fail to know him face to face:  
for the deathless gods are not unknown to one another,<sup>8</sup>
- 80 not even one whose dwelling lies far off.  
But great-hearted Odysseus he did not find within:  
he sat weeping on the shore, where he always sat,<sup>9</sup>  
shredding his heart with tears and groans and pains,  
and over the barren sea he would gaze, letting the tears run.
- 85 And Calypso, shining among goddesses, questioned Hermes,  
seating him on a chair all bright and gleaming:  
"Why have you come to me, Hermes of the golden rod,  
honored guest and dear? You have not been used to come before.  
Say what is in your mind: my heart bids me do it
- 90 if I can do it — if it is a thing that can be done.  
But follow me in first, and let me set out guest-fare."  
So speaking the goddess drew up a table for him,  
heaping it with ambrosia, and mixed the red nectar;  
and the guide, the slayer of Argus, drank and ate.
- 95 And when he had supped, and steadied his heart with food,  
then he spoke out in answer to her question:  
"You ask me why I come — goddess to god; and I will tell you  
the whole of it truly, since you bid me.  
Zeus ordered me here. I did not want to come:
- 100 who would choose to cross so vast a stretch of salt water,  
past speaking? And no city of mortals near, to offer  
the gods their victims and their choice hecatombs.  
But there is no way for another god to slip past<sup>10</sup>  
or thwart the mind of Zeus who bears the aegis.
- 105 He says there is a man with you — the most miserable of all  
the men who fought nine years around the city of Priam

- and in the tenth year sacked it, and turned for home.  
 But on the way home they sinned against Athena,  
 and she roused an evil wind against them, and long seas.
- 110 There all the rest of his brave companions perished,  
 but wind and wave carried him here.  
 That man Zeus bids you send on his way — and quickly:  
 it is not his portion to die here, far from his own people;  
 it is still his portion to see his own people and come
- 115 to his high-roofed house and his own fatherland."  
 So he spoke; and Calypso, shining among goddesses, shivered,  
 and lifting her voice she spoke winged words to him:  
 "You are merciless, you gods — jealous beyond all beings —<sup>11</sup>  
 who begrudge goddesses their sleeping with men
- 120 openly, if one takes a man as her own dear husband.  
 So when Dawn of the rose-red fingers took Orion,  
 you gods who live at ease begrudged it to her,  
 until in Ortygia chaste Artemis of the golden throne  
 came at him with her gentle arrows and killed him.
- 125 So when Demeter of the lovely braids gave way to her heart  
 and lay with Iasion in love in the bed  
 of a thrice-plowed fallow field — Zeus was not long<sup>12</sup>  
 in hearing, and he killed him with a hurl of the white lightning.  
 And so now me, you gods: you begrudge me a mortal man beside me.
- 130 I saved him — riding astride his keel, alone,  
 after Zeus with a hurl of the white lightning had shattered  
 his fast ship apart in the middle of the wine-dark sea.  
 There all the rest of his brave companions perished,  
 but wind and wave carried him here.
- 135 And I loved him, and I fed him, and I promised  
 to make him deathless and unaging all his days.<sup>13</sup>  
 But since there is no way for another god to slip past  
 or thwart the mind of Zeus who bears the aegis —  
 let him go, if that one urges it and commands,
- 140 out over the barren sea. Only I will not convey him:  
 I have no ships at hand, no oars, no companions  
 to carry him over the broad back of the sea.  
 But with a willing heart I will counsel him, and hide nothing,



- so that he may reach his own fatherland untouched."
- 145 Then the guide, the slayer of Argus, answered her:  
 "Send him so, then — and beware the wrath of Zeus:  
 let him not turn against you afterward and bear hard on you."  
 So speaking, the strong slayer of Argus went away.  
 And the queenly nymph went to great-hearted Odysseus,
- 150 now that she had heard the message of Zeus.  
 She found him sitting on the shore. His eyes were never  
 dry of tears; his sweet life was draining away  
 in mourning for his homecoming — the nymph no longer pleased him.  
 True, at night he would sleep beside her — he had to —<sup>14</sup>
- 155 in the hollow caves, unwilling man by willing goddess;  
 but all his days he sat out on the rocks and the beaches,  
 shredding his heart with tears and groans and pains,  
 and over the barren sea he would gaze, letting the tears run.  
 Standing near him, she spoke, shining among goddesses:
- 160 "Luckless man, do not sit grieving here any longer; do not let<sup>15</sup>  
 your life waste away. I am ready now — wholly — to send you off.  
 Come: cut long timbers, and join with bronze  
 a wide raft; and fix an upper half-deck to it,  
 raised high, to carry you over the misted sea.
- 165 And I will put in bread and water and red wine  
 to your heart's content, to keep hunger from you,  
 and I will clothe you, and send a fair wind behind you,  
 so that you may reach your own fatherland untouched —  
 if the gods are willing, who hold wide heaven,
- 170 who are stronger than I to purpose and accomplish."  
 So she spoke; and much-enduring noble Odysseus shuddered,<sup>16</sup>  
 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to her:  
 "Something else you are plotting here, goddess — not my sending —  
 you who bid me cross the great gulf of the sea on a raft,
- 175 that terror, that misery: not even the trim fast-running  
 ships cross it, for all their joy in the wind of Zeus.  
 I will not set foot on any raft against your will —  
 not unless you bring yourself, goddess, to swear me the great oath  
 that you are not planning some new evil against me."
- 180 So he spoke; and Calypso, shining among goddesses, smiled,

- and stroked him with her hand, and spoke a word, and named him:  
 "You are a rogue indeed — no lightweight in cunning —  
 to have thought of a speech like that to say to me.  
 Now let Earth be witness, and the wide Heaven above,<sup>17</sup>  
 185 and the down-dripping water of Styx — the greatest oath  
 and the most terrible the blessed gods can swear —  
 that I am not planning some new evil against you.  
 No: I am thinking and advising exactly what I would  
 devise for my own self, if such need came on me.  
 190 My mind is honest through and through, and the heart  
 in my breast is not made of iron. It knows pity."
- So speaking she led the way, shining among goddesses,  
 swiftly, and he followed in the footsteps of the god.  
 They came to the hollow cave, the goddess and the man,<sup>18</sup>  
 195 and he sat down there on the chair from which Hermes  
 had risen, and the nymph set out all manner of food beside him,  
 to eat and drink, such things as mortal men eat;  
 and she took her seat facing godlike Odysseus,  
 and slave-women set ambrosia and nectar beside her.  
 200 And their hands went out to the good things spread before them.  
 But when they had had their joy of food and drink,  
 Calypso began, shining among goddesses:  
 "Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices —<sup>19</sup>  
 so you would go home now, home to your own dear country,  
 205 at once, this moment? Go, then — and joy go with you even so.  
 But if you knew in your heart how full your measure  
 of sorrow is before you reach your own country,  
 you would stay here with me and keep this house,  
 and be deathless — for all your longing to see  
 210 that wife of yours, whom you ache for all your days.  
 And yet I dare say I am not beneath her —  
 not in form, not in stature: it is in no way seemly  
 for mortal women to vie with immortals in body and looks."  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
 215 "Goddess and queen, do not be angry with me for this. I know it all<sup>20</sup>  
 myself, well enough: watchful-minded Penelope  
 is less than you — slighter to look at, smaller —

for she is mortal, and you are deathless and unaging.  
 But even so I wish — and all my days I long —  
 220 to go home, and to look upon my day of homecoming.  
 And if some god wrecks me again on the wine-dark sea,  
 I will endure it, with a heart schooled in enduring sorrows.  
 Much have I suffered already, much have I labored  
 through waves and war. Let this be added to the rest."  
 225 So he spoke; and the sun went down, and the dusk came on;  
 and the two of them went into the inner hollow of the cave  
 and took their joy of love, and stayed side by side.<sup>21</sup>

When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,  
 straightway Odysseus put on a cloak and tunic,  
 230 and she, the nymph, put on a great silver-shining mantle,  
 fine-woven and graceful, and cast about her waist a belt,  
 beautiful, golden, and set a veil on her head above.  
 Then she turned her mind to the sending of great-hearted Odysseus.  
 She gave him a great axe, fitted to his palms,<sup>22</sup>  
 235 of bronze, sharpened on both edges, and set in it  
 a beautiful handle of olive-wood, made firm and fast;  
 then she gave him a polished adze, and led the way  
 to the island's farthest edge, where the tall trees grew:  
 alder and black poplar, and fir that reached the sky,  
 240 long dry, dead-seasoned, that would ride for him lightly.  
 And when she had shown him where the tall trees grew,  
 Calypso went back to her house, shining among goddesses,  
 and he set to cutting timbers, and the work went quickly under him.  
 Twenty trees in all he felled, and trimmed them with the bronze,  
 245 and dressed them smooth with skill, and trued them to the line.  
 Meanwhile Calypso, shining among goddesses, brought augers,  
 and he bored through every piece and fitted each to each,  
 and drove her together with pegs and joinery.  
 As wide as a man lays out the round of the hull of a broad  
 250 cargo ship — a man who knows his craft —  
 so wide Odysseus built his raft.  
 He set up half-decks, fitting them to close-set ribs,  
 and finished with long gunwale planks.

- He made a mast in her, and a yard fitted to it,  
 255 and he made besides a steering-oar to hold her straight,  
 and fenced her round from stem to stern with plaited willow  
 to break the wave, and heaped down brush for ballast.  
 Meanwhile Calypso, shining among goddesses, brought cloth  
 to make a sail; and he made that too, with craft,  
 260 and lashed into her the braces, the halyards, and the sheets.  
 Then on rollers he hauled her down to the bright salt water.  
 It was the fourth day, and all his work was done;<sup>23</sup>  
 and on the fifth shining Calypso sent him from the island,  
 having bathed him and dressed him in fragrant clothes.  
 265 And the goddess put a skin of dark wine aboard,  
 one skin, and another, a great one, of water, and provisions  
 in a sack, and set in plenty of comforting meats;  
 and she sent up a fair wind for him, harmless and warm.  
 Rejoicing in the wind, noble Odysseus spread his sail,  
 270 and with the steering-oar he steered her, craftsmanlike,  
 sitting there; and sleep never fell on his eyelids  
 as he watched the Pleiades, and Boötes that sets late,<sup>24</sup>  
 and the Bear, that men also call by the name of the Wagon,  
 who turns in her place and keeps her watch on Orion,  
 275 and alone has no share in the baths of Ocean:  
 for Calypso, shining among goddesses, had told him  
 to keep her on his left hand as he crossed the sea.  
 Seventeen days he sailed on, crossing the water,  
 and on the eighteenth appeared the shadowy mountains  
 280 of the Phaeacians' land, where it lay nearest him:  
 it looked like a shield laid on the misted sea.<sup>25</sup>
- But the strong earth-shaker, coming back from the Ethiopians,<sup>26</sup>  
 saw him far off, from the mountains of the Solymi: he showed  
 to his eye, sailing the sea. And the god's heart grew the angrier,  
 285 and shaking his head he spoke to his own heart:  
 "Damnation! So the gods have changed their counsels  
 about Odysseus while I was among the Ethiopians —  
 and here he is, close to the Phaeacians' land, where it is his portion  
 to slip the great noose of misery that has come upon him.  
 290 But I say I will yet drive him deep enough in trouble."

- So speaking he herded the clouds together, and stirred up the sea,  
the trident in his hands; and he roused all the squalls  
of every wind there is, and covered land and sea alike  
with cloud; and night rose up out of heaven.
- 295 East Wind and South fell on him together, and the hard-blowing West,<sup>27</sup>  
and the North Wind born of the clear sky, rolling a great wave.  
And then Odysseus' knees went loose, and his heart;  
and deeply stirred he spoke to his own great heart:<sup>28</sup>  
"Ah, wretch that I am — what happens to me at the last?
- 300 I fear the goddess spoke it all unerringly,  
who said that on the sea, before I reached my own country,  
I would fill my measure of pains. Now it is all coming to pass:  
look how Zeus crowns the wide heaven with cloud on cloud,  
and has stirred up the sea, and the squalls of every wind
- 305 there is come driving. Now my sheer destruction is certain.  
Three times blessed the Danaans, and four times, who died<sup>29</sup>  
in those years in wide Troy, doing the Atreidae's pleasure!  
Would that I too had died so, met my doom,  
on the day the Trojans in their hundreds hurled
- 310 their bronze-tipped spears at me over the dead son of Peleus.  
Then I would have had my death-rites, and the Achaeans carried my  
fame;  
now it is my lot to be taken in a miserable death."  
As he said it, a great wave drove down on him from above,  
rushing terribly, and spun the raft around.
- 315 Far from the raft he fell, and the steering-oar  
flew from his hands; the mast snapped in the middle  
under the terrible squall of winds meeting from all quarters,  
and sail and yard fell far off in the sea.  
And the wave held him under a long time: he could not
- 320 rise quickly from beneath the great sea's downrush,  
for the clothes weighed on him that shining Calypso gave.<sup>30</sup>  
At long last he came up, spitting from his mouth the bitter  
brine that ran streaming in torrents down his head.  
Yet even so, ground down as he was, he did not forget his raft:
- 325 he lunged after her through the waves and caught hold,  
and sat down in the middle of her, dodging the end that is death,

- while the great wave carried her with the current, here and there.  
 As when the North Wind of autumn carries thistledown<sup>31</sup>  
 across the plain, and the tufts cling close to one another,  
 330 so the winds carried her over the open water, here and there:  
 now the South Wind would toss her to the North to carry,  
 now again the East would yield her to the West to chase.
- But the daughter of Cadmus saw him — Ino of the beautiful ankles,<sup>32</sup>  
 the White Goddess, who once was mortal, with a mortal voice,  
 335 and now in the salt depths has her share of honor from the gods.  
 She pitied Odysseus, driven wandering, worn with pains,  
 and in the likeness of a shearwater she rose on the wing from the  
 water,  
 and perched on the close-bound raft, and said:  
 "Luckless man, why is Poseidon the earth-shaker  
 340 so terribly at odds with you, that he plants all these evils for you?  
 Yet he shall not destroy you, for all his fury.  
 Only do exactly this — you do not seem to me short of sense.  
 Strip off these clothes, and leave the raft for the winds  
 to carry; strike out swimming with your hands for a homecoming  
 345 on the Phaeacians' land, where it is your portion to escape.  
 Here — spread this veil under your chest.<sup>33</sup>  
 It is immortal: no fear then of suffering or death.  
 But the moment your hands take hold of dry land,  
 untie it again and throw it into the wine-dark sea,  
 350 far out from land, and turn your own face away."  
 So speaking the goddess gave him the veil,  
 and she herself sank back into the surging sea  
 in the likeness of a shearwater, and the black wave closed over her.  
 But much-enduring noble Odysseus pondered,  
 355 and deeply stirred he spoke to his own great heart:  
 "Ah me — let this not be some new snare of the immortals<sup>34</sup>  
 woven against me, when she bids me abandon my raft.  
 No: I will not obey her yet. Far off with my own eyes  
 I saw the land where she said my refuge is.  
 360 I will do this instead — it seems to me the best:  
 as long as the timbers hold in their fastenings,  
 so long I stay aboard and endure my sufferings where I am;

but the moment the wave shakes the raft to pieces,  
I swim. There is no better plan to see."

- 365 While he was turning this over in his mind and in his heart,  
Poseidon the earth-shaker heaved up a great wave,  
terrible and grim, arching over him, and drove it down.  
And as a violent wind tosses a heap of dry chaff  
and scatters the wisps this way and that way,  
370 so it scattered the raft's long timbers. But Odysseus  
got astride one beam, like a man riding a racehorse,<sup>35</sup>  
and stripped off the clothes that shining Calypso gave,  
and spread the veil at once beneath his chest,  
and plunged headfirst in the sea, arms spread wide,  
375 hungry to swim. And the strong earth-shaker saw him,  
and shaking his head he spoke to his own heart:  
"So — now suffer your many evils and drift the sea,  
until you come among a people nurtured of Zeus.  
But even so I do not think you will make light of your trouble."  
380 So speaking he lashed his horses of the beautiful manes  
and came to Aegae, where his famous house is.

- But Athena, daughter of Zeus, thought of other things.  
She bound up the courses of all the other winds  
and commanded every one to rest and fall asleep,  
385 and roused the quick North Wind, and broke the waves before him,  
so that Zeus-born Odysseus might come among the oar-loving  
Phaeacians, having slipped past death and the dooms.  
Two nights then and two days on the close-packed swell  
he drifted, and many times his heart looked destruction in the face.  
390 But when Dawn of the lovely braids brought the third day round,  
then at last the wind fell, and a windless calm  
came on; and he saw the land close by,  
casting a sharp glance forward, lifted on a great wave.  
As when a father's life shows dear and welcome to his children —<sup>36</sup>  
395 a father who lies in sickness suffering strong pains,  
long wasting away, some hateful power upon him,  
and then, dear and welcome, the gods set him free of his evil —  
so welcome to Odysseus showed the land and the trees,

- and he swam hard, straining to set foot on solid earth.
- 400 But when he was as far offshore as a man's shout carries,<sup>37</sup>  
 he heard the boom of sea against the rock-teeth:  
 the great swell thundered on the dry land's edge,  
 belching terribly, and everything was shrouded in salt spray.  
 For there were no harbors there to hold ships, no roadsteads —
- 405 only jutting headlands, rock-teeth, and cliff-faces.  
 And then Odysseus' knees went loose, and his heart,  
 and deeply stirred he spoke to his own great heart:  
 "Ah me — now that Zeus has given me sight of land  
 unhopèd for, and I have won across this gulf at last,  
 410 no way out of the gray salt water shows anywhere:  
 sharp crags offshore, and all around them the wave  
 roaring and churning, and the rock running up sheer,  
 and the sea deep close in — nowhere to stand  
 on both my feet and escape the evil.
- 415 If I try to climb out, the great wave may snatch me  
 and hurl me on the standing stone, and my try go for nothing.  
 But if I swim along still farther, hoping to find  
 shelving beaches somewhere, and harbors of the sea,  
 I fear the storm-squall snatches me up again
- 420 and carries me, groaning heavily, over the fish-filled sea —  
 or some power looses a monster on me out of the brine,<sup>38</sup>  
 one of the swarm that famous Amphitrite pastures:  
 for I know how the famous shaker of earth is at odds with me."  
 While he was turning this over in his mind and in his heart,
- 425 a great wave carried him onto the jagged shore.  
 There his skin would have been stripped, his bones smashed in,  
 had not the goddess, gray-eyed Athena, put a thought in him:  
 lunging in, he seized the rock with both hands  
 and clung there groaning while the great wave went past.
- 430 That one he escaped so; but its backwash leapt on him again  
 and struck him and threw him far out to sea.  
 As when an octopus is dragged out of its den<sup>39</sup>  
 and thick pebbles cling in the cups of its arms,  
 so from his bold hands the skin was stripped away
- 435 against the rocks; and the great wave closed over him.



- There, before his time, wretched Odysseus would have perished,  
 had not gray-eyed Athena given him clear sense.  
 Coming up out of the surf where it belches at the land,  
 he swam along outside it, looking to the shore in hope of finding  
 440 shelving beaches somewhere, and harbors of the sea.  
 But when, swimming, he came to the mouth of a fair-flowing river,  
 there at last the ground seemed best to him,  
 clear of stones, and there was shelter from the wind.  
 He felt the current flowing and prayed in his heart:  
 445 "Hear me, lord, whoever you are. I come to you — the much-prayed-to  
 —<sup>40</sup>  
 a fugitive out of the sea, from the threats of Poseidon.  
 Even to the deathless gods that man is sacred  
 who comes as a wanderer, as I come now  
 to your stream and to your knees, after much labor.  
 450 Pity me, lord: I declare myself your suppliant."  
 So he spoke; and at once the god stayed his current, held back the wave,  
 and made the water calm before him, and brought him safe  
 into the river's mouth. And he bent both knees  
 and let his strong hands fall: the sea had crushed the heart in him.  
 455 All his flesh was swollen, and the sea oozed in streams  
 up through his mouth and nostrils. Breathless and speechless  
 he lay, barely alive, and a terrible weariness came over him.  
 But when he got his breath again, and the spirit gathered in his chest,  
 then he unbound the goddess's veil from his body  
 460 and let it go into the river running seaward,  
 and the great wave carried it back down the current, and quickly Ino  
 took it in her own dear hands. And he turned from the river,  
 sank down in the reeds, and kissed the grain-giving earth;<sup>41</sup>  
 and deeply stirred he spoke to his own great heart:  
 465 "Ah me, what now? What happens to me at the last?  
 If I keep watch through the anxious night here by the river,  
 the two together — the evil frost and the soaking dew —  
 may finish me: weak as I am, my spirit gasping;  
 and toward dawn a cold breeze blows off a river.  
 470 But if I climb the slope to the shadowy wood  
 and fall asleep in the thick brush — supposing cold

and weariness release me, and sweet sleep comes —  
I fear I become spoil and carrion for wild beasts."

Yet as he weighed it, this seemed the better way:

- 475 he went up toward the wood, and found it near the water  
on a rise in the open. He crept in under a double thicket  
grown from a single stock — one wild olive, one the planted tree.<sup>42</sup>  
Through these no strength of wet-blowing winds could pierce,  
nor could the shining sun strike through with its rays,  
480 nor rain soak through them, so close they grew,  
laced into one another. Under these Odysseus  
crept, and heaped himself at once a wide bed  
with his own hands: for there was a drift of fallen leaves there, deep,  
enough to shelter two men or three  
485 in the winter season, however hard it blew.  
Seeing it, much-enduring noble Odysseus rejoiced,  
and he lay down in the middle and poured the fallen leaves over him.  
As when a man buries a burning log in a black ash-heap<sup>43</sup>  
at the far edge of the fields — a man with no neighbors near —  
490 saving the seed of fire, so as not to seek a light elsewhere,  
so Odysseus buried himself in the leaves. And Athena  
poured sleep upon his eyes, to free him soonest  
from his toil-worn weariness, when she had folded his dear eyelids  
shut.

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 5

- 1    *l. 1* The book opens with Dawn rising from the bed of Tithonus — her mortal lover, to whom the gods gave endless life without endless youth. It is not the standard dawn formula but a pointed variant: a goddess-and-mortal bed, on the morning the gods will order another goddess to give her mortal up. The frame is the theme.
- 2    *l. 8* Lines 8–12 repeat Mentor's bitter assembly-speech (2.230–234) word for word — Athena has carried the complaint of an old man in Ithaca to the floor of Olympus, and the translation repeats itself accordingly. The poem's machinery of justice runs on quotation.
- 3    *l. 23* Zeus' testy reply — "was this not your plan all along?" — is the poem smiling at its own structure. This second council restates the first (Book 1) so the Odysseus half of the poem can launch; analyst critics saw a seam, but Zeus turns the repetition into characterization: Athena is the author of this plot, and everyone on Olympus knows it.
- 4    *l. 34* Zeus states the itinerary in advance — raft, suffering, twentieth day, Scheria, honor like a god, treasure greater than his Troy-share. Homeric narrative does not fear spoilers: the tension is never *what*, always *how*. And the arithmetic will keep: four days building, seventeen sailing (278), two adrift, landing on the twentieth.
- 5    *l. 47* Hermes' rod — putting whom he wills to sleep, waking whom he wills — is the psychopomp's tool (it will herd the suitors' ghosts in Book 24). Here it merely travels with him: a reminder of what the messenger *is*, paying a call on the island where a man is kept deathless-in-life.
- 6    *l. 51* Hermes skims the waves "like a shearwater... hunting fish." A god traveling as a seabird opens the book; Ino will surface and dive "in the likeness of a shearwater" to close its storm (337, 353). The same bird brackets the book — divine help, in this poem of the sea, wears gull-gray.
- 7    *l. 59* The cave of Calypso (59–74) is the first full paradise-landscape in Greek literature: cedar smoke, the singing weaver at her golden shuttle, the vine heavy with clusters, four springs, meadows of violet and wild celery. The clincher is the connoisseur's touch: "even a deathless one, arriving, would gaze in wonder" — and one does; Hermes stands there sightseeing (75). The poem builds paradise convincingly enough that the refusal of it, 150 lines later, means something.
- 8    *l. 79* "The deathless gods are not unknown to one another": divine society has no disguises internally. All the recognition-labor in this poem — the aching, testing, tokened recognitions of mortals — belongs to the human world alone. Gods simply *know*; men must find out.
- 9    *l. 82* The entrance of the hero, four and a half books in: not fighting, not scheming — weeping on a beach, "shredding his heart," staring at the sea. The Odyssey introduces its protagonist at his absolute nadir, in a posture of pure longing, and lets the epithet "much-enduring" (171) gather its meaning from this image.

- 10 l. 103 "No way for another god to slip past or thwart the mind of Zeus": Hermes says it as diplomacy (103–104); Calypso repeats it back verbatim as bitterness (137–138). The same couplet, submissive in one mouth and seething in the other, is a masterclass in what formula can do.
- 11 l. 118 Calypso's protest is the poem's frankest statement of the divine double standard: gods may take mortal women, but a goddess who takes a mortal man "openly" draws the jealousy of heaven — Dawn's Orion shot down by Artemis, Demeter's Iasion blasted by Zeus. Her argument is unanswerable, and the poem lets it stand unanswered; she yields to power, not persuasion.
- 12 l. 127 Demeter and Iasion "in the bed of a thrice-plowed fallow field": the old sacred marriage of grain-goddess and farmer, earth as the marriage bed. Zeus' lightning ends it — the new order striking down the older fertility rite even as the poem remembers it.
- 13 l. 135 "Deathless and unaging all his days" — the offer on the table, stated by Calypso to Hermes before we ever hear it made to Odysseus. The poem wants us holding the full price-tag through the whole episode: what the man on the beach is weeping *through* is an open offer of immortality.
- 14 l. 154 "Unwilling man by willing goddess" — παρ' οὐκ ἐθέλων ἐθελούση. The Greek grammar of consent, compressed to four words, and a deliberate inversion of Nestor's Clytemnestra line (3.272), "he willing, she willing." The poem tracks who wants what in every bed it mentions.
- 15 l. 160 κάμμορε, "luckless man" — Calypso's address of tenderness, and the exact word Ino the sea-goddess will use at 339. Two goddesses of the sea, one keeping him and one saving him, call him by the same name: doom-burdened.
- 16 l. 171 He *shudders* at the offer of release — because a raft on the open sea reads to him as a plot. Seven years a goddess's captive have taught him that gifts are traps; his demand for the great oath (178–179) is the captive's earned paranoia, and Calypso's smile at it (180) is her acknowledgment that he is exactly the man she says he is at 182: "a rogue, no lightweight in cunning."
- 17 l. 184 The oath by Earth, Heaven, and "the down-dripping water of Styx — the greatest oath and the most terrible the blessed gods can swear." She swears the maximum. Whatever else Calypso is, she is not, in the end, a deceiver; the poem gives her a clean exit and a self-description — "my heart is not made of iron; it knows pity" — that we are given no reason to doubt.
- 18 l. 194 "The goddess and the man" — θεὸς ἡδὲ καὶ ἀνὴρ: the book's whole polarity in one line-end. At dinner they eat from separate menus, he "such things as mortal men eat," she served ambrosia and nectar (197–199) — one table, two natures, the gulf between them laid out in the place-settings.
- 19 l. 203 "Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices" — the hero's full ceremonial address, here in its first occurrence, from Calypso's mouth. It will recur throughout the poem from gods, kings, and ghosts alike, and this translation keeps it identical every time.

- 20 l. 215 The most consequential speech in the poem, and its manner is the point: he concedes everything. Yes, Penelope is "less" — slighter, smaller, mortal, aging. No counter-argument is offered, no comparison contested. The refusal rests on nothing but "even so I wish" — the unarguable preference for one's own finite life over a perfect eternity that belongs to someone else's world. And the closing shrug is pure Odysseus: "Let this be added to the rest."
- 21 l. 225 The poem's tact: having refused eternity with her, he goes to bed with her, and the narration gives it one clause and no commentary. Ancient readers found no contradiction; the modern reader is free to. The sun-goes-down formula does the discretion.
- 22 l. 234 The raft-building (234–261) is the fullest description of skilled handwork in Homer — axe, adze, twenty trees, augers, pegs and joinery, ribs, half-decks, gunwales, mast, yard, steering-oar, willow bulwark against the wave, and a sail from the goddess's cloth. The embedded simile is professional: as wide as a shipwright lays out a cargo hull, "a man who knows his craft." Odysseus' identity as *maker* — which will climax in the secret of the olive-tree bed — is established here, in four days' honest carpentry.
- 23 l. 262 Fourth day, work done; fifth day, departure. Homer's calendars audit cleanly: with seventeen days' sailing and two adrift, the landing falls on Zeus' promised twentieth day (34).
- 24 l. 272 The star-course (272–277) is the earliest surviving text of Greek celestial navigation: steer by the Pleiades, late-setting Boötes, and the Bear "who turns in her place and keeps her watch on Orion, and alone has no share in the baths of Ocean" — i.e., never sets. Keeping her on the left hand means sailing east. The astronomy is real, and the Bear's exemption from Ocean's baths was already proverbial.
- 25 l. 281 The land "like a shield laid on the misted sea" — ῥινόν, an ox-hide shield: how a mountainous island actually looks, hull-down on the horizon. A sailor's simile.
- 26 l. 282 Poseidon returns from the Ethiopians — the plot-latch set at 1.22–26 now released. One god's vacation has been the whole window of opportunity: the Odyssey's Olympus runs on scheduling.
- 27 l. 295 All four winds at once — East, South, West, and "the North Wind born of the clear sky" — is not weather but signature: only a god unseats the compass itself. Athena's counter-move at 383–385 is to *silence* three winds and choose one. Divine combat here is meteorology.
- 28 l. 298 "Deeply stirred he spoke to his own great heart" — the soliloquy formula, four times in this book (298, 355, 407, 464). Alone on the sea, the poem's most social intelligence has no interlocutor but his own θυμός; Book 5 invents, in effect, the interior monologue of survival.
- 29 l. 306 "Three times blessed the Danaans, and four times, who died in wide Troy": the drowning man's arithmetic of envy. His terror is precise and cultural — not death but *this* death, wet and unwitnessed: no rites, no mound, no fame (311). It is Telemachus' fear for his father (1.239–241) spoken now by the father himself.

- 30 *l. 321* Calypso's clothes drag him under. Read allegorically since antiquity, and the poem invites it: everything of hers must be stripped off (372) before her sea will let him live. Her last gift nearly finishes what her love could not.
- 31 *l. 328* The raft rides the sea like autumn thistledown — the mightiest forces in the poem rendered through the lightest thing in a farmer's field. The four named winds tossing her "now to the North to carry, now to the West to chase" play a game of catch; the terror is in the toy-scale.
- 32 *l. 333* Ino Leucothea, "who once was mortal, with a mortal voice, and now in the salt depths has her share of honor" — a mortal woman who *became* a goddess, surfacing to save the man who has just refused to become a god. The symmetry is perfect and unremarked: the poem simply sets the two trajectories crossing in mid-storm.
- 33 *l. 346* The κρήδεμνον — a woman's head-veil — as flotation and talisman: an intimate garment made life-line. It is a loan, not a gift: it must be thrown back seaward, face averted (349–350), and Ino's hands are waiting for it (461–462). Divine aid in this poem is exact about its terms.
- 34 *l. 356* Offered a goddess's own rescue, he suspects a trap — and then hedges: keep the raft while it holds, swim when it shatters. "There is no better plan to see." The empirical hero: no gift is trusted until tested, including salvation. That the suspicion is *wrong* this time does not make it unreasonable; the poem has taught him its world.
- 35 *l. 371* Astride one beam "like a man riding a racehorse" — a flash of jaunty, almost comic athleticism in the middle of shipwreck. The image does double work: mastery and absurdity, the tactician reduced to a jockey on driftwood.
- 36 *l. 394* The reversed family simile: land looks as welcome to Odysseus as a father's recovery looks to his children. The father starved of his own children for twenty years can feel relief only as a child of the thing that saves him. Homer's similes keep displacing this hero's longings into other people's households — the emotional bookkeeping of a man who has no household in reach.
- 37 *l. 400* "As far offshore as a man's shout carries" — distance measured by the human voice, just as time is measured by meals and dawns. The Homeric world is calibrated in body-units.
- 38 *l. 421* The fear of a sea-monster "of the swarm that famous Amphitrite pastures" — the deep as the hostile god's ranch, stocked and grazed. Even Odysseus' terrors are precisely inventoried.
- 39 *l. 432* The octopus simile, admired since antiquity for its cold-eyed reversal: when an octopus is dragged from its den, pebbles cling to its suckers; when Odysseus is dragged from the rock, his skin stays behind on it. The observation is a fisherman's; the application is a torturer's. Nothing else in Homer renders the sea's violence so anatomically.
- 40 *l. 445* The prayer to the nameless river — "Hear me, lord, whoever you are" — is answered instantly, the fastest-granted prayer in the poem. Lines 447–450 state the doctrine of supplication in full: the wanderer is sacred even to the gods. A minor local god honors in four lines what Poseidon has spent a book violating.

- 41 *l. 463* He kisses "the grain-giving earth" — the formulaic epithet suddenly literal: after eighteen days of salt, the first thing to bless about land is that bread grows in it. Agamemnon kissed his homeland soil (4.522); Odysseus kisses any earth at all. Homecoming has been beaten down to its minimum unit: dry ground.
- 42 *l. 477* The double thicket "grown from a single stock — one wild olive, one the planted tree": wildness and cultivation sharing one root, and the poem's emblem of its hero, who survives by being both at once. The olive is Athena's tree; its marriage of wild and tame will return, grown into furniture, in the bed-secret of Book 23. He shelters, of course, exactly here.
- 43 *l. 488* The last simile of the book: a solitary farmer "with no neighbors near" banks a burning log in ash, "saving the seed of fire." Odysseus under his leaves is fire in latency — identity, banked; heat, hidden; the whole coming poem held as a spark. And it is Athena, keeper of that spark, who closes his eyelids over it. No book of the Odyssey ends better.





## Odyssey — Book 6

*Nausicaa at the river; the naked stranger; the road to the city.*

- So he slept there, much-enduring noble Odysseus,  
 overcome with sleep and weariness. But Athena  
 went her way to the land and city of the Phaeacian men,  
 who once, in years past, lived in spacious Hypereia,<sup>1</sup>  
 5 near the Cyclopes, men of overweening pride,  
 who kept raiding them, and were the stronger in force.  
 From there godlike Nausithous had uprooted them and led them,  
 and settled them in Scheria, far from men who eat bread,  
 and drove a wall around the city, and built houses,  
 10 and made temples for the gods, and divided out the plowlands.  
 But he long since had gone down to Hades, broken by fate,  
 and now Alcinous ruled, his counsels known from the gods.  
 To his house went the goddess, gray-eyed Athena,  
 devising the homecoming of great-hearted Odysseus.  
 15 She went into the richly-worked chamber where a girl  
 lay sleeping, like the immortals in build and beauty:  
 Nausicaa, daughter of great-hearted Alcinous;  
 and by her two handmaids, with beauty from the Graces,  
 one at each doorpost; and the shining doors were shut.  
 20 Like a breath of wind she swept to the girl's bed<sup>2</sup>  
 and stood above her head, and spoke to her,  
 in the likeness of the daughter of Dymas, famed for ships,  
 a girl her own age, and dear to her heart.  
 In her likeness gray-eyed Athena said:  
 25 "Nausicaa, how did your mother bear so careless a girl?<sup>3</sup>  
 Your shining clothes lie there uncared-for —  
 and your wedding is near, when you must wear beautiful things  
 yourself, and provide them for those who lead you in procession:  
 it is from things like these that a good name goes up  
 30 among the people, and a father and honored mother are glad.  
 Come, let us go washing at the showing of dawn:  
 I will come with you and work beside you, so you may be ready

the sooner — for truly not much longer will you be unwed:  
 already the best men through all the land of the Phaeacians  
 35 are wooing you — and your own line is theirs.  
 Come then: press your famous father, before the dawn,  
 to make ready the mules and a wagon to carry  
 the sashes and the robes and the shining coverlets.  
 And for yourself, too, it is far more fitting so than going  
 40 on foot: the washing-pools are a long way from the city."  
 So speaking, gray-eyed Athena went away  
 to Olympus, where they say the seat of the gods stands fast<sup>4</sup>  
 forever: not shaken by winds, never soaked  
 by rain, nor does snow come near it, but clear sky  
 45 spreads cloudless there, and a white radiance runs over it;  
 in that place the blessed gods take pleasure all their days.  
 There the gray-eyed one went, when she had counseled the girl.

At once Dawn came on her fair throne, and woke  
 Nausicaa of the lovely robe; and she wondered at her dream  
 50 and went through the house to tell her parents,  
 her dear father and mother. She found them within:  
 her mother sat at the hearth with her attendant women,  
 spinning yarn dyed sea-purple; her father she met  
 at the door, on his way out to join the famous kings  
 55 in council, where the lordly Phaeacians called him.  
 She stood close to her dear father and said:  
 "Papa dear, won't you make ready a wagon for me,<sup>5</sup>  
 the high one with the good wheels, so I can take the fine clothes  
 to the river for washing, that lie about me dirty?  
 60 And for you too it is only proper, when you sit among the first men  
 debating counsels, to have clean clothing on your body.  
 And five dear sons have been born to you in these halls —  
 two married, and three flourishing bachelors —  
 and they are always wanting fresh-washed clothes to wear  
 65 when they go to the dancing. All this is on my mind."  
 So she spoke: she was shy of naming ripe marriage<sup>6</sup>  
 to her dear father. But he saw it all, and answered:  
 "I do not grudge you the mules, child, or anything else.  
 Go: the slaves will make ready a wagon for you,

- 70 the high one with the good wheels, fitted with its top-rack."  
 So saying he called to the slaves, and they obeyed.  
 Outside, they made ready the smooth-running mule wagon  
 and led the mules under and yoked them to it;  
 and the girl brought the shining clothing from her room  
 75 and laid it in the polished wagon,  
 and her mother packed a box with heartening food  
 of every kind — put in delicacies, and poured wine  
 in a goatskin bag; and the girl climbed up on the wagon.  
 And she gave her soft olive oil in a golden flask,  
 80 so she and her attendant women might anoint themselves after  
 bathing.  
 And she took up the whip and the glossy reins  
 and whipped the mules to a run; and there was a clatter of hooves,  
 and they strained on without slackening, carrying the clothes and her  
 —  
 not alone: her handmaids went along beside her.
- 85 And when they came to the beautiful stream of the river,  
 where the washing-pools never fail — plenty of clear water  
 welling up through and running over, to clean the dirtiest things —  
 there they loosed the mules from under the wagon  
 and shooed them along the eddying river  
 90 to graze the honey-sweet water-grass; and they lifted the clothes  
 from the wagon in armfuls and carried them into the dark water,  
 and trod them briskly in the trenches, racing one another.<sup>7</sup>  
 And when they had washed and rinsed away all the dirt,  
 they spread everything out in rows along the shingle of the sea,  
 95 where the waves washed the pebbles cleanest against the shore.  
 And when they had bathed and rubbed themselves richly with oil,  
 they took their meal by the banks of the river  
 and waited for the clothes to dry in the shining of the sun.  
 And when she and her slave-women had had their joy of food,  
 100 they threw off their head-veils and played at ball,  
 and white-armed Nausicaa led them in the singing.  
 As Artemis the arrow-pourer goes down the mountains,<sup>8</sup>  
 down long Taygetus or Erymanthus,  
 delighting in the boars and the running deer,

- 105 and with her the nymphs, daughters of aegis-bearing Zeus,  
play across the wild country, and Leto's heart is glad,  
for she carries her head and brow above them all  
and is known at once, though all of them are beautiful:  
so the unwed girl outshone her handmaids.
- 110 But when she was about to fold the beautiful clothes,  
yoke the mules, and turn for home again,  
then the goddess thought of one thing more, gray-eyed Athena:  
that Odysseus should wake, and see the lovely-eyed girl,  
and she should lead him to the city of the Phaeacian men.
- 115 So the princess tossed the ball to one of her handmaids;<sup>9</sup>  
the handmaid she missed, and it fell in a deep eddy,  
and they shrieked aloud. And noble Odysseus woke,  
and sitting up he turned it over in his mind and heart:  
"Ah me — whose country have I come to now? What men's?"<sup>10</sup>
- 120 Are they violent, savage, without justice,  
or kind to strangers, with hearts that fear the gods?  
A female crying rang around me just now — girls' voices:  
nymphs, who hold the sheer peaks of the mountains  
and the springs of rivers and the grassy water-meadows?
- 125 Or am I now, can it be, near men with human speech?  
Come — I will test it for myself, and see."  
So speaking noble Odysseus slipped out from the thicket,  
and from the thick wood with his heavy hand he broke a branch  
in leaf, to hold about his body and screen a man's privates.
- 130 And he went like a mountain-bred lion, sure of his strength,<sup>11</sup>  
who goes on through rain and wind, his two eyes  
burning, and he comes down on the cattle or the sheep  
or the wild deer, for his belly commands him  
to make trial of the flocks — even to enter the close-built fold:
- 135 so Odysseus was about to come among the fair-braided girls,  
naked as he was: for need had come upon him.  
And he loomed terrible before them, crusted with the salt sea's brine,  
and they scattered, one here, one there, along the jutting sandspits.  
Alone the daughter of Alcinous stayed: for Athena
- 140 set courage in her heart and took the trembling from her limbs.

- She stood and faced him, holding her ground. And Odysseus weighed it,<sup>12</sup>  
 whether to clasp the knees of the lovely-eyed girl and beg,  
 or standing apart as he was, with honeyed words,  
 to beg her to show him the city and give him clothing.
- 145 And as he weighed it, this seemed the better way:  
 to stand apart and beg with honeyed words,  
 lest the girl's heart take anger if he touched her knees.  
 At once he spoke — a honeyed speech, and a shrewd one:<sup>13</sup>  
 "I am at your knees, queen — goddess or mortal, are you?"
- 150 If you are one of the gods who hold wide heaven,  
 then it is to Artemis, daughter of great Zeus,  
 that I liken you nearest — in beauty, in stature, in bearing.  
 But if you are one of the mortals who live on the earth,  
 three times blessed your father and your honored mother,
- 155 three times blessed your brothers! Surely their hearts  
 are warmed through with gladness always because of you,  
 watching such a young shoot go stepping into the dance.  
 But blessed at heart above all others is that man  
 who weighs down the scales of the bride-gifts and leads you home.
- 160 For my eyes have never seen a mortal like you,  
 not man, not woman. Awe takes me, looking at you.  
 In Delos once, beside Apollo's altar, I saw<sup>14</sup>  
 such a thing: the young shoot of a date-palm springing up —  
 for I came there too, and a great host followed me,
- 165 on that road where my bitter cares were to be —  
 and just as, seeing that, I stood amazed at heart  
 a long time, since no such stem had ever risen from the earth,  
 so, lady, I wonder at you, amazed, and I am terribly afraid  
 to touch your knees. But hard grief is upon me.
- 170 Yesterday, on the twentieth day, I escaped the wine-dark sea:  
 all that time the waves carried me, and the driving storms,  
 away from the island Ogygia. And now some power has cast me here —  
 to suffer some new evil in this place too, no doubt: for I do not think  
 the evil will stop; the gods will accomplish plenty more first.
- 175 But pity me, queen. After many hard labors  
 it is to you first I have come; I know not one

- of the others whose city and land this is.  
 Show me the town, and give me a rag to throw around me —  
 if perhaps you had some wrapping-cloth for the linen when you came.
- 180 And may the gods grant you all your heart desires:<sup>15</sup>  
 a husband and a house — and may they add like-mindedness,  
 the good kind. For nothing is stronger or better than that:  
 when two who think alike keep house together,  
 a man and his wife — much grief to their ill-wishers,
- 185 joy to their friends; and they themselves know it best."  
 Then white-armed Nausicaa answered him:  
 "Stranger — since you seem neither base nor witless a man —  
 it is Olympian Zeus himself who deals out fortune to mankind,  
 to good and bad, to each one as he wills;
- 190 and to you, I suppose, he gave this lot, and you must bear it, come what  
 may.  
 But now, since you have come to our city and our land,  
 you shall not want for clothing, nor for anything else  
 that is owed a hard-worn suppliant when he comes.  
 I will show you the town, and tell you the name of the people.
- 195 The Phaeacians hold this city and this land,  
 and I am the daughter of great-hearted Alcinous,  
 on whom the strength and power of the Phaeacians hang."  
 She spoke, and called to her fair-braided handmaids:  
 "Stand still, you girls! Where are you running at the sight of a man?
- 200 You cannot think he is one of an enemy people?  
 There is no living mortal, and there will be none,<sup>16</sup>  
 who could come bearing war into the land  
 of the Phaeacian men. For we are very dear to the deathless ones,  
 and we live apart, in the much-surging sea,
- 205 at the world's edge, and no other mortals mix with us.  
 No — this is some poor wanderer come here astray,  
 whom we must care for now. From Zeus they come, all of them,<sup>17</sup>  
 strangers and beggars; and a gift, though small, is dear.  
 Come, girls: give the stranger food and drink,
- 210 and bathe him in the river, where there is shelter from the wind."  
 So she spoke; and they stood, and called to one another,

and they set Odysseus down in the sheltered place, as she commanded

—  
Nausicaa, daughter of great-hearted Alcinous —

and laid a mantle and a tunic by him for clothing,

215 and gave him soft olive oil in the golden flask,

and urged him to bathe in the streams of the river.

Then noble Odysseus spoke among the handmaids:

"Stand off there, girls, at a distance, so that I myself<sup>18</sup>

may wash the brine from my shoulders, and rub myself

220 with oil: it is long indeed since oil came near my skin.

But I will not bathe in front of you. I would be ashamed  
to stand naked among fair-braided girls."

So he spoke; and they went apart, and told the girl.

And noble Odysseus washed his body in the river,

225 sluicing off the brine that caked his back and broad shoulders,  
and scrubbed from his head the salt-scurf of the barren sea.

And when he had washed all over, and rubbed himself with oil,  
and put on the clothes the unwed girl had given him,

then Athena, born of Zeus, made him<sup>19</sup>

230 taller to look at, and broader, and down from his head  
she made the locks flow in curls, like the hyacinth flower.

As when a man lays gold over silver — a craftsman  
whom Hephaestus and Pallas Athena have taught  
art of every kind, and he finishes works full of grace —

235 so she poured grace over his head and shoulders.

Then he went apart and sat on the shingle of the sea,  
shining with beauty and grace. And the girl gazed at him,  
and spoke among her fair-braided handmaids:

"Listen, my white-armed girls, while I say something.

240 Not against the will of all the gods who hold Olympus  
does this man come among the godlike Phaeacians.

Before, I confess, he seemed to me a sorry sight;  
now he is like the gods who hold wide heaven.

If only such a man might be called my husband,<sup>20</sup>

245 living here — if only it pleased him to stay!

But come, girls: give the stranger food and drink."

So she spoke, and they listened well and obeyed,

and set food and drink beside Odysseus.

And he drank and ate, much-enduring noble Odysseus,  
 250 ravenously: it was long since he had tasted food.<sup>21</sup>

But white-armed Nausicaa thought of one thing more:  
 she folded the clothes and stowed them in the beautiful wagon,  
 and yoked the strong-hoofed mules, and mounted herself,  
 and called Odysseus on, and spoke a word, and named him:

255 "Up now, stranger, and we go to the city, so I may send you  
 to the house of my wise father — where, I promise you,  
 you will meet the best men of all the Phaeacians.

Only do exactly this — you do not seem to me short of sense.<sup>22</sup>

While we are passing the fields and the works of men,  
 260 walk with the handmaids, behind the mules and wagon,  
 briskly; I will lead the way.

But when we are about to enter the city — a high wall rings it,<sup>23</sup>  
 and a beautiful harbor lies on either side of the town,

with a narrow causeway in; and the curved ships are drawn up  
 265 along the road, for every man has his own slip there;  
 and there is the gathering-place around Poseidon's fine precinct,  
 fitted with quarried stones set deep in the earth;  
 and there men see to the tackle of their black ships,  
 the cables and the sails, and fine down their oars —

270 for the Phaeacians care nothing for the bow or the quiver,  
 but for masts, and ships' oars, and the trim ships themselves,  
 in which they delight as they cross the gray salt sea —  
 it is their ugly talk I shrink from: someone behind my back<sup>24</sup>  
 might sneer; there are insolent men enough in the town;

275 and one of the meaner sort, meeting us, might say:

'Who is this following Nausicaa — this tall handsome  
 stranger? Where did she find him? A husband for her, no doubt!

Some castaway she has taken up, off his ship,  
 a man from far parts — since nobody lives near us;

280 or some god, long prayed-for, come down to her  
 out of heaven in answer, and hers he will be all her days!  
 Better so, if she has gone out and found herself a husband  
 from elsewhere — since she scorns her own, here in the land,  
 the Phaeacians, though many fine men are wooing her!'



- 285 So they will say, and it would be a reproach against me.  
 And I would blame another girl who did such things myself:  
 who, against the will of her dear father and mother living,  
 kept company with men before the day of open marriage.  
 So, stranger, mark my word quickly, and you will win  
 290 escort and homecoming from my father soonest.  
 You will find a shining grove of Athena near the road —  
 poplars; a spring wells up in it; a meadow lies around it.  
 There is my father's park there, and his flourishing orchard,  
 as far from the city as a man's shout carries.<sup>25</sup>
- 295 Sit down there and wait a while, until we  
 have entered the town and reached my father's house.  
 But when you judge that we have reached the house,  
 then go into the city of the Phaeacians, and ask  
 for the house of my father, great-hearted Alcinous.
- 300 It is easily known: a little child could lead you —  
 a baby; for the houses of the Phaeacians are not built  
 anything like it — such is the house of the hero  
 Alcinous. And once the buildings and the court have hidden you,  
 go quickly straight through the great hall, until you come  
 305 to my mother. She sits at the hearth in the light of the fire,<sup>26</sup>  
 spinning yarn dyed sea-purple — a wonder to see —  
 leaning against a pillar, and her slave-women sit behind her.  
 And there my father's chair is tilted close to hers,  
 where he sits and drinks his wine like an immortal.
- 310 Pass him by, and throw your arms around the knees  
 of my mother — if you would see your day of homecoming  
 with rejoicing, and quickly, though you come from very far.  
 If she once takes kindly thought for you in her heart,  
 then there is hope you will see your own people, and come  
 315 to your well-built house and your own fatherland."  
 So speaking she touched the mules with the shining whip,  
 and they quickly left the flowing river behind.  
 Well they trotted, well they wheeled their legs along,  
 and she drove with care, so that the walkers could keep pace —  
 320 the handmaids and Odysseus — and used the lash with judgment.<sup>27</sup>  
 And the sun went down, and they came to the famous grove

sacred to Athena. There noble Odysseus sat down,  
and at once he prayed to the daughter of great Zeus:  
"Hear me, child of aegis-bearing Zeus, Unwearied One."<sup>28</sup>

- 325 Hear me now at last, since before you never heard me  
when I was broken — when the famous earth-shaker broke me.  
Grant that I come among the Phaeacians pitied, and a friend."  
So he spoke in prayer, and Pallas Athena heard him.  
But she did not yet show herself to him face to face: she stood<sup>29</sup>  
330 in awe of her father's brother, who raged on furiously  
against godlike Odysseus, until the day he reached his own land.

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 6

- 1 l. 4 The Phaeacian founding legend (4–10): refugees from Cyclops-raids in Hypereia, led out by Nausithous to Scheria, "far from men who eat bread." The founder's checklist — wall, houses, temples, division of plowland — is the exact program of Greek colonization in the poet's own century; Phaeacia is a colonist's dream written into fairyland. And the detail that they once lived *next to the Cyclopes* quietly links the poem's two ends of the hospitality spectrum: the perfect hosts were once the monster's neighbors, and moved.
- 2 l. 20 Athena enters "like a breath of wind" past shut doors — the same dream-physics as the phantom at 4.802, which slipped in "past the strap of the bolt." Dreams are deliveries; the bedroom's locks are no argument.
- 3 l. 25 The dream-speech is a small masterpiece of misdirection: Athena never mentions the man on the beach. She motivates the girl entirely within the girl's own world — laundry, reputation, a wedding soon, what people will say — and lets the plot follow from the trousseau. The goddess of stratagem writes each mortal's motive in that mortal's own language.
- 4 l. 42 Olympus as the poets ever after inherited it: never shaken by wind, never wet by rain, no snow, cloudless clear air, "a white radiance runs over it." The description matches Elysium (4.565–568) almost weather-clause for weather-clause — the gods live in the same eternal fair weather they grant their favorite son-in-law. Sophocles and Lucretius both rewrote these lines.
- 5 l. 57 *πάππα φίλ'* — "Papa dear": the only "papa" in Homer. The wheedling is expert — the wagon is for *his* council-clothes and *the boys'* dance-clothes, her own wedding never named — and line 67 gives the scene its grace: "he saw it all," and granted everything without making her say it. Two sentences of family tact, complete.
- 6 l. 66 "She was shy of naming ripe marriage to her dear father" — *αἶδετο*, the same *aidōs* Athena told Telemachus to drop (3.14). In the boy it was a deficit; in the girl, decorum. The poem prices shame by context.
- 7 l. 92 "Racing one another" at treading laundry in the trenches: work as game. Phaeacia is the poem's land of ease, and even its chores are competitive play — the detail sets up the ball game, and the ball game wakes the plot.
- 8 l. 102 Nausicaa as Artemis among her nymphs, Leto glad at heart — the narrator's simile. Forty-nine lines later Odysseus, who has seen nothing of this, spontaneously offers *the same comparison* (151–152). His courtesy is instinctively exact: he divines the very image the poem has just certified as true. That convergence — his rhetoric landing on reality — is the measure of both his art and her quality. (Helen got the same simile at 4.122; the two Artemis-women meet the same wandering house of Atreus/Laertes at their thresholds.)
- 9 l. 115 The thrown ball, the missed catch, the shriek: the smallest hinge in epic. Athena's grand device for delivering the hero to his hosts is a botched throw in a girls' game. The

poem loves to run destiny through the trivial.

- 10 l. 119 "Are they violent, savage, without justice, or kind to strangers, with hearts that fear the gods?" — the arrival-question, here in its first full form; Odysseus will ask it verbatim off the Cyclops' shore (9.175–176) and on unrecognized Ithaca (13.201–202). It is the poem's entire anthropology in two lines: societies are sorted by one metric only — what they do with a stranger.
- 11 l. 130 The lion simile, deliberately outsized: a starving, salt-crust-ed, naked man holding a leafy branch advances on some girls doing laundry — "like a mountain-bred lion, sure of his strength." The mock-heroic surface has a real edge (the girls scatter; he is terrifying), and one working part: "his belly commands him." The γαστήρ, the belly as tyrant, enters the poem here and will become Odysseus' great theme as beggar.
- 12 l. 141 The deliberation is pure Odysseus: the *correct* suppliant procedure is to clasp the knees — and he rejects it, calculating that a touched girl may take anger where a distanced one will take pity. He chooses rhetoric over ritual, and it works. Tact, in this poem, is a survival technology.
- 13 l. 148 "A honeyed speech, and a shrewd one" — μελίχιον καὶ κερδαλέον: the narrator files this masterpiece under *both* labels before it starts. Sincerity and calculation are not alternatives in Odysseus; the speech is beautiful *and* engineered, and the poem sees no scandal in that.
- 14 l. 162 The Delos palm: the one moment of pure wonder Odysseus reports from his entire war itinerary — a young date-palm shooting up beside Apollo's altar, seen en route to Troy "on that road where my bitter cares were to be." He compares a girl to a tree and makes it the highest compliment in Greek literature: something singular, growing, sacred, and briefly capable of stopping an army-leader in his tracks. (Delos' sacred palm was the one Leto gripped giving birth to Apollo; the poem's audience knew.)
- 15 l. 180 The blessing of ὁμοφροσύνη — "like-mindedness": the poem's definition of marriage, given away by Penelope's husband to a marriageable girl on a beach. "When two who think alike keep house together... much grief to their ill-wishers, joy to their friends; and they themselves know it best." It is at once the most naked self-revelation in his rhetoric and its most perfectly aimed stroke — he blesses her with exactly the thing his whole voyage is for. The last clause — *they themselves know it best* — is a married man speaking.
- 16 l. 201 "There is no living mortal" — διεπὸς βροτός, a crux since antiquity (διεπὸς elsewhere means "wet"; "living" is the guess of the ancients, perhaps via "quick with sap"). However translated, the sense is her serene island-confidence: war cannot reach the Phaeacians. Book 13 will show what can.
- 17 l. 207 "From Zeus they come, all of them, strangers and beggars; and a gift, though small, is dear." The creed of xenia in its most quotable form — spoken by a princess, and repeated verbatim later by a slave, the swineherd Eumaeus (14.57–58). The poem puts its deepest ethical sentence in the mouths of a girl and a herdsman; the suitors, who feast in a palace, never say anything like it.

- 18 l. 218 His refusal to bathe before the girls — "I would be ashamed" — answers her courage with courtesy: reciprocal *aidōs*. The man who has nothing left still has manners; it is the first gift he gives on Scheria, and the only one he can afford.
- 19 l. 229 Athena's transformation, with the gold-over-silver simile: grace *poured over* him like gilding by a craftsman trained by Hephaestus and Athena herself. The entire passage returns verbatim at 23.156–162, when he is beautified for Penelope — the poem uses the same makeover, once for the girl who might have been and once for the wife who is.
- 20 l. 244 "If only such a man might be called my husband" — said aloud, but to the handmaids, in the optative of wishing. The poem's most delicately handled might-have-been: her wish, his blessing (180–185), and the plot that must carry him past her. Alcinous will make the offer openly at 7.311–315; the poem lets the road not taken stay visible its whole length.
- 21 l. 250 "Ravenously: it was long since he had tasted food." Between the two great courtesies — his speech, her welcome — the poem sets down the body's plain fact. The belly that "commanded" the lion at 133 gets its due; heroism in the Odyssey always eats.
- 22 l. 258 "Only do exactly this — you do not seem to me short of sense": Nausicaa reuses, word for word, the formula the sea-goddess Ino used to Odysseus in the storm (5.342). A girl instructing the veteran in her own domain — the town, its gossip, its politics — with a goddess's formula: on Scheria, local knowledge outranks heroic experience, and he obeys her as he obeyed Ino.
- 23 l. 262 The city she sketches (262–272) is the idealized sailor-polis: double harbor, narrow causeway, every man his own ship-slip, the assembly-place by Poseidon's precinct, and the pointed disclaimer — "the Phaeacians care nothing for the bow or the quiver." A city whose only weapons are masts and oars: seafaring entirely demilitarized, trade without raid — the exact inversion of Nestor's polite assumption (3.71–74) that any sailor might be a pirate.
- 24 l. 273 The gossip speech: to warn him, she must *perform* the slander, inventing a mocker and quoting him at length (276–284) — and her invented sneer includes the fantasy of a god come down from heaven to be hers "all her days." The prim conclusion (286–288: *I would blame such a girl myself*) sits directly atop the wish she spoke at 244. Homer lets a marriageable girl's propriety and desire share one speech without reconciling them — psychological realism about three millennia ahead of schedule.
- 25 l. 294 "As far from the city as a man's shout carries" — the voice-measure again (5.400): Phaeacia mapped in the same body-units as the sea.
- 26 l. 305 The strategy of the hearth (303–315): pass the king, supplicate the *queen*. Arete at the fire, spinning sea-purple wool against a pillar, is the house's true center, and everyone in Phaeacia seems to know it. Why the queen's favor decides a suppliant's fate here has been argued since antiquity (a trace of older custom? simply this queen's standing? — Book 7 will give her genealogy and her honors); the poem states the protocol through a daughter who reports it as plain fact.
- 27 l. 320 "She drove with care, so that the walkers could keep pace... and used the lash with judgment" — νόω, with mind. The last we see of Nausicaa in this book is a small portrait

in competence: even her whip-hand is thoughtful.

- 28 *l. 324* The prayer permits itself a reproach: "Hear me now at last, since before you never heard me." Mortals may bill the gods for arrears, politely; the formula's first line is Penelope's (4.762), and the family resemblance between the two petitioners — the wife and the husband, praying to the same goddess in the same words — is the kind of rhyme this poem builds across oceans.
- 29 *l. 329* Athena hears, and does not appear: she "stood in awe of her father's brother." The book ends on Olympian family politics — the goddess managing her uncle's rage by working only behind the scenes — and its final line repeats the poem's opening problem (1.20–21) verbatim: Poseidon raging "against godlike Odysseus, until the day he reached his own land." The clock set in Book 1 is still running; two more books of Phaeacia stand between the grove and that day.

## Odyssey — Book 7

*The palace and gardens of Alcinous; Arete's question.*

- So he prayed there, much-enduring noble Odysseus,  
while the mules' strength carried the girl to the city.  
And when she reached her father's famous house,  
she halted at the gateway; and her brothers around her  
5 stood, men like the immortals, and from under the wagon  
they loosed the mules, and carried the clothing in;  
and she herself went to her room. And her fire was lit  
by an old woman of Apeire, the chamber-keeper Eurymedusa,<sup>1</sup>  
whom once the curved ships brought from Apeire:  
10 they had picked her out as a prize of honor for Alcinous,  
because he ruled all the Phaeacians, and the people listened to him as  
to a god.  
She had nursed white-armed Nausicaa in the halls,  
and now she kindled her fire and made her supper in her room.
- And then Odysseus rose to go to the city; and Athena,  
15 with kind thought for Odysseus, poured a thick mist around him,<sup>2</sup>  
so that no great-hearted Phaeacian, crossing his path,  
might needle him with words and ask him who he was.  
But when he was on the point of entering the lovely city,  
there the goddess, gray-eyed Athena, met him,  
20 in the likeness of a young girl, unwed, carrying a pitcher.  
She stopped in front of him, and noble Odysseus asked her:  
"Child, would you not guide me to the house of a man  
named Alcinous, who is lord among these people?  
I am a stranger, hard-worn, come here  
25 from far away, out of a distant country: so I know not one  
of the people whose city and land this is."  
Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-eyed Athena:  
"Then I will show you, father stranger, the house you bid me  
show: for he lives close by my own blameless father.  
30 Only go in silence, so, and I will lead the way:  
do not look at any of the people, and ask no questions.

For these men do not much endure strangers,<sup>3</sup>  
 nor welcome with open love the man who comes from elsewhere.  
 They trust instead in their fast ships, their swift ones,  
 35 and cross the great gulf on them, since the earth-shaker granted it:  
 ships swift as a wing, or as a thought."<sup>4</sup>  
 So speaking, Pallas Athena led the way  
 swiftly, and he followed in the footsteps of the god.  
 And the Phaeacians, famed for ships, never marked him  
 40 going through the city among them: Athena  
 of the lovely braids would not allow it — the dread goddess —  
 who poured a wondrous haze around him, with kind thought in her  
 heart.  
 And Odysseus wondered at the harbors and the trim ships,  
 at the gathering-places of the heroes themselves, and the walls,  
 45 long and high, fitted with palisades, a wonder to see.  
 But when they came to the king's famous house,  
 the goddess, gray-eyed Athena, began to speak among them:  
 "Here, father stranger, is the house you bid me  
 show you. You will find the Zeus-nurtured kings  
 50 feasting at the feast. Go in, and let your heart  
 fear nothing: the bold man proves the better man<sup>5</sup>  
 in every venture, though he come from another country.  
 First you will come upon the mistress in the halls:  
 Arete is the name she is called, and she comes of the same<sup>6</sup>  
 55 parents, the very ones who fathered King Alcinous.  
 Nausithous first was born from Poseidon the earth-shaker  
 and Periboea, loveliest of women,  
 youngest daughter of great-hearted Eurymedon,  
 who once was king over the overweening Giants —  
 60 but he destroyed his reckless people, and was destroyed himself.  
 With her Poseidon lay, and fathered a son,  
 great-hearted Nausithous, who ruled among the Phaeacians;  
 and Nausithous fathered Rhexenor and Alcinous.  
 Rhexenor — still without a son, a bridegroom in his hall —  
 65 Apollo of the silver bow struck down, leaving one only child,  
 Arete. Her Alcinous made his wife,  
 and honored her as no other woman on earth is honored,<sup>7</sup>



- of all the wives who now keep house under their husbands:  
 so heartfelt is the honor she has held, and holds still,  
 70 from her dear children and from Alcinous himself  
 and from the people, who look on her as on a god  
 and greet her with blessings when she walks through the town.  
 For she herself has no lack of noble understanding:  
 for those she favors — even men — she dissolves quarrels.<sup>8</sup>  
 75 If she once takes kindly thought for you in her heart,  
 then there is hope you will see your own people, and come  
 to your high-roofed house and your own fatherland."  
 So speaking, gray-eyed Athena went away  
 over the barren sea, and left lovely Scheria,  
 80 and came to Marathon and wide-wayed Athens,<sup>9</sup>  
 and entered the close-built house of Erechtheus. But Odysseus  
 went toward the famous house of Alcinous, and his heart  
 was churning as he stood there, before he reached the threshold of  
 bronze.  
 For there was a sheen as of the sun or the moon<sup>10</sup>  
 85 through the high-roofed house of great-hearted Alcinous.  
 Walls of bronze ran this way and that,  
 from the threshold to the inmost room, with a frieze of blue enamel  
 round them;  
 doors of gold closed the close-built house within;  
 the doorposts standing on the bronze threshold were of silver,  
 90 the lintel above was silver, and the door-handle gold;  
 and on either side stood dogs of gold and silver<sup>11</sup>  
 that Hephaestus had made with his knowing craft  
 to guard the house of great-hearted Alcinous —  
 creatures deathless and unaging all their days.  
 95 And within, seats stood along the wall this way and that,  
 from the threshold to the inmost room in an unbroken line, and over  
 them  
 were thrown fine close-spun coverings, the work of women.  
 There the leaders of the Phaeacians would sit  
 drinking and eating: what they had never failed.  
 100 And youths of gold on well-built pedestals  
 stood holding blazing torches in their hands,

lighting the nights through the house for the feasters.  
 And fifty slave-women serve the house:<sup>12</sup>  
 some grind the apple-gold grain at the mill,  
 105 others weave at the looms and turn the spindles,  
 sitting close as the leaves of a tall poplar,  
 and from the close-woven linen the soft oil runs.  
 As far as the Phaeacian men are skilled beyond all others  
 at driving a fast ship on the sea, so are their women  
 110 masters of the loom: for Athena has given them beyond others  
 knowledge of beautiful work, and noble minds.  
 And outside the courtyard, close by the doors, is a great orchard<sup>13</sup>  
 of four acres, with a hedge driven round it on both sides.  
 There tall trees grow in full leaf and flower:  
 115 pears and pomegranates and apple trees bright with fruit,  
 sweet figs and olives in full flourish.  
 Their fruit never perishes, never fails,  
 winter or summer, the year round; but always  
 the breathing West Wind sets some growing, ripens others:  
 120 pear grows old upon pear, apple upon apple,  
 grape-cluster upon cluster, fig upon fig.  
 And there his vineyard, heavy with fruit, is rooted,  
 one part of it a drying-ground on level open earth,  
 baking in the sun; other grapes they are gathering,  
 125 and others they are treading; and out in front are the unripe ones,  
 one row shedding its blossom, another darkening toward purple.  
 And there, by the last row of vines, grow ordered beds  
 of greens of every kind, shining the whole year through;  
 and two springs: one is scattered through all the garden,  
 130 the other dives under the courtyard threshold and runs  
 toward the high house, where the townsfolk drew their water.  
 Such were the shining gifts of the gods in the house of Alcinous.  
 There much-enduring noble Odysseus stood gazing.<sup>14</sup>  
 And when his heart had wondered at it all,  
 135 he stepped quickly over the threshold into the house.  
 He found the leaders and counselors of the Phaeacians  
 pouring from their cups to the sharp-eyed slayer of Argus,<sup>15</sup>  
 to whom they poured last of all, when they thought of sleep.

- But much-enduring noble Odysseus went on through the house  
 140 wrapped in the thick mist Athena had poured around him,  
 until he came to Arete and to King Alcinous.  
 And Odysseus threw his arms around Arete's knees —<sup>16</sup>  
 and then, just then, the god-sent mist poured back off him.  
 And they fell dumb through the house at the sight of the man,  
 145 and stared in wonder. And Odysseus made his plea:  
 "Arete, daughter of godlike Rhexenor:  
 to your husband, to your knees, I come after much labor —  
 and to these feasters. May the gods grant them fortunate  
 lives; and may each hand down to his children  
 150 the wealth in his halls, and the honors the people have given him.  
 But for me — speed my sending, that I may come to my fatherland,  
 and quickly: for long now, far from my own people, I suffer pains."  
 So speaking he sat down on the hearth, in the ashes<sup>17</sup>  
 by the fire; and they were all hushed in silence.  
 155 At long last the old hero Echeneus spoke —  
 a man elder-born beyond the other Phaeacians,  
 who excelled in speech, knowing many things grown old with him;  
 with good will toward them he spoke to the assembly:  
 "Alcinous, this is not the fairer way — it is not fitting —  
 160 a stranger sitting on the ground, on the hearth, in the ashes,  
 while these men hold themselves in, waiting for your word.  
 Come — raise the stranger up, and seat him on a chair  
 with silver studs, and bid the heralds  
 mix more wine, so that to Zeus who delights in thunder  
 165 we may pour also — the god who walks beside honored suppliants;<sup>18</sup>  
 and let the housekeeper give the stranger supper from her stores."  
 And when the sacred strength of Alcinous heard it,<sup>19</sup>  
 he took the hand of battle-wise Odysseus, the man of shifting counsels,  
 raised him from the hearth and set him on a shining chair,  
 170 making his son stand up — kind-hearted Laodamas,<sup>20</sup>  
 who sat beside him, and whom he loved the most.  
 A handmaid brought water for their hands in a pitcher,  
 a beautiful golden one, and poured it over a silver basin  
 for them to wash, and drew up a polished table beside them.  
 175 The grave housekeeper brought bread and set it before them,

- laying out delicacies in plenty, giving gladly of her store;  
 and he drank and ate, much-enduring noble Odysseus.  
 And then the strength of Alcinous said to the herald:  
 "Pontonous, mix the bowl, and serve out the wine  
 180 to all in the hall, so that to Zeus who delights in thunder  
 we may pour also — the god who walks beside honored suppliants."  
 So he spoke, and Pontonous mixed the honey-hearted wine  
 and served all, pouring first drops in each cup for the gods.  
 But when they had poured, and drunk what their hearts would have,  
 185 Alcinous addressed them all, and said:  
 "Hear me, leaders and counselors of the Phaeacians,<sup>21</sup>  
 while I say what the heart in my breast commands.  
 Now you have feasted: go home and take your rest;  
 in the morning we will call more of the elders together  
 190 and host the stranger in the halls, and offer the gods  
 fine victims; and after that we will think also  
 of his sending, so that without labor or pain this stranger  
 may come, under our escort, to his own fatherland  
 rejoicing, and quickly, though he come from very far,  
 195 and suffer no evil or harm midway  
 before he sets foot in his own land. There, afterward,  
 he will suffer whatever Destiny and the grave Spinners<sup>22</sup>  
 spun in his thread at his birth, when his mother bore him.  
 But if he is one of the deathless ones, come down from heaven,<sup>23</sup>  
 200 then this is some new thing the gods are devising:  
 for always in time past the gods have shown themselves openly  
 to us, whenever we offer glorious hecatombs,  
 and they feast beside us, sitting where we sit.  
 And if a lone traveler on the road meets them,  
 205 they use no disguise with us — for we are of near kin,  
 like the Cyclopes and the wild tribes of the Giants."  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 "Alcinous, let your mind be easy on that count. I am not<sup>24</sup>  
 like the deathless ones who hold wide heaven,  
 210 not in build, not in bearing: I am like mortal men.  
 Whoever you know among mankind who carry the heaviest  
 loads of misery — it is to them I would compare my pains.

Yes, and I could tell a still longer tale of evils,  
all that I have labored through by the gods' will.  
215 But let me eat my supper, for all my grief:<sup>25</sup>  
for there is nothing more dog-shameless than the hateful belly,  
which commands a man to remember it, by force,  
however worn he is, however deep the sorrow in his heart —  
as I have sorrow in my heart, and still this thing  
220 forever bids me eat and drink, and makes me forget  
all I have suffered, and orders me: be filled.  
But you — bestir yourselves at the showing of dawn,  
to set me, unlucky as I am, on my own fathers' soil,  
even after all I have suffered. And let life leave me once I have seen<sup>26</sup>  
225 my own possessions, my slaves, and my great high-roofed house."  
So he spoke, and they all approved it and urged  
that the stranger be sent home, since he had spoken rightly.  
But when they had poured, and drunk what their hearts would have,  
the others went home to sleep, each man to his own house,  
230 and noble Odysseus was left behind in the hall,  
and beside him sat Arete and godlike Alcinous,  
while the handmaids cleared away the service of the feast.  
And white-armed Arete began to speak among them —<sup>27</sup>  
for she had recognized the mantle and the tunic, seeing the beautiful  
235 clothes she herself had made with her attendant women —  
and lifting her voice she spoke winged words to him:  
"Stranger, this question first, and I ask it myself:  
What man are you, and from where? Who gave you these clothes?  
Did you not say you came here wandering over the sea?"  
240 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
"It is hard, my queen, to tell my griefs straight through<sup>28</sup>  
to the end: the gods of heaven have given me so many.  
But this I will tell you, since you ask it of me and inquire.  
There is an island, Ogygia, lying far off in the sea,  
245 where the daughter of Atlas lives — guileful Calypso  
of the lovely braids, a dread goddess; and no one  
mixes with her, no god, no mortal man.  
But me — unlucky me — some power brought to her hearth  
alone, after Zeus with a hurl of the white lightning had shattered

- 250 my fast ship apart in the middle of the wine-dark sea.  
 There all the rest of my brave companions perished,  
 but I threw my arms round the keel of my curved ship  
 and was carried nine days; and on the tenth, in the black night,  
 the gods brought me near the island Ogygia, where Calypso  
 255 lives, she of the lovely braids, the dread goddess. And she took me in  
 and loved me and tended me devotedly, and promised  
 to make me deathless and unaging all my days;  
 but she never once persuaded the heart in my breast.  
 There I stayed seven years unbroken, and forever wet  
 260 with my tears the immortal clothing Calypso gave me.  
 But when the eighth year came wheeling round for me,  
 then at last she urged me — commanded me — to go,  
 whether by some message from Zeus, or her own mind had turned.<sup>29</sup>  
 She sent me off on a raft bound plank to plank, and gave me much —  
 265 bread and sweet wine — and dressed me in immortal clothing,  
 and sent up a fair wind for me, harmless and warm.  
 Seventeen days I sailed on, crossing the water,  
 and on the eighteenth appeared the shadowy mountains  
 of your land, and my own heart was glad —  
 270 ill-fated as I was: for I was yet to keep company with misery  
 in plenty, sent upon me by Poseidon the earth-shaker,  
 who loosed the winds against me and barred my road,  
 and stirred up a sea past all speaking; nor would the wave  
 let me be carried on my raft, for all my thick groaning.  
 275 The squall then shattered the raft to pieces. But I  
 swam — cut my way across that gulf — until wind and water  
 carried me near, and brought me to your land.  
 There, as I climbed out, the wave would have forced me onto the shore,  
 dashing me on the great rocks in a joyless place;  
 280 but I gave way, and swam back out, until I came  
 to a river, where at last the ground seemed best to me,  
 clear of stones, and there was shelter from the wind.  
 I dropped there, gathering my spirit back; and ambrosial night  
 came on. I climbed out clear of the heaven-fed river  
 285 and fell asleep in the bushes, and heaped the fallen leaves  
 around me; and a god poured down boundless sleep.

- There in the leaves, my heart worn down with grief,  
 I slept the whole night through, and dawn, and midday;  
 the sun was slanting down when sweet sleep let me go.
- 290 And I saw your daughter's handmaids on the beach  
 at play, and she among them, like the goddesses.  
 To her I made my plea. And she did not fail in noble understanding —<sup>30</sup>  
 as you would not hope of the young when you meet them  
 face to face: for the young are forever thoughtless.
- 295 She gave me bread in plenty, and fire-bright wine,  
 and a bath in the river, and gave me these clothes.  
 That, for all my grieving, is the truth of it, told through."  
 Then Alcinous answered him in turn, and said:  
 "Stranger, in this one point, truly, my child did not see  
 300 rightly: that she did not bring you with her attendant women  
 to our house — when she was the first you supplicated."  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 "Hero, do not scold your blameless daughter for that."<sup>31</sup>  
 She did tell me to follow along with her handmaids;  
 305 it was I who would not — out of fear, out of shame,  
 lest perhaps your own heart darken at the sight:  
 we are jealous-minded things, we tribes of men upon the earth."  
 Then Alcinous answered him in turn, and said:  
 "Stranger, the heart in my breast is not the kind  
 310 to take fire for nothing. Due measure is better in all things.  
 If only — father Zeus, Athena, Apollo! —<sup>32</sup>  
 being the man you are, and thinking as I think,  
 you would take my daughter and be called my son-in-law,  
 staying here: I would give you a house and possessions —  
 315 if you stayed willingly. Against your will no Phaeacian  
 shall hold you: father Zeus forbid such a thing.  
 As for your sending, I appoint it — be sure of it —  
 for tomorrow. Till then you will lie mastered by sleep,  
 and they will row the calm, until you come  
 320 to your fatherland and your house, and whatever place is dear to you,  
 though it be far, much farther than Euboea —<sup>33</sup>  
 which those of our people say is farthest of all  
 who saw it, when they carried fair-haired Rhadamanthus

out to visit Tityus, the son of Earth.

325 They went all the way there, and finished it without strain,  
and on the same day accomplished the journey home again.  
And you shall know for yourself, in your own heart, how far my ships  
are the best — and my young men at throwing up the sea with the oar-  
blade."

So he spoke; and much-enduring noble Odysseus was glad,  
330 and he spoke in prayer, and said a word, and named:  
"Father Zeus, may Alcinous accomplish all  
he has said: on the grain-giving earth his fame  
would be unquenchable — and I would come to my fatherland."  
So the two of them spoke such things to one another,

335 while white-armed Arete told her handmaids  
to set out bedsteads under the porch, and to lay on them<sup>34</sup>  
beautiful purple blankets, and spread rugs above,  
and fleecy cloaks on top of all, for cover.

Out of the hall they went with torches in their hands;  
340 and when they had briskly spread the close-corded bed,  
they came and stood beside Odysseus and called him:  
"Up, stranger, come and sleep: your bed is made."<sup>35</sup>

So they spoke; and welcome it seemed to him to sleep.  
So he slept there, much-enduring noble Odysseus,  
345 on a corded bedstead under the echoing porch;  
but Alcinous lay down in the inner room of the high house,<sup>36</sup>  
where the lady his wife made ready his bed and his rest.



NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 7

- 1 l. 8 Eurymedusa, the old chamber-keeper, gets the poem's standard slave-biography: where she was taken from (Apeire), how she came (by ship), and why she went to the king ("a prize of honor"). As with Eurycleia's twenty oxen (1.430–431), the poem dignifies the person while stating the transaction plainly.
- 2 l. 15 Athena's mist — the hero walking unseen through a marveling city to a royal hall — is the scene Virgil lifted whole for Aeneas' entry into Carthage (*Aeneid* 1.411ff.). The mist does double work: protection, and theatrical timing; it will burst at the exact moment of maximum effect (143).
- 3 l. 32 "These men do not much endure strangers": the guide-girl's warning sits oddly against Phaeacia's perfect hospitality — and that is the point. The blessed are insular; their kindness, once triggered by proper supplication, is flawless, but nothing about them goes looking for the world. They are hosts, not neighbors (they have none: 6.204–205, 279).
- 4 l. 36 "Ships swift as a wing, or as a thought" — the first hint of the marvel made explicit at 8.557–563: Phaeacian ships steer by thought, without helmsmen. Poseidon's own grant (35), which makes what Poseidon later does about it a family matter.
- 5 l. 51 "The bold man proves the better man in every venture" — Athena's parting maxim to a man about to walk into a strange hall with nothing. It is the disguised goddess's variant of what she told Telemachus at 3.14; father and son get the same curriculum, adjusted for experience.
- 6 l. 54 Arete's name is transparent in Greek: ἀρητός, "prayed-for" — both the long-desired only child of a dead father, and precisely the person to whom this book's prayer must be addressed. The poem names its own protocol: to get home, pray to the Prayed-For.
- 7 l. 67 The claim is absolute: honored "as no other woman on earth is honored... of all the wives who now keep house under their husbands." The genealogy behind it (uncle marrying his dead brother's only child) makes her both queen and sole heiress of the founder's line — one root of her extraordinary standing, though the poem rests the case on her mind (73–74), not her blood.
- 8 l. 74 "For those she favors — even men — she dissolves quarrels": Arete exercises judicial authority, settling men's disputes. No other mortal woman in Homer holds that power. Odysseus is being routed toward the one person on Scheria whose verdict functions like a court's.
- 9 l. 80 Athena exits to "Marathon and wide-wayed Athens... the close-built house of Erechtheus" — one of the poem's very few notices of mainland cult: the goddess lodging in the old king's house on the Acropolis (the arrangement the Erechtheum later monumentalized). A quiet bow toward an Athenian audience, planted in fairyland.

- 10 l. 84 The palace (84–132) glows with the sun-and-moon line used of Menelaus' hall (4.45) — and then outbids it: walls of bronze, a frieze of κύαρος (blue glass-paste — a real Mycenaean architectural luxury; excavation found exactly such friezes at Tiryns), gold doors, silver posts and lintel. The poem's memory of the Bronze Age is sometimes archaeologically exact.
- 11 l. 91 Hephaestus' watchdogs of gold and silver, "deathless and unaging all their days" — automata, like the god's golden serving-women in *Iliad* 18. The phrase is the very one Calypso used of the immortality offered Odysseus (5.136). On Scheria, what he refused is lawn ornamentation.
- 12 l. 103 Fifty slave-women — grinding, weaving, spinning, "sitting close as the leaves of a tall poplar," the oil sheen running off the close-woven linen. Then the summary economy (108–111): the men are masters of ships, the women of looms, both by Athena's gift. It is the same praise-structure Antinous used of Penelope's skill (2.116–118) — Athena's gifts to women are real capital in this poem.
- 13 l. 112 The garden of Alcinous — the most famous orchard in Western literature: four acres where fruit "never perishes, never fails, winter or summer," the West Wind ripening one crop while it starts the next, "pear grows old upon pear, apple upon apple." Eternal yield without labor — the agricultural face of the Olympus/Elysium weather (6.42–46, 4.566–568). Its deliberate opposite waits at the far end of the poem: Laertes' orchard in Book 24, where every tree is known by name because every tree was dug, dunged, and counted — love's agriculture against paradise's.
- 14 l. 133 He stands and gazes until "his heart had wondered at it all" — the identical formula used of Hermes admiring Calypso's cave (5.75–76). The poem grades its paradises by making gods and heroes tourists in each other's.
- 15 l. 137 The last cup of the night is poured to Hermes — god of sleep-bringing (5.47–48) and safe conduct. The Phaeacians' nightcap piety is exactly the god a homeless traveler needs already in the room.
- 16 l. 142 The staged epiphany: he crosses the hall invisible, touches the queen's knees, and *then* the mist pours off — the suppliant materializing out of nothing at the one correct pair of knees. Athena has choreographed the supplication Nausicaa scripted (6.310–315) into a coup de théâtre.
- 17 l. 153 After the plea, he sits down "on the hearth, in the ashes": the suppliant's total self-abasement, placing himself at the house's sacred center as its lowest thing. The hall's stunned silence (154) is the ritual working; Echeneus' intervention states the norm the scene has been built to trigger — no stranger sits in ashes while men look on.
- 18 l. 165 "Zeus who delights in thunder... the god who walks beside honored suppliants" — Zeus Hiketesios, protector of suppliants, invoked twice in seventeen lines (164–165, 180–181). The doctrine Nausicaa cited on the beach (6.207–208) is here performed as liturgy by the state.
- 19 l. 167 "The sacred strength of Alcinous" — the same periphrasis of honor the poem gave Telemachus on the night of his first command (2.409). Applied to Alcinous it is nearly a title; the translation keeps the strangeness both times.

- 20 l. 170 To seat the suppliant, the king displaces Laodamas — the son "he loved the most," from the chair nearest him. Precedence made physical: on Scheria the stranger outranks the favorite child. Remember the suitors, who would not yield a stool.
- 21 l. 186 "Hear me, leaders and counselors of the Phaeacians" — Alcinous' assembly-formula, fixed here; it will toll through Books 8, 11, and 13, the Phaeacian counterpart of "Hear me now, men of Ithaca" (2.25).
- 22 l. 197 "Whatever Destiny and the grave Spinners spun in his thread at his birth" — the Κλωθεῖς, the Spinners, appear by that name only here in Homer (elsewhere fate is spun by gods or by Aisa). Alcinous' theology is precise: escort ends at the beach; thread resumes at the property line.
- 23 l. 199 Alcinous' strange boast: gods dine with Phaeacians undisguised, "for we are of near kin, like the Cyclopes and the wild tribes of the Giants." The genealogy is real (Poseidon fathered their founder; Periboea was a Giant's daughter) — and unsettling: the perfect hosts locate themselves beside the poem's monsters, kin to both. Civilization here is a choice made *within* that bloodline, not an escape from it — the Cyclops episode, one narrative hour away, is a family portrait.
- 24 l. 208 For the second time in three books, Odysseus is mistaken for (or offered the status of) a god, and refuses downward: "compare me instead to the most miserable of men." His identity-claims run consistently toward the mortal, the suffering, the hungry — which his next sentence makes literal.
- 25 l. 215 The belly speech: "nothing more dog-shameless than the hateful belly," which makes even the deep-grieving eat, "and orders me: be filled." Ancient critics were scandalized that an epic hero talks this way; it is precisely the poem's signature. The γαστήρ that drove the lion at 6.133 here gets its full philosophy: grief is aristocratic, hunger is democratic, and the survivor obeys the latter to keep the former. No Iliadic hero could have said it; ten years of shipwreck teach a different physics.
- 26 l. 224 His stated wish: to see "my own possessions, my slaves, and my great high-roofed house" — and then die content. No wife named. To read it as coldness is to misread the room: he is a nameless stranger among strangers, and Penelope is the one possession of his heart he will not set on the table. The reticence is protective — and the poem lets it also be ominous: he does not yet know what he will find.
- 27 l. 233 Arete has waited out the whole evening — feast, speeches, the hall emptying — and then asks, with the two of them beside the fire, the poem's standard identity question plus one of her own: "Who gave you these clothes?" She wove them; she knows. It is the shrewdest three lines any host asks in the Odyssey: courteous in form, and in substance a queen cross-examining a stranger who has appeared out of thin air wearing her household's linen with her marriageable daughter unaccounted for.
- 28 l. 241 His answer (241–297) is the poem's first extended self-narration: strictly truthful, strictly selective. No name, no Troy, no fame — the story begins at Ogygia and covers exactly what we watched in Books 5–6, reusing the very lines (Zeus' thunderbolt = 5.131–132; deathless-and-unaging = 5.136; seventeen days and the shadowy mountains = 5.278–279; the river-mouth "clear of stones... shelter from the wind" = 5.442–443). He answers

the clothes question fully, and the identity question not at all — and Arete lets it stand, for now.

- 29 l. 263 "Whether by some message from Zeus, or her own mind had turned" — he genuinely does not know why Calypso released him: Hermes' visit happened offstage of his life. The poem is scrupulous about who knows what; its hero narrates from inside his own horizon, and the audience holds the fuller map. This discipline is about to matter enormously, four books of first-person narration ahead.
- 30 l. 292 Covering for Nausicaa begins with a general slander of the young ("forever thoughtless") that she has just disproven — and proceeds, under Alcinous' mild criticism, to a full gallant lie (304–305): *she* told him to follow; *he* refused from fear and shame. The reverse of the truth (6.257ff.), told to spare her the exact reproach she foresaw. Odysseus' first lie on Scheria is told for someone else's sake; Alcinous believes it, and the poem smiles.
- 31 l. 303 "Do not scold your blameless daughter": he deploys ἀμύμων — the grand epic honorific — for a girl accused of a breach of etiquette, gently overweighting the scale in her favor. The word choice is itself part of the shield.
- 32 l. 311 Alcinous' offer — my daughter, a house, possessions, "being the man you are, and thinking as I think" (τά τε φρονέων ἄ τ' ἐγώ περ). The father independently arrives at Nausicaa's own wish (6.244–245), and grounds it in *like-mindedness* — the very ὁμοφροσύνη Odysseus blessed her with on the beach (6.181–185). And then, in the same breath, the anti-Calypso clause: "against your will no Phaeacian shall hold you." An offer that guarantees your freedom to refuse it is Phaeacia in one sentence — the good temptation, courteously declined by a man whose measure of marriage the family keeps unknowingly quoting back to him.
- 33 l. 321 Euboea as "farthest of all" — the geography of fairyland, for which the middle of the Greek world is the edge of the earth. The proof-voyage: they once ferried Rhadamanthus (the Elysian judge, 4.564) to visit Tityus son of Earth, and were home the same day. Ships that day-trip between paradise and the giants make short work of Ithaca — and the boast will draw Poseidon's eye (13.125ff.).
- 34 l. 336 The bed-making orders repeat Helen's verbatim (4.297–299), and the guest-bed line "on a corded bedstead under the echoing porch" is Telemachus' at Pylos (3.399). Odysseus has entered the same hospitality type-scene his son traveled through — father and son now sleeping in the poem's same formulaic bed, three seas apart.
- 35 l. 342 "Up, stranger, come and sleep: your bed is made." After eighteen days of open water, cliff-faces, and leaf-piles, the poem gives the handmaids one line of plain human kindness — the simplest sentence in the book, and the most restorative.
- 36 l. 346 The closing couplet reworks the Nestor-night ending (3.402–403), lightly adapted to its new house: king in the inner room, wife making ready the bed. The book is one immense hospitality type-scene executed perfectly at every step — mist to knees to ashes to chair to feast to question to bed — and it closes on the form's quietest cadence: everyone, at last, in their right place.

## Odyssey — Book 8

*The games; the song of Ares and Aphrodite; the wooden horse, and the weeping guest.*

- When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,  
 the sacred strength of Alcinous rose up from his bed,  
 and up rose Zeus-born Odysseus, sacker of cities.<sup>1</sup>  
 And the sacred strength of Alcinous led the way  
 5 to the Phaeacians' gathering-place, built there beside the ships.  
 They came and sat down on the polished stones  
 side by side. And Pallas Athena went up and down the city  
 in the likeness of a herald of wise Alcinous,  
 devising the homecoming of great-hearted Odysseus,  
 10 and standing beside each man she spoke her word:  
 "This way, come — leaders and counselors of the Phaeacians —  
 to the gathering-place, to learn about the stranger  
 who has come new to the house of wise Alcinous  
 after wandering the sea — a man like the immortals in body."  
 15 So speaking she stirred the strength and spirit of each,  
 and quickly the gathering-place and the seats were filled  
 with men assembling; and many marveled at the sight  
 of Laertes' battle-wise son. For Athena  
 poured a wondrous grace over his head and shoulders  
 20 and made him taller to look at, and broader,  
 so that he might be dear to all the Phaeacians,  
 and dreaded, and revered, and might accomplish the many  
 trials in which the Phaeacians would test Odysseus.  
 And when they were assembled, all in one gathering,  
 25 Alcinous addressed them all, and said:  
 "Hear me, leaders and counselors of the Phaeacians,  
 while I say what the heart in my breast commands.  
 This stranger — I do not know who he is — has come wandering to my  
 house,  
 whether from the men of the east or of the west;  
 30 he presses for a sending, and pleads that it be made sure.

- Let us then, as always before, speed his sending on.  
 For no man, no — no one who ever comes to my house  
 waits here long, grieving for his escort.  
 Come: let us haul a black ship down to the bright salt water,  
 35 one on her first voyage, and let fifty-two young men<sup>2</sup>  
 be chosen through the town, as many as have proven best.  
 Lash your oars well to the benches, every one,  
 then come ashore; and afterward come to my house  
 and see to a feast at speed: I will provide well for all.  
 40 To the young men these are my orders. And you others,  
 sceptered kings, come to my beautiful house,  
 so we may welcome the stranger in the halls —  
 let no man refuse. And call the godlike singer,  
 Demodocus: for to him the god has given song<sup>3</sup>  
 45 beyond all others, to delight men however his heart is stirred to sing."  
 So speaking he led the way, and the sceptered kings  
 followed with him; and a herald went for the godlike singer.  
 And the fifty-two young men, chosen out,  
 went, as he commanded, to the beach of the barren sea.  
 50 And when they had come down to the ship and the sea,  
 they hauled the black ship down to deep water,  
 and set the mast and the sails in the black ship,  
 and fitted the oars into their leather slings,  
 all in due order, and spread the white sails open.  
 55 They moored her well out in the water, and then  
 went their way to the great house of wise Alcinous.  
 And the porticoes and courts and halls were filled  
 with men assembling: there were many, young and old.  
 For them Alcinous slaughtered twelve sheep,  
 60 eight white-tusked hogs, and two shambling oxen;  
 these they flayed and dressed, and made the lovely feast ready.  
 And the herald came near, leading the trusted singer,  
 whom the Muse loved beyond other men, and gave him good and evil  
 both:<sup>4</sup>  
 she took away his eyes, and gave him sweet song.  
 65 For him Pontonous set a silver-studded chair  
 in the middle of the feasters, leaning it on a tall pillar,

and hung the clear-voiced lyre on its peg  
just above his head, and showed him how to reach it  
with his hands; and set by him a basket and a beautiful table,  
70 and a cup of wine beside, to drink when his heart should bid him.  
And their hands went out to the good things spread before them.  
But when they had put away desire for food and drink,  
the Muse stirred the singer to sing the famous deeds of men,  
from that song whose fame had then already reached wide heaven:  
75 the quarrel of Odysseus and Achilles, Peleus' son —<sup>5</sup>  
how once they clashed at the gods' rich feast  
with terrible words, and the lord of men Agamemnon  
rejoiced in his heart that the best of the Achaeans were quarreling.  
For so Phoebus Apollo had told him in prophecy  
80 at holy Pytho, when he crossed the stone threshold  
to consult the god: then the beginning of woe was rolling down  
on Trojans and Danaans alike, through the counsels of great Zeus.

This the famous singer sang. But Odysseus<sup>6</sup>  
took his great purple cloak in his heavy hands  
85 and drew it down over his head, and hid his handsome face:  
he was ashamed to let the tears run under his brows before the  
Phaeacians.  
Whenever the godlike singer paused in his singing,  
he would wipe the tears away, and take the cloak from his head,  
and lifting the two-handled cup would pour to the gods;  
90 but whenever he began again, and the best of the Phaeacians  
urged him to sing, because they took joy in the tale,  
Odysseus would cover his head again, and mourn.  
From all the others he hid the tears he shed;  
Alcinous alone remarked him and noticed,  
95 sitting beside him, and heard his heavy groaning.  
At once he spoke among the oar-loving Phaeacians:  
"Hear me, leaders and counselors of the Phaeacians.  
By now we have had our hearts' fill of the shared feast,  
and of the lyre, which is the companion of the rich feast.  
100 Now let us go out and try our hands at contests,  
all of them — so that the stranger may tell his own people,  
when he has come home, how far we surpass others

- at boxing and wrestling and jumping and speed of foot."  
 So speaking he led the way, and they went with him.
- 105 And the herald hung the clear-voiced lyre on its peg,  
 took Demodocus by the hand, and led him out of the hall,  
 guiding him along the same road the others  
 had gone, the best of the Phaeacians, to wonder at the games.  
 They went their way to the gathering-place, and a huge crowd  
 followed,
- 110 thousands; and many fine young men stood up.  
 Up rose Acroneus and Ocyalus and Elatreus,<sup>7</sup>  
 Nauteus and Prymneus and Anchialus and Eretmeus,  
 Ponteus and Proreus, Thoon and Anabesineus,  
 and Amphialus, son of Polyneus, Tecton's son;
- 115 and up rose Euryalus, the equal of man-destroying Ares,  
 Naubolus' son, who was best in beauty and body  
 of all the Phaeacians after blameless Laodamas.  
 And up stood the three sons of blameless Alcinous:  
 Laodamas, and Halius, and godlike Clytoneus.
- 120 First they made trial of one another in the footrace.  
 The course was stretched for them from the turning-post, and all  
 together  
 they flew off quickly, raising the dust of the plain;  
 and far the best at running was blameless Clytoneus:  
 by as much as the width of a mule-team's furrow in fallow ground,<sup>8</sup>
- 125 by that much he outran the rest to the crowd, and left them behind.  
 Then they made trial of grinding wrestling,  
 and there Euryalus outdid all the best;  
 at the jump Amphialus was first of them all;  
 with the discus far the best of all was Elatreus,
- 130 and at boxing Laodamas, Alcinous' good son.  
 And when they had all taken their hearts' pleasure in the contests,  
 Laodamas, Alcinous' son, spoke among them:  
 "Come, friends, let us ask the stranger whether he knows  
 any contest, and has learned it. In build, at least, he is no mean man —
- 135 the thighs and calves of him, the two arms above,  
 the massive neck, the great strength; nor does he lack  
 the prime of youth — only he is broken by many evils.



- For I say there is nothing worse than the sea  
to shatter a man, however strong he be."
- 140 Then Euryalus answered him in turn, and said:  
"Laodamas, you have spoken this word in due measure.  
Now go yourself and challenge him, and speak your speech."  
And when the good son of Alcinous heard it,  
he went and stood in the middle, and addressed Odysseus:
- 145 "Come you too, father stranger: try your hand at the contests,  
if you have learned any — and it is like you to know contests:  
for there is no greater fame for a man, while he lives,<sup>9</sup>  
than what he achieves with his own feet and hands.  
Come, make a trial; scatter the cares from your heart.
- 150 Your road will not be long delayed now: already  
the ship is hauled down, and the companions are ready."  
Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
"Laodamas, why do you all urge this on me, mocking?  
Cares are closer to my heart than contests.
- 155 I have suffered much before now, much have I labored,  
and now I sit in your gathering hungry for homecoming,  
pleading with the king and with all the people."  
Then Euryalus answered him — and jeered to his face:  
"No, stranger: I do not take you for a man of contests,<sup>10</sup>
- 160 such as are held in plenty among mankind —  
rather for one who plies to and fro in a many-benched ship,  
a master of sailors who are traders,  
with a memory for cargo, an eye on his freight  
and his grasping profits. You are no athlete."
- 165 Then, glaring from under his brows, Odysseus of the many designs  
replied:<sup>11</sup>  
"Stranger, you have not spoken well. You are like a man blinded by  
folly.  
So true it is that the gods do not give their graces to all men<sup>12</sup>  
alike — not build, and brains, and speaking-skill together.  
One man is slighter to look at, but the god
- 170 crowns his shape with words, and men gaze at him  
delighted, while he speaks on without a stumble,  
with honeyed modesty, and shines among the gathered people,

and when he walks the town they look on him as on a god.  
 Another again is like the immortals in beauty,  
 175 but no grace is set like a crown upon his words.  
 So with you: your looks are striking — not a god  
 could better them — but your mind is an empty thing.  
 You have stirred the heart in my breast  
 by speaking out of all measure. I am no novice at contests,  
 180 whatever you may say. I count myself among the first,  
 as long as I could trust my youth and these my hands.  
 Now I am held in misery and pain: I have endured much,  
 cutting through wars of men and the grinding waves.  
 But even so, for all my many evils, I will try your contests:  
 185 your word has bitten to the heart, and your speech has stung me to it."  
 He spoke, and cloak and all he sprang up, and seized a discus<sup>13</sup>  
 bigger than the rest, and thick — heavier by no small measure  
 than the ones the Phaeacians threw among themselves.  
 He spun and let it fly from his massive hand,  
 190 and the stone hummed; and down to the ground they cowered —  
 the Phaeacians of the long oars, men famed for ships —  
 under the rush of the stone. Past all their marks it flew,  
 running light off his hand. And Athena set the mark,  
 in the likeness of a man, and spoke a word, and named him:  
 195 "Even a blind man, stranger, could pick out your token,  
 groping — for it is not mixed in with the crowd of them  
 but far in front. Take heart, at least for this contest:  
 no Phaeacian will reach this, let alone throw beyond it."  
 So he spoke; and much-enduring noble Odysseus was glad,  
 200 rejoicing to find one true friend in the field.  
 And then with a lighter heart he spoke among the Phaeacians:  
 "Now match that, young men — and soon after, I think,  
 I will send another as far, or farther still.  
 As for the rest of you — whoever's heart and spirit bid him,  
 205 come out and be tried, since you have angered me so:  
 at boxing, wrestling, running — I refuse nothing —  
 any Phaeacian at all, except Laodamas himself.<sup>14</sup>  
 He is my host: who would fight the man who loves him?  
 Witless, worth nothing — that is the man

- 210 who challenges his own host to a bout of games  
in a strange country: he cuts himself off at the knees.  
But of the rest I refuse no one, scorn no one:  
I want to know you, and be tried face to face.  
I am not bad at anything — of all the contests men keep.
- 215 I know well how to handle the polished bow:<sup>15</sup>  
first of a company I would strike my man with an arrow  
in the enemy crowd, though comrades in plenty  
stood close beside me shooting at the men.  
Philoctetes alone outdid me with the bow
- 220 in the Trojans' country, whenever we Achaeans shot;  
but of all others I say I am far the best,  
all mortals now alive who eat their bread on earth.  
With the men of the past I will not seek to rival —  
not Heracles, not Eurytus of Oechalia,
- 225 who rived the very immortals with the bow.  
That is why great Eurytus died so soon — old age  
never found him in his halls: Apollo in his anger  
killed him, for daring to challenge him at the bow.  
And I hurl a spear as far as another man shoots an arrow.
- 230 Only at running I fear one of you might pass me —<sup>16</sup>  
one of the Phaeacians: I was broken past all decency  
among the many waves, with no steady keep aboard ship;  
and so the joints of my limbs are loosened."  
So he spoke, and they were all hushed in silence.
- 235 Alcinous alone made him this answer:  
"Stranger, nothing you say among us is said ungraciously:  
you are willing to show the prowess that attends you,  
in anger that this man stood up beside you in the field  
and taunted you — as no mortal would slight your prowess
- 240 who knew in his heart how to speak things fitly.  
But mark my word now, so that you may tell it  
to another hero, when in your own halls  
you feast beside your wife and your children  
and remember our prowess: what works Zeus grants
- 245 to us as well, unbroken from our fathers' days.  
For we are not flawless boxers, nor wrestlers:<sup>17</sup>

- but we run swift-footed, and we are best with ships,  
and always dear to us is the feast, the lyre, the dances,  
changes of clothing, hot baths, and beds.
- 250 Come then, dancers of the Phaeacians, all your best,  
and play — so the stranger may tell his own people,  
when he has come home, how far we surpass others  
in seamanship and running and dance and song.  
And let someone go quickly and fetch Demodocus
- 255 the clear-voiced lyre, which lies somewhere in our halls."  
So spoke godlike Alcinous; and a herald rose  
to bring the hollow lyre from the king's house.  
And chosen stewards stood up, nine in all,  
public men, who at the gatherings set each thing in order:
- 260 they smoothed a dancing-floor and widened a fine ring.  
And the herald came near, bearing the clear-voiced lyre  
for Demodocus; and he stepped to the middle, and around him stood  
boys in their first youth, skilled in the dance,  
and they beat the shining floor with their feet. And Odysseus
- 265 gazed at the flickerings of their feet, and marveled in his heart.<sup>18</sup>
- And the singer, striking the lyre, struck up a beautiful song<sup>19</sup>  
of the love of Ares and Aphrodite of the lovely crown:  
how first they lay together in the house of Hephaestus,  
in secret; and Ares gave her many gifts, and shamed the marriage-bed
- 270 of the lord Hephaestus. But to him came a messenger —  
Helios, the Sun, who had seen the two of them lying in love.  
And when Hephaestus heard the heart-stinging tale,  
he went his way to his forge, brooding evils deep in his heart,  
and set the great anvil on the block, and hammered out bonds
- 275 that could not break or slip, to hold them fast where they stood.  
And when he had made his snare, in his fury against Ares,  
he went his way to the chamber where his own bed stood,  
and around the bedposts he poured the bonds in a circle everywhere,  
and many hung down from above, from the roof-beam,
- 280 fine as spider-webs, which no one could so much as see —<sup>20</sup>  
not even the blessed gods: for they were made past all cunning.  
And when he had poured his whole snare around the bed,  
he made as if to go to Lemnos, that strong-founded city,

- which is dearest to him by far of all lands.
- 285 And Ares of the golden reins kept no blind watch:  
 he saw Hephaestus, famed for craft, going off,  
 and went his way to the house of famous Hephaestus,  
 hungry for the love of Cytherea of the lovely crown.  
 She was newly come from her father, the mighty son of Cronos,  
 290 and had just sat down; and he came inside the house  
 and clamped a hand on hers, and spoke a word, and named her:  
 "Come, love — to bed, and take our joy together lying close:  
 Hephaestus is no longer at home; by now, I think,  
 he is off to Lemnos, among the wild-tongued Sintians."
- 295 So he spoke; and welcome it seemed to her to lie with him.  
 So the two went to the bed and lay down; and around them poured  
 the artful bonds of Hephaestus of the many designs,  
 and they could not move a limb, could not lift themselves —  
 and then they knew it: there was no escaping now.
- 300 And near them came the famous god of the two strong arms,  
 turned back on his road before ever reaching Lemnos:  
 Helios had kept the watch for him, and told him the tale.  
 He went his way to his house, his heart heavy within him,  
 and stood in the gateway, and savage anger gripped him,  
 305 and he cried out terribly, and called to all the gods:  
 "Father Zeus, and you other blessed gods who are forever:  
 come here — see something for laughter, deeds past bearing —<sup>21</sup>  
 how Aphrodite, Zeus' daughter, forever  
 dishonors me for being lame, and loves that destroyer Ares  
 310 because he is handsome and straight of limb, while I  
 was born crippled. And whose fault is that? No one's  
 but my two parents' — I wish they had never bred me!  
 Look, see where the two of them sleep in love,  
 climbed into my own bed. And I watch, and it eats my heart.
- 315 Yet I do not think they will want to lie so one minute longer,  
 however much in love: soon enough the two of them will lose  
 their taste for sleeping. But the snare and the bond will hold them  
 until her father pays me back the bride-gifts, every one,<sup>22</sup>  
 all I handed over for his bitch-eyed girl —  
 320 because his daughter is beautiful, and cannot hold her heart."

- So he spoke, and the gods gathered to the bronze-floored house:  
 Poseidon came, who holds the earth; and the runner  
 Hermes came; and the lord who works from far, Apollo.  
 But the goddesses stayed at home, for shame, every one of them.<sup>23</sup>
- 325 So they stood in the gateway, the gods, the givers of good things,  
 and unquenchable laughter rose among the blessed gods  
 as they gazed on the craft of Hephaestus of the many designs.  
 And thus one would say, with a glance at his neighbor:  
 "Bad deeds do not prosper. The slow one catches the swift —"<sup>24</sup>
- 330 look, Hephaestus now, slow as he is, has taken Ares,  
 the swiftest of the gods who hold Olympus:  
 lame, and by craft. Now the adulterer's fine is owing."  
 So they spoke such things to one another.  
 But the lord Apollo, son of Zeus, said to Hermes:
- 335 "Hermes, son of Zeus, guide, giver of good things:  
 would you be willing, pressed hard in strong bonds,  
 to sleep in that bed beside golden Aphrodite?"  
 Then the guide, the slayer of Argus, answered him:  
 "If only that could be, lord Apollo of the far arrows!"<sup>25</sup>
- 340 Let three times as many bonds hold me, past all number,  
 and you gods look on — yes, and all the goddesses too:  
 I would still sleep beside golden Aphrodite."  
 So he spoke, and laughter rose among the deathless gods.  
 But Poseidon did not laugh; he kept pleading<sup>26</sup>
- 345 with Hephaestus, the famous worker, to set Ares free,  
 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to him:  
 "Release him. I promise you, before the deathless gods,  
 he shall pay all that is fair, as you demand."  
 Then the famous god of the two strong arms answered him:
- 350 "Do not ask this of me, Poseidon who hold the earth.  
 Worthless the pledges you take for worthless men.  
 How could I hold you bound before the deathless gods  
 if Ares slips both debt and bond and goes his way?"  
 Then Poseidon the earth-shaker answered him:
- 355 "Hephaestus, if Ares does slip his debt  
 and vanishes, I will pay you the fine myself."  
 Then the famous god of the two strong arms replied:

"It cannot be, and it would not be right, that I refuse your word."  
 So speaking, the strength of Hephaestus undid the bond.

- 360 And the two of them, loosed from the bond, strong as it was,  
 sprang up at once: he was gone to Thrace,  
 and she came to Cyprus, laughter-loving Aphrodite —  
 to Paphos, where her precinct is, and her altar fragrant with smoke.  
 There the Graces bathed her and rubbed her with oil,<sup>27</sup>  
 365 the immortal oil that blooms on the gods who are forever,  
 and dressed her in lovely clothing, a wonder to see.

This the famous singer sang; and Odysseus  
 took delight in his heart as he listened, and so did the others,<sup>28</sup>  
 the Phaeacians of the long oars, men famed for ships.

- 370 Then Alcinous told Halius and Laodamas  
 to dance alone, since no one could rival them.  
 And when they had taken in their hands the beautiful ball,  
 purple, which wise Polybus had made them,  
 one would bend far back and hurl it up toward the shadowy clouds,  
 375 and the other, leaping high off the ground, would catch it  
 lightly, with ease, before his feet came back to earth.  
 And when they had tried their skill at the ball thrown straight up,  
 then the two of them danced on the nourishing earth,  
 passing it swiftly back and forth; and the other young men  
 380 beat time, standing around the ring, and a great din went up.  
 And then noble Odysseus addressed Alcinous:  
 "Lord Alcinous, most renowned among all peoples,<sup>29</sup>  
 you promised your dancers were the best,  
 and here it stands accomplished. Awe takes me, looking at it."  
 385 So he spoke; and the sacred strength of Alcinous was glad,  
 and at once he spoke among the oar-loving Phaeacians:  
 "Hear me, leaders and counselors of the Phaeacians.  
 This stranger seems to me a man of clear-headed sense.  
 Come, let us give him a guest-gift, as is fitting.  
 390 Twelve glorious kings hold sway through this land<sup>30</sup>  
 as leaders, and I myself am the thirteenth:  
 let each of you bring a fresh-washed mantle and a tunic  
 and a talent of precious gold;

- and let us bring it all together at once, so that the stranger  
395 may take it in his hands and go to supper glad at heart.  
And let Euryalus make it up to him, man to man, with words  
and with a gift: for his word was not spoken in due measure."  
So he spoke, and they all approved it and urged it on,  
and each sent off a herald to bring his gifts.
- 400 And Euryalus answered him in turn, and said:  
"Lord Alcinous, most renowned among all peoples,  
I will make it up to the stranger, as you command.  
I will give him this sword, all bronze, with a hilt  
of silver on it, and a scabbard of fresh-sawn ivory  
405 turned round it: it will be worth much to him."  
So saying he set the silver-studded sword in his hands,  
and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to him:  
"Hail, father stranger. If some word was blurted out<sup>31</sup>  
too harsh, may the storm-winds snatch it up and carry it away.
- 410 And may the gods grant you to see your wife, and to come  
to your fatherland: for long, far from your own people, you have  
suffered pains."  
Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
"And to you, friend: hail, and warmly. May the gods give you fortune,  
and may you never feel the lack, hereafter, of this sword  
415 you have given me — you who made it up to me with words."  
He spoke, and slung the silver-studded sword about his shoulders.  
And the sun went down, and the famous gifts lay there before him.  
The lordly heralds carried them to the house of Alcinous,  
and the sons of blameless Alcinous received them  
420 and set the beautiful gifts before their honored mother.
- And the sacred strength of Alcinous led the way,  
and they came and sat down on the high seats.  
And then the strength of Alcinous said to Arete:  
"Bring here a glorious chest, wife — the best one —  
425 and set in it yourself a fresh-washed mantle and a tunic.  
And heat the bronze cauldron over the fire, and warm water,  
so that once he has bathed, and seen well laid together all  
the gifts the blameless Phaeacians have brought him here,  
he may take joy in the feast, and in hearing the singer's strain.



- 430 And I will give him this beautiful cup of mine,  
golden, so that remembering me all his days  
he may pour in his hall to Zeus and the other gods."  
So he spoke, and Arete told her slave-women  
to set a great three-legged cauldron on the fire with all speed.
- 435 They set the bath-cauldron on the blazing fire  
and poured water in, and fed the wood beneath till it flamed:  
the fire wrapped round the belly of the cauldron, and the water  
warmed.
- Meanwhile Arete brought out from her chamber a beautiful chest  
for the stranger, and laid the fine gifts in it,
- 440 the clothing and the gold the Phaeacians had given,  
and in with them she laid a mantle and a beautiful tunic,  
and lifting her voice she spoke winged words to him:  
"See to the lid yourself now, and tie the knot on it quickly,<sup>32</sup>  
for fear someone rob you on the voyage, when later on
- 445 you sleep your sweet sleep as the black ship carries you."  
And when much-enduring noble Odysseus heard it,  
at once he fitted the lid, and quickly tied upon it  
the intricate knot that the lady Circe once taught him.<sup>33</sup>  
And straightway the housekeeper called him to his bath,
- 450 to step in the tub; and his heart was glad at the sight  
of the hot water: for he had known no such tending<sup>34</sup>  
since he left the house of fair-haired Calypso —  
though while he was there, he was tended like a god without fail.  
And when the slave-women had bathed him and rubbed him with oil,
- 455 and thrown a beautiful cloak around him, and a tunic,  
he stepped from the bath and went to join the men at their wine.  
And Nausicaa, with her beauty from the gods,<sup>35</sup>  
stood by the pillar of the close-built roof,  
and marveled at Odysseus as her eyes took him in,
- 460 and lifting her voice she spoke winged words to him:  
"Farewell, stranger. And sometime, in your own fatherland,  
remember me — for to me first you owe the price of your life."  
Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
"Nausicaa, daughter of great-hearted Alcinous:
- 465 only may Zeus grant it so — the loud-thundering lord of Hera —

- that I go home and look upon my day of homecoming:  
 then even there I would pray to you as to a god,  
 always, all my days. For you saved my life, girl."<sup>36</sup>  
 He spoke, and went to his seat beside King Alcinous.
- 470 And already they were serving portions and mixing the wine,  
 and the herald came near, leading the trusted singer,  
 Demodocus, honored among the people, and seated him  
 in the middle of the feasters, leaning him on a tall pillar.  
 And then Odysseus of the many designs called the herald —
- 475 cutting off a slice of the chine, with more left over,  
 of the white-tusked hog, rich fat along it either side:  
 "Herald — here, take this cut of meat to Demodocus,  
 so he may eat; and I will pay my respects to him, for all my grief.  
 For among all men upon the earth, singers<sup>37</sup>
- 480 have their share of honor and reverence, because the Muse  
 has taught them her paths, and loves the tribe of singers."  
 So he spoke, and the herald carried it and set it in the hands  
 of the hero Demodocus; and he received it, and his heart was glad.  
 And their hands went out to the good things spread before them.
- 485 But when they had put away desire for food and drink,  
 then Odysseus of the many designs said to Demodocus:  
 "Demodocus, I praise you beyond all mortal men.  
 Either the Muse taught you, Zeus' daughter, or Apollo:  
 for all in due order you sing the fate of the Achaeans —
- 490 all they did and suffered, all the Achaeans' labors —  
 as if you had been there yourself, or heard it from one who was."<sup>38</sup>  
 But come now, change your path: sing the making of the horse  
 of wood, which Epeius built, and Athena with him —  
 the snare that noble Odysseus brought up into the citadel,
- 495 filled with the men who sacked Ilium.  
 If you tell me this tale too in its due measure,  
 then I will proclaim at once to all mankind<sup>39</sup>  
 how the god of his grace has given you divine song."  
 So he spoke; and the singer, stirred by the god, began, and made the  
 song appear,<sup>40</sup>
- 500 taking it up where the Argives had boarded their well-benched ships  
 and were sailing away, after casting fire on their camp,

- while those others, around famous Odysseus, already  
 sat in the Trojans' gathering-place, hidden inside the horse:  
 for the Trojans themselves had dragged it up into the citadel.  
 505 So it stood there, and they talked on and on, undecided,  
 sitting around it; and three ways the counsel pleased them:  
 to split the hollow timber with the pitiless bronze,  
 or drag it to the height and hurl it down the rocks,  
 or leave it standing, a great offering to appease the gods —  
 510 and that was the way it was to end at last:  
 for it was their portion to perish when the city took within it  
 the great horse of wood, where all the best of the Argives  
 sat carrying death and doom to the Trojans.  
 And he sang how the sons of the Achaeans sacked the city,  
 515 pouring from the horse, leaving their hollow ambush;  
 he sang how they ravaged the steep city, each man his own way,  
 and how Odysseus went, like Ares himself, to the house  
 of Deiphobus, with godlike Menelaus beside him;  
 and there, he sang, he dared the grimmest fight of all —  
 520 and conquered, in the end, through great-hearted Athena.
- This the famous singer sang. And Odysseus  
 melted: the tears from under his eyelids wet his cheeks.  
 As a woman weeps, fallen on the body of her dear husband<sup>41</sup>  
 who has gone down before his city and his people,  
 525 warding the pitiless day from his town and his children:  
 she sees him dying, gasping his last,  
 and pours herself around him with a high thin cry; and behind her  
 the spearmen, beating her back and shoulders with their spears,  
 lead her away into slavery, to labor and misery,  
 530 and her cheeks are wasted with a grief most pitiful:  
 so pitiful were the tears Odysseus let fall from under his brows.  
 From all the others he hid the tears he shed;  
 Alcinous alone remarked him and noticed,  
 sitting beside him, and heard his heavy groaning.  
 535 At once he spoke among the oar-loving Phaeacians:  
 "Hear me, leaders and counselors of the Phaeacians —  
 and let Demodocus still his clear-voiced lyre now:  
 for what he sings does not give joy to all alike.

- Since the hour we supped, and the godlike singer rose,  
 540 since then the stranger has never ceased  
 his grieving lament. Great sorrow, surely, has fenced his heart around.  
 Come, let the singer hold, so that we may all take pleasure  
 alike, hosts and guest together: far better so.  
 For all this has been made ready for our honored guest —  
 545 his sending, and the friendly gifts we give him in our love.  
 As dear as a brother is the stranger and the suppliant<sup>42</sup>  
 to any man whose wits have even a little reach.  
 So do not hide now, behind shrewd calculations,  
 whatever I ask you. To speak out is the fairer way.  
 550 Tell the name they call you there by, your mother and your father<sup>43</sup>  
 and the others, in the town and dwelling round about.  
 For no one among mankind is altogether nameless,  
 base man or noble, once he has come into the world:  
 parents lay a name on every child they bear.  
 555 And tell me your land, your people, and your city,  
 so that our ships may carry you there, plotting the course by thought:<sup>44</sup>  
 for the Phaeacians have no steersmen,  
 no steering-oars at all, such as other ships carry:  
 the ships themselves know the thoughts and minds of men,  
 560 and know the cities and rich fields of every  
 people, and swiftest of all things cross the gulf of the salt sea  
 wrapped in mist and cloud; and never do they fear  
 harm or wreck on any crossing.  
 Yet this I once heard my father Nausithous<sup>45</sup>  
 565 say: he would tell us that Poseidon looked on us with anger  
 because we are safe escorts of all men without distinction;  
 and he said that one day, as a well-made ship of the Phaeacian men  
 came home over the misted sea from such a sending,  
 the god would smash it, and pile a great mountain round our city.  
 570 So the old man said. And these things the god may accomplish,  
 or may leave unaccomplished, as pleases his own heart.  
 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:  
 where have you wandered? To what countries of men  
 have you come — the peoples, the cities well-lived-in —  
 575 both the harsh among them, the savage and unjust,<sup>46</sup>

and the kind to strangers, whose hearts fear the gods?  
 And tell why you weep, and mourn within your heart,  
 when you hear the fate of the Argive Danaans and of Ilium.  
 That fate the gods made; they spun that destruction for men,<sup>47</sup>  
 580 so that there might be a song for those still to come.  
 Did some kinsman of yours die before Ilium —  
 a good man, a wife's father, a daughter's husband? — those who stand  
 closest after our own blood and stock;  
 or perhaps a companion, a man dear to your heart,  
 585 a good man? For no less than a brother<sup>48</sup>  
 is a companion who is clear-headed and true."

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 8

- 1 l. 3 *πολίπορθος*, "sacker of cities" — Odysseus' great war-epithet, used here for the first time in the poem, on the very morning that will end with him weeping at a song of the sack. The epithet and the widow simile (523–531) are this book's two poles, and the poem sets them up in its third line.
- 2 l. 35 Fifty-two picked oarsmen — two beyond the poem's standard crew of fifty. Phaeacian numbers are always crisp: twelve kings and a thirteenth, nine stewards, fifty-two rowers; fairyland is beautifully administered.
- 3 l. 44 Demodocus — the name means roughly "received by the people" (or "honored by the people"), a singer named for his audience. Alcinous' description sets the terms the book will test: the god gave him song "to delight men however his heart is stirred" — but this evening, what delights the hall will twice devastate the guest.
- 4 l. 63 "She took away his eyes, and gave him sweet song": the Muse's double gift, stated with terrifying evenness — good and evil in one clause each. Antiquity read the blind singer of Scheria as Homer's self-portrait (the blind bard of Chios in the *Hymn to Apollo* reinforced it). Whatever the truth, the poem here prices poetry: it costs the eyes; it buys the world.
- 5 l. 75 The quarrel of Odysseus and Achilles at a feast of the gods is attested nowhere else in Greek literature — either a lost epic episode or (many suspect) invented for this scene: a song about *the best of the Achaeans* quarreling, brain against brawn, is precisely calibrated to this audience of one. Agamemnon "rejoiced" because Delphi had told him the war would end when the best fell out — the oracle-logic of a lost tradition, delivered in four lines as if everyone knew it.
- 6 l. 83 The cloak-ritual of grief (83–92), in iterative verbs: song, weep, pause, wipe, pour, song again, weep again. He mourns in installments, timed to the singer's breath. And the poem's tact is Alcinous': he alone notices, and rather than ask, he invents an excuse to change the entertainment. Book-length courtesy: the question waits until 577.
- 7 l. 111 The catalogue of young Phaeacians is a roster of sea-puns: Acroneus ("Topship"), Ocyalus ("Swiftsea"), Elatreus ("Rower"), Nauteus ("Shipman"), Prymneus ("Sternman"), Anchialus ("Nearsea"), Eretmeus ("Oarsman"), Ponteus ("Seaman"), Proreus ("Prowman"), Anabesineus ("Ship-boarder"), Amphialus son of Polyneus son of Tecton ("Seagirt, son of Manyships, son of Shipwright") — and Euryalus ("Broadsea"). A whole society named from its element, the way Nausicaa and Nausithous are. I transliterate and let the note carry the joke.
- 8 l. 124 Distance measured by "the width of a mule-team's furrow in fallow ground" — the plowman's unit, like the shout-measure (5.400) and the meal-clock. Even Phaeacian athletics are surveyed in farm-lengths.
- 9 l. 147 "No greater fame for a man, while he lives, than what he achieves with his own feet and hands" — the athletic creed of the young, delivered to the man whose fame rests on

neither. Laodamas means it kindly; the poem means it as the book's question: what is the glory of a man whose instrument is his mind?

- 10 l. 159 Euryalus' insult reaches for the lowest available identity: a cargo-master "with a memory for freight and an eye on his grasping profits." The aristocratic contempt for trade is period-real (and the poem's Phoenicians will carry it), but the barb's irony is exquisite: of all the identities Odysseus has worn, profit-trader is the one he never claims — and the accusation of *remembering cargo* is aimed at the man whose whole cargo is memory.
- 11 l. 165 ὑπόδρα ἰδών — the dark glare from under the brows: the *Iliad*'s battlefield formula, here imported to a garden party. The Trojan-war register switches on for exactly one speech and one throw, then switches off. The Phaeacians have never seen it before; the audience has.
- 12 l. 167 The gifts-of-the-gods speech (167–177): no man gets everything — build, brains, eloquence; there is the plain man whose words the god "crowns with shape" until the town watches him walk like a god, and the beauty with nothing behind the face. It is a self-portrait from the tradition (Antenor in *Iliad* 3.216ff. describes exactly this Odysseus: unimpressive until the words come like winter snow), delivered as general wisdom to a beautiful fool.
- 13 l. 186 "Cloak and all" — he doesn't trouble to strip, and takes the *heavier* discus. The throw's aftermath is pure sound and posture: the stone hums, a nation of sailors ducks. One motion answers the whole afternoon of games.
- 14 l. 207 The host-exemption: he will meet anyone except Laodamas — "he is my host: who would fight the man who loves him?" A rule of *xenia* stated as though obvious, in a poem heading toward a hall where a hundred guests have made war on their host for three years.
- 15 l. 215 The bow-boast, with genealogy: better than all living men, second only to Philoctetes at Troy, and *deliberately* not to be measured against Heracles and Eurytus, who bent their bows against gods — a rivalry that killed Eurytus, cut down by angry Apollo. The modesty is theology, and the résumé is a plant: the poem's audience knows an archery contest is coming (Book 21), and knows the bow at home in Ithaca came from Eurytus' own son Iphitus. The skill announced here on a holiday field will next appear over a threshold heaped with dead men.
- 16 l. 230 The one conceded weakness — his legs, "loosened" by the sea. The confession is precise and bodily: this hero's honesty about his own diminishment is part of the same realism as the belly speech (7.215ff.).
- 17 l. 246 Alcinous' concession is the most disarming self-description in epic: "we are not flawless boxers... dear to us is the feast, the lyre, the dances, changes of clothing, hot baths, and beds." A civilization declares comfort its excellence, without shame. The line drew moralists' fire for centuries (Horace's "youths of Alcinous"), but the poem is not sneering: this softness will send Odysseus home; the hard men in Ithaca's hall will not.
- 18 l. 265 μαρμαρυγᾶς — the "flickerings" of the dancers' feet: light-off-water shimmer applied to footwork. The connoisseur of every craft "marvels in his heart" — the same

verb the poem gives him for palaces and harbors. Odysseus is the Odyssey's best audience.

- 19 l. 266 The Song of Ares and Aphrodite (266–366): a full comic epyllion at the poem's center. Its architecture mirrors the Odyssey's own: the husband deficient in glamour but supreme in craft; the glamorous intruder in his bed; the trap prepared in secret and sprung in public; the demand for restitution. The lame smith catches the swiftest of gods — and the moral the gods themselves draw (329) is "the slow one catches the swift": the Odyssey's whole plot, stated as a proverb inside its own entertainment. That this adultery-farce is sung to the husband of besieged Penelope — and that he *delights* in it (367–368) — is the poem at its most self-aware: he is hearing his own story told as a comedy where the craftsman wins.
- 20 l. 280 The bonds "fine as spider-webs, which no one could so much as see — not even the blessed gods": the craftsman's masterpiece is invisibility, the snare indistinguishable from the household it protects. Weaving imagery again — the trap for the lovers is spun, like Penelope's web and every plot in this poem.
- 21 l. 307 "Come here — see something for laughter, deeds past bearing": Hephaestus summons an audience for his own humiliation, and the Greek yokes the two words (γελαστά... οὐκ ἐπεικτά) without resolving them. His speech swings from bitterness about his lameness to the wish his parents had never bred him — real pain inside the farce, which is what keeps the farce from weightlessness.
- 22 l. 318 The economics of the exposure: the bonds hold "until her father pays back the bride-gifts." Adultery is actionable property law even on Olympus — the μοιχάγρια, "the adulterer's fine" (332), is a real archaic institution. The comedy runs on a genuine legal chassis.
- 23 l. 324 "The goddesses stayed at home, for shame, every one of them" — one line establishing the gendered economy of spectatorship: the male gods gather and laugh; the goddesses may not even look. The poem notices exactly who is permitted to enjoy whose disgrace.
- 24 l. 329 "Bad deeds do not prosper. The slow one catches the swift." The gods' own moral, drawn amid their laughter — and the Odyssey's thesis. Every slow thing in this poem catches its swift thing: the lame smith, the old beggar, the waiting wife, the twenty-year homecoming.
- 25 l. 339 Hermes' answer — triple the bonds, all the goddesses watching, "I would still sleep beside golden Aphrodite" — is the bawdiest joke in Homer, and it *lands*: "laughter rose among the deathless gods." Xenophanes and Plato would later cite this whole song as what poets must not say about gods; the poem's answer is already in the text — the gods themselves find it funny.
- 26 l. 344 Poseidon does not laugh. He stands surety for the adulterer — the enforcer of debts, the guarantor of order among gods. The irony goes unspoken: the god acting as bond for a caught transgressor is the same god whose grudge against one mortal man the whole poem must outlast.



- 27 l. 364 Aphrodite's exit through Paphos — bathed by the Graces, oiled with "the immortal oil that blooms on the gods," dressed as "a wonder to see." No punishment, no shame that adheres: she leaves the farce restored to full glory. The poem lets beauty be beauty even in disgrace — and the bath-and-oil-and-clothing formula is the same one mortals get; the difference is only that hers ends in Paphos.
- 28 l. 367 "Odysseus took delight in his heart as he listened." The first Troy song made him weep under his cloak; the adultery-comedy delights him. He is moved by his own past, entertained by his own future — and the poem, with perfect economy, does not gloss the difference.
- 29 l. 382 "Lord Alcinous, most renowned among all peoples" — a new fixed vocative, and a plant: it is with this exact line that Odysseus will open the greatest speech of the poem, the beginning of his own tale, at 9.2.
- 30 l. 390 Twelve kings and Alcinous the thirteenth: the Phaeacian constitution in a line and a half. Thirteen basileis in council, one presiding — closer to Ithaca's contested plural kingship (1.394–396) than to any absolute monarchy; the fairyland polity is recognizably Greek.
- 31 l. 408 Euryalus' apology is a small masterpiece of the form: "may the storm-winds snatch it up and carry it away" — the insult reclassified as wind-words (the ἀνεμώλια family, 4.837). And his blessing — "may the gods grant you to see your wife" — makes him the *first person on Scheria to mention a wife for Odysseus*. The man who insulted him is the one who guesses the shape of his heart. Odysseus' acceptance (413–415) returns grace for grace, with one glinting condition: may you never *miss* this sword — i.e., may you never need what you gave away.
- 32 l. 443 Arete's send-off gift is advice: knot the chest yourself, "for fear someone rob you on the voyage" while you sleep. Even in fairyland the queen assumes crews pilfer. Her practicality is the counterweight to her husband's magic-ship raptures thirty lines later — between the two of them, the poem gets both Phaeacias on record.
- 33 l. 448 "The intricate knot that the lady Circe once taught him" — Circe, named for the first time in the poem, casually, as the source of a skill, well before she enters the tale Odysseus is about to tell. The poem trusts its audience to know the story already; the effect for them is not confusion but a shiver of prolepsis — and a hint that his year with her furnished practical arts as well as delays.
- 34 l. 450 His pleasure in the hot bath is dated precisely: no such tending "since he left the house of fair-haired Calypso — though while he was there, he was tended like a god without fail." The narrator's small honesty: captivity included excellent care. The poem never cheapens what he refused; that is why the refusal weighs.
- 35 l. 457 Nausicaa's farewell (457–462): she has slipped in to stand "by the pillar of the close-built roof" — the same doorway-pillar posture as Penelope's public appearances (1.333) — for twelve lines and two sentences: *Farewell; remember me; you owe me your life*. ζῳάγρια, "the price of your life," is the word for ransom paid by a spared captive: she names their whole story in a single legal metaphor, without one word of what might have been.

- 36 l. 468 His answer grants her the highest thing in his gift: "even there I would pray to you as to a god, always, all my days" — cult status in his homeland, the exact fulfillment of her beach-daydream transposed into the only register now possible. And the last word is *κούρη* — "girl": tender, truthful, final. The romance that never was closes in perfect form, and neither of them says one word more than honor allows.
- 37 l. 479 "Among all men upon the earth, singers have their share of honor and reverence, because the Muse has taught them her paths" — the sacker of cities serving the best cut of pork to the man whose song just flayed him. Respect for the singer is respect for the truth of what the song did to him; the gesture is the argument.
- 38 l. 491 "As if you had been there yourself, or heard it from one who was": the Homeric standard of poetic truth — eyewitness fidelity, at one remove at most. Odysseus certifies the singer's accuracy from the only position that can: he was there. The poem is having its own veracity notarized by its hero.
- 39 l. 497 The commission's payment: sing it rightly "and I will proclaim at once to all mankind" that your song is divine. *Kleos* for *kleos* — the hero offers the singer exactly the currency singers offer heroes. The economy of fame runs both directions through this scene, one professional to another.
- 40 l. 499 "Stirred by the god, he began, and made the song appear" — *φαῖνε δ' ἀοιδήν*: song as manifestation, made visible like something summoned. The summary that follows (500–520) is our earliest connected account of the wooden horse — three fates debated (axe, cliff, offering), Troy's own citizens dragging the ambush inside — compressed with the confidence of a poet whose audience knows every beat.
- 41 l. 523 The widow simile — the moral summit of the book, perhaps of the poem. Odysseus weeps as a woman weeping over her husband fallen defending his city, who is beaten from his body with spear-butts and led into slavery, "to labor and misery." The sacker of cities (line 3) hears his triumph sung and grieves as its victim: the simile forces the victor through the vanquished's exact experience — the widow it describes is a woman from a city such as *he* sacked. Nothing else in archaic literature crosses that line. The poem does not comment; it just holds the two mirrors — *πτολίπορθος* and the widow — facing each other, with the man between them weeping.
- 42 l. 546 "As dear as a brother is the stranger and the suppliant / to any man whose wits have even a little reach" — Alcinous' summa of guest-ethics, quietly seconding his daughter's beach-creed (6.207–208) and Echeneus' hearth-doctrine (7.165). Three generations of Phaeacians have now stated the law the suitors break nightly.
- 43 l. 550 The name-demand: "no one among mankind is altogether nameless... parents lay a name on every child they bear." Identity in this poem is not private property but a social fact bestowed at birth — which is why withholding a name (as Odysseus has for two days) is such a charged act, and why the alias he will build in the Cyclops' cave (Nobody, *οὔτις*) is a violation of the order of things clever enough to shake it. The book ends with the question that Book 9 answers in the poem's most famous self-naming.
- 44 l. 556 The thought-steered ships (556–563): no steersmen, no rudders; the ships "know the thoughts and minds of men," know every city and field, and cross the sea wrapped in mist, unwreckable. Navigation without pilotage — the final Phaeacian marvel, and the

fairy-tale inversion of everything Books 5 and 12 cost. Note the shadow inside the boast: "never do they fear harm" is spoken by a man about to recall a prophecy of exactly that harm.

- 45 l. 564 Nausithous' prophecy: Poseidon angered "because we are safe escorts of all men without distinction" — universal kindness itself is the offense — and one day a returning ship smashed, a mountain piled round the city. Alcinous reports his own doom and shrugs: "the god may accomplish it, or leave it unaccomplished" (570–571). The fatalism of the blessed. The poem will collect this debt at 13.159ff., with the same words, on the day Odysseus lands home.
- 46 l. 575 The wandering question borrows its categories from the arrival-formula (6.120–121) — one word swapped, "harsh" (χαλεποί) for "overweening" (ὕβρισται): the harsh, savage, unjust versus the stranger-kind and god-fearing. Alcinous unknowingly hands Odysseus the organizing rubric of the next four books: the apologoi are, among everything else, a survey of exactly that taxonomy, port by port.
- 47 l. 579 "That fate the gods made; they spun that destruction for men, so that there might be a song for those still to come." The deepest sentence in the book: suffering is the raw material of song, and song is the *purpose* the gods had in weaving the suffering. Helen says nearly the same in the *Iliad* (6.357–358). It is the poem's own theodicy of art — offered here as consolation to a weeping man who is, though his host does not know it, the song's subject, sitting in the audience of his own destruction.
- 48 l. 585 The book's last thought before the great question: a true companion "is no less than a brother." Alcinous guesses at the guest's grief — kinsman? friend? — and his final guess lands nearest: what Odysseus lost at Troy and after was companions, all of them. The question mark hangs over the night; Book 9 opens with the answer the whole poem has withheld: *I am Odysseus, son of Laertes*.



## Odyssey — Book 9

*"I am Odysseus": the Cicones, the Lotus-eaters, and the Cyclops.*

- Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 "Lord Alcinous, most renowned among all peoples,<sup>1</sup>  
 truly it is a fine thing to hear a singer  
 such as this man is, with a voice like the gods'.
- 5 For I say there is no accomplishment more graceful<sup>2</sup>  
 than when joy holds a whole people,  
 and feasters up and down the hall sit listening to a singer,  
 seated in order, and beside them the tables are loaded  
 with bread and meats, and the cupbearer draws wine  
 10 from the bowl and carries it round and fills the cups:  
 this seems to my mind the fairest thing there is.  
 But your heart has turned to asking after my grievous  
 cares — so that I may mourn and groan the more.  
 What first, then, what last shall I tell through?
- 15 For the gods of heaven have given me sorrows past counting.  
 Now first I will tell my name, so that you too  
 may know it — and I hereafter, if I escape the pitiless day,  
 may be your guest-friend, though my home is far away.  
 I am Odysseus, son of Laertes — known to all mankind<sup>3</sup>
- 20 for my cunning designs; and my fame has reached heaven.  
 My home is Ithaca, clear-skied under its mountain,  
 Neriton, tall in its shivering leaves; and around it islands  
 lie in a cluster, close to one another —  
 Dulichium and Same and wooded Zacynthus.
- 25 Ithaca itself lies low, farthest out in the sea  
 toward the dark of sunset — the rest face dawn and the sun —  
 rough ground, but a good nurse of men. I cannot<sup>4</sup>  
 see any sweeter sight, for my part, than a man's own country.  
 The queenly goddess Calypso would have kept me there beside her<sup>5</sup>
- 30 in her hollow caves, hungry to make me her husband,  
 and so, in the same way, Circe detained me in her halls,  
 the guileful lady of Aeaea, hungry to make me her husband:

but they never once persuaded the heart in my breast.

So true it is that nothing is sweeter than a man's own country

- 35 and his own parents, even if he lives in a rich house  
far away in a strange land, cut off from his parents.

But come — let me tell you also my journey home, and all its cares,  
which Zeus laid on me on the way from Troy.

From Ilium the wind bore me to the Cicones —<sup>6</sup>

- 40 to Ismarus. There I sacked the city and destroyed the men;  
and out of the city we took their wives and much substance  
and divided all, so that no man might go cheated of his share by me.  
Then, you may be sure, I ordered a quick-footed retreat —  
and they, the great fools, would not obey.<sup>7</sup>

- 45 There and then much wine was being drunk, and many sheep  
they slaughtered along the shore, and shambling crook-horned cattle;  
and meanwhile Cicones went crying to Cicones,  
their neighbors inland — more of them, and better men,  
skilled at fighting men from chariots

- 50 and, where need was, on foot.

They came, then, thick as leaves and flowers come in their season,  
in the morning mist. Then an evil doom of Zeus stood by us,  
luckless men, to load us with pains in plenty.

They set their battle-line and fought by the fast ships,

- 55 and each side pelted each with bronze-tipped spears.

As long as it was morning, and the sacred day still growing,  
so long we stood them off and held our ground, though they were  
more;

but when the sun turned over toward unyoking-time,<sup>8</sup>  
then the Cicones broke the Achaeans, and mastered them.

- 60 Six from each ship, six strong-greaved companions  
were killed; the rest of us fled from death and doom.

From there we sailed on further, grieved at heart,<sup>9</sup>  
glad to be out of death, having lost our dear companions.

But my curved ships would not go forward

- 65 before we had called three times on each of those poor companions<sup>10</sup>  
who died on the plain, cut down by the Cicones.

And Zeus who gathers the clouds roused the North Wind against the ships

in a howling squall, and covered land and sea alike  
with cloud; and night rose up out of heaven.

70 The ships were swept along slantwise, their sails  
ripped into three and four rags by the strength of the wind.

We lowered them into the hulls, in terror of death,  
and rowed the ships hard in toward the shore.

There for two nights and two days without a break

75 we lay, eating our hearts with weariness and pain together.

But when Dawn of the lovely braids brought the third day round,  
we set up the masts and hauled the white sails open  
and sat, and the wind and the steersmen held them on course.

And now I would have come unharmed to my own country,

80 but the wave and the current, as I rounded Malea,<sup>11</sup>

and the North Wind beat me off course and drove me wide of Cythera.

From there for nine days I was carried by ruinous winds  
across the fish-filled sea; and on the tenth we stepped ashore  
in the land of the Lotus-eaters, who eat a flower for food.<sup>12</sup>

85 There we set foot on the mainland and drew water,  
and the companions quickly took their meal beside the fast ships.

And when we had tasted food and drink,

then I sent companions ahead to learn

what men they were who ate bread upon this earth:

90 two men I chose, and sent a third with them as herald.

They went their way at once, and fell in with the Lotus-eater men;

and the Lotus-eaters had no thought of killing

our companions — but they gave them lotus to taste.

And whoever of them ate the honey-sweet fruit of the lotus<sup>13</sup>

95 no longer wished to bring back word or to return:

there they wanted to stay, among the Lotus-eater men,

browsing the lotus, and to forget their homecoming.

These men I forced back weeping to the ships,

dragged them under the benches of the hollow ships and bound them,

100 and I ordered the rest of my trusted companions

to hurry and board the fast ships —

for fear some other might eat of the lotus and forget his homecoming.

And they came aboard at once and took their places at the oarlocks,  
and sitting in order they struck the gray salt water with their oars.

- 105 From there we sailed on further, grieved at heart.  
And we came to the land of the Cyclopes — the overweening,<sup>14</sup>  
the lawless — who, trusting in the deathless gods,  
plant no crop with their hands, and plow nothing;  
everything springs up for them unsown, unplowed,  
110 wheat and barley, and vines that carry  
wine in their heavy clusters, and Zeus' rain swells it for them.  
They have no counsel-bearing assemblies, no established laws,  
but live on the crests of the high mountains  
in hollow caves, and each man lays down the law  
115 to his own wives and children — and they care nothing for one another.

- Now a scrubby island stretches outside the harbor there,<sup>15</sup>  
neither close in to the Cyclopes' land nor far out,  
wooded; and on it goats past counting breed,  
wild goats: no tread of men scares them away,  
120 no hunters push through to it, men who suffer  
hard days in the timber, working the mountain crests;  
it is held by no flocks and no plowed fields,  
but unsown and unplowed all its days  
the island is widowed of men, and feeds its bleating goats.  
125 For the Cyclopes have no red-cheeked ships,  
and no shipwrights among them who might labor out  
well-benched vessels to accomplish every need,  
crossing to the cities of the world, the way men  
so often traverse the sea in ships to one another:  
130 such craftsmen would have made the island a fair settlement too.  
For it is not a bad island at all: it would bear every crop in season.  
There are meadows in it along the shores of the gray salt water,  
soft, well-watered; vines there would never die;  
there is level plowland, and a deep standing harvest always  
135 ready for the scythe in season, for the soil beneath is rich.  
And there is a harbor with safe anchorage, where there is no need of  
mooring-line —  
no anchor-stones to throw, no stern-cables to make fast:



- you beach her, and wait until the sailors'  
 hearts prompt them, and the breezes blow.
- 140 And at the harbor's head runs shining water,  
 a spring under a cave, with black poplars growing round it.  
 There we sailed in — and some god was guiding us —  
 through the dead of night, with nothing to be seen ahead:  
 a fog lay thick around the ships, and the moon
- 145 showed nothing from heaven, shut in by clouds.  
 No one's eyes made out that island then,  
 nor did we see the long combers rolling in against the shore  
 before the well-benched ships ran up the beach.  
 And with the ships beached, we took down all the sails
- 150 and stepped out ourselves onto the surf-line of the sea,  
 and there we dropped asleep, and waited for shining Dawn.
- When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,  
 we walked that island marveling, all through it.  
 And the nymphs, daughters of aegis-bearing Zeus, started
- 155 the mountain goats, so my companions might have their meal.  
 At once we fetched our curved bows and long-socketed goat-spears  
 out of the ships, and forming in three bands  
 we shot; and quickly the god gave us game to our hearts' content.  
 Twelve ships followed with me, and to each
- 160 nine goats fell by lot; for me alone they picked out ten.  
 So then all day long till the setting of the sun  
 we sat feasting on meat past counting and sweet wine.  
 For the red wine was not yet spent from out our ships:  
 there was still some left, for each crew had drawn off much
- 165 in two-handled jars when we took the Cicones' holy citadel.  
 And we looked across at the land of the Cyclopes, who were near:  
 smoke, and voices — theirs, and their sheep's and goats'.<sup>16</sup>  
 And when the sun went down and the dusk came on,  
 then we lay down to sleep on the surf-line of the sea.
- 170 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,  
 then I called an assembly, and spoke among them all:  
 'The rest of you stay here now, my trusted companions,  
 while I with my own ship and my own crew  
 go and make trial of those men over there — what they are:

175 whether violent, savage, without justice,<sup>17</sup>  
 or kind to strangers, with hearts that fear the gods.'  
 So speaking I went aboard, and ordered my companions  
 to board in their turn and loose the stern-cables.  
 And they came aboard at once and took their places at the oarlocks,  
 180 and sitting in order they struck the gray salt water with their oars.  
 But when we reached the place — it was not far —  
 there on the land's edge, close by the sea, we saw a cave,  
 high, overhung with laurels. There many  
 flocks — sheep and goats — were penned at night; around it a yard  
 185 ran high-built, of stones set deep in the earth,  
 and tall pines, and oaks with lofty crowns.  
 And there a man slept, a monster of a man, who shepherded<sup>18</sup>  
 his flocks alone and far apart; he kept no company  
 with others, but held aloof, and his heart knew no law.  
 190 For he was built a monstrous wonder — nothing like  
 a man who eats bread, but like a wooded crag  
 of the high mountains, standing clear of all the rest.

Then I ordered the rest of my trusted companions  
 to stay there by the ship and guard the ship,  
 195 while I picked the twelve best of my companions  
 and went. And I took a goatskin of dark wine,  
 sweet wine, that Maron gave me, Euanthes' son,<sup>19</sup>  
 the priest of Apollo, the god who watches over Ismarus —  
 because we had protected him, with his child and his wife,  
 200 out of reverence: for he lived in the wooded grove  
 of Phoebus Apollo. And he gave me shining gifts:  
 he gave me seven talents of well-wrought gold,  
 and he gave me a mixing-bowl all of silver, and then  
 wine, drawn off in two-handled jars, twelve in all,  
 205 sweet and unmixed, a drink for gods. Not one  
 of the slaves or handmaids in his house knew of it —  
 only himself and his dear wife, and one housekeeper only.  
 Whenever they drank that honey-sweet red wine,  
 he would fill one cup and pour it into twenty measures  
 210 of water, and a sweet smell would rise from the bowl,  
 a marvel: no joy then in holding back.

Of this I filled a great skin and brought it, and provisions too  
 in a sack: for my proud heart had a foreboding, even then,  
 that a man would come against me clothed in great strength,  
 215 a savage, knowing nothing of judgments or of laws.

Quickly we came to the cave, and did not find him  
 within: he was herding his fat flocks in the pasture.  
 We went into the cave and stared in wonder at everything:  
 crates sagging with cheeses; pens crowded<sup>20</sup>  
 220 with lambs and kids — each sort folded separately,  
 the firstlings apart, apart the middle-born,  
 apart again the newborn; and every vessel swimming with whey,  
 the pails and bowls, all made by hand, that he milked into.  
 There first my companions begged me, pleading:  
 225 take some cheeses and go back; then quickly,  
 driving the kids and lambs out of their pens  
 down to the fast ship, sail away over the salt water.  
 But I would not listen — it would have been far better —<sup>21</sup>  
 not until I saw him, and whether he would give me guest-gifts.  
 230 And his appearing was to be no joy to my companions.

We lit a fire there and made an offering, and helped ourselves  
 to cheeses, and ate, and sat inside waiting for him,  
 until he came back herding. He carried a huge weight  
 of dry wood, to serve him at supper-time,  
 235 and flung it down inside the cave with a crash;  
 and we in terror shrank away into the cave's far corner.  
 He drove his fat flocks into the wide cavern —  
 all those he milked; the males he left outside,  
 the rams and he-goats, out in the deep yard.  
 240 Then he lifted high and set in place a huge door-stone,  
 a massive thing: twenty-two carts, good ones,<sup>22</sup>  
 four-wheeled, could not have levered it off the ground —  
 such a towering cliff of rock he set in the doorway.  
 Then, sitting, he milked the ewes and bleating goats,  
 245 all in due order, and set the young under each.  
 And straightway he curdled half the white milk  
 and gathered it and stored it in the plaited baskets,

- and half he stood in vessels, so it might be there  
for him to take and drink, and serve him at supper-time.
- 250 And when at last he had hurried through his work,  
then he lit the fire — and saw us, and asked:  
'Strangers, who are you? From where do you sail the watery ways?'<sup>23</sup>  
Is it on some business — or do you rove at random,  
the way sea-raiders do, who wander  
255 staking their own lives, bearing evil to strangers?'  
So he spoke, and our own hearts broke within us  
in terror of the deep voice and the monster himself.  
Even so I answered him, and said:  
'We are Achaeans, blown off course from Troy  
260 by every wind there is, across the great gulf of the sea,  
making for home — but by other routes, other roads  
we came: so Zeus, I suppose, chose to devise it.  
We declare ourselves the people of Agamemnon, Atreus' son,<sup>24</sup>  
whose fame is now the greatest thing under heaven,  
265 so vast the city he sacked, so many the peoples  
he destroyed. But we, for our part, have come to your knees  
in hope you may offer guest-friendship — or give besides  
some gift, as is the right and custom done for strangers.  
Respect the gods, mighty one. We are your suppliants,  
270 and Zeus is the avenger of suppliants and of strangers —  
Zeus of Strangers, who walks beside honored guests.'  
So I spoke, and he answered me at once, with pitiless heart:  
'You are a fool, stranger — or you have come from far away —<sup>25</sup>  
you who tell me to fear the gods or shun their anger.  
275 The Cyclopes pay no heed to Zeus who bears the aegis,  
nor to the blessed gods: for we are the better men by far.  
I would not spare you or your companions to dodge  
the hatred of Zeus — not unless my own heart bade me.  
But tell me: where did you moor your well-made ship when you came?  
280 At the far end of the shore, or near? I want to know.'  
So he spoke, testing; but I knew too much, and he did not catch me;  
I answered him back with words of guile:  
'My ship — Poseidon the earth-shaker smashed her to pieces,<sup>26</sup>  
driving her on the rocks at the border of your country:

285 he brought her against a headland, and the wind carried her in from the sea.

But I, with these men here, escaped sheer destruction.'  
So I spoke; and out of his pitiless heart he answered nothing,  
but sprang up and reached his hands out at my companions,  
snatched up two together, and dashed them like puppies<sup>27</sup>

290 against the ground: their brains ran out on the earth, and wetted it.  
He tore them limb from limb and made ready his supper,  
and he ate like a mountain-bred lion, and left nothing —  
the entrails, the flesh, the bones with their marrow.

And we, weeping, lifted up our hands to Zeus  
295 at the horror we watched, helplessness holding our hearts.  
And when the Cyclops had filled his great belly,  
feeding on man-flesh and washing it down with unmixed milk,  
he lay stretched out in the cave among his sheep.  
And I made a plan in my own great heart<sup>28</sup>

300 to steal close, draw the sharp sword from beside my thigh,  
and stab him in the chest, where the midriff holds the liver,  
feeling for the place with my hand. But a second thought held me:  
there we too would have perished in sheer destruction,  
for we could never have pushed back with our hands

305 the massive stone he had set in the high doorway.  
So then, groaning, we waited for shining Dawn.

When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,  
then he lit the fire, and milked his famous flocks,  
all in due order, and set the young under each.

310 And when at last he had hurried through his work,  
he snatched up two men together again, and made his meal ready.  
And having fed, he drove his fat flocks out of the cave,  
lifting off the great door-stone with ease — and then  
set it back, the way a man sets the lid on a quiver.<sup>29</sup>

315 With a great whistling the Cyclops turned his fat flocks  
toward the mountain; and I was left brooding evil deep in my heart:  
if somehow I might pay him back, and Athena grant me the glory.

And this, as I turned it over, seemed to me the best plan.  
There lay beside a pen a great club of the Cyclops',

320 green olive-wood: he had cut it to carry<sup>30</sup>

- once it seasoned. Looking it over we judged it  
big as the mast of a black twenty-oared ship,  
a broad-beamed freighter, that crosses the great gulf:<sup>31</sup>  
that was its length, that its thickness to the eye.
- 325 Standing to it, I cut off about a fathom's measure  
and handed it to my companions, and told them to dress it down;  
and they made it smooth, while standing by I brought it to a point  
at the tip, and then took it and hardened it in the blazing fire.  
And I laid it carefully by, hiding it under the dung
- 330 that was strewn in a great deep litter through the cave.  
And I told the others to shake lots among them  
for who would dare, together with me, to lift the stake  
and grind it in his eye, when sweet sleep came on him.  
The lot fell on the very men I would have chosen —
- 335 four of them, and I counted myself in with them, the fifth.  
At evening he came back, herding his fair-fleeced flocks,  
and drove those fat flocks straight into the wide cavern,  
all of them: he left not one outside in the deep yard,  
whether some foreboding moved him, or a god so ordered it.<sup>32</sup>
- 340 Then he lifted high and set in place the great door-stone,  
and sitting, he milked the ewes and bleating goats,  
all in due order, and set the young under each.  
And when at last he had hurried through his work,  
he snatched up two men together again, and made his supper ready.
- 345 And then I came up close and spoke to the Cyclops,  
holding in my hands an ivy-wood bowl of the dark wine:  
'Cyclops — here, drink wine, now you have fed on man-flesh:<sup>33</sup>  
so you may know what kind of drink our ship  
carried stored. I was bringing it as an offering for you, in hope
- 350 you might pity me and send me home. But your madness is past all  
bearing.  
Merciless one — how will any other man of all the many  
ever come near you again? What you have done is past all measure.'  
So I spoke; and he took it, and drank it down; and it pleased him —  
terribly —  
the sweet drink; and he demanded a second helping:
- 355 'Give me more — be generous. And tell me your name,

- here, now, so I can give you a guest-gift that will make you glad.  
 The grain-giving plowland bears wine for the Cyclopes too —  
 fine clusters, and Zeus' rain swells them for us;  
 but this — this is a rivulet of ambrosia and nectar!
- 360 So he spoke, and I handed him the fire-bright wine again.  
 Three times I brought and gave it; three times, in his folly, he drained it.  
 And when the wine had come circling round the Cyclops' wits,  
 then I spoke to him with honeyed words:  
 'Cyclops, you ask my glorious name? Then I
- 365 will tell it — and you give me the guest-gift, as you promised.  
 Nobody is my name. Nobody is what they call me —<sup>34</sup>  
 my mother and my father and all my companions.'  
 So I spoke, and he answered me at once, with pitiless heart:  
 'Nobody I will eat last of all his company,
- 370 and the others before him. That shall be your guest-gift.'<sup>35</sup>  
 He spoke — and reeling back he fell flat, and lay there  
 with his thick neck lolled over sideways; and sleep  
 the all-subduer took him. And from his gullet gushed wine  
 and gobbets of human flesh, as he belched in his drunkenness.
- 375 And then I drove the stake under the deep ash-heap  
 to heat; and with my words I put courage in all  
 my companions, so no man might flinch and hang back.  
 But when that olive stake in the fire, green though it was,  
 was on the point of catching, and glowed clean through, terrible —
- 380 then I brought it close out of the fire, and my companions  
 stood round me; and a great power breathed courage into us.  
 They took up the olive stake, sharpened at its point,  
 and rammed it in his eye; and I, throwing my weight on from above,  
 spun it — the way a man bores a ship-timber<sup>36</sup>
- 385 with a drill, and his mates below keep it running  
 with a strap they hold at either end, and it spins on without stopping:  
 so we took the fire-pointed stake and spun it  
 in his eye, and the blood came boiling up round its heat,  
 and the blast singed all his lids and brows away
- 390 as the eyeball burned, and the roots of it crackled in the fire.  
 As when a smith dips a great axe-head or an adze<sup>37</sup>  
 in cold water, and it hisses loud and high,

- tempering it — for that is what gives iron its strength —  
so his eye hissed round the olive stake.
- 395 And he let out a huge and hideous howl, and the rock rang round it,  
and we shrank back in terror. He wrenched the stake  
out of his eye, all fouled with streaming blood,  
and flung it from him, flailing his arms in agony,  
and set up a great bellowing to the Cyclopes who lived  
400 around him in caves along the windy heights.  
And they heard his cry and came thronging from every side,  
and standing round the cave they asked him what was wrong:  
'What in the world, Polyphemus? What hurt, that you cry out so<sup>38</sup>  
through the ambrosial night and make us sleepless?
- 405 Surely no mortal is driving off your flocks against your will?  
Surely no one is killing you — by cunning or by force?'  
And out of the cave strong Polyphemus answered them:  
'Friends — Nobody is killing me, by cunning and not by force!'  
And they answered with winged words, and gave it back:  
410 'If nobody is forcing you, then — alone as you are —<sup>39</sup>  
it must be sickness from great Zeus, and there is no escaping that.  
Pray to our father, the lord Poseidon.'  
So they spoke as they went; and my own heart laughed,  
how my name had utterly deceived him — the name, and the flawless  
cunning.
- 415 But the Cyclops, groaning and heaving in his agonies,  
groped with his hands and lifted the stone from the doorway,  
and sat himself down in the door with both arms spread,  
in hope of catching anyone who tried to slip out with the sheep:  
such a fool, I suppose, he hoped to find in me.
- 420 But I was planning how it might all come out best —  
if I could find some release from death for my companions  
and for myself; and I wove every guile and design,<sup>40</sup>  
as a man does for his very life: for the great evil was close.  
And this, as I turned it over, seemed to me the best plan.
- 425 There were rams there, well-fed, thick in the fleece,  
fine big animals, their wool dark as violets.  
These, working quietly, I lashed together with plaited withies —  
the ones that monster slept on, the outlaw — in threes:



the middle one of each three carried a man,  
 430 and the other two walked either side, protecting my companions.  
 So three sheep to each man. But for myself —  
 there was one ram, far the finest of all the flock;  
 I caught him along the back and curled under his shaggy belly  
 and lay there; and in that wondrous fleece, with my hands  
 435 twisted fast, I hung on, with an enduring heart.  
 So then, groaning, we waited for shining Dawn.

When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,  
 then the male flocks poured out toward pasture,  
 and the unmilked females bleated about the pens  
 440 with their udders bursting. And their lord, worn down  
 by evil agonies, ran his hands along the backs of all his sheep  
 as they stood up straight — and never sensed it, the fool:  
 my men bound under the breasts of his own fleecy sheep.  
 Last of the flock the great ram walked toward the doorway,  
 445 heavy with his wool — and with me, and my crowding thoughts.<sup>41</sup>  
 And strong Polyphemus, running his hands over him, said:  
 'Old sweetheart — my ram — why last of all the flock<sup>42</sup>  
 through the cave this time? Before, you were never one to lag behind:  
 first, always first, striding out to graze the soft flowering grass,  
 450 first to reach the running rivers,  
 first in your longing to turn home to the fold  
 at evening. And now — last of all. Grieving, are you,  
 for your master's eye, that a coward of a man put out,  
 with his miserable companions, when he had crushed my wits with  
 wine —  
 455 Nobody — who is not yet, I promise, clear of destruction.  
 If only you could think with me, if only you had a voice<sup>43</sup>  
 to say where that man is dodging from my fury:  
 then his brains would be dashed against the floor and spattered  
 this way and that through the cave, and my heart would find  
 460 some ease from the evils this worthless Nobody has brought me.'  
 So speaking he sent the ram away from him, out the door.  
 And when we had gone a little way from the cave and the yard,  
 first I loosed myself from under the ram, and then set my companions  
 free.

Swiftly then we drove those long-shanked sheep, deep in fat,  
 465 turning again and again to look behind, until we came  
 to the ship. And a welcome sight we were to our dear companions —  
 we who had escaped death — but the others they wept and wailed for.  
 I would not have it: I frowned each man's tears back<sup>44</sup>  
 and ordered them quickly to fling the fine-fleeced sheep  
 470 aboard in numbers, and sail out over the salt water.  
 And they came aboard at once and took their places at the oarlocks,  
 and sitting in order they struck the gray salt water with their oars.  
 But when I was as far offshore as a man's shout carries,  
 then I called to the Cyclops with jeering words:  
 475 'Cyclops! Not so weak a man's companions, after all,  
 were those you meant to eat by main force in your hollow cave.  
 And your own evil deeds were bound to find you out —  
 merciless one — you who did not shrink from eating guests  
 in your own house. For that Zeus has paid you, and the other gods.'  
 480 So I spoke, and the anger in his heart grew fiercer,  
 and he tore off the peak of a great mountain and hurled it,  
 and brought it down just ahead of the dark-blue prow —  
 barely — it missed the tip of the steering-oar;  
 and the sea heaved up under the falling rock,  
 485 and the backwash carried the ship straight in toward the land,  
 a flood-surge out of the deep, and drove her toward the shore.  
 But I seized a long pole in my hands  
 and shoved her off and out, and roused my companions,  
 ordering them to fall to their oars and get us clear of the evil,  
 490 nodding hard with my head; and they bent to it and rowed.  
 But when we were twice as far out over the sea,  
 then I made to call to the Cyclops again; and around me my  
 companions  
 tried to hold me back with honeyed words, this one and that one:  
 'Merciless man — why must you provoke a savage'<sup>45</sup>  
 495 who even now, with that shot into the sea, has driven the ship  
 straight back ashore — and we thought we died there!  
 If he had heard a voice, heard any one of us speaking,  
 he would have smashed our heads and the ship's timbers together  
 with one jagged boulder: he throws that far.'

- 500 So they spoke, but they could not persuade my great heart,<sup>46</sup>  
 and I called back to him with fury in my breast:  
 'Cyclops — if any mortal man ever asks you  
 who put the shameful blinding on your eye,  
 tell him: Odysseus, sacker of cities, blinded me —<sup>47</sup>
- 505 the son of Laertes, who has his home in Ithaca.'  
 So I spoke, and he groaned aloud, and answered:  
 'Ah, then it comes home to me — the old prophecy!<sup>48</sup>  
 There was a seer here once, a great man and a good one,  
 Telemus, Eurymus' son, who excelled in prophecy
- 510 and grew old prophesying among the Cyclopes.  
 He told me all this would come to pass in time:  
 that I would lose my sight at the hands of an Odysseus.  
 But I always watched for some big man, a handsome one,  
 to come here, clothed in great strength;
- 515 and now a little man, a worthless thing, a weakling,  
 has put out my eye — after he crushed me with wine.  
 But come here, Odysseus — let me set out a guest-gift for you,<sup>49</sup>  
 and press the famous earth-shaker to give you passage home.  
 For I am his son, and he declares himself my father.
- 520 He himself, if he wills it, will heal me — and no one else,  
 none of the blessed gods, and no mortal man.'  
 So he spoke; and I answered him and said:  
 'Would to god I could strip you of breath and life  
 and send you down to the house of Hades
- 525 as surely as not even the earth-shaker will ever heal that eye.'  
 So I spoke; and he then prayed to the lord Poseidon,  
 stretching out his hands to the starry heaven:  
 'Hear me, Poseidon who hold the earth, dark-haired one:<sup>50</sup>  
 if I am truly yours, and you declare yourself my father,
- 530 grant that Odysseus, sacker of cities, never come home —  
 the son of Laertes, who has his home in Ithaca.  
 But if it is his portion to see his own people, to reach  
 his well-built house and his own fatherland,  
 late may he come, and in evil case, all companions lost,
- 535 on another man's ship — and find trouble in his house.'  
 So he spoke in prayer, and the dark-haired god heard him.<sup>51</sup>

Then once again he lifted a stone — far bigger —  
 whirled it, and let it fly, putting his measureless strength behind it,  
 and brought it down just astern of the dark-blue ship —  
 540 barely — it missed the tip of the steering-oar;  
 and the sea heaved up under the falling rock,  
 and the wave carried her forward, and drove her toward the far shore.  
 But when we came back to the island where the other  
 well-benched ships waited all together, with the companions  
 545 sitting round them weeping, watching for us without end,  
 there we ran the ship up on the sands  
 and stepped out ourselves onto the surf-line of the sea.  
 And taking the Cyclops' flocks out of the hollow ship  
 we divided all, so that no man might go cheated of his share by me.<sup>52</sup>  
 550 But the great ram — my strong-greaved companions gave him  
 to me alone, when the flocks were shared, a gift apart; and on the shore  
 I offered him to Zeus of the black cloud, the son of Cronos,  
 lord of all, and burned the thigh-cuts. But he took no heed of my  
 offering:<sup>53</sup>  
 he was pondering, even then, how all my well-benched ships  
 555 might be destroyed, and all my trusted companions.  
 So then all day long till the setting of the sun  
 we sat feasting on meat past counting and sweet wine;  
 and when the sun went down and the dusk came on,  
 then we lay down to sleep on the surf-line of the sea.  
 560 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,  
 then I roused my companions and ordered them  
 to board in their turn and loose the stern-cables.  
 And they came aboard at once and took their places at the oarlocks,  
 and sitting in order they struck the gray salt water with their oars.  
 565 From there we sailed on further, grieved at heart,<sup>54</sup>  
 glad to be out of death, having lost our dear companions.

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 9

- 1    *l. 2* The vocative planted at 8.382 pays off exactly here: the greatest speech in the poem opens with the same ceremonial line Odysseus used to compliment the dancers. From this line to the end of Book 12 — over 2,200 lines — the "I" of the poem is Odysseus, and Homer's own voice waits outside the tale.
- 2    *l. 5* The proem-before-the-name: peace, a full hall, a singer, loaded tables — "this seems to my mind the fairest thing there is." Plato was scandalized (a hero ranking dinner-parties as life's *telos*), but the sentence is engineered: he blesses precisely the civilization his hosts embody, from the mouth of the man about to narrate its every opposite — famine, lawlessness, caves, and man-eating. The apologoi are framed as the photographic negative of the Phaeacian feast at which they are told.
- 3    *l. 19* "I am Odysseus, son of Laertes — known to all mankind for my cunning designs; and my fame has reached heaven." Eight and a half books withheld, the name arrives with a claim attached: he identifies himself not by war or kingship but by δόλοι — cunning — and states his own celebrity as plain fact. The whole scene is the poem's economy of kleos made visible: last night Demodocus sang of him as of a dead legend; now the legend stands up in the audience and takes over the singing.
- 4    *l. 19* "Rough ground, but a good nurse of men" — the praise of thin-soiled Ithaca that Telemachus offered Menelaus in nearly the same breath (4.605–608: "goat-pasture, and lovelier to me than horse-pasture"). Father and son, who have never spoken, love the island in the same argument. And then the sentence the whole poem rests on: "I cannot see any sweeter sight than a man's own country."
- 5    *l. 29* Calypso and Circe, dispatched in five lines and made grammatically identical — each "hungry to make me her husband" (the phrase from 1.15). He opens his story's summary with the theme of detention refused — establishing before the adventures begin that the ending was never in doubt where his own will was concerned.
- 6    *l. 39* The first adventure, told without a flicker of apology: "There I sacked the city and destroyed the men; and out of the city we took their wives and much substance." The tale begins with Odysseus doing to Ismarus exactly what was done to the widow of his own simile (8.523–531) — the poem placing the raid and its grief back to back across a single night of storytelling. His one note of pride is distributive justice among his own: "so that no man might go cheated of his share by me" (repeated verbatim of the Cyclops' sheep at 549 — his bookkeeping survives everything).
- 7    *l. 44* "The great fools would not obey" — μέγα νήπιοι, the proem's own word for the crew (1.8). The account-ledger of blame the proem opened is now kept by Odysseus himself, entry by entry: ordered retreat, refused; wine drunk, cattle slaughtered (the exact idiom of the suitors' feasting); six men per ship dead. Seventy-two lost to disobedience before anything supernatural has happened at all.

- 8 l. 58 "When the sun turned over toward unyoking-time" — βουλυτόνδε, the hour the plowman unyokes his oxen: time told by farm-work even in battle, like the mule-furrow of 8.124.
- 9 l. 62 The refrain of the apologoi, fixed here: "From there we sailed on further, grieved at heart, / glad to be out of death, having lost our dear companions." It will toll between episodes through three more books — the wanderings counted out in identical griefs.
- 10 l. 65 Calling each dead man's name three times before sailing: the rite owed to the unburied, a voice-cenotaph. The poem's care for death-rites (Elpenor will die of their neglect) begins in its hero's punctiliousness even in flight.
- 11 l. 80 Malea and Cythera — the last real place-names. Nine days of storm from rounding the Peloponnese, and the ships pass off the map: everything from the Lotus-eaters to Phaeacia happens in a geography that ancient and modern readers alike have tried and failed to chart. The poem gives the boundary a name and a wind.
- 12 l. 84 The Lotus-eaters: the gentlest danger in the poem — no violence, no malice, only a fruit after which "they wanted to stay... and to forget their homecoming." The first adversary of the *nostos* is not death but oblivion — the will itself dissolving. Odysseus' response is proportionate and terrible: the weeping men dragged back and bound under the benches. Homecoming, in this poem, can be a thing done to you by force.
- 13 l. 94 What the lotus was — jujube? poppy? — was already guessed at in antiquity and never settled. The poem needs no botany: "honey-sweet," and it eats memory.
- 14 l. 106 The Cyclopes ethnography, all negations: no planting, no plowing, no assemblies, no laws (θέμιστες), each a law to his own household, "and they care nothing for one another." Civilization is defined by its absence — and with a barb: everything grows for them anyway, "trusting in the deathless gods." Lawlessness with divine subsidy. Odysseus the raider-king describes them with the fascinated contempt of a man cataloguing everything his own world is not.
- 15 l. 116 The goat island (116–141) is surveyed with a colonist's eye: meadows, deep soil, a harbor needing no anchor-stone, a spring — "it would bear every crop in season." The island is "widowed of men" only because the Cyclopes have no ships, "no shipwrights" — seafaring as the exact boundary between having a world and having a cave. This passage, the eighth-century reader's own colonial appraisal form, is the poem's clearest window onto its age of western settlement.
- 16 l. 166 "Smoke, and voices — theirs, and their sheep's and goats'": the reconnaissance is aural. Compare Odysseus on Ogygia, aching "to see even the smoke leaping up" from Ithaca (1.58): smoke on a horizon is this poem's sign of inhabited land — hearth-fire, the first legible mark of any society, kind or monstrous.
- 17 l. 175 The arrival-question, verbatim from 6.120–121 — but there he asked it of Phaeacia, and the answer was the kindest people in the poem. Asked here, the answer is the Cyclops. The formula is a coin the poem keeps flipping; the two faces land in adjacent books.
- 18 l. 187 The first sight of him is all isolation-words: alone, far apart, no company, aloof, "his heart knew no law" (ἀθεμίστια ἦδη — *themis* again). And then scale: not like a bread-

eating man but "like a wooded crag... standing clear of all the rest." He is landscape, not society — the ethnography of 112–115 condensed into one body.

- 19 l. 197 Maron's wine: the episode's engine, and a parable of xenia's economy. Because Odysseus once *spared* a priest — reverence, not profit — he was given a wine so potent it takes twenty parts of water; because a monster despises guest-law, that wine destroys him. The gift-chain is the theology: what you do at your door comes back at someone else's. Even its secrecy is loving detail — one wife, one housekeeper, no one else in the house knew.
- 20 l. 219 The cave interior is a model dairy: cheese-crates, lambs sorted by age in three pens, every vessel brimming. The monster is a meticulous husbandman — the horror ahead is not chaos but *order*, a well-run farm whose livestock now includes men.
- 21 l. 228 "But I would not listen — it would have been far better": the narrator convicts his younger self in mid-sentence. The motive is stated with terrible honesty: to see him, "and whether he would give me guest-gifts." Curiosity, and the desire to collect xenia from the uttermost edge of the world — the collector's greed of a connoisseur of hospitality. Six men will pay for it.
- 22 l. 241 The door-stone that twenty-two four-wheeled carts could not shift: the number is absurdly exact, an engineer's estimate. It is also the plot: the stone converts the cave into a problem force cannot solve (299–305), which is why this, of all adventures, belongs to Nobody.
- 23 l. 252 The Cyclops asks Nestor's question — the piracy formula of 3.71–74, word for word — but before welcome, from above his own supper-fire. In Pylos the question followed the feast and was courtesy; flung at suppliants before any word of greeting, it is the signature of the monster. The poem has waited six books to spring this reuse.
- 24 l. 263 Odysseus' plea leans on Agamemnon's fame and sack-count — the credentials of a raider offered to a hermit who has never heard of Troy — and then rises to the full doctrine: "Zeus is the avenger of suppliants and of strangers — Zeus of Strangers." The theology Echeneus and Nausicaa and Alcinous all recited is here spoken to its one perfect unbeliever.
- 25 l. 273 "The Cyclopes pay no heed to Zeus... for we are the better men by far." The only speech of genuine atheism in Homer — not doubt but contemptuous superiority. And his follow-up question (where is your ship?) shows cunning inside the savagery: he tests, Odysseus lies (283–286), and the lie — the ship wrecked by Poseidon — saves the crews and is, prophetically, half true.
- 26 l. 283 The instant lie — ship wrecked by Poseidon, survivors only — protects the crew at the shore and the fleet at the island in one stroke. It is also, unknowingly, half a prophecy: wreck does await — the fleet under the Laestrygonian rocks, the last ship under Zeus' bolt, and Poseidon saving his wrath for the raft. In this poem even the lies come true; the liar just doesn't know how.
- 27 l. 289 "Like puppies" — the most sickening simile in the poem precisely because of its smallness: not battle-death but the casual destruction of something young by something

- huge. Then the lion formula, and the total consumption — "entrails, flesh, bones with their marrow" — the feast type-scene inverted into a meal without fire, portion, or god.
- 28 l. 299 The sword-impulse checked: kill him now and die entombed. The stone forces the plot's grammar — βίη (force) is useless; everything must run through μῆτις (cunning). The episode is built as a demonstration-proof of the hero's defining quality, with the door-stone as the theorem's given.
- 29 l. 314 "The way a man sets the lid on a quiver": the boulder no twenty-two carts could shift, handled like an archer's kit — scale comedy, and a reminder between the horrors that to him this is housekeeping.
- 30 l. 320 The stake is *olive* — green olive-wood, Athena's tree, the wood of the bed at 23. The instrument of vengeance and the symbol of the marriage are cut from the same timber; the poem's materials are never neutral.
- 31 l. 322 Measured against "the mast of a black twenty-oared ship, a broad-beamed freighter" — the second time Odysseus sizes timber by merchant shipping (the raft-hull at 5.249–251). Euryalus' sneer (8.161–164) keeps being half-right: the hero's imagination is genuinely nautical-commercial. The poem lets the insult be observation.
- 32 l. 339 This once, the Cyclops drives *all* the flock inside, rams included — "whether some foreboding moved him, or a god so ordered it." Without that unexplained variance there is no escape under the rams. The narrator leaves the door open between chance and providence, and it is the tale's only such shrug: even Odysseus cannot say who arranged his instrument.
- 33 l. 347 The wine-offer is staged as a grievance-gift: "I was bringing it as an offering... but your madness is past all bearing." He serves the destroying draught in the language of the very hospitality being violated — and the Cyclops, delighted, promises a guest-gift in return, completing the parody: the exchange-of-gifts scene performed by a poisoner and a cannibal.
- 34 l. 366 Οὔτις — "Nobody." The man who spent eight books refusing to be named (and heard last night that "no one among mankind is altogether nameless," 8.552) weaponizes namelessness itself. The alias is also a self-annihilation with a truth in it: stripped of ships, companions, and fame, what is he in this cave but nobody? The name he gives falsely is the condition he is actually in.
- 35 l. 369 "Nobody I will eat last... that shall be your guest-gift." The Cyclops' single joke — and it is a real one, the ghastly wit of parodied xenia. The poem gives its monster exactly one flash of humor, and it is about eating-order.
- 36 l. 384 The blinding runs on two craftsman similes back to back: the shipwright's bow-drill (spun with a strap by mates below — precise, collaborative, professional) and the smith quenching an axe-head, "for that is what gives iron its strength." The atrocity is narrated as skilled labor — Odysseus the carpenter of the raft and the bed at his trade — and the second simile is knowingly anachronistic: iron-tempering is the poet's own technology, imported into the bronze-age tale for the sound of the hiss.
- 37 l. 391 The quench-simile carries a workshop aside — "for that is what gives iron its strength" — a craftsman's parenthesis on metallurgy in the middle of an atrocity. The



poet knows his trade-lore and cannot resist sharing it, even here.

- 38 l. 403 Polyphemus is named at last — by his worried neighbors, 403 lines into his episode. The name means "much-famed" (or "much-speaking"): Fame-himself, blinded by Nobody. The pun-architecture of the episode is total.
- 39 l. 410 The trap sprung: "if nobody is forcing you" — Greek μή τίς, one breath away from μήτις, *cunning*. The neighbors' diagnosis ("sickness from Zeus — pray to our father Poseidon") is wrong in the first clause and disastrous in the second: their prescribed prayer is exactly what will curse the escaping trickster. And at 414 the narrator lands the pun openly: the name deceived him — "the name, and the flawless *mētis*." Nobody and cunning are, in Greek, nearly the same word: the alias was the trait, spelled aloud.
- 40 l. 422 "I wove every guile and design, as a man does for his very life" — plotting as weaving yet again (Penelope's loom, Hephaestus' snare-webs, Nestor's "stitched evils"). The poem has one master-metaphor for intelligence, and every member of this family uses it.
- 41 l. 445 "Heavy with his wool — and with me, and my crowding thoughts": the great ram carries a double freight, fleece and mind. The zeugma is the escape itself in miniature — the monster's own best possession loaded with the *mētis* that ruined him.
- 42 l. 447 The address to the ram — the episode's astonishing mercy. The cannibal, in agony, speaks to his lead animal with the tenderness the poem has shown nowhere else in the cave: *first always first, to the grass, to the rivers, home at evening — now last. Grieving, are you, for your master's eye?* For ten lines the monster is a shepherd who loves his beast and is loved in his imagination by it, and the listening hall — and we — are forced to pity him with the escaping hero literally hanging beneath the words.
- 43 l. 456 "If only you could think with me" — ὁμοφρονέοις: the *homophrosynē* word, the like-mindedness Odysseus blessed Nausicaa with as the best thing two people can have (6.181–184). The Cyclops wishes it of a sheep. It is the loneliest line in the poem: the creature with no society, no law, and now no sight, reaching for the poem's word for marriage — toward the animal carrying his enemy out the door.
- 44 l. 468 "I frowned each man's tears back": grief for the six left in the cave is suppressed by a movement of the brows — mourning deferred by command, as at the Cicones it was rationed to three calls of the name. The captain's arithmetic: weep later, row now.
- 45 l. 494 The companions' plea is the sanest speech in the episode — and it fails. "They could not persuade my great heart" (500): the identical formula for heroic obstinacy the poem elsewhere uses admiringly. This is the hero's great flaw scene: the need to *sign the deed* overrides survival itself.
- 46 l. 500 "They could not persuade my great heart" — the formula of heroic resolve, used here for the one decision in the poem that everyone, crew and listener alike, can see is wrong. The epic language of steadfastness deployed against sane advice: obstinacy and heroism share a vocabulary, and the poem knows it.
- 47 l. 504 The boast: "tell him: Odysseus, sacker of cities, blinded me — the son of Laertes, who has his home in Ithaca." Name, title, patronymic, address — a herald's full formula, delivered to the one auditor who can turn it into a curse. Kleos demands attribution;

Nobody saves your life, but Nobody gets no credit. The claiming of the deed is at once his signature virtue (fame) and the single costliest sentence he speaks in ten years.

- 48 l. 507 The Cyclops had a prophecy too — Telemus foretold blinding "at the hands of an Odysseus" — and he had mis-imagined his enemy: "I always watched for some big man, a handsome one." Expectation as blindness before the stake: he was watching for the wrong shape. File this beside every person in Ithaca who will look at a beggar and watch for a king.
- 49 l. 517 The monster's second hospitality-parody: *come back, let me give you a guest-gift, my father will escort you home*. The vocabulary of *xenia* (ξείνια, πομπή — gifts, sending) in the mouth that ate six guests. Odysseus' refusal wishes him to Hades; the exchange of courtesies is complete.
- 50 l. 528 The curse — and it is the plot of the Odyssey dictated by its villain: *never come home; or if it is his portion* (the fate-formula from Proteus, 4.475–477, respected even by a praying monster) — *late, in evil case, all companions lost, on another man's ship, and find trouble in his house*. Every clause will be executed: ten years late; the borrowed Phaeacian ship; the hundred and eight suitors. Poseidon's grudge, announced at 1.20–21 and unexplained for eight books, is here given its cause and its exact text.
- 51 l. 536 "And the dark-haired god heard him." Four words, and the poem's engine is installed. Compare 6.328: Athena heard Odysseus' prayer in the grove. Both prayers of this pair of enemies are heard; the whole poem is the interference-pattern.
- 52 l. 549 The distributive-justice line repeated verbatim from the Cicones (42): loot or livestock, the shares are always even, "so that no man might go cheated by me." And the crew's answering grace — the great ram voted to him "a gift apart" — is the campaign's one moment of pure solidarity, promptly spent on a rejected sacrifice.
- 53 l. 553 "He took no heed of my offering: he was pondering, even then, how all my ships might be destroyed." This is Odysseus' theology of his own catastrophe — Zeus as premeditating destroyer — and it stands in unresolved friction with Zeus' own opening speech (1.32–43: mortals blame the gods for what their recklessness earns). The poem lets its hero's bitter reading and its god's self-defense coexist; between them sits every ship and man lost to Thrinacia's cattle, where both explanations will be tested at once.
- 54 l. 565 The refrain closes the book as it closed the Cicones — same grief, same relief, same dead. One adventure per moral: the raid cost six per ship by disobedience; the cave cost six by the captain's curiosity and six more words at the rail. The ledger sails on.

## Odyssey — Book 10

*Aeolus and the bag of winds; the Laestrygonians; a year with Circe.*

- We came next to the Aeolian island; and there lived  
 Aeolus, Hippotas' son, dear to the deathless gods,  
 on a floating island: all around it a wall<sup>1</sup>  
 of bronze, unbreakable, and the cliff runs up sheer.
- 5 Twelve children of his live in his halls,  
 six daughters and six sons in their prime,  
 and he has given his daughters to his sons to be their wives.<sup>2</sup>  
 They are always feasting beside their dear father  
 and their honored mother, and good things past counting are set before  
 them;
- 10 all day the house is savory with roasting, and the courtyard rings with  
 the sound;  
 and at night they sleep beside their honored wives  
 among blankets, on corded bedsteads.  
 To their city, then, we came, and their beautiful house.  
 A full month he made much of me, and questioned me on everything —
- 15 Ilium, the Argives' ships, the Achaeans' homecoming —  
 and I told him all of it through, in its due order.  
 And when I in my turn asked for the road, and begged him  
 to send me on, he refused me nothing: he prepared my sending.  
 He gave me a bag — the flayed hide of a nine-year ox —<sup>3</sup>
- 20 and in it he bound the courses of the blustering winds:  
 for the son of Cronos made him steward of the winds,  
 to still them or to rouse them, whichever he will.  
 In my hollow ship he lashed it fast with a shining cord  
 of silver, so that not the smallest breath could slip past;
- 25 and for me he sent out the West Wind's breath to blow,  
 to carry the ships and the men. But it was not to be  
 accomplished: we were destroyed by our own folly.<sup>4</sup>  
 Nine days and nights alike we sailed on,  
 and on the tenth our fathers' fields were rising into view —
- 30 so near, we could see men tending their fires.<sup>5</sup>

- Then sweet sleep came over me, worn out as I was:  
all that time I had worked the ship's sheet myself, yielding it  
to no other companion, to bring us home the faster.  
And the companions began to talk to one another,  
35 and said I was bringing home gold and silver for myself,  
gifts of great-hearted Aeolus, Hippias' son.  
And thus would one of them say, with a glance at his neighbor:<sup>6</sup>  
'Look at him — how loved he is, how honored,  
among all men, whatever city or land he comes to!  
40 He carries out of Troy a mass of beautiful treasure,  
his plunder — while we, who have accomplished the same long road,  
come home with empty hands.  
And now Aeolus, obliging him in friendship, has given him  
this besides. Quick, then — let us see what is in it:  
45 how much gold, how much silver the bag holds.'  
So they talked, and the companions' evil counsel won.  
They opened the bag — and all the winds burst out,  
and the storm snatched them up at once and swept them seaward,  
weeping, away from their fathers' land. And I,  
50 waking, debated in my own blameless heart  
whether to drop from the deck and drown in the sea<sup>7</sup>  
or endure in silence and stay among the living.  
I endured, and I stayed. Covering my head  
I lay where I was; and the ships were carried by the evil blast of the  
storm  
55 back to the Aeolian island; and my companions groaned.
- There we set foot on the mainland and drew water,  
and the companions quickly took their meal beside the fast ships.  
And when we had tasted food and drink,  
then I took with me a herald and one companion  
60 and went to the famous house of Aeolus. I found him  
feasting beside his wife and his children.  
We came into the house and sat down by the doorposts  
on the threshold; and they were amazed at heart, and asked:  
'How are you here, Odysseus? What evil power attacked you?  
65 Surely we sent you off with all care, to reach  
your fatherland and your house, and whatever place is dear to you.'

So they spoke; and I, grieving at heart, addressed them:  
'My evil companions ruined me — they, and a pitiless  
sleep. But heal it, friends: the power is yours.'

- 70 So I spoke, plying them with soft words;  
and they fell silent. And the father answered:  
'Out of this island — fast — you vilest thing alive!'<sup>8</sup>  
It is against all right for me to harbor or to send on his way  
a man the blessed gods detest.
- 75 Out! — since you come here hated by the deathless ones.'  
So speaking he sent me from his house, groaning heavily.

From there we sailed on further, grieved at heart.  
And the men's spirit was worn down by the grinding rowing —  
our own fault: no sending wind showed any more.

- 80 Six days and nights alike we sailed on,  
and on the seventh we came to Lamus' steep citadel —  
Telepylus of the Laestrygonians, where herdsman hails herdsman:<sup>9</sup>  
the one driving in calls, and the one driving out answers.  
There a sleepless man could have earned a double wage,
- 85 one herding cattle, one pasturing silvery sheep:  
so close together are the paths of night and day.  
There, when we came into the famous harbor — a sheer cliff<sup>10</sup>  
runs unbroken all around it, on both sides,  
and jutting headlands, facing one another,
- 90 thrust out at the mouth, and the entrance is narrow —  
there all the others steered their curved ships in,  
and moored them inside the hollow harbor, close together:  
for no wave ever swelled in there, great or small,  
but a white calm lay all around it.

- 95 I alone held my black ship outside,<sup>11</sup>  
there at the edge, and made the cables fast to the rock;  
and I climbed a broken lookout-height and stood there.  
No works of oxen or of men showed anywhere;  
we saw only smoke springing up from the land.
- 100 Then I sent companions ahead to learn  
what men they were who ate bread upon this earth:  
two men I chose, and sent a third with them as herald.  
They went ashore and took a level road, by which the wagons

hauled timber down to the city from the high mountains,  
 105 and before the city they met a girl drawing water,<sup>12</sup>  
 the sturdy daughter of Laestrygonian Antiphates.  
 She had come down to the fair-flowing spring  
 Artacia, from which they carried water to the town;  
 and they came up beside her and spoke to her, and asked  
 110 who was king of these people, and whom he ruled;  
 and she pointed them at once to her father's high-roofed house.  
 But when they entered the famous house, they found his wife  
 huge as a mountain peak — and they were sick with horror at her.  
 She called famous Antiphates straightway from the gathering-place —  
 115 her husband — and he plotted their wretched destruction:  
 he snatched up one of my companions on the spot and made his meal  
 of him,  
 and the other two sprang away and came flying to the ships.  
 Then he raised the war-cry through the city; and hearing it  
 the mighty Laestrygonians came thronging from every side,  
 120 thousands of them — not like men, but like the Giants.<sup>13</sup>  
 From the cliffs they pelted us with man-heavy stones,  
 and at once an evil din rose up along the ships —  
 the scream of dying men, the crunch of shattering hulls.  
 Spearing them like fish, they carried home their loathsome meal.<sup>14</sup>  
 125 While they were slaughtering those inside the deep harbor,  
 I drew the sharp sword from beside my thigh  
 and cut the cables of my dark-blue-prowed ship,  
 and quickly I roused my companions and ordered them  
 to fall to their oars and get us clear of the evil;  
 130 and they tore up the sea together, in terror of death.  
 Gladly my ship fled out to open water, away from the beetling  
 cliffs; but the others were destroyed there, all together.  
  
 From there we sailed on further, grieved at heart,<sup>15</sup>  
 glad to be out of death, having lost our dear companions.  
 135 And we came to the island of Aeaëa; and there lived  
 Circe of the lovely braids, dread goddess with a mortal's voice,<sup>16</sup>  
 own sister of Aeetes the deadly-minded:  
 both born of Helios, who carries light to mortals,  
 and of Perse their mother, whom Ocean fathered.

- 140 There we brought the ship silently to the shore  
and into a harbor fit for ships; and some god was guiding us.  
We stepped ashore there, and for two days and two nights  
we lay, eating our hearts with weariness and pain together.  
But when Dawn of the lovely braids brought the third day round,  
145 then I took my spear and my sharp sword  
and went up quickly from the ship to a viewing-place,  
in hope of seeing men's works, or catching a voice.  
I climbed a broken lookout-height and stood there,  
and smoke showed to my eyes, rising from the wide-wayed earth  
150 in Circe's halls, up through the dense brush and the timber.  
And I debated then in my mind and in my heart  
whether to go and look, since I had seen the fire-bright smoke.  
And as I weighed it, this seemed to me the better way:<sup>17</sup>  
to go first to the fast ship and the shore of the sea,  
155 give the companions their meal, and send them out to learn.  
But when, on my way down, I was near the curved ship,  
then some god took pity on me, alone as I was,  
and sent a great high-antlered stag into my very path.<sup>18</sup>  
He was coming down to the river from his forest pasture  
160 to drink, for the sun's force was heavy on him;  
and as he stepped out I struck him on the spine, mid-back:  
the bronze spear went clean through,  
and down he dropped in the dust with a cry, and the life flew from him.  
I set my foot on him and drew the bronze spear  
165 out of the wound, and laid it down there on the ground  
and left it; then I pulled brushwood and withies  
and plaited a rope, a fathom's length, well-twisted  
all along, and bound together the feet of the huge beast,  
and went down to the black ship carrying him slung across my neck,  
170 leaning on my spear: there was no carrying him on the shoulder  
with one hand — he was a very great beast.  
I flung him down before the ship, and woke my companions  
with gentle words, standing by each man in turn:  
'Friends — for all our grief, we will not go down  
175 to the house of Hades before our destined day.  
Come then, while there is food and drink in the fast ship,

- let us think of eating, and not be worn away with hunger.'  
 So I spoke, and they quickly heeded my words:  
 they uncovered their heads there by the shore of the barren sea  
 180 and marveled at the stag: he was a very great beast.  
 And when they had had their joy of gazing,  
 they washed their hands and made the glorious feast ready.  
 So then all day long till the setting of the sun  
 we sat feasting on meat past counting and sweet wine;  
 185 and when the sun went down and the dusk came on,  
 then we lay down to sleep on the surf-line of the sea.  
 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,  
 then I called an assembly, and spoke among them all:  
 'Hear my words, companions, for all your suffering.  
 190 Friends — we do not know where the dark is, or where the dawn,<sup>19</sup>  
 or where the sun that carries light to mortals goes under the earth,  
 or where he rises. Let us think, then — quickly —  
 whether any device is left us. I do not believe there is.  
 I climbed a broken lookout-height and saw  
 195 an island, wreathed round with the boundless sea;  
 the island itself lies low, and in the middle of it my eyes  
 caught smoke, up through the dense brush and the timber.'  
 So I spoke, and their own hearts broke within them,  
 remembering the deeds of Laestrygonian Antiphates  
 200 and the violence of the great-hearted man-eating Cyclops.  
 They wept aloud, letting the big tears fall —  
 but nothing came of all their mourning.<sup>20</sup>
- Then I counted off all my strong-greaved companions  
 into two bands, and gave each band a leader:  
 205 I led the one, and godlike Eurylochus the other.<sup>21</sup>  
 We shook the lots quickly in a bronze helmet,  
 and out jumped the lot of great-hearted Eurylochus.  
 So he set out, and with him two-and-twenty companions,  
 weeping — and they left us behind in tears as well.  
 210 In a forest glen they found the house of Circe, built  
 of polished stones, in a place with a clear view all around;  
 and around it were mountain wolves and lions —<sup>22</sup>  
 creatures she herself had bewitched, giving them evil drugs.



- And these did not spring at the men, no:  
 215 they rose and fawned around them, waving their long tails.  
 As when dogs fawn around their master coming from a feast —  
 for he always carries home some sweet morsel for them —  
 so the strong-clawed wolves and the lions fawned  
 around them; and they were terrified at the sight of the dread huge  
 creatures.
- 220 They stood in the gateway of the goddess of the lovely hair,  
 and inside they heard Circe singing in a beautiful voice,<sup>23</sup>  
 moving to and fro at her great imperishable loom — the weaving  
 goddesses do: fine-spun work, graceful and shining.  
 And Polites began to speak among them — a leader of men,  
 225 who of all my companions was closest and dearest to me:  
 'Friends — someone inside there, moving at a great loom,  
 is singing, beautifully — the whole floor hums with it —  
 goddess or woman. Quick, let us call out to her.'  
 So he spoke, and they lifted their voices and called.
- 230 And she came out at once, and opened the shining doors,  
 and invited them in; and all together, in their innocence,  
 they followed her. Only Eurylochus stayed behind, suspecting a snare.  
 She led them in and seated them on benches and chairs,  
 and stirred them a mixture: cheese and barley meal and pale honey<sup>24</sup>  
 235 in Pramnian wine. And into the dish she blended  
 baleful drugs, to make them wholly forget their fathers' land.  
 And when she had served it and they had drunk it down, at once  
 she struck them with her wand and penned them in the pigsties.  
 And they had the heads of pigs — the voice, the bristles,  
 240 the body — but their minds stayed steady, exactly as before.<sup>25</sup>  
 So they were penned there weeping; and Circe threw them  
 acorns of oak and ilex, and cornel berries,  
 the things pigs eat, the wallowers on the ground.
- But Eurylochus came running back to the fast black ship  
 245 to bring the news of the companions and their bitter fate.  
 And he could not get one word out, for all his straining —  
 struck to the heart with his great anguish; his eyes  
 brimmed full of tears, and his spirit was all lament.  
 But when we questioned him, all of us, in our amazement,

- 250 at last he told the destruction of the other companions:  
 'We went up through the brush, as you commanded, glorious  
 Odysseus,<sup>26</sup>  
 and in a forest glen we found a beautiful house, built  
 of polished stones, in a place with a clear view all around.  
 And there someone at a great loom was singing, clear and high —  
 255 goddess or woman. And they lifted their voices and called.  
 And she came out at once, and opened the shining doors,  
 and invited them in; and all together, in their innocence,  
 they followed her. But I stayed behind, suspecting a snare.  
 And they vanished — all of them together. Not one of them  
 260 appeared again, though I sat a long time watching.'  
 So he spoke; and I slung my silver-studded sword  
 about my shoulders — the great bronze one — and my bow with it,  
 and ordered him to lead me back by the same way.  
 But he seized me with both hands, clasping my knees,  
 265 and wailing he spoke winged words to me:  
 'Do not take me back there — Zeus-nurtured — against my will. Leave  
 me here.  
 For I know it: you will not come back yourself, and you will not bring  
 one of your companions. No — with these men here, quickly,  
 let us run: we may still escape the evil day.'  
 270 So he spoke, and I answered him and said:  
 'Eurylochus — stay here, then, where you are,  
 eating and drinking beside the hollow black ship.  
 But I am going. Hard necessity is on me.'<sup>27</sup>  
 So speaking I went up from the ship and the sea.  
 275 But just as, threading the sacred glens, I was about  
 to reach the great house of Circe of the many drugs,  
 there Hermes of the golden rod met me<sup>28</sup>  
 as I came toward the house — in the likeness of a young man  
 with his first down on his lip, in the loveliest season of youth.  
 280 He clamped a hand on mine, and spoke a word, and named me:  
 'Where now, poor doomed man, alone along the heights,  
 a stranger to the country? Your companions there in Circe's house  
 are penned like pigs, packed in their hidden sties.  
 Is it to free them you are going? You will not come back yourself,

- 285 I tell you: you will only stay there with the others.  
 But come — I will release you from the evil, I will save you.  
 Here. Take this good drug with you into Circe's house —  
 it will keep the evil day away from your head.  
 And I will tell you all the deadly designs of Circe.
- 290 She will mix you a potion, and cast drugs into the dish;  
 but even so she will not have power to bewitch you: the good drug  
 I give you will not let her. And I will tell you everything.  
 The moment Circe strikes at you with her long wand,  
 that instant draw the sharp sword from beside your thigh
- 295 and go for Circe as though you meant to kill her.  
 She will be seized with terror, and invite you to her bed.  
 Do not, then, refuse the bed of the goddess —<sup>29</sup>  
 if you want her to free your companions and host you well —  
 but order her to swear the great oath of the blessed ones
- 300 that she is not planning some new evil against you:  
 lest she strip you naked and make you a coward, an unmanned thing.'  
 So speaking, the slayer of Argus handed me the drug,  
 pulling it out of the ground, and showed me its nature:  
 at the root it was black, but its flower like milk.<sup>30</sup>
- 305 Moly, the gods call it. And it is hard for mortal men  
 to dig — but the gods have power to do all things.  
 Then Hermes went away over the wooded island  
 toward high Olympus; and I went on to the house of Circe,  
 and my heart ran dark with many things as I went.
- 310 I stopped at the doors of the goddess of the lovely hair,  
 and standing there I shouted; and the goddess heard my voice.  
 And she came out at once, and opened the shining doors,  
 and invited me in; and I followed her, grieved at heart.  
 She led me in and seated me on a silver-studded chair,
- 315 beautiful, cunningly worked, with a footstool for my feet,  
 and made me a potion in a golden cup, for me to drink,  
 and slipped a drug in it, with evil purpose in her heart.  
 And when she served it and I drank it off — and it did not bewitch me —  
 she struck me with her wand, and spoke a word, and named me:
- 320 'Off to the sty now. Lie down with the rest of your companions.'  
 So she spoke; and I drew the sharp sword from beside my thigh

and went for Circe as though I meant to kill her.

And she shrieked, and ran under the blade, and seized my knees,  
and wailing she spoke winged words to me:

325 'What man are you, and from where? Where are your city and your  
parents?'<sup>31</sup>

Wonder holds me: you drank these drugs and were not bewitched —  
and no other man, no, not one, has withstood these drugs  
once he drank them, once they passed the fence of his teeth.  
The mind in your breast is proof against enchantment.

330 Surely you are Odysseus — the man of many turnings — whom<sup>32</sup>  
the golden-rodded slayer of Argus always told me would come,  
on his way home from Troy in his fast black ship.

Come now — put your sword in its sheath, and let the two of us  
mount my bed together, so that mingled there

335 in the bed of love, we may come to trust one another.'

So she spoke, and I answered her and said:

'Circe — how can you bid me be gentle with you?

You who turned my companions into pigs in your own halls,  
and keep me here, and — scheming still — invite me

340 to your chamber, to climb into your bed,  
so that stripped naked I may be made a coward, an unmanned thing.

I will not consent to climb into your bed  
unless you bring yourself, goddess, to swear me the great oath<sup>33</sup>  
that you are not planning some new evil against me.'

345 So I spoke, and she swore it at once, as I demanded.

And when she had sworn, and made an end of the oath,  
then I mounted the surpassingly beautiful bed of Circe.<sup>34</sup>

Meanwhile four handmaids were busy through the halls —  
the serving-women who keep her house in order,

350 daughters of the springs and the groves<sup>35</sup>  
and the sacred rivers that flow out to the sea.

One of them threw beautiful covers over the chairs,  
purple above, with linen spread beneath;  
another drew silver tables up before the chairs

355 and set out golden baskets on them;  
the third mixed honey-hearted wine, sweet wine,  
in a silver bowl, and set out golden cups;

- and the fourth brought water and kindled a great fire  
under a huge cauldron, and the water warmed.
- 360 And when the water boiled in the bright bronze,  
she set me in the tub and bathed me from the great cauldron,  
tempering it to my liking, pouring it over my head and shoulders,  
until she had taken the heart-wasting weariness from my limbs.  
And when she had bathed me and rubbed me richly with oil,
- 365 and thrown a beautiful cloak around me, and a tunic,  
she led me in and seated me on a silver-studded chair,  
beautiful, cunningly worked, with a footstool for my feet;  
and a handmaid brought water for my hands in a pitcher,  
a beautiful golden one, and poured it over a silver basin
- 370 for me to wash, and drew up a polished table beside me.  
The grave housekeeper brought bread and set it before me,  
laying out delicacies in plenty, giving gladly of her store,  
and pressed me to eat. But my heart was not in it:  
I sat with my thoughts elsewhere, and my spirit boded evil.
- 375 And when Circe saw me sitting there, not reaching  
my hands to the bread, gripped in a strong grief,  
she came near, and spoke winged words to me:  
'Why do you sit like this, Odysseus, like a man struck dumb,  
eating your heart, and touching neither food nor drink?
- 380 Do you suspect some other snare? You have no cause  
to fear: I have already sworn you the strong oath.'  
So she spoke, and I answered her and said:  
'Circe — what man with any decency in him<sup>36</sup>  
could bear to taste of food and drink
- 385 before his companions were set free, and he saw them with his eyes?  
If you press me in good faith to eat and drink,  
then free them — let my eyes see my trusted companions.'  
So I spoke, and Circe went out through the hall,  
wand in hand, and opened the doors of the sty,
- 390 and drove them out — in the shape of nine-year fattened hogs.  
They stood there facing her; and she went among them  
anointing each with another drug;  
and the bristles the baleful drug had grown on them —  
the drug the lady Circe gave them — dropped from their limbs,

- 395 and they were men again — younger than they were before,<sup>37</sup>  
 far more beautiful, and taller to the eye.  
 They knew me; and each man clung to my hands;  
 and a passionate weeping came over us all, and the house  
 rang terribly around us; and the goddess herself was moved to pity.
- 400 She came close beside me and spoke, shining among goddesses:  
 'Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices —  
 go now to your fast ship and the shore of the sea.  
 First of all, haul the ship up onto dry land,  
 and stow your goods and all the tackle in the caves;  
 405 then come back yourself, and bring your trusted companions.'  
 So she spoke, and my proud heart consented.  
 I went my way to the fast ship and the shore of the sea,  
 and there by the fast ship I found my trusted companions  
 in pitiful lamentation, letting the big tears fall.
- 410 As when farmyard calves around the herded cows<sup>38</sup>  
 that come back to the dung-yard, filled with grazing,  
 all skip and frisk to meet them — the pens no longer  
 hold them, but lowing without pause they run  
 around their mothers: so those men, when their eyes took me in,  
 415 poured around me weeping. And to their hearts it felt  
 as if they had come to their fatherland, to their very town  
 in rugged Ithaca, where they were bred and born.  
 And wailing, they spoke winged words to me:  
 'At your return, Zeus-nurtured, we rejoice  
 420 as if we had come home to Ithaca, our fathers' land.  
 But come — tell the destruction of the other companions.'  
 So they spoke, and I answered with soft words:  
 'First of all, let us haul the ship up onto dry land,  
 and stow our goods and all the tackle in the caves;  
 425 then bestir yourselves, all of you, and come with me,  
 so you may see our companions in the sacred halls of Circe,  
 eating and drinking: what they have never fails.'  
 So I spoke, and they quickly heeded my words.  
 Only Eurylochus tried to hold back all my companions,  
 430 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to them:

'Poor fools — where are we going? Why do you hanker after these evils  
—<sup>39</sup>

to go down into Circe's hall, who will turn  
every one of us into pigs or wolves or lions  
to guard her great house for her — and guard it we must —  
435 the way the Cyclops did his work, when our companions  
came to his inner yard, and the reckless Odysseus with them:  
it was that man's blind folly killed them too.'  
So he spoke; and I turned it over in my mind —<sup>40</sup>  
whether to draw the long-edged sword from beside my thick thigh,  
440 strike off his head and bring it down in the dust,  
kinsman by marriage though he was, and a close one. But my  
companions  
held me back with honeyed words, this one and that one:  
'Zeus-born — this man, if you command it, we will leave  
here by the ship, to stay and guard the ship;  
445 lead the rest of us to the sacred house of Circe.'  
So speaking they went up from the ship and the sea;  
and Eurylochus was not left behind by the hollow ship —  
he followed. For he feared my terrible rebuke.

Meanwhile, in her house, Circe had bathed the other companions  
450 with kind care, and rubbed them richly with oil,  
and thrown about them fleecy cloaks and tunics,  
and we found them all feasting well in the halls.  
And when the men saw one another, face to face, and knew each other,  
they wept and lamented, and the house rang round them.  
455 And she came close beside me and spoke, shining among goddesses:<sup>41</sup>  
'No more of this swelling lament now. I know it myself —  
all you have suffered on the fish-filled sea,  
all the harm lawless men have done you on dry land.  
460 Come now: eat your food, and drink your wine,  
until you gather back the spirit in your breasts  
that was yours when you first left your fathers' land  
of rugged Ithaca. Now you are withered, spiritless,  
forever brooding on the misery of your wandering — your hearts  
465 never in the feast, for truly you have suffered much.'  
So she spoke, and our proud hearts consented.

So there, day after day, for the full round of a year,<sup>42</sup>  
 we sat feasting on meat past counting and sweet wine.  
 But when the year was out, and the seasons turned in their wheel,  
 470 as the months waned and the long days came round,  
 then my trusted companions called me out, and said:  
 'You are possessed! It is time to remember your fatherland —<sup>43</sup>  
 if it is truly decreed that you be saved, and come  
 to your high-roofed house and your own fatherland.'  
 475 So they spoke, and my proud heart consented.  
 So then all day long till the setting of the sun  
 we sat feasting on meat past counting and sweet wine;  
 and when the sun went down and the dusk came on,  
 the men lay down to sleep through the shadowy halls,  
 480 but I climbed into the surpassingly beautiful bed of Circe  
 and clasped her knees in supplication; and the goddess heard my voice.  
 And lifting my voice I spoke winged words to her:  
 'Circe — make good now the promise that you made me,  
 to send me home. My spirit strains for it already,  
 485 and my companions' too: they wear my heart away,  
 mourning around me whenever you are elsewhere.'  
 So I spoke, and she answered at once, shining among goddesses:  
 'Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices:  
 stay no longer in my house against your will.  
 490 But there is another journey you must accomplish first: you must go  
 down<sup>44</sup>  
 to the house of Hades and dread Persephone  
 to consult the ghost of Theban Tiresias,  
 the blind seer, whose mind stands fast:  
 to him, even dead, Persephone has granted understanding —  
 495 to him alone the power of thought. The rest flit past as shadows.'<sup>45</sup>  
 So she spoke, and my heart broke within me,  
 and I wept, sitting there on the bed; my heart  
 had no more will to live and see the light of the sun.  
 But when I had had my fill of weeping and writhing,  
 500 then I answered her with words, and said:  
 'Circe — and who will be pilot on that voyage?<sup>46</sup>  
 No man ever yet reached Hades in a black ship.'



So I spoke, and she answered at once, shining among goddesses:  
 'Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices:  
 505 let no lack of a pilot at the ship concern you.  
 Set up the mast, spread the white sails open,  
 and sit: the breath of the North Wind will carry her.  
 But when in your ship you have crossed the stream of Ocean,  
 there is a scrub shore there, and the groves of Persephone —  
 510 tall black poplars, and willows that shed their fruit unripened,<sup>47</sup>  
 Beach the ship there, on Ocean's deep-eddy edge,  
 and go on yourself into the dank house of Hades.  
 There into Acheron pour Pyriphlegethon  
 and Cocytus, which is a branch broken off the water of Styx;  
 515 and there is a rock, at the meeting-roar of the two rivers.  
 Draw close to it there, hero, as I command you,  
 and dig a pit about a cubit's measure this way and that,<sup>48</sup>  
 and around it pour a drink-offering to all the dead —  
 first with milk and honey mingled, then with sweet wine,  
 520 the third time with water; and sprinkle white barley over it.  
 And entreat, over and over, the strengthless heads of the dead:  
 vow that, come to Ithaca, you will offer in your halls  
 a barren heifer, your best, and heap the pyre with good things;  
 and to Tiresias, apart, alone, you will sacrifice a ram  
 525 all black, the one that stands out from all your flocks.  
 Then, when with prayers you have entreated the glorious tribes of the  
 dead,  
 sacrifice a ram and a black ewe,  
 bending their heads toward Erebus — but turn yourself away,  
 facing the river's streams. And there will come, in crowds,  
 530 the souls of the dead who are gone.  
 Then rouse your companions, and command them  
 to flay the sheep that lie there slaughtered by the pitiless bronze,  
 and burn them, and pray to the gods —  
 to mighty Hades and dread Persephone.  
 535 And you: draw the sharp sword from beside your thigh  
 and sit, and do not let the strengthless heads of the dead  
 come near the blood before you question Tiresias.  
 And quickly then the seer will come, leader of peoples,

and he will tell you the road, and the measures of your journey,  
540 and your homecoming — how you shall go over the fish-filled sea.'  
 So she spoke; and at once Dawn of the golden throne came on.  
 She dressed me then in my clothes, a cloak and a tunic,  
 and she, the nymph, put on a great silver-shining mantle,<sup>49</sup>  
 fine-woven and graceful, and cast about her waist a belt,  
545 beautiful, golden, and set a veil on her head above.  
 And I went through the halls and roused my companions  
 with gentle words, standing by each man in turn:  
 'No more lying now, drowsing in sweet sleep.  
 Let us go: the lady Circe has shown me the way.'  
550 So I spoke, and their proud hearts consented.  
 But not even from there could I bring my companions off unharmed.<sup>50</sup>  
 There was one, Elpenor, the youngest of all —  
 no great fighter in war, no steady mind on him —  
 who had lain down apart from his companions in the sacred house of  
 Circe,  
555 heavy with wine, wanting the cool air.  
 Hearing the noise and stir of his companions moving,  
 he leapt up all at once — and forgot, in his fuddled wits,  
 to come back down again by the long ladder;  
 he fell headlong from the roof, and his neck  
560 snapped from the spine; and his soul went down to Hades.  
 And as my men were setting out I spoke among them:  
 'You think, no doubt, that you are going home, to your own  
 dear fatherland. But Circe has marked out another road for us:  
 to the house of Hades and dread Persephone,  
565 to consult the ghost of Theban Tiresias.'  
 So I spoke, and their own hearts broke within them:  
 they sat down right where they were, and wailed, and tore their hair —  
 but nothing came of all their mourning.  
  
 And while we walked to the fast ship and the shore of the sea,  
570 grieving, letting the big tears fall,  
 Circe meanwhile had gone down, and beside the black ship  
 had tethered a ram and a black ewe —  
 slipping past us with ease. Who could see a god<sup>51</sup>  
 against the god's will, moving here or there?



NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 10

- 1    l. 3 A floating island ringed by an unbroken bronze wall: Aeolia is a sealed system, drifting free of the world's map. Everything about the place — the wall, the cliff, the closed marriages, the perpetual feast — is circular and self-contained; the visitor who leaves it twice will find the circle closed against him.
- 2    l. 7 Six sons married to six daughters, feasting forever beside their parents: the incest is reported without a flicker of censure, as divine-household economics (Zeus and Hera are siblings, after all; Alcinous married his niece). Aeolus' family is the wind-system itself — twelve of them, paired and self-contained, going nowhere.
- 3    l. 19 The bag of winds is world folklore (sailors bought wind-knots from witches into the nineteenth century), but Homer's version is precise: Aeolus is Zeus' appointed "steward of the winds," the bag is the flayed hide of a nine-year ox, and the seal is a silver cord. What the companions mistake for treasure is treasure — the only wealth that matters at sea, a fair wind home, packaged.
- 4    l. 27 "We were destroyed by our own folly" — ἀφραδίῃσιν. The ledger-word again, and this time the entry is collective: the catastrophe requires the crew's envy *and* the captain's secrecy (he never told them what was in the bag) *and* his sleep. The poem lets the blame sit distributed and unresolved.
- 5    l. 30 "So near, we could see men tending their fires": ten years of war and ten days of sailing end within sight of the home smoke — and then sleep. The cruelest near-miss in Greek literature, and the poem will do it to him again (he sleeps at Thrinacia while the cattle die, 12.338): both of Odysseus' great disasters begin the moment his vigilance finally fails. The man who cannot delegate (32–33: he held the sheet nine days, "yielding it to no other") is destroyed precisely by the one nap his body forced on him.
- 6    l. 37 The envy speech — the crew's grievance quoted in full, and it is *reasonable*: same war, same road, empty hands, while the captain collects gifts at every port. The poem gives the mutineers a real economics before it gives them their catastrophe; the "evil counsel" (46) is not stupidity but distributive resentment, the plunder-sharing theme (9.42, 549) turned inside out.
- 7    l. 51 The suicide deliberation, weighed in one breath: drown now, or "endure in silence and stay among the living." Then the plainest sentence in the poem: "I endured, and I stayed." The epithet πολύτλας — much-enduring — is earned in exactly these two verbs, with his head covered, saying nothing.
- 8    l. 72 Aeolus' expulsion is the theology of hospitality's limit: "It is against all right (θέμις) for me to harbor... a man the blessed gods detest." A returned gift is proof of divine hatred; the second visit that xenia cannot cover. He is not wrong — Poseidon's curse is on the guest — and he is not kind: the poem lets both stand. Note that the friendly month-long host and the shrieking expeller are the same man; the difference is one piece of evidence.

- 9    *l. 82* Telepylus of the Laestrygonians, "where herdsman hails herdsman" — the night-shepherd coming in as the day-shepherd goes out, "so close together are the paths of night and day," where a sleepless man could earn double wages. Ancients and moderns alike have read the midnight sun of the far north into these lines; whatever the source, the poem uses compressed daylight to signal the world's rim — and the double wage is a laborer's-eye view of the marvel: more light means more work.
- 10   *l. 87* The harbor is described as perfection — sheer shelter, narrow mouth, "a white calm" — and it is a killing-jar. Every feature that makes it safe from waves makes it fatal under thrown stones: no room to scatter, no swell to ride out, one narrow exit. The poem builds the trap out of the very vocabulary of refuge (contrast the goat island's genuinely safe harbor, 9.136–139).
- 11   *l. 95* "I alone held my black ship outside." No reason is given — suspicion, habit, the lookout's instinct — and the silence is the point: this unexplained mooring decision is the entire difference between one surviving ship and eleven destroyed. The poem lets the captain's caution stand as pure practice, not announced wisdom; he does not even claim credit for it in the telling.
- 12   *l. 105* The approach runs the standard arrival sequence — road, girl drawing water at a named spring, directions to the king's house — the exact template that on Scheria (Athena with her pitcher, 7.19ff.) led to welcome. Point-for-point the same protocol, ending in the host eating the guest: the poem re-runs its own hospitality scene as a horror film.
- 13   *l. 120* "Not like men, but like the Giants" — the third appearance of the Giants at the world's edges: the Phaeacians and Cyclopes are named their kin (7.205–206), and the Laestrygonians are merely *likened* to them here. The far world keeps monstrous company, and the Phaeacians are its one civilized branch.
- 14   *l. 124* "Spearing them like fish, they carried home their loathsome meal." Eleven ships' companies — the poem's greatest single loss, greater than everything Poseidon ever does — dispatched in one line with a fishing simile. The economy is deliberate: the horror is industrial, a harvest. After the refrain at 133–134, "we" means one ship's company, and every later "we" in the Odyssey is the survivors of this harbor.
- 15   *l. 133* The refrain returns exactly as after the Cicones — but now it closes the loss of the fleet. The identical formula for six men and for five hundred: grief in this poem is a liturgy, not an arithmetic.
- 16   *l. 136* Circe: "dread goddess with a mortal's voice" (αὐδήεσσα — the same word that marked Ino, 5.334): a divinity who speaks human speech, which is precisely her danger. Daughter of Helios the all-seeing, sister of Aetes (keeper of the Golden Fleece — one line of genealogy quietly hooks the Odyssey into the Argonaut saga). Her island is where the sun's family lodges at the world's eastern rim.
- 17   *l. 153* The deliberation runs captain-fashion: dinner for the crew first, reconnaissance second. After the Laestrygonian harbor, his procedure has visibly hardened — feed them, scout in force, split the company by lot. The Circe episode opens as a study in learned command.

- 18 l. 158 The stag "some god" sends: providence as protein. The scene is pure hunter's vignette — the beast heavy with the sun's heat coming down to drink, the spine-shot, the plaited withy rope, the carry across the neck with the spear for a staff — and its function is morale: the captain who cannot yet free anyone can at least feed everyone. His twice-repeated wonder ("he was a very great beast," 171, 180) is a hunter's honest pride, kept intact in the retelling.
- 19 l. 190 "We do not know where the dark is, or where the dawn": total loss of orientation — east and west themselves gone. For a sailor this is annihilation; no course can exist. And from the master of devices, the bleakest sentence he speaks in the poem: "whether any device (μήτις) is left us. I do not believe there is." The mētis-hero declaring mētis bankrupt — the episode's true low point, before any magic happens.
- 20 l. 202 "Nothing came of all their mourning" — the line will recur verbatim at 568. Twice in one book the poem lets grief run and then audits it: zero. Not contempt — the weeping is always allowed first — but the survivor's bookkeeping.
- 21 l. 205 Eurylochus enters: leader of the second search party, kinsman by marriage (441), and the poem's licensed dissenter. The lots are shaken in a helmet — command decisions by fair chance once again — and his lot "jumped out": the man who will refuse the house is chosen by luck to find it.
- 22 l. 212 The wolves and lions "fawning like dogs around their master coming from a feast" — the most unsettling tameness in Homer. The simile's content is domestic comfort (the master, the treats, the wagging); the reality is predators chemically stripped of themselves. Drugged docility wearing the image of home — Circe's whole island in one picture.
- 23 l. 221 Circe at her great loom, singing — the identical posture in which Hermes found Calypso (5.61–62): the divine woman weaving and singing alone at the world's edge. The loom is the island goddess's signature — and weaving is this poem's other name for plotting.
- 24 l. 234 The kykeon — Pramnian wine, grated cheese, barley, pale honey — is a real archaic posset (Nestor drinks nearly the identical mixture in *Iliad* 11.624ff.). The horror is served in comfort food: the drug rides in on the taste of home, and its stated purpose is the lotus-purpose — "to make them wholly forget their fathers' land."
- 25 l. 240 "But their minds stayed steady, exactly as before" — νοῦς ἔμπεδος: the transformation's exquisite cruelty. Pig body, human mind, weeping in the sty over acorns. Circe's magic inverts the lotus exactly: the lotus left the body free and dissolved the will; the wand keeps the will intact inside a body that cannot use it. Between them the two islands map the poem's whole anatomy of the self.
- 26 l. 251 Eurylochus' report repeats the narrative almost line for line — Homeric messenger-convention, but with one adjustment: "I stayed behind, suspecting a snare" becomes his signature. He is the man who is right about danger and wrong about everything to do in its presence: correct to suspect, correct to survive — and paralyzed, speechless, and finally mutinous on the strength of it.

- 27 l. 273 "But I am going. Hard necessity is on me." — κρατερὴ δέ μοι ἔπλετ' ἀνάγκη. No plan exists yet; the sword and bow he slings on are props against sorcery. The captain's necessity is not strategy but obligation: twenty-two men in a sty. The rescue begins as pure duty walking uphill.
- 28 l. 277 Hermes as a youth "with his first down on his lip, in the loveliest season of youth" — the god's favorite mortal disguise (so he meets Priam in *Iliad* 24), met on a path here exactly as his Olympian errands frame the poem (Books 1, 5). His speech does something unique in the apologoi: it scripts the future in detail — potion, wand, sword-rush, bed, oath — and the scene then executes the script beat for beat. Odysseus survives Aeaea the way an actor survives a play: by knowing the lines in advance.
- 29 l. 297 "Do not refuse the bed of the goddess" — the instruction no other epic would give its hero as tactical advice, complete with the safeguard oath and the stated risk: "lest she strip you naked and make you a coward, an unmanned thing" (κακὸν καὶ ἀνήνορα — the emasculation fear said straight out). Divine sex here is an instrument of policy with a liability clause. The oath-formula is Calypso's from 5.178–179, verbatim — but repurposed: there it guarded a departure plan against a trap; only here is the contract language brought to a goddess's bed.
- 30 l. 304 Moly: black at the root, flower like milk, "hard for mortal men to dig — but the gods have power to do all things." The most famous plant in Western literature, and the poem never shows it working: no brandishing, no antidote-drinking dramatized — Circe's drug simply fails (318). But Hermes is explicit about the cause: the good drug he gives "will not allow" her enchantment (291–292) — counter-magic that operates invisibly, its working as hidden as its name. Identifications (snowdrop? rue?) have been guessed at for millennia; "the gods call it" moly — its true name is not in mortal vocabulary at all.
- 31 l. 325 Beaten, Circe reaches for the poem's standard identity-question — "What man are you, and from where? Where are your city and your parents?" (=1.170) — and then answers it herself. The interrogation formula that every host asks becomes, in her mouth, recognition.
- 32 l. 330 "Surely you are Odysseus — the man of many turnings" — πολύτροπος. The poem's first epithet for its hero (1.1), used *nowhere else in the poem except these two places*. The word the poet chose to open the *Odyssey* is spoken inside it only once — by the witch, at the moment her drugs fail — as if only she and the Muse know his true name-tag. Hermes had foretold him to her: the trap and the marriage of minds were both scheduled.
- 33 l. 343 He answers her invitation with the oath-demand he once made to Calypso, verbatim (5.178–179 = 10.343–344) — same words, new work: there the oath safeguarded his passage home; only here does it stand guard over a bed. The hero's consistency across islands is itself formulaic — the poem's way of saying this is *procedure*, not romance.
- 34 l. 347 "Then I mounted the surpassingly beautiful bed of Circe." Consent, stated plainly, after terms. The poem never equates Aeaea with Ogygia: with Calypso he wept daily on the shore, "unwilling man by willing goddess" (5.155); here he bargains, beds, and stays a

year without a recorded tear — until the crew intervenes. The difference is not virtue but liberty: Circe's door, after the oath, is open.

- 35 l. 350 Circe's four handmaids are daughters "of the springs and the groves and the sacred rivers": nymphs of wild water doing housework — the wilderness itself domesticated into table-service, exactly as the wolves are domesticated into dogs. On Aeaea nature is staff.
- 36 l. 383 The refusal of food until the companions are freed — from the man who preached the tyranny of the belly at 7.215ff. The one force in the poem that outranks the γαστήρ is φιλότης; he will not eat in front of the sty. Circe yields, and the counter-drug scene (388–396) is the book's hinge from horror to healing.
- 37 l. 395 Restored, they come back "younger... more beautiful, and taller": Circe's magic overshoots mere reversal into rejuvenation. The gift previews the year of ease to come — Aeaea, once its terms are settled, is a spa. The weeping reunion that follows (397–399) moves even the goddess: "the house rang terribly" is the same phrase-world as grief's other outbreaks, and she pities what she caused.
- 38 l. 410 The calves simile: penned calves breaking loose to frisk around the returning herd, "lowing without pause" — homecoming in miniature, complete with the poem's own gloss: "as if they had come to their fatherland." Every joy in the Odyssey is measured on the nostos-scale; the crew's relief at seeing one man alive registers as a rehearsal of Ithaca.
- 39 l. 431 Eurylochus' mutiny speech reaches its climax in the poem's most loaded word: our companions died at the Cyclops' yard "by that man's ἀτασθαλίῃσιν" — *recklessness*, the poem's term for the crew's own fatal folly (1.7) and Zeus' term for mortal self-destruction (1.34). Hurlled at the captain by his own kinsman, and the poem lets the counter-indictment stand unanswered: from inside the crew, the six dead in the cave were the price of one man's curiosity. Both ledgers — the poem's and Eurylochus' — remain open to the end.
- 40 l. 438 The captain's response to the accusation is nearly a beheading — of a close kinsman by marriage — checked only by the crew's plea. The poem does not flinch from what command has become by mid-voyage: the sword-reflex against internal dissent, one honeyed-word intervention away from kin-murder. That the accusation had truth in it is exactly what made the sword move.
- 41 l. 455 Here the translation follows Murray's text, which omits the traditional line 456 (a variant of the "she came close and spoke" formula); the line-numbering accordingly steps from 455 to 457, as in the Greek.
- 42 l. 467 A year, in three lines. The man who refused an immortal's eternity loses twelve months to a comfortable enchantress without noticing — no spell alleged, just meat, sweet wine, and a beautiful bed. Comfort is the drug that needs no drug: the lotus in its most respectable form.
- 43 l. 472 "You are possessed! It is time to remember your fatherland." The great role-reversal: the crew de-lotuses the captain. The men he dragged weeping from the lotus and bound under the benches (9.98–99) now perform the same rescue on him, with a



word — δαίμόνιε, "you are possessed" — that treats his contentment as the seizure it is. The poem's fairness to the companions peaks here: they are the keepers of the nostos this once, and he consents with the same formula he used for their good advice.

- 44 l. 490 "You must go down to the house of Hades" — the sentence that breaks him flat on the bed, wishing not to live. The road home runs through the country no black ship has ever reached; the homecoming must first pass through death. Structurally this is the poem's center of gravity: Circe, keeper of the eastern threshold, sets the itinerary that makes Book 11 the pivot of the entire epic.
- 45 l. 495 Tiresias "whose mind stands fast... to him alone the power of thought. The rest flit past as shadows." Homeric death-psychology in two lines: the dead lose νόος, coherent mind, and become fluttering shades; Persephone's grant to Tiresias is the single exemption. This is the metaphysics the whole Nekyia will run on — held with a poet's looseness: Elpenor talks before any blood is poured, and the rite's drink restores recognition and memory more than bare speech.
- 46 l. 501 The sailor's objection to metaphysics: fine — *who pilots?* "No man ever yet reached Hades in a black ship." Even at the threshold of the underworld, Odysseus' first question is navigational. Circe's answer keeps the register: set the mast, sit down, the North Wind does it. The land of the dead has a sailing direction: downwind, all the way.
- 47 l. 510 Persephone's groves: black poplars and "willows that shed their fruit unripened" — trees of barrenness for the country of the unfulfilled dead. The catalogue of underworld rivers (Pyriphlegethon "fire-blazing," Cocytus "wailing," branch of Styx "the hateful") flows into Acheron by a rock at "the meeting-roar": Greek eschatology's entire river-map, given as pilotage.
- 48 l. 517 The necromantic rite (517–540) is the oldest full necromancy in Greek literature, and it is *ritual*, not magic: a cubit-square pit, triple libation (honeyed milk, wine, water), white barley, vows of future sacrifice, black victims bled with heads bent toward Erebus, the officiant's face averted, and the drawn sword rationing the blood to which the strengthless dead will crowd. Every detail was studied by ancient religion and echoed by every later katabasis. Circe delivers it as she delivered the sailing directions: precisely, and without comment.
- 49 l. 543 Circe dresses in Calypso's exact wardrobe — the great silver-shining mantle, golden belt, veil (= 5.230–232, line for line). The two island goddesses share a formulaic dressing-scene as they share an oath-scene: the poem builds them as variations on one figure — and the differences (consent, release, help freely given) stand out the sharper against the identical clothes.
- 50 l. 551 Elpenor: "the youngest of all — no great fighter in war, no steady mind on him." Drunk, he slept on the cool roof; woke at the bustle; forgot the ladder; broke his neck. The obituary is three understatements and a fall — the least heroic death in epic, refused none of the poem's care. His unburied ghost will be the first to meet Odysseus in Hades (11.51ff.), before Tiresias, before his own mother: the poem's ethics of burial made plot. On the island of enchantments, the killer is wine and a ladder.
- 51 l. 573 The book closes on a small theological shiver: Circe has passed them invisibly to tether the black victims at the ship — "Who could see a god against the god's will,

moving here or there?" The narrating Odysseus generalizes from his own tale: divinity is seen only by consent (Athena will state the doctrine at 16.161). It is the apologoi's quiet epistemology — the gods move through these stories exactly as visibly as they choose — offered as a sailor's shrug on the way to the land of the dead.

## Odyssey — Book 11

*The dead: Tiresias' prophecy, Anticleia, the heroines, Agamemnon,  
Achilles, Ajax.*

And when we had come down to the ship and the sea,  
first of all we hauled the ship down to the bright salt water,  
and set the mast and the sails in the black ship,  
and took the sheep and put them aboard, and ourselves  
5 went aboard grieving, letting the big tears fall.  
And for us, behind the dark-blue-prowed ship,  
a following wind that filled the sail, a good companion,  
was sent by Circe of the lovely braids, dread goddess with a mortal's  
voice.  
So when we had seen to the tackle through the ship,  
10 we sat, and the wind and the steersman held her on course.  
All day long her sail was stretched as she crossed the water;  
and the sun went down, and all the ways grew dark.<sup>1</sup>

She came to the limits of deep-flowing Ocean.  
There is the land and city of the Cimmerian men,<sup>2</sup>  
15 shrouded in mist and cloud: never does the shining  
sun look down on them with his rays,  
not when he climbs toward the starry heaven,  
not when he turns back from heaven to earth,  
but deadly night is stretched over wretched mortals.  
20 Coming there we beached the ship, and took out the sheep,  
and walked along the stream of Ocean  
until we came to the place that Circe had appointed.

There Perimedes and Eurylochus held the victims,<sup>3</sup>  
and I drew the sharp sword from beside my thigh  
25 and dug a pit about a cubit's measure this way and that,  
and around it I poured a drink-offering to all the dead —  
first with milk and honey mingled, then with sweet wine,  
the third time with water; and I sprinkled white barley over it.  
And I entreated, over and over, the strengthless heads of the dead:

- 30 vowing that, come to Ithaca, I would offer in my halls  
 a barren heifer, my best, and heap the pyre with good things;  
 and to Tiresias, apart, alone, I would sacrifice a ram  
 all black, the one that stands out from all our flocks.  
 And when with vows and prayers I had entreated them,  
 35 the tribes of the dead, I took the sheep and cut their throats  
 over the pit, and the dark-clouded blood ran; and they gathered,  
 the souls of the dead who are gone, up out of Erebus:<sup>4</sup>  
 brides, and unwed youths, and old men worn by long suffering,  
 and tender girls with the fresh grief on their hearts,  
 40 and many men gashed by the bronze-tipped spears,  
 men killed in war, in armor caked with their blood.  
 In crowds from every side they came flocking about the pit  
 with a sound that had no earthly likeness; and the pale terror took me.  
 Then I roused my companions, and commanded them  
 45 to flay the sheep that lay there slaughtered by the pitiless bronze,  
 and burn them, and pray to the gods —  
 to mighty Hades and dread Persephone;  
 and I myself, drawing the sharp sword from beside my thigh,  
 sat there, and would not let the strengthless heads of the dead  
 50 come near the blood before I had questioned Tiresias.

- First came the soul of my companion Elpenor,<sup>5</sup>  
 for he was not yet buried under the wide-wayed earth:  
 we had left his body behind in Circe's hall,  
 unwept and unburied, since another task was driving us.  
 55 I wept to see him, and my heart pitied him,  
 and lifting my voice I spoke winged words to him:  
 'Elpenor — how did you come here, under the misty dark?  
 You have outstripped me — on foot, and I in my black ship.'<sup>6</sup>  
 So I spoke, and he groaned aloud, and answered:  
 60 'Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices,  
 the evil doom of a god blinded me — that, and wine past measure.<sup>7</sup>  
 Lying down to sleep in Circe's hall, I never thought  
 to come back down again by the long ladder;  
 I fell headlong from the roof, and my neck  
 65 snapped from the spine; and my soul came down to Hades.  
 Now I beg you — by those left behind, those not here beside us:

by your wife; by your father, who reared you when you were small;  
by Telemachus, whom you left an only child in your halls.

For I know that when you go from here, from the house of Hades,  
70 you will put in again with your well-made ship at the island of Aeaea:  
there, my lord, I charge you: remember me.

Do not go on and leave me behind you unwept, unburied,<sup>8</sup>  
turning away — lest I become a cause of gods' wrath against you —  
but burn me with all the armor that is mine,

75 and heap me a mound on the shore of the gray salt sea:  
an unlucky man's marker, for men to come to learn of.

Accomplish this for me — and fix upon the mound the oar<sup>9</sup>  
I rowed with when I lived, when I was among my companions.'

So he spoke, and I answered him and said:

80 'All this, poor luckless man, I will accomplish and do.'

So the two of us sat trading grim words,  
I on one side, holding my sword over the blood,  
and across from me the phantom of my companion, talking on.

Then came the soul of my dead mother,<sup>10</sup>

85 Anticleia, daughter of great-hearted Autolycus,  
whom I had left alive when I went to holy Ilium.  
I wept to see her, and my heart pitied her;  
but even so, for all my thick grief, I would not let her  
come near the blood before I had questioned Tiresias.

90 Then came the soul of Theban Tiresias,  
holding a golden scepter; and he knew me, and spoke:<sup>11</sup>  
'Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices —  
what now, unlucky man? Why have you left the light of the sun  
and come to see the dead, and this place without joy?

95 Draw back from the pit; hold off your sharp sword,  
so that I may drink of the blood, and tell you the unerring truth.'  
So he spoke, and I stepped back, and drove the silver-studded sword  
home in its sheath. And when he had drunk the dark blood,  
then at last the blameless seer addressed me:

100 'It is honey-sweet homecoming you seek, shining Odysseus,  
and a god will make it grim for you. For I do not think  
the shaker of earth will fail to see you — the grudge is set in his heart,

- raging because you blinded his dear son.  
 Yet even so, though you suffer evils, you may still come home,  
 105 if you are willing to hold hard your own heart and your companions',  
 from the hour when you first bring your well-made ship  
 in to the island Thrinacia, escaping the violet sea,  
 and find at pasture there the cattle and the strong flocks  
 of Helios, who sees all things and hears all things.<sup>12</sup>  
 110 If you leave them unharmed, and keep your mind on homecoming,  
 then you may yet reach Ithaca, though you suffer evils.  
 But if you harm them, then I foretell destruction  
 for ship and companions; and even if you yourself escape,  
 late you will come, and in evil case, all companions lost,<sup>13</sup>  
 115 on another man's ship; and you will find trouble in your house —  
 overweening men, who eat away your living,  
 courting your godlike wife and offering bride-gifts.  
 Yet, truly, you will come and repay their violence.  
 And when you have killed the suitors in your halls,  
 120 whether by guile or in the open, with the sharp bronze,  
 then go on a journey, taking a well-shaped oar,<sup>14</sup>  
 until you come to men who know nothing of the sea,  
 men who eat no food that is mixed with salt,  
 who know nothing of red-cheeked ships,  
 125 nothing of well-shaped oars, which are wings for ships.  
 And I will tell you a sign, unmistakable: it will not escape you.  
 When another traveler, meeting you on the road,  
 says you carry a winnowing-fan on your shining shoulder,<sup>15</sup>  
 then and there fix the well-shaped oar in the earth  
 130 and offer fine victims to the lord Poseidon —  
 a ram, a bull, and a boar that has mounted sows —  
 and turn away home, and offer holy hecatombs  
 to the deathless gods who hold wide heaven,  
 to all of them, each in order. And death will come to you  
 135 from the sea, so gentle a death, and take you<sup>16</sup>  
 worn down under sleek old age; and around you the peoples  
 will be prosperous. This I tell you is unerring truth.'  
 So he spoke, and I answered him and said:  
 'Tiresias — all that, no doubt, the gods themselves have spun.'<sup>17</sup>

- 140 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly.  
 I see here the soul of my dead mother:  
 she sits in silence near the blood, and cannot bring herself  
 to look her own son in the face, or speak to him.  
 Tell me, lord: how may she know me for the man I am?'
- 145 So I spoke, and he answered me at once:  
 'An easy word I will tell you, and set it in your mind.  
 Whomever of the dead who are gone you allow  
 to come near the blood, that one will speak you truth;  
 whomever you begrudge it, that one will draw back and go.'
- 150 So speaking, the soul of the lord Tiresias went back  
 into the house of Hades, when he had told out the decrees of fate.  
 But I stayed rooted where I was until my mother  
 came and drank the dark-clouded blood. And at once she knew me,  
 and wailing she spoke winged words to me:
- 155 'My child — how did you come here, under the misty dark,  
 alive? Hard it is for the living to look on all this:  
 for between lie great rivers, and terrible waters —  
 Ocean first of all, which there is no crossing on foot,  
 never, unless a man has a well-made ship.
- 160 Are you only now come wandering here from Troy —  
 after all this time — with ship and companions? Have you not yet  
 been to Ithaca — not seen your wife in your own halls?'  
 So she spoke, and I answered her and said:  
 'Mother, need brought me down to Hades:
- 165 to consult the soul of Theban Tiresias.  
 For not yet have I come near Achaea — not yet  
 set foot on our own land; I have wandered without pause, in misery,  
 since the day I first followed noble Agamemnon  
 toward Ilium of the fine horses, to fight the Trojans.
- 170 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:  
 what doom of death, that lays men low, mastered you?<sup>18</sup>  
 A long illness? Or did Artemis the arrow-pourer  
 come with her gentle arrows, and kill you?  
 And tell me of my father, and the son I left behind:
- 175 does my honor still rest safe with them, or does some other  
 man hold it now — do they say I will come home no more?

- And tell me the mind and purpose of my wedded wife:  
 does she stay by the boy and keep all things safe?  
 Or has the best man of the Achaeans married her already?'  
 180 So I spoke, and at once my honored mother answered:  
 'Oh yes — she stays, and more: with an enduring heart<sup>19</sup>  
 she is there in your halls; and always in misery  
 her nights waste away, and her days, in tears.  
 Your fine honor no man holds yet: at his ease  
 185 Telemachus farms the estates unchallenged, and feasts  
 at the equal banquets it is fitting a lawgiving man should tend:  
 for all men issue him the summons. But your father stays out there  
 on the farm, and never comes down to the city. Bedding  
 he has none — no bedstead, no cloaks, no shining blankets:  
 190 through the winter he sleeps where the slaves do, in the house,  
 in the ashes by the fire, and puts poor clothing on his skin;  
 but when summer comes, and the heavy autumn,  
 then anywhere along the rise of his vineyard plot  
 a bed of fallen leaves is thrown on the ground for him,  
 195 and there he lies grieving, and the sorrow grows great in his heart,  
 aching for your homecoming; and hard old age comes on him.<sup>20</sup>  
 And so it was with me: so I too died and met my doom.  
 Not in the halls did the keen-eyed arrow-pourer  
 come with her gentle arrows and kill me;  
 200 no illness fell upon me, of the kind that most often  
 draws the life from the limbs in hateful wasting:  
 no — it was longing for you, your counsels, shining Odysseus,  
 your gentle-heartedness, that robbed me of honey-sweet life.<sup>21</sup>  
 So she spoke; and I, my mind stirred, longed  
 205 to take the soul of my dead mother in my arms.  
 Three times I started toward her, and my heart bade me hold her;<sup>22</sup>  
 three times, out of my hands, like a shadow or a dream  
 she flew. And the grief grew sharper in my heart each time,  
 and lifting my voice I spoke winged words to her:  
 210 'Mother — why will you not stay for me, when I long to hold you,  
 so that even here in Hades, throwing our arms around each other,  
 the two of us might take our fill of icy mourning?  
 Or is this a phantom queenly Persephone



- has sent me, so that I may weep and groan the more?'
- 215 So I spoke, and at once my honored mother answered:  
 'Ah me, my child, luckless beyond all mortal men —  
 in no way does Persephone, the daughter of Zeus, deceive you:  
 this is the settled way of mortals, when one dies.<sup>23</sup>  
 The sinews no longer hold the flesh and bones together:  
 220 all that, the strong fury of the blazing fire  
 breaks down, as soon as the life has left the white bones,  
 and the soul flits away like a dream, and hovers.  
 But press on toward the light, as fast as you can. And mark  
 all these things — to tell them to your wife hereafter.<sup>124</sup>
- 225 So the two of us traded words. And then the women  
 came — for queenly Persephone sent them on —<sup>25</sup>  
 all who had been the wives and daughters of the great.  
 They came flocking in crowds around the dark blood,  
 and I considered how I might question each in turn.
- 230 And this, as I turned it over, seemed to me the best plan:  
 drawing the long-edged sword from beside my thick thigh,  
 I would not let them drink the dark blood all together.  
 So they came up one by one, in file, and each declared  
 her lineage; and I questioned them all.
- 235 There the first I saw was Tyro, born of a noble father,<sup>26</sup>  
 who said she was the child of blameless Salmoneus,  
 and called herself the wife of Cretheus, Aeolus' son.  
 She fell in love with a river — divine Enipeus,  
 far the most beautiful of rivers flowing on the earth —  
 240 and she would haunt Enipeus' beautiful streams.  
 And the earth-holder, the shaker of earth, took the river's likeness  
 and lay beside her at the mouths of the eddying water;  
 and a dark-gleaming wave stood up around them, mountain-high,  
 arched over, and hid the god and the mortal woman.
- 245 He loosed the girdle of her maidenhood, and poured sleep over her.  
 And when the god had finished the works of love,  
 he clamped a hand on hers, and spoke a word, and named her:  
 'Rejoice in this love, woman. As the year turns round  
 you will bear glorious children — for the beds of the immortals

- 250 are not fruitless. Tend them, and rear them.  
 Now go home, and hold your peace, and name no name.  
 But know it: I am Poseidon, shaker of the earth.'  
 So speaking he plunged under the surging sea.  
 And she conceived, and bore Pelias and Neleus,  
 255 who both grew to be strong servants of great Zeus;  
 Pelias lived in wide-dancing-grounded Iolcus,  
 rich in flocks, and Neleus in sandy Pylos.  
 And her other sons this queen among women bore to Cretheus:  
 Aeson, and Pheres, and Amythaon the chariot-fighter.
- 260 After her I saw Antiope, Asopus' daughter,  
 who could boast she had slept in the very arms of Zeus,  
 and she bore two sons, Amphion and Zethus,  
 who first founded the seat of seven-gated Thebes<sup>27</sup>  
 and walled it round — for without walls they could not  
 265 live in wide-dancing-grounded Thebes, strong though they were.  
 After her I saw Alcmene, Amphitryon's wife,  
 who bore Heracles, the lion-hearted, bold in the fight,  
 after she lay mingled in the arms of great Zeus;  
 and Megara, daughter of high-spirited Creon,  
 270 whom Amphitryon's son held as wife — the man whose strength never  
 wore.  
 And I saw the mother of Oedipus, beautiful Epicaste,<sup>28</sup>  
 who did a monstrous thing in the ignorance of her mind,  
 marrying her own son; and he, who had killed his father,  
 married her; and the gods made it known among men at once.
- 275 Yet he ruled on over the Cadmeians in lovely Thebes,  
 suffering pains, through the gods' deadly designs;  
 and she went down to the house of Hades, strong warden of the gate,  
 fastening a noose to hang sheer from the high roof-beam,  
 gripped by her anguish — and left behind for him the pains  
 280 past counting that a mother's Furies bring to pass.  
 And I saw Chloris, beautiful past telling, whom Neleus once  
 married for her beauty, bringing bride-gifts past number:  
 youngest daughter of Amphion, Iasus' son,  
 who once ruled in strength in Minyan Orchomenus.  
 285 She was queen of Pylos, and bore him shining children:

- Nestor, and Chromius, and lordly Periclymenus,  
 and after them she bore that wonder of mortals, strong Pero,<sup>29</sup>  
 whom all the neighboring men were courting; but Neleus  
 would give her to no man who could not drive off
- 290 the crook-horned, broad-browed cattle of mighty Iphicles  
 out of Phylace — a dangerous herd. Only the blameless seer  
 undertook to drive them; and the hard doom of a god bound him fast,  
 the cruel bonds, and the herdsmen of the wild.  
 But when at last the months and the days were coming to fulfillment,
- 295 as the year rolled round and the seasons came again,  
 then at last mighty Iphicles set him free,  
 when he had told out all the decrees of fate. And the design of Zeus was  
 accomplished.
- And I saw Leda, wife of Tyndareus,  
 who bore to Tyndareus two strong-hearted sons:
- 300 Castor the horse-breaker, and Polydeuces good with his fists.  
 These two the life-giving earth holds — both of them living:<sup>30</sup>  
 even under the earth they have honor from Zeus,  
 and live turn about, one day each in turn,  
 and each in turn are dead. They have won honor equal to the gods'.
- 305 After her I saw Iphimedeia, wife of Aloeus,  
 who could say that she had lain with Poseidon,  
 and she bore two sons — but short-lived they proved —  
 godlike Otus, and far-famed Ephialtes:<sup>31</sup>  
 the tallest men the grain-giving earth ever nourished,
- 310 and far the most beautiful, after famous Orion.  
 At nine years old they measured nine cubits  
 across, and stood nine fathoms high;  
 and they threatened the very immortals — to carry  
 the din of furious war up into Olympus.
- 315 Ossa they strained to pile on Olympus, and on Ossa  
 Pelion of the shivering leaves, to make heaven scalable.  
 And they would have accomplished it, had they reached the measure of  
 manhood;  
 but the son of Zeus, whom fair-haired Leto bore, destroyed them  
 both, before the down had bloomed beneath their temples
- 320 and thickened on their chins in the flower of a young beard.

- And Phaedra I saw, and Procris, and beautiful Ariadne,<sup>32</sup>  
the daughter of Minos the deadly-minded, whom Theseus once  
carried off from Crete, making for the hill of holy  
Athens — and had no joy of her: Artemis killed her first,  
325 on sea-ringed Dia, on the testimony of Dionysus.  
And Maera I saw, and Clymene, and hateful Eriphyle,<sup>33</sup>  
who took precious gold as the price of her own husband.  
But all of them I could not tell through or name —  
all the wives and daughters of heroes I saw there:  
330 the divine night would waste away first. No — it is the hour  
for sleep, whether I go down to the fast ship and the crew  
or stay here. My sending rests with the gods, and with you."
- So he spoke; and they were all hushed in silence,<sup>34</sup>  
held fast under the spell, through the shadowy halls.  
335 And white-armed Arete began to speak among them:  
"Phaeacians — how does this man appear to you now:  
his looks, his stature, the balanced mind within?  
And he is my guest — though each of you shares the honor.  
Do not hurry, then, to send him off, and do not cut short  
340 your gifts to one so needy: for many are the treasures  
lying in your halls by the gods' good will."  
And among them spoke the old hero Echeneus,  
the man elder-born beyond the other Phaeacians:  
"Friends — not wide of the mark, not short of our own thought,  
345 are the words of our watchful-minded queen. Heed them.  
But on Alcinous here depend both word and deed."  
Then Alcinous answered him in turn, and said:  
"This word shall stand — so surely as I  
live and rule the oar-loving Phaeacians.  
350 Let the guest endure it, then, for all his hunger for homecoming:  
let him stay till tomorrow, until I make our whole  
gift complete. His sending shall be the men's concern —  
all men's, and mine above all: for mine is the power in this land.<sup>35</sup>  
Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
355 "Lord Alcinous, most renowned among all peoples,  
if you bade me stay here even for a year  
and readied my sending, and gave me shining gifts,

- even that I would choose; and it would profit me far more<sup>36</sup>  
to come to my own dear country with a fuller hand:
- 360 so should I be more honored, and more dear, to all  
the men who saw me sailing home to Ithaca."  
Then Alcinous answered him in turn, and said:  
"Odysseus — looking at you, we cannot liken you  
to a cheat or a thief — the kind the black earth breeds<sup>37</sup>  
365 in such crops, scattered everywhere:  
men who build lies out of what no eye could ever test.  
There is a shape upon your words, and a noble mind within them,  
and you have told your tale with knowledge, like a singer —<sup>38</sup>  
the grim sorrows of all the Argives, and your own.
- 370 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:  
did you see any of your godlike companions, who went  
to Ilium with you, and met their doom there?  
This night is long — marvelously long. It is not yet time  
to sleep in the hall. Tell me the deeds of wonder.
- 375 I could hold out until the shining dawn, if only you  
could bear, here in the hall, to tell me your sorrows."  
Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
"Lord Alcinous, most renowned among all peoples —  
there is an hour for many tales, and an hour for sleep.
- 380 But if you long to listen still, I would not  
grudge you the telling of things more pitiful still:  
the sorrows of my companions, who perished afterward —  
who slipped out of the Trojans' battle-cry and its groaning  
only to die on the homeward way, by an evil woman's will.<sup>39</sup>
- 385 Now when holy Persephone had scattered  
the women's souls this way and that,  
there came the soul of Agamemnon, Atreus' son,  
grieving; and around him others were gathered — all who  
died with him in the house of Aegisthus, and met their doom.
- 390 He knew me at once, when he had drunk the dark blood,  
and he wept, shrill and loud, letting the big tears fall,  
stretching his hands toward me, straining to reach me —  
but there was no strength grounded in him now, no force<sup>40</sup>  
such as once filled his supple limbs.

- 395 I wept to see him, and my heart pitied him,  
and lifting my voice I spoke winged words to him:  
'Most glorious son of Atreus, Agamemnon, lord of men —  
what doom of death, that lays men low, mastered you?  
Did Poseidon master you in your ships,  
400 rousing the wretched blast of hard winds?  
Or did hostile men cut you down on dry land  
as you carved away their cattle and their fine flocks of sheep,  
or fought them for their city and their women?'  
So I spoke, and he answered me at once:
- 405 'Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices:  
Poseidon did not master me in my ships,  
rousing the wretched blast of hard winds,  
and hostile men did not cut me down on dry land.  
Aegisthus built my death and my doom,  
410 and killed me — with my cursed wife — after calling me to his house  
and feasting me: as a man cuts down an ox at the manger.<sup>41</sup>  
So I died the most pitiable of deaths; and around me my other  
companions were killed without pause, like white-tusked  
swine slaughtered in the house of a rich and powerful man  
415 for a wedding, a club-feast, or a swelling banquet.<sup>42</sup>  
You have stood in the killing of many men before now,  
cut down singly, or in the crush of battle —  
but you would have grieved at heart above all to see that sight:  
how around the wine-bowl and the loaded tables  
420 we lay in the hall, and the whole floor steamed with blood.  
And the most pitiful voice I heard was Priam's daughter's —  
Cassandra's, whom Clytemnestra of the crooked counsels killed<sup>43</sup>  
over my body; and I, dying, tried to raise my hands  
and beat them down on the sword-blade — and she, the bitch-faced,  
425 turned her back: she could not bring herself, though I was going down  
to Hades,  
to draw my eyelids shut with her hands, or close my mouth.<sup>44</sup>  
So true it is that nothing is more dread, more dog-shameless, than a  
woman  
who can set her mind on deeds like these —  
the way that woman plotted her unspeakable work,

- 430 building the murder of her own wedded husband. And I had thought  
to come home welcome to my children and my slaves!  
But she — that mistress of atrocity — has poured out shame  
on her own head, and on all women after her,  
the female kind — yes, even on the doer of good.'
- 435 So he spoke, and I answered him and said:  
'Ah, gods — how terribly has Zeus of the wide voice hated  
the seed of Atreus from the beginning, and through the designs  
of women: for Helen's sake we died in our thousands,  
and for you Clytemnestra set her snare while you were far away.'
- 440 So I spoke, and he answered me at once:  
'Then never be gentle, you too, even to your own wife.<sup>45</sup>  
Do not tell out to her the whole word that you know:  
say part, and let part stay hidden.  
But not for you, Odysseus, will murder come from a wife.
- 445 Too understanding she is, too watchful the mind in her breast —  
the daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded Penelope.  
A young bride we left her, when we went  
to the war; and a boy was at her breast,  
an infant, who now, I suppose, sits numbered among men —
- 450 the fortunate one! His dear father will see him, coming home,  
and he will embrace his father: that is the right way of things.  
But my wife did not let me fill even my eyes  
with my own son. She killed me before that — killed the man himself.  
And I will tell you another thing: lay it up in your heart.
- 455 In secret — not in the open — bring your ship in<sup>46</sup>  
to your own dear country. For there is no trusting women any more.  
But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:  
do you hear whether my son is still alive, somewhere —  
in Orchomenus perhaps, or in sandy Pylos,
- 460 or with Menelaus in wide Sparta?  
For noble Orestes has not yet died on the earth.'
- So he spoke, and I answered him and said:  
'Son of Atreus, why ask me this? I know nothing —  
whether he lives or is dead. It is evil to speak words empty as wind.'<sup>47</sup>
- 465 So the two of us stood trading grim words,  
grieving, letting the big tears fall.

And there came the soul of Achilles, Peleus' son,  
 and of Patroclus, and of blameless Antilochus,<sup>48</sup>  
 and of Ajax, who was first in beauty and in body  
 470 of all the Danaans, after the blameless son of Peleus.  
 And the soul of swift-footed Aeacides knew me,  
 and mourning he spoke winged words to me:  
 'Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices —  
 reckless man! What deed will your mind plot now, still greater?<sup>49</sup>  
 475 How did you dare come down to Hades, where the dead  
 live without wits — the phantoms of worn-out mortals?'  
 So he spoke, and I answered him and said:  
 'Achilles, son of Peleus, far the mightiest of the Achaeans —  
 I came for Tiresias, out of need: in hope he might tell  
 480 some plan for reaching rugged Ithaca.  
 For not yet have I come near Achaea — not yet  
 set foot on my own land: evil is with me always. But you, Achilles —  
 no man before you was more blessed, and none will be after:  
 living, we Argives honored you like the gods,  
 485 and now you rule in strength among the dead,  
 here where you are. Do not grieve at dying, then, Achilles.'  
 So I spoke, and he answered me at once:  
 'Do not talk death over sweetly to me, shining Odysseus.<sup>50</sup>  
 I would rather be bound to the plow-land, hired out to another —  
 490 some man without a land-lot, without much living —  
 than be king over all the wasted dead.  
 Enough — tell me word of that proud son of mine:  
 did he follow to the war, to be a champion, or did he not?  
 And tell me of blameless Peleus, if you have heard:  
 495 does he still hold his honor among the Myrmidon crowds,  
 or do they slight him now through Hellas and Phthia,  
 because old age has hold of him, hand and foot?  
 For I am no longer his defender under the rays of the sun —  
 no longer the man I was when in wide Troy  
 500 I cut down the best of their host, in the Argives' defense.  
 Could I come, that man, even for an hour, to my father's house,<sup>51</sup>  
 I would make my fury and my unconquerable hands a horror  
 to those who do him violence and shut him from his honor.'



So he spoke, and I answered him and said:  
 505 'Of blameless Peleus I have heard nothing.  
 But of your own dear son, Neoptolemus,  
 I will tell you the whole truth, as you ask.  
 I myself carried him, in my trim hollow ship,  
 out of Scyros to join the strong-greaved Achaeans.  
 510 And whenever we framed our counsels around the city of Troy,  
 he was always first to speak, and his words never missed:  
 godlike Nestor and I alone outdid him.  
 And whenever we fought on the Trojan plain with the bronze,  
 he never lingered back in the mass of men or the crush,  
 515 but ran far out in front, yielding his fury to no one,  
 and he cut down many men in the terrible fighting.  
 All of them I could not tell through or name —  
 all the host he killed in the Argives' defense;  
 but such a man was the son of Telephus he brought down with the  
 bronze,  
 520 the hero Eurypylus — and around him his Ceteian  
 companions in crowds were slain, for the sake of a woman's gifts.<sup>52</sup>  
 He was the handsomest man I ever saw, after noble Memnon.  
 And when we climbed down into the horse Epeius built —  
 we, the best of the Argives — and it all lay upon me,  
 525 to throw open our close-packed ambush or to shut it,  
 then the other leaders and counselors of the Danaans  
 kept wiping tears away, and each man's legs shook under him;  
 but him — never once did my eyes see  
 his beautiful skin go pale, or catch him wiping  
 530 a tear from his cheeks. No: he begged me, over and over,  
 to let him out of the horse, and kept fingering his sword-hilt  
 and his spear heavy with bronze, with evil in his heart for the  
 Trojans.<sup>53</sup>  
 And when we had sacked the steep city of Priam,  
 he boarded his ship with his share and a fine prize of honor —  
 535 unscarred: never touched by a thrown spear, never gashed  
 in the close work, the way it happens so often  
 in war. For Ares rages blind, and makes no distinctions.'  
 So I spoke; and the soul of swift-footed Aeacides

went away with long strides across the meadow of asphodel,<sup>54</sup>  
 540 rejoicing that I had said his son was preeminent.

And the other souls of the dead who are gone  
 stood grieving, and each asked after what was dear to it.  
 Alone of them all, the soul of Ajax, Telamon's son,  
 stood apart, still raging over the victory<sup>55</sup>

545 I won against him, pleading my case by the ships,  
 for the arms of Achilles. His honored mother set the prize,  
 and the sons of the Trojans judged it, and Pallas Athena.  
 Would to god I had never won a contest like that one:  
 such a head the earth closed over for those arms' sake —

550 Ajax, who in beauty and in every deed of war stood first  
 of all the Danaans, after the blameless son of Peleus.

Him I addressed with honeyed words:

'Ajax, son of blameless Telamon — could you not, then,  
 even in death forget your anger at me for those cursed  
 555 arms? The gods made them a scourge for the Argives —  
 such a tower fell when you fell. For you the Achaeans  
 grieve without ceasing, as for the very head  
 of Achilles, Peleus' son. And no one else  
 bears the blame, but Zeus: he hated the army of the Danaan  
 560 spearmen with a terrible hatred, and laid your doom on you.

Come here, lord — come hear our word, our speech.

Master your fury; break that proud heart down.'

So I spoke. He answered me nothing. He went his way<sup>56</sup>  
 after the other souls, into the Erebus of the dead who are gone.

565 There, even so, for all his anger, he might yet have spoken to me,  
 or I to him. But the heart in my breast  
 wished to see the souls of the other dead.

There I saw Minos, the shining son of Zeus,<sup>57</sup>

holding a golden scepter, delivering law among the dead —

570 he seated, and around him the dead pleading their cases before the  
 lord,

sitting and standing through the wide-gated house of Hades.

And after him I marked out huge Orion

herding the wild beasts together across the meadow of asphodel —

the very beasts he had killed on the lonely mountains —  
575 a club in his hands, all bronze, forever unbroken.  
And I saw Tityus, the son of glorious Earth,  
laid out on the ground: over nine roods he sprawled,  
and two vultures, sitting either side, tore at his liver,<sup>58</sup>  
plunging into the caul; and his hands could not beat them off:  
580 for he had assaulted Leto, the honored consort of Zeus,  
as she walked toward Pytho through Panopeus of the lovely dancing-  
grounds.  
And Tantalus too I saw, holding his hard agonies,  
standing in a pool that lapped against his chin —  
and he strained with thirst, and could not reach a drop to drink:<sup>59</sup>  
585 as often as the old man stooped, in a fury to drink,  
so often the water was swallowed away and gone, and around his feet  
the black earth showed, parched dry by a god.  
And trees in tall leaf poured their fruit above his head,  
pears and pomegranates and apple trees bright with fruit,  
590 sweet figs and olives in full flourish;<sup>60</sup>  
and whenever the old man reached out to close his hands on them,  
the wind would toss them away toward the shadowing clouds.  
And Sisyphus too I saw, holding his hard agonies,  
wrestling a monstrous stone with both his arms.  
595 Bracing himself — straining with hands and feet —  
he would shove the stone uphill toward the crest; but each time,  
just as he was about to heave it over the top, the sheer weight wheeled  
it round,  
and down to the plain again rolled the shameless stone.<sup>61</sup>  
And he would strain again, and shove — the sweat streaming  
600 off his limbs, and the dust rising off his head.  
And after him I marked the strength of Heracles —  
his phantom: for the man himself, among the deathless gods,<sup>62</sup>  
delights in the feasting, with fair-ankled Hebe for his wife,  
the child of great Zeus and of Hera of the golden sandals.  
605 Around that phantom rose a clamor of the dead, like birds  
scattering in panic every way. And he, like black night,  
the bow bare in his hand, an arrow on the string,  
glared terribly about him, forever like a man on the point of shooting.

- And terrible was the baldric crossing his chest,  
 610 the sword-belt all of gold, where deeds of wonder had been worked —  
 bears, and wild boars, and lions with fire in their eyes,  
 and combats, and battles, and murders, and the killings of men.<sup>63</sup>  
 May the man who designed that belt design nothing further —  
 whoever took such work into his craft!
- 615 And he in his turn knew me, the moment his eyes fell on me,  
 and mourning he spoke winged words to me:  
 'Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices —  
 poor man! So you too are dragging out an evil doom<sup>64</sup>  
 such as I bore beneath the rays of the sun?
- 620 I was a son of Zeus, of Cronos' line — and my misery  
 had no end: for I was bound in service to a man  
 far worse than I, who laid hard labors on me,  
 and once he sent me here, to fetch the Hound: no other  
 labor, he reckoned, could be mightier than that one.
- 625 I carried the Hound up and out of Hades,  
 and Hermes saw me on my way, and gray-eyed Athena.'  
 So speaking he went back into the house of Hades;  
 but I stayed rooted there, in hope some other might yet come  
 of the hero men who died in the time before.
- 630 And now I would have seen still earlier men, the ones I longed for —  
 Theseus and Pirithous, glorious children of the gods —<sup>65</sup>  
 but first the tribes of the dead came gathering, thousand  
 on thousand, with a sound that had no earthly likeness; and the pale  
 terror took me  
 that queenly Persephone might send out of Hades
- 635 the Gorgon head of the dread monster against me.<sup>66</sup>  
 Straight to the ship I went, and ordered my companions  
 to board in their turn and loose the stern-cables;  
 and they came aboard at once and took their places at the oarlocks.  
 And the wave of the current bore her down the river of Ocean —
- 640 the rowing first; and afterward, a beautiful following wind.

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 11

- 1    *l. 12* One day's sail, and the sunset line — and the ship is at "the limits of deep-flowing Ocean." Hades is a single day downwind from Circe's island: the geography of fairyland compresses to the exact length of the formula.
- 2    *l. 14* The Cimmerians: a people wrapped in mist at the world's edge, on whom the sun never looks — real twilight-dwellers guarding the border of the dead. Ancient geographers hunted them from the Crimea (whose name some have derived from theirs, though the link is disputed) to the volcanic fields near Naples; the poem needs only their darkness — the sun of Helios' own daughter Circe cannot reach the doorstep of Hades.
- 3    *l. 23* Lines 23–50 execute Circe's protocol (10.517–540) nearly word for word, and the translation repeats itself accordingly: the cubit-square pit, the triple libation, the barley, the vows, the black victims, the sword over the blood. The instructions and their performance are the same liturgy heard twice — ritual language is exact or it is nothing.
- 4    *l. 36* The dead come up *before* they drink — drawn to blood like gulls to bait. The catalogue of the arriving dead (38–41) is the poem's census of mortality: brides, unwed boys, worn old men, girls "with the fresh grief on their hearts," and the war-dead still in their bloody armor. Death is presented not as a place but as a *population* — and the sound they make is "θεσπεσίη ἰαχῆ," a cry past mortal likeness. Then the plainest confession in the poem: "the pale terror took me."
- 5    *l. 51* Elpenor first — before the seer, before his own mother — because the unburied travel faster than protocol. The poem's ethics of burial made into queue order: the corpse left "unwept and unburied" on Aeaea outruns the black ship to the door of Hades.
- 6    *l. 57* Odysseus' greeting is the gentlest dark joke in epic: "You have outstripped me — on foot, and I in my black ship." Grief in this poem is allowed wit; the wit is the tenderness.
- 7    *l. 61* "The evil doom of a god blinded me — that, and wine past measure": Elpenor's self-obituary splits the blame evenly between heaven and the bottle, with the poem's word for ruinous folly (ἄσέ, from *atē*) doing the work. No one in Homer lies about how they died.
- 8    *l. 72* His plea is the poem's doctrine of burial stated from the inside: unburied, he becomes "a cause of gods' wrath"; buried, a marker "for men to come to learn of." Even the least of the dead is owed his mound and his name — and Odysseus' one-line promise (80) will be kept to the letter at 12.8–15.
- 9    *l. 77* The tomb-furniture he asks for is not a sword but his oar — "the oar I rowed with when I lived, when I was among my companions." An ordinary man asks to be remembered as a man who pulled his weight, in the company he pulled it with. The image returns transfigured forty-four lines later in Tiresias' prophecy (121): another oar planted in earth, at the other end of the world, as the sign of a labor finished.

- 10 l. 84 Anticleia comes to the blood — and he holds his sword against his own mother, keeping her from speaking until Tiresias has drunk. The discipline of the errand over the claim of the heart: no moment in the poem costs him more, and none is narrated with fewer words (88–89, "for all my thick grief").
- 11 l. 91 Tiresias knows him *before* drinking — the one exemption (10.494–495) working exactly as specified: his mind stands fast. He drinks not to recognize but to prophesy: blood is the medium of truth-telling, not of identity.
- 12 l. 109 Helios "who sees all things and hears all things" — the formula that makes Thrinacia a theological trap: the cattle belong to total surveillance. The prophecy's practical content is a single self-command: *hold hard your own heart and your companions'* — everything else is consequence.
- 13 l. 114 Lines 114–115 repeat the Cyclops' curse (9.534–535) almost word for word — late, in evil case, all companions lost, on another man's ship, trouble in the house. The curse has become the itinerary: what Polyphemus prayed, Poseidon heard, and Tiresias now simply *reads out*. Fate in this poem has an audit trail, and the translation keeps the language identical at every stage of it.
- 14 l. 121 The oar journey: inland until the sea is not even a rumor — men who eat unsalted food, who have never seen a ship, to whom an oar reads as a farm tool. The errand's meaning has been argued for millennia: Poseidon's cult carried to those who have never had reason to fear him; the sea-man's reconciliation with the land. It is the poem's strangest and most beautiful invention — the hero's final task is to walk far enough that his defining tool becomes unrecognizable.
- 15 l. 128 ἀθηρηλοιγόν — "chaff-destroyer," a winnowing-fan: the shovel that throws grain to the wind so the chaff blows clear. The sign is a misreading: when a stranger *gets the oar wrong*, the journey is over. The instrument of wandering, mistaken for the instrument of harvest, in a country where the confusion is possible — that mistake is the destination.
- 16 l. 134 "Death will come to you from the sea, so gentle a death" — ἐξ ἁλός, the most argued two words in the poem: "from the sea" or "away from the sea"? The Greek permits both an ocean-borne death and a death far from salt water; later tradition (the *Telegony*) took the first route. The prophecy's tone is what matters: gentle (ἀβληχρός), in "sleek old age," the people prosperous — the softest death-sentence in epic, and deliberately ambiguous about its address.
- 17 l. 139 His whole response to the prophecy of his own death: "all that, no doubt, the gods themselves have spun" — one line of acceptance, and then immediately, "But come, tell me this": how do I speak with my mother? The pivot from fate to family in a single breath is the man entire.
- 18 l. 171 "What doom of death, that lays men low, mastered you?" — the question-formula he will ask Agamemnon in the identical words (398). In Hades all interviews open with the same door: *how did you die?*
- 19 l. 181 Anticleia's report is the poem's status dispatch from home, delivered from the far side of death: Penelope enduring in tears; Telemachus farming "unchallenged" (the news is years stale — the dead know only what they knew); and Laertes — the poem's

first full picture of him — sleeping in the ashes with the slaves in winter, on fallen leaves in the vineyard in autumn, "aching for your homecoming." The king's father bedded like the poorest laborer on his own land: grief expressed as self-abasement, held in reserve by the poem until Book 24.

- 20 l. 196 Note what Anticleia does *not* know: nothing of the suitors. Her Ithaca is sad but uninvasion. The poem is scrupulous with its dead — they are informants with a cutoff date.
- 21 l. 202 Her cause of death, in the poem's most devastating diagnosis: not Artemis' arrows, not wasting illness — "it was longing for you, your counsels, shining Odysseus, your gentle-heartedness (ἀγανόφροσύνῃ), that robbed me of honey-sweet life." The mother died of the son's absence — of missing precisely his *mind* and his *gentleness*, the two things the epithets never advertise. He learns in Hades that his wandering has already cost a life at home.
- 22 l. 206 The three embraces: "Three times I started toward her... three times, out of my hands, like a shadow or a dream she flew." The most imitated lines in Western literature — Virgil borrowed them twice (Creusa, Anchises), Dante and Milton after him. The failed embrace is the Nekyia's whole metaphysics enacted in gesture: knowledge crosses the blood-line; touch does not.
- 23 l. 218 Anticleia's anatomy of death — sinews gone, flesh and bone burned down once the life leaves "the white bones," the soul flitting off "like a dream" — is the plainest statement of Homeric death-physiology, delivered as a mother's comfort: *Persephone is not tricking you; this is simply the settled way (δίκη) of mortals*. Consolation by physics.
- 24 l. 224 Her last words: "mark all these things — to tell them to your wife hereafter." From inside death, the mother directs the son's memory toward the living woman. The Nekyia keeps pointing home; and he will, in fact, tell Penelope everything (23.322ff.).
- 25 l. 226 The Catalogue of Heroines (225–332): Persephone curates a procession of the great women of legend, and Odysseus interviews them "one by one" at sword-point rationing. A female counter-epic embedded in the poem — mothers of dynasties, wronged wives, hanged queens — told to a hall ruled, as Odysseus has noticed, by a queen. The audience-within-the-poem shapes the tale: this catalogue is aimed at Arete, and it is she who speaks first when it ends (335).
- 26 l. 235 Tyro, who loved a river: Poseidon takes the river's own shape, and the wave arches "mountain-high" over god and girl — the sea's grandest bed-curtain. His parting speech is divine etiquette complete: praise, promise ("the beds of the immortals are not fruitless"), gag order, and self-identification in the same breath. From this union: Pelias and Neleus — hence Nestor's whole line, and half the Argonaut world.
- 27 l. 263 Amphion and Zethus "first founded seven-gated Thebes and walled it" — Homer's Thebes begins with the twins, with no word of Cadmus — and even they, strong as they were, "could not live in Thebes without walls": civilization's minimum requirement stated in passing, by the poem whose Cyclopes have no walls at all.
- 28 l. 271 Epicaste — Homer's name for Jocasta — and the Oedipus story in six lines, differing from tragedy's version at every joint: the gods reveal the incest "at once"; she hangs

herself; *he rules on in Thebes*, suffering but enthroned, hounded by "a mother's Furies." No self-blinding, no exile, no Antigone. Sophocles is three centuries downstream; here the tale is a mother's catastrophe, filed under her name, not his.

- 29 l. 287 The Pero digression — Neleus' bride-price of the cattle of Iphicles, and "the blameless seer" (Melampus, unnamed) who alone dared drive them, was bound a year, and freed himself by prophecy — is told in the clipped, allusive manner of a story every listener already knows. The poem's audience carried a library; Homer footnotes it with a gesture.
- 30 l. 301 Castor and Polydeuces, "both of them living" beneath the earth — alive and dead on alternate days, "honor equal to the gods'." The strangest afterlife in Homer, stated without explanation: the shared immortality Zeus granted the twins, time-sliced. Even death, for some families, is negotiable — the Nekyia's rule (the dead are witless shades) admits exceptions at every rank.
- 31 l. 308 Otus and Ephialtes: nine years old, nine cubits wide, nine fathoms tall — fairy-tale arithmetic for the boys who stacked Ossa on Olympus and Pelion on Ossa "to make heaven scalable," and would have *done it* had they reached manhood. Apollo kills them before their beards bloom. The pathos is deliberate: even the world-stormers enter the catalogue as their mother's short-lived sons.
- 32 l. 321 Ariadne's variant is the dark one: Theseus "had no joy of her — Artemis killed her first, on sea-ringed Dia, on the testimony of Dionysus." No abandonment on Naxos, no wedding to the god: instead the god as *witness for the prosecution* in a divine execution the poem does not explain. Whatever the lost story was, Homer's audience knew it; we hold only the four-line verdict.
- 33 l. 326 The catalogue ends on its one moral judgment: "hateful Eriphyle, who took precious gold as the price of her own husband" — bribed with a necklace to send Amphiaraus to his death. Between Clytemnestra behind him in the tale and Eriphyle at the catalogue's close, the Nekyia is building a jury for the question the poem never stops asking: what may a man trust in a wife? The answer sits in Ithaca.
- 34 l. 333 The Intermezzo (333–384): mid-tale, mid-Hades, the poem surfaces to Phaeacia — the hall "hushed in silence, held fast under the spell" (κηληθμῶ: the enchantment-word, cousin of Circe's charms). Storytelling as literal spellbinding; the audience of the poem watches an audience bound by it.
- 35 l. 353 Alcinoos seals his promise with the very formula of authority Telemachus used against his mother (1.359: "mine is the power in this house") — here, "mine is the power in this land" (κράτος). The idiom of sovereignty travels intact from a boy's first assertion to a king's guarantee.
- 36 l. 356 Odysseus' answer to "stay another day" is cheerful, unembarrassed avarice: he would stay a *year* if it filled his hands, since a richer return means a more respected return. Gift-wealth is honor's raw material, and he says so — the same frank materialism as "let me see my possessions, my slaves, and my great high-roofed house" (7.225). The hero's accounting is always shown, never hidden.



- 37 l. 363 Alcinous' certification: you are not one of the cheats "the black earth breeds in such crops... who build lies out of what no eye could ever test." The praise is double-edged in the poem's own hands — building untestable lies is *exactly* what Odysseus will do professionally through the second half (the Cretan tales) — and the compliment defines the craft while acquitting the craftsman.
- 38 l. 368 "There is a shape upon your words... you have told your tale with knowledge, like a singer." The poem's boldest self-reference: its hero is credentialed as an αἰδοῦς by his royal audience, mid-performance, in the poem's own terms of praise (μορφή ἐπέων — form upon words). Odysseus has become Demodocus; the apologoi are certified as song from inside. Every question about the tale's truth is deliberately left alive inside the compliment.
- 39 l. 384 The resumption headline: companions who escaped Troy "only to die on the homeward way, by an evil woman's will." The second half of the Nekyia is announced as Clytemnestra's section — the war's survivors murdered by the peace.
- 40 l. 393 Agamemnon reaches for him, weeping — "but there was no strength grounded in him now, no force such as once filled his supple limbs." The lord of men cannot complete a handclasp. Where Anticleia's failed embrace was metaphysics, this one is pure pathos: the king's grip was his scepter, and it is gone.
- 41 l. 411 "As a man cuts down an ox at the manger" — the line the poem fixed at 4.535 (Proteus' telling), now spoken by the victim himself, verbatim. Three tellings of Agamemnon's death (Nestor's, Proteus', and now the ghost's own), and the ox-line is the constant: slaughtered as livestock, at dinner, in trust.
- 42 l. 415 The companions die "like white-tusked swine... for a wedding, a club-feast, or a swelling banquet" — the same three feast-categories Athena listed on Ithaca (1.226: banquet? wedding? no shared feast). Men butchered as the catering at the very institutions of hospitality: the feast-corruption theme at its ghastliest, told by its casualty to the man whose own hall hosts an endless uninvited feast.
- 43 l. 422 Cassandra — "the most pitiful voice I heard" — killed by Clytemnestra "over my body." One line for the prophetess, and the epithet transferred: Clytemnestra is δολόμητις, "of the crooked counsels," Aegisthus' fixed tag (1.300) now branded onto the wife. In the ghost's telling she has absorbed the plot entirely.
- 44 l. 425 The detail Agamemnon cannot forgive is not the sword: "she could not bring herself... to draw my eyelids shut with her hands, or close my mouth." The last offices — the small mercies owed the dead by their nearest — withheld. His bitterness fixes not on being murdered but on being left unclosed: even Clytemnestra's atrocity is measured, in this poem, by an omitted ritual of care.
- 45 l. 441 Agamemnon's counsel — never be gentle, tell her part and hide part, land in secret — comes with its own retraction in the middle: "But not for you, Odysseus, will murder come from a wife. Too understanding she is, too watchful the mind in her breast" — and the ghost speaks her full formula, "the daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded Penelope," the fixed epithet sounding like a verdict. The poem lets its worst husband certify its best wife — and Odysseus will still follow the advice (the secret landing, the testing) to the letter. Trust and technique are kept separate to the end.

- 46 l. 455 "There is no trusting women any more" — οὐκέτι πιστὰ γυναῖξιν: the ghost's bitter general law, ten lines after exempting Penelope from it. The poem stages misogyny as damage — a murdered man's wound talking — and shows the exception standing in Ithaca before the law is even uttered. Both the wound and the exception are in the text; neither cancels the other.
- 47 l. 464 His refusal to speculate about Orestes reuses the phantom's line from 4.837 verbatim: "It is evil to speak words empty as wind." The living son he cannot report on is the one man whose story every listener knows — the poem's audience holds the ending (Orestes lives, avenges) that the speakers in Hades cannot reach.
- 48 l. 467 Achilles enters flanked by Patroclus, Antilochus, Ajax — the dead of the *Iliad* and its aftermath in one file. The lineup is the war's honor roll, and the book will speak with the first and last of them: the best of the Achaeans, and the best after him.
- 49 l. 474 Achilles' greeting — σῆτ' αἶε, "reckless man! What deed will your mind plot now, still greater?" — is half rebuke, half admiration, entirely in character: dying has not changed his opinion that Odysseus over-schemes. And his description of his own realm is definitive: "where the dead live without wits — the phantoms of worn-out mortals" (βροτῶν εἶδωλα καμόντων). No one rates Hades lower than its king.
- 50 l. 488 The recantation: "I would rather be bound to the plow-land, hired out to another — some man without a land-lot, without much living — than be king over all the wasted dead." The θῆς — the landless hired man — is the *lowest* free status Greek society knew, beneath even the slave in security. The *Iliad*'s whole wager (short glorious life over long obscure one) is repudiated by its winner, in four lines, to the man who will spend the rest of the *Odyssey* choosing survival over glory at every fork. This is the hinge on which the two epics turn their backs to each other — and note that the poem does not let it be Achilles' last word.
- 51 l. 501 Because his last fury is not for himself: it is Peleus — the old father possibly scorned, unshielded — that pulls the old *Iliadic* fire out of him: "Could I come, that man, even for an hour, to my father's house..." One hour, for the father. Achilles in Hades has become what Odysseus is: a son and a father first. The *Nekyia* turns every hero it touches toward family.
- 52 l. 521 Eurypylus and his Ceteians died "for the sake of a woman's gifts" — Priam bribed the hero's mother with a golden vine to send her son. Another woman, another payment, another dead man: Eriphyle's golden necklace (326–327) has a twin in the tale Odysseus chooses to tell. The *Nekyia*'s economy of women-and-gold is consistent to the smallest digression.
- 53 l. 528 The report on Neoptolemus is built as a father's checklist — counsel (first to speak; only Nestor and I better), battle (always in front), the horse (the others wept and trembled; he begged to be let out), and the return (unscarred, "for Ares rages blind"). Every clause is calibrated to the listener; whether every clause is *true* is a question the certified singer's tale politely does not raise. It is the kindest speech in the book.
- 54 l. 538 The one happy exit in Hades: Achilles "went away with long strides across the meadow of asphodel, rejoicing that I had said his son was preminent." The asphodel

meadow — gray, spectral pasture of the dead — crossed for once at a warrior's pace, in joy. Fatherhood is the only good news death can receive.

- 55 l. 543 Ajax: still furious over the judgment of Achilles' arms — the contest Odysseus won "pleading my case by the ships," which drove Ajax to madness and suicide (the lost *Little Iliad*'s matter; Sophocles' later). Odysseus' own verdict now: "Would to god I had never won a contest like that one" — the prize acknowledged as ruin, the dead man ranked "first after Achilles" without reservation.
- 56 l. 563 "He answered me nothing. He went his way after the other souls, into the Erebus of the dead." The most celebrated silence in literature — Longinus called it more sublime than any speech. Ghost after ghost has talked; the one man with the unanswerable grievance, appealed to directly, refuses the only thing the living visitor came for. And Odysseus' obituary for the moment (565–567) admits the wound stayed open: he might have spoken, *or I to him* — but curiosity, as ever, pulled the survivor onward. The poem's greatest apology is left unaccepted forever.
- 57 l. 568 Minos "delivering law among the dead... the dead pleading their cases": Hades has a docket. Not punishment — jurisdiction: the dead bring lawsuits, the wide-gated house has a sitting judge with a golden scepter. Homer's underworld bureaucracy, one line before its athletes (Orion, still herding the beasts he killed — occupation continued, forever).
- 58 l. 577 With Tityus the register changes: the punished. Nine roods of him, vultures at the liver (seat of appetite), for assaulting Leto. Then Tantalus and Sisyphus — but note who is *not* explained: Homer gives Tityus' crime and leaves Tantalus' and Sisyphus' unstated, as if the punishments were labels enough. The great sinners arrive in this poem already proverbial.
- 59 l. 583 Tantalus: the water "swallowed away and gone" at every stoop, the black earth showing "parched dry by a god" — deprivation administered with personal attention. English *tantalize* was minted from these ten lines.
- 60 l. 589 The fruit above Tantalus' head is Alcinous' orchard, tree for tree — "pears and pomegranates and apple trees bright with fruit, sweet figs and olives in full flourish" (=7.115–116, verbatim; kept verbatim here). Paradise's own catalogue, replanted in hell as apparatus: the identical line describing eternal abundance and eternal denial. Whether the echo is design or the formula's indifference, the effect for the listening Phaeacians is exquisite — the damned man starves under their own garden.
- 61 l. 598 Sisyphus, in the poem's most kinetic lines: the stone shoved "straining with hands and feet," the crest almost gained, and then "the shameless weight" (λαῖας ἀναιδής — the stone itself gets a moral adjective) wheeling him round, "and down to the plain again rolled the pitiless stone... the sweat streaming off his limbs, and the dust rising off his head." Ancient critics heard the labor in the meter itself — slow spondees uphill, the rock tumbling home in quick dactyls. The dust off the head is the detail genius adds: effort has a weather.
- 62 l. 602 The Heracles split — "his phantom: for the man himself, among the deathless gods, delights in the feasting, with Hebe for his wife" — is the boldest metaphysical patch in Homer: the hero both deified on Olympus and stalking Hades as an εἶδωλον. Ancient

critics flagged the lines as a later harmonizing insertion (the apotheosis doctrine grafted onto the older dead-Heracles), and they may be; the poem as we have it simply pays both theologies. What no interpolator supplied is the figure itself: bow drawn, arrow nocked, "forever like a man on the point of shooting" — the hero's essence looped for eternity, menace with no target left.

- 63 *l. 612* The golden baldric — bears, boars, lions, "and combats, and battles, and murders, and the killings of men" — draws from Odysseus a craftsman's curse: "May the man who designed that belt design nothing further." The connoisseur of workmanship (rafts, palaces, brooches) recoils for the only time: some things are made too well. It is the poem's one review of art as atrocity.
- 64 *l. 618* Heracles' fellow-feeling — "So you too are dragging out an evil doom such as I bore beneath the sun" — is the strongest of the Nekyia's mirrors: the son of Zeus who served "a man far worse" and was sent to fetch the Hound, greeting the son of Laertes still serving his own long labor. The catalogue of encounters ends with the hero who *finished* his labors and was translated; Odysseus' are not finished, and the poem sends him back up the river to them.
- 65 *l. 631* He waited for Theseus and Pirithous — "the ones I longed for" — the connoisseur of heroes hoping for one more exhibit even at the rim of Hades. What ends the Nekyia is not satisfaction but crowd-panic: the ten-thousand tribes gathering with the unearthly cry, and the fear of one face.
- 66 *l. 634* The Gorgon head: the terror that Persephone might send up "the head of the dread monster" — petrification, the one fate that would end all homecomings — finally moves the man whom nothing else in Hades could move to his feet. The pale terror of line 43 returns as the book's exit-spring; the boundary of the tellable is a monster's face. Then oars, then a fair wind: the dead are left behind at rowing-speed, and the longest night of storytelling in Greek literature closes with the current of Ocean carrying the ship — and the tale — back toward the light.

## Odyssey — Book 12

*The Sirens; Scylla and Charybdis; the cattle of the Sun.*

- Now when the ship had left the stream of the river Ocean  
 and come out into the swell of the wide-wayed sea  
 and the island of Aeaea — where the house of early-born<sup>1</sup>  
 Dawn is, and her dancing-grounds, and the risings of the sun —
- 5 we ran her in there onto the sands  
 and stepped out ourselves onto the surf-line of the sea,  
 and there we dropped asleep, and waited for shining Dawn.  
 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,  
 then I sent companions ahead to the house of Circe
- 10 to bring the body of Elpenor, who had died.  
 We cut billets of wood, quickly, and where the headland ran out highest  
 we buried him, grieving, letting the big tears fall.  
 And when the dead man was burned, and the dead man's armor,  
 we heaped a mound, and dragged a pillar-stone onto it,
- 15 and on the very top of the mound we fixed his well-shaped oar.<sup>2</sup>
- So we saw to it all, each thing. And our coming up from Hades  
 was not lost on Circe: she readied herself and came  
 quickly, and her handmaids with her carried  
 bread and meat in plenty and fire-bright red wine.
- 20 And she stood in our midst and spoke, shining among goddesses:  
 'Hard men — you who went down living into the house of Hades:  
 twice-dying, when other men die once.'<sup>3</sup>  
 Come now: eat your food, and drink your wine,  
 here, all day long. And when dawn shows
- 25 you shall sail; and I will point out your road, and make each thing  
 plain, so that no grinding evil design,  
 on sea or on land, can catch you and make you suffer.'  
 So she spoke, and our proud hearts consented.  
 So then all day long till the setting of the sun
- 30 we sat feasting on meat past counting and sweet wine;  
 and when the sun went down and the dusk came on,  
 the men lay down to sleep beside the ship's stern-cables,

- but she took me by the hand, apart from my dear companions,  
and made me sit, and lay beside me, and asked me everything;  
35 and I told it all through to her, in its due order.  
And then the lady Circe spoke to me in words:  
'So all that has been brought to its end. Now hear<sup>4</sup>  
what I will tell you — and a god himself will bring it back to your mind.  
First you will come to the Sirens, who enchant  
40 all mankind — whoever comes upon them.  
Whoever in ignorance draws near and hears the voice  
of the Sirens — no wife, no little children  
will ever stand beside that man to welcome him home;  
no — the Sirens enchant him with their clear-toned song,  
45 sitting in a meadow; and around them is a great heap of the bones<sup>5</sup>  
of rotting men, and the skins are shriveling on them.  
Drive past them; and knead honey-sweet wax  
and stop your companions' ears with it, so that none of the others  
may hear. But you yourself — listen, if you will:<sup>6</sup>  
50 only let them bind you in the fast ship, hand and foot,  
upright in the mast-step, with the rope-ends made fast to the mast  
itself,  
so that you may hear the two Sirens' voice, and delight in it.  
And if you beg your companions — if you order them to free you —  
then let them bind you down with still more bonds.  
55 But when your companions have driven past them,  
from there I will not spell it out for you to the end —  
which of two roads will be yours. You yourself  
must weigh it in your heart. But I will tell you both.  
On the one side, overhanging rocks; and against them  
60 roars the great swell of dark-eyed Amphitrite.  
The blessed gods call them the Wandering Rocks.  
That way not even winged things pass — not even the shy doves<sup>7</sup>  
that carry ambrosia to father Zeus:  
the sheer rock always takes one even of those,  
65 and the Father sends in another to keep the number full.  
That way no ship of men has ever yet escaped, whichever came,  
but ships' planks and men's bodies together  
are carried off by the waves of the sea and the squalls of deadly fire.

- One seagoing ship alone has sailed past there —  
70 Argo, whom all minds know — sailing home from Aeetes;<sup>8</sup>  
and even her the wave would have flung swiftly on the great rocks,  
but Hera sent her through, because Jason was dear to her.  
On the other side are two crags: one reaches the wide heaven  
with its sharp peak, and a dark-blue cloud rings it,  
75 never drawing off — no clear sky ever holds  
that summit, not in summer, not in harvest-time.  
No mortal man could climb it, or set foot on the top,  
not if he had twenty hands and twenty feet:  
the rock is smooth — as if dressed smooth all around.  
80 And in the middle of the crag is a misty cave  
turned toward the dark, toward Erebus — the very way you  
will steer your hollow ship, shining Odysseus.  
Not even a strong man's arrow, shot from a hollow ship,  
could reach up into that vaulted cave.  
85 And in it lives Scylla — yelping horribly.  
Her voice, truly, is no more than a newborn puppy's,<sup>9</sup>  
but she herself is an evil monster: no one  
could look at her and rejoice — not a god, if a god should meet her.  
Twelve feet she has, all of them dangling;<sup>10</sup>  
90 six necks, immensely long, and on each one  
a hideous head, and in each three rows of teeth,  
thick-set and crowded, full of black death.  
Waist-deep she is sunk in the hollow of the cave,  
but she holds her heads out of that terrible pit  
95 and fishes there, quivering with hunger around the crag,  
for dolphins and dogfish, and whatever bigger beast  
she can seize, of the thousands deep-moaning Amphitrite pastures.  
Past her no sailors yet can boast  
to have fled unharmed with their ship: with each head  
100 she carries off a man, snatched from the dark-blue-prowed vessel.  
The other crag is lower — you will see it, Odysseus —  
close by the first: a bowshot would carry across.  
On it stands a great fig tree, dense in leaf,  
and beneath it shining Charybdis gulps down the black water.<sup>11</sup>  
105 Three times a day she spouts it forth, three times she gulps it down —

- terribly. May you not chance to be there when she gulps:  
no one could save you from that evil then — not the earth-shaker  
himself.  
No: keep close to Scylla's crag, and quickly  
drive the ship past. It is far better
- 110 to mourn six companions from your ship than all together.<sup>12</sup>  
So she spoke, and I answered her and said:  
'Come then, goddess — tell me this, and tell it true:  
might I somehow slip out from under deadly Charybdis  
and stand off the other, when she strikes at my companions?'
- 115 So I spoke, and she answered at once, shining among goddesses:  
'Hard man! So even now your heart is set on the works of war<sup>13</sup>  
and struggle. Will you not yield even to the deathless gods?  
She is not mortal — she is an immortal evil,  
terrible, grim, savage, not to be fought.
- 120 There is no defense. To flee her is the best courage.<sup>14</sup>  
For if you linger by the rock to arm yourself,  
I fear she will dart out a second time and catch you  
with all six heads, and take six men again.  
No — row past with all your force, and call on Crataeis,<sup>15</sup>
- 125 the mother of Scylla, who bore her, a plague on mortals:  
she will stop her then from darting out again.  
And you will come to the island Thrinacia. There in plenty  
graze the cattle of Helios, and his strong flocks:  
seven herds of cattle, and as many fine flocks of sheep,<sup>16</sup>
- 130 fifty in each. No young are born to them,  
and they never die away. Goddesses are their shepherds,  
nymphs of the lovely braids, Phaethusa and Lampetie,  
whom shining Neaera bore to Helios Hyperion.  
Their honored mother, when she had borne and reared them,
- 135 settled them far away, on the island Thrinacia,  
to keep their father's sheep and his crook-horned cattle.  
If you leave these unharmed, and keep your mind on homecoming,<sup>17</sup>  
then you may yet reach Ithaca, though you suffer evils;  
but if you harm them, then I foretell destruction
- 140 for ship and companions. And even if you yourself escape,  
late you will come, and in evil case, all companions lost.'



- So she spoke; and at once Dawn of the golden throne came on.  
 Then she went away up the island, shining among goddesses,  
 and I went to the ship and roused my companions  
 145 to board in their turn and loose the stern-cables;  
 and they came aboard at once and took their places at the oarlocks,  
 and sitting in order they struck the gray salt water with their oars.  
 And for us, behind the dark-blue-prowed ship,  
 a following wind that filled the sail, a good companion,  
 150 was sent by Circe of the lovely braids, dread goddess with a mortal's  
 voice.  
 So when we had seen to the tackle through the ship,  
 we sat, and the wind and the steersman held her on course.  
 Then, grieving at heart, I spoke among my companions:  
 'Friends — it is not right that one man only, or two,<sup>18</sup>  
 155 should know the decrees that Circe told me, shining among goddesses.  
 No: I will speak, so that knowing them we may die —  
 or swerve aside, and escape death and doom.  
 First she commands us to shun the marvelous Sirens —  
 their voice, and their flowering meadow.  
 160 Me alone she bade listen to their song. But bind me  
 in a bond that bites, so that I stay fixed where I stand,  
 upright in the mast-step, with the rope-ends made fast to the mast  
 itself.  
 And if I beg you — if I order you to free me —  
 then squeeze me down with still more bonds.'  
 165 So I went through it all, telling my companions,  
 while the well-made ship ran swiftly on  
 toward the island of the two Sirens: a fair wind drove her.  
 Then all at once the wind fell still, and a calm  
 came, breathless: some power lulled the waves to sleep.<sup>19</sup>  
 170 My companions rose and furled the sails  
 and stowed them in the hollow ship, and sitting to the oars  
 they whitened the water with the polished blades of fir.  
 And I with my sharp bronze cut a great round cake of wax  
 into little pieces, and kneaded them in my heavy hands;  
 175 and quickly the wax grew warm, for my great strength pressed it,  
 and the beam of the lord Helios, Hyperion's son;<sup>20</sup>

- and one by one I stopped the ears of all my companions.  
 And they bound me in the ship, hand and foot together,  
 upright in the mast-step, and made the rope-ends fast to the mast  
 itself;
- 180 and sitting down they struck the gray salt water with their oars.  
 But when we were as far off as a man's shout carries,  
 running swiftly, the sea-quick ship did not slip past them  
 unseen as she leapt near — and they raised their clear-toned song:  
 'Come here, come, much-praised Odysseus, great glory of the  
 Achaeans.'<sup>21</sup>
- 185 bring your ship in, so you may hear the voice of us two.  
 For no man yet has rowed past this place in his black ship  
 before hearing the honey-voiced song from our lips —  
 no: he has his delight of it, and goes his way knowing more.<sup>22</sup>  
 For we know all that in wide Troy
- 190 the Argives and the Trojans labored through by the gods' will;  
 and we know all that comes to pass on the nourishing earth.'  
 So they sang, sending out their beautiful voice; and my heart  
 longed to listen, and I ordered my companions to free me,  
 signaling with my brows; but they threw themselves forward and  
 rowed.<sup>23</sup>
- 195 And at once Perimedes and Eurylochus rose  
 and bound me with more bonds, and squeezed them tighter.  
 But when they had driven past them, and we could no longer  
 hear the Sirens' voice, or their singing,  
 quickly my trusted companions took out the wax
- 200 I had stopped their ears with, and loosed me from my bonds.
- But when we had left the island behind, at once  
 I saw smoke, and a great wave, and heard a booming.  
 The men were terrified: the oars flew from their hands  
 and clattered, all of them, along the current; and the ship stopped
- 205 dead, since their hands no longer drove the tapered blades.  
 And I went through the ship, heartening my companions  
 with gentle words, standing by each man in turn:  
 'Friends — we are not unschooled in evils, not we.  
 This evil that stands over us now is no greater than when the Cyclops<sup>24</sup>  
 210 penned us in his hollow cave by brute force —

- and even from there, by my prowess and my counsel and my mind,  
we escaped. Someday, I think, we will remember this one too.  
Come then — all of us — do exactly as I say.  
You, keep to your benches and strike the deep surf  
215 of the salt sea with your oar-blades, in hope Zeus somehow  
may grant us to slip clear of this destruction;  
and you, steersman, here is my order — lay it up  
in your heart, since you handle the steering-oar of our hollow ship:  
keep the ship outside that smoke and that surf,  
220 and hug the crag, for fear the ship, before you know it,  
shears off toward the other side — and you pitch us into the evil.<sup>1</sup>  
So I spoke, and they quickly heeded my words.  
But Scylla I did not speak of — that hopeless horror —<sup>25</sup>  
for fear my companions, terrified, might drop  
225 the oars and pack themselves into the hold.  
And then — Circe's hard command, that I should not  
arm myself — I let it slip from my mind:<sup>26</sup>  
I put on my famous armor, took two long spears  
in my hands, and went up to the half-deck at the bow,  
230 for it was from there I expected the first sight  
of Scylla of the rock, bringing ruin on my companions.  
And I could not glimpse her anywhere; my eyes grew weary  
scanning every hand-span of the misty rock.  
So we sailed up the narrows, wailing:  
235 on this side Scylla; on that, shining Charybdis  
gulped down, terribly, the salt water of the sea.  
When she vomited it up, like a cauldron over a great fire<sup>27</sup>  
she would seethe and boil in all her churning depth, and the spray  
fell high on the very tops of both the crags;  
240 but when she gulped the salt sea down again,  
all her churning depth showed open, and the rock around her  
roared terribly, and at the bottom the earth showed,  
dark-blue with sand. And the pale terror took them.  
We looked to her, then, in our dread of destruction —<sup>28</sup>  
245 and that was when Scylla snatched from the hollow ship  
six of my companions, the best in hands and strength.  
Turning to look at the fast ship, after my men,

- I caught their feet and hands already above me,  
 swung high aloft; and they cried out and called to me  
 250 by name — for the last time — in the anguish of their hearts.<sup>29</sup>  
 As when a fisherman on a jutting rock, with his long rod,<sup>30</sup>  
 casts down baits as a snare for the little fishes,  
 dropping into the sea the horn of a field-ox,  
 and each fish he catches he flings up gasping onto the land:  
 255 so they were swung gasping up toward the rocks.  
 And there in her doorway she devoured them, shrieking as they were,  
 stretching their hands toward me in the terrible struggle.  
 That was the most pitiful thing my eyes ever looked on<sup>31</sup>  
 of all I suffered searching out the pathways of the sea.
- 260 Now when we had escaped the rocks, and dread Charybdis  
 and Scylla, we came quickly then to the god's  
 blameless island: there were the beautiful broad-browed  
 cattle, and the many strong flocks, of Helios Hyperion.  
 And while I was still at sea, in the black ship,  
 265 I heard the lowing of cattle being folded<sup>32</sup>  
 and the bleating of sheep; and there fell upon my heart the word  
 of the blind seer, Theban Tiresias,  
 and of Circe of Aeaea, who charged me over and over  
 to shun the island of Helios, the delight of mortals.
- 270 Then, grieving at heart, I spoke among my companions:  
 'Hear my words, companions, for all your suffering,  
 so I may tell you the prophecies of Tiresias  
 and of Circe of Aeaea, who charged me over and over  
 to shun the island of Helios, the delight of mortals:  
 275 there, she said, is the most terrible evil waiting for us.  
 No — drive the black ship on, wide of the island.'  
 So I spoke, and their own hearts broke within them.  
 And at once Eurylochus answered me — with a hateful word:  
 'You are a hard one, Odysseus. Your strength is beyond us; your limbs<sup>33</sup>  
 280 never tire. Truly you are made of iron through and through —  
 you who will not let your companions, worn down with labor  
 and sleeplessness, set foot on land, where on this  
 sea-ringed island we might at last make ready a savory supper;  
 no — just as we are, through the fast-falling night, you order us

- 285 to wander, driven off the island, over the misted sea.  
 Out of the nights are born the hard winds,<sup>34</sup>  
 the wreckers of ships. How would a man escape sheer destruction  
 if somehow, suddenly, a squall of wind should come,  
 South Wind or hard-blowing West, which more than any others  
 290 smash ships to pieces — in despite of the gods our lords?  
 No: for now let us yield to black night  
 and make our supper ready, staying by the fast ship;  
 at dawn we will board, and stand out onto the wide sea.'  
 So spoke Eurylochus, and the other companions approved.
- 295 And then I knew it: some power was plotting evils —  
 and lifting my voice I spoke winged words to him:  
 'Eurylochus, you force my hand: I am one man alone.'<sup>35</sup>  
 But come — every one of you swear me a strong oath:  
 if we find some herd of cattle or great flock  
 300 of sheep, let no man in his evil recklessness<sup>36</sup>  
 kill one cow, one sheep. No: sit quiet  
 and eat the food immortal Circe gave.'  
 So I spoke, and they swore at once, as I demanded.  
 And when they had sworn, and made an end of the oath,  
 305 we moored the well-made ship in the hollow harbor  
 close by a spring of sweet water, and the companions went  
 ashore, and skillfully made their supper ready.  
 But when they had put away desire for food and drink,  
 they fell to weeping, remembering their dear companions  
 310 whom Scylla had snatched from the hollow ship and eaten;  
 and as they wept, a deep sleep came upon them.  
 But in the night's third watch, when the stars had crossed their height,  
 Zeus who gathers the clouds roused a raging wind against us  
 in a howling squall, and covered land and sea alike  
 315 with cloud; and night rose up out of heaven.  
 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,  
 we dragged the ship up and made her fast in a hollow cave  
 where the nymphs had their fine dancing-floors and seats;  
 and then I called them all together, and said:  
 320 'Friends — there is food and drink in the fast ship:  
 let us keep our hands off these cattle, or we shall suffer for it.

- These are the cattle and the strong flocks of a terrible god —  
 Helios, who sees all things and hears all things.<sup>137</sup>  
 So I spoke, and their proud hearts consented.
- 325 Then for a whole month the South Wind blew without let, and no other  
 wind rose after that, except the East and the South.  
 As long as the men had bread and red wine,  
 they kept their hands from the cattle: they wanted to live.  
 But when all the ship's provisions were spent,
- 330 and need drove them roaming after game —  
 fish, birds, whatever came to their dear hands —  
 with bent hooks, while hunger wore their bellies down,<sup>38</sup>  
 then I went away up the island, to pray  
 to the gods, in hope one might show me a road home.
- 335 And when, crossing the island, I had left my companions behind,  
 I washed my hands where there was shelter from the wind  
 and prayed to all the gods who hold Olympus —  
 and they poured sweet sleep upon my eyelids.<sup>39</sup>  
 And Eurylochus began his evil counsel to the companions:
- 340 'Hear my words, companions, for all your suffering.  
 All deaths are hateful to wretched mortals —  
 but to die of hunger, and meet doom that way, is the most pitiful.<sup>40</sup>  
 Come then: let us drive off the best of the cattle of Helios  
 and sacrifice them to the immortals who hold wide heaven.
- 345 And if we come to Ithaca, our fathers' land,  
 we will build at once a rich temple to Helios Hyperion  
 and set up in it fine offerings, many of them.  
 But if, in anger over his straight-horned cattle, he wills  
 to destroy our ship, and the other gods go with him —
- 350 I would rather gulp once at the wave and lose my life<sup>41</sup>  
 than be starved slowly to death on a desert island.'  
 So spoke Eurylochus, and the other companions approved.  
 And at once they drove off the best of the cattle of Helios,  
 from close by — for not far from the dark-blue-prowed ship
- 355 the beautiful broad-browed crook-horned cattle were grazing —  
 and they stood around them and prayed to the gods,  
 plucking the tender leaves of a high-crowned oak:<sup>42</sup>  
 for they had no white barley aboard the well-benched ship.

- And when they had prayed, and cut the throats, and flayed,  
 360 they carved out the thigh-pieces and wrapped them deep in fat,  
 folding it double, and laid raw flesh upon them;  
 and they had no wine to pour over the blazing offerings,  
 so they made libation with water, and roasted all the entrails.  
 And when the thighs were burned through, and they had tasted the  
 innards,  
 365 they carved up the rest and threaded it on spits.  
 Then it was that the deep sleep fled from my eyelids,  
 and I went down to the fast ship and the shore of the sea.  
 But as I came near the curved ship,  
 the sweet smell of the fat's smoke drifted all around me,  
 370 and I groaned aloud, and cried out to the deathless gods:  
 'Father Zeus, and you other blessed gods who are forever —  
 it was for my ruin, then, that you laid me down in that pitiless sleep,  
 while my companions, waiting, devised this monstrous thing.'  
 Swiftly the word came to Helios Hyperion:  
 375 long-robed Lampetie brought it — that we had killed his cattle.  
 And at once, with anger in his heart, he spoke among the immortals:  
 'Father Zeus, and you other blessed gods who are forever:  
 make them pay — the companions of Odysseus, Laertes' son —  
 who in their insolence have killed my cattle: the cattle  
 380 I took my joy in, every day I climbed toward the starry heaven  
 and every day I turned from heaven back toward earth.  
 If they do not pay me a fitting price for the cattle,  
 I will go down into Hades and shine among the dead.'<sup>43</sup>  
 Then Zeus who gathers the clouds answered him:  
 385 'Helios — you shine on among the immortals, surely,  
 and among mortal men across the grain-giving plowland;  
 and as for those men: their fast ship I will soon strike  
 with the white lightning, and shatter it to splinters in the middle of the  
 wine-dark sea.'  
 — This I heard afterward from fair-haired Calypso;<sup>44</sup>  
 390 and she said she heard it herself from Hermes the guide. —  
 Now when I had come down to the ship and the sea,  
 I went up and down and rebuked them, man by man; but no remedy  
 could we find anywhere: the cattle were dead already.

- And soon the gods began to show forth portents among the men:  
 395 the hides crawled; the meat on the spits was lowing,<sup>45</sup>  
 the roasted and the raw; and there rose a sound as of cattle crying.  
 Six days after that my trusted companions  
 feasted on the cattle of Helios they had driven off, the best of them;<sup>46</sup>  
 but when Zeus the son of Cronos set the seventh day upon us,  
 400 then at last the wind fell from its raging squall,  
 and we boarded at once and stood out onto the wide sea,  
 stepping the mast and hauling up the white sails.  
 But when we had left the island behind, and no other  
 land showed anywhere — only sky and sea —  
 405 then the son of Cronos set a dark-blue cloud  
 over the hollow ship, and the deep went black beneath it.  
 And she ran on not much longer: for all at once came the shrieking  
 West Wind, raging in a great squall,  
 and the storm-blast snapped both forestays of the mast:  
 410 the mast toppled backward, and all its tackle spilled  
 down into the bilge; and in the stern of the ship the mast  
 struck the steersman's head, and crushed the bones of the skull  
 all together; and like a diver he dropped<sup>47</sup>  
 from the half-deck, and his proud life left his bones.  
 415 And Zeus thundered in the same instant, and hurled his bolt into the  
 ship,  
 and she shivered stem to stern, struck by the bolt of Zeus,  
 and filled with the reek of sulfur; and the men fell from the ship.  
 Like sea-crows around the black hull  
 they were carried off on the waves; and the god took away their  
 homecoming.<sup>48</sup>  
 420 But I kept moving through the ship, until the surge  
 tore the sides loose from the keel, and the wave carried her stripped  
 bare,  
 and snapped the mast off at the keel. But over the mast  
 the backstay had been flung — a thing made of ox-hide;  
 with it I lashed the two together, keel and mast,<sup>49</sup>  
 425 and settling myself on them, I was carried before the deadly winds.  
 Then indeed the West Wind fell from its raging squall,  
 but the South came fast in its place, bringing anguish to my heart:



- that I should measure back my way to deadly Charybdis.  
 All night I was carried; and with the rising sun  
 430 I came to Scylla's crag, and to dread Charybdis.  
 She was gulping down the salt water of the sea —  
 but I, swinging up high toward the tall fig tree,  
 caught it and clung there like a bat. And there was no way<sup>50</sup>  
 to plant my feet firm anywhere, no way to climb it:  
 435 the roots were far below, and the branches out of reach,  
 long and great boughs that shadowed Charybdis.  
 I clung there without slackening, until she should vomit back  
 the mast and keel again. And to my longing, late,  
 they came: at the hour when a man rises from the assembly for supper  
 —<sup>51</sup>
- 440 the judge of many quarrels among contending young men —  
 at that hour the timbers reappeared out of Charybdis.  
 I let go, feet and hands, from above,  
 and dropped with a crash into the water beyond the long timbers,  
 and settling on them, I rowed hard with my hands.
- 445 And Scylla — the father of men and gods did not let her<sup>52</sup>  
 see me again: I would not have slipped clear of sheer destruction.  
 From there I was carried nine days; and on the tenth, in the black night,  
 the gods brought me near the island Ogygia, where Calypso  
 lives, she of the lovely braids, the dread goddess with a mortal's voice,  
 450 and she loved me and cared for me. But why tell that tale over?<sup>53</sup>  
 Only yesterday I told it in this house — to you  
 and to your strong wife. And it is hateful to me  
 to tell a tale over again that has been told out plainly."

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 12

- 1 l. 3 Aeaea is now located "where the house of early-born Dawn is, and her dancing-grounds, and the risings of the sun" — the uttermost East, though nothing in the voyage there had promised any such thing. The fairyland compass does not resolve: Circe is Helios' daughter, so her island is wherever the sun gets up. Homer's wanderings run on mythic adjacency, not bearings — which is why every attempt to chart them since antiquity has ended in the cartographer's despair.
- 2 l. 15 Elpenor's funeral, exactly as the ghost prescribed (11.74–78): burned with his armor, the mound, the pillar-stone — and the oar fixed on the very top. The promise of 11.80 kept to the letter, first thing, before Circe, before the road. It is the only funeral Odysseus ever conducts in the poem, performed for the least of his men.
- 3 l. 21 "Twice-dying" — *δισθανέες*, a word Circe appears to coin on the spot for men who will owe death two visits. Her greeting is the wanderings' running theme in one syllable-cluster: Odysseus does everything twice — two Charybdis passages, two prophecy-briefings, two great sleeps, and death itself once in advance.
- 4 l. 37 The second briefing. Note the change of genre: Tiresias gave destiny (what must be), Circe gives pilotage (what to do about it) — wax, cords, course-choices, even the escape-clause prayer to Scylla's mother. And at the fork she withdraws: "You yourself must weigh it in your heart." The gods of this poem brief; they do not decide. The deciding is what the hero is *for*.
- 5 l. 45 The Sirens' setting is the poem's most economical horror: a flowering meadow, and in it "a great heap of the bones of rotting men, and the skins are shriveling on them." No claws, no cave — just the voice, the flowers, and what remains of the audience. The listeners stayed; that is the entire mechanism. Note that no appearance is ever described: the Sirens are the one monster in the Odyssey who are only sound.
- 6 l. 49 "But you yourself — listen, if you will": the arrangement is Circe's gift to *his* curiosity, unasked. She knows her man: he will want the song, so she engineers a way to have it without dying of it — desire licensed under restraint, the whole Odysseus-problem solved in ship's tackle. The image of the bound listener has been philosophy's property ever since; the poem invented it as seamanship.
- 7 l. 62 Even Zeus' ambrosia-doves pay a toll of one to the Wandering Rocks, "and the Father sends in another to keep the number full." Heaven's own supply line runs on attrition and replacement — a two-line glimpse of cosmic bookkeeping, casually terrifying.
- 8 l. 70 "Argo, whom all minds know" — Ἀργὼ πᾶσι μέλουσα: Homer cites another epic as universally famous in three words, the oldest literary cross-reference in Greek. The Argonaut saga (Aeetes, Jason, Hera's patronage) is assumed knowledge; the Odyssey positions its own route one island over from a rival poem's — and sends its hero the *other* way.

- 9    *l. 86* Scylla's voice "is no more than a newborn puppy's" — the Greek puns her name on σκύλαξ, *puppy*. A six-headed devourer that whimpers like something you would pick up and hold: the mismatch of sound and thing is the horror, in a poem whose last monster was all voice and honey.
- 10   *l. 89* The anatomy is exact and unvisualizable — twelve dangling feet, six enormously long necks, triple rows of teeth "full of black death," body sunk waist-deep in rock. She is a fishing creature; men are simply the largest catch that passes. The bowshot-wide strait with a monster on each side is the poem's geometry of the unchoosable — and she takes one man per head, a tax collected in sixes.
- 11   *l. 104* Charybdis under her fig tree: not a creature at all but a schedule — three times a day, down and up. Scylla is appetite with heads; Charybdis is pure physics. Between a predator you can count and a tide you cannot, Circe's seamanship is unsentimental: choose the one that takes six, not everything.
- 12   *l. 109* "Far better to mourn six companions from your ship than all together": the coldest sentence of command in the poem, handed to him in advance by a goddess. The captain sails the strait already carrying the arithmetic — and the poem lets us watch him pay it out in real men at 245–250.
- 13   *l. 116* His reflex — *can I fight her?* — draws Circe's exasperated diagnosis: "So even now your heart is set on the works of war... Will you not yield even to the deathless gods?" The last time anyone called him σχέτλιος like this it was Achilles' ghost (11.474). The Iliadic reflex is the one thing ten years of sea have not washed out of him.
- 14   *l. 120* "To flee her is the best courage" — φυγέειν κάρτιστον: flight as the superlative of strength. No sentence in the poem is less Iliadic; it is the wanderings' whole revaluation of heroism in four words.
- 15   *l. 124* Crataeis — "Force" — is Scylla's mother, invocable to call her daughter off. Even the unfightable has a parent who can be petitioned: the poem's world remains, to the last monster, a web of families.
- 16   *l. 129* Seven herds of fifty, seven flocks of fifty: 350 cattle and 350 sheep, breeding never, dying never. Ancient readers did the sum and saw the days of the lunar year in each — the cattle of the Sun as the sun's own calendar, guarded by daughters named Shining (Phaethusa) and Radiant (Lampetie). To eat them is to eat time itself; the allegory was already old when Aristotle heard it, and the poem neither confirms nor forbids it.
- 17   *l. 137* Circe's Thrinacia warning repeats Tiresias' prophecy nearly verbatim (11.110–115), and the translation repeats with it. The two authorities of the two worlds — the dead seer, the deathless witch — issue one text. No event in the poem is more thoroughly notarized in advance than the crew's destruction.
- 18   *l. 154* He briefs the crew in the name of shared knowledge — "it is not right that one man only, or two, should know" — and tells them the Sirens in full... and Scylla not at all (223–225). Full disclosure as principle, censorship as practice, each defended in its place: the captain manages truth like any other ration. The poem hands us both passages sixty-nine lines apart and lets us do the ethics ourselves.

- 19 l. 168 The wind dies at the Sirens' island — "some power lulled the waves to sleep." The becalming is the trap's velvet: silence so total the song will be the only sound on the sea. Rowing into it, the men whiten still water while their captain kneads the wax soft.
- 20 l. 175 The wax warms under "my great strength... and the beam of the lord Helios" — the sun himself, whose cattle will destroy this crew, here helps seal their ears. The gods lend their forces indifferently; the poem notes the courtesy without comment.
- 21 l. 184 The Song. They address him "much-praised Odysseus, great glory of the Achaeans" — μέγα κῦδος Ἀχαιῶν, the honorific otherwise reserved for Nestor (3.79): the Sirens speak flawless epic diction, and their opening move is his own fame recited back to him. For this hero the fatal bait is not flesh but *renown and information* — they offer Troy complete (the war he cannot stop weeping over in Books 8's songs) plus omniscience: "all that comes to pass on the nourishing earth." The Sirens are epic poetry weaponized — the song of kleos with the homecoming subtracted. The bone-meadow is an audience that never left the recital.
- 22 l. 188 "He has his delight of it, and goes his way knowing more" — the Sirens' prospectus is a lie with a true clause: the delight is real, the going-away is not. Odysseus, bound, becomes the single exception that proves their sales-pitch: the only man who did hear and did leave — knowing more.
- 23 l. 194 The system absorbs its designed failure: he signals with his brows to be freed (the same brow-signal that commanded silence at 9.468), and Perimedes and Eurylochus — *acting on his own prior orders* — add rope. Ulysses bound is the West's founding image of precommitment: the self that plans outranking the self that wants. The poem states it without a word of theory: they rowed; they bound; they passed.
- 24 l. 209 The heartening speech runs on the captain's résumé: "no greater evil than the Cyclops... and even from there, by my prowess and my counsel and my mind, we escaped." True — and edited: the cave was also entered by his curiosity and signed with the boast that bought Poseidon's curse. Command rhetoric curates the past; the poem, having shown us the whole ledger, lets the speech work anyway. "Someday, I think, we will remember this one too" echoes his own 20-year brand of consolation — memory as the promised land beyond every horror.
- 25 l. 223 The withheld briefing: Scylla is edited out "for fear my companions... might pack themselves into the hold." Six men will die unwarned. Militarily impeccable, morally unresolved — and narrated by the man himself years later without apology or defense, which is its own kind of confession.
- 26 l. 226 "Circe's hard command... I let it slip from my mind": he arms anyway, two spears, up on the foredeck, scanning rock. The one order the man cannot obey is *don't fight* — the armor is useless, the enemy never shows herself to him, and the poem lets his obsolete magnificence stand there in full bronze, watching the wrong monster.
- 27 l. 237 Charybdis as kitchen-physics: a cauldron over a great fire, seething to the rim — then the gulp, and "at the bottom the earth showed, dark-blue with sand." The seafloor exposed is the sea turned inside out — the one sight sailors are never meant to see; the pale terror (χλωρὸν δέος, the Nekyia's own fear-formula) is its correct price.

- 28 *l. 244* The trap's true mechanism: "We looked to her" — all eyes on the spectacle of Charybdis — "and that was when Scylla snatched..." Attention itself is the toll. The strait charges you six men for looking at the wrong danger, exactly as Circe's geometry promised.
- 29 *l. 250* "They cried out and called to me by name — for the last time." His name — the thing he boasted to the Cyclops, the thing the Sirens sang — is the last word of six men being lifted into a mouth. The poem's economy of the name closes its darkest circuit here.
- 30 *l. 251* The angler simile: a fisherman on a rock, long rod, ox-horn line-guard, flinging the little fish "gasping onto the land." The men are the little fish; the tackle is described with a professional's precision; the scale is the cruelty. It is the Laestrygonian image (men speared like fish, 10.124) miniaturized and made leisurely — slaughter at the tempo of a pastime. Homer's similes keep domesticating his horrors, and that is what makes them unbearable.
- 31 *l. 258* "The most pitiful thing my eyes ever looked on of all I suffered searching out the pathways of the sea." The superlative of ten years — awarded not to Polyphemus or Hades but to six pairs of reaching hands. The teller ranks his own griefs, and the ranking is the man.
- 32 *l. 264* He hears the cattle while still at sea — "the lowing of cattle being folded" carries over water — and the prophecy lands on his heart in the same instant. For once fore-knowledge and temptation arrive together, sound first: Thrinacia is audible doom, as the Sirens were audible desire.
- 33 *l. 279* Eurylochus' "you are made of iron" speech is mutiny with a case: the men are exhausted, night passages kill ships, the winds born of darkness are real ("wreckers of ships" is sound pilotage). The poem gives the rebellion its best arguments — rest tonight, sail at dawn — and then lets the weather, not the logic, spring the trap: the dawn that was promised brings a month of imprisoning wind.
- 34 *l. 286* "Out of the nights are born the hard winds": a genuine sailor's proverb doing the work of rhetoric. Everything Eurylochus says is true; that is what makes the scene tragedy rather than folly. Odysseus yields to a sound argument — and knows, in the same breath, that "some power was plotting evils."
- 35 *l. 297* "You force my hand: I am one man alone" — βιάζετε μούνον έόντα: command's arithmetic stated plainly, one against a crew. The oath he extracts is the only instrument left to a captain outvoted; it will hold exactly as long as the food does.
- 36 *l. 300* The oath's key word is the proem's: άτασθαλίησι — let no man "in his evil recklessness" kill a cow. The poem's opening indictment (1.7: they perished by their own recklessness) is here written into a sworn contract, in advance, in the perpetrator's hearing. When they break it, they break it under its proper name.
- 37 *l. 323* His warning ends on the surveillance formula: "Helios, who sees all things and hears all things" (= 11.109). On an island owned by total observation, the crew will wait for the captain to fall asleep — as if the only eye were his.

- 38 *l. 331* Bent hooks, birds, "whatever came to their dear hands," hunger wearing the belly — the stranded-crew cluster shared with Menelaus' men on Pharos (4.368–369), its closing line word for word. The apologoi keep meeting the Telemachy's stories at the seams: same sea, same hunger, same grammar.
- 39 *l. 338* The fatal sleep again. Aeolus' bag within sight of home; now Thrinacia; the pattern is exact — catastrophe enters only when his vigilance lapses, and the lapse is always bodily, blameless, human. "It was for my ruin that you laid me down" (372): he reads his sleep as the gods' instrument, and the poem does not correct him. A hero whose weakness is not pride or lust but the simple need to close his eyes: that is the Odyssey's realism about limits.
- 40 *l. 341* Eurylochus' second speech is the belly-doctrine turned catechism: "all deaths are hateful, but to die of hunger is the most pitiful." It is Odysseus' own theology (7.216: nothing more dog-shameless than the belly) recited by the mutineer to justify the unforgivable. The poem built its hero's materialism carefully for five books precisely so this speech would be irrefutable in his own terms.
- 41 *l. 350* "I would rather gulp once at the wave and lose my life than be starved slowly" — the sailor's ranking of deaths, and a wish the poem grants with horrible precision: he will get exactly that death, mouth open at the wave, within the week. In the Odyssey, stated preferences about dying are always heard by someone.
- 42 *l. 357* The sacrilege is performed as scrupulous ritual with every material wrong: oak leaves for barley, water for wine, prayers over stolen victims, a temple vowed from the proceeds. Form perfect, substance inverted — piety's grammar spoken in theft. The poem's most detailed sacrifice scene after Nestor's (3.430ff.) is this parody of it; the two scenes are each other's mirror at ten books' distance.
- 43 *l. 383* Helios' threat: "I will go down into Hades and shine among the dead." Four words from a minor god, and the cosmos tilts: the sun proposes to invert the universe — light for the dead, darkness for the living — unless compensated. Zeus' answer is a settlement (keep shining; I'll handle it), and the affair closes like a lawsuit between great houses: the thunderbolt as damages.
- 44 *l. 389* "This I heard afterward from fair-haired Calypso; and she said she heard it herself from Hermes the guide." Unique in Homer: the narrator cites his sources — for an Olympian conversation he could not have witnessed, a two-link chain of transmission is produced on the spot. The apologoi's one gesture of documentation is also its quietest boast: the rest, we are to take it, he saw — though the oath-taking and the sacrilege on Thrinacia he tells us himself he slept through. Storytelling inventing source criticism, in the middle of the Bronze Age.
- 45 *l. 394* The portents: "the hides crawled; the meat on the spits was lowing, the roasted and the raw." The uncanniest lines in Homer — the meal refusing to become food, the sacrilege bellowing from the fire. And the sentence that follows is the true horror: "Six days after that my trusted companions feasted." Not one meal in madness — six days of eating meat that cries. The crew's doom is not a lapse but a persistence.
- 46 *l. 397* "The best of them" — even in cataloguing the sin, the connoisseur's precision: they stole the *best* cattle. The poem's fair-division captain (9.42, 549) reports the crime with

the same bookkeeping he brought to the loot.

- 47 *l. 413* The steersman dies "like a diver" — the man of steering dropped head-first from his post, his craft converted in one simile to falling gracefully. It is the poem's last professional death: the storm kills the helmsman first, then the ship.
- 48 *l. 419* "The god took away their homecoming" — the proem's exact clause (1.9: "the god took from them their day of homecoming"), executed at last, twelve books later, on the men the proem indicted in its seventh line. The sea-crows simile gives the crew their final form: small dark birds around a black hull, then nothing. Every death the poem promised in its first ten lines has now been delivered.
- 49 *l. 423* Keel and mast lashed with the ox-hide backstay: the raft of Book 5 anticipated at its absolute minimum — two timbers and a strap, rigged in a breaking sea by the man who built a twenty-tree vessel with axe and auger. Craft scales down to whatever is left; that is its definition.
- 50 *l. 432* Hanging "like a bat" from the fig tree over Charybdis — feet unable to reach, branches too high, roots too far — while she digests his raft. The greatest survivor in literature spends the crisis as a small nocturnal animal, waiting. Endurance here is not muscle but grip and timing.
- 51 *l. 439* The judge simile: the timbers resurface "at the hour when a man rises from the assembly for supper — the judge of many quarrels among contending young men." Time told by a magistrate's working day, cited by a naked man clinging over a whirlpool at the edge of the world. The poem's clocks are all civic and agricultural (the plowman's supper, the mule-furrow, the shout) — the wanderer measures even the abyss in units of the ordered human town he is trying to get back to. It is the most homesick simile in the poem.
- 52 *l. 445* Zeus hides him from Scylla — the Father's single direct intervention in all the wanderings, one line, unexplained. The poem's theology in miniature: named mercy, unnamed motive.
- 53 *l. 450* The ending: "But why tell that tale over? Only yesterday I told it in this house... it is hateful to me to tell a tale over again that has been told out plainly." The four-book performance closes with the performer's professional ethic — no encores of finished material — and with the ring sealed exactly where Book 7's short account began: Calypso. The joke underneath is exquisite: the most repetition-built poem in existence ends its greatest recital by declaring repetition hateful. The singer knows the difference between formula, which is architecture, and retelling, which is padding — and so does Homer, who now takes the poem back from his hero. The wanderings are over; every subsequent mile is Ithaca's.





## Odyssey — Book 13

*The sending home; the ship turned to stone; Athena and Odysseus on Ithaca.*

- So he spoke; and they were all hushed in silence,<sup>1</sup>  
 held fast under the spell, through the shadowy halls.  
 Then Alcinous answered him in turn, and said:  
 "Odysseus — now that you have come to my house with its floor of  
 bronze,  
 5 its high roof, I do not think you will be driven wandering  
 back again as you return, however much you have suffered.  
 And to each man of you I say this, laying it on you —  
 you who in my halls forever drink the elders' fire-bright  
 wine, and listen to the singer:  
 10 clothing for the guest lies packed already in the polished chest,  
 with gold of intricate work and all the other  
 gifts the counselors of the Phaeacians brought him here.  
 Come now, let us give him besides a great tripod and a cauldron,  
 each man of us; and we in turn will gather it back from the people:  
 15 it is hard on one man to give so freely without repayment."<sup>2</sup>  
 So spoke Alcinous, and his word pleased them well,  
 and they went home to sleep, each man to his own house.  
 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,  
 they hurried to the ship, carrying the bronze that does honor to a man,  
 20 and the sacred strength of Alcinous stowed it well,  
 going himself through the ship, under the benches, so that it might not  
 hamper any of the crew at the rowing, when they leaned to the oars.  
 Then they went to the house of Alcinous and saw to the feast.  
 For them the sacred strength of Alcinous slaughtered an ox  
 25 to Zeus of the black cloud, the son of Cronos, lord of all.  
 They burned the thigh-cuts and shared the glorious feast,  
 rejoicing; and among them sang the godlike singer,  
 Demodocus, honored among the people. But Odysseus  
 kept turning his head toward the blazing sun,<sup>3</sup>  
 30 willing it to set: for now his whole heart strained toward home.

- As when a man aches for his supper — all day long<sup>4</sup>  
 his two wine-dark oxen have dragged the jointed plow through fallow  
 ground,  
 and welcome to him is the setting of the sun's light,  
 the going home to supper, and his knees buckle as he walks:  
 35 so welcome to Odysseus was the setting of the sun's light.  
 At once he spoke among the oar-loving Phaeacians,  
 and to Alcinous above all he declared his word:  
 "Lord Alcinous, most renowned among all peoples:  
 pour the offering, and send me on my way unharmed. And yourselves  
 — farewell.  
 40 For now all that my own heart wished is brought to pass:  
 a sending, and gifts of friendship. May the gods of heaven  
 make them a blessing! And may I come home and find my blameless  
 wife<sup>5</sup>  
 there, with those I love unharmed.  
 And you who stay: may you be the joy of your wedded wives  
 45 and of your children; and may the gods grant prosperity  
 of every kind, and no evil come to dwell among your people."  
 So he spoke, and they all approved it and urged  
 that the guest be sent home, since he had spoken rightly.  
 And then the strength of Alcinous said to the herald:  
 50 "Pontonous, mix the bowl, and serve out the wine  
 to all in the hall, so that with a prayer to father Zeus  
 we may send the guest to his own fatherland."  
 So he spoke, and Pontonous mixed the honey-hearted wine  
 and served it to all in turn; and they poured to the blessed  
 55 gods who hold wide heaven, there where each man  
 sat. But noble Odysseus rose to his feet  
 and set the two-handled cup in Arete's hand,  
 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to her:  
 "Fare well, my queen, through all the years, until old age<sup>6</sup>  
 60 comes, and death, which stand over every one of us.  
 I go now. And you — have joy of this house,  
 of your children and your people and Alcinous the king."  
 So speaking, noble Odysseus stepped across the threshold,  
 and the strength of Alcinous sent the herald with him

- 65 to lead him to the fast ship and the shore of the sea;  
and Arete sent slave-women along with him,  
one carrying a fresh-washed mantle and a tunic,  
another she sent to bring the close-packed chest,  
and a third carried bread and red wine.
- 70 And when they had come down to the ship and the sea,  
the lordly escorts took it all at once and stowed it  
in the hollow ship, all the food and drink;  
and for Odysseus they spread a blanket and a linen sheet  
on the half-deck of the hollow ship, so that he might sleep
- 75 unwaking, at the stern. And he came aboard himself and lay down  
in silence. And they took their places at the oarlocks, each in  
order, and loosed the cable from the pierced stone.  
And the moment they leaned back and tossed the sea with the oar-  
blade,  
that moment sweet sleep fell upon his eyelids —<sup>7</sup>
- 80 unwaking, sweetest sleep, and most like death.  
And the ship — as on the plain a team of four stallions<sup>8</sup>  
springs forward all together under the lash's strokes,  
and rearing high they swiftly accomplish their road:  
so her stern reared and plunged, and behind her the great
- 85 dark-gleaming wave of the loud-roaring sea rushed on.  
And she ran sure and steady, never yielding: not even the hawk  
could have kept beside her, the falcon, nimblest of winged things.  
So running lightly she cut the waves of the sea,  
carrying a man with counsels like the gods' —
- 90 a man who before had suffered pains in plenty, heart-deep,  
cutting through wars of men and the grinding waves,  
and who now slept without a tremor, all he had suffered forgotten.<sup>9</sup>
- When the brightest of stars was rising, the one that comes  
above all others announcing the light of early-born Dawn,
- 95 then the seagoing ship was drawing near the island.  
There is a harbor of Phorcys, the old man of the sea,<sup>10</sup>  
in the land of Ithaca: two jutting headlands in it,  
sheer on the seaward side but sloping down toward harbor,  
which shelter it from the great waves the hard-blowing winds raise

- 100 outside; and within, the well-benched ships ride  
without a mooring-line, once they have reached anchoring-ground.  
At the head of the harbor is a long-leafed olive,  
and near it a lovely cave, full of sea-mist,  
sacred to the nymphs that men call Naiads.
- 105 In it are mixing-bowls and two-handled jars  
of stone; and there the bees lay up their honey.  
And in it are long looms of stone, where the nymphs  
weave cloth of sea-purple, a wonder to see;  
and ever-flowing waters. It has two doors:<sup>11</sup>
- 110 one toward the North Wind, by which men come down;  
the other, toward the South, is for the gods: by that way  
men do not enter — it is the immortals' road.  
In there they rowed, knowing the place of old. And the ship  
ran up on the shore a full half of her length,
- 115 at speed: such was the drive of the rowers' arms.  
And they stepped from the well-benched ship onto dry land,  
and first they lifted Odysseus out of the hollow ship,  
linen sheet and shining blanket and all,  
and laid him down on the sand, still mastered by sleep;<sup>12</sup>
- 120 and they lifted out the goods that the lordly Phaeacians  
had given him for his journey home, through the grace of great-  
hearted Athena.  
These they set in a heap by the trunk of the olive,  
out of the path, for fear some passer-by  
might come and pillage them before Odysseus woke;
- 125 and they themselves set off for home again. But the shaker of earth  
had not forgotten the threats he had made at the first  
against godlike Odysseus; and he asked out the design of Zeus:  
"Father Zeus, I shall have honor no longer among the deathless  
gods, when mortals honor me not at all —
- 130 the Phaeacians, who are of my very own line."<sup>13</sup>  
I said just now that Odysseus should suffer evils in plenty  
before he came home — his homecoming itself I never  
wholly denied him, once you had promised it and bowed your head —  
and look: they have carried him sleeping over the sea in their fast ship
- 135 and set him down in Ithaca, and given him gifts past speaking,

- bronze and gold in heaps and woven clothing,  
 more than Odysseus would ever have carried out of Troy<sup>14</sup>  
 had he come home untouched with his fair share of the spoils."  
 Then Zeus who gathers the clouds answered him:
- 140 "Shame on you, wide-ruling shaker of earth — what a thing to say.  
 The gods do not dishonor you: it would be a hard thing  
 to pelt our eldest and best with dishonor.  
 As for men — if any man, yielding to his own force and power,  
 fails to honor you, vengeance is yours, now and always after.
- 145 Do as you will: whatever is dear to your heart."  
 Then Poseidon the earth-shaker answered him:  
 "I would have done it at once, lord of the black cloud, as you say;  
 but I always shrink before your anger, and I avoid it.  
 Now, then: that beautiful ship of the Phaeacians,  
 150 coming home over the misted sea from her sending —  
 I will smash her, so that they hold off at last and cease  
 their escorting of men; and I will pile a great mountain round their  
 city."  
 Then Zeus who gathers the clouds answered him:  
 "Friend — hear how it seems best to my own mind.<sup>15</sup>
- 155 When all the people are watching her from the city  
 as she drives in, turn her to stone close offshore —  
 a stone in the likeness of a fast ship, so that all mankind  
 may marvel; and pile the great mountain round their city."  
 And when Poseidon the earth-shaker heard it,  
 160 he went his way to Scheria, where the Phaeacians are born and bred,  
 and there he waited. And she came close in, the seagoing ship,  
 running lightly on. And the shaker of earth came near her,  
 and turned her to stone, and rooted her to the sea-floor  
 with one downward stroke of the flat of his hand. And he was gone.
- 165 And they spoke to one another with winged words,  
 the Phaeacians of the long oars, men famed for ships;  
 and thus one would say, with a glance at his neighbor:  
 "Ah me — who has shackled our fast ship on the open sea  
 as she drove for home — in full view, every timber of her?"<sup>16</sup>
- 170 So they would say — knowing nothing of how it had been done.  
 And Alcinous addressed them all, and said:

- "Ah, then it comes home to me — the old prophecy<sup>17</sup>  
of my father, who would tell us that Poseidon looked on us with anger  
because we are safe escorts of all men without distinction.
- 175 He said that one day, as a beautiful ship of the Phaeacian men  
came home over the misted sea from such a sending,  
the god would smash her, and pile a great mountain round our city.  
So the old man said. And now it is all being accomplished.  
Come then — all of us — do exactly as I say:
- 180 cease your escorting of mortals, whoever comes  
to our city hereafter; and to Poseidon let us sacrifice  
twelve chosen bulls, in hope he may take pity  
and not pile the long mountain round our city."  
So he spoke; and they were afraid, and made the bulls ready.
- 185 So they were praying to the lord Poseidon,  
the leaders and counselors of the land of the Phaeacians,  
standing around the altar.<sup>18</sup> — And noble Odysseus woke  
out of sleep in his own fathers' land — and did not know it,  
so long had he been gone. For the goddess had poured a mist around  
him,
- 190 Pallas Athena, daughter of Zeus, so that she might make him  
unknowable to all, and tell him everything through,  
lest his wife should know him, and his townsmen, and his friends,  
before the suitors paid for all their trespass.<sup>19</sup>  
And so to their lord all things showed strange —
- 195 the long straight paths, the anchorages that take ships from every  
wind,  
the sheer-climbing rocks and the trees in full leaf.  
He sprang up and stood, and stared at his own fatherland,  
and then he groaned aloud, and struck both thighs  
with the flats of his hands, and spoke in raw lament:
- 200 "Ah me — whose country have I come to now? What men's?<sup>20</sup>  
Are they violent, savage, without justice,  
or kind to strangers, with hearts that fear the gods?  
Where am I to carry all this treasure? Where am I myself  
to wander? Would it had stayed with the Phaeacians, all of it,  
205 there where it was — and I had come to some other mighty king,  
who would have hosted me kindly and sent me on my way home.

As it is, I have nowhere to put it — and I will not leave it  
here, to fall as plunder to other men.  
Shame on them — not righteous through and through, then, and not  
just,

- 210 the leaders and counselors of the Phaeacians,  
who carried me off to a strange country! They said, truly,  
they would bring me to clear-skied Ithaca — and did not do it.  
May Zeus of Suppliants pay them for it, who watches over  
all mankind, and punishes whoever goes astray.
- 215 But come — let me count my goods and look them over,<sup>21</sup>  
in case they carried something off with them in the hollow ship."  
So speaking he counted up the surpassingly beautiful tripods  
and the cauldrons, and the gold, and the fine woven clothing —  
and missed not one thing. Then, mourning for his fatherland,
- 220 he crept along the shore of the loud-roaring sea,  
grieving without pause. And Athena came near him  
in the likeness of a young man, a herder of sheep,<sup>22</sup>  
delicate-skinned, such as the sons of kings are,  
a fine-made double cloak hanging from her shoulders,
- 225 sandals under her shining feet, a javelin in her hand.  
Odysseus rejoiced at the sight of her, and came to meet her,  
and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to her:  
"Friend — since you are the first I meet in this country,  
hail to you! And may you come at me with no evil purpose:  
230 save these things, and save me. To you as to a god  
I pray, and I come to your knees in supplication.  
And tell me this too, honestly, so that I may know it:  
what land is this? what people? what men are born here?  
Is it some clear-skied island — or is it a headland  
235 of the rich-soiled mainland, shelving down into the sea?"  
Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-eyed Athena:  
"You are a fool, stranger — or you have come from far away —<sup>23</sup>  
if you ask about this land. It is not so very  
nameless as all that: very many men know her,  
240 both all who live toward the dawn and the sun  
and all who live back westward, toward the misty dark.  
Rough she is, truly — no ground for driving horses —

- yet not too poor a land, though no wide one either:  
 grain grows in her past speaking, and wine as well,  
 245 and the rain never fails her, or the fresh dew;  
 good pasture she is for goats and cattle; there is timber  
 of every kind, and watering-places that flow the year round.  
 And so, stranger, the name of Ithaca has reached even to Troy —<sup>24</sup>  
 and that, they say, lies far from this Achaean land."
- 250 So she spoke; and much-enduring noble Odysseus was glad,  
 rejoicing in the land of his fathers, at the word  
 of Pallas Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus.  
 And lifting his voice he spoke winged words to her —  
 yet he did not speak the truth: he swallowed the word back down,<sup>25</sup>  
 255 forever steering, in his breast, the mind of many profits:  
 "I heard tell of Ithaca even in wide Crete,  
 far over the sea. And now I have come here myself  
 with all this treasure — and left as much again for my children —  
 a fugitive: for I killed the dear son of Idomeneus,  
 260 Orsilochnus the swift-footed, who in wide Crete  
 outran all bread-eating men with his quick feet.  
 He meant to strip me of all my Trojan plunder,  
 the winnings I had suffered pains for, heart-deep,  
 cutting through wars of men and the grinding waves —  
 265 all because I would not oblige his father and serve  
 under him at Troy, but led my own command.  
 So I struck him with my bronze-tipped spear as he came in  
 from the fields — lay in ambush by the road with one companion.  
 Black night held the sky that night: no living soul  
 270 saw us; I took his life unseen.  
 And when I had cut him down with the sharp bronze,  
 I went straight to a ship of the lordly Phoenicians  
 and begged their grace, and gave them plunder to content their hearts:  
 I asked them to take me aboard and set me down at Pylos,  
 275 or at shining Elis, where the Epeians hold power.  
 But the wind's force beat them off that course —  
 much against their will: they had no wish to cheat me —  
 and driven wide, we came here in the night.  
 We rowed hard into the harbor, and not one of us



- 280 had a thought of supper, hungry for it as we were:  
 we simply stepped ashore, all of us, and lay down as we landed.  
 Then sweet sleep came over me, worn out as I was,  
 and they lifted my goods out of the hollow ship  
 and set them down where I myself lay on the sands,  
 285 and boarded, and went off toward well-peopled Sidon —  
 and I was left behind, my heart aching."  
 So he spoke; and the goddess smiled, gray-eyed Athena,<sup>26</sup>  
 and stroked him with her hand — and now her body was a woman's,  
 beautiful and tall, and skilled in glorious handwork —  
 290 and lifting her voice she spoke winged words to him:  
 "A sharp one he would have to be, a master-thief, to slip past you<sup>27</sup>  
 in all your manifold tricks — even a god, if one should meet you.  
 You hard man — shifting-crafted, glutton for guile — so not even  
 here, in your own country, would you leave off the cheating  
 295 and the thieving tales that are dear to you from the ground of your  
 heart!  
 But come, no more of this now. We are both old hands  
 at profit: you are far the best of all mortal men  
 in counsel and in words, and I among all the gods  
 am famed for cunning and for profit. And yet you did not know  
 300 Pallas Athena, daughter of Zeus — I who stand  
 beside you in every labor, always, and keep watch over you,  
 and who made you dear to all the Phaeacians.  
 Now I have come here to weave a design with you,<sup>28</sup>  
 and to hide the goods the lordly Phaeacians  
 305 gave you for your journey home — by my own thought and counsel —  
 and to tell you all the cares that fate must fill  
 your well-built house with. You must endure them — there is no choice  
 —  
 and tell no one, no man and no woman,  
 none of them all, that it is you, come home from your wandering. No:  
 310 in silence suffer your many pains, and submit to men's violence."  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
 "Hard it is, goddess, for a mortal man who meets you to know you,<sup>29</sup>  
 however knowing he be: for you take what likeness you will.  
 This I know well — that you were kind to me once,

- 315 as long as we sons of the Achaeans made war at Troy;  
 but after we had sacked Priam's steep city,  
 and gone to our ships, and a god scattered the Achaeans,  
 from then on I never saw you, daughter of Zeus — never marked you  
 setting foot on my ship to beat some grief away from me.
- 320 No: I wandered on, always carrying a heart torn open  
 in my breast, until the gods released me from evil —  
 until that day, in the rich land of the Phaeacian men,  
 when you heartened me with your words, and led me to the city  
 yourself.  
 Now I beg you by your father — for I cannot think
- 325 I have truly come to clear-skied Ithaca: it is some other  
 country I am turned loose in, and you are mocking me  
 when you tell me this, to lead my wits astray —  
 tell me: am I really come to my own dear fatherland?"  
 Then the goddess answered him, gray-eyed Athena:
- 330 "Always the same — that mind in your breast!"<sup>30</sup>  
 And that is why I cannot forsake you in your misery:  
 because you are civil, and quick-witted, and steady-souled.  
 Gladly would any other man, come home from wandering,  
 have rushed to his hall to see his children and his wife;
- 335 but you — you have no wish yet to learn or to ask  
 until you have made trial of your wife besides — who sits  
 as ever in your halls, and always in misery  
 her nights waste away, and her days, in tears.<sup>31</sup>  
 I, though — I never doubted it: I knew in my heart
- 340 you would come home with all your companions lost.  
 But I had no mind, you see, to fight Poseidon,  
 my father's brother, who set the grudge in his heart,  
 raging because you blinded his dear son.  
 Come — I will show you the ground-plan of Ithaca, so you will believe.
- 345 This is the harbor of Phorcys, the old man of the sea;<sup>32</sup>  
 and this, at the head of the harbor, the long-leaved olive;  
 and near it the lovely cave, full of sea-mist,  
 sacred to the nymphs that men call Naiads —  
 there is the wide vaulted cavern where you used to offer
- 350 the nymphs so many perfect hecatombs;

and this is the mountain Neriton, clothed in its forest."

So speaking, the goddess scattered the mist — and the land showed plain.

Then much-enduring noble Odysseus rejoiced —

he exulted in his own land, and kissed the grain-giving earth,<sup>33</sup>

355 and at once he prayed to the nymphs, lifting up his hands:

"Nymphs of the springs, daughters of Zeus — I told myself

I would never see you again. Now take my greeting

and my gentle prayers. And we will give you gifts, as in the old days,

if the daughter of Zeus, the driver of spoils, in her grace

360 lets me live, and brings my dear son to his manhood."

Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-eyed Athena:

"Take heart: let none of that weigh on your mind.

Rather let us stow the goods in the innermost hollow of the wondrous cave, this instant, so that they stay there safe for you;

365 and let us two take counsel how the best may come about."

So speaking, the goddess plunged into the misty cave,

searching along its hiding-holes; and Odysseus

carried everything close in — the gold, the wear-proof bronze,

and the well-made clothing the Phaeacians gave him.

370 He laid them carefully by; and a stone was set at the door

by Pallas Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus.<sup>34</sup>

Then the two of them sat down at the trunk of the sacred olive<sup>35</sup>  
and plotted death for the overweening suitors.

And the goddess began to speak, gray-eyed Athena:

375 "Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices —

consider how you will lay your hands on the shameless suitors,

who for three years now have lorded it through your hall,

courting your godlike wife and offering bride-gifts;<sup>36</sup>

and she — grieving without pause for your homecoming, heart-deep,

380 gives hope to all, and makes promises to every man,

sending out messages — while her mind wills otherwise."<sup>37</sup>

Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:

"Ah, gods — so I was to have perished by the same evil doom

as Agamemnon, Atreus' son, in my own halls,

385 had you not told me each thing rightly, goddess, in its measure.

- Come then — weave a design, how I shall pay them back;<sup>38</sup>  
 and stand beside me yourself, breathing bold fury into me,  
 as on the day we loosed the shining head-veil of Troy.<sup>39</sup>  
 Were you to stand by me with that same fire, gray-eyes,
- 390 I would fight three hundred men together —  
 with you, sovereign goddess, when you choose in your heart to help  
 me."  
 Then the goddess answered him, gray-eyed Athena:  
 "Oh, I will be with you — be sure of it — you will not slip my sight  
 when the hour comes and we are at this work. And more than one, I  
 think,
- 395 of the suitor-men who eat away your living  
 will spatter the vast floor with his blood and brains.<sup>40</sup>  
 But come: I will make you unknowable to every mortal.  
 I will wither the fine skin on your supple limbs;  
 I will strip the fair hair from your head; I will wrap you in rags
- 400 such that a man would shudder to see a human being wear;  
 and I will dim those eyes, so beautiful before,  
 so that you seem a vile thing to all the suitors —  
 and to your wife, and to the son you left in your halls.<sup>41</sup>  
 And you yourself: go first of all to the swineherd,
- 405 the keeper of your pigs — whose heart is loyal to you all the same,  
 who loves your boy, and steady-hearted Penelope.  
 You will find him sitting by the swine; and they are at pasture  
 by the Rock of the Raven, at the spring Arethusa,<sup>42</sup>  
 eating acorns to their hearts' content and drinking
- 410 black water — the things that feed the rich fat on swine.  
 Stay there; sit by him and question him of everything,  
 while I go on to Sparta, the country of beautiful women,  
 to summon Telemachus — your own dear son, Odysseus —  
 who went to wide-dancing-grounded Lacedaemon, to Menelaus,
- 415 seeking news of you, whether you were still alive anywhere."  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
 "Why did you not tell him, then — you whose mind holds everything?<sup>43</sup>  
 So that he too might wander in misery over the barren  
 sea, while other men eat away his living?"
- 420 Then the goddess answered him, gray-eyed Athena:

- "Do not let him weigh too heavily on your heart.  
 I myself was his escort, so that he might win himself  
 a good report by going there. He has no hardship — he sits  
 at his ease in the house of Atreus' son, with plenty before him.  
 425 True — the young men lie in ambush for him with their black ship,<sup>44</sup>  
 hungry to kill him before he reaches his fathers' land.  
 But I do not look for that. No: sooner will the earth close over  
 more than one of the suitor-men who eat away your living."  
 So speaking, Athena touched him with her wand.  
 430 She withered the fine skin on his supple limbs;  
 she stripped the fair hair from his head; and about all his limbs  
 she set the skin of an aged old man;  
 and she dimmed those eyes, so beautiful before,  
 and threw about him a foul rag and a tunic —  
 435 tattered things, filthy, black with reeking smoke —  
 and over them she dressed him in the great hide of a swift deer,<sup>45</sup>  
 worn bald. And she gave him a staff, and a miserable pouch,  
 ragged full of holes, slung on a rope of twisted cord.  
 So the two of them, their plot laid, parted. And she<sup>46</sup>  
 440 went off to shining Lacedaemon, after the son of Odysseus.

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 13

- 1    *l. 1* The opening couplet repeats 11.333–334 verbatim — the spellbound hall — and the translation repeats with it. The same silence greets the Intermezzo and the finished tale: four books of story are framed, fore and aft, by an audience forgetting to breathe.
- 2    *l. 13* Alcinous' last gift-order comes with the poem's frankest line of political economy: a tripod and cauldron from each king, "and we in turn will gather it back from the people: it is hard on one man to give so freely without repayment." Royal generosity is a tax passed downward, stated without embarrassment. Fairyland keeps books.
- 3    *l. 28* Odysseus watching the sun, "willing it to set": the man who told four books of adventures now cannot bear one more afternoon of hospitality. The greatest guest in literature has reached the end of being a guest.
- 4    *l. 31* The plowman simile: supper-hunger after a day at the plow, oxen-weary, knees buckling on the walk home. For the sack of his longing the poem reaches past kings and heroes to a tired farmhand — the wanderings end where the poem's clocks have always pointed, at the working day and its supper (the judge at 12.439, the unyoking-hour at 9.58). Twenty years of war and sea are calibrated, at the last, against one laborer's evening.
- 5    *l. 42* His farewell wish: to find at home "my blameless wife... with those I love unharmed." Before the Phaeacians — who offered him a princess — he wishes for his wife openly now, in his own person and not through the tale (the Nekyia had already named Penelope). The reticence of 7.225 (possessions, slaves, house — no wife), first loosened inside the storytelling, is dropped entirely now that the ship is waiting and it stops being protective.
- 6    *l. 59* The farewell to Arete is the courtliest sentence in the poem: joy to her until old age and death, "which stand over every one of us." He came to her knees as a nameless suppliant; he leaves wishing her the whole of a human life. The queen who held his homecoming in her hands (7.75–77) receives the last cup and the last word.
- 7    *l. 79* The sleep: "unwaking, sweetest sleep, and most like death." The man crosses from fairyland to Ithaca unconscious — carried over the threshold of his own story like a corpse or a bride. Twenty years of vigilance, and the final leg is pure surrender; the poem marks it with its boldest oxymoron, the sweetness that resembles dying. Ancient readers saw the death-and-rebirth shape; the poem needs no doctrine — only the fact that the great watcher does not get to watch his own arrival.
- 8    *l. 81* Two similes race each other: the ship as a four-horse team springing under the lash, then outrunning the falcon, "nimblest of winged things." The Phaeacian marvel gets land's fastest image and the sky's in ten lines — and between them, the cargo: "a man with counsels like the gods'," asleep.
- 9    *l. 92* "All he had suffered forgotten" — λελασμένος ὅς' ἐπεπόνθει. The lotus promised oblivion of home; sleep grants, for one night, oblivion of the suffering. The poem's

tenderest clause: forgetting, which was the enemy all through the wanderings, is here the mercy.

- 10 l. 96 The harbor of Phorcys and the cave of the Naiads: stone bowls, stone jars, bees laying up honey, stone looms where nymphs weave sea-purple cloth, waters that never fail. No passage of Homer was more allegorized in antiquity — Porphyry wrote a whole treatise (*On the Cave of the Nymphs*) reading it as the cosmos: souls descending by one door, gods by the other, the honey and the weaving as generation itself. The poem's own picture is enough: Ithaca's front hall is a working sanctuary where nature keeps house — the island answer to Calypso's cave and Circe's halls, wild and holy and nobody's prison.
- 11 l. 109 Two doors: the north for men, the south "the immortals' road." The cave where mortal and divine traffic use separate entrances is about to host exactly that: a man and a goddess, entering together, to hide treasure and plot a war.
- 12 l. 117 They carry him ashore asleep — the hero delivered onto Ithaca like freight, laid on the sand with his blankets, his treasure heaped by the olive. Twenty years of striving for this beach, and the arrival happens without him. The poem's profoundest irony about homecoming: the moment itself cannot be experienced — only, like everything else in this poem, told afterward.
- 13 l. 130 Poseidon's grievance is family shame: the Phaeacians "are of my very own line" (his son Nausithous founded them). The god's honor is wounded worst by his own descendants' kindness — and his complaint concedes the whole war: "his homecoming itself I never wholly denied him." The curse only ever ran to *late and in evil case*; the ledger closes with Poseidon himself reading out its limits.
- 14 l. 137 Poseidon's bitterest clause repeats Zeus' own prophecy from 5.38–40 verbatim — more treasure than Troy would have given him — and the translation repeats it. What Zeus promised in council, Poseidon must now watch delivered on a beach; the same line is triumph in one god's mouth, salt in the other's.
- 15 l. 154 Zeus' amendment to the plan: don't just smash the ship — turn her to stone "close offshore... so that all mankind may marvel," and pile the mountain. An ancient variant (known to Aristophanes of Byzantium) read "and do *not* pile the mountain," softening Zeus into mercy. Murray's text keeps the harder reading: Zeus improves the punishment into a monument. The poem then leaves the Phaeacians mid-sacrifice, praying against the mountain (183–187), and never returns to them: the kindest people in the poem exit the epic frozen between marvel and doom — unresolved forever, in payment for one act of grace.
- 16 l. 168 The watcher's line — "who has shackled our fast ship... in full view, every timber of her?" — is answered by the narrator's dry refrain from 4.772: "knowing nothing of how it had been done." The stone ship in the roadstead was still being shown to travelers off Corfu in antiquity, and is still pointed out today: the poem planted a landmark and geography obliged.
- 17 l. 172 "Ah, then it comes home to me — the old prophecy": Alcinous receives fulfillment in the *identical line* Polyphemus used (9.507), and the translation repeats it exactly. The two hosts of the wanderings — the monster who ate his guests and the king who enriched them — get the same formula for the same discovery: contact with Odysseus

was foretold, and it costs. Lines 173–178 then replay Nausithous' prophecy from 8.565–569 nearly word for word, as promised when the glossary flagged it: prophecy in this poem is a text, quoted precisely by everyone who owns a copy.

- 18 l. 185 The scene-cut is merciless: the Phaeacians "standing around the altar" — and mid-line, the poem turns its back on them forever to wake Odysseus. Two clauses share one verse: the last we hear of Scheria, and the first breath of the homecoming. No book-division in ancient literature does more work in half a line.
- 19 l. 192 Athena's stated reasons for the mist and the disguise: he must not be known "before the suitors paid for all their trespass" — ὑπερβασίην, the legal-moral word (3.206). The unrecognizable Ithaca is not a trick played on him but the first move of the revenge plot: estrangement as strategy. Still, the poem lets the cruelty land — the man who wept toward this island for ten years gets to see it first as a stranger's coast.
- 20 l. 200 The arrival-taxonomy, third and last time (= 6.120–121 = 9.175–176): "violent, savage, without justice, or kind to strangers?" — in Books 6 and 13 preceded by the same bewildered whose-country-is-this, a preamble the Cyclops' coast never got. Asked of Phaeacia, the answer was the kindest people in the poem; of the Cyclops' coast, the cruelest. Asked of *Ithaca*, the question stops being rhetorical: his own island now contains both answers — the loyal swineherd and the hall full of men eating his house. The formula has been aimed at this target for seven books.
- 21 l. 215 Grief, then audit: he laments his betrayal — and immediately counts the tripods. "And missed not one thing." The inventory clears the Phaeacians of theft (they are innocent; he now knows it) and restores the world to order the only way this man trusts: by arithmetic. Mourning and bookkeeping share one heart; the poem has never pretended otherwise (9.42, 549).
- 22 l. 221 Athena as a shepherd boy "delicate-skinned, such as the sons of kings are," with a fine double cloak and a javelin — an aristocrat's idea of a shepherd, a disguise wearing a disguise. Meeting her, Odysseus takes no chances either way: he prays to the possible god and lies to the possible man in the same breath.
- 23 l. 237 Her teasing opens with the put-down formula the Cyclops used on him ("You are a fool, stranger, or you have come from far away," 9.273) — recycled now as affectionate irony. And her description of Ithaca answers everything its exiles have said of it: rough, no horse-country (Telemachus at 4.601–608; his own "rugged, but a good nurse of men," 9.27) — and then grain, wine, rain, dew, goat-pasture, timber, watering-places: a bounty the lovers never claimed. She identifies the island by praising it past its own praisers.
- 24 l. 248 "The name of Ithaca has reached even to Troy": the goddess certifies his homeland's fame by the measure of his own war. The compliment is engineered to test — anyone else would cry out at the name. What he does instead is the next note.
- 25 l. 254 "He did not speak the truth: he swallowed the word back down, forever steering, in his breast, the mind of many profits." Told he stands on Ithaca — the word he has bled twenty years to hear — his first act is a lie. The first Cretan tale (256–286) is a masterpiece of instant fabrication: a plausible exile (a killing over loot, an ambush by night, hired Phoenicians, a wind off course), studded with true details relocated — the treasure, the sleep, the beach landing are his actual morning, re-plotted as crime fiction.



He lies the way other men flinch: as a reflex of self-protection, and the poem admires and exposes the reflex in the same line.

- 26 l. 287 The recognition: she *smiles* — the second smile of the poem's gods on him — strokes him with her hand (the gesture kings and goddesses reserve for favorites: Menelaus at 4.610, Calypso at 5.181), and drops the shepherd for "a woman beautiful and tall, and skilled in glorious handwork": Athena as she is, the weaver-goddess. The lie did not offend her. It delighted her. Nowhere else in ancient literature does a deity fall in love with a mortal's *dishonesty*.
- 27 l. 291 The speech that names him better than his name: "A sharp one he would have to be, a master-thief, to slip past you... You hard man — shifting-crafted, glutton for guile — not even in your own country would you leave off the cheating and the thieving tales that are dear to you from the ground of your heart." Then the great leveling: "We are both old hands at profit: you are far the best of all mortal men in counsel and in words, and I among all the gods am famed for cunning and for profit." The patron-goddess declares the partnership explicitly — one craft, two planes of being. It is the poem's theology of intelligence: *mētis* is the one field where a mortal and a god can be colleagues. And her mild rebuke — "yet you did not know Pallas Athena" — is also the point: perfect craft means even your patron can stand before you unrecognized.
- 28 l. 303 "To weave a design with you" — μήτιν ὑφίηνω: the master-metaphor (Penelope's loom, Hephaestus' snare, the Nekyia's "wove every guile") now spoken by the goddess of weaving herself, proposing joint work. The revenge on the suitors is, from this line, a co-production.
- 29 l. 312 His answer to the revelation is not worship but a grievance and a cross-examination: where were you for ten years? — and then, incredibly, a demand for proof that this is really Ithaca, "for I think you are mocking me... to lead my wits astray." He doubts the goddess of truth-by-cunning to her face, on the theory that a being who can look like anything might be lying about geography. It is the most in-character prayer ever prayed.
- 30 l. 330 Her delighted verdict: "Always the same — that mind in your breast!" — followed by the poem's formal citation of his virtues: ἐπιτήρης, ἀγχίνοος, ἐχέφρων — civil, quick-witted, steady-souled. And then the observation that defines the second half of the epic: any other man would have run home to his wife and children; "you have no wish yet to learn or to ask until you have made trial of your wife besides." Testing before trusting, even of Penelope, even now. Athena states it without censure — it is *why* she cannot forsake him. The gods love in others what they are.
- 31 l. 336 Her report on Penelope retells Anticleia's dispatch from the Nekyia (11.181–183), its closing line word for word: sitting in the halls, nights and days wasting in tears. Mother and goddess file the same report — the last line in the same words — the poem's fixed image of the waiting wife, stable across every witness.
- 32 l. 344 The proof is the ground-plan itself, point by point, reusing the narrator's own lines from 96–104: the harbor of Phorcys, the long-leafed olive, the Naiads' cave, Neriton. She adds the one detail that clinches it as *his*: the cave "where you used to offer the nymphs

so many perfect hecatombs" — identification by his own history of piety. Home is the place where your old sacrifices are on file.

- 33 l. 354 The mist scatters, "and the land showed plain" — and he kisses the grain-giving earth, the gesture last performed by a half-drowned nobody in the reeds of Scheria (5.463). Then, before any human greeting, he prays to the springs: "I told myself I would never see you again." His first words home are to the island's water. The homecoming is real now — not when his foot touched sand, but when he could *see* it and speak to it.
- 34 l. 370 The treasure sealed in the cave, "and a stone was set at the door by Pallas Athena." The last time the poem set a stone at a cave door, the hand was the Cyclops' (9.240–243). The poem's doors keep their memory: this one closes on wealth, not victims, and opens on the poem's endgame.
- 35 l. 372 The war council under the sacred olive: the goddess and the man sitting at the root of Athena's own tree — the tree of the double thicket that sheltered him (5.477), of the stake (9.320), of the bed to come (23.190) — "and plotted death for the overweening suitors." The whole second half of the poem is planned in this shade, on the ground of Ithaca, between the two best minds in the epic.
- 36 l. 378 Athena's briefing quotes Tiresias' prophecy word for word — "courting your godlike wife and offering bride-gifts" (11.117) — seer and goddess filing the identical clause. Note her "three years": the poem's chronology of the siege of the house, consistent with Antinous' "third year, soon the fourth" (2.89).
- 37 l. 380 And then she quotes *Antinous* — "gives hope to all, and makes promises to every man, sending out messages — while her mind wills otherwise" (2.91–92, verbatim, kept verbatim). The suitor's complaint, in the goddess's mouth, as praise: what Antinous called cheating, Athena reports as strategy. Penelope's double game is confirmed at the highest level, in her enemy's own words — the poem's final word on whose side that famous ambiguity is on.
- 38 l. 386 "Weave a design, how I shall pay them back" — he asks the goddess for exactly what she offered (303), in the same metaphor. Then the old soldier's requisition: stand beside me "as on the day we loosed the shining head-veil of Troy" — and I'll fight three hundred. The Iliadic partnership, reactivated on a beach, for a war of one household.
- 39 l. 388 Troy's fall as the loosing of a veil — κρήδεμνα, the word for a woman's headdress (Ino's life-saving veil, 5.346; Penelope's, 1.334). The sacked city is a woman unveiled by force: the poem's own widow-simile (8.523–531) compressed into a single genitive. That Odysseus uses it as a happy memory — *our* great day — while the audience holds Book 8's weeping is the kind of double exposure this poem trusts its listeners to develop.
- 40 l. 394 Her battle-promise, delivered with relish: more than one suitor "will spatter the vast floor with his blood and brains." The gray-eyed goddess of wisdom talks like a soldier when the work is settled. Book 22 is signed for, here, in advance, by its second combatant.
- 41 l. 402 The disguise's cruelest clause, stated without softening: you will seem vile "to all the suitors — and to your wife, and to the son you left in your halls." The mask must deceive the enemies *and* the beloved; the plot requires his wife's and son's revulsion at

the sight of him. He accepts it without a word of protest — the price of the test is being untested-against, unrecognizable to the very people whose recognition is the poem's goal.

- 42 l. 408 The swineherd is introduced by his loyalty before his name (he will not be named until 14.55): keeper of pigs "whose heart is loyal to you all the same... who loves your boy, and steady-hearted Penelope." His address is given like a deed's coordinates — the Rock of the Raven, the spring Arethusa, the acorns and black water "that feed the rich fat on swine." The poem's aristocratic machinery now routes its king through the hut of a slave; Book 14, the great pastoral of the poem, is on the itinerary.
- 43 l. 417 The father's flash of anger at the goddess — why did you *let* the boy sail into danger, "you whose mind holds everything?" — earns him the coolest divine answer in the epic: I took him myself, "so that he might win himself a good report." Kleos requires risk; the goddess runs the son on the same curriculum as the father, and tells the father so to his face. Parenting, Olympian style.
- 44 l. 425 She discloses the ambush with a shrug — yes, they lie in wait, "but I do not look for that" — and caps it with the poem's running death-sentence formula: sooner will the earth close over the suitors. The threat to Telemachus, live since Book 4, is defused in tone before it is defused in fact (Book 16); Athena spends suspense the way she spends everything — deliberately.
- 45 l. 436 The transformation, executed clause by clause as promised — withered skin, stripped hair, dimmed eyes, smoke-black rags — plus the finishing touch: "the great hide of a swift deer, worn bald." The man whom Menelaus imaged as the lion returning to the fawns' lair (4.335–340) will enter his own hall dressed *as the deer*. The staff and the holed pouch on its twisted cord complete the poem's most consequential costume: the king as the least of the earth, the beggar who tests the world — and the world, from now to Book 22, will be judged by how it treats him.
- 46 l. 439 The parting line closes the book like a hinge: "their plot laid" — βουλεύσαντε, the dual: *the two of them*, plotting as one grammatical unit — and she is away to Sparta after the son. Father and son now stand at the two ends of the poem's map with one goddess shuttling between them, and every plot-thread of Books 1–4 begins to reel back in. The wanderings are over; the *design* has begun.



## Odyssey — Book 14

*The hut of Eumaeus: the slave's welcome, the second Cretan tale, the cloak story.*

But he went up from the harbor by a rough track  
through wooded country, along the heights, where Athena  
had shown him the noble swineherd — the man who cared<sup>1</sup>  
for his substance beyond all the house-slaves noble Odysseus had  
acquired.

- 5 He found him sitting in the fore-court, where his yard  
was built up high, in a place with a clear view all around,  
big and handsome, with a cleared run round it. The swineherd  
had built it himself for the swine of his absent master —<sup>2</sup>  
without his mistress, without old Laertes —
- 10 out of quarried stones, and coped it with wild pear;  
and outside he had driven stakes the whole circuit, this way and that,  
close-set and thick, split out of the black heart of the oak;  
and inside the yard he had made twelve sties  
hard by one another, bedding for the swine; and in each one
- 15 fifty wallowing sows were penned,  
breeding females. The boars slept outside,  
far fewer: for the godlike suitors kept thinning them  
at their feasts — the swineherd forever sending in<sup>3</sup>  
the best of all the fatted hogs;
- 20 and these numbered three hundred and sixty.  
And beside them four dogs always slept — like wild beasts,  
raised by the swineherd, a leader of men.<sup>4</sup>  
He himself was fitting sandals to his feet,  
cutting them from a well-tanned oxhide. The others
- 25 had gone their ways, this man here, that man there, with the herded  
swine —  
three of them; the fourth he had sent off to the city  
to bring a hog to the overweening suitors — forced to it —  
so they might slaughter it and glut their hearts with meat.  
Suddenly the baying dogs caught sight of Odysseus:

- 30 they rushed him, yelping. And Odysseus<sup>5</sup>  
 sat down — pure craft — and the staff dropped from his hand.  
 There, at his own farm, he would have suffered shameful hurt,  
 but the swineherd came fast on his quick feet after them,  
 darting through the gateway — the hide flew from his hand —  
 35 and shouting he scattered the dogs this way and that  
 with a shower of stones. And he addressed his master:  
 "Old man — the dogs came one breath short of tearing you  
 to pieces, and the shame of it would have poured on me.  
 And the gods have given me griefs enough besides, and groaning:  
 40 here I sit, mourning a godlike master,<sup>6</sup>  
 and fatten hogs for other men  
 to eat, while he, perhaps, is starving for bread  
 and wanders the lands and towns of men of alien speech —  
 if indeed he lives still, and sees the light of the sun.  
 45 But follow me — into the hut, old man, so that you too,  
 when you have had your fill of bread and wine,  
 may say where you come from, and all the cares you have borne."  
 So speaking the noble swineherd led him to the hut,  
 brought him in and set him down: he heaped springy brushwood  
 50 and spread on it the skin of a shaggy wild goat —  
 his own bedding, big and thick. And Odysseus was glad<sup>7</sup>  
 that he received him so, and spoke a word, and named him:  
 "May Zeus grant you, stranger, and the other deathless gods,  
 whatever you wish most — since you welcomed me with all your  
 heart."  
 55 And you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd:<sup>8</sup>  
 "Stranger, it is not right for me — not though a worse man came —  
 to slight a stranger: for from Zeus they come, all of them,<sup>9</sup>  
 strangers and beggars; and a gift, though small, is dear —  
 from such as we are: for that is the way of slaves,  
 60 always afraid, when the masters who hold the power  
 are the young ones. As for him — the gods have bound his  
 homecoming,  
 the man who would have loved me devotedly, and given me possessions  
 —  
 a house, a plot of land, a wife that many men had courted —<sup>10</sup>

- such things as a kind-hearted master gives his house-slave  
65 who has labored hard for him, whose work a god makes prosper,  
the way this work of mine prospers, at which I hold my post.  
For that my master would have paid me richly, had he grown old here.  
But he is dead. — And I wish Helen's whole breed had gone down<sup>11</sup>  
on its knees to destruction, for she loosed the knees of many men:  
70 he too went off for the sake of Agamemnon's honor  
to Ilium of the fine horses, to fight the Trojans."  
So speaking he quickly belted in his tunic with his sash  
and went to the sties, where the tribes of young pigs were penned.  
He took two out of there, and slaughtered them both,  
75 singed them, cut them small, and threaded them on spits,  
and when he had roasted all of it, he brought and set it by Odysseus  
hot on the spits themselves, and dusted it with white barley,  
and mixed honey-sweet wine in an ivy-wood bowl,  
and sat down facing him, and pressed him on:  
80 "Eat now, stranger — what house-slaves have to offer:<sup>12</sup>  
young pig. The fatted hogs — the suitors eat those,  
with no thought in their hearts of the gods' watching eye, no mercy.  
Yet the blessed gods love no ruthless dealing:<sup>13</sup>  
they honor justice, and the right acts of men.  
85 Why — even enemies, even raiders, who land  
on a foreign coast, and Zeus grants them plunder,  
and they fill their ships and set off home —  
even on their hearts falls the strong fear of the watching eye.  
But these men — these men know something; they have heard some  
god's own voice  
90 telling his grim death: that is why they will not woo  
in the right way, nor go home to their own, but at their ease  
they devour the goods, high-handed, and spare nothing.  
For every night and every day that comes from Zeus,  
they slaughter victims — never one, and never only two —  
95 and wine they draw off past all measure, and waste it.  
For his livelihood was past speaking. No hero anywhere  
had so much — not on the dark mainland,  
not on Ithaca itself; no twenty men together  
have wealth so great. I will count it through for you:<sup>14</sup>

- 100 twelve herds of cattle on the mainland; as many flocks of sheep;  
as many droves of pigs; as many ranging herds of goats  
in the care of foreigners and of his own herdsmen there.  
And here, at the island's end, wide-ranging herds of goats  
graze, eleven in all, with good men watching over them,  
105 and every day each man of them drives up a beast for those others —  
whichever of the fattened goats looks best;  
and I keep guard over these sows, and protect them,  
and choose out the best of the swine, and send it in."  
So he spoke; and Odysseus ate his meat and drank his wine,  
110 ravenous, silent — planting evils for the suitors.<sup>15</sup>  
But when he had supped, and steadied his heart with food,  
the swineherd filled the cup he drank from himself  
brim-full of wine and gave it; and he took it, glad at heart,  
and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to him:  
115 "Friend — who was the man who bought you with his goods,  
the master rich and powerful as you describe?  
You say he perished for the sake of Agamemnon's honor:  
name him — I may know him, being such a one as he was.  
For Zeus knows, I suppose, and the other deathless gods,  
120 whether I have seen him and could bring you news. I have wandered  
far."  
Then the swineherd answered him, a leader of men:  
"Old man — no wanderer coming with news of him  
could persuade his wife now, or his dear son.  
Drifters in need of keep — they lie<sup>16</sup>  
125 at random, and have no wish to speak the truth.  
Every vagrant who finds his way to the land of Ithaca  
goes to my mistress and babbles his deceits;  
and she receives him kindly, and treats him well, and questions  
everything,  
and as she grieves the tears come falling from her lids,  
130 as is the right way of a wife whose husband dies far off.  
You too, old man, would have a story stitched together fast enough<sup>17</sup>  
if someone would give you clothing — a cloak and a tunic.  
But him — by now the dogs and the quick birds  
have torn the skin from his bones, and the life has gone out of him;



- 135 or the fish have eaten him in the sea, and his bones  
lie on a shore somewhere, wrapped deep in drifting sand.  
So he is dead and gone over there, and grief is left behind  
for all who loved him — for me above all: for never again  
will I find a master so gentle, wherever I go —
- 140 not though I came again to my father's and my mother's  
house, where I was born, and where they reared me.  
And it is not even for them I mourn so much, for all my longing  
to see them with my eyes again in my own country:  
no — it is longing for Odysseus, who is gone, that takes hold of me.
- 145 I shrink from naming him, stranger, even now he is absent,<sup>18</sup>  
for he loved me beyond measure, and cared for me at heart.  
I call him 'my beloved lord,' even far away."  
Then much-enduring noble Odysseus spoke to him again:  
"Friend — since you deny it flat, and say that he
- 150 will come no more, and your heart is set in disbelief —  
then I will say it not just so, but with an oath upon it:  
Odysseus is coming home. And let my reward for the good news  
come the moment he arrives at his own halls:  
dress me then in a cloak and a tunic, fine clothing.
- 155 Before that — though I stand in sore need — I will take nothing.  
For hateful to me as the very gates of Hades<sup>19</sup>  
is the man who yields to poverty and babbles deceits.  
Now Zeus be my witness, first of the gods, and this table of friendship,  
and the hearth of blameless Odysseus, to which I have come:
- 160 all this shall be accomplished exactly as I say.  
Within this very turning of the light Odysseus will be here:<sup>20</sup>  
between this month's waning and the rising of the next,  
he will come home; and he will punish whoever  
dishonors his wife and his shining son in this place."
- 165 And you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd:  
"Old man, I will never be paying that reward for good news,  
and Odysseus will come home no more. Drink your wine  
in peace, and let us turn our minds to other things. Do not  
remind me of all this: for the heart in my breast
- 170 aches whenever anyone recalls my faithful master.  
As for the oath — we will let it be. But may Odysseus

- come — as I wish it, as Penelope wishes,  
and old Laertes, and godlike Telemachus.  
And now it is the boy I mourn past all forgetting — Odysseus' own son
- 175 Telemachus. The gods reared him like a young tree,  
and I thought he would stand among men no whit behind  
his own dear father, a wonder in build and beauty —  
and some immortal crippled the balanced mind within him,  
or some man did: he has gone for news of his father
- 180 to holy Pylos. And the lordly suitors lie in wait  
for his homecoming — so that the line of godlike Arceisius<sup>21</sup>  
may perish out of Ithaca and leave no name.  
Well — we will let him be, whether he is taken  
or escapes, and the son of Cronos stretches a hand over him.
- 185 But come, old man, tell me your own troubles now;  
and tell me this too, honestly, so that I may know it:  
What man are you, and from where? Where are your city and your  
parents?<sup>22</sup>  
On what kind of ship did you come? And how did sailors  
bring you to Ithaca? Who did they claim to be?
- 190 For I hardly think you came here on foot."  
Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
"Then I will tell you all of it, and truly.  
If only there were food for the two of us, for a good while,  
and sweet wine here inside the hut,
- 195 to feast on quietly while others did the work —  
then I could go on easily for a full year  
and still not finish out the tale of my heart's cares,  
all that I have labored through by the gods' will."<sup>23</sup>
- Out of wide Crete I claim my lineage:<sup>24</sup>
- 200 a rich man's son. Many other sons besides  
were born and bred in his hall, true-born,  
sons of his wife. My mother was bought — a concubine.  
Yet Castor, Hylax' son — the man whose blood I claim —  
honored me equally with his lawful sons.
- 205 In those days the Cretan people honored him like a god  
for his fortune, his wealth, and his glorious sons.  
But the death-spirits came and carried him away

- to the house of Hades. And his high-hearted sons  
divided up the living and cast lots for it,  
210 and to me they gave a pittance, and allotted me a house.  
Still, I won myself a wife from a family of wide holdings —  
by my own worth: for I was no empty man,<sup>25</sup>  
no shirker of the fight. Now it is all gone from me;  
but even so, I think, looking at the stubble  
215 you can tell the standing grain. Since then, trouble past measure has  
held me.  
Ares and Athena, yes, they gave me boldness  
and the strength that breaks men's ranks. Whenever I picked  
the best men for an ambush, sowing evils for the enemy,  
my proud heart never once looked forward to death:  
220 far the first, I would leap out and take my man with the spear —  
whichever of the enemy gave me his back in flight.  
Such I was in war. But field-work I never loved,  
nor the housekeeping that rears shining children:<sup>26</sup>  
what I loved, always, was the oared ships,  
225 and wars, and polished javelins, and arrows —  
grim things, that other men shudder at.  
But I loved what the god, I suppose, set in my heart:  
one man delights in one work, another in another.  
For before the sons of the Achaeans set foot on Troy,  
230 nine times I led men and fast-running ships  
against foreign peoples, and rich takings came my way.  
From it I drew out my pleasure, and much fell to me  
by lot besides. My house grew great at once, and thereafter  
I walked among the Cretans feared and respected.  
235 But when Zeus of the wide voice devised at last  
that hateful road that loosed the knees of many men,  
then they pressed me and glorious Idomeneus  
to lead the ships to Ilium. There was no device  
for refusing: the people's hard talk held us to it.<sup>27</sup>  
240 There we sons of the Achaeans made war nine years,  
and in the tenth we sacked Priam's city and set off  
home with our ships; and a god scattered the Achaeans.  
But for me — wretched me — Zeus the deviser designed evils.

One month, no more, I stayed, delighting in my children,  
 245 my wedded wife, and my possessions. And then  
 my heart bade me fit out ships and sail  
 for Egypt, with my godlike companions.<sup>28</sup>  
 Nine ships I fitted out, and the crews gathered fast.  
 Six days after that my trusted companions  
 250 feasted, and I gave victims in plenty  
 for sacrifice to the gods, and for the men to make their feast.  
 On the seventh we boarded, and from wide Crete  
 we sailed with a fresh fair North Wind behind us,  
 easily, as if downstream. No ship of mine  
 255 took harm: unhurt and whole  
 we sat, and the wind and the steersmen held them on course.  
 On the fifth day we reached the fair-flowing river of Egypt,  
 and in the river of Egypt I moored my curved ships.  
 Then, you may be sure, I ordered my trusted companions  
 260 to stay there by the ships and guard the ships,  
 and I sent out scouts to the lookout places.  
 But they gave way to arrogance — followed their own force —<sup>29</sup>  
 and straightway began to pillage the beautiful fields  
 of the Egyptian men: they carried off the women and small children,  
 265 and killed the men. And quickly the cry reached the city.  
 Hearing the shout, at the showing of dawn the people  
 came; and the whole plain filled with infantry and horses  
 and the lightning of bronze. And Zeus who delights in thunder  
 threw an evil panic on my companions, and no man dared  
 270 stand and face it: for destruction ringed us everywhere.  
 There they killed many of us with the sharp bronze,  
 and others they led up alive, to slave for them by force.<sup>30</sup>  
 But as for me — Zeus himself put this thought in my mind  
 (would I had died instead, and met my doom  
 275 there, in Egypt! for more grief stood waiting to receive me):  
 at once I took the well-made helmet from my head,  
 and the shield from my shoulders, and dropped the spear from my  
 hand,  
 and went straight toward the king's chariot,  
 and clasped his knees and kissed them. He spared me, and had mercy,<sup>31</sup>

- 280 and sat me in his car, and took me, weeping, to his house.  
 Truly, man after man came lunging at me with the ash spear,  
 raging to kill me — for they were angered beyond all measure —  
 but he held them off: he feared the wrath of Zeus  
 of Strangers, who above all feels fury at evil deeds.
- 285 There I stayed seven years, and I gathered much wealth  
 among the Egyptian men: for all of them gave.  
 But when the eighth year came wheeling round for me,  
 then there came a Phoenician, a man well-schooled in deceits —<sup>32</sup>  
 a gnawer of men, who had already done the world much harm.
- 290 He talked me round, that one, and took me with him to Phoenicia,  
 where his house and his possessions lay,  
 and there I stayed with him for the full round of a year.  
 But when at last the months and the days were coming to fulfillment,  
 as the year rolled round and the seasons came again,
- 295 he put me aboard a seagoing ship for Libya —  
 a lying scheme: I was to help him run a cargo there,  
 but there he meant to sell me, and take a boundless price.  
 I went with him aboard — suspecting it, but forced.  
 And she ran on with a fresh fair North Wind behind her,
- 300 on the mid-sea track above Crete. And Zeus was devising their  
 destruction:  
 for when we had left Crete behind, and no other<sup>33</sup>  
 land showed anywhere — only sky and sea —  
 then the son of Cronos set a dark-blue cloud  
 over the hollow ship, and the deep went black beneath it.
- 305 And Zeus thundered in the same instant, and hurled his bolt into the  
 ship,  
 and she shivered stem to stern, struck by the bolt of Zeus,  
 and filled with the reek of sulfur; and all the men fell from the ship.  
 Like sea-crows around the black hull  
 they were carried off on the waves; and the god took away their  
 homecoming.
- 310 But as for me — Zeus himself, though my heart was full of anguish,  
 put the huge mast of the dark-blue-prowed ship  
 into my two hands, so that I might yet escape the evil.  
 Wrapped around it I was carried before the deadly winds.

Nine days I was carried; and on the tenth, in the black night,  
 315 a great rolling wave brought me near the Thesprotians' land.  
 There the king of the Thesprotians, the hero Pheidon,  
 took me in — and asked no price: his own dear son<sup>34</sup>  
 had found me beaten down by cold and weariness, and led me home,  
 raising me up by the hand, until we reached his father's halls;  
 320 and he put clothing on me, a cloak and a tunic.  
 It was there I heard of Odysseus. For the king said<sup>35</sup>  
 he had hosted him, a guest and friend, on his way home to his fathers'  
 land,  
 and he showed me all the treasure Odysseus had gathered —  
 bronze and gold and iron worked with labor —  
 325 enough to feed a man's line to the tenth generation,  
 such a store of it lay in the lord's halls.  
 Odysseus, he said, was gone to Dodona, to hear<sup>36</sup>  
 the will of Zeus out of the god's own high-crowned oak:  
 how he should come home to the rich land of Ithaca,  
 330 openly or in secret, after so long away.  
 And he swore an oath to me, pouring the libation in his house,  
 that a ship was hauled down and a crew standing ready  
 to convey him home to his own dear fatherland.  
 But me he sent off first: for a Thesprotian ship  
 335 happened to be sailing for Dulichium, rich in wheat.  
 He charged them to bring me there, with all care, to King Acastus.  
 But an evil counsel about me pleased their hearts instead —  
 so that I might yet come down to the last dregs of misery.  
 When the seagoing ship was far out from the land,  
 340 they set about contriving, then and there, my day of slavery.<sup>37</sup>  
 They stripped me of my clothing, cloak and tunic both,  
 and threw around me different gear — this foul rag  
 and this torn tunic — the very ones you see with your own eyes;  
 and at evening they reached the tilled fields of clear-skied Ithaca.  
 345 There they lashed me tight in the well-benched ship  
 with a twisted rope, and went ashore themselves  
 and hurried their supper along the margin of the sea.  
 But the gods themselves undid my lashing —  
 easily. And wrapping my rag about my head,

- 350 I slid down the polished lading-plank, breasted the sea,  
 then struck out with both arms, swimming,  
 and very soon I was out of the water, clear of them.  
 I climbed up where a thicket of flowering brush stood,  
 and lay there, crouched. And they, groaning loud,  
 355 cast about; but there seemed no profit for them  
 in searching further, so they went back again  
 aboard their hollow ship. And the gods hid me  
 easily, and brought me on my way to the steading  
 of an understanding man. For it is still my portion to live."
- 360 And you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd:  
 "Poor luckless stranger — truly you have stirred the heart in me,  
 telling all this through, all you have suffered, all your wandering.  
 But one part is not in order, and you will never persuade me —  
 that about Odysseus. Why should a man like you<sup>38</sup>  
 365 lie into the empty air? I know it well myself,  
 my master's homecoming: how the gods all hated him,  
 utterly — since they did not bring him down among the Trojans,  
 or in the arms of his friends, once he had wound the war to its end.  
 Then the whole Achaean people would have built him a tomb,<sup>39</sup>  
 370 and he would have won great fame in time to come for his son as well.  
 Instead the whirlwinds have snatched him away without glory.  
 And I — I keep apart, with my pigs. I do not go  
 to the city, unless perhaps watchful-minded Penelope  
 bids me come, when news arrives from somewhere;  
 375 then they all sit around the newcomer and question everything —  
 those who grieve for their long-gone lord,  
 and those who rejoice, eating up his living unpunished.  
 But I have no love of asking and inquiring,  
 ever since an Aetolian cheated me with his tale —<sup>40</sup>  
 380 a man who had killed someone, and wandered over the wide earth,  
 and came to my house; and I received him with open arms.  
 He said he had seen him among the Cretans, at Idomeneus' side,  
 mending the ships the storms had shattered on him,  
 and said he would come by summer, or by harvest-time,  
 385 bringing much wealth, together with his godlike companions.

So you, old man of many sorrows — since some power has brought you to me —

do not court my favor with lies, do not charm me:<sup>41</sup>

it is not for that I will respect you or befriend you,

but out of fear of Zeus of Strangers, and out of pity for yourself."

390 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:

"Truly the heart in your breast is past all persuading —

such a man you are: not even my oath won you over; nothing convinces you.

Come then, let us make a bargain of it — and above the two of us let the gods who hold Olympus stand witness on both sides.

395 If your master comes home, to this very house,

you dress me in a cloak and a tunic, and send me on

to Dulichium, where my own heart longs to be;

and if your master does not come as I say he will,

set your slaves on me: pitch me down from the great rock —<sup>42</sup>

400 so that the next beggar too may think twice before he cheats."

And the noble swineherd answered him, and said:

"Stranger — yes! and a fine name I would win among mankind for goodness, now and ever after,

I who led you to my hut and gave you a guest's due,

405 if then I killed you and took the dear life out of you:

with a clean heart, after that, I could pray to Zeus the son of Cronos!<sup>43</sup>

But it is supper time. Soon now my companions

should be in, so we can make a savory supper in the hut."

So the two of them spoke such things to one another;

410 and the swine came near, and the men who herd them.

They shut the sows in their pens for the night's sleep,

and a clamor past speech went up as the swine were folded.

Then the noble swineherd called to his companions:

"Bring the best of the hogs, so I may slaughter it for a guest<sup>44</sup>

415 from far away. And we will have some good of it ourselves,

who bear the misery of these white-tusked swine and suffer for it so long, while others eat our labor and pay nothing."

So speaking, he split the firewood with the pitiless bronze,

and they brought in a hog, well fattened, five years old,

420 and stood it by the hearth. Nor did the swineherd



- forget the deathless ones: for his mind was set on good.<sup>45</sup>  
 No — beginning the rite, he cast into the fire the head-bristles  
 of the white-tusked hog, and prayed to all the gods  
 that wise Odysseus might come home to his own house.
- 425 Then he lifted an oak billet, left over from the splitting,  
 and struck; and the life left the hog; and the others cut the throat,  
 and singed it, and quickly quartered it out. And the swineherd,  
 beginning the offering, laid raw flesh from every limb  
 in the rich fat, and cast the pieces in the fire,
- 430 sprinkled over with barley meal; and they carved the rest  
 and threaded it on spits, and roasted it with care,  
 and drew it all off, and heaped it on the platters. And the swineherd  
 stood up to divide it: for his mind knew what was fair.  
 Into seven portions he divided the whole:<sup>46</sup>
- 435 one he set aside, with a prayer, for the Nymphs and for Hermes,  
 Maia's son; the rest he served out to each man;  
 and Odysseus he honored with the long unbroken chine  
 of the white-tusked hog — and made his master's heart proud.<sup>47</sup>  
 And Odysseus of the many designs lifted his voice and said:
- 440 "Eumaeus — may you be as dear to father Zeus  
 as you are to me: for you honor such a man as I am now with the best."  
 And you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd:  
 "Eat, my god-touched guest, and take your pleasure in such things  
 as are here. The god will give one thing and let another go,
- 445 whatever his own heart wills: for he can do all things."<sup>48</sup>  
 He spoke, and burned the first-cuts to the gods who are forever,  
 and poured the fire-bright wine, and set the cup in the hands  
 of Odysseus, sacker of cities; and sat down to his own portion.  
 And Mesaulius served them bread — a man the swineherd
- 450 had got for himself, alone, while his master was away,<sup>49</sup>  
 without his mistress, without old Laertes:  
 he had bought him from the Taphians with goods of his own.  
 And their hands went out to the good things spread before them.  
 But when they had put away desire for food and drink,
- 455 Mesaulius took away the bread; and they, filled  
 full of bread and meat, bestirred themselves for bed.
- And the night came on, foul, at the moon's dark, and Zeus rained<sup>50</sup>

the whole night through, and the wet West Wind blew big without ceasing.

- Then Odysseus spoke among them, testing the swineherd —  
 460 whether he would strip off his own cloak and give it,  
 or urge it out of one of his companions, since he cared for him so:  
 "Hear me now, Eumaeus, and all you other companions,  
 while I speak a word of boasting: it is the crazing wine<sup>51</sup>  
 that commands me — wine, that sets even the deep-minded singing  
 465 and giggling softly, and stirs him up to dance,  
 and tosses out many a word better left unspoken.  
 Still, since I have blurted once, I will hide nothing.  
 Would I were young, and my strength stood firm in me,  
 as on the day we laid our ambush and led it under Troy.  
 470 Odysseus led, and Atreus' son Menelaus,  
 and with them I was third in command: they asked it themselves.<sup>52</sup>  
 When we had come up to the city and the steep wall,  
 we lay around the town in the dense brushwood,  
 crouched under our arms among the reeds and marsh-grass,  
 475 and a foul night came on, the North Wind dropping down,  
 freezing; and snow came falling on us like hoarfrost,  
 bitter cold, and ice crusted thick on the shields.  
 Then all the others had their cloaks and tunics,  
 and slept at their ease, shoulders wrapped in their shields;  
 480 but I had left my cloak behind with my companions —  
 fool that I was — never thinking I would freeze:  
 I had come with only my shield and my shining waist-guard.  
 But in the night's third watch, when the stars had crossed their  
 height,<sup>53</sup>  
 then I spoke to Odysseus — he was there beside me —  
 485 nudging him with my elbow; and he listened on the instant:  
 'Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices,  
 I shall not be among the living long: this cold  
 is killing me. I have no cloak. Some power tricked me  
 into a single tunic. And now there is no way out.'  
 490 So I spoke; and he then held this plan in his heart —  
 such a man he was for counsel, and for fighting —  
 and speaking low, close in my ear, he said:

- 'Quiet now, lest some other Achaeon hear you.'<sup>54</sup>  
 Then he propped his head on his elbow and spoke out:  
 495 'Hear me, friends. A divine dream came to me in my sleep.<sup>55</sup>  
 We have come out too far from the ships. Let someone go  
 and tell Atreus' son Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,  
 to send more men from the ships to join us here.'  
 So he spoke; and up jumped Thoas, Andraemon's son,  
 500 fast, and flung off his purple cloak,  
 and set off running for the ships. And I, in that man's garment,  
 lay glad until Dawn shone on her golden throne.  
 Would I were young like that now, and my strength stood firm:  
 then someone in this steading might give a swineherd's cloak —  
 505 both ways at once: in kindness, and in respect for a good man.<sup>56</sup>  
 As it is, they scorn me for the foul clothes on my skin."  
 And you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd:  
 "Old man — that is a blameless fable you have told:<sup>57</sup>  
 not one word of it off the measure; nothing said without its profit.  
 510 So you shall not lack for clothing, nor for anything else  
 that is owed a hard-worn suppliant when he comes —  
 tonight. But at dawn you will knock about in those rags of yours again:  
 for there are not many cloaks here, or changes of tunic,  
 to put on — one only for each man.  
 515 But when the dear son of Odysseus comes,  
 he will give you clothing himself, a cloak and a tunic,  
 and send you wherever your heart and spirit bid you go."  
 So speaking he sprang up and set a bed for him  
 close by the fire, and threw on it skins of sheep and goats.  
 520 There Odysseus lay down; and over him the swineherd threw a cloak,  
 thick-woven and big, that he kept by him for a change  
 of clothing, to put on when some terrible storm arose.  
 So Odysseus slept there, and beside him slept  
 the young men. But the swineherd — a bed in that place  
 525 did not please him, to sleep apart from his swine;  
 he armed himself to go outside. And Odysseus was glad<sup>58</sup>  
 that he took such care of his substance while he was far away.  
 First he slung his sharp sword over his sturdy shoulders,  
 then wrapped himself in a wind-breaking cloak, thick-woven,

530 and took up the fleece of a big well-fattened goat,  
and took his sharp javelin, to hold off dogs and men,  
and went out to lie where the white-tusked boars  
slept, under a hollow rock, in the lee of the North Wind.

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 14

- 1    *l. 3* "The noble swineherd" — δῖος ὑφορβός: the epithet of kings and heroes (δῖος Ὀδυσσεύς) attached, calmly and repeatedly, to a slave who tends pigs. No word in the poem does more social work. And the next line prices the paradox: the man who "cared most for his substance" is one of the οἰκῆες "noble Odysseus had *acquired*" — the poem states the ownership and the nobility in one breath and declines to feel the contradiction. Book 14 is built on that refusal.
- 2    *l. 7* The steading itself is a character-witness: yard, coping, oak-heart palisade, twelve sties — built by Eumaeus "himself... without his mistress, without old Laertes," for an absent master's swine. Unbidden, through the master's long absence: capital improvement as an act of faith. The poem introduces its most loyal man through his masonry before a word of his speech.
- 3    *l. 17* The audit of the herd: six hundred breeding sows within, only three hundred and sixty boars outside — "for the godlike suitors kept thinning them," one fatted hog per day. The arithmetic of the house's ruin is kept in livestock, by the man who must ship the tribute himself. (Ancient allegorists, counting 360, saw the days of the year being devoured; the swineherd counts only his losses.)
- 4    *l. 22* "The swineherd, a leader of men" — συμβώτης, ὄρχαμος ἀνδρῶν: the title elsewhere given to princes (Peisistratus, 3.400). Homer promotes the pig-keeper to the officer class by formula, and will keep doing so. Together with "noble swineherd" it makes Book 14's music: aristocratic diction wrapped around absolute poverty, and meaning every word.
- 5    *l. 29* The dogs' attack, and the trick that saves him: he *sits down* — genuine dog-lore (a seated figure defuses the charge), instantly deployed — while the staff falls from his hand. But the poem marks what it costs: "there, at his own farm, he would have suffered shameful hurt." The king of the island one bite from mauling by his own watchdogs, saved by his slave's stones: the homecoming's true condition, acted out in the first thirty lines.
- 6    *l. 39* Eumaeus' first speech mourns his master to a total stranger, unprompted, before the guest is even seated: I fatten hogs for other men "while he, perhaps, is starving for bread" somewhere. The irony is exact and double: the master is standing in front of him, and is hungry. The poem will spend three books cashing that sentence.
- 7    *l. 50* The guest-bed is "his own bedding, big and thick" — the wild-goat skin Eumaeus himself sleeps on. The man gives the thing he sleeps in. Menelaus gave purple blankets; the swineherd gives his bed. The poem has been grading hospitality since Book 1, and the scale just recalibrated.
- 8    *l. 55* "And you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd" — προσέφη: the poet breaks the third person and speaks to his character, here for the first of fifteen times. In the Iliad this apostrophe belongs above all to Patroclus — the most loved and doomed of men; in the Odyssey, only Eumaeus receives it. Explanations (metrical convenience, formulaic

inheritance) exist and fail: the effect on any listener is tenderness — the narrator cannot keep his distance from this man. The translation keeps every occurrence.

- 9 l. 56 The creed: "it is not right (θέμις) for me — not though a worse man came — to slight a stranger: for from Zeus they come, all of them, strangers and beggars; and a gift, though small, is dear." Lines 57–58 repeat Nausicaa's beach-creed verbatim (6.207–208), as the glossary promised — princess and slave alone in the poem speak the law of Zeus Xenios in its pure form. But Eumaeus adds a codicil no princess could: "from such as we are: for that is the way of slaves, always afraid, when the masters who hold the power are the young ones." Hospitality practiced *from below*, under fear — the same commandment, costlier obedience. It is the moral center of the poem, and the poem knows exactly whom it gave the speech to.
- 10 l. 64 Here the translation follows Murray's text, which prints line 64 before 63 (the second of his two transpositions, catalogued with 3.304–305): the sense runs "possessions — a house, a plot, a much-courtèd wife — such things as a kind master gives his slave." Note what Eumaeus' dream is: not freedom, which the poem's world barely imagines, but the good master's full reward — house, land, wife. The horizon of a slave's hope, stated without bitterness, which is its own indictment.
- 11 l. 68 "I wish Helen's whole breed had gone down on its knees to destruction, for she loosed the knees of many men." The war seen from below: to the great, Helen is a face and a grievance; to the slave whose master she cost him, a breed to be cursed root and branch. The κατ' γούνατα wordplay (may her line fall to its knees, who unstrung so many men's) is a hater's pun, and the poem gives it to the gentlest man in it.
- 12 l. 80 "Eat, stranger — what house-slaves have to offer: young pig. The fatted hogs — the suitors eat those." The menu is the class system: sucklings below, fatted hogs above, and the slave apologizes for the difference while the disguised owner of every pig on the table eats his own property as charity.
- 13 l. 83 Eumaeus' theology is the poem's argument in miniature: the gods "honor justice and the right acts of men" — even *pirates*, he says, who raid with Zeus' own leave, feel "the strong fear of the watching eye" (ὄπις) and go home. The suitors do not. In the swineherd's ethics, professional sea-raiders stand a full rung above gentlemen who eat a neighbor's house: the raider at least knows he owes; the suitor believes it's free. No character indicts the suitors more precisely, and none has read less philosophy.
- 14 l. 99 The estate audit, "I will count it through for you": twelve herds of cattle, twelve of sheep, twelve of swine, twelve goat-ranges on the mainland, eleven more here, plus his own six hundred sows. Eumaeus carries the entire wealth of Odysseus in his head, itemized — the bookkeeping loyalty of a steward who has balanced a dead man's accounts for twenty years and cannot stop. The master listening is the ledger's owner; the poem lets him hear his fortune recited as an elegy.
- 15 l. 109 "Ravenous, silent — planting evils for the suitors": the great double-clause. The beggar's body eats; the king's mind sows (φύτευεν — the farming verb). Every meal in these books is also a war council of one.
- 16 l. 122 Eumaeus' epistemology of vagrants: "drifters in need of keep lie at random, and have no wish to speak the truth"; each one reaches Penelope and "babbles his deceits"

while she weeps and questions. The report is doubly loaded: it is true (we will watch beggar-tales manipulate her), it describes *exactly what the listening beggar is about to do* — and it establishes the tragic economy of hope in the house: lies are the only news supply, so all news is discounted to zero. Odysseus learns here that the truth, when he tells it, will not be believed either.

- 17 l. 131 "You too, old man, would have a story stitched together fast enough if someone would give you clothing." Eumaeus states, to Odysseus' face, the precise exchange-rate of the coming books: tales for cloaks. The poem's most-repeated transaction is quoted in advance by its most clear-eyed victim — who will pay out the cloak anyway (520–522), knowingly, which is the whole difference between him and a fool.
- 18 l. 145 "I shrink from naming him, stranger, even now he is absent... I call him 'my beloved lord' (ἡθεῖον)" — the address of a younger brother to an elder. The name has become taboo through grief; in its place, a kinship term. The slave has promoted the master to family — and the master, sitting three feet away, must hear himself so named and stay silent under the disguise.
- 19 l. 156 "Hateful to me as the very gates of Hades is the man who yields to poverty and babbles deceits" — Achilles' line, almost exactly (Iliad 9.312–313: hateful as the gates of Hades the man who hides one thing in his heart and says another), the most famous anti-lying credo in Greek. Spoken here by the poem's champion liar, *inside a lie*, as a warranty for the true oath he is about to swear. The audacity is the art: he quotes the code of the man who despised him, to notarize the one thing he says all evening that is strictly true — Odysseus is coming.
- 20 l. 161 The prophecy is precise: "within this very turning of the light (λυκάβας)... between this month's waning and the rising of the next." The dark of the moon — which is exactly when the festival of Apollo falls in Book 20, the day of the bow. The beggar names the true date of the revenge to the day, under oath, and is not believed. Prophecy in this poem is never wrong, only discounted — and this time the prophet is the event.
- 21 l. 180 Eumaeus' grief widens to the son: the ambush may end "the line of godlike Arceisius... and leave no name." The slave counts the dynasty's generations like the family's own (four, as at 4.755) and fears its extinction as his own catastrophe — which, in the world of 61–67, it literally would be: a slave's whole fortune is the quality of his masters.
- 22 l. 187 The identity-questions, verbatim from Telemachus' to Athena (1.170–173) down to the small joke, "for I hardly think you came here on foot." A slave interrogates the stranger with the same formula princes use — Book 14's leveling machine at work again — and receives, as answer, the poem's longest and best lie.
- 23 l. 193 The preamble to the Cretan tale — give me food and quiet "and I could go on easily for a full year" — signals the genre: this is a professional's performance, with the fee (food, wine, and peace to talk) named up front. What follows (199–359) is the greatest of the Cretan tales: 160 lines of fiction built, like all his best work, almost entirely out of relocated truth.
- 24 l. 199 The false autobiography is a variant self: Cretan, a bought concubine's son honored equally with the true-born — then cheated of the inheritance by the legitimate heirs. A

man of Odysseus' talents starting from *no* position: the tale runs his own qualities (ambush-craft, restlessness, command) through a harder childhood. His fictions are always thought-experiments on himself — Odysseus minus one advantage, compounding differently.

- 25 l. 211 "I was no empty man, no battle-shirker... looking at the stubble you can tell the standing grain." The harvest-metaphor for ruined greatness — the finest line the beggar-persona ever gets, and it does double duty: it begs respect for the fiction and pleads, through the mask, for the real man in the rags.
- 26 l. 222 The confession of vocation: field-work and housekeeping "I never loved... what I loved, always, was the oared ships, and wars, and polished javelins, and arrows — grim things, that other men shudder at. But I loved what the god, I suppose, set in my heart: one man delights in one work, another in another." The most honest sentence in the lie: it is Odysseus' own psychology, barely translated. The poem's theory of temperament — desire as a god-given allotment, beyond praise or blame — is delivered by a fictional Cretan and believed by everyone, including, perhaps, the speaker.
- 27 l. 238 "There was no device for refusing: the people's hard talk held us to it" — δῆμου φῆμις; the voice of the community as a compulsion no lord can defy. One line on how the levy for Troy actually worked: reputation-pressure, not conscription. The real Odysseus feigned madness to dodge the draft (a tale the poem knows but never tells); his fiction goes quietly, dreading gossip.
- 28 l. 246 The Egypt raid replays the Cicones (9.39–61) beat for beat — landfall, the captain's orders ignored, the crew's greed, the countryside roused, dawn counterattack, rout. He has folded his own worst command failure into the fiction, unimproved. Even his lies keep honest accounts of how expeditions die: not by monsters, but by indiscipline between one landfall and the next dawn.
- 29 l. 262 "They gave way to arrogance (ὑβρεῖ)... carried off the women and small children, and killed the men." The raid is narrated without euphemism — this is what his profession is when it goes to plan, and the fictional crew's atrocity is the real trade's routine. Told in a slave's hut, to a man whom exactly such a raid enslaved as a child (15.403ff.), by the man who owns him. The poem's ironies do not come tighter.
- 30 l. 271 "Others they led up alive, to slave for them by force" — δούλιον ἡμᾶρ hangs over the whole tale. The Cretan's companions become slaves in Egypt; the Cretan himself will be nearly sold twice more before the tale ends. To his audience of one slave, slavery is the fiction's recurring weather — the fate the teller keeps grazing and dodging, which his listener did not dodge.
- 31 l. 278 The supplication scene: helmet off, shield down, spear dropped, the king's knees kissed — and it *works*: "he spared me, and had mercy... he feared the wrath of Zeus of Strangers, who above all feels fury at evil deeds." The Egyptian king is the anti-Polyphemus: identical doctrine (9.269–271), opposite verdict. In Odysseus' fictions the *xenia*-law functions — his invented world is more pious than the one he has actually sailed.
- 32 l. 288 The Phoenician "gnawer" (τρώκτης) — the swindling trader who sells passengers — is the stock villain of Greek sea-lore (the type returns in Eumaeus' own life story,



- 15.415ff.). Note the economy of prejudice: Phaeacians are the fantasy of seafaring (escort freely given), Phoenicians its libel (passage as kidnapping). Both are mirrors of the Greek trader looking at himself.
- 33 l. 301 Lines 301–309 reuse the true shipwreck of Book 12 nearly verbatim — the dark-blue cloud (12.403–406), the thunderbolt, sulfur, men like sea-crows, "the god took away their homecoming" (12.415–419) — and the translation repeats itself accordingly. The liar plagiarizes his own catastrophe: the realest thing that ever happened to him is cut and pasted into the fiction, because nothing invented could beat it. For the poem's audience, who heard it three books ago as truth, the effect is vertiginous — the same verses, now load-bearing in a lie.
- 34 l. 316 Pheidon takes him in "and asked no price" (ἀπρίστην) — the word marks the alternative fate: a castaway is salvage, and decency is declining to sell him. The Thesprotian interlude is built to be checkable-sounding: a named king, the king's own son for a rescuer, an oath over libation. This same tale, nearly verbatim, will be retold to Penelope (19.269ff.) — he is drafting, tonight, the version his wife will hear.
- 35 l. 321 Inside the lie, the truth, one ring out: Odysseus alive, heavy with banked treasure ("enough to feed a man's line to the tenth generation" — a hoard to rival the Phaeacians'), the man himself weighing "how he should come home... openly or in secret." That last clause is this very evening's actual question, placed in a fictional king's mouth. The Cretan tales converge on fact asymptotically — alive, rich, deliberating his return — while the Thesprotian bank and the Dodona errand remain scaffolding, invented like the narrator.
- 36 l. 327 Dodona: Zeus' oldest oracle, where the god speaks from the rustling of "the high-crowned oak." The poem's second oracle-consultation (Agamemnon at Pytho, 8.79–81) — heroes check with heaven before the last leg. That the fictional Odysseus consults an oak about *open versus secret* return while the real one sits disguised in rags is the tale winking at its teller.
- 37 l. 340 "My day of slavery" — δούλιον ἦμαρ: the threatened fate arrives at Ithaca's very coast — stripped, re-dressed in "the very rags you see with your own eyes" (the boldest touch: his actual costume, sourced within the lie), lashed in the ship. Then the escape: gods loosen the rope, the swim, the flowering thicket, "the gods hid me easily." The fiction lands its hero on Ithaca by night, hunted, hidden by gods — which is precisely how the real one arrived at dawn this very day. He is telling Eumaeus the truth at one remove, and the poem lets us grade the fit.
- 38 l. 363 Eumaeus' verdict is a masterpiece of critical method: the travelogue moves him ("you have stirred the heart in me") but "one part is not in order (οὐ κατὰ κόσμον)... that about Odysseus." He audits the tale and strikes the one stretch of it that carries the truth — the Odysseus section, its factual core bundled with its invented Thesprotian trimmings. Twenty years of hope-vendors have taught him a filter that now screens out the fact. The poem's meditation on testimony: a lie detector calibrated by grief will fail exactly once — on the truth.
- 39 l. 369 Lines 368–371 repeat Telemachus' lament verbatim (1.238–241): the tomb the Achaeans would have built, the fame for the son, "the whirlwinds have snatched him

away without glory." Son and slave, who have never compared notes, grieve in the same fixed sentences — the household's sorrow has a liturgy, and the poem keeps it word-perfect across twelve books.

- 40 l. 378 The Aetolian — a killer on the run who paid for welcome with a tale of Odysseus in Crete, "back by summer or by harvest" — is Eumaeus' inoculation story, the specific betrayal behind his disbelief. Note the detail: that liar also used *Crete*. When the real Odysseus chose a Cretan persona tonight, he picked, by black luck or the poem's design, the exact provenance already poisoned for this listener.
- 41 l. 386 The great sentence of the book: "do not court my favor with lies, do not charm me: it is not for that I will respect you or befriend you, but out of fear of Zeus of Strangers, and out of pity for yourself." Kindness fully decoupled from credence: I do not believe you, and it changes nothing about what I owe you. Every other host in the poem was testing the stranger's story; Eumaeus alone declares the story irrelevant to the duty. It is the purest statement of unconditional hospitality in Greek literature — from the man with least to give.
- 42 l. 399 Odysseus raises the stakes to a gambler's contract: if I'm wrong, have your slaves throw me off the cliff, "so that the next beggar too may think twice before he cheats." He offers his life as a performance bond on his own truthfulness — safely, since he is the collateral event. The bravado is real and the risk is zero: the house always wins when the house is Odysseus.
- 43 l. 402 Eumaeus' refusal drips with the poem's driest irony: "a fine name I would win for goodness... if having given you a guest's due I then killed you — with a clean heart, after that, I could pray to Zeus!" He declines the wager because accepting it would make him the Cyclops: host-murder as the one unthinkable. Then, without a beat: "But it is supper time." The moral abyss surveyed and dismissed between courses.
- 44 l. 414 For the stranger, Eumaeus breaks his own rationing: "the best of the hogs" — a fattened five-year-old, the class of animal reserved for the suitors' tribute. His stated accounting: we who suffer for these swine deserve some good of them, "while others eat our labor and pay nothing" (νήποινον — the suitors' word since 1.377). One pig, reclaimed from the expropriators, spent on a beggar: the little feast is a small act of economic justice, and everyone at the table knows it.
- 45 l. 420 The sacrifice-scene in miniature, scrupulous at every step — bristles to the fire, prayer, first-cuts wrapped in fat, barley — "for his mind was set on good." And the prayer itself: "that wise Odysseus might come home to his own house" — offered over the fire while wise Odysseus watches from the guest-seat. The swineherd's rite is answered before it is finished; no prayer in the poem has a shorter delivery distance.
- 46 l. 434 Seven portions: one for the Nymphs and Hermes (the herdsman's gods — the local spring-nymphs of 13.356 and the patron of flocks and luck), five for the men, and the seventh — the poem lets us do the arithmetic — for the server himself last. Distributive justice at a slave's table, conducted "for his mind knew what was fair": the same ἰσχύς-ethic Odysseus practiced with his loot (9.42) practiced here with a single pig.
- 47 l. 437 The guest is honored with the chine — the hero's cut, exactly what Menelaus served Telemachus at Sparta (4.65–66) — "and made his master's heart proud" (κῶδαινε

δὲ θυμὸν ἄνακτος). The Greek is a loaded double exposure: the swineherd honors the beggar and, unknowing, thereby honors *the master himself* — the heart the line gladdens is ἄνακτος, the hidden owner's. The poem's grammar knows who is at the table.

- 48 l. 444 "The god will give one thing and let another go, whatever his own heart wills: for he can do all things." Eumaeus' grace before meat is Helen's theology (4.236–237) in a slave's plain diction — the same clause, δύναιται γὰρ ἅπαντα, closing both. Sparta's queen and Ithaca's pig-keeper keep one creed; the poem's religion has no class accent.
- 49 l. 449 Mesaulius: bread-server, and a slave *owned by a slave* — bought by Eumaeus "with goods of his own," from Taphian traders, "without his mistress, without old Laertes" (the formula of his self-reliance, repeated from 9). The poem's most granular economics: property runs all the way down, and even at the bottom of the pyramid a man saves, buys, and staffs. No ancient text otherwise bothers to record that a swineherd could hold an asset; Homer files it twice.
- 50 l. 457 The cloak-night: moonless dark, all-night rain, wet west wind — and Odysseus "testing the swineherd" one more time. He has been fed, blessed, bedded; now he probes the last increment: will the man strip his own back? The test is engineered as entertainment — what follows is the most elegant con in the poem, run for a blanket.
- 51 l. 463 The wind-up is a disclaimer-performance: blame the wine, "that sets even the deep-minded singing... and tosses out many a word better left unspoken." He licenses the boast before making it — the professional storyteller's liability waiver, and a wink the audience can price: this speaker has drunk exactly enough to seem loose while being surgical.
- 52 l. 470 The fable (ἄϊνος): an ambush under Troy — led by *Odysseus*, with the teller as third officer. The disguised man inserts his real self into the story as a separate character, then narrates his own legendary cunning from the outside: the freezing night, the forgotten cloak, and "Odysseus'" solution — a fake dream, a fake tactical errand, and Thoas sprinting off leaving his purple cloak behind. A lie (the Cretan) telling a story (the ambush) containing a lie (the dream) that produced a cloak: three nested fictions, each generating real warmth. It is the poem's compactest model of its own hero — and of itself.
- 53 l. 483 "In the night's third watch, when the stars had crossed their height" — the same star-clock as Thrinacia (12.312), here timing not a divine storm but a freezing man's calculation. The formulas serve comedy and catastrophe with equal precision.
- 54 l. 493 "Quiet now, lest some other Achaean hear you" — the in-fable Odysseus' first move is sound-discipline, whispered "in a small voice." The real Odysseus, telling it, is performing his own legend's tradecraft in miniature: even the fictional rescue begins with operational security.
- 55 l. 495 The fake dream is a small masterpiece of plausible orders: gods send dreams (everyone believes it — cf. 4.795ff.), positions do get overextended, Agamemnon should be told. Thoas volunteers because the errand is *plausible glory* — and the cloak falls to the schemer. Note whom the fable robs: a named hero, Thoas son of Andraemon, still alive and ruling in Aetolia — and Eumaeus' one bad experience was with *an Aetolian* (379). The tale's textures interlock like joinery.

- 56 l. 504 The moral, spelled out twice so no one can miss it: "someone in this stading might give a swineherd's cloak... in kindness, and in respect for a good man. As it is, they scorn me for the foul clothes on my skin." The ask, at last, in the open — clothed (the only word) as nostalgia.
- 57 l. 508 Eumaeus' response is the book's crown: "that is a blameless fable (αἶνος ἀμύμων)... nothing said without its profit (νηκερδέξ)." He names the genre, praises the craftsmanship, *itemizes the angle* — "not without profit" is a critic identifying the con — and then pays out anyway: the cloak comes (520–522), his spare, the storm-cloak. He is the poem's ideal audience: alert to the angle and generous in the same motion. Where Alcinous certified the teller as singer (11.368), the swineherd certifies him as operator — and both reward the performance. He sees the fable's profit even as the larger disguise holds: the listener who catches the con is the one who gives most freely.
- 58 l. 524 The close: the young men sleep inside by the fire, but Eumaeus arms — sword, wind-cloak, goat's fleece, javelin "against dogs and men" — and walks out into the rain-black night to sleep under a rock beside the boars. "And Odysseus was glad that he took such care of his substance while he was far away" (526–527): the master watching his slave choose the storm for the sake of property whose owner, as far as the slave knows, is dead. Gladness is the poem's word; the audience may supply the rest. The book's final line (533) leaves Eumaeus bedded under the hollow rock — Book 14 ending as it began, with Eumaeus guarding what he believes is a ghost's estate, while the ghost, warm under the guard's own cloak, takes notes.

## Odyssey — Book 15

*Telemachus called home; Theoclymenus; the life of Eumaeus.*

- But Pallas Athena went her way to wide-dancing-grounded  
Lacedaemon  
to remind the shining son of great-hearted Odysseus  
of his homecoming, and to stir him to return.  
She found Telemachus and Nestor's splendid son
- 5 sleeping in the forecourt of glorious Menelaus —  
Nestor's son, at least, mastered by soft sleep;  
but no sweet sleep held Telemachus: through the ambrosial night<sup>1</sup>  
cares for his father kept his heart awake.  
And gray-eyed Athena stood near him and spoke:
- 10 "Telemachus, it is no longer good, this roaming far from home  
with your goods abandoned, and men in your own house  
of such overbearing insolence — or they will devour it all,  
dividing your goods among them, and your journey come to nothing.  
Rouse Menelaus of the great war-cry — quickly —
- 15 to send you off, so you may find your blameless mother still at home.  
For already her father and her brothers press her<sup>2</sup>  
to marry Eurymachus: he outbids all the suitors  
in gifts, and keeps raising the bride-price higher.  
Take care nothing is carried from the house against your will.
- 20 You know what kind of heart is in a woman's breast:<sup>3</sup>  
she wants to swell the house of the man who marries her,  
and of her former children, of the wedded husband she has lost,  
she thinks no more once he is dead. She asks nothing.  
No — go back yourself and put everything in the hands
- 25 of whichever of the slave-women seems the best to you,  
until the gods reveal to you your honored bride.  
And another word I will tell you: lay it up in your heart.  
The best men of the suitors lie in wait for you — deliberately —  
in the strait between Ithaca and rugged Samos,
- 30 hungry to kill you before you reach your fathers' land.  
But I do not look for that. No: sooner will the earth close over<sup>4</sup>

- more than one of the suitor-men who eat away your living.  
 Keep your well-made ship far out from the islands,  
 and sail by night as well as day: that one of the deathless ones  
 35 who guards and keeps you will send a breeze behind you.  
 And when you reach the first shore of Ithaca,  
 send the ship and all the companions on to the city,  
 but yourself, before all else, go to the swineherd  
 who keeps your swine — whose heart is loyal to you all the same.  
 40 Sleep the night there; and send him into the city  
 to carry the news to watchful-minded Penelope:  
 that you are safe, and have come home from Pylos."  
 So speaking, she went away to high Olympus.  
 And he woke Nestor's son out of his sweet sleep,  
 45 rousing him with a kick of his heel, and said to him:<sup>5</sup>  
 "Wake up, Peisistratus, son of Nestor. Bring out the strong-hoofed  
 horses and yoke them under the chariot, so we can be on our road."  
 Then Peisistratus, Nestor's son, answered him:  
 "Telemachus — however we press for the road, there is no  
 50 driving through the pitch-dark night. And it will soon be dawn.  
 Wait, then, until the hero Atreus' son, Menelaus  
 famed for the spear, brings his gifts and sets them in the chariot  
 and sends us on our way with kindly words.  
 For a guest remembers, all his days,<sup>6</sup>  
 55 the host who shows him kindness."  
 So he spoke; and at once Dawn of the golden throne came on.  
 And Menelaus of the great war-cry came up to them,  
 fresh-risen from his bed, from beside fair-haired Helen.  
 When the dear son of Odysseus caught sight of him,  
 60 he hurried the shining tunic on about his body  
 and threw his great mantle over his sturdy shoulders —  
 the young hero — and went out; and coming up beside him,  
 Telemachus, dear son of godlike Odysseus, said:  
 "Menelaus, son of Atreus, Zeus-nurtured, leader of peoples:  
 65 send me back now, at last, to my own dear fatherland,  
 for now my heart is longing to go home."  
 Then Menelaus of the great war-cry answered him:  
 "Telemachus — far be it from me to hold you here for long,

- when you strain for home. I would blame another man  
70 as much for it — a host who loved beyond measure<sup>7</sup>  
or hated beyond measure: due measure is better in all things.  
It is equal wrong to push out a guest who does not wish  
to go, and to hold one back who is eager.  
Cherish the guest who is with you; speed the one who would leave.  
75 Only wait until I bring my gifts and set them in the chariot —  
beautiful gifts; your own eyes will see them — and I tell the women  
to lay a meal in the hall from the plenty stored within.  
It is both honors at once — the glory and the profit —  
to dine before you go, over the wide and boundless earth.  
80 And if you care to swing through Hellas and the heart of Argos,<sup>8</sup>  
I will go with you myself; I will yoke you horses  
and guide you through the cities of men; and no one will send us  
away as we came — each will give us one thing at least to carry:  
some tripod of fine bronze, or a cauldron,  
85 or a pair of mules, or a golden cup."  
Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
"Menelaus, son of Atreus, Zeus-nurtured, leader of peoples,  
I want to go home to our own place now. For when I left  
I set no guard behind me over my possessions:  
90 I fear I may perish myself, hunting my godlike father,  
or some fine treasure vanish from my halls."  
And when Menelaus of the great war-cry heard it,  
at once he told his wife and her slave-women  
to lay a meal in the hall from the plenty stored within.  
95 And Eteoneus, Boethous' son, came up to him,  
just out of bed — for he lived not far away —  
and Menelaus of the great war-cry bade him light the fire  
and roast some of the meat. He heard, and did not disobey.  
And Menelaus himself went down to his fragrant treasure-chamber —  
100 not alone: Helen went with him, and Megapenthes.  
And when they came to where his treasures lay,  
Atreus' son took up a two-handed cup,  
and bade his son Megapenthes carry the mixing-bowl  
of silver; and Helen stood by the chests

- 105 where her robes lay, worked all over with figures — she had made them herself.<sup>9</sup>  
Helen lifted one of them out, shining among women:  
the one loveliest in its weaving, and the amplest,  
glittering like a star; it lay lowest of all the rest.  
Then they went back up through the house until they reached
- 110 Telemachus; and fair-haired Menelaus said to him:  
"Telemachus — your homecoming, as your heart desires it,  
may Zeus accomplish, the loud-thundering lord of Hera.  
Of all the treasures lying stored in my house  
I will give you the most beautiful, the most honored:<sup>10</sup>
- 115 I will give you a wrought mixing-bowl — all silver  
it is, and its rims are finished off in gold —  
the work of Hephaestus. The hero Phaedimus gave it,  
king of the Sidonians, when his house sheltered me  
on my way home there. This I would send with you."
- 120 So speaking, the hero Atreus' son set the two-handled cup  
in his hands; and strong Megapenthes carried in  
the shining mixing-bowl of silver and set it  
before him; and Helen of the lovely cheeks stood by  
with the robe in her hands, and spoke a word, and named him:
- 125 "I too have a gift for you, dear child — this:<sup>11</sup>  
a keepsake of Helen's hands, against the hour of the marriage  
you long for, for your bride to wear. Until then let it lie  
in your dear mother's keeping. And may you come rejoicing  
to your well-built house and your own fatherland."
- 130 So speaking she set it in his hands; and he received it gladly.  
And the hero Peisistratus took the gifts and stowed them  
in the chariot-basket, wondering at them all in his heart.  
Then fair-haired Menelaus led them into the house,  
and the two of them sat down on benches and high seats.
- 135 A handmaid brought water for their hands in a pitcher,  
a beautiful golden one, and poured it over a silver basin  
for them to wash, and drew up a polished table beside them.  
The grave housekeeper brought bread and set it before them,  
laying out delicacies in plenty, giving gladly of her store;
- 140 and close by, Boethous' son carved the meat and shared the portions,



- and the son of glorious Menelaus poured the wine.  
 And their hands went out to the good things spread before them.  
 But when they had put away desire for food and drink,  
 then Telemachus and Nestor's splendid son
- 145 yoked the horses and mounted the inlaid chariot  
 and drove out of the gateway and the echoing porch.  
 And after them came Atreus' son, fair-haired Menelaus,  
 bearing honey-hearted wine in his right hand,  
 in a golden cup, for them to pour before they went.
- 150 He stood before the horses, and pledging them he spoke:  
 "Farewell, young men — and carry my greeting to Nestor,  
 shepherd of the people: truly he was gentle as a father to me  
 while we sons of the Achaeans made war at Troy."  
 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:
- 155 "All this, Zeus-nurtured, just as you say,  
 we will tell him when we come. And would that I as surely,  
 arriving home in Ithaca, might find Odysseus in the house,  
 and tell him how I came from you, having met with every kindness,  
 and bring home treasures many and fine."
- 160 And even as he spoke, a bird flew by on the right hand:<sup>12</sup>  
 an eagle, carrying in its talons a huge white goose,  
 a tame one, out of the yard; and men and women  
 streamed after it, shouting. And the eagle, closing near them,  
 shot off to the right, in front of the horses. At the sight
- 165 their hearts lifted: the spirit warmed in every breast,  
 and among them Peisistratus, Nestor's son, began:  
 "Read it, Menelaus, Zeus-nurtured, leader of peoples:  
 is it for us two the god has shown this sign, or for yourself?"  
 So he spoke; and Menelaus, dear to Ares, pondered
- 170 how he might read it rightly and reply.  
 But long-robed Helen was before him, and spoke out:<sup>13</sup>  
 "Hear me — and I will prophesy as the immortals  
 cast it in my heart, and as I think it will be accomplished.  
 As this eagle snatched the goose fattened in the house,  
 175 coming out of the mountain where his kin are, and his birthplace,  
 so Odysseus, after much suffering and much wandering,  
 will come home and take his vengeance — or even now he is

- home already, planting evil for all the suitors."  
 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:
- 180 "May Zeus grant it so, the loud-thundering lord of Hera:  
 then even there I would pray to you as to a god."<sup>14</sup>  
 He spoke, and laid the whip to the horses; and they, full of fire,  
 sprang quickly through the city toward the plain.  
 All day long they shook the yoke they bore between them.
- 185 The sun went down, and all the ways grew dark,  
 and they came to Pherae, to the house of Diocles,  
 son of Ortilochus, whom Alpheus fathered.  
 There they slept the night, and he set guest-gifts before them.  
 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,
- 190 they yoked the horses and mounted the inlaid chariot  
 and drove out of the gateway and the echoing porch;  
 and he whipped them to a run, and the pair flew on, nothing loath.<sup>15</sup>  
 And soon they came to the steep citadel of Pylos.  
 Then Telemachus spoke to the son of Nestor:
- 195 "Son of Nestor — will you undertake a thing for me and see it  
 done, as I ask? Guest-friends from of old we may call ourselves,  
 from our fathers' friendship — and we are of one age besides,  
 and this journey has set us still more of one mind.  
 Do not drive me past my ship, Zeus-nurtured: leave me there —
- 200 or the old man will keep me in his house against my will,<sup>16</sup>  
 aching to host me. And I must get home quickly."  
 So he spoke; and Nestor's son debated with his heart  
 how he might undertake it rightly, and see it done.  
 And as he weighed it, this seemed to him the better way:
- 205 he turned the horses toward the fast ship and the shore of the sea,  
 and in the ship's stern he unloaded the beautiful gifts,  
 the clothing and the gold that Menelaus gave;  
 and urging Telemachus on, he spoke winged words to him:  
 "Aboard with you now — quick — and order all your companions,
- 210 before I reach home and bring the old man the news.  
 For I know this well, in my mind and in my heart:  
 so overpowering is his spirit, he will not let you go —  
 he will come down here himself to summon you, and I tell you

he will not go back empty-handed. Angry he will be, whatever happens."

- 215 So speaking he drove the fine-maned horses back  
to the city of the Pylians, and quickly reached the house.  
And Telemachus called to his companions and commanded them:  
"Set the tackle in order, companions, through the black ship,  
and let us board ourselves, and be on our road."  
220 So he spoke, and they listened well and obeyed:  
and they came aboard at once and took their places at the oarlocks.

- So he busied himself; and by the stern of the ship he prayed  
and sacrificed to Athena. And there came up beside him a man  
from a far country, in flight from Argos for killing a man —  
225 a seer, of the lineage of Melampus,<sup>17</sup>  
who once, in time past, lived in Pylos mother of flocks,  
a rich man among the Pylians, in a house of great wealth;  
but he fled to another people, away from his fatherland  
and from great-hearted Neleus, proudest of living men,  
230 who held his vast estate by force a full year round;  
while Melampus, all that time, in the halls of Phylacus  
lay bound in bitter bonds, suffering strong pains  
for the sake of Neleus' daughter, and the deep blindness of heart  
that the goddess laid on him, the Fury who strikes the house.  
235 Yet he escaped his doom, and drove the deep-lowing cattle  
from Phylace to Pylos, and paid the ugly deed  
of godlike Neleus back, and led the woman home  
to be his brother's wife. And he himself went to another people,  
to horse-pasturing Argos: there it was fated for him  
240 to live from then on, ruling over many Argives.  
There he married a wife and built a high-roofed house,  
and fathered Antiphates and Mantius, strong sons both.  
Antiphates fathered great-hearted Oicles,  
and Oicles Amphiaraus, the rouser of armies,  
245 whom Zeus who bears the aegis and Apollo loved  
in their hearts, with every kind of love; yet he never reached  
the threshold of old age: he died at Thebes — a woman's bribes.<sup>18</sup>  
And to him were born sons, Alcmaeon and Amphilochus.  
And Mantius, in his turn, fathered Polypheides and Cleitus —

- 250 but Cleitus golden-throned Dawn snatched away,<sup>19</sup>  
 for his beauty's sake, to live among the immortals;  
 and of high-hearted Polypheides Apollo made a seer  
 far the best among mortals, once Amphiaraus was dead.  
 He moved to Hyperesia, angry at his father,  
 255 and dwelling there he prophesied for all men.  
 It was this man's son who now came up — Theoclymenus  
 was his name — and stood beside Telemachus.  
 He found him pouring wine and praying by his fast  
 black ship, and he raised his voice and spoke winged words:  
 260 "Friend — since I find you burning offerings in this place,  
 I beg you by these offerings, and by the god, and then  
 by your own head, and your companions' who go with you:  
 tell me truly what I ask; hold nothing back.  
 What man are you, and from where? Where are your city and your  
 parents?"<sup>20</sup>
- 265 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 "Then I will tell you, stranger, and tell you truly.  
 By birth I am of Ithaca; my father is Odysseus —  
 if he ever was; by now he has died some grim death.  
 That is why I took companions and a black ship  
 270 and came out for news of my father, so long gone."  
 Then godlike Theoclymenus said to him:  
 "So I too am out of my country: I killed a man  
 of my own tribe; and his brothers and kinsmen are many<sup>21</sup>  
 in horse-pasturing Argos, with great power among the Achaeans.  
 275 It is their death I flee — the black doom of their hands —  
 since now it is my lot to wander among men.  
 Take me aboard your ship, since in my flight I have found you  
 begging: or they will kill me. I think they are on my track."  
 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 280 "Then I will not push you, willing as you are, from the trim ship.  
 Come with us: there you will be made welcome from what we have."  
 So he spoke, and took the man's bronze spear from him  
 and laid it flat along the deck of the curved ship;  
 and he himself stepped aboard the seagoing vessel  
 285 and sat down in the stern, and beside him

- he seated Theoclymenus. And his men cast off the stern-lines.  
 And Telemachus called to his companions and commanded them  
 to lay hands on the tackle; and they obeyed him swiftly:  
 they raised the fir mast and stepped it in the hollow  
 290 mast-box, made it fast with the forestays,  
 and hauled the white sail up by the twisted ox-hide halyards.  
 And gray-eyed Athena sent them a following wind  
 rushing hard through the clear sky, so the ship might run  
 her course at speed across the salt water of the sea.
- 295 And they ran past Crouni, and Chalcis of the lovely streams.  
 The sun went down, and all the ways grew dark,  
 and the ship bore on for Pheae, driven by the wind of Zeus,  
 and along bright Elis, where the Epeians hold power.  
 From there again he steered her for the Sharp Islands,<sup>22</sup>
- 300 wondering whether he would slip past death, or be taken.  
 And in the hut, meanwhile, Odysseus and the noble swineherd  
 were at supper; and the other men were at supper with them.  
 When they had put away desire for food and drink,  
 Odysseus spoke among them, making trial of the swineherd —<sup>23</sup>
- 305 whether he would still befriend him with all care and press him  
 to stay there at the farmstead, or start him toward the city:  
 "Hear me now, Eumaeus, and all you other companions.  
 At dawn I want to go off to the city and beg there,  
 so as not to wear you down — you and your men.
- 310 Only advise me well, and send along a good guide  
 to bring me there. And through the town I will drift on my own —  
 I must — in hopes someone will hand me a cup and a crust.  
 And I would come to the house of godlike Odysseus  
 and give my news to watchful-minded Penelope,
- 315 and mix with those suitors in their insolence —  
 they might spare me a dinner out of their endless plenty.  
 I would serve well among them, whatever they wanted done.  
 For I will tell you this — take it in, and hear me out:  
 by the favor of Hermes the guide, who lends the grace<sup>24</sup>
- 320 and glory to all the labor of men's hands,  
 no other mortal can compete with me at service:  
 at building up a fire, at splitting seasoned wood,

- at carving and at roasting meat, at pouring wine —  
all that lesser men do, waiting on the great."
- 325 Then, greatly stirred, you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd:<sup>25</sup>  
"Ah, stranger — why has such a thought come into  
your mind? You must be hungry to die on the spot,  
if you truly mean to walk into that crowd  
of suitors, whose arrogance and violence reach the iron sky."<sup>26</sup>
- 330 Their serving-men are nothing like you:  
they are young, well-dressed in cloaks and tunics,  
sleek their heads always, and handsome their faces —  
those are the men who wait upon the suitors' polished tables,  
loaded down with bread and meat and wine.
- 335 No — stay. Nobody is put out by your being here,  
not I, and not any of my companions with me.  
But when the dear son of Odysseus comes,  
that man will clothe you in a cloak and a tunic,  
and send you wherever your heart and spirit bid you go."<sup>27</sup>
- 340 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus answered him:  
"Eumaeus — may you be as dear to father Zeus  
as you are to me: for you have stopped my wandering and my grim  
misery.  
Nothing is more wretched for mortal men than roaming:<sup>28</sup>  
it is for the cursed belly's sake men take hard pains,  
345 when wandering and sorrow and grief have come upon them.  
But now, since you hold me here to wait for that young man,  
come, tell me of godlike Odysseus' mother,  
and his father, whom he left on the doorsill of old age:  
are they still living, somewhere under the rays of the sun,  
350 or dead by now, and down in the house of Hades?"  
Then the swineherd answered him, a leader of men:  
"Then I will tell you, stranger, and tell you truly.  
Laertes is living still, but praying always  
to Zeus that the life may waste out of his limbs in his own halls:  
355 so terribly he mourns for his son who is gone,  
and for the wise wife of his youth — her death above all  
has broken him, and brought him raw old age before his time.  
And she died of grief for her son, for her famous son —"<sup>29</sup>

- a wretched death. May no one die so who lives here  
 360 and is a friend to me, and has dealt with me in kindness.  
 While she still lived, for all her endless sorrow,  
 it was some pleasure to me to ask for her and after her,  
 because she reared me herself, with long-robed Ctimene,<sup>30</sup>  
 her stately daughter, the youngest child she bore.  
 365 With her I was raised, and honored little less.  
 But when the two of us came to the threshold of our prime,  
 they gave her in marriage to Same — and got a fortune for her —  
 while me the lady dressed in a mantle and tunic,  
 fine clothes, and bound good sandals on my feet,  
 370 and sent me to the farm. But she loved me from the heart still more.  
 Now I go without all that. And yet the blessed gods  
 make the work prosper under my hand, the work I keep to:  
 from it I have eaten and drunk, and given to those I owe respect.  
 But from the mistress herself there is nothing sweet to hear,  
 375 no word, no kindness, since that evil fell upon the house —  
 those overweening men. And slaves miss it greatly,<sup>31</sup>  
 speaking before the mistress, and learning all the news,  
 and eating and drinking, and carrying something afterward  
 off to the fields — the things that warm a slave's heart."  
 380 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 "Well — how small you must have been, swineherd Eumaeus,  
 when you were carried so far from your country and your parents.  
 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:  
 was it a wide-wayed city of men that was sacked,  
 385 the one where your father and your honored mother lived,  
 or were you alone with your sheep or with your cattle  
 when raiders took you into their ships and carried you over  
 to this man's house, and he paid a worthy price?"<sup>32</sup>  
 Then the swineherd answered him, a leader of men:  
 390 "Stranger, since you ask me this, and want it all —  
 listen in silence now, and take your ease, and sit  
 drinking your wine. These nights go on past telling.<sup>33</sup>  
 There is time enough for sleep, and time to take joy in listening;  
 no need to bed down before the hour: even sleep grows a weariness.  
 395 As for the rest of you — whoever's heart and spirit bid him,

- go out and sleep; and at the showing of the dawn  
eat, and follow out the swine of our master.  
But we two in the hut, over our drink and food,  
will take our pleasure in each other's grim sorrows,  
400 remembering them. For afterward a man finds pleasure even in pains,<sup>34</sup>  
when he has suffered much and wandered far.  
So I will tell you what you ask me, what you probe for.  
There is an island called Syrie — you may have heard of it —  
above Ortygia, where the turnings of the sun are:<sup>35</sup>  
405 not so crowded with people, but a good land,  
rich in herds, rich in flocks, full of wine, deep in wheat.  
Famine never enters that country, nor does any  
hateful sickness fall on wretched mortals there:  
but when the generations of men grow old in the town,  
410 Apollo of the silver bow comes with Artemis  
and visits them with his gentle arrows, and kills them.<sup>36</sup>  
Two cities are there, and everything is halved between them,  
and over both of them my father was the king —  
Ctesius, son of Ormenus, a match for the immortals.  
415 There Phoenicians came — men famed for ships,  
gnawers, with countless trinkets in their black vessel.<sup>37</sup>  
Now in my father's house there was a Phoenician woman,  
beautiful and tall, and skilled in glorious handwork;<sup>38</sup>  
and the Phoenicians, subtle-minded, led her astray.  
420 Washing clothes by the hollow ship, one of them first  
lay with her in love — the thing that leads astray<sup>39</sup>  
the minds of women, even one whose works are honest.  
Then he asked her who she was, and where she came from,  
and she pointed at once to my father's high-roofed house:  
425 'I claim my birth from Sidon, rich in bronze,  
and I am the daughter of Arybas, a man of flowing wealth.  
But Taphian pirates snatched me as I came in'<sup>40</sup>  
from the fields, and carried me over the sea and sold me  
to this man's house; and he paid a worthy price.'<sup>41</sup>  
430 Then the man who had lain with her in secret said:  
'Then would you come home again with us, to look on  
the high-roofed house of your father and mother — and on them?



- For they are living still, and are called wealthy.'  
 Then the woman answered him and said:  
 435 'Even that could be, if you sailors were willing  
 to bind yourselves by oath to bring me home unharmed.'  
 So she spoke, and they all swore the oath she demanded.  
 And when they had sworn and sealed the oath entire,  
 the woman spoke among them again and answered:  
 440 'Silence, now. Let none of your company say a word  
 to me, meeting me in the street or at the well,  
 or someone may go to the house and tell the old man;  
 and he, suspecting, would bind me in hard bonds,  
 and set his mind on death for all of you.  
 445 Keep the word in your hearts, and press the buying of your cargo.  
 But when your ship is full and freighted with goods,  
 let a message come quickly to me at the house.  
 For I will bring gold too — whatever comes under my hand.  
 And there is another thing I would gladly give for my passage:  
 450 I nurse a child of this fine man in the halls —  
 such a knowing little thing, always running out beside me.<sup>42</sup>  
 I would bring him aboard the ship, and he would fetch you  
 a boundless price, wherever you sell him among strange-tongued men.'  
 So speaking, she went off to the beautiful house.  
 455 And they stayed among us a whole year long,  
 and bought and gathered goods in their hollow ship;  
 and when the hollow hull was freighted for their crossing,  
 they sent a messenger up to bring the woman word.  
 A man came, deep in cunning, to my father's house  
 460 with a necklace of gold, strung here and there with amber.<sup>43</sup>  
 And in the hall the slave-women and my honored mother  
 kept turning it in their hands and drinking it with their eyes,  
 offering him their price; and he nodded to the woman in silence.  
 He nodded — then went his way to the hollow ship;  
 465 and she took me by the hand and led me out through the doors.  
 In the forecourt she found the cups and the tables  
 of the banqueters, the men who attended on my father:  
 they had gone out to the people's session and debate.  
 Quickly she hid three goblets away at her breast

- 470 and carried them off. And I followed — in my child's witlessness.<sup>44</sup>  
 The sun went down, and all the ways grew dark,  
 and we came at a run to the famous harbor,  
 where the sea-swift ship of the Phoenician men was lying.  
 Then they embarked, and went their way over the watery paths,  
 475 with the two of us aboard; and Zeus sent down a wind.  
 Six days we sailed on, alike by day and night;  
 but when Zeus, the son of Cronos, brought the seventh day,  
 then Artemis the shooter of arrows struck the woman,  
 and she dropped with a thud into the bilge, like a sea-tern.<sup>45</sup>  
 480 They heaved her overboard, spoil for the seals and fishes,  
 and I was left alone, my heart aching.  
 Then wind and water carried them along to Ithaca,  
 and there Laertes bought me, with his own possessions.  
 So it was my eyes first looked upon this land."  
 485 Then Odysseus, seed of Zeus, answered him with words:  
 "Eumaeus, you have deeply stirred the heart here in my breast,  
 telling all these things — the sorrows your heart has suffered.  
 And yet, I say, Zeus set the good beside the evil for you,<sup>46</sup>  
 since after all that pain you came to the house of a kind  
 490 man, who provides your food and drink with every care,  
 and you live a good life — while I come to you here  
 as I am: still wandering through the many cities of men."  
 So they spoke to each other of such things,  
 then lay down to sleep — no long time, a little only,  
 495 for soon Dawn came on her fair throne. And on the shore  
 the companions of Telemachus were striking sail:  
 they took the mast down smartly and rowed her in to anchorage,  
 and threw the mooring-stones out, and made the stern-lines fast;  
 and they themselves stepped out into the breaking surf  
 500 and readied a meal, and mixed the sparkling wine.  
 And when they had put away desire for food and drink,  
 clear-headed Telemachus began and spoke among them:  
 "Row the black ship on now, all of you, to the city.  
 I will make my way to the fields and to the herdsmen,  
 505 and at evening, once I have looked over the farmlands, I will come  
 down.

- In the morning I will set before you the wages of the voyage:  
a good feast of meats, and honey-hearted wine."  
Then godlike Theoclymenus said to him:  
"And where shall I go, dear child? Whose house shall I come to,  
510 of the men who hold power in rocky Ithaca?  
Straight to your mother's house — is that where I go — and yours?"  
Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
"At any other time I would tell you: come to our house —  
there is no lack there of what a guest is given. But for you, now,  
515 it would be the worse way: I will be gone, and my mother  
will not see you. For not often before the suitors in that house  
does she appear: apart from them she weaves at her loom, upstairs.  
But I will name you another man you might go to:  
Eurymachus, glorious son of thoughtful Polybus,<sup>47</sup>  
520 whom now the men of Ithaca look on like a god.  
For he is far the best man there — and hungriest of all  
to marry my mother and take the honor that was Odysseus'.  
But Zeus the Olympian, who has his home in the bright sky,  
knows whether before any wedding he will bring their evil day."  
525 And even as he spoke, a bird flew by on his right hand:  
a hawk, the swift messenger of Apollo. In its talons<sup>48</sup>  
it held a dove, and was tearing it, and shook the feathers down  
to the ground, midway between the ship and Telemachus himself.  
And Theoclymenus called him apart from his companions,  
530 and pressed his hand, and spoke a word, and named him:  
"Telemachus, not without a god did that bird fly past on the right:  
I knew it, looking at it face-on, for a bird of omen.  
There is no line more kingly than your own  
in the land of Ithaca. No: yours is the power forever."<sup>49</sup>  
535 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
"Ah, stranger, if only that word might be accomplished:  
then you would quickly know my friendship, and gifts  
in plenty from me — any man who met you would call you blessed."  
And he turned and spoke to Piraeus, his trusted companion:  
540 "Piraeus, son of Clytius — you who in other things obey me  
most of all the companions who followed me to Pylos:  
now too, I ask you, take this stranger to your house

and care for him kindly, and honor him, until I come."

Then Piraeus, famous for the spear, answered him:

545 "Telemachus, even if you should stay out there a long while,  
I will look after this man; no guest's due shall he lack."

So speaking, he went aboard the ship, and called the companions  
to come aboard themselves and loose the stern-lines;  
and they came aboard at once and took their places at the oarlocks.

550 And Telemachus bound his beautiful sandals under his feet  
and took his strong spear up from the deck of the ship,  
sharp-tipped with bronze. And the men cast off the stern-lines:  
they shoved out and sailed on to the city, as they were ordered  
by Telemachus, dear son of godlike Odysseus.

555 But his feet carried him swiftly, striding, until he reached the yard<sup>50</sup>  
where his swine past counting were; and beside them the swineherd  
slept, a good man, whose heart was loyal to his masters.

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 15

- 1    *l. 7* The book opens by splitting the sleepers: Peisistratus sleeps, Telemachus cannot. It is the same night in which, at the end of Book 14, Odysseus lay awake testing Eumaeus for a cloak. Father and son are wakeful at the two ends of the poem's map, and the narrative now begins pulling them toward a single hut.
- 2    *l. 16* Athena sharpens the truth to move the boy. The family pressure is real — Penelope herself will say her parents urge her to remarry (19.157–159) — but the Eurymachus particular appears nowhere else, and Penelope's own conduct answers it. The goddess of *mētis* tells the anxious son the version that will make him move fastest.
- 3    *l. 20* This cold little essay on women's hearts — the remarrying widow forgets her first children and dead husband — is Athena speaking, not the poet, and it is aimed like a goad. Its cynicism is precisely calibrated to Telemachus' worst fear (cf. Odysseus' own darker version of the same anxiety at 11.441–456, from Agamemnon). The poem as a whole spends its second half refuting the generalization through Penelope.
- 4    *l. 31* Lines 31–32 repeat Athena's assurance to Odysseus at 13.427–428 word for word — the goddess makes the same promise about the same ambush to father and son separately. The English repeats verbatim.
- 5    *l. 44* A homely detail unique in Homer: Telemachus wakes his friend "rousing him with a kick of his heel" (λάξ ποδὶ κινήσας). The gesture is affectionate roommate-familiarity, and marks how far the shy boy of Book 1 has come.
- 6    *l. 54* "A guest remembers, all his days, / the host who shows him kindness" — Peisistratus' gentle rebuke states the whole social theory of *xenia* in two lines: hospitality is an investment in memory.
- 7    *l. 69* Menelaus' famous maxims of measured hospitality: blame alike for the host who "loves beyond measure" and who "hates beyond measure"; "equal wrong to push out a guest who does not wish to go, and to hold one back who is eager"; and the summary couplet, "cherish the guest who is with you; speed the one who would leave." After the near-imprisoning warmth of Sparta in Book 4 (and with Nestor's clutching hospitality about to be dodged at 199–201), the maxim is also mildly self-aware comedy.
- 8    *l. 80* Menelaus' counter-offer — a gift-collecting tour through Hellas with himself as guide — is princely generosity that is also exactly the delay Athena warned against. Telemachus' refusal (88–91) shows the new sharpness of purpose the journey has given him.
- 9    *l. 104* Helen's robes, "worked all over with figures — she had made them herself," recall the weaving Helen of Iliad 3.125–128, who wove the battles fought for her sake into a web. Here the artistry is turned to a wedding gift.
- 10    *l. 113* Lines 113–119 repeat Menelaus' offer at 4.613–619 word for word — there interrupted by the wedding feast, here finally performed. The English repeats the earlier

rendering verbatim: the silver mixing-bowl with gold-finished rims, work of Hephaestus, gift of Phaedimus king of the Sidonians. Note that Sidon returns three hundred lines later in a darker key: Eumaeus' treacherous nurse is Sidonian too (425–429). Phoenicia in this book gives with one hand and kidnaps with the other.

- 11 *l. 125* Helen's gift-speech is one of the loveliest small speeches in the poem: a robe that is "a keepsake of Helen's hands," to lie in Penelope's keeping until Telemachus' wedding day, when his bride will wear it. The most notorious bride in the world weaves for the marriage of her guest's son — Helen quietly writing herself into a future domestic happiness she never had.
- 12 *l. 160* The eagle bearing off the tame white goose "out of the yard" is the book's first omen and a transparent allegory: the wild raptor from the mountains (Odysseus from his long absence) seizing the fattened domestic bird (the suitors, fed tame in another man's yard). Penelope will dream the same image, geese and eagle, at 19.536–550.
- 13 *l. 171* Helen "was before him" — she out-prophesies her husband, who is still pondering. To her roles in Book 4 (hostess, drug-mistress, storyteller who recognized Odysseus in disguise) the poem adds mantis: "I will prophesy as the immortals cast it in my heart." Her reading is flawless, down to the alternative "or even now he is home already" — which is in fact the truth.
- 14 *l. 180* Telemachus' farewell — "then even there I would pray to you as to a god" — repeats, word for word, his father's promise to Nausicaa (8.467): the formula of gratitude that elevates a mortal benefactor to cult. Spoken to Helen, of all women, it lands with peculiar force; his last word in Sparta is to her, not Menelaus — and the son, unknowing, speaks in his father's exact words.
- 15 *l. 184* Lines 184–192 repeat the outbound journey's lines (3.486–494) verbatim — the day of driving, sunset at Pherae with Diocles, and the dawn departure. Ring-composition closes the Telemachy's Peloponnesian loop in the same words that opened it.
- 16 *l. 200* The dodge of Nestor: Telemachus begs to be dropped at the ship because "the old man will keep me in his house against my will, / aching to host me." Peisistratus' answering assessment of his own father — he will come down and summon you personally, "and he will not go back empty-handed" — is the poem's fondest joke about hospitality as benevolent captivity, the comic inverse of Menelaus' maxim at 72–74.
- 17 *l. 225* The Melampus digression (225–255) is told in the poem's densest genealogical shorthand, and it completes a story the Nekyia left as a riddle: at 11.287–297 we heard of the "blameless seer" bound in Phylacus' halls for Neleus' daughter Pero and the cattle of Iphiclus, without ever being named. Here he is named — Melampus — and the sequel added: escape, the driving of the cattle, revenge on Neleus, the bride delivered to his brother (Bias), and emigration to Argos. The whole pedigree exists to authenticate Theoclymenus: great-grandson of a seer whose gift ran in the blood.
- 18 *l. 247* Amphiaraus, beloved of Zeus and Apollo, "died at Thebes — a woman's bribes": Eriphyle, bribed with the golden necklace of Harmonia to send her husband to the war of the Seven, where he knew he would die. The poem has already set her among the damned wives at 11.326–327 ("hateful Eriphyle, who took precious gold for the life of her own husband"). Note the quiet rhyme with this book's other fatal necklace: the gold-

and-amber strand that transfixes the women of Ctesius' hall at 460–464 while a child is stolen.

- 19 l. 250 Cleitus snatched by golden-throned Dawn "for his beauty's sake" belongs with Orion (5.121–124) and Tithonus (5.1) in the poem's set of mortals taken by the goddess of morning — a one-line flash of myth in the middle of a pedigree.
- 20 l. 264 The identity-question formula — "What man are you, and from where? Where are your city and your parents?" — recurs here from 1.170, 10.325, 14.187. Theoclymenus asks it of Telemachus as a suppliant, inverting the usual direction: the stranger interrogates the host.
- 21 l. 272 Theoclymenus is a fugitive homicide — "I killed a man of my own tribe" — received without hesitation. In heroic custom the exiled killer is a standard suppliant figure (cf. Patroclus in Iliad 23.85–90). The mirror is precise: in the hut across the island, Odysseus' invented Cretan is also a fugitive killer (13.259–275). Telemachus here passes the same test of receiving the dangerous stranger that his father is setting the swineherd — and that he himself will face again with the beggar in his own hall.
- 22 l. 299 The "Sharp Islands" (νήσοισιν ἐπιπροέηκε θοῆσιν) are probably the Echinades off the Acarnanian coast; the route past Crouni, Chalcis, Pheae, and Elis runs up the western Peloponnese before the crossing. Line 300 leaves Telemachus suspended — "wondering whether he would slip past death, or be taken" — and the poet cuts away to the hut for two hundred lines: suspense by scene-change.
- 23 l. 304 The second formal test of Eumaeus (after the cloak-story of 14.459–522): Odysseus proposes to leave for the city and beg. The stakes are practical — the plot needs to know whether the swineherd's care is durable — but the scene's pleasure is the disguise itself deepening: see 319–324.
- 24 l. 319 The king lists his qualifications as a servant: fire-laying, wood-splitting, carving, roasting, wine-pouring — "all that lesser men do, waiting on the great" — under the patronage of Hermes, god of profitable skill and service. The man who strung the bow and sacked Troy inventories the menial arts flawlessly, because a Homeric noble does command these skills (Odysseus can build his own bed, raft, and house). The irony cuts both ways: aristocratic self-sufficiency and the beggar's servility are the same competence in different clothes.
- 25 l. 325 The apostrophe again — "you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd" — the poet's second-person address reserved in this poem for Eumaeus (see note at 14.55). It recurs throughout this book (325, and again in the exchanges below) at moments of the swineherd's strongest feeling.
- 26 l. 329 "Their arrogance and violence reach the iron sky" — Eumaeus' hyperbole for the suitors repeats the formula of 17.565 in advance; the "iron heaven" (σιδήρεον οὐρανόν) is the sky as unbreakable vault. His horrified portrait of the suitors' own serving-men — young, sleek-headed, handsome, in fine cloaks — measures the social gulf: even the servants of the wicked outdress an honest beggar.
- 27 l. 337 Lines 337–339 repeat 14.515–517 nearly verbatim (wait for Telemachus, who will clothe you in mantle and tunic and send you where you wish). The refrain "...a cloak and

a tunic, / and send you wherever your heart and spirit bid you go" is the hut's standing promise, kept at 16.78–79 and finally at 21.339 by Penelope.

- 28 l. 343 Odysseus' blessing (341–342) repeats his oath-frame of 14.440–441 ("May you be as dear to father Zeus as you are to me..."), and then restates the belly-doctrine of 7.216–221 and 17.286–289: "it is for the cursed belly's sake men take hard pains." Wandering, the poem's own subject, is here named the worst of mortal conditions — by its most famous wanderer, disguised, to a man whom wandering sold into slavery.
- 29 l. 358 Anticleia "died of grief for her son — a wretched death": Eumaeus confirms exactly what her shade told Odysseus in the underworld (11.202–203 — not the arrows of Artemis, but "longing for you... took the honey-sweet life from me"). The listener already knows this is true; the teller does not know the listener is the son in question. The dramatic irony is the engine of the whole hut-sequence.
- 30 l. 363 A jolt of household history: Eumaeus was reared by Anticleia herself alongside Ctimene, Odysseus' younger sister — nowhere else mentioned in the poem — and "honored little less" than the daughter of the house. The slave was almost family; then Ctimene was married to Same ("and got a fortune for her" — the bride-price noted with a servant's precision) and Eumaeus was sent to the farm. The kindness is real, and so is the sorting: one child of that nursery was sold in, one married out, and the line between them held.
- 31 l. 376 The most remarkable piece of social observation in Homer: what slaves miss when the great house fails — "speaking before the mistress, and learning all the news, and eating and drinking, and carrying something afterward off to the fields." Conversation, information, commensality, and a small perquisite to carry home: a complete anthropology of the well-run household from below, in four lines, spoken by a slave.
- 32 l. 388 "He paid a worthy price" (ἄξιον ὦνον ἔδωκε): note the phrase, because Eumaeus will use it again at 429 — of the Phoenician nurse's own sale. Master and nurse, kidnapper and kidnapped, are links in one chain of transactions; the formula's repetition is the poem's quiet way of showing that the trade in persons is systemic, not episodic.
- 33 l. 392 "These nights go on past telling" (νύκτες ἀθέσφατοι) — the long nights near the solstice invite storytelling; "even sleep, too much of it, becomes a weariness." Eumaeus frames his autobiography with the poem's own justification for its existence: the night is long, the wine is poured, and a story is the proper pleasure.
- 34 l. 400 "We two... will take our pleasure in each other's grim sorrows, / remembering them. For afterward a man finds pleasure even in pains, / when he has suffered much and wandered far." This is the poem's aesthetic credo in miniature — suffering transmuted by memory and telling into terpsis, delight — spoken by a slave to the disguised master whose own epic works exactly this way (cf. Odysseus weeping at Demodocus' songs, 8.83–92, 521–531, and Alcinous' reflection at 8.579–580 that the gods wove ruin "so there might be song for men to come").
- 35 l. 404 Syrie "above Ortygia, where the turnings of the sun are" (ὄθι τροπαὶ ἡελίοιο): perhaps "toward the solstice-point," i.e., the west or the sun's turning-places — the geography is fabulous rather than mappable, like Alcinous' Scheria. The island's blessedness (no famine, no sickness, painless death from Apollo's gentle arrows) marks



Eumaeus' origin as a lost golden world — the swineherd is an exiled prince of a near-paradise.

- 36 *l. 411* Death by the "gentle arrows" (ἀγανοῖς βελέεσσιν) of Apollo and Artemis is the Homeric formula for sudden, painless death — the kindest end the poem knows (Penelope prays for exactly this at 18.202; cf. 3.279–280, 11.172–173). On Syrie it is the only way anyone dies. The same goddess's arrow, at 478–479, kills the treacherous nurse — the gentle formula turned executioner.
- 37 *l. 416* "Gnawers" (τρώκται) — the same contemptuous word for Phoenician traders that the Cretan tale used at 14.289. Homer's Phoenicians are the poem's masters of the sea-borne swindle: brilliant sailors, sellers of trinkets, stealers of persons. Eumaeus' story and Odysseus' invented voyage with the swindling captain (14.287–297) agree on this ethnography — though the stereotype admits exceptions: his Book 13 Phoenicians land him, and his goods, untouched (13.272–286).
- 38 *l. 418* The nurse is introduced with the formula "beautiful and tall, and skilled in glorious handwork" — the very words that described Athena's assumed shape at 13.289. The poem uses its formula for an admirable woman precisely where the woman will prove treacherous; the dissonance is the point.
- 39 *l. 421* Eumaeus' gnome — sex "leads astray the minds of women, even one whose works are honest" — is the bitter verdict of the man whose childhood it cost. But the story he then tells complicates his own maxim: the woman is herself a stolen child (see next note), bargaining with the only assets she has for the one thing she wants, which is to go home. The poem lets the gnome and the biography argue with each other.
- 40 *l. 427* The nurse's own history, in her own words: daughter of a rich man of Sidon, kidnapped by Taphian pirates from the fields, sold into Ctesius' house. She is Eumaeus before Eumaeus: an abducted child of good family sold overseas. What she then does — steal another such child to buy her own passage home — makes her both the villain of his story and its first victim; the wrong she suffered is precisely the wrong she commits.
- 41 *l. 429* "And he paid a worthy price" — her sale, in the identical formula Odysseus used of Eumaeus' sale at 388. See note there. In her mouth the phrase carries a further edge: she quotes the market's judgment of her own worth.
- 42 *l. 451* "Such a knowing little thing" (κερδαλέον δὴ τοῖον): the child Eumaeus is described with the kerdos-word — "shrewd, profit-quick" — that elsewhere attaches to Odysseus himself (6.148, 13.291). In the nurse's sales-pitch the word is literal: the boy's brightness is his market value ("he would fetch you a boundless price"). The poem's darkest use of its favorite virtue.
- 43 *l. 460* The necklace "of gold, strung here and there with amber" is the trap: while the household women turn it in their hands, "drinking it with their eyes," the trader nods the signal and the theft begins. Amber (ἤλεκτρον) marks the far-northern trade Phoenicians brokered. The scene rhymes deliberately with Eriphyle's necklace at 247 (see note): in this book, gold necklaces buy lives.
- 44 *l. 470* Three goblets and a king's son: the loot of the abduction, precisely inventoried by its victim a lifetime later. "In my child's witlessness" (ἄεσιφροσύνησι) — the grown

Eumaeus passing judgment on the toddler who trustingly followed his nurse's hand. The detail that the father's table-service was left out in the forecourt because the men "had gone out to the people's session" gives the theft its exact domestic hour.

- 45 *l. 479* Artemis' arrow — sudden painless death, the blessing of Syrie (411–412) — strikes the nurse on the seventh day at sea, and she drops "like a sea-tern" (εἰναλίη κήξ) into the bilge, is thrown to "the seals and fishes" (κύρμα γενέσθαι — the body left as prey, the poem's image of unburied death, cf. ἔλωρ at 3.271, 5.473, 14.135), and vanishes from the story. Divine justice, if that is what it is, arrives without comment; the child is simply "left alone, my heart aching" (= 14.286's line-shape) — and sold on Ithaca all the same. The punishment saves no one.
- 46 *l. 488* Odysseus' consolation is the book's hardest sentence to hear well: "Zeus set the good beside the evil for you, / since after all that pain you came to the house of a kind man" — the good beside the evil of kidnapping and sale is enslavement to a gentle owner, with food and drink, "and you live a good life." Set against Eumaeus' own accounting at 371–379 (and the poem's verdict at 17.322–323 that Zeus takes half a man's worth away the day slavery seizes him), the comfort is real, limited, and spoken by the man who owns him — who then, keeping his disguise, ranks his own state lower still: "while I come to you here... still wandering." The poem does not resolve this; it sets the two lives side by side in the dark and lets the wine go round.
- 47 *l. 519* Bitter courtesy: unable to host Theoclymenus himself, Telemachus directs him to Eurymachus — "whom now the men of Ithaca look on like a god... hungriest of all / to marry my mother and take the honor that was Odysseus'." Whether this is despairing irony, a test of the seer, or camouflage (naming the man of power a stranger would be safest with), the lines curdle as he speaks them — and the hawk interrupts before the recommendation can stand.
- 48 *l. 526* The hawk, "swift messenger of Apollo," tearing a dove between Telemachus and his ship, is the omen that cancels the Eurymachus plan; Theoclymenus, reading it apart and pressing his hand, delivers his first prophecy: "There is no line more kingly than your own / in the land of Ithaca... yours is the power forever." The seer pays for his passage at once — and Telemachus quietly reroutes him to Piraeus instead. The dove-tearing hawk will find its fulfillment in the omen-reader's terrible vision at 20.351–357.
- 49 *l. 533* "There is no line more kingly than your own" — the omen's meaning in one sentence. Theoclymenus' function in the poem is to say true things at right angles to the action, and this is the first: the kingship stays in the house of Odysseus.
- 50 *l. 555* The book ends with the two travelers converging: the ship rowing for the city, and Telemachus on foot, striding for the yard where the swineherd sleeps beside his herds — "a good man, whose heart was loyal to his masters." The sentence completes itself, but the scene does not: Book 16 opens in the same yard at the same hour — the division is a breath, not a break — and in the hut the father is waiting.

## Odyssey — Book 16

*Father and son: the recognition at the swineherd's hut.*

- But the two in the hut, Odysseus and the noble swineherd,  
 had lit a fire and were readying breakfast at dawn,  
 and had sent the herdsmen out with the gathered swine;  
 and around Telemachus the yapping dogs went fawning,<sup>1</sup>  
 5 and did not bark as he came. And noble Odysseus noticed  
 the dogs fawning, and the sound of footsteps came to him.  
 At once he spoke winged words to Eumaeus:  
 "Eumaeus, surely some companion of yours is coming,  
 or another man well known, since the dogs are not barking  
 10 but fawn around him; and I hear the thud of feet."  
 The word was not all spoken when his own dear son  
 stood in the gateway. The swineherd sprang up amazed,  
 and out of his hands fell the vessels he was busy with,<sup>2</sup>  
 mixing the sparkling wine. He went to meet his master,  
 15 and kissed his head, and both his beautiful eyes,  
 and both his hands; and a warm tear fell from him.  
 And as a father, in the fullness of his heart, embraces his son<sup>3</sup>  
 come from a far country in the tenth year,  
 an only son, late-born, for whom he has suffered many sorrows —  
 20 so then the noble swineherd took godlike Telemachus  
 in his arms and kissed him all over, as one escaped from death;  
 and sobbing he spoke winged words to him:  
 "You have come, Telemachus — sweet light! I told myself<sup>4</sup>  
 I would never see you again, once you had gone by ship to Pylos.  
 25 Come in now, come, dear child, so my heart may take  
 its joy of looking at you, newly here from elsewhere.  
 You do not often visit the farm and the herdsmen;  
 you stay in town: so, it seems, it has pleased your heart —  
 to look on that deadly crowd of the suitor-men."  
 30 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 "So be it, old father. It is for your sake I have come here,<sup>5</sup>  
 to see you with my eyes, and to hear you tell me

- whether my mother still remains in the halls, or by now  
 some other man has married her, and Odysseus' bed  
 35 lies empty of sleepers, holding only foul spider-webs."<sup>6</sup>  
 Then the swineherd answered him, a leader of men:  
 "Indeed she remains, with an enduring heart,  
 in your own halls; and always in misery  
 her nights and her days waste away in weeping."  
 40 So speaking, he took the bronze spear from him,  
 and Telemachus went in and crossed the stone threshold.  
 As he came on, his father Odysseus yielded his seat;<sup>7</sup>  
 but Telemachus, from his side, checked him and said:  
 "Sit, stranger. We will find a seat elsewhere  
 45 in our own farmstead. Here is the man who will set one."  
 So he spoke; and Odysseus went back and sat down. And the swineherd  
 strewed green brushwood under, and a fleece on top,  
 and there the dear son of Odysseus seated himself.  
 And the swineherd set before them platters of roasted  
 50 meat, which they had left from their eating the day before,  
 and briskly heaped up bread in the baskets,  
 and mixed honey-sweet wine in an ivy-wood bowl,  
 and himself sat down opposite godlike Odysseus.  
 And their hands went out to the good things spread before them.  
 55 But when they had put away desire for food and drink,  
 then Telemachus spoke to the noble swineherd:  
 "Old father, where has this guest of yours come from? How did sailors<sup>8</sup>  
 bring him to Ithaca? Who did they claim to be?  
 For I hardly think he came here on foot."  
 60 And you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd:  
 "Then I will tell you, child, the whole truth of it.  
 He claims his birth from Crete of the wide dancing-grounds,  
 and says he has wandered rolling through many cities  
 of mortal men: so a god has spun it for him.  
 65 Now, run off from a ship of Thesprotian men,  
 he has come to my farmstead; and I put him in your hands."<sup>9</sup>  
 Do as you will. He declares himself your suppliant."  
 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 "Eumaeus, this word of yours cuts to the heart.

- 70 How am I to receive this guest in my house?<sup>10</sup>  
 I am young myself, and have no faith yet in my hands  
 to defend a man, when someone picks a quarrel first.  
 And my mother's heart is divided in her breast, two ways:<sup>11</sup>  
 whether to stay here with me and keep the house,  
 75 respecting her husband's bed and the voice of the people,  
 or to follow now whichever of the Achaeans is best  
 among her suitors in the halls, and offers the most.  
 But as for this guest, since he has come to your house,  
 I will dress him in a cloak and a tunic, fine clothing,<sup>12</sup>  
 80 and give him a two-edged sword, and sandals for his feet,  
 and send him wherever his heart and spirit bid him go.  
 Or if you will, keep him and care for him at the farmstead,  
 and I will send clothing here, and all his bread  
 to eat, so he will not wear you down, you and your men.  
 85 But in among the suitors I would not let him  
 go: too reckless is the insolence they carry —  
 they would mock him, and it would be a terrible grief to me.  
 It is hard for one man to get anything done among many,  
 even a strong man: they are far the more powerful."  
 90 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus spoke to him:  
 "Friend — since surely it is right for me to answer also —  
 truly my heart is eaten through as I listen,  
 hearing you tell what reckless things the suitors  
 devise in the halls, against the will of such a man as you.  
 95 Tell me: do you bow to it willingly, or do the people  
 through the land hate you, following the voice of a god?  
 Or have you some fault to find with brothers — those a man  
 trusts to fight beside him, though a great feud rise?  
 Ah, would that I were as young as this anger of mine,<sup>13</sup>  
 100 or were a son of blameless Odysseus, or the man himself —  
 then straightway might some stranger cut the head from my neck<sup>14</sup>  
 if I did not walk into the hall of Laertes' son  
 Odysseus, and become an evil to every man of them.  
 105 And if they overpowered me by their numbers, alone as I am,  
 I would rather die cut down in my own halls  
 than look on forever at these disgraceful doings:

- guests roughly handled, and men hauling the slave-women<sup>15</sup>  
shamefully through the beautiful house,  
110 and wine drawn off and squandered, and them eating my bread  
idly, recklessly, endlessly — for a work never to be finished."  
Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
"Then I will tell you, stranger, exactly how it is.  
It is not that the whole people hates me and bears a grudge,  
115 nor have I fault to find with brothers — those a man  
trusts to fight beside him, though a great feud rise.  
For so the son of Cronos has made ours a line of only sons:<sup>16</sup>  
Arceisius fathered Laertes, an only son;  
his father got Odysseus, an only son; and Odysseus  
120 fathered only me, and left me in the halls, and had no joy of me.  
And that is why enemies past counting are in the house.  
All the great men who hold power among the islands —<sup>17</sup>  
Dulichium and Same and wooded Zacynthus —  
and all who lord it through rocky Ithaca:  
125 so many woo my mother, and wear this house away.  
And she neither refuses the marriage she loathes, nor can she  
bring it to an end. And they eat on, wasting  
my house. Soon they will tear me to pieces too.  
But surely these things lie on the knees of the gods.  
130 Old father, you go — quickly — and tell steady-hearted Penelope  
that I am safe for her, and have come back from Pylos.  
I will stay here. And you return to this place  
when you have told her — her only. Let none of the other Achaeans  
learn it: for there are many devising evil against me."  
135 And you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd:  
"I know. I understand. You order a man who is thinking it too."<sup>18</sup>  
But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:  
shall I go the same road with the news to Laertes  
as well? Poor man — for a long while, for all his great grief  
140 for Odysseus, he still would oversee the field-works, and in the house  
would drink and eat with the slaves, whenever the heart within him  
bade.  
But now, from the day you went by ship to Pylos,  
they say he no longer eats and drinks as before,

- nor looks to the field-works, but with moaning and groaning  
 145 sits mourning; and the flesh wastes away around his bones."<sup>19</sup>  
 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 "The harder for it; but all the same we will let him be, though it grieves  
 us.  
 For if everything whatever could be had for the choosing by mortals,<sup>20</sup>  
 we would choose first the day of my father's homecoming.  
 150 No — give your message and come back; do not go wandering  
 over the fields after him. But tell my mother  
 to send her handmaid, the housekeeper, quickly —  
 and secretly: she could carry the news to the old man."  
 He spoke, and roused the swineherd, who took his sandals in his hands,  
 155 bound them under his feet, and set off for the city. And it did not  
 escape Athena, that Eumaeus the swineherd was gone from the farm:  
 she came near; and in body she was like a woman  
 beautiful and tall, and skilled in glorious handwork.<sup>21</sup>  
 She stood at the door of the hut, showing herself to Odysseus;  
 160 but Telemachus did not see her before him, did not sense her —  
 for the gods do not appear manifest to everyone —<sup>22</sup>  
 but Odysseus saw her, and the dogs: and they did not bark,  
 but whimpered and shrank in fear to the far side of the farmstead.  
 She signaled with her brows; and noble Odysseus understood,  
 165 and came out of the hall, past the great wall of the yard,  
 and stood before her; and Athena said to him:  
 "Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices:  
 now speak your word to your son. Hide it no longer —  
 so that you two may fit death and doom to the suitors  
 170 and go to the famous city. And I myself  
 will not be long away from you: I am hungry for battle."<sup>23</sup>  
 She spoke, and Athena touched him with her golden wand.  
 First she laid a well-washed mantle and a tunic  
 about his chest, and filled out his frame and his youth:  
 175 dark color came back to his skin, his jaws grew full,  
 and the beard about his chin turned blue-black again.  
 That done, she went away again; and Odysseus  
 went into the hut. His dear son was struck with wonder,  
 and turned his eyes aside, afraid, in case it was a god,

- 180 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to him:  
 "Stranger, you look other to me now than a moment ago:  
 you wear other clothes; your skin is not the same.  
 Surely you are some god, one of those who hold wide heaven.  
 Be gracious, then! — and we will give you pleasing sacrifices,  
 185 and wrought gifts of gold. Only spare us."<sup>24</sup>  
 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus answered him:  
 "I am no god. Why do you liken me to the immortals?  
 No: I am your father — for whose sake you go groaning<sup>25</sup>  
 and suffer many pains, and take men's violence on yourself."  
 190 So speaking, he kissed his son, and down his cheeks  
 a tear fell to the ground. Before, he had held them back, always.<sup>26</sup>  
 But Telemachus — for he did not yet believe it was his father —  
 found words again, and said to him in answer:  
 "You are not Odysseus, not my father. A god is casting<sup>27</sup>  
 195 a spell on me, so I may sob and grieve still more.  
 No mortal man could ever contrive these things  
 by his own wit — not unless a god in person came  
 and made him young or old at a stroke, at will.  
 Just now, I know, you were old, and meanly dressed;  
 200 and now you are like the gods who hold wide heaven."  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 "Telemachus, it is not right, when your own father is here,  
 to marvel at him past measure, or stand amazed.  
 No other Odysseus will ever come to you here:  
 205 he is I — such as you see, having suffered, having wandered long —  
 come in the twentieth year to my father's land."<sup>28</sup>  
 But this — this is the work of Athena, driver of the spoil,<sup>29</sup>  
 who makes of me whatever she wills — for she has the power —  
 now like a beggar man, and now again  
 210 like a young man with fine clothes upon his body.  
 It is easy for the gods who hold wide heaven  
 to glorify a mortal man — or to break him."  
 So speaking he sat down; and Telemachus,  
 flinging his arms around his noble father, wept and shed tears,  
 215 and in both of them rose the longing for lament.  
 They cried shrill, in bursts thicker than the cries of birds —<sup>30</sup>



- of ospreys, or of vultures with crooked talons, whose young  
the country people have taken from the nest before they were fledged:  
so pitifully the tears fell from beneath their brows.
- 220 And the light of the sun would have gone down on their weeping  
had not Telemachus suddenly spoken to his father:  
"What ship was it, dear father, whose sailors brought you  
here to Ithaca? Who did they claim to be?  
For I hardly think you came here on foot."<sup>31</sup>
- 225 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus spoke to him:  
"Then I will tell you, child, the truth of it.  
The Phaeacians brought me, famed for their ships, who give<sup>32</sup>  
passage to other men too, whoever comes to them.  
They carried me asleep in a fast ship over the sea  
230 and set me down in Ithaca, and gave me shining gifts,  
bronze and gold in plenty, and woven clothing —  
all lying now in caves, by the gods' will.  
And I have come here at Athena's prompting,  
so we may plan together the slaughter of our enemies.
- 235 Come, count me off the suitors, one by one,  
so I may know how many they are, and what men;  
then I will weigh it in my blameless heart, and decide  
whether we two can stand against them by ourselves,  
alone, or should look for others."
- 240 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
"Father, I have always heard your great fame:  
a spearman with your hands, and weighty in counsel.  
But what you say is too great. Awe holds me. It could not be<sup>33</sup>  
for two men to fight with many, and strong men too.
- 245 The suitors are no exact ten, nor two tens only,  
but many more. You shall have the count here and now.  
From Dulichium, two-and-fifty young men,<sup>34</sup>  
chosen, and six serving-men follow with them;  
from Same there are four-and-twenty men;  
250 from Zacynthus, twenty young Achaeans;  
and from Ithaca itself, twelve, all of them the best;  
and with them are Medon the herald, and the godlike singer,  
and two henchmen skilled in the carving of meats.

- If we come against all of these inside the house,  
 255 beware: your avenging of their violence could cost too bitter, too grim a price.  
 No — you, if you can think of some defender,  
 think of one who would stand by us two with a willing heart."  
 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus answered him:  
 "Then I will tell you — mark me now, and listen.  
 260 Consider: will Athena, with father Zeus beside her,<sup>35</sup>  
 be enough for us two? Or shall I think of some other defender?"  
 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 "Good defenders indeed, those two you name,  
 though they sit high among the clouds; and they rule  
 265 all others — men in their power, and the deathless gods."  
 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus answered him:  
 "Those two will not stand long apart from the strong  
 din of battle, when between the suitors and ourselves  
 the war-strength of Ares is put to trial in my halls.  
 270 But you, for now: go home at the showing of the dawn  
 and mix among the overweening suitors;  
 and later the swineherd will bring me to the city,  
 looking like a beggar, wretched and old.  
 And if they treat me shamefully in the house, let the heart<sup>36</sup>  
 275 in your breast endure it while I suffer —  
 even if they drag me by the feet through the hall to the door,  
 or throw things and hit me: look on, and hold yourself in.  
 Tell them, yes, to stop their follies —  
 win at them with gentle words. They will not listen,  
 280 not at all: for their fated day is standing near.  
 And another thing I will tell you: lay it up in your heart.  
 When Athena of the many counsels puts it in my mind,  
 I will nod to you with my head; and when you see it,  
 take all the weapons of war that lie about the hall  
 285 and store them up in the corner of the high chamber —  
 all of them; and when the suitors miss them and ask you,  
 talk them around with soft words:  
 'I laid them out of the smoke: they no longer looked like the arms'<sup>37</sup>  
 Odysseus left behind when he went to Troy —

- 290 they are fouled over, as far as the breath of the fire reached.  
 And a greater fear the son of Cronos put into my heart:  
 that in your wine you might raise a quarrel among you  
 and wound one another, and shame the feast  
 and the wooing. For iron of itself draws a man on.<sup>38</sup>
- 295 But for us two alone leave out two swords, two spears,  
 and two oxhide shields for our hands to seize,  
 so we can rush and take them up; and the suitors —  
 Pallas Athena and Zeus the counselor will daze them.  
 And another thing I will tell you: lay it up in your heart.
- 300 If you are truly mine, and truly of our blood,<sup>39</sup>  
 then let no one hear that Odysseus is within —  
 not Laertes: he is not to know it; nor the swineherd,  
 nor any of the household; no — not Penelope herself.  
 You and I alone will learn the set of the women;
- 305 and we might test this or that man of the slaves as well:<sup>40</sup>  
 where one honors the two of us, and fears us in his heart,  
 and where one cares nothing, and slights you — such as you are."  
 Then his shining son spoke out and answered him:  
 "Father — you will come to know my heart hereafter,
- 310 I think; there is no slackness in me — none.  
 But I do not believe this plan will be a profit  
 to us both. Think again, I urge you.<sup>41</sup>  
 You will be a long time going round the farms and testing  
 each man, one by one; and meanwhile in the halls, at their ease,
- 315 they eat through our goods with a high hand, and spare nothing.  
 The women — yes, I would have you find out  
 which ones dishonor you, and which are guiltless.  
 But the men about the farmsteads — I for one would rather  
 we not test them now. Keep that work for later,
- 320 if you truly know some sign from Zeus who bears the aegis."
- So they spoke to each other of such things.  
 And meanwhile the well-built ship was putting in to Ithaca,  
 the ship that carried Telemachus from Pylos with all his companions.  
 When they had come inside the deep harbor,  
 325 they hauled the black ship up onto the land,  
 and high-spirited henchmen carried off their gear

- and took the beautiful gifts straight to Clytius' house.<sup>42</sup>  
 And they sent a herald ahead to the house of Odysseus  
 to bring the news to watchful-minded Penelope —  
 330 that Telemachus was in the country, and had ordered the ship  
 to sail on to the city — lest the strong queen  
 take fright at heart, and let the soft tear fall.  
 And the two of them met, the herald and the noble swineherd,  
 come on the same errand, to bring the woman word.
- 335 But when they reached the house of the godlike king,  
 the herald spoke out in the midst of the slave-women:<sup>43</sup>  
 "Already, O queen, your dear son has come home."  
 But the swineherd stood close to Penelope and told her  
 everything her dear son had charged him to say.
- 340 And when he had delivered the whole of his commission,  
 he went his way to his swine, and left the walls and the hall.  
 But the suitors were downcast, dejected in spirit,  
 and came out of the hall past the great wall of the yard,  
 and there before the gates they sat themselves down.
- 345 And Eurymachus, Polybus' son, began to speak among them:  
 "Friends, here is a great work brought off insolently —  
 this voyage of Telemachus. We swore it would never be done.<sup>44</sup>  
 Come — let us drag down a black ship, the best we have,  
 and gather seamen for rowers, to carry word  
 350 quickly to those two out there: come home at speed."  
 He had not finished speaking when Amphinomus, turning<sup>45</sup>  
 in his place, saw the ship inside the deep harbor,  
 the crew furling the sail and holding the oars in their hands.  
 He broke into easy laughter and called to his companions:
- 355 "No need now to send any message. They are in.  
 Either some god told them, or they saw the ship themselves  
 passing by — and could not catch her."  
 So he spoke; and they rose and went to the shore of the sea.  
 Quickly the men hauled the black ship up onto the land,  
 360 and high-spirited henchmen carried off their gear;  
 and they themselves went in a body to the assembly-place, and allowed  
 no one else to sit among them, young or old.<sup>46</sup>  
 And Antinous spoke among them, Eupheithes' son:

"Damn it all — see how the gods have slipped this man out of harm's reach!<sup>47</sup>

- 365 Day after day our watchers sat on the windy headlands,  
relief upon relief of them; and with the sun gone down  
we never passed a night ashore, but afloat on the sea  
in our fast ship we waited for the bright Dawn,  
lying in ambush for Telemachus, to take him  
370 and kill him. And all the while some god has brought him home.  
Then let us here devise a wretched death  
for Telemachus — not let him slip between our hands. For I tell you,  
while he lives, this business of ours will not be brought off.  
He is shrewd himself now, in counsel and in mind,  
375 and the people no longer look on us with any favor.<sup>48</sup>  
Act, then — before he can call the Achaeans together  
to assembly. He will not hang back, I promise you:  
he will keep his anger; he will stand up among them all and tell  
how we wove sheer murder for him — and could not catch him.  
380 And they will not praise us, hearing of evil deeds.  
Beware they do not do us harm, and drive us  
out of our own country, and we come to the land of strangers.  
Take him first: catch him in the field, far from the city,  
or on the road. His livelihood and goods we hold ourselves,  
385 dividing them share and share among us; the house  
we would give his mother to keep — hers and the man who weds her.<sup>49</sup>  
But if this word displeases you, and you choose instead  
that he live, and keep all that was his father's —  
then let us not go on gathering here to eat away  
390 his store of pleasant things. Let each man from his own hall  
court her with bride-gifts, seeking her; and she then  
may wed the man who gives the most, and comes as her fate."  
So he spoke; and they all fell silent and still.  
Then Amphinomus rose and spoke among them —  
395 the shining son of Nisus, of the lord Aretias' line,  
who from Dulichium, land of wheat and grass,  
led the suitors; and beyond the others he pleased  
Penelope with his talk, for his mind was set on good.<sup>50</sup>  
With good intent he rose and spoke among them:

- 400 "Friends, I for one would have no wish to kill  
 Telemachus. Dreadful it is to kill the blood of kings.<sup>51</sup>  
 No — first let us ask what is the counsel of the gods.  
 If the ordinances of great Zeus approve it,  
 I will kill him myself, and bid all the rest to help;  
 405 but if the gods turn us aside, I say: stop here."  
 So spoke Amphinomus, and his word pleased them well.  
 They rose at once and went to the house of Odysseus,  
 and coming in they sat on the polished chairs.  
 Then watchful-minded Penelope thought of one thing more:<sup>52</sup>  
 410 to show herself to the suitors in their overweening insolence.  
 For she had learned of her son's death plotted in the halls —  
 the herald Medon told her, who had overheard their counsels.<sup>53</sup>  
 She went down to the hall with her attendant women.  
 And when she reached the suitors, shining among women,  
 415 she stood beside the pillar of the close-built roof,  
 holding her glistening veil before her cheeks,<sup>54</sup>  
 and rebuked Antinous, and spoke a word, and named him:  
 "Antinous — insolence itself, deviser of evils! And they say<sup>55</sup>  
 that in the land of Ithaca you are the best of your years  
 420 in counsel and in speech. You were never such a man.  
 Madman! Why do you weave death and doom for  
 Telemachus, and pay no heed to suppliants — over whom  
 Zeus stands witness? It is unholy to weave evil against each other.  
 Do you not know the day your father came here in flight,<sup>56</sup>  
 425 in terror of the people? For they were bitterly enraged,  
 because he had joined with Taphian pirates  
 to harry the Thesprotians — men who were our allies.  
 They wanted to destroy him, to tear the dear heart out of him,  
 and to swallow his great and pleasing livelihood whole;  
 430 but Odysseus held them back and checked them, hot as they were.  
 His house you now eat up scot-free; you woo his wife;  
 you would kill his son; and me you grieve to the core.  
 Stop, I command you. And command the rest to stop."  
 Then Eurymachus, Polybus' son, answered her:  
 435 "Daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded Penelope,<sup>57</sup>  
 take heart. Do not let these things trouble your mind.

- The man does not exist, will not exist, cannot be born  
 who shall lay hands upon your son Telemachus  
 while I am alive and look upon the light of the earth.
- 440 For I will say this outright, and it will be accomplished:  
 in an instant his black blood would run down my spear —<sup>58</sup>  
 that man's. For Odysseus, sacker of cities — many a time  
 he sat me on his knees, and put roast meat  
 into my hands, and held the red wine to my lips.
- 445 And so Telemachus is to me by far the dearest  
 of all men; and I tell him he need not tremble at death —  
 not from the suitors. From the gods there is no escaping."  
 So he spoke to soothe her — and was himself preparing the boy's  
 destruction.<sup>59</sup>
- But she climbed to her shining upper room,  
 450 and wept there for Odysseus, her dear husband, until  
 gray-eyed Athena cast sweet sleep upon her eyelids.<sup>60</sup>  
 And at evening the noble swineherd came back  
 to Odysseus and his son. They were making their supper,  
 busy about it, having killed a year-old pig. But Athena  
 455 came and stood close by Laertes' son Odysseus,  
 and struck him with her wand and made him an old man again,  
 and dressed his body in miserable clothes — lest the swineherd<sup>61</sup>  
 look at him face to face and know him, and go with the news  
 to steady-hearted Penelope, not holding it fast in his heart.
- 460 And Telemachus was first to speak to him:  
 "You have come, noble Eumaeus. What news in the town?  
 Are the haughty suitors back inside by now,  
 home from their ambush — or still watching for me on my way?"  
 And you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd:
- 465 "I had no mind to ask about that, going down  
 through the town. My heart said: tell your message  
 and be quick, and come back here again.  
 And a swift messenger from your companions overtook me,  
 a herald — and he spoke to your mother first.
- 470 But this much more I know; this I saw with my eyes.  
 I was already above the city, where the hill of Hermes<sup>62</sup>  
 stands, on my way, when I saw a fast ship coming down

into our harbor. There were many men aboard her,  
and she rode heavy with shields and double-pointed spears.

475 I thought it was they — but I cannot know."

So he spoke; and the sacred strength of Telemachus smiled,<sup>63</sup>  
and his eyes went to his father — slipping past the swineherd's.  
And when they had ceased their labor and made the meal ready,  
they feasted; and no man's appetite went short of the equal feast.

480 But when they had put away desire for food and drink,  
they remembered their beds, and took the gift of sleep.<sup>64</sup>



NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 16

- 1    *l. 4* The dogs that nearly tore the disguised Odysseus apart at 14.29–31 fawn on Telemachus without a bark. The book runs a quiet experiment in recognition by species: dogs know the beloved familiar (here), cower at divinity (163), and — in the poem's most famous case, waiting at 17.291 — one old hound will know the master himself.
- 2    *l. 13* The dropped vessels are the Homeric seismograph of feeling: work stops; the wine spills; the body answers before the mind.
- 3    *l. 17* The first of the book's two great inverted similes: the swineherd welcomes the prince "as a father embraces his son... come from a far country in the tenth year." The real father sits three feet away, unrecognized, listening. Homer gives Eumaeus the father-simile *before* the recognition scene, so that the true reunion must share its tenderness with a slave's.
- 4    *l. 23* "You have come, Telemachus — sweet light!" (γλυκερὸν φάος): Penelope will greet him with the identical exclamation at 17.41. The slave hears the homecoming first and coins its cry; the mother, a book later, repeats the swineherd word for word — one greeting shared out between the two people who feared most.
- 5    *l. 31* "Old father" — ἄττα, a child's word for a beloved elder, the nursery address a grown man keeps for the man who part-raised him. Telemachus uses it to Eumaeus here and throughout (57, 130; again in 17); it is the same intimacy in the other direction as the poet's own "you" to the swineherd.
- 6    *l. 35* The empty bed "holding only foul spider-webs" (κάκ' ἀράχνια): the most desolate image of the whole absence — twenty years of marriage reduced to what accumulates where no one sleeps. Telemachus can imagine his mother remarried; what he images first is not her new house but the abandoned bed.
- 7    *l. 42* The disguised king rises to give his son the seat. Guest yields to host's son; beggar yields to prince; father yields to child — the gesture is correct in every register at once, and Telemachus, refusing it, courteously waves his unknown father back into his own chair.
- 8    *l. 57* Lines 57–59 recycle the question Telemachus himself was asked by disguised Athena at 1.171–173 — "How did sailors / bring you to Ithaca?... For I hardly think you came here on foot" — and he will put it again, person-shifted, to his revealed father at 222–224. The island's standing joke (nobody walks to Ithaca) is also its standing security question.
- 9    *l. 66* "I put him in your hands" — ἐγγυαλίζω, the formal verb of handing over a charge. Eumaeus transfers the suppliant up the chain of protection with legal punctilio: the slave has fed the guest two nights, and now delivers him — with full disclosure of his story — to the master of the house. That the story is false and the guest owns the house is the scene's silent second floor.

- 10 *l. 70* Telemachus' answer is the poem's most honest confession of weakness: he cannot guarantee a guest's safety in his own house. The failure of *xenia* at the palace is total when the heir must ask a swineherd to keep his guest for him.
- 11 *l. 73* The divided mind of Penelope, as her son reads it: keep the house and honor "her husband's bed and the voice of the people," or marry the best and biggest bidder. He states it without blame — a boy calmly reporting that his mother stands at a fork. Athena used a crueller version of the same fork to hurry him home (15.20–23).
- 12 *l. 79* The clothing promise a third time (14.515–517, 15.337–339) — but upgraded from the hut's version: to the cloak and tunic Telemachus adds "a two-edged sword, and sandals for his feet." The formula's fixed close, "send him wherever his heart and spirit bid him go," stands. What the beggar is actually about to receive is a bow.
- 13 *l. 99* The triple wish — young as my anger, or Odysseus' son, or Odysseus himself — is the beggar playing horseshoes around the truth: the third wish is the fact. He voices his own identity as an impossible hypothesis and dares the room not to notice.
- 14 *l. 102* Murray's text omits line 101 (bracketed in other editions: "...might come back from his wandering; for there is still a portion of hope"); the numbering passes from 100 to 102, as at 10.456.
- 15 *l. 108* The catalogue of what cannot be watched: guests abused, slave-women dragged through the house, wine squandered, bread eaten "for a work never to be finished" (*ἀτέλεστον* — the wooing that can have no wedding). The last item is the coldest: the whole outrage is not even *for* anything.
- 16 *l. 117* The genealogy of only sons — Arceisius, Laertes, Odysseus, Telemachus, one thread of a line four generations long. The Greek hammers *μοῦνον* three times at line-start. No brothers to fight beside him (97–98) is not a misfortune of this generation but the house's structure: everything always hangs on one life.
- 17 *l. 122* Lines 122–128 repeat 1.245–251 verbatim — the suitor catalogue by island and the "she neither refuses... nor can she bring it to an end" analysis, first spoken to disguised Athena, now to disguised Odysseus. Telemachus has been giving this same briefing to gods in beggar's clothing since the poem began. Line 129 caps it with the "knees of the gods" formula (1.267).
- 18 *l. 136* "I know. I understand. You order a man who is thinking it too" (*γιννώσκω, φρονέω*) — Eumaeus' answer compressed to two verbs. The swineherd's mind runs ahead of instruction; it is the same competence Odysseus will trust with the armory keys of Book 21.
- 19 *l. 145* Laertes' decline, stage two: in Book 15 he still lived and prayed to die (15.353–357); now, since Telemachus sailed, he neither eats nor drinks nor oversees the work, "and the flesh wastes away around his bones." Each report of the old man is worse; the poem is preparing the terrible testing scene of Book 24, where the father kept in the dark here will be made to weep by Odysseus himself before the revealing.
- 20 *l. 148* "If everything whatever could be had for the choosing by mortals, / we would choose first the day of my father's homecoming." Telemachus says this while looking at

the stranger who is that day. The pathos is engineered: the wish is already granted and he cannot see it — the last hour of his fatherlessness spent wishing.

- 21 *l. 158* Athena's woman-shape once more "beautiful and tall, and skilled in glorious handwork" — third appearance of the formula (13.289, 15.418). Odysseus and the dogs see her; Telemachus cannot: "the gods do not appear manifest to everyone" (161) — a rule stated exactly once in the poem, at the moment it protects the surprise.
- 22 *l. 161* The line is doctrine and stagecraft at once: divine visibility is selective, so the son can sit oblivious while the father is summoned outside. The dogs, who see her, do not bark this time but whimper away — the third of the book's three canine verdicts (fawn at the familiar, cower at the god).
- 23 *l. 171* "I am hungry for battle" (μεμαυῖα μάχεσθαι): the goddess of craft declaring appetite. Her promise "I will not be long away from you" is kept at 22.205ff, when she joins the hall-fight as Mentor.
- 24 *l. 184* Telemachus responds to the transfiguration with liturgy: sacrifices and wrought gold, "only spare us" — the correct protocol for a divine epiphany (cf. Odysseus to Nausicaa, 6.149ff, working the same script in courtship). The scene needs him to be wrong in the pious direction: he has no category for "father" except "god."
- 25 *l. 188* Nine words end twenty years: "I am no god... I am your father." The revelation is phrased as a correction of theology — and then defines fatherhood not by begetting but by cost: "for whose sake you go groaning and suffer many pains."
- 26 *l. 191* "Before, he had held them back, always" — νωλεμέξ αἰεί. One line measures the whole discipline of the disguise: through Eumaeus' tears, through his own lies, through the night on the threshold of his house. He kisses his son and lets go of exactly one tear's worth.
- 27 *l. 194* Telemachus' refusal — "a god is casting a spell on me, so I may sob and grieve still more" — is the poem's recurring epistemology of reunion: joy this large reads first as malicious enchantment. Penelope will mount the same defense at greater length in Book 23; the family resemblance is precisely their disbelief.
- 28 *l. 206* "In the twentieth year" — the phrase that has tolled since 2.175 (Halitherses' prophecy) and 19.222ff hereafter. Odysseus states his identity in the poem's own units: not name and lineage first, but suffering, wandering, and the count of years.
- 29 *l. 207* Athena "driver of the spoil" (ἀγελείης) — the plunderer's epithet, apt for the goddess managing this homecoming as a military operation. Odysseus' explanation of his shape-shifting — "she makes of me whatever she wills" — hands his own πολυτροπία (many-turnedness) back to its divine sponsor.
- 30 *l. 216* The second inverted simile, crueller than the first: father and son, reunited, weep "thicker than the cries of birds... whose young the country people have taken from the nest before they were fledged." The comparison for reunion is bereavement — parents robbed of children. Twenty stolen years are mourned at the moment of recovery; what they weep for is everything the reunion cannot give back.

- 31 *l. 222* The ship-question again (see note at 57) — now from son to father, in the same fixed close: "For I hardly think you came here on foot." Practicality reasserts itself after the weeping, and the interrogation formula that opened the poem's first disguise scene now serves its most honest conversation.
- 32 *l. 227* To his son, Odysseus tells the plain truth — Phaeacians, sleep, treasure in the caves — where Eumaeus got a Cretan lie running on invented mechanics of its own (14.321ff: Thesprotia, a king's safekeeping, the Dodona errand). The poem grades honesty by intimacy: gods get recognition, sons get truth, everyone else gets craft.
- 33 *l. 243* "What you say is too great. Awe holds me" — Telemachus said exactly this to Nestor at 3.226–227, refusing to believe Odysseus could ever come home and take revenge. The line returns verbatim with the situation transformed: then he could not hope it; now the plan itself stands before him asking for a head-count.
- 34 *l. 247* The arithmetic of the odds, at last made explicit: 52 from Dulichium (plus six servants), 24 from Same, 20 from Zacynthus, 12 from Ithaca — 108 suitors, with herald, singer, and two carvers besides — against a father, a son, and (unknown yet) two herdsmen. The catalogue is epic convention turned tactical briefing.
- 35 *l. 260* Odysseus' answer to "find a defender" is a riddle with one pious solution: will Athena and Zeus *do*? Telemachus' reply — good defenders, "though they sit high among the clouds" — has a young man's dry realism about divine assistance; his father's correction (267–269) is a veteran's: those two never miss a real fight.
- 36 *l. 274* The hardest order in the plan: watch your father be abused and endure it. The trials come exactly as forecast — the footstool (17.462), the ox-hoof (20.299), the taunts — and Telemachus' obedience, biting down rage at each, becomes his coming-of-age. The command "look on, and hold yourself in" is the family discipline: Odysseus has been obeying it himself since Book 13.
- 37 *l. 288* The prepared speech about the armor is a masterpiece of plausible lying, and Odysseus scripts it verbatim for his son: soot-damage plus a proverb. Telemachus delivers it, lightly adapted, at 19.5–13. Teaching your child a cover story, speech by speech, is also a form of inheritance.
- 38 *l. 294* "Iron of itself draws a man on" (αὐτὸς γὰρ ἐφέλκεται ἄνδρα σίδηρος) — the poem's most quoted proverb: weapons in reach create the violence they wait for. That it appears inside a fabricated excuse does not make it less true; the plan works because the lie is wisdom.
- 39 *l. 300* "If you are truly mine, and truly of our blood" — the recognition is minutes old and already conditional, a test wrapped in an endearment. The secrecy list that follows — not Laertes, not Eumaeus, not Penelope herself — is breathtaking in its exclusions: the wife who has held the house twenty years is ranked with the servants for operational security. The poem will spend Books 19 and 23 paying the cost of that decision.
- 40 *l. 305* Testing the slaves — who honors, who slights — is the seed of the poem's harshest justice: the loyal (Eumaeus, Philoetius) will be armed and elevated; the disloyal (Melanthius, the twelve women) will die terribly in Book 22. The household is about to be audited.

- 41 *l. 311* Telemachus amends his father's plan — respectfully, precisely: testing the farm-men one by one wastes time while the suitors eat; test the women, defer the men. And Odysseus accepts it silently (the plan proceeds as amended). The son's first act after recognition is to out-plan the master planner on a point of economy; nothing could please the poem — or the father — more.
- 42 *l. 327* Piraeus son of Clytius took charge of Theoclymenus and the gifts at 15.539ff; the treasure goes to his father's house for safekeeping. The seer waits offstage until 17.
- 43 *l. 336* The two messengers, graded by manner: the herald blurts the news "in the midst of the slave-women" — broadcast, artless; the swineherd "stood close to Penelope" and delivers privately, exactly as charged (133: "her only"). One line each, and the poem has drawn the whole difference between an employee and a loyalist.
- 44 *l. 347* "We swore it would never be done" — Eurymachus convicts the suitors out of his own mouth: the voyage they mocked in Book 2 is "a great work brought off insolently" (ὑπερφιάλως — their own signature adverb, handed to Telemachus almost with respect).
- 45 *l. 351* Amphinomus enters the poem laughing — "easy laughter," seeing the ambush ship come home empty. He is introduced at 394–398 as the decent one: best-liked by Penelope, "his mind was set on good." His speech (400–405) merely postpones the murder pending an omen, and that half-decency is enough for Odysseus to try to save him at 18.119ff — and not enough to save him from Telemachus' spear at 22.89ff. The poem gives its most sympathetic suitor a coward's virtue: he objects, and stays.
- 46 *l. 361* A private assembly: the suitors take the public ἀγορή of Ithaca — dormant since Book 2 — and let "no one else... sit among them, young or old." The civic organ of the island is briefly a gangsters' caucus; Antinous' speech inside it is an open conspiracy to murder the man who convened the real assembly.
- 47 *l. 364* Antinous' speech is the conspiracy stripped of pretense: the ambush confessed in operational detail (watchers on the headlands, relays, nights afloat), the failure blamed on a god, and the conclusion drawn without a blush — kill him faster. Note what he fears: not guilt, but publicity — Telemachus telling the assembly, the people's anger, exile (376–382). Antinous' conscience is entirely political.
- 48 *l. 375* "The people no longer look on us with any favor" — the suitors know the δῆμος has turned. The line quietly answers Odysseus' question at 95–96 (does the town hate Telemachus?): no — it is coming to hate *them*. The revenge of Book 22, lawless as it looks, will have public opinion behind it — until Book 24 tests even that.
- 49 *l. 383* The two options Antinous offers are annihilation or divestment: murder Telemachus and split his goods (the house thrown to the mother and her new man), or disband the siege and woo like decent men with bride-gifts from their own halls. The second option — simply behaving properly — has been available for three years. It is offered here only as leverage, and no one takes it.
- 50 *l. 397* Amphinomus "pleased Penelope with his talk, for his mind was set on good" — the single line that will weigh most in his scenes to come. See note at 351.
- 51 *l. 401* "Dreadful it is to kill the blood of kings" (δεινὸν δὲ γένος βασιλῆϊόν ἐστιν κτείνειν): Amphinomus' scruple is dynastic taboo, not mercy — and even it must be sub-

contracted to Zeus for permission. Still, in this company, a superstition against regicide passes for a conscience.

- 52 *l. 409* "Then watchful-minded Penelope thought of one thing more" — the ἐνόησε formula (2.382 family) that elsewhere launches Athena's and Nausicaa's stratagems here powers Penelope's boldest public act so far: she comes down to face her son's would-be murderers with the plot still warm.
- 53 *l. 412* Medon the herald — the suitors' own crier — overheard their council and told the queen, just as he carried her their first murder-plot in Book 4 (4.677–679): the machine's standing leak. Odysseus will spare him for it in the slaughter (22.357ff), on Telemachus' word.
- 54 *l. 415* The veil-and-pillar lines repeat 1.333–334 exactly — Penelope's fixed entrance. But in Book 1 she came down to stop a song; now she comes down to stop a murder. Same doorway, same glistening veil, and the poem lets the identical frame measure how far the stakes have risen.
- 55 *l. 418* Penelope's rebuke of Antinous is the sharpest speech she has made: insult ("insolence itself"), demolition of his reputation ("they say you are the best... You were never such a man"), indictment (suppliants, Zeus as witness), and then the unanswerable family history: your father ran to this house for his life, and Odysseus saved him. The debt is precise — Eueithes owed Odysseus his life, his son repays it by devouring the house and plotting the heir's murder.
- 56 *l. 424* The Eueithes backstory — Taphian piracy against allied Thesprotians, the mob, Odysseus' protection — is new information, planted with terrible economy: this same Eueithes will lead the kinsmen's revolt in Book 24, raging for the son Odysseus kills, having forgotten the life Odysseus gave him. The poem's moral bookkeeping spans both ends of the epic through one minor name.
- 57 *l. 435* "Daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded Penelope" — the ceremonial vocative (first appearance; it will recur through Books 17–24). Eurymachus reaches for maximum formality because he is about to tell maximum lies.
- 58 *l. 441* Eurymachus' oath is engineered irony at its cruellest: "his black blood would run down my spear — that man's" — while he plots that man's death; and the childhood memory he cites (Odysseus dandling him, roast meat, red wine held to his lips) is presumably true, which makes it worse. At 22.79ff Eurymachus will draw on Odysseus and die with the sacker of cities' arrow in his liver — his own blood, the spear the other way. The narrator's flat epilogue (448) has already convicted him.
- 59 *l. 448* "So he spoke to soothe her — and was himself preparing the boy's destruction": the narrator's single-line exposure, the poem's coldest use of its omniscience. No rhetoric; just the two clauses set side by side.
- 60 *l. 449* Lines 450–451 repeat 1.363–364 verbatim: she weeps for Odysseus until Athena gives sleep. The refrain of Penelope's nights closes appearance after appearance like a door; it will sound again at 19.602–604 and 21.357–358. Within it the queen's entire interior life is kept — offstage, nightly, unchanged for twenty years.

- 61 *l. 457* The re-disguise, with reason given: not that Eumaeus is disloyal, but that he could not hold such news — he would run to Penelope with it. The poem is exact about the swineherd's one weakness: an incontinence of love. The wand works both ways, and the family's circle of knowledge closes back to two.
- 62 *l. 471* The hill of Hermes (Ἑρμῆος λόφος) — a landmark cairn of the god of wayfarers, exactly where a traveler pauses and looks back at the harbor. Eumaeus' report is the observant countryman's: hull heavy in the water, the glint of shields and spears — the ambush ship home, armed and empty-handed.
- 63 *l. 476* "The sacred strength of Telemachus smiled, / and his eyes went to his father — slipping past the swineherd's." The first fruit of the recognition: a shared glance over a servant's unknowing head. The periphrasis ἱερὴ ἰς Τηλεμάχιοι ("sacred strength," the honorific formerly reserved for Alcinous) marks the promotion: the boy is now a conspirator in his own house, smiling at what he knows.
- 64 *l. 481* "They remembered their beds, and took the gift of sleep" — the book that began with dogs who would not bark closes the hut in a single quiet line: father, son, and swineherd under one roof, two of them sharing a secret, all of them armed with nothing yet but sleep.





## Odyssey — Book 17

*The beggar comes to his own house; Argus; Antinous' footstool.*

- When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,<sup>1</sup>  
 then Telemachus bound the beautiful sandals under his feet —  
 Telemachus, dear son of godlike Odysseus —  
 and took his strong spear, which fitted his palm well,  
 5 straining toward the city; and he spoke to his swineherd:  
 "Old father, I am off to the town, so my mother  
 may see me. I do not think she will leave off  
 her hateful weeping and her tearful mourning before  
 she sees me in the flesh. And this is my charge to you:  
 10 take this luckless stranger to the city, so there  
 he can beg his dinner; whoever wishes will give him  
 a crust and a cupful. I cannot carry every man  
 who comes, not I — I have griefs enough at heart.  
 And if the stranger takes it hard, so much the worse  
 15 for him. I like to say the truth of things straight out."<sup>2</sup>  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 "Friend, I have no wish myself to be kept back here.  
 Better for a beggar to beg his dinner in the town  
 than in the fields; whoever wishes will give to me.  
 20 I am no longer of an age for staying on at farmsteads,  
 obeying in everything the word of an overseer.  
 Go on, then. This man will bring me, as you order,  
 as soon as I have warmed myself at the fire, and the sun's heat comes.<sup>3</sup>  
 These clothes I have are terribly bad: the morning frost  
 25 might be too much for me — and the town, you say, is far."  
 So he spoke; and Telemachus went out through the farmstead,  
 stepping fast, planting evils for the suitors.  
 And when he reached the well-settled house,  
 he set his spear against a tall pillar, carrying it in,  
 30 and went inside himself, over the stone threshold.  
 And far the first to see him was the nurse Eurycleia,<sup>4</sup>  
 spreading fleeces over the inlaid chairs;

- with a burst of tears she came straight toward him, and around him  
the other slave-women of enduring-hearted Odysseus
- 35 gathered, and kissed his head and shoulders, welcoming him.  
And out of her chamber came watchful-minded Penelope,  
like Artemis, or golden Aphrodite,<sup>5</sup>  
and threw her arms around her dear son, weeping,  
and kissed his head, and both his beautiful eyes,
- 40 and sobbing spoke winged words to him:  
"You have come, Telemachus — sweet light! I told myself<sup>6</sup>  
I would never see you again, once you had gone by ship to Pylos —  
secretly, against my will, for news of your dear father.  
Come now, tell me over: what sight of him did you meet?"
- 45 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:  
"Mother mine, do not stir up weeping in me, nor rouse  
the heart in my breast — I have just escaped sheer death.  
No: bathe, and take clean clothing for your body,  
and go up to the upper room with your attendant women,
- 50 and vow to all the gods that you will offer perfect  
hecatombs, if Zeus may some day accomplish works of requital.  
And I will go to the assembly-place, to call in  
a guest who followed with me as I traveled here.  
I sent him on ahead with my godlike companions,
- 55 and told Piraeus to take him home with him  
and care for him kindly, and honor him, until I come."  
So he spoke; and for her the word stayed wingless.<sup>7</sup>  
And she bathed, and took clean clothing for her body,  
and vowed to all the gods that she would offer perfect
- 60 hecatombs, if Zeus might some day accomplish works of requital.  
Then Telemachus went on out through the hall,  
spear in hand; two swift dogs followed with him,  
and Athena poured a wondrous grace upon him.  
All the people gazed at him in wonder as he came;<sup>8</sup>
- 65 and around him the lordly suitors gathered,  
speaking him fair, but brooding evils deep in their hearts.  
He slipped away from their thick crowd  
and went where Mentor sat, and Antiphus, and Halitherses,<sup>9</sup>  
who were his father's companions from the beginning,

- 70 and sat down there; and they questioned him on everything.  
 And Piraeus, famous for the spear, came near them,  
 leading his guest through the town to the assembly-place; and  
 Telemachus  
 did not stand off long from his guest, but went to him.  
 And Piraeus spoke to him first:
- 75 "Telemachus, send women to my house at once,  
 so I can send you back the gifts Menelaus gave you."  
 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 "Piraeus — we do not know yet how these matters will fall.<sup>10</sup>  
 If the lordly suitors kill me in my halls  
 80 by treachery, and divide up all my father's goods,  
 I would rather you keep the gifts and have the joy of them  
 than any of those men. But if I plant death and doom for them,  
 then bring them, glad, to my house — and glad I shall be."  
 So speaking, he led the travel-worn stranger home.
- 85 And when they reached the well-settled house,  
 they laid their mantles down on the couches and chairs  
 and stepped into the polished baths and bathed.  
 And when the slave-women had bathed them and rubbed them with  
 oil,  
 and thrown about them fleecy cloaks and tunics,  
 90 they came out of the baths and sat down on the couches.  
 A handmaid brought water for their hands in a pitcher,  
 a beautiful golden one, and poured it over a silver basin  
 for them to wash, and drew up a polished table beside them.  
 The grave housekeeper brought bread and set it before them,  
 95 laying out delicacies in plenty, giving gladly of her store;  
 and his mother sat opposite, by the pillar of the hall,  
 leaning back in her chair, spinning fine threads of yarn.<sup>11</sup>  
 And their hands went out to the good things spread before them.  
 But when they had put away desire for food and drink,  
 100 watchful-minded Penelope began to speak among them:  
 "Telemachus, I am going up to my upper room  
 to lie on the bed that has become a bed of groaning for me,<sup>12</sup>  
 forever stained with my tears, since the day Odysseus

- went with the sons of Atreus to Ilium. And you have not brought yourself,
- 105 before the lordly suitors come back into this house,  
to tell me plainly of your father's homecoming — if you heard anything."
- Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:  
"Then I will tell you, mother, the truth of it."<sup>13</sup>  
We went to Pylos, and to Nestor, shepherd of the people;
- 110 and he received me in his high house  
and gave me loving welcome, as a father would his son  
come home at last from far away: with such  
kindness he tended me, he and his glorious sons.  
But of enduring-hearted Odysseus, alive or dead,
- 115 he said he had heard nothing from anyone on earth.  
He sent me on, with horses and a bolted chariot,  
to Atreus' son, Menelaus famed for the spear.  
There I saw Argive Helen, for whose sake  
the Argives and the Trojans labored so much, by the gods' will.
- 120 And Menelaus of the great war-cry asked me at once  
what need had brought me to shining Lacedaemon;  
and I told him the whole truth of it.  
And then he answered me with these words:  
'Shame on them! Truly in the bed of a strong-hearted man
- 125 they want to lie — the spineless creatures that they are!  
As when a deer beds down her newborn suckling fawns<sup>14</sup>  
in the thicket-lair of a mighty lion,  
and goes questing the spurs and grassy hollows,  
grazing — and then the lion comes back to his own bed
- 130 and lets an ugly doom loose on them both:  
so Odysseus will let an ugly doom loose on those men.  
If only — father Zeus, Athena, Apollo! —  
the man he was long ago in strong-founded Lesbos,  
when he rose on a challenge and wrestled Philomeleides
- 135 and threw him hard, and all the Achaeans cheered:  
such as he was then, let that Odysseus close with the suitors:  
quick would their fates be then, and bitter their weddings.  
As for what you ask of me and beg me: I will not

- talk around it, swerving aside, and I will not deceive you.
- 140 What the unerring Old Man of the Sea told me,  
not one word of it will I hide or cover from you.  
He said he saw him on an island, in strong pain,  
in the halls of the nymph Calypso, who holds him there  
by force; and he cannot come to his own fatherland,
- 145 for he has no ships at hand, no oars, no companions  
to carry him over the broad back of the sea.'  
So spoke Atreus' son, Menelaus famed for the spear.  
That done, I came away; and the deathless ones gave me  
a breeze, and brought me quickly to my own dear country."
- 150 So he spoke, and stirred the heart in her breast.  
And godlike Theoclymenus spoke among them too:  
"Honored wife of Laertes' son Odysseus,  
truly he does not know it plainly. Mark my word:  
I will prophesy to you exactly, and hide nothing.
- 155 Zeus be witness now, first of the gods, and this table of guest-right,<sup>15</sup>  
and this hearth of blameless Odysseus to which I have come:  
Odysseus is already in his own dear country —  
sitting still, or moving — learning of these evil doings,  
and planting evil for all the suitors.
- 160 So clear was the bird of omen I marked  
as I sat on the well-benched ship, and I cried it out to Telemachus."  
Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:  
"Ah, stranger, if only that word might be accomplished:<sup>16</sup>  
then you would quickly know my friendship, and gifts
- 165 in plenty from me — any man who met you would call you blessed."  
So they spoke to one another of such things.  
But the suitors, in front of Odysseus' hall,  
were amusing themselves with discus and javelin throws  
on the leveled ground, insolent as ever, where they always played.<sup>17</sup>
- 170 But when it was dinner-time, and the flocks came in  
from the fields all around, led by the men who always led them,  
then Medon spoke to them — for he of all the heralds  
pleased them best, and was always by them at the feast:  
"Young men — now that you have all delighted your hearts with games,
- 175 come toward the house, so we can lay the meal.

- There is nothing the worse in a dinner taken on time."  
 So he spoke; and they rose and went, and obeyed his word.  
 And when they reached the well-settled house,  
 they laid their mantles down on the couches and chairs  
 180 and slaughtered big sheep and fat goats,  
 slaughtered sleek hogs and a heifer of the herd,  
 making their meal ready. And meanwhile from the country  
 Odysseus and the noble swineherd were stirring themselves  
 to go to the city; and the swineherd began, a leader of men:  
 185 "Stranger — since you are set on going to the town  
 today, as my master ordered — though for myself  
 I would rather have left you here to guard the farmstead,  
 but him I respect and fear: he might scold me  
 afterward, and a master's reproofs are hard to bear —<sup>18</sup>  
 190 come then, let us be off: the day is mostly  
 gone already, and toward evening you will feel the cold."  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 "I know. I understand. You order a man who is thinking it too.<sup>19</sup>  
 Let us go, then — and you lead the whole way through.  
 195 And give me a staff to lean on, if you have one  
 cut anywhere, since you say the road is treacherous."  
 He spoke, and slung about his shoulders his beggar's pouch,  
 full of holes, hanging by a twisted cord,  
 and Eumaeus gave him a stick that suited him.<sup>20</sup>  
 200 The two set out; and the dogs and the herdsmen stayed  
 behind, guarding the farm. And he led his master toward the city  
 in the likeness of a beggar, wretched and old,  
 leaning on a stick, with miserable clothing on his body.
- But when, making their way down the rugged road,  
 205 they were near the town, and came to the fountain,  
 well-built, fair-flowing, where the people of the town drew water —  
 made by Ithacus and Neritus and Polyctor;<sup>21</sup>  
 around it stood a grove of water-nourished poplars,  
 circling it on every side, and the cold water ran down  
 210 from the rock above; and on top an altar was built  
 to the nymphs, where all wayfarers made their offerings —  
 there Melanthius the son of Dolius overtook them,<sup>22</sup>

- driving his goats, the ones that stood out in all the herds,  
a dinner for the suitors; and two herdsmen followed with him.
- 215 Seeing the pair he broke out against them — named them  
in words beyond all bounds, indecent — and it stirred Odysseus' heart:  
"Now here is the vile leading the vile, no mistake —  
as ever, the god is bringing like and like together!<sup>23</sup>  
Where are you taking that glutton, you pitiful swineherd,  
220 that beggar-pest, that lick of feast-plates?<sup>24</sup>  
He is the sort to stand rubbing his shoulders on many doorposts,  
whining for scraps — not for swords and cauldrons.  
Give him to me, to keep watch over my farmstead,  
to sweep the pens and carry green shoots to the kids —  
225 and drinking whey he might put some meat on that thigh.  
But no: he has learned bad ways, and he will not  
set himself to work; he would rather cringe through the town  
begging, to feed that bottomless belly of his.  
But I will tell you this, and it will be accomplished:  
230 if he comes to the house of godlike Odysseus,  
many the footstools flying round his head from men's hands<sup>25</sup>  
that his ribs will wear away with, pelted through the house."  
So he spoke; and passing, the fool, he lashed out a heel  
at his hip — yet did not knock him off the path:  
235 he stood there, steady. And Odysseus weighed it —<sup>26</sup>  
whether to spring after him and take his life with the stick,  
or lift him by the middle and dash his head against the ground.  
But he mastered himself, and held it in. And the swineherd  
rebuked the man to his face, and lifting his hands prayed aloud:  
240 "Nymphs of the spring, daughters of Zeus — if ever Odysseus<sup>27</sup>  
burned thigh-pieces for you, wrapped in rich fat,  
of lambs or of kids, grant me this my prayer:  
that the man himself come back, and a god guide him home.  
He would scatter all those airs of yours,  
245 every one — that you now wear so insolently, forever drifting  
around the town, while bad herdsmen ruin the flocks."  
Then Melanthius the goatherd answered him:  
"Well, well! How the cur talks — nothing but mischief in him!  
One day I will take him on a black well-benched ship

- 250 far from Ithaca, where he could fetch me a good living.  
 If only Apollo of the silver bow would strike Telemachus<sup>28</sup>  
 today in the halls, or the suitors bring him down,  
 as surely as for Odysseus, far away, the day of homecoming is dead!"  
 So speaking he left them there, walking slowly on,  
 255 and strode off, and came very quickly to the master's house.  
 He went straight in and sat down among the suitors,  
 opposite Eurymachus: for him he loved best of all.<sup>29</sup>  
 The serving-men set a portion of meat beside him,  
 and the grave housekeeper brought bread and set it by him  
 260 to eat. And meanwhile Odysseus and the noble swineherd  
 came up close and stopped; and around them came the ringing  
 of the hollow lyre: for Phemius was striking up  
 his song among them. And Odysseus took the swineherd's hand and  
 said:  
 "Eumaeus — surely this is the beautiful house of Odysseus.<sup>30</sup>  
 265 Easy it is to know it, to pick out at a glance among many.  
 One part is joined to another; the courtyard is finished  
 with wall and coping; the double doors are strong  
 and well-fenced. No man could storm it with contempt.  
 And I can tell that a crowd of men is feasting  
 270 in it: the smell of roasting rises, and the lyre  
 is ringing there, which the gods made companion to the feast."  
 And you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd:  
 "Easily known — you, who are not slow-witted in anything else.  
 But come, let us think how these things are to go.  
 275 Either you go first into the well-settled house  
 and slip in among the suitors, and I stay behind here;  
 or, if you like, you wait, and I go on ahead.  
 But do not linger long, or someone may see you outside  
 and throw something, or strike you. Think on it, I say."  
 280 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus answered him:  
 "I know. I understand. You order a man who is thinking it too.  
 You go on ahead; I will stay behind here.  
 I am not unacquainted with blows and peltings:  
 my heart is a patient one — I have suffered much evil  
 285 from waves and from war. Let this be added to the rest.



- But a ravening belly there is no hiding away,<sup>31</sup>  
 that accursed thing, which gives so many evils to men;  
 for its sake even the well-benched ships are rigged  
 to cross the barren sea, bearing evil to enemies."
- 290 So they spoke to one another of such things.  
 And a dog lying there lifted his head and ears:  
 Argus, the dog of enduring-hearted Odysseus, whom once he<sup>32</sup>  
 raised himself — and had no joy of him: too soon he was gone  
 to holy Ilium. In the old days the young men took him  
 295 out after wild goats, and roe deer, and hares;  
 now he lay neglected, his master gone away,  
 on the deep pile of dung that the mules and cattle<sup>33</sup>  
 dropped in heaps before the doors, until Odysseus' slaves  
 could cart it off to manure his great estate.
- 300 There lay the dog Argus, covered with dog-ticks.  
 And now, as he sensed Odysseus near him,  
 he wagged his tail, and laid both his ears back flat,  
 but no longer had the strength to come any closer  
 to his master. And Odysseus, glancing aside, wiped away a tear —<sup>34</sup>  
 305 easily hidden from Eumaeus — and at once he questioned him:  
 "Eumaeus — a strange thing: this dog lying on the dung-heap.  
 His frame is beautiful; though this I cannot tell for certain:  
 whether he had speed to run to match this beauty,  
 or was merely one of those table-dogs men keep,  
 310 the kind their masters tend for show alone."  
 And you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd:  
 "Only too true: this is the dog of a man who died far away.  
 If he were now in form and action such  
 as Odysseus left him, going away to Troy,  
 315 you would stare at the speed and strength of him.  
 Nothing escaped him in the deep places of the wood,  
 no game he chased: he was surest of all on a trail.  
 Now he is in a bad way: his master has perished  
 far from home, and the women are careless and give him no tending.
- 320 Slaves — when their masters lose the upper hand,<sup>35</sup>  
 they will no longer do their work as it should be done:  
 for Zeus of the wide voice takes half the worth away

from a man, the day the day of slavery seizes him."  
 So speaking he entered the well-settled house  
 325 and went straight down the hall among the haughty suitors.  
 But Argus — the doom of black death took him<sup>36</sup>  
 the moment he had seen Odysseus, in the twentieth year.  
 And godlike Telemachus was far the first to see  
 the swineherd coming down the house; and quickly then  
 330 he nodded, calling him over. Glancing about, he took a stool  
 that lay there, where the carver would sit  
 while carving meat in plenty for the suitors feasting through the  
 house;  
 this he carried and set at Telemachus' table,  
 opposite him, and sat down on it himself. And a herald  
 335 took up a portion and set it before him, with bread lifted from the  
 basket.  
 And close behind him Odysseus entered the house  
 in the likeness of a beggar, wretched and old,  
 leaning on a stick, with miserable clothing on his body.  
 He sat down on the ash-wood threshold, inside the doors,<sup>37</sup>  
 340 leaning against the cypress doorpost, which a carpenter  
 once planed with skill and trued to the line.  
 And Telemachus called the swineherd to him and said —  
 taking a whole loaf out of the beautiful basket,  
 and meat, as much as his two cupped hands could hold —  
 345 "Take these and give them to the stranger, and tell him this:  
 to go the round of the suitors, every one, and beg.  
 Shame is no good companion to a man in need."<sup>38</sup>  
 So he spoke; and the swineherd went when he heard the word,  
 and standing close he spoke winged words:  
 350 "Telemachus gives you these, stranger, and he bids you  
 go the round of the suitors, every one, and beg.  
 Shame, he says, is no good thing in a beggar-man."  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 "Lord Zeus — grant me that Telemachus be blessed among men,  
 355 and that all his heart desires be brought to pass."  
 He spoke, and took it in both hands, and set it down  
 there at his feet, on the shabby pouch,

- and ate, all the while the singer sang in the halls;  
and when he had done his meal, the godlike singer ended.
- 360 And the suitors raised a din through the hall. But Athena  
came and stood close by Laertes' son Odysseus  
and urged him on: to go gathering crusts among the suitors,  
and learn which of them were decent and which were lawless —  
though even so she had no mind to save one man of them from ruin.<sup>39</sup>
- 365 So he set off, going right-handed round, begging from each man,  
stretching out his hand on every side, as if he had begged all his life.<sup>40</sup>  
And they pitied him and gave, and wondered at him,  
and asked each other who he was and where he came from.  
And Melanthius the goatherd spoke among them:
- 370 "Hear me, you suitors of the far-famed queen,  
about this stranger: I have seen him before.  
It was the swineherd, no other, brought him here;  
the man himself I do not know for certain — where he claims his birth."  
So he spoke; and Antinous laid into the swineherd:
- 375 "You — swineherd — everyone knows you. Why did you bring  
this thing to town? Have we not vagrants enough already,  
beggar-pests, lickers of feast-plates?  
Do you think it a small matter that they gather here  
and eat your master's living away — and now you invite one more?"
- 380 And you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd:  
"Antinous — well-born you may be, but that was not well spoken.  
Who ever goes himself and invites a stranger  
from abroad — unless it be one of the public workers:<sup>41</sup>  
a seer, a healer of sickness, a builder in timber,  
385 or an inspired singer, who delights with his singing?  
Those men are invited the wide earth over;  
but a beggar — who would invite a beggar, to eat him bare?  
No: of all the suitors you are always hardest  
on the slaves of Odysseus, and beyond all on me. But I —
- 390 I care nothing, so long as steady-hearted Penelope  
lives in the halls, and godlike Telemachus."  
Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
"Hush — do not trade long speeches with this man.  
It is Antinous' way, forever needling, ugly,

- 395 with hard words; and he sets the others on as well."  
 He spoke, and then to Antinous said winged words:  
 "Antinous — how finely you care for me, as a father for his son,<sup>42</sup>  
 you who order me to drive this stranger from my hall  
 with a word of command! May god never bring that to pass.
- 400 Take and give to him. I do not grudge it — I order it, I myself.  
 And have no fear of my mother in this, nor of any  
 of the slaves in the house of godlike Odysseus.  
 But no — no such thought is in your breast:  
 you would far rather eat it yourself than give to another."
- 405 Then Antinous answered him and said:  
 "Telemachus, high talker, temper past restraining — what a thing to  
 say.  
 If all the suitors handed him as much as I will,<sup>43</sup>  
 this house would keep him at arm's length three full months."  
 So he spoke, and snatched up the footstool from under the table and  
 showed it —
- 410 the stool where he propped his sleek feet while he feasted.
- But all the others gave, and they filled the pouch  
 with bread and meat. And soon Odysseus was to go  
 back to the threshold, to taste the Achaeans' free bounty;  
 but he stopped beside Antinous, and spoke a word to him:
- 415 "Give, friend. You do not look to me the meanest of the Achaeans —  
 no, the noblest of them: you have the look of a king.<sup>44</sup>  
 So it is right that you should give even better than the others —  
 bread; and I would spread your fame over the boundless earth.  
 For I too once lived in a house among men,
- 420 a fortunate man in a wealthy one, and I often gave to a wanderer,  
 whoever he might be and whatever need he came in.  
 Slaves I had past counting, and everything in plenty  
 by which men live well and get the name of rich.  
 But Zeus the son of Cronos stripped it all — such, no doubt, was his will  
 —
- 425 he who sent me out with roving pirates  
 to Egypt, a long road, to be destroyed there.<sup>45</sup>  
 And in the river of Egypt I moored my curved ships.  
 Then, you may be sure, I ordered my trusted companions

- to stay there by the ships and guard the ships,  
 430 and I sent out scouts to the lookout places.  
 But they gave way to arrogance — followed their own force —  
 and straightway began to pillage the beautiful fields  
 of the Egyptian men: they carried off the women and small children,  
 and killed the men. And quickly the cry reached the city.  
 435 Hearing the shout, at the showing of dawn the people  
 came; and the whole plain filled with infantry and horses  
 and the lightning of bronze. And Zeus who delights in thunder  
 threw an evil panic on my companions, and no man dared  
 stand and face it: for destruction ringed us everywhere.  
 440 There they killed many of us with the sharp bronze,  
 and others they led up alive, to slave for them by force.  
 But me they gave to a guest-friend who met them there, for Cyprus —  
 Dmetor, Iasus' son, who ruled Cyprus by his strength.  
 From there I have come here now, suffering hardship."  
 445 Then Antinous answered him and raised his voice:  
 "What god has brought this plague here to sour the feast?  
 Stand off there, in the middle, away from my table,  
 or you may come soon to a bitter Egypt and a bitter Cyprus —<sup>46</sup>  
 a bold and shameless beggar you are!  
 450 You stand by every man in turn, and they give  
 recklessly: there is no holding back, no scruple  
 in being generous with other men's goods — each has plenty at  
 hand."<sup>47</sup>  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs drew back and said:  
 "Well, well. So the wits in you are no match for the looks!  
 455 You would not give so much as a grain of salt from your own stores,<sup>48</sup>  
 you who sit now at another man's table and cannot  
 bring yourself to take of the bread and give it — and plenty is at hand."  
 So he spoke; and Antinous grew the angrier at heart,  
 and glaring from under his brows he spoke winged words:  
 460 "Now I do not think you leave this hall so prettily  
 after all — not now you take to insults too."  
 With that he seized the footstool and threw it, and struck the right  
 shoulder<sup>49</sup>  
 low, at the base of the back. And he stood like rock,

- steady: the cast of Antinous did not stagger him.
- 465 He only shook his head, silent, brooding evils deep in his heart.<sup>50</sup>  
 Then he went back to the threshold and sat, and laid down  
 the well-filled pouch, and spoke out among the suitors:  
 "Hear me, you suitors of the far-famed queen,  
 while I say what the heart in my breast commands.
- 470 There is no grief in the mind, no sorrow worth the name,  
 when a man is struck fighting for his own possessions,  
 for his cattle, say, or his silver-white sheep.  
 But Antinous struck me for my wretched belly's sake,  
 that accursed thing, which gives so many evils to men.
- 475 If anywhere there are gods and Furies for beggars,<sup>51</sup>  
 may death's end find Antinous before any wedding."  
 Then Antinous answered him, Eupheithes' son:  
 "Sit still and eat, stranger, or take yourself elsewhere —  
 or for words like these the young men will drag you through the house
- 480 by hand or foot, and flay the skin from every part of you."  
 So he spoke; but all the rest were angered beyond measure,  
 and one of the arrogant young men would say:  
 "Antinous — that was not well done, striking the luckless wanderer.  
 Doomed man! — what if he should be some god come down from  
 heaven?
- 485 And the gods do go about, in the likeness of strangers<sup>52</sup>  
 from far countries, taking every shape, and move through the cities,  
 watching over the violence of men, and the good order they keep."  
 So the suitors spoke; but he paid no heed to their words.  
 And Telemachus nursed a great grief swelling in his heart
- 490 for the striking of him; yet he let no tear fall to the ground,  
 but only shook his head, silent, brooding evils deep in his heart.<sup>53</sup>  
 And when watchful-minded Penelope heard of it —  
 the man struck in the hall — she said among her slave-women:  
 "So may Apollo the famed archer strike you, Antinous!"
- 495 And the housekeeper Eurynome added her word:<sup>54</sup>  
 "If an end could only come in answer to our prayers,  
 not one of these men would live to see fair-throned Dawn."  
 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered her:  
 "Nurse, they are enemies all, for they all plot evil;

- 500 but Antinous most of all is like black doom itself.<sup>55</sup>  
 Some luckless stranger wanders through the house  
 begging alms of the men — his poverty commands him —  
 and all the others filled his pouch and gave,  
 but that one struck him with a footstool at the base of the right  
 shoulder."
- 505 So she spoke among her attendant slave-women,  
 sitting in her chamber. And meanwhile noble Odysseus was at his meal.  
 And she called the noble swineherd to her side and said:  
 "Go, noble Eumaeus. Tell the stranger to come here,  
 so I may greet him a little, and ask him  
 510 whether he has heard anything of enduring-hearted Odysseus,  
 or seen him with his eyes. He looks a far-wandered man."  
 And you answered her, Eumaeus the swineherd:  
 "If only the Achaeans would keep silence for you, queen:  
 the things he tells would charm your very heart.
- 515 Three nights I had him, three days I kept him with me  
 in the hut — for I was the first he came to, running from a ship —  
 and even so he never finished the tale of his sufferings.  
 As a man gazes at a singer, who sings to mortals<sup>56</sup>  
 lessons of longing that the gods have taught him,  
 520 and they ache to hear him on and on, as long as he will sing —  
 so that man cast his spell on me, sitting in my house.  
 And he says he is a guest-friend of Odysseus' father's line,  
 and lives in Crete, where the race of Minos is.  
 From there he has come here now, suffering hardship,  
 525 tumbled on and on; and he swears he has heard of Odysseus<sup>57</sup>  
 near, in the rich land of the Thesprotian men,  
 alive — and bringing treasures home in plenty."  
 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:  
 "Go, call him here, so he can tell it to my face.
- 530 And those men — let them sit at the doors and amuse themselves,  
 or here in the house, since their hearts are merry.  
 Their own possessions lie untouched at home,  
 bread and sweet wine: their house-folk eat that,  
 while they crowd our house day after day,  
 535 slaughtering our oxen and sheep and fat goats,

- feasting away and drinking the sparkling wine  
recklessly. The most of it is wasted. For there is no man here,  
such as Odysseus was, to ward ruin from the house.  
But if Odysseus came — if he reached his own country —
- 540 quickly, with his son, he would repay these men their violence."  
So she spoke; and Telemachus sneezed — a great sneeze — and round  
about<sup>58</sup>  
the whole house rang terribly with it. And Penelope laughed,  
and quickly spoke winged words to Eumaeus:  
"Go — please — and call the stranger here before me.
- 545 Do you not see how my son sneezed on all I said?  
So may death be not unaccomplished for the suitors —  
for every man of them; not one shall slip out of death and the fates.  
And another thing I will tell you: lay it up in your heart.  
If I find that everything he says is true,
- 550 I will dress him in a cloak and a tunic, fine clothing."<sup>59</sup>  
So she spoke; and the swineherd went when he heard the word,  
and standing close he spoke winged words:  
"Stranger — father — watchful-minded Penelope is calling for you,<sup>60</sup>  
the mother of Telemachus. Her heart bids her ask
- 555 about her husband, for all the griefs she has borne.  
And if she finds that everything you say is true,  
she will dress you in a cloak and a tunic — the things you need  
most of all. And your bread you can beg through the town  
and feed your belly; whoever wishes will give to you."
- 560 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus answered him:  
"Eumaeus, I would tell it all, truly, and at once,  
to the daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded Penelope —  
for I know about that man well: we have taken up the same misery.<sup>61</sup>  
But I am afraid of this mob of hard suitors,
- 565 whose arrogance and violence reach the iron sky.<sup>62</sup>  
Just now, when that man hit me and gave me pain  
as I went through the hall doing no harm at all,  
neither Telemachus nor any other man stepped in.  
So tell Penelope to wait in the halls,  
570 however eager, until the sun goes down;<sup>63</sup>  
and then let her ask me about her husband's day of homecoming,



- giving me a seat closer to the fire: for the clothes  
I wear are miserable. You know it yourself — I begged you first of all."  
So he spoke; and the swineherd went when he heard the word.
- 575 And as he crossed the threshold Penelope said:  
"You do not bring him, Eumaeus? What has the wanderer in mind?  
Is he too much afraid of someone? Or shy for some other cause,  
here in the house? A shy man makes a bad beggar."<sup>64</sup>  
And you answered her, Eumaeus the swineherd:
- 580 "He speaks as is right — as anyone would judge who thought it through  
—  
wanting to keep clear of the insolence of these overbearing men.  
He asks you to wait until the sun goes down.  
And for you too, queen, it is far the better way:  
to speak your word to the stranger alone, and hear him alone."
- 585 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:  
"The stranger is no fool. He guesses what could happen:<sup>65</sup>  
for I think there are no men anywhere, none among mortals,  
who plot such reckless evil in their insolence."  
So she spoke her say; and the noble swineherd went off
- 590 into the crowd of the suitors, when he had told her everything,  
and at once he spoke winged words to Telemachus,  
leaning his head close, so the others would not hear:  
"Friend, I am going back, to watch the swine and all that is there —  
your living and mine. And everything here — let it be your care.
- 595 Keep yourself safe first of all, and be watchful at heart  
that nothing happens to you. Many of the Achaeans think evil —  
may Zeus wipe them out before harm comes to us!"  
Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
"So be it, old father. Go when you have had your evening meal;<sup>66</sup>
- 600 and in the morning come again, and bring fine beasts for slaughter.  
All the rest shall be my care, and the deathless ones'."  
So he spoke; and the other sat down again on the polished stool,  
and when he had filled his heart with food and drink,  
he went his way to his swine, and left the walls and the hall
- 605 full of banqueters; and they were delighting in dance and song,  
for already the day had come on to evening.<sup>67</sup>

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 17

- 1    *l. 1* The dawn formula here opens the poem's great single day — or nearly: Books 17 and 18 run to this evening, Book 19 fills the night, and Book 20 wakes into the day of the bow. From this sunrise on, the poem's clock slows almost to real time, and everything converges on the house — the farm and the road up to town filling the morning before the hall claims the rest.
- 2    *l. 14* Telemachus plays his part with relish: brusque, put-upon, disclaiming the stranger ("I cannot carry every man who comes"). The rudeness is camouflage — he owes the beggar nothing in public — but the closing tag, "I like to say the truth of things straight out," is a private joke buried in the performance: everything he has just said is theater.
- 3    *l. 23* The beggar's reasons for lingering — warm the fire out of his bones, let the frost burn off, the town is far — are a poor man's calculations rendered without condescension. The poem knows what cold means to a man in rags; so does the king wearing them.
- 4    *l. 31* Eurycleia "far the first" to see him — the nurse outstrips the mother by a room's length, as the swineherd outstripped them both by a day. The poem keeps strict account of the order in which love arrives.
- 5    *l. 37* "Like Artemis, or golden Aphrodite" — the double comparison held ready for Penelope's re-entries (it returns at 19.54). Chastity and desirability at once: the two goddesses between whom her whole situation is strung.
- 6    *l. 41* "You have come, Telemachus — sweet light!" — Penelope repeats, word for word, the greeting Eumaeus cried at 16.23. Mother and swineherd share one cry between them, a book apart; neither will ever know the other said it.
- 7    *l. 57* "For her the word stayed wingless" (ἄπτερος ἔπλετο μῦθος) — the poem's strangest small formula: the reply that never takes flight. She obeys in silence — no answer rises to her lips at all. It recurs at 19.29, 21.386, 22.398, always of a woman receiving instruction wordlessly; here it carries a mother's whole swallowed protest.
- 8    *l. 62* Lines 62–64 repeat Telemachus' first walk to the assembly (2.10–13): the two swift dogs, Athena's wondrous grace, the people gazing. The frame returns with the situation transformed — then he went to plead and fail; now he comes back from the sea with a father hidden behind him and "evils planted" for the men who mocked him.
- 9    *l. 68* Mentor, Antiphus, Halitherses — the loyal remnant, "his father's companions from the beginning." Antiphus is a bitter name to find alive here: his namesake, Aegyptius' son, is the man the Cyclops ate last (2.19–20). The poem seats Telemachus with the old guard — Mentor and Halitherses, the very men who spoke for Odysseus in the Book 2 assembly.
- 10    *l. 78* Telemachus' answer to Piraeus is estate-planning by a man who expects to be murdered: if the suitors kill me, keep the gifts yourself — better a friend enjoy them than

those men. The heir has learned to hold even treasure lightly, and the grim proviso ("but if I plant death and doom for them...") no longer sounds like bravado.

- 11 *l. 96* Penelope at the pillar of the hall, "spinning fine threads of yarn," while the men eat: the poem's emblem of her — present, apart, working wool. The image will hold until the bow takes its place.
- 12 *l. 102* "The bed that has become a bed of groaning for me, forever stained with my tears" — Penelope's own account of the marriage bed matches her son's spider-web image (16.35) from the other side: he imagined it empty; she reports it occupied nightly by grief.
- 13 *l. 108* Telemachus' report is truthful and strategically cropped: Pylos, Sparta, Helen, Menelaus' words — and not one syllable of the ambush, of Theoclymenus' omen, or of anything since. He has adopted his father's information discipline whole: the truth, less everything operational.
- 14 *l. 126* The deer-in-lion's-lair simile arrives on schedule (= 4.335–340 verbatim, with the whole Menelaus speech 124–141 = 4.333–350): the suitors as fawns bedded in the lion's lair, doomed the moment the owner returns. Spoken in Sparta as consolation, it is relayed here — in the lion's own hall, while the lion himself is still making his way up from the farm — as prophecy at one remove. Lines 142–146 likewise repeat the Proteus report (= 4.556–560, the Calypso block).
- 15 *l. 155* Theoclymenus swears the strongest guest-oath in the poem — Zeus, the table of guest-right, the hearth of Odysseus — and delivers his second true prophecy: Odysseus is already in the country, "sitting still, or moving," planting evil. It is exact to the hour. Penelope answers with the fixed courtesy formula (163–165 = 15.536–538), warm and disbelieving: the truth has been told to her outright, under oath, and it cannot land — the poem's tragedy of information in one exchange.
- 16 *l. 163* Lines 163–165 repeat 15.536–538 word for word — Telemachus' reply to the seer's first prophecy, now his mother's reply to the second. Mother and son answer the same true prophecy with the same blessing-formula; neither can afford belief.
- 17 *l. 167* Lines 167–169 repeat 4.625–627 exactly: the suitors at their discus and javelins "insolent as ever, where they always played." In Book 4 the games filled the gap after the ambush plot was hatched; here they fill the hour before the ambushers' target walks in — the idle men's idleness, formulaic because it never changes.
- 18 *l. 188* Eumaeus on Telemachus: "him I respect and fear: he might scold me... a master's reproofs are hard to bear." A window on the slave's world even at its kindest — affection and fear are not alternatives but one braided feeling; the "gentle" master is still the man whose word is weather.
- 19 *l. 193* "I know, I understand. You order a man who is thinking it too" — Eumaeus' own compressed formula (16.136), now handed back to him by the disguised Odysseus, and again at 281. Master and slave have begun to speak each other's sentences; the poem lets the borrowed phrase measure their growing likeness.
- 20 *l. 197* The costume is completed with props: pouch, holes, twisted cord, and a stick from Eumaeus' hand. The line's quiet irony is regal — this is a σκήπτρον, the same word as the

staff of kings and speakers in assembly. Odysseus enters his kingdom carrying the scepter Eumaeus gave him.

- 21 *l. 205* The fountain of Ithacus, Neritus, and Polyctor — civic archaeology: the town's founders named as builders of its waterworks, with the poplar grove and the nymphs' altar "where all wayfarers made their offerings." The poem builds a real, loved, ordinary place — then stages the book's ugliest encounter beside it.
- 22 *l. 212* Melanthius son of Dolius: Eumaeus' structural opposite — where the swineherd feeds strangers and prays for the master's return, the goatherd drives the best goats to the suitors' table, kicks beggars, and wishes the heir dead. His sister Melanthe will be his mirror among the women (18.321ff). The disloyal family is met on the road exactly where the loyal one lives in a hut.
- 23 *l. 217* "The god is bringing like and like together" — the proverb (ὥς τὸν ὁμοῖον ἄγει θεὸς ὥς τὸν ὁμοῖον) delivered as a sneer: trash leads trash. Its truth runs the other way — the two men he mocks are indeed alike: the two most loyal hearts on the island, one of them its king.
- 24 *l. 220* "Licker of feast-plates" (δαϊτῶν ἀπολυμαντήρα) — Melanthius' coinage; Antinous will reuse the same phrase at 377, master and lackey sharing one vocabulary of contempt. The insult catalogue (doorpost-rubbing, scrap-whining, whey-drinking) is the poem's richest specimen of low-life abuse — aimed, unknowingly, up.
- 25 *l. 231* Melanthius' threat is a prophecy in the poem's ironic mode: "many the footstools flying round his head" — and at 462 Antinous throws exactly that. The goatherd knows his masters' manners perfectly; what he cannot know is that every footstool is being counted.
- 26 *l. 235* The deliberation formula — kill him with the stick, or dash his head on the ground — then "he mastered himself, and held it in": the same inner motion as 20.10–21 (the heart growling at the maids). Odysseus' revenge discipline is built of these swallowed executions; Melanthius' actual death (22.474–477) will be the worst in the poem, and this kick is the first installment of its price.
- 27 *l. 240* Eumaeus answers the kick not with his fists but with a prayer to the nymphs of the very spring they stand beside — citing Odysseus' old burnt offerings as credit ("if ever Odysseus burned thigh-pieces for you..."). The theology of reciprocity, invoked by a slave at a roadside altar, with its subject standing next to him pretending not to own the debt.
- 28 *l. 251* Melanthius' answer escalates to open treason: he wishes Telemachus dead today — by Apollo's arrow or the suitors' hands — "as surely as for Odysseus the day of homecoming is dead." Spoken to Odysseus' face. The νόστιμον ἦμαρ formula, the poem's most sacred phrase, used as a corpse to swear by: no speech in the poem buys its speaker a worse death.
- 29 *l. 257* Melanthius sits "opposite Eurymachus: for him he loved best of all" — the goatherd has a patron among the suitors, as Medon "pleased them best" among the heralds (172–173). The poem maps the collaborators precisely: every tyranny runs on such seating arrangements.

- 30 l. 264 Odysseus admires his own house aloud, room by room, wall and coping and double doors, as a stranger would — "surely this is the beautiful house of Odysseus." Twenty years, and he tours it with his voice, praising the fortifications he is about to need ("no man could storm it with contempt"). The lyre "which the gods made companion to the feast" is Phemius, singing for the occupation.
- 31 l. 286 The belly-doctrine reaches its widest claim: not just that hunger drives beggars, but that "for its sake even the well-benched ships are rigged... bearing evil to enemies" — commerce, piracy, war itself traced to the stomach. Spoken at his own gate by the man whose war took him twenty years, it is as close as the poem comes to a materialist theory of the Trojan expedition.
- 32 l. 292 Argus, "whom once he raised himself — and had no joy of him" (οὐδ' ἀπόνητο): the identical verb and grief as the line of only sons — Odysseus "fathered only me... and had no joy of me" (16.120). Dog and son take the same clause; the man left both unfinished, and the poem files both under the war's unpaid debts.
- 33 l. 297 The dung-heap before the doors, waiting until the slaves cart it out to manure "his great estate" (τέμενος μέγα): even the filth of the house is wealth in waiting. On that waiting store lies the dog — the household's loyalty, discarded onto the compost of its economy.
- 34 l. 304 The recognition no disguise can defeat: Athena remade the man's skin, hair, and eyes, and the dog needs none of them. The tear Odysseus wipes — "easily hidden from Eumaeus" — is the only tear the disguise concedes between Book 13 and the recognition scenes, and it falls for a dog. Then, in the same breath, the actor recovers: "Eumaeus — a strange thing: this dog..." The question that follows (a champion? or a table-dog kept for show?) invites praise of his own hound.
- 35 l. 320 Eumaeus' verdict on slavery, spoken over Argus: "Zeus of the wide voice takes half the worth away from a man, the day the day of slavery seizes him." The poem's single most quoted line on the institution, delivered by a slave, about careless slave-women, in front of the enslaved dog of an absent master — and in front of the master. Its companion doctrine at 15.371–379 (what slaves miss) gives the same law from inside.
- 36 l. 326 "But Argus — the doom of black death took him / the moment he had seen Odysseus, in the twentieth year." The first in Ithaca to know him unaided — Telemachus had to be told (16.187–189); the dog simply *knows* — and the knowing kills him: he had, it turns out, been waiting, and the waiting was his life. The poem grants him the epic dignity of the μοῖρα-formula and the count of years — an obituary in the same units as his master's war.
- 37 l. 339 The ash-wood threshold, inside the doors, against the cypress doorpost "planed with skill and trued to the line": the beggar's station for the rest of the poem — just inside the border of the house, admitted no further. The loving carpentry detail is the owner's eye again: this is a man who knows what a trued post costs.
- 38 l. 347 "Shame is no good companion to a man in need" — Telemachus' proverb, relayed by Eumaeus with the paraphrase "no good thing in a beggar-man" (352). The command performs charity while ordering reconnaissance: begging the round of the suitors is a muster-inspection in disguise (Athena makes it explicit at 363).

- 39 l. 364 "Though even so she had no mind to save one man of them from ruin" — Athena's test sorts the decent from the lawless with the verdict pre-sealed. The poem states the theological terms of Book 22 flatly: discrimination now, no clemency later. Whatever the audit finds, the account is already closed.
- 40 l. 366 "As if he had begged all his life" — the highest compliment the poem pays its actor. The verb is professional: hand out on every side, working the room right-handed, technique without a seam. The king is now performing poverty better than the poor.
- 41 l. 383 Eumaeus' sociology of invitation: the δημιοεργοί — "public workers" — seer, healer, carpenter, singer, are summoned across the wide earth; no one invites a beggar. The list is the poem's census of valued skill (note the singer, last and most lovingly described), and its economics are exact: hospitality follows utility, except at the hearths of the good.
- 42 l. 397 "How finely you care for me, as a father for his son" — Telemachus' sarcasm has its own hidden floor: his actual father sits on the threshold listening. The speech performs the son's role brilliantly — defiant, ironic, protective of the guest — for an audience of one.
- 43 l. 407 Antinous' joke is bookkeeping: if every suitor gave the beggar a footstool (that is what he means by "as much as I will"), the house would be rid of him three months. He shows the stool to the table like a wit displaying his epigram — premeditated, displayed, and aimed at a suppliant.
- 44 l. 415 The begging speech to Antinous opens with the flattery of kings — "you have the look of a king" — and then produces, as beggar's credentials, the Egypt tale: lines 427–441 repeat 14.258–272 word for word from the Cretan story told to Eumaeus. The fiction is stable across performances (the mark of the practiced liar), but the ending is customized: instead of seven fat years in Egypt, he is handed to Dmetor of Cyprus — a new misery invented for a new audience, and a discreet compliment threaded through it: I once had a house, slaves past counting; I know what you are supposed to be.
- 45 l. 425 "To be destroyed there" — ὄφρ' ἀπολοίμην: the tale-teller assigns Zeus a purpose for his ruin with a bitter final-clause shrug. The grammar of a man for whom catastrophe has become syntax.
- 46 l. 448 "A bitter Egypt and a bitter Cyprus" — Antinous turns the beggar's biography into a threat: I'll show you Egypt. Cruelty by quotation — the mark of a man who was listening only for material.
- 47 l. 450 Antinous' theory of the other suitors' charity: "no scruple in being generous with other men's goods." It is true — and it is a self-indictment lifted whole: no man present has given anything of his own for three years. The one accurate moral observation Antinous ever makes, and he makes it as an excuse for giving nothing.
- 48 l. 455 "Not so much as a grain of salt" — the proverbial minimum of giving. The beggar's retort measures Antinous exactly: looks of a king (416), wits beneath a table-scrap. Odysseus is grading his enemies aloud now.
- 49 l. 462 The footstool lands where Melanthius' prophecy aimed it (231–232), on the right shoulder at the base of the back — and "he stood like rock, steady." The simile is geological because the provocation is calculated: Antinous' best throw cannot move

what is coming for him. First blood of the revenge is Odysseus' own, absorbed on the threshold of his own hall.

- 50 *l. 465* "He only shook his head, silent, brooding evils deep in his heart" — and twenty-six lines later (491) his son, watching, does exactly the same in the identical line. Father and son now share a fixed verse the way they share the secret: the poem's formula-system used as a family resemblance.
- 51 *l. 475* The beggar's curse — "if anywhere there are gods and Furies for beggars, may death's end find Antinous before any wedding" — is the book's live ammunition. It is answered to the letter: Antinous dies first of all the suitors, at the feast, arrow through the throat, cup in hand (22.8–21), before any wedding. The Furies of beggars exist; one of them threw the curse.
- 52 *l. 485* The anonymous suitor's warning is the poem's theology of hospitality spoken entire: gods walk the cities "in the likeness of strangers from far countries... watching over the violence of men, and the good order they keep." Every audience knows the scene it describes is the scene it is in — with the correction that the watcher is no god but the owner, which is worse. Antinous "paid no heed": the poem's damnation-formula at its driest.
- 53 *l. 491* See note at 465: the son's silence in his father's exact line. What Telemachus is learning in these books is given a grammatical form — he is being conjugated into the same verse.
- 54 *l. 495* Eurynome the housekeeper, first named here, praying the suitors dead by dawn: even the domestic staff now curses in daylight. Penelope calls her "nurse" and out-curses her — Antinous is "like black doom itself" — while retelling the footstool-throw she never saw, detail-perfect down to "the base of the right shoulder": the house's grapevine runs fast, and the queen is on it.
- 55 *l. 500* "Like black doom itself" (μελαίνῃ κηρὶ ἔοικε): Penelope's image for Antinous is the poem's death-word κήρ. She means he resembles death in his malice; the poem means he resembles his own imminent fate. Even her curses are proleptic.
- 56 *l. 518* The singer-simile, from the poem's most honest man: the beggar's lying tales hold a listener "as a man gazes at a singer... and they ache to hear him on and on." Alcinous made the same comparison to the same storyteller (11.363–369). The poem twice certifies its hero as its own equal — the fiction-maker praised in the poet's own coin, here by a man who does not know the tales were false.
- 57 *l. 525* Eumaeus relays the Thesprotian rumor — Odysseus near, alive, rich — exactly as the beggar designed it to travel. The news now reaches Penelope twice in one afternoon (Theoclymenus' oath, the beggar's report at one remove), from independent sources, both true in substance. She will sit down with the source himself at nightfall.
- 58 *l. 541* Telemachus' sneeze detonates on the exact clause — "he would repay these men their violence" — and Penelope laughs: her first laugh in the poem. The sneeze-omen (an involuntary truth-mark on spoken words) is folk-divination, and she rides it instantly into a formal death-wish for every suitor. Under the grief, the queen keeps a gambler's eye for signs; the laugh is the sound of odds shifting.

- 59 *l. 550* Penelope takes up the clothing formula in her own voice — "I will dress him in a cloak and a tunic" — the same promise made by Eumaeus (14.516), Telemachus (16.79), and relayed to the beggar at 557–558. The whole loyal household now stands in a queue to dress this man; the poem lets the formula accumulate like a debt paid at last in Book 23, when Eurynome bathes him and dresses him in the house's own cloth (23.153–155).
- 60 *l. 553* "Stranger — father" (ξεῖνε πάτερ): the swineherd's honorific for an old man, and the poem lets the address do double work — Eumaeus keeps calling Odysseus "father" without knowing it, as Telemachus calls Eumaeus "old father" while his own father listens.
- 61 *l. 563* "I know about that man well: we have taken up the same misery" (ὁμῆν ἀνεδέγμεθ' οἷζύν) — the disguised man's densest truth yet: literally claiming shared suffering with himself. Every listener hears sympathy; the sentence is a confession.
- 62 *l. 565* "Whose arrogance and violence reach the iron sky" = 15.329, Eumaeus' hyperbole handed back to him by the man he warned. The borrowed line is also an argument: you yourself told me what these men are.
- 63 *l. 570* Odysseus dictates the terms of the Book 19 interview: after sunset, by the fire, close — and Eumaeus, relaying the message, adds "alone." He gives the pretext of his rags, but the stagecraft is exact — firelight, the suitors gone — and his best stagehand quietly improves the blocking. The most important conversation of the homecoming is being laid out in advance by its director; even Penelope's own summons must run on his schedule. Her approving comment (586–589: "the stranger is no fool") grades his caution correctly and misses whose caution it is.
- 64 *l. 578* "A shy man makes a bad beggar" (κακὸς δ' αἰδοῖος ἀλήτης) — Penelope has proverbs for beggars too; it is the exact inverse of her son's at 347 ("shame is no good companion to a man in need"). Mother and son quote the same folk-wisdom from opposite ends; the house thinks in shared maxims, as it weeps in shared formulas.
- 65 *l. 586* Penelope's verdict — "the stranger is no fool: he guesses how it might be" — rests on her own bitter superlative: no men on earth contrive reckless outrage *like these* (ὥδε). The queen has become the connoisseur of her hall's evil; the beggar's caution is, by her own measure, simply accurate.
- 66 *l. 599* "So be it, old father" — Telemachus closes with the same words that opened the book (16.31's formula at 17.6 "old father"), sending Eumaeus home to the pigs he guards, with orders for the morning's beasts. The book ends as it began, in the language of the foster-bond — while the true father sits on in the hall among his enemies.
- 67 *l. 606* The day ends in "dance and song" — the suitors' pleasure machine running on into the evening, unaware it has been inspected. The beggar has begged their measure man by man; Argus is dead; the footstool has been thrown and counted; and the interview by firelight is set for Book 19, once Book 18's brawling has burned through the evening. "Already the day had come on to evening": the poem's slow clock strikes once, quietly.



## Odyssey — Book 18

*The fight with Irus; the warning to Amphinomus; Penelope shines before the suitors.*

- And there came a public beggar, who used to beg<sup>1</sup>  
 through the town of Ithaca, notorious for his ravening belly,  
 eating and drinking without end; no strength was in him  
 and no force, but in bulk he was very big to look at.
- 5 Arnaeus was his name — his honored mother gave it him  
 at birth; but Irus all the young men called him,  
 because he would run messages whenever anyone bade him.  
 He came now to drive Odysseus from his own house,<sup>2</sup>  
 and abusing him he spoke winged words:
- 10 "Off the porch, old man — or be dragged off quick by the foot.  
 Don't you see how they're all winking at me,  
 telling me to drag you? I am ashamed to, even so.  
 Up, then — before our quarrel comes to fists."  
 Then, glaring from under his brows, Odysseus of the many designs  
 replied:
- 15 "Man possessed — I do you no harm, I say you none;  
 I grudge no one giving to you, however much he takes up.  
 This threshold will hold the two of us. You have no need<sup>3</sup>  
 to grudge what is other men's. You seem to me a wanderer  
 just as I am — and prosperity is the gods' to give.
- 20 Only do not challenge me too far with your fists, or you will anger me,  
 and old as I am I will spatter your chest and lips  
 with blood. And I would have the more peace for it  
 tomorrow: for I do not think you would come back  
 a second time to the hall of Laertes' son Odysseus."
- 25 Then Irus the vagrant answered him in anger:  
 "Listen to the glutton — how he rattles on,  
 like an old woman at her oven! I'll plan him a nasty turn:<sup>4</sup>  
 hit him with both hands and knock every tooth  
 from his jaws to the ground, like a crop-raiding sow's.
- 30 Belt up now, so all these men may know us

- as we fight. But how would you fight a younger man?"  
 So, before the high doors, on the polished  
 threshold, the two of them bristled at each other with whole hearts.  
 And the sacred strength of Antinous took note of them,<sup>5</sup>  
 35 and breaking into easy laughter he called to the suitors:  
 "Friends — nothing like this has ever happened yet:  
 what sport the god has brought into this house!  
 The stranger and Irus are wrangling with each other  
 to fight it out with fists. Quick — let us match them!"  
 40 So he spoke; and they all sprang up laughing  
 and crowded round the ill-dressed beggars.  
 And Antinous spoke among them, Eupheithes' son:  
 "Hear me, lordly suitors, while I say a word.  
 There are goats' paunches lying at the fire, which we set by<sup>6</sup>  
 45 for supper, filled with fat and blood.  
 Whichever of the two wins and proves the better man,  
 let him stand up and take his pick of them;  
 and ever after he shall feast with us, and no other  
 beggar will we let inside to beg among us."  
 50 So spoke Antinous, and his word pleased them well.  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs, with craft in mind, spoke among  
 them:  
 "Friends, there is no way an old man can fight  
 a younger one — a man worn down by misery. But the belly,  
 that worker of evil, eggs me on, to go down under his blows.  
 55 Come then, all of you swear me a strong oath:<sup>7</sup>  
 that no one, doing Irus a favor, will strike me  
 a foul blow with a heavy hand, and force me under for him."  
 So he spoke; and they all swore the oath as he demanded.  
 And when they had sworn and sealed the oath entire,  
 60 the sacred strength of Telemachus spoke among them:  
 "Stranger — if your heart and your proud spirit move you  
 to beat this man off, fear none of the other  
 Achaeans: whoever strikes you will have more than one to fight.  
 Your host is myself; and the kings second it,  
 65 Antinous and Eurymachus, sound-thinking men both."<sup>8</sup>  
 So he spoke, and they all approved. And Odysseus

- girded his rags about his loins, and bared his thighs —  
 beautiful, massive — and his broad shoulders came to light,  
 his chest, his heavy arms. And Athena
- 70 came close and filled out the limbs of the shepherd of the people.<sup>9</sup>  
 And the suitors, every one, were amazed beyond all measure,  
 and a man would say, with a glance at his neighbor:  
 "Irus un-Irused soon — a self-invited beating!"<sup>10</sup>  
 Look what a thigh the old man shows from under those rags."
- 75 So they spoke; and Irus' heart was stirred — for the worse.  
 Even so the serving-men girded him and led him out  
 by force, in terror, the flesh trembling on his limbs.  
 And Antinous rebuked him, and spoke a word, and named him:  
 "Better you were not alive, you ox of a braggart, nor ever born,
- 80 if you shiver and fear so terribly before this man —  
 an old man, worn out with the misery that has found him.  
 But I will tell you this, and it will be accomplished:  
 if this man beats you and proves the better man,  
 I will throw you in a black ship and send you to the mainland,
- 85 to King Echetus, the maimer of all mankind,<sup>11</sup>  
 who will slice away your nose and ears with the pitiless bronze  
 and tear off your parts and give them raw to the dogs to share."  
 So he spoke; and a still greater trembling seized Irus' limbs.  
 But they led him into the middle; and both men put up their hands.
- 90 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus debated<sup>12</sup>  
 whether to hit him so the life would leave him where he fell,  
 or to hit him gently and just stretch him on the ground.  
 And as he weighed it, this seemed to him the better way:  
 to strike gently, so the Achaeans would not take note of him.
- 95 Then both put up their guard; Irus drove at the right shoulder,  
 but he struck the neck under the ear, and crushed the bones  
 inward: at once the red blood came up in his mouth,  
 and he went down bleating in the dust, teeth clenched together,<sup>13</sup>  
 heels drumming the ground. And the lordly suitors
- 100 threw up their hands and died laughing. Then Odysseus<sup>14</sup>  
 took him by the foot and dragged him out through the porch  
 to the courtyard and the colonnade gates; and there he propped him

- against the courtyard fence, sitting up, and pushed his stick into his hand,  
and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to him:
- 105 "Sit there now, and keep off the pigs and dogs,<sup>15</sup>  
and stop lording it over strangers and beggars,  
wretch that you are, or a worse evil yet may find you."  
He spoke, and slung about his shoulders his beggar's pouch,  
full of holes, hanging by a twisted cord,
- 110 and went back to the threshold and sat down. And they went inside  
laughing sweetly, and saluted him with words:  
"May Zeus give you, stranger, and the other deathless gods,<sup>16</sup>  
whatever you most desire, whatever is dear to your heart —  
you who stopped that insatiable one from begging  
115 through the land! For soon we will haul him to the mainland,  
to King Echetus, the maimer of all mankind."  
So they spoke; and noble Odysseus rejoiced at the omen of the words.  
And Antinous set beside him the great paunch,  
filled with fat and blood; and Amphinomus  
120 took up two loaves from the basket and set them by him,  
and pledged him with a golden cup, and said:  
"Your health, father stranger! May happiness be yours  
in time to come — though now you are held fast in many evils."  
Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:
- 125 "Amphinomus — you seem to me a man of good sense,  
and such was the father you come from: I have heard his good name —  
Nisus of Dulichium, a brave man and a rich one.  
They say you are his son; and you seem a civil man.<sup>17</sup>  
So I will tell you something. Mark it; hear me out.
- 130 The earth breeds nothing feebler than a man —<sup>18</sup>  
of all things that breathe and move on the face of it.  
He tells himself he will never suffer evil in time to come,  
as long as the gods lend him prowess and his knees are quick;  
but when the blessed gods bring hard days too to pass,  
135 these too he bears — unwilling, on an enduring heart.  
For such is the mind of men who live on earth:  
it is weather — whatever day the father of gods and men brings on.<sup>19</sup>  
I too was once set fair to be fortunate among men,

- and I did many reckless things, giving way to my force and power,  
 140 trusting in my father and my brothers.  
 So let no man ever be lawless in anything,  
 but keep in silence whatever gifts the gods may give.  
 Such recklessness I see the suitors devising here —  
 shearing away the goods, dishonoring the wife  
 145 of a man who, I tell you, will not long be far  
 from his friends and his fathers' land. He is very close. But you —<sup>20</sup>  
 may your own fate steal you home instead; may you not meet him  
 the day he comes back to his own dear country.  
 For not without blood, I think, will they be parted,  
 150 the suitors and that man, once he comes in under his roof."  
 So he spoke, and poured, and drank the honey-sweet wine,  
 then gave the cup back into the hands of the marshal of the people.  
 And that man went off down the hall with an aching heart,  
 head sinking down: for his spirit foresaw the evil.  
 155 But even so he did not escape his fate: Athena bound him too,<sup>21</sup>  
 to be broken under the hands and spear of Telemachus.  
 Back he went, and sat down on the chair from which he had risen.  
 And now the goddess, gray-eyed Athena, put it in the mind<sup>22</sup>  
 of Icarius' daughter, watchful-minded Penelope,  
 160 to show herself to the suitors: so she might open  
 their hearts wide as sails, and come to stand more precious  
 in her husband's eyes, and her son's, than she had been before.  
 She laughed — an empty laugh — and spoke a word, and named her:<sup>23</sup>  
 "Eurynome, my heart longs — as it never has before —  
 165 to show myself to the suitors, hateful as they are.  
 And I would say a word to my son — the better for him:  
 not to keep such company with the overweening suitors,  
 who speak him fair and mean him evil behind."  
 And Eurynome the housekeeper answered her:  
 170 "Yes, child — all this you have said as it should be.  
 Go then, and speak your word to your son; hide nothing.  
 But first wash your skin, and put a shine on your cheeks:  
 do not go with your face all stained like this  
 with tears. Grief without respite makes everything worse.  
 175 And your son is now the age you prayed the deathless ones<sup>24</sup>

- so long to let you see: a bearded man."  
 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered her:  
 "Eurynome, do not coax me so — out of love, I know —  
 to wash my skin and put a gloss upon it.  
 180 Whatever bloom I had, the gods who hold Olympus<sup>25</sup>  
 destroyed it the day that man went off in the hollow ships.  
 But tell Autonoe and Hippodamia to come  
 and stand beside me in the hall:  
 alone I will not go among men. I would be ashamed."  
 185 So she spoke; and the old woman went off through the hall  
 to carry word to the women and hurry them along.  
 Then the goddess, gray-eyed Athena, thought of one thing more:  
 over Icarius' daughter she poured sweet sleep,  
 and she slept, leaning back, and all her joints went loose  
 190 right there on the couch. And meanwhile the shining goddess  
 was giving her immortal gifts, to make the Achaeans stare.<sup>26</sup>  
 First, for her beauty, she cleansed her lovely face  
 with the ambrosial balm that crowned Cytherea  
 anoints herself with, when she goes to the Graces' lovely dance;  
 195 and she made her taller and fuller to the eye,  
 and made her whiter than sawn ivory.<sup>27</sup>  
 That done, the shining goddess went away,  
 and the white-armed handmaids came in from the hall,  
 talking as they came; and the sweet sleep let her go.  
 200 She rubbed her cheeks with her hands and said:  
 "Soft — the softest of trances wrapped me round, for all my anguish.  
 If only pure Artemis would give me a death as soft,<sup>28</sup>  
 this very instant — so that I need no longer mourn at heart,  
 wasting my life away, longing for my dear husband  
 205 and his every excellence: for he stood out among the Achaeans."  
 So speaking she came down from her shining upper room —  
 not alone: two handmaids followed with her.  
 And when she reached the suitors, shining among women,  
 she stood beside the pillar of the close-built roof,  
 210 holding her glistening veil before her cheeks,  
 a trusted handmaid standing on either side.<sup>29</sup>

And their knees went slack on the spot, their hearts spellbound with desire,<sup>30</sup>

and every man prayed to lie in bed beside her.

But she spoke to Telemachus, her dear son:

215 "Telemachus, your mind is no longer steady, nor your thought.

While you were still a boy, you turned shrewder plans than this;  
but now that you are grown, come to the measure of manhood,<sup>31</sup>  
so that a stranger, looking at your height and beauty,  
would say you must be some rich man's son —

220 your mind and thought are no longer as they should be.

What a thing has been done here in the halls:

you let the stranger be manhandled so!

What now — if a stranger, sitting in our house,  
should come to harm from such ugly hauling-about?

225 On you the shame and the disgrace would fall, among all men."

Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:

"Mother mine, I cannot resent your anger at this.

But I do take note in my heart, I do know each thing,  
the good and the worse alike. Before, I was still a child.

230 Yet I cannot manage to think out everything wisely:

these men unhinge me — crowding me this side and that,  
plotting their mischief; and I have no helpers.

Still, the bout of the stranger and Irus did not go  
as the suitors intended: the stranger was the stronger.

235 If only — father Zeus, Athena, Apollo! —<sup>32</sup>

the suitors in our house would nod their heads  
like that, beaten and broken, some in the courtyard,  
some inside the house, and the limbs of each gone slack,  
the way that Irus over there at the courtyard gates

240 sits lolling his head like a man dead drunk,

and cannot stand upright on his feet, or go  
home, wherever home is — since his own limbs are slack."

So they spoke to one another of such things.

And Eurymachus addressed Penelope with words:

245 "Daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded Penelope,  
if all the Achaeans through Iasian Argos could see you,  
more suitors yet would be feasting in your house

- from tomorrow morning: for you surpass all women  
in form and stature, and in the balanced mind within."
- 250 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:  
"Eurymachus, my excellence — my face, my figure —<sup>33</sup>  
the deathless ones destroyed the day the Argives  
boarded ship for Ilium, and my husband Odysseus with them.  
If he came back — if he watched over this life of mine —
- 255 my fame would be greater so, and lovelier.  
Now I only grieve: so many evils the god has driven at me.  
Truly, when he went, leaving his fathers' land,  
he took me by the right hand at the wrist and said:<sup>34</sup>  
'Wife — I do not think the strong-greaved Achaeans
- 260 will all come home from Troy unharmed and whole:  
the Trojans too, they say, are men of war,  
spear-throwers, drawers of the bow,  
mounters of swift-footed horses — such as decide  
soonest the great strife of leveling war.
- 265 So I cannot know whether the god will bring me back,  
or I go down there in Troy. Let everything here be your care.  
Remember my father and my mother in these halls  
as now, or even more, while I am far away.  
But when you see our son a bearded man,<sup>35</sup>
- 270 marry whom you will, and leave your house behind.'  
So he spoke it, that man. And now it is all being accomplished:  
the night will come when the marriage I loathe will meet me —  
my cursed self, whose happiness Zeus has torn away.  
But this bitter shame comes over my heart and spirit:
- 275 this is not what suitors' custom used to be.<sup>36</sup>  
Men who would woo a good woman, a rich man's  
daughter, and contend with one another for her —  
they drive up cattle of their own, and fat sheep,  
a feast for the bride's people, and they give her shining gifts.
- 280 They do not devour another man's living, scot-free."  
So she spoke; and much-enduring noble Odysseus was glad<sup>37</sup>  
that she drew gifts out of them, charming their hearts  
with honeyed words, while her mind was bent on other things.  
Then Antinous answered her, Eupheithes' son:



- 285 "Daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded Penelope,  
the gifts — whatever any Achaeon wishes to bring here,  
accept them: it is not good manners to refuse a gift.  
But we are not going to our lands, nor anywhere else,  
until you marry whichever of the Achaeans is best."
- 290 So spoke Antinous, and his word pleased them well,  
and each man sent a herald off to bring his gifts.  
For Antinous he brought a great embroidered robe,<sup>38</sup>  
beautiful, and in it were brooches, twelve in all,  
of gold, fitted with well-bent clasps.
- 295 For Eurymachus one brought a necklace, richly worked  
in gold, strung with pieces of amber, bright as the sun.  
For Eurydamas two henchmen brought a pair of earrings,  
triple-dropped like mulberries; and much grace glinted from them.  
And out of the house of lord Peisander, Polyctor's son,
- 300 a henchman brought a neck-band, a jewel of great beauty.  
And so one Achaeon after another brought his lovely gift.  
Then she went up to her upper room, shining among women,  
and her handmaids carried the beautiful gifts beside her.  
But the men turned to the dance and to lovely song
- 305 and took their pleasure there, and waited for evening to come.  
And as they took their pleasure, the black evening came upon them.  
At once they set up three braziers in the halls  
to give them light, and heaped dry kindling round —  
long-seasoned, bone-dry, new-split with the bronze —
- 310 and mixed in pine-brands. And turn by turn the slave-women  
of enduring-hearted Odysseus kept the flame alive. And to them  
he himself spoke, Zeus-born Odysseus of the many designs:  
"Slave-women of Odysseus, of your master so long gone:  
go through to the rooms where the honored queen is;
- 315 turn the spindle at her side, and cheer her heart,  
sitting there in her chamber, or card the wool with your hands.  
I will keep up the light for all these men myself."<sup>39</sup>  
Even if they choose to wait for fair-throned Dawn,  
they will not outlast me. I am a very patient man."<sup>40</sup>
- 320 So he spoke; and they burst out laughing, glancing at one another.  
And fair-cheeked Melantho jeered at him shamefully —<sup>41</sup>

- Dolius fathered her, but Penelope brought her up  
and cherished her like her own child, and gave her toys to her heart's  
desire;  
yet even so no grief for Penelope touched her mind,  
325 but she slept with Eurymachus, and loved him.  
She now jeered at Odysseus with words of abuse:  
"You sorry stranger — you must be some kind of half-wit:  
you will not go and sleep at the smithy's house,<sup>42</sup>  
or some public shed — no, you stand here running your mouth,  
330 bold as brass among all these men, and your heart feels  
no fear. Either the wine has hold of your wits, or your mind  
is always of this sort — that is why you babble so idly.  
Or are you giddy because you beat that vagrant Irus?  
Watch out that no better man than Irus stands up soon,  
335 who will box both sides of your skull with his heavy hands  
and send you out of the house all fouled with blood."  
Then, glaring from under his brows, Odysseus of the many designs  
replied:  
"One word to Telemachus, you bitch, and I go straight to him now,<sup>43</sup>  
for what you are saying — and he will cut you limb from limb on the  
spot."  
340 So speaking, he set the women scattering in terror:  
off they went through the house, and the knees of every one  
went slack with fear; they thought he spoke the truth.  
But he took his stand by the burning braziers, tending  
the light, and watched them all; and other things his heart  
345 was pondering deep within — things not destined to fall short.<sup>44</sup>  
And Athena would not let the lordly suitors  
hold back from heart-stinging outrage — so that pain might sink<sup>45</sup>  
still deeper into Laertes' son Odysseus.  
So Eurymachus, Polybus' son, began to speak among them,  
350 baiting Odysseus; and he raised a laugh among his companions:  
"Hear me, you suitors of the far-famed queen,  
while I say what the heart in my breast commands.  
Not without god's guidance has this man come to Odysseus' house —  
at any rate the blaze of the torches seems to me to come  
355 straight off his head: for there is not one hair on it, not a wisp."<sup>46</sup>

- He spoke, and turned to Odysseus, sacker of cities:  
 "Stranger — would you take a hire, if I took you on,  
 out at the end of my lands — your pay will not fail you —  
 picking stones for walls and planting tall trees?  
 360 There I would furnish you bread the year round,  
 and put clothes on your body, and give you sandals for your feet.  
 But no: you have learned bad ways, and you will not<sup>47</sup>  
 set yourself to work; you would rather cringe through the town  
 begging, to feed that bottomless belly of yours."
- 365 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 "Eurymachus — if only the two of us could have a match at work,<sup>48</sup>  
 in the spring season, when the days grow long:  
 at mowing — I with a well-curved scythe in hand,  
 and you with one like it — a trial of work,  
 370 fasting right up to dark, and the grass still standing thick.  
 Or oxen to drive — the very best oxen,  
 tawny and big, both of them fat with grass,  
 matched in age and pull, their strength no trifle,  
 and a four-acre field, the soil giving under the plow:  
 375 then you would see whether I could cut a furrow straight and long.  
 Or if the son of Cronos stirred up war — from anywhere —  
 this very day, and I had a shield and two spears  
 and a helmet all of bronze, fitted to my temples:  
 then you would see me mixed into the front fighters,  
 380 and you would not talk and talk, jeering at this belly of mine.  
 But no — you are full of insolence, and your mind is hard,  
 and no doubt you fancy yourself a big man and a mighty,  
 because you keep company with few — and none of them good.<sup>49</sup>  
 But if Odysseus came — if he reached his own country —  
 385 those doors, wide as they are, would all at once  
 be too narrow for you, flying through the porch for the street."<sup>50</sup>  
 So he spoke; and Eurymachus grew the angrier at heart,  
 and glaring from under his brows he spoke winged words:  
 "Wretch — I will finish you off for good, for the way you talk,  
 390 bold as brass among all these men, and your heart feels<sup>51</sup>  
 no fear. Either the wine has hold of your wits, or your mind  
 is always of this sort — that is why you babble so idly.

Or are you giddy because you beat that vagrant Irus?"  
 With that he seized a footstool. But Odysseus  
 395 sank down at the knees of Amphinomus of Dulichium,  
 in fear of Eurymachus; and the stool struck the cupbearer<sup>52</sup>  
 on the right hand: his wine-jug rang on the floor where it fell,  
 and the man groaned and went over backward in the dust.  
 And the suitors raised a din through the shadowy halls,  
 400 and a man would say, with a glance at his neighbor:  
 "If only the stranger had died on his wanderings somewhere else  
 before he ever came! He would not have brought all this uproar.  
 Now here we are brawling over beggars; there will be no joy  
 even in the good feast, now the worse is winning out."<sup>53</sup>  
 405 And the sacred strength of Telemachus spoke among them:  
 "You are possessed — you have gone mad. You can no longer hide  
 what you have eaten and drunk. Some god is goading you on."<sup>54</sup>  
 No — you have feasted well: now go home and lie down,  
 whenever the spirit moves you. Not that I am driving anyone out."  
 410 So he spoke; and they all bit their lips and stared  
 in wonder at Telemachus, that he spoke so boldly.  
 Then Amphinomus rose and spoke among them —  
 the shining son of Nisus, of the lord Aretias' line:  
 "Friends — no man should take offense at a just word spoken,  
 415 and answer it with wrangling and hard speech.  
 Do not knock the stranger about, nor any other  
 of the slaves in the house of godlike Odysseus.  
 Come — let the cupbearer pour first-drops in the cups,  
 so we can make libation and go home to bed;  
 420 and the stranger — let us leave him in the halls of Odysseus  
 for Telemachus to see to: it is his dear house the man has come to."<sup>55</sup>  
 So he spoke, and the word he spoke pleased all of them.  
 And the hero Moulus mixed the bowl for them,  
 the herald from Dulichium, Amphinomus' henchman;  
 425 he served it round to all in turn; and they poured  
 to the blessed gods, and drank the honey-sweet wine.  
 And when they had poured, and drunk as much as their hearts would  
 have,  
 they went their ways to bed, each man to his own house.<sup>56</sup>

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 18

- 1    *l. 1* Irus, the poem's only other beggar with a name — two names: Arnaeus from his mother, "Irus" from the young men, a mock-masculine of Iris because he ran their messages. A "public beggar" (πανδήμιος) with a recognized beat, big, soft, and hungry: everything Odysseus is pretending to be, embodied by a man who is nothing else. The book opens the poem's cruellest mirror: the true king disguised as a beggar must fight the true beggar for the throne of the threshold.
- 2    *l. 8* "To drive Odysseus from his own house" — the line's whole irony in five words. Every party to the fight mistakes the property claim: Irus defends a doorway he thinks is his territory, in a house belonging to the man he is evicting.
- 3    *l. 17* "This threshold will hold the two of us" — the real beggar's ethic, offered by the false beggar: room for both, no grudging what belongs to others, fortune is the gods' to deal. Odysseus opens with solidarity and a warning; Irus, sponsored by the suitors' winks, refuses the offer. The poor man siding with the rich against the poorer is the book's first study in corruption.
- 4    *l. 26* "Like an old woman at her oven" (γρηῖ καμινόῃ ἴσος) — a glimpse of working-class invective older than the epic: the crone who talks while she tends the kiln-fire. Irus' threats are all borrowed teeth — the sow image, the tooth-scattering — from a man whose flesh will shortly be "trembling on his limbs."
- 5    *l. 34* "The sacred strength of Antinous" — the honorific periphrasis elsewhere reserved for King Alcinous (and for Telemachus at 60, where it belongs) here gilds the ringleader as he organizes a beggar-fight for after-dinner sport. The formula is a rented crown: on Antinous it reads as the poem's straight-faced sarcasm.
- 6    *l. 44* The prize: blood-and-fat sausages off the fire, plus a standing dinner invitation and a beggars' monopoly. Antinous invents the pauper's Olympics complete with purse and title — organized generosity, suitor-style: a cruelty with catering.
- 7    *l. 55* Odysseus makes the whole company swear not to interfere — invoking oath-procedure, the suitors' own institutions, before throwing a single punch. They swear "as he demanded": the mob that respects no law of guest or god is punctilious about sporting rules. He is learning exactly how far their formality goes.
- 8    *l. 64* Telemachus as guarantor, "and the kings second it, Antinous and Eurymachus, sound-thinking men both" (πεπνυμένω — his own epithet, handed to the two worst men present). The son has learned his father's art of the straight-faced compliment.
- 9    *l. 67* The unveiling: thighs "beautiful, massive," broad shoulders, heavy arms, with Athena inflating the limbs for effect. The rags gape and the body of the sacker of cities shows through — the disguise's first deliberate crack, and the suitors stare straight at the evidence and see only a well-built old tramp.

- 10 l. 73 "Irus un-Irused" (Ἴρος Ἰῖρος) — the suitors' own pun: the messenger-beggar about to be stripped of the name, "a self-invited beating" (ἐπίσπαστον κακόν). The poem lets the mockers be witty; their laughter is the same instrument that will register as ash in Book 20.
- 11 l. 85 Echetus "the maimer of all mankind" — the bogeyman-king of the mainland, with his catalogue of mutilations (nose, ears, and worse to the dogs). Whether folk-monster or remembered tyrant, he is the suitors' favorite threat (again at 116, and at 21.308): their imagination of justice is torture outsourced to a foreign specialist.
- 12 l. 90 The deliberation formula, applied to a punch: kill him outright, or tap him? He chooses the "gentle" blow so the Achaeans "would not take note of him" — operational security measured in foot-pounds. Even so the gentle version crushes the neck-bones under the ear: the poem lets us feel the coiled violence being throttled down, and what "gentle" means from this man.
- 13 l. 98 Irus goes down "bleating" (μακών) — the animal-verb; his heels drum the ground like a slaughtered beast's. The sausage-prize and the sacrificial imagery close the circle: the suitors staged a beast-fight and got one victim ready for the altar.
- 14 l. 100 "Threw up their hands and died laughing" (γέλω ἔκθανον) — the poem's grimmest idiom, chosen for men who are, on the schedule now running, going to do exactly that. Their laughter is proleptic; Book 20.345ff will literalize it into hysteria.
- 15 l. 105 Odysseus props the beaten man against the fence sitting up, folds the stick into his hand, and appoints him scarecrow: "keep off the pigs and dogs, and stop lording it over strangers and beggars." Rough justice with a coronation parody in it — the stick a scepter, the fence a throne, the kingdom pigs. The true owner distributes offices in his own courtyard, and no one notices.
- 16 l. 112 The suitors' blessing — "may Zeus give you whatever you most desire, whatever is dear to your heart" — is the poem's textbook kledon: a chance utterance carrying more truth than the speaker knows. What he most desires is their deaths, and "noble Odysseus rejoiced at the omen of the words": they have just prayed for their own funeral, formally, in his hearing.
- 17 l. 128 "You seem a civil man" — ἐπιτήης, the rare word of praise Athena herself gave Odysseus at 13.332. Amphinomus earns the poem's most personal warning because he shows the poem's most personal virtue.
- 18 l. 130 The speech to Amphinomus is the poem's deepest meditation, and its most famous: "The earth breeds nothing feeblier than a man." Not weaker in body — feeblier in foresight: he cannot believe in future evil while his knees are quick. The lines are the beggar's credentials cashed as wisdom — only a man who has been both fortunate and ruined can testify to the whole arc.
- 19 l. 136 "It is weather — whatever day the father of gods and men brings on": the mind of man is the day (ἐπ' ἥμαρ) Zeus sends. Identity as weather, selfhood as the day's light — the most quoted two lines of the Odyssey outside the proem, and they are spoken by a king in rags to the one decent man among his enemies, as a reason to go home.

- 20 l. 146 "He is very close" (μάλα δὲ σχεδόν) — the warning strips itself almost naked: the wronged man "will not long be far from his friends and his fathers' land." Then the plea: may a god steal you home first; there will be blood. Odysseus offers Amphinomus the exit Athena will lock (155–156). No one else among the suitors is offered anything.
- 21 l. 155 "But even so he did not escape his fate: Athena bound him too." The poem's hardest theological sentence: the man is warned, believes the warning ("his spirit foresaw the evil"), walks away heartsick — and the goddess pins him to his chair. Divine justice here is not persuasion but a net; Amphinomus' half-goodness earns him only the full foreknowledge of his death at Telemachus' spear (22.89ff). The poem does not explain; it reports.
- 22 l. 158 Athena's stated triple purpose: open the suitors' hearts like sails, and raise Penelope's worth in the eyes of her husband and her son. The goddess choreographs an apparition with three audiences — and the queen experiences the impulse as inexplicable ("as it never has before," 164). The scene runs on two wills, one of them unaware.
- 23 l. 163 "She laughed — an empty laugh" (ἄχρητον δ' ἐγέλασσεν) — the most argued adverb in the poem. Pointless, forced, nervous — a laugh with no object, at her own inexplicable urge. Her second laugh in two books (17.542 rode an omen; this one rides an impulse from a goddess she cannot see). Between the two laughs the poem sketches a woman whose gaiety has lost its uses and flickers on anyway.
- 24 l. 175 Eurynome says it plainly: your son is bearded now — the very condition Odysseus set (269–270). The household knows the clock has struck; and when Penelope recites the terms below (257–270), the man who set them will be standing in the hall in rags, hearing his own clause come due — and rejoicing (281–283).
- 25 l. 180 "The gods destroyed my bloom the day that man went off" — she says it to Eurynome here and repeats it to Eurymachus at 251–253: her beauty left with the fleet, twenty years ago, as far as she is concerned. The goddess's cosmetics (187–196) are applied to a woman who has formally resigned from beauty; the gap between her self-account and her effect (212–213) is the scene's engine.
- 26 l. 187 The makeover happens while she sleeps: Athena pours sleep on her, and while she lies unknowing applies the "immortal gifts" — the balm of Cytherea, height, fullness, ivory skin. Penelope is beautified the way Odysseus was (6.229ff, 23.156ff), but unconscious, and wakes wishing for death by Artemis' soft arrow (202–205). She is the only recipient of a divine glow-up in the poem who was not asked and did not want it.
- 27 l. 196 "Whiter than sawn ivory" — πριστοῦ ἐλέφαντος: the simile is a craftsman's, from the workshop bench (fresh-cut ivory, before handling yellows it). The poem beautifies her in materials, as it beautified Odysseus in metallurgy (gold over silver): the household arts supplying the language of divine cosmetics.
- 28 l. 202 The soft-death prayer to Artemis — the goddess's "gentle arrows" (cf. 15.410–411 and note) as release from a life of longing. She will pray it again, expanded and more terrible, at 20.61–82. That the wish follows directly on the divine beauty treatment is the poem's bleakest comedy: Athena giftwraps her for the suitors; she wakes and asks the other goddess for the arrow.

- 29 l. 209 The entrance repeats 1.333–335 to the letter — pillar, glistening veil, a handmaid on either side. Third strike of the fixed frame (16.415–416 lacked the handmaid line; here it is complete): the queen appears, cheeked in cloth, flanked, and each time the stakes have risen — a song stopped, a murder stopped, and now a hall of hearts to be opened like sails.
- 30 l. 212 "Their knees went slack on the spot, their hearts spellbound with desire, / and every man prayed to lie in bed beside her." The knee-slackening formula is elsewhere what death does; the poem spends it here on desire, then re-spends it through the book — Irus' broken limbs (238–242), the maids' terror (341–342). Slack knees are Book 18's connective tissue: lust, beating, fear — one physiology.
- 31 l. 217 Her rebuke measures her son against his own growth-spurt: big enough that a stranger would call him a rich man's son, and yet he let a guest be mauled. News of the footstool has reached the upper room with its details intact (as at 17.492ff): the house's reporting chains run true, and the queen audits *xenia* from behind a veil.
- 32 l. 235 "If only — father Zeus, Athena, Apollo!" — the wish-formula (4.341 = 17.132, Menelaus wishing Odysseus on the suitors) now in Telemachus' mouth, wishing the suitors into Irus' posture: heads lolling, limbs slack, "like a man dead drunk." Menelaus wished it first; Telemachus carried it home in quotation; now he prays it in his own right — three soundings, two voices, and the poem stacks them like sworn depositions.
- 33 l. 251 Her answer to Eurymachus' gallantry is the same formula she gave Eurynome (180–181): my beauty died on departure day. Then — to the man who leads the suitors with charm — she produces the departure speech itself, quoted entire. To flirtation she answers with a marriage's founding document.
- 34 l. 258 "He took me by the right hand at the wrist" — the precise grip (ἐπὶ καρπῷ) of solemn undertaking, the gesture of weddings and pledges. Twenty years on she reproduces her husband's farewell wrist to word: his modesty about surviving ("the Trojans too, they say, are men of war" — from the man who would beat them), the household instructions, the parents, and the terrible codicil.
- 35 l. 269 "When you see our son a bearded man, marry whom you will" — the poem's time-bomb, quoted by the woman it is set to detonate under, in the hearing of the disguised man who set it. Eurynome has just confirmed the beard (176). Penelope is announcing, in open hall, that the term has run out — "the night will come when the marriage I loathe will meet me." Whether she knows the beggar is listening, or for whom the performance is meant, the poem leaves shut; what is certain is that the deadline is real and she has stopped pretending otherwise.
- 36 l. 275 Even surrendering, she invoices them: proper suitors bring cattle and sheep, feast the bride's kin, give shining gifts — "they do not devour another man's living, scot-free." The complaint is genealogy-deep (bride-price custom recited as law), and it works: gifts are sent for within twenty lines. She converts her own capitulation announcement into a levy on the men who forced it.
- 37 l. 281 The crux of Book 18: Odysseus "was glad that she drew gifts out of them, charming their hearts with honeyed words, while her mind was bent on other things" (νόος δέ οἱ ἄλλα μενοίνα). What other things? The poem does not say — only that the husband,



watching his wife work the room that is besieging her, recognizes the technique and delights in it. Whatever else the marriage is, it is two people who fleece a crowd the same way; the recognition scenes still to come are prefigured here as a recognition of *method*.

- 38 l. 292 The gift catalogue: a robe with twelve golden brooches, an amber necklace "bright as the sun," triple-drop mulberry earrings, a neck-band of great beauty. The suitors finally pay bride-gifts — to the wife of the living king, at her rebuke, to his suppressed delight. Note the amber necklace to Eurymachus' name: the third fatal necklace of the poem's recent memory (Eriphyle's at 15.247, the kidnappers' at 15.460).
- 39 l. 317 Odysseus volunteers as lamplighter: "I will keep up the light for all these men myself." The king takes the meanest station in his own hall — tending fire for his enemies' pleasure — and converts it into a watchtower ("watched them all," 344). The man who was the beacon of the house now literally holds its light.
- 40 l. 319 "I am a very patient man" — πολυτλήμων: he cites his own epic epithet (πολύτλας, "much-enduring") as a job qualification for staying up all night. The disguise keeps doing this — telling the truth at an angle so acute it reads as banter.
- 41 l. 321 Melantho, "fair-cheeked": Dolius' daughter, Melanthius' sister — the disloyal siblings. Her biography is given in Eumaeus' shape reversed: raised by Penelope "like her own child," given toys "to her heart's desire" — the same nursery intimacy Eumaeus had with Ctimene (15.363ff) — and out of it came no grief for her mistress, only Eurymachus' bed. The poem is explicit that kindness does not manufacture loyalty; it only reveals what receives it.
- 42 l. 328 The smithy and the public shed (λέσχη) — where the homeless actually slept warm in an Ithacan winter: the working town's real geography of destitution, known to the slave-girl in detail. Her cruelty is informed cruelty — she knows exactly where beggars belong, having decided she will never be one.
- 43 l. 338 His reply to Melantho is disproportionate and precise: one word to Telemachus "and he will cut you limb from limb." The women scatter believing him. The threat is the book's darkest foreshadowing — the twelve women die by Telemachus' decision at 22.462ff, by hanging rather than the sword, "so they might die most pitifully." Here already the punisher named is the son, not the father.
- 44 l. 343 The tableau: the beggar standing at the braziers, feeding light, "watching them all," his heart pondering "things not destined to fall short" (οὐκ ἀτέλεστα — the same word as the suitors' "work never to be finished," 16.111, flipped: their feast has no completion; his plans have nothing else). One line of firelit surveillance carries the whole revenge in suspension.
- 45 l. 346 Athena's goad again (as at 17.360ff but sharpened): she prevents the suitors from stopping their abuse, "so that pain might sink still deeper" into Odysseus. The goddess is stoking her own champion — cruelty rationed to him as fuel. The economy of the revenge requires his rage topped up; his patroness sees to the supply chain.
- 46 l. 353 Eurymachus' torch-and-bald-head joke — the firelight "comes straight off his head, for there is not one hair on it." The wit lands on the man Athena balded by hand at

13.431. The suitors keep grading the disguise excellent without knowing there is a disguise; every joke doubles as an inspection passed.

- 47 *l. 362* Lines 362–364 repeat Melanthius' sneer at 17.226–228 nearly verbatim, person-shifted: "you have learned bad ways... to feed that bottomless belly of yours." Master and goatherd run on the same script; the formula-system files Eurymachus and Melanthius as one voice in two stations (as it will pair him with Melantho at 390–393 — he shares insults with both disloyal siblings).
- 48 *l. 366* The work-challenge: mowing "fasting right up to dark," plowing a four-acre field behind matched oxen, or war with shield and two spears — "then you would see me." The king's résumé as laborer completes the servant's résumé of 15.319–324: between them, Odysseus has now claimed competence at every station of his own household, from wine-pouring to plow to front rank. The aristocratic ideal underneath is αὐτάρκεια — the master who can out-work every man he owns.
- 49 *l. 382* "You fancy yourself a big man... because you keep company with few — and none of them good": the beggar diagnoses Eurymachus' whole stature as a small-pond effect. It is the book's most surgical insult, and true — the poem has shown us no suitor who would rank anywhere among the men of Troy.
- 50 *l. 384* "Those doors, wide as they are, would be too narrow for you, flying": the prophecy is exact. At 22.79ff Eurymachus will draw his sword, charge — and die at the tables, nowhere near the doors, which stay as wide as ever. The beggar keeps publishing the ending; the audience keeps hearing rhetoric.
- 51 *l. 390* Lines 390–393 = 330–333, Melantho's insult verbatim in Eurymachus' mouth — "bold as brass... the wine has hold of your wits... giddy because you beat that vagrant Irus?" Mistress's lover and slave-girl share one script for abusing beggars; the formula repetition is the poem's evidence-tag: these two talk alike because they lie in the same bed.
- 52 *l. 396* The second thrown stool of the day misses and breaks a servant: the cupbearer struck on the right hand, wine-jug clanging, the man himself groaning in the dust. The suitors' violence, aimed at the invulnerable man, is beginning to land on bystanders — the collateral pattern of a house sliding toward the slaughter that will spare so few of its occupiers.
- 53 *l. 403* "Now the worse is winning out" (τὰ χερείονα νικᾷ) — the anonymous suitor's verdict on the evening comes closer to prophecy than he knows: brawling over beggars, joy gone from the feast, the worse winning. The chorus of nameless suitors keeps issuing true bulletins (as at 17.483ff) that the named ones override.
- 54 *l. 406* Telemachus' boldest speech yet: "You are possessed — you have gone mad... Some god is goading you on" — which is, at 346–348, literally the case; the boy diagnoses Athena's hand without knowing it. Then the perfect dismissal: eat well, go home when you like, "not that I am driving anyone out." They bite their lips and wonder: the heir has begun speaking like the master of the house, with the reckoning barely a day away.
- 55 *l. 420* Amphinomus ends the evening as he ended the murder-council (16.400ff): with the decent, small, insufficient proposal — libation, bed, leave the stranger to Telemachus.

His goodness has exactly the reach of a nightcap. It is he the poem chooses to close the suitors' last full day of life — proposing the round that Moulus the herald mixes and pours (423–425) for men Athena has already bound.

- 56 l. 428 "They went their ways to bed, each man to his own house" — the suitors still have houses, this one night more. The book that began with two beggars brawling for a doorway ends with every man sleeping behind his own door — an arrangement the poem is about to make permanent for one hundred and eight of them.



## Odyssey — Book 19

*The interview by the fire; the scar; the contest announced.*

- But noble Odysseus stayed behind in the hall,<sup>1</sup>  
 plotting the suitors' slaughter with Athena's help.  
 At once he spoke winged words to Telemachus:  
 "Telemachus, the weapons of war must be laid away inside —  
 5 all of them; and the suitors — when they miss them and question you —  
 talk them around with soft words:  
 'I laid them out of the smoke: they no longer looked like the arms'<sup>2</sup>  
 Odysseus left behind when he went to Troy —  
 they are fouled over, as far as the breath of the fire reached.  
 10 And a greater fear — this too a god has cast into my heart:  
 that in your wine you might raise a quarrel among you  
 and wound one another, and shame the feast  
 and the wooing. For iron of itself draws a man on."  
 So he spoke; and Telemachus obeyed his dear father,  
 15 and calling out the nurse Eurycleia he said:  
 "Nurse, come — shut the women in their quarters for me  
 until I have stowed away in the storeroom my father's  
 beautiful arms, which the smoke dulls, uncared for, all about  
 the house, since my father went away. I was still a child then.  
 20 Now I want to lay them where the breath of the fire will not reach."  
 Then the dear nurse Eurycleia answered him:  
 "Yes, child — and if only you would take up the good sense at last  
 to care for the house and guard all its possessions!  
 But come — who then will fetch a light and carry it for you,<sup>3</sup>  
 25 if the slave-women, who would have lit you, may not come out?"  
 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:  
 "This stranger here. I will keep no man idle who takes  
 from my grain-measure, however far he has come."  
 So he spoke; and for her the word stayed wingless.  
 30 And she locked the doors of the well-settled halls.  
 Then the two sprang up, Odysseus and his shining son,  
 and carried in the helmets and the bossed shields

- and the sharp-pointed spears; and before them Pallas Athena,  
holding a golden lamp, made a light most beautiful.<sup>4</sup>
- 35 And suddenly Telemachus said to his father:  
"Father — here is a great wonder my eyes look on!<sup>5</sup>  
The walls of the hall — no question — and the fine crossbeams,  
the fir rafters, and the pillars rising high  
shine in my eyes as if from a blazing fire.
- 40 Surely some god is in the house, one of those who hold wide heaven."  
Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
"Quiet. Rein in your thought. Ask no questions.  
This is the way of the gods who hold Olympus.  
Go you to bed. I will remain behind here
- 45 to stir the slave-women a little more, and your mother:<sup>6</sup>  
in her grief she will ask me about every particular."  
So he spoke; and Telemachus went out through the hall  
to his chamber, under the blazing torches, to lie down  
where he always slept when sweet sleep came to him.
- 50 There he lay down now too, and waited for shining Dawn.  
But noble Odysseus stayed behind in the hall,  
plotting the suitors' slaughter with Athena's help.  
And out of her chamber came watchful-minded Penelope,  
like Artemis, or golden Aphrodite.
- 55 They set her chair, where she always sat, beside the fire —  
a chair wound round with ivory and silver, which the craftsman<sup>7</sup>  
Icmalius once made, and fixed beneath it a footrest  
all of a piece with it, where a great fleece would be thrown.  
There she sat down now, watchful-minded Penelope.
- 60 And the white-armed slave-women came in from the hall  
and cleared away the piles of bread, and the tables,  
and the cups from which the overbearing men had drunk;  
they raked the fire from the braziers to the floor and stacked  
fresh wood upon them, for light and for warmth.
- 65 And Melantho went at Odysseus a second time:<sup>8</sup>  
"Stranger — are you going to plague us even now, all through the night,  
prowling around the house, spying on the women?  
Out the door, you wretch — and be glad of the meal you got —  
or you'll go out quick enough with a torch-brand at your back!"

- 70 Then, glaring from under his brows, Odysseus of the many designs  
replied:  
"Woman possessed — why go for me with a heart so angry?  
Because I am dirty, because the clothes on my body are bad,  
because I beg through the land? Necessity is on me:  
that is what beggars and wandering men are like.
- 75 I too once lived in a house among men,  
a fortunate man in a wealthy one, and I often gave to a wanderer,  
whoever he might be and whatever need he came in.  
Slaves I had past counting, and everything in plenty  
by which men live well and get the name of rich.
- 80 But Zeus the son of Cronos stripped it all — such, no doubt, was his will.  
So look to yourself, woman: take care you never lose  
all that shine of yours, that sets you off among the slave-women —  
in case your mistress turns on you in anger,  
or Odysseus comes. For a portion of hope is left.
- 85 And even if he is dead as you think, and past returning,  
by Apollo's grace there is his son by now,  
such a son — Telemachus. Not one woman in these halls  
escapes his eye at her mischief. He is past that age."<sup>9</sup>  
So he spoke; and watchful-minded Penelope heard him,
- 90 and rounded on the handmaid, and spoke a word, and named her:  
"Be sure of this, bold face, dog past all shame: your grand<sup>10</sup>  
performance is not lost on me — you will wipe it off on your own head.  
You knew — every part of it — you heard it from my own mouth:  
that I meant to question the stranger in my halls
- 95 about my husband, for whom I grieve past telling."  
Then she spoke to Eurynome the housekeeper:  
"Eurynome, bring up a bench, and a fleece on it,  
for the stranger to sit and speak his word and hear me  
out: I wish to question him through and through."
- 100 So she spoke; and the woman bustled to bring the polished  
bench and set it down, and threw a fleece upon it,  
and there much-enduring noble Odysseus sat.  
And watchful-minded Penelope began to speak among them:  
"Stranger, this first will I myself ask you:

- 105 What man are you, and from where? Where are your city and your  
 parents?"<sup>11</sup>  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
 "Lady, no mortal man on the boundless earth  
 could find a fault in you: your fame goes up to the wide sky —  
 like the fame of some blameless king, a god-fearing man<sup>12</sup>  
 110 ruling among many people and mighty,  
 upholding straight judgments; and the black earth bears  
 wheat and barley under him, and the trees hang heavy with fruit,  
 the flocks throw firm young, the sea yields fish,  
 all from his good governing; and under him the people flourish.  
 115 So — question me now on any other matter, here in your house,  
 but do not ask my race and my fathers' country,  
 or you will fill my heart still fuller with pains  
 as I remember: I am a man of many sorrows. And there is no need  
 to sit in a stranger's house grieving and lamenting —  
 120 grief without respite makes everything worse —  
 and one of the slave-women might take offense — or you yourself —  
 and say I swim in tears because the wine has weighed my wits."  
 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:  
 "Stranger, my excellence — my face, my figure —<sup>13</sup>  
 125 the deathless ones destroyed the day the Argives  
 boarded ship for Ilium, and my husband Odysseus with them.  
 If he came back — if he watched over this life of mine —  
 my fame would be greater so, and lovelier.  
 Now I only grieve: so many evils the god has driven at me.  
 130 All the great men who hold power among the islands —  
 Dulichium and Same and wooded Zacynthus —  
 and those whose homes are round clear-skied Ithaca itself:  
 they woo me against my will, and wear this house away.  
 So I pay no mind to strangers, none to suppliants,  
 135 none at all to heralds, the workers for the people;  
 no — longing for Odysseus melts the heart in me.  
 They press the marriage on; and I wind out my skein of tricks.<sup>14</sup>  
 First it was the robe: a god breathed it into my heart —  
 to set up a great loom in the halls and weave at it,  
 140 fine-threaded, beyond all measure wide; and I told them straightway:



- 'Young men, my suitors — since noble Odysseus is dead,<sup>15</sup>  
 wait, though you burn for my wedding, till I finish  
 this cloth — let my spinning not be wasted on the wind —  
 a shroud for the hero Laertes, against the day  
 145 the ruinous doom of death that lays men low will take him:  
 let no Achaean woman in the land hold it against me  
 that a man who won so much should lie without his winding-sheet.'  
 So I spoke, and their proud hearts were persuaded.  
 Then every day I wove at the great loom,  
 150 and every night I unwove it by torchlight.  
 Three years my trick escaped them, and I kept the Achaeans persuaded;  
 but when the fourth year came, as the seasons rolled on,  
 the months waning away, the long tale of days accomplished,  
 then — through my slave-women, those careless bitches —  
 155 they came on me and caught me, and shouted me down.  
 So I finished it — against my will, under force.  
 And now I can neither escape the marriage nor find  
 any other design. My parents urge me hard<sup>16</sup>  
 to marry; and my son chafes as these men eat his living —  
 160 he understands now: he is a man by now, fully able  
 to care for a house that Zeus grants glory to.  
 But even so, tell me your stock, where you are from:  
 you were not born of the oak in the old tales, nor of a stone."<sup>17</sup>  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
 165 "Honored wife of Laertes' son Odysseus,  
 will you not leave off asking me my lineage?  
 Well — I will tell you. Though truly you hand me over to sorrows  
 more than hold me now: that is the way of it, when a man  
 has been gone from his country as long as I have,  
 170 wandering through many cities of men, suffering pains.  
 Even so, I will tell you what you ask and probe for.  
 There is a land called Crete, out in the wine-dark sea,<sup>18</sup>  
 beautiful and rich, ringed by the water; and in it are people  
 past counting, and ninety cities:  
 175 tongue mixed with tongue — Achaeans there,  
 great-hearted native Cretans, Cydonians,  
 Dorians in their three clans, and noble Pelasgians;

- and among the cities is Cnossus, the great town, where Minos  
was king by nine-year terms, great Zeus's intimate —<sup>19</sup>
- 180 the father of my father, great-hearted Deucalion.  
Deucalion fathered me, and lord Idomeneus;  
but Idomeneus had gone in the beaked ships  
to Ilium with the sons of Atreus. My famous name is Aethon —<sup>20</sup>  
the younger brother by birth; he was elder, and the better man.
- 185 There I saw Odysseus, and gave him guest-gifts:<sup>21</sup>  
for the strength of the wind had brought him down on Crete  
as he made for Troy, driving him off course past Malea.  
He anchored at Amnisus, by the cave of Eileithyia,  
in that difficult harbor, and barely rode out the squalls.
- 190 He came straight up to the town, asking for Idomeneus:  
his guest-friend, he said, beloved and honored.  
But it was now the tenth dawn for Idomeneus, or the eleventh,<sup>22</sup>  
since he had gone with the beaked ships to Ilium.  
So I brought him to the house and gave him welcome,
- 195 warm and openhanded — the house had plenty in it —  
and for the rest, for the companions who followed with him,  
I gathered barley-meal from the public store, and sparkling wine,  
and oxen for sacrifice, till their hearts were satisfied.  
Twelve days the noble Achaeans stayed with me,
- 200 pinned there: the great North Wind held them, and would not let them  
stand even on shore — some hard god had raised it.  
On the thirteenth the wind dropped, and they put out to sea."  
He made the many lies he told seem like the truth.<sup>23</sup>
- And as she listened her tears ran, and her flesh melted —<sup>24</sup>
- 205 as snow melts away on the high crests of the mountains,  
snow the West Wind piled and the East Wind thaws,  
and as it melts the rivers run full with it:  
so her beautiful cheeks melted with falling tears,  
as she wept for her own husband — sitting at her side. And Odysseus
- 210 pitied his wife in his heart as she grieved,  
but his eyes stood fixed as horn or iron,<sup>25</sup>  
unwavering in their lids: with craft he hid his tears.  
And when she had taken her fill of tear-heavy mourning,  
she found words again, and answered him:

- 215 "Now, stranger, I think I shall put you to the test:<sup>26</sup>  
 whether you truly hosted my husband there in your halls  
 with his godlike companions, as you say.  
 Tell me what kind of clothes he wore on his body,  
 and what kind of man he was, and the companions who followed him."
- 220 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
 "Lady, that is hard — for one so long apart  
 to say. It is the twentieth year already  
 since he went from there and left my country behind.  
 Even so I will tell you how my heart's eye pictures him.
- 225 Noble Odysseus wore a woolen mantle of sea-purple,  
 a double fold; and the brooch on it was fashioned of gold,  
 with paired sheaths for the pins; the face of it was a marvel:  
 a hound held a dappled fawn between its forepaws,<sup>27</sup>  
 gripping it as it writhed. And everyone wondered at them —
- 230 both of gold: the one gripping the fawn and throttling it,  
 the fawn straining with its feet to escape, even as it struggled.  
 And I noticed the tunic on his body, all a-shimmer,  
 like the skin that slips from a dried onion:<sup>28</sup>  
 that soft it was, and bright as the sun itself.
- 235 Many the women, I tell you, who gazed at him in wonder.  
 And another thing I will tell you: lay it up in your heart.  
 I do not know whether Odysseus wore these things from home,  
 or some companion gave them to him boarding the fast ship,  
 or perhaps some guest-friend, since to many men Odysseus
- 240 was dear: few of the Achaeans were his equals.  
 I too gave him things: a sword of bronze, a folded mantle,  
 fine, sea-purple, and a fringed tunic,  
 and sent him off with honor on his well-benched ship.  
 Also a herald attended him, a little older
- 245 than he was; and I will tell you what he looked like too:  
 round in the shoulders, dark-skinned, curly-headed,<sup>29</sup>  
 Eurybates his name; and Odysseus prized him above  
 his other companions, for their minds ran matched.  
 So he spoke; and he stirred in her still more the longing for weeping,
- 250 as she recognized the tokens Odysseus described so surely.<sup>30</sup>  
 And when she had taken her fill of tear-heavy mourning,

then she found words again, and said to him:

"Now, stranger, pitiable as you were to me before,  
in my halls you shall be dear and honored.

255 It was I who gave him those clothes — I, the very clothes you speak of —  
31

folded from the storeroom, and I pinned on the shining brooch  
to be his jewel. And I shall never welcome him again  
come home to his own dear fatherland.

By an evil fate Odysseus went in the hollow ship  
260 to look on Evil-Ilium, never to be named."<sup>32</sup>

Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:

"Honored wife of Laertes' son Odysseus,  
mar your lovely skin no more, and melt your heart  
no more away, weeping for your husband. Not that I blame you at all:  
265 any woman mourns the husband she has lost,  
the man of her youth, whose children she bore in love —  
even a lesser man than Odysseus, whom they call the equal of the gods.

But cease from weeping, and attend to my word:  
for I will speak the exact truth and hide nothing:

270 I have already heard of Odysseus' homecoming —<sup>33</sup>  
near, in the rich land of the Thesprotian men,  
alive; and he is bringing many fine treasures home,  
begging his way through the country. But his trusted companions  
he lost, and the hollow ship, on the wine-dark sea,

275 on the way from the island of Thrinacia: for Zeus and Helios  
were set at odds with him — his companions killed the Sun's cattle.<sup>34</sup>  
They all perished in the surging sea;  
but he rode the keel of the ship, and the wave threw him ashore  
on the land of the Phaeacians, whose birth is next to the gods'.

280 They honored him from the heart like a god,  
and gave him many things, and were themselves ready to bring him  
home unharmed. And Odysseus would have been here  
long since; but this seemed to his heart the more profitable way:  
to travel wide and gather wealth — for beyond<sup>35</sup>

285 all mortal men Odysseus knows the profitable turn:  
no living man could rival him at that.

So Pheidon told me all of it, the king of the Thesprotians;

and he swore an oath to me, pouring the libation in his house,  
 that a ship was hauled down and a crew standing ready  
 290 to convey him home to his own dear fatherland.  
 But me he sent off first: for a Thesprotian ship  
 happened to be sailing for Dulichium, rich in wheat.  
 And he showed me all the treasure Odysseus had gathered:  
 truly it would feed a man's line to the tenth generation,  
 295 such a store of the lord's goods lay there in his halls.  
 Odysseus, he said, was gone to Dodona, to hear  
 the will of Zeus out of the god's own high-crowned oak:  
 how he should come home to his own dear fatherland,  
 openly or in secret, after so long away.  
 300 So he is safe; so he will come — and soon now,  
 very near: not far from his friends and his fathers' land  
 will he be for long. And still I will give you my oath on it.  
 Now Zeus be my witness first — highest and best of the gods —<sup>36</sup>  
 and the hearth of blameless Odysseus, to which I have come:  
 305 all this shall be accomplished exactly as I say.  
 Within this very turning of the light Odysseus will be here:  
 between this month's waning and the rising of the next."  
 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:  
 "Ah, stranger, if only that word might be accomplished:<sup>37</sup>  
 310 then you would quickly know my friendship, and gifts  
 in plenty from me — any man who met you would call you blessed.  
 But this is how my heart forebodes it, and how it will be:  
 Odysseus is not coming home; and you will get no passage —  
 for there are no masters in this house  
 315 such as Odysseus was among men — if he ever was —  
 to welcome honored strangers, and to send them on.  
 But wash him, my handmaids, and lay out a bed:<sup>38</sup>  
 bedstead and cloaks and shining blankets,  
 so he may come warm through to Dawn of the golden throne.  
 320 And in the early morning bathe him and rub him with oil,  
 so that here inside, at Telemachus' side, he may look to his dinner,  
 seated in the hall. And the worse for any man of them  
 who galls him — heart-destroyer: he will accomplish nothing  
 here ever again, rage at it as he bitterly may.

- 325 For how will you learn of me, stranger, whether I stand out<sup>39</sup>  
 at all among women in mind and thoughtful counsel,  
 if all unwashed and badly dressed you sit at meat  
 in my halls? Men are creatures of a short day.  
 The man who is hard himself, and knows hard thoughts,  
 330 on him all mortals call down pains to come  
 while he lives, and when he is dead they mock him, every one;  
 but the man who is blameless himself, and knows blameless thoughts —  
 his fame the guests he served carry wide  
 to all mankind, and many call him noble."
- 335 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
 "Honored wife of Laertes' son Odysseus,  
 cloaks and shining blankets turned hateful to me  
 the day I first put the snowy mountains of Crete  
 behind me, going aboard the long-oared ship.  
 340 I will lie this night as I have lain through sleepless nights before:  
 many the nights I have spent on some rough bed,  
 waiting it out for shining fair-throned Dawn.  
 Nor do foot-washings bring my heart any pleasure:  
 no woman shall touch this foot of mine<sup>40</sup>  
 345 of all those who serve about your house —  
 unless there is some old woman, old and faithful-hearted,  
 who has endured in her spirit as much as I have endured:  
 such a one I would not grudge the touching of my feet."  
 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:
- 350 "Dear stranger — no man so discerning, of all the guests  
 from far lands, ever came more welcome to my house:  
 so shaped and thought-through is everything you say.  
 I have an old woman whose breast is packed with counsel,  
 who nursed and reared that unlucky man, my husband —  
 355 took him into her arms the hour his mother bore him:  
 she will wash your feet, feeble with age though she is.  
 Up now, watchful-minded Eurycleia:<sup>41</sup>  
 wash him — a man the same age as your master. And perhaps Odysseus  
 by now is like him in his feet, like him in his hands:  
 360 for in misfortune mortal men age fast."<sup>42</sup>  
 So she spoke; and the old woman hid her face in her hands

- and shed hot tears, and gave voice to words of mourning:  
 "Ah me, child, and I helpless for you! Truly Zeus<sup>43</sup>  
 hated you beyond all men — and yours was a god-fearing heart.  
 365 For no mortal ever burned to Zeus who delights in thunder  
 so many fat thigh-pieces, such choice hecatombs,  
 as you gave him, praying you might come  
 to a sleek old age and raise your shining son.  
 And now from you alone he has cut off the day of homecoming.  
 370 So too, I suppose, the women mocked him —  
 women of strangers in far lands, when he came to some man's famous  
 house —  
 just as these bitches here mock you, all of them together:  
 it is to dodge their insults, their crowd of taunts,  
 that you will not let the women wash you. And I — not at all unwilling  
 —  
 375 am ordered to it by Icarius' daughter, watchful-minded Penelope.  
 So I will wash your feet — for Penelope's own sake  
 and for yours as well; for the heart within me is stirred  
 with sorrows. But come — take in the word I say:  
 many a travel-worn stranger has come to this house,  
 380 but never, I tell you, have I seen such a likeness  
 as you have — in body, in voice, in feet — to Odysseus."<sup>44</sup>  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
 "Old mother, so they all say who have seen the two of us  
 with their own eyes: that we are very like each other —  
 385 just as you yourself observe, and say."<sup>45</sup>  
 So he spoke; and the old woman took the shining basin  
 she used for washing feet, and poured in water,  
 cold in plenty, then added hot to it. And Odysseus  
 sat down at the hearth — and swung round quickly toward the dark,<sup>46</sup>  
 390 for a fear came over his heart that as she took hold  
 she might mark the scar, and the whole work come open.  
 She came close and began to wash her master. And at once she knew<sup>47</sup>  
 the scar — the wound the boar dealt him with its white tusk  
 when he went to Parnassus, to Autolycus and his sons,  
 395 his mother's noble father, who outdid all men  
 in thievery and the oath: the god himself had given it him —<sup>48</sup>

Hermes: to him he burned welcome thigh-pieces  
of lambs and of kids, and the god companioned him with a will.  
Once Autolycus, coming to the rich land of Ithaca,  
400 found his daughter's son a baby newly born;  
and Eurycleia laid the child on his knees<sup>49</sup>  
as he finished supper, and spoke a word, and named him:  
"Autolycus — find the name yourself, to give  
your own child's child. He is a child of many prayers."  
405 Then Autolycus answered her and said:  
  
"Son-in-law and daughter, give him the name I say.  
Since I have come to this place at odds with many —<sup>50</sup>  
with men and with women across the nourishing earth —  
let Odysseus, Man at Odds, be the name he carries.  
410 And for my part: when he is grown, and comes to Parnassus,  
to his mother's great house, where my possessions are,  
I will give him a share and send him home rejoicing."  
For those gifts Odysseus went: to receive his shining presents.  
And Autolycus and the sons of Autolycus  
415 clasped his hands in welcome, and greeted him with honeyed words;  
and Amphithea, his mother's mother, folding Odysseus in her arms,  
kissed his head, and both his beautiful eyes.<sup>51</sup>  
Then Autolycus called to his glorious sons  
to make the meal ready; and they heard his urging:  
420 at once they led in a bull of five years,  
flayed it and dressed it, and split the whole in pieces,  
and jointed the meat with skill, and fixed it on the spits,  
and roasted it with care, and shared out all the portions.  
So then, the whole day long until the setting of the sun,  
425 they feasted; and no man's appetite went short of the equal feast.  
And when the sun went down and the dusk came on,  
they lay down then, and took the gift of sleep.  
When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,  
they went their way to the hunt — the hounds and with them  
430 the sons of Autolycus themselves; and noble Odysseus  
went along with them. They climbed the steep mountain, mantled  
in forest — Parnassus — and soon they reached its windy folds.  
The sun was just striking the plowlands, rising<sup>52</sup>



- out of the deep smooth stream of Ocean,  
 435 when the beaters came to a glen; ahead of them  
 ran the hounds, casting for the scent, and behind them  
 came the sons of Autolycus; and noble Odysseus  
 moved close behind the hounds, swinging his long-shadowed spear.  
 There, in a dense thicket, lay couched a great boar.<sup>53</sup>
- 440 No force of wet-blowing winds could pierce that covert,  
 no shaft of the shining sun could strike into it,  
 no rain drive through it, so dense it was,  
 and the fallen leaves lay heaped in it past counting.  
 Around the boar came the din of feet — men's and hounds' —  
 445 as they pressed in on him; and out of his lair, head-on,  
 bristles ridged on his neck, fire standing in his eyes,  
 he stood at bay, close in. And first of all Odysseus  
 rushed him, the long spear high in his heavy hand,  
 hungry to strike; but the boar was quicker — gashed him  
 450 above the knee, charging in slantwise, and ripped away  
 a long gouge of flesh with his tusk: but it did not reach the bone.  
 And Odysseus struck home on the right shoulder,  
 and the point of the shining spear went through and through:  
 down in the dust he went, bleating, and the life flew out of him.<sup>54</sup>
- 455 Then the dear sons of Autolycus busied themselves with the carcass,  
 and the wound of blameless, godlike Odysseus  
 they bound with skill, and with a chanted spell they stanch<sup>55</sup>  
 the black blood; and quickly they came to their father's house.  
 And Autolycus and the sons of Autolycus  
 460 healed him well, and gave him shining gifts,  
 and quickly sent him back rejoicing to his own dear country,  
 to Ithaca. And his father and his honored mother  
 rejoiced at his homecoming, and questioned him on everything —  
 the scar, and what had happened; and he told them all of it well:  
 465 how the boar's white tusk had gashed him at the hunt  
 on his climb up Parnassus with the sons of Autolycus.  
 That scar — as the old woman took his leg in the flat of her hands<sup>56</sup>  
 she knew it under her fingers. She let the foot drop:  
 the shin fell in the basin; the bronze rang out;  
 470 the basin tipped over sideways, and the water ran on the ground.

- And joy and anguish seized her mind at once: her eyes  
filled up with tears; her welling voice stuck fast.  
She touched Odysseus on the chin, and said:  
"You are Odysseus — dear child! And I did not know you,"<sup>57</sup>  
475 not before I had handled all of him — my master."  
She spoke, and her eyes went toward Penelope,  
ready to tell her that her own husband was in the house.  
But Penelope could not meet the look or take its meaning,  
for Athena had turned her mind away. And Odysseus,<sup>58</sup>  
480 feeling for her throat, caught it with his right hand,  
and with the other pulled her closer to him, and said:  
"Nurse — why would you destroy me? You yourself nursed me"<sup>59</sup>  
at this breast of yours. Now, after suffering many pains,  
I have come in the twentieth year to my fathers' land.  
485 But since you have found it out, and a god has put it in your heart,  
be silent — let no one else in the halls learn of it.  
For I will say this outright, and it will be accomplished:  
if a god brings the haughty suitors down beneath my hands,  
I will not spare even you, my nurse though you are, that day  
490 I kill the other slave-women in my halls."  
Then watchful-minded Eurycleia answered him:  
"My child, what a word has slipped the fence of your teeth!"<sup>60</sup>  
You know my strength — how it stands and will not bend:  
I will hold like solid stone, like iron.  
495 And another thing I will tell you: lay it up in your heart.  
If a god brings the haughty suitors down beneath your hands,  
then I will name you the women of the halls, every one:  
which of them dishonor you, and which are guiltless."  
Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
500 "Nurse, why would you name them? There is no need."<sup>61</sup>  
I will observe them well myself, and learn each one.  
No — keep the story silent. Leave it to the gods."  
So he spoke; and the old woman went off through the hall  
to fetch fresh water for his feet: the first was all spilled.  
505 And when she had washed him and rubbed him richly with oil,  
Odysseus drew his bench again nearer the fire  
to warm himself, and covered the scar with his rags.<sup>62</sup>

- And watchful-minded Penelope began to speak among them:  
 "Stranger, one small thing more I will ask you myself —
- 510 for soon enough now comes the hour of sweet rest,  
 for whomever sweet sleep will take, however careworn.  
 But to me the god has dealt grief past measuring:  
 by day my one delight is weeping and lamenting,<sup>63</sup>  
 while I look to my work and the work of my women in the house;
- 515 but when night comes, and rest takes all the others,  
 I lie in my bed, and crowding round my beating heart  
 the sharp anxieties torment me as I mourn.  
 As when the daughter of Pandareus, the pale-green nightingale,<sup>64</sup>  
 sings beautifully at the first new standing of spring,
- 520 perched in the thick leafage of the trees,  
 and pouring, turning, threads her many-noted voice,  
 mourning her child, her beloved Itylus, whom once with the bronze  
 she killed in her blindness of mind — the son of lord Zethus:  
 so my heart too is torn two ways, this way and that.<sup>65</sup>
- 525 do I stay by my son and keep everything unmoved —  
 my goods, my slave-women, the great high-roofed house —  
 respecting my husband's bed and the voice of the people;  
 or do I follow now whichever of the Achaeans is best  
 among my suitors in the halls, and offers bride-gifts past counting?
- 530 My son — while he was still a child, and soft in mind,  
 he would not have me marry and leave my husband's house;  
 but now that he is grown, come to the measure of manhood,  
 he prays me to go back home, out of these halls —  
 chafing over the estate the Achaeans eat away.
- 535 But come — hear this dream of mine, and read it for me.<sup>66</sup>  
 I keep twenty geese about the house; they eat wheat  
 softened in water, and it warms me to watch them.<sup>67</sup>  
 And out of the mountain came a great hook-beaked eagle  
 and broke all their necks, and killed them; and they lay strewn
- 540 in a heap through the halls, while he was borne up to the bright sky.  
 And I wept — I wailed aloud, though it was a dream,  
 and around me gathered the fair-braided Achaean women,  
 as I grieved most pitifully because the eagle had killed my geese.  
 But back he came, and perched on the jut of the roof-beam,

- 545 and with a man's voice he checked my grieving:  
 'Take heart, daughter of far-famed Icarius:  
 this is no dream but a waking sight — a good one, and it shall be  
 accomplished.<sup>68</sup>  
 The geese are the suitors; and I — I was the eagle-bird  
 before; but now I have come back, and I am your husband,  
 550 and I will let loose an ugly doom on all the suitors.'<sup>69</sup>  
 So he spoke; and the honey-sweet sleep let me go;  
 and casting about, I saw the geese there in the halls  
 pecking their wheat beside the trough, just where they always were."  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
 555 "Lady, there is no way to wrench this dream aside  
 to read it another way: Odysseus himself, no other,  
 has shown you how he will end it: destruction shows plain for the  
 suitors —  
 for every man of them; not one shall slip out of death and the fates."<sup>70</sup>  
 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:  
 560 "Stranger, dreams are hopeless things, and their talk past sorting;  
 not everything in them is accomplished for mortals.  
 For two are the gates of strengthless dreams:<sup>71</sup>  
 one pair is fashioned of horn, and one of ivory.  
 Those dreams that come through the gate of sawn ivory  
 565 cheat and beguile: they carry words that come to nothing.  
 But those that come out through the gate of polished horn  
 accomplish true things, whenever a mortal sees them.  
 But my strange dream, I fear, did not come from there —  
 ah, welcome as that would be to me and to my child.  
 570 And another thing I will tell you: lay it up in your heart.  
 Here now comes the dawn of the evil name, that will cut me<sup>72</sup>  
 away from the house of Odysseus. For now I will set the contest:  
 the axes he used to stand up in a row in his halls,  
 like the props of a ship on the stocks — twelve in all;<sup>73</sup>  
 575 and standing far back he would shoot an arrow through them.  
 Now I will set this contest before the suitors:  
 whoever strings the bow most easily in his hands,  
 and shoots an arrow through all twelve axes —  
 him I will follow, forsaking this house,

- 580 this house of my marriage, this beautiful house, full of all  
that sustains life. I think I shall remember it even in my dreams."<sup>74</sup>  
Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
"Honored wife of Laertes' son Odysseus,  
do not put off this contest in your house one hour.
- 585 For Odysseus of the many designs will be here first —<sup>75</sup>  
before these men, handling and handling the polished bow,  
can string the cord and shoot through the iron."  
Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:  
"Stranger, if you were only willing to sit by me in the halls<sup>76</sup>
- 590 and give me pleasure, sleep would never settle on my eyes.  
But there is no way men can go sleepless forever:  
the deathless ones have set a portion for each thing  
mortals do on the grain-giving earth.  
So I will go up now to my upper room
- 595 to lie on the bed that has become a bed of groaning for me,<sup>77</sup>  
forever stained with my tears, since the day Odysseus  
went to look on Evil-Ilium, never to be named.  
There I will lie; and you lie down in this house —  
spread something on the floor, or let them set you a bed."
- 600 So speaking she climbed to her shining upper room,  
not alone: her handmaids went up with her.  
Climbing to her upper room with her serving-women,  
she wept there for Odysseus, her dear husband, until  
gray-eyed Athena cast sweet sleep upon her eyelids.<sup>78</sup>

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 19

- 1    *l. 1* Lines 1–2 return verbatim at 51–52, bracketing the arms-removal like a refrain: the man alone in the hall, "plotting the suitors' slaughter with Athena's help." The book of the poem's most intimate conversation opens and re-opens on the murder being arranged around it.
- 2    *l. 7* The smoke-speech, delivered as scripted at 16.286–294 — cover story, soot damage, and the proverb, word for word as his father dictated (with one variant: "a god has cast into my heart" for "the son of Cronos"). Telemachus will perform it flawlessly. The plan is now running on rehearsed lines; the poem lets us hear the rehearsal and the performance two books apart.
- 3    *l. 24* Eurycleia's question is pure household logistics — who carries the light if the women are locked in? — and it earns the poem's answer: Athena herself will (33–34). The gap between the nurse's lamp-problem and its divine solution measures the whole night: ordinary housekeeping, extraordinary guests.
- 4    *l. 33* Athena with the golden lamp — the only *λύχνος* in Homer. The goddess as lamp-bearer for two men carrying weapons: the humblest divine service in the poem, and the most intimate — the household's true light restored for one night's secret work.
- 5    *l. 36* Telemachus senses the theophany — not seeing her (16.161's rule holds), but seeing the glow on rafters and pillars. His father's response is liturgical discipline: "Quiet... This is the way of the gods." The son is being trained in the etiquette of divine partnership: notice, do not name, keep working.
- 6    *l. 45* "To stir the slave-women a little more, and your mother" — *ἐρεθίζω*, the verb of provoking. He announces the interview as a probe: even the meeting with his wife is framed, to his son, as a test to run. What the night actually becomes exceeds the operational language that scheduled it.
- 7    *l. 56* The chair of Icmalius — ivory and silver, the maker named, the footrest built in one piece. Furniture with a pedigree, like the basin and the bed to come: the poem is beginning its inventory of the objects that know the family. She sits where "she always sat"; the stranger watches his wife take her place in the furniture of a house he knows to its joints.
- 8    *l. 65* Melanthe's second attack (the first at 18.327ff) — now with the torch-brand threat. Her taunt "spying on the women" is exactly right: he is auditing the women; she is failing the audit in real time, twice, with the mistress listening.
- 9    *l. 87* The warning to Melanthe maps every exit: the mistress may turn on you, Odysseus may come ("a portion of hope is left" — *ἐλπίδος αἴσα*, the phrase Murray's text lost from 16.101 restored to the living text here), and if not, Telemachus is of age and misses nothing. Three jurisdictions, all closing; she hears rhetoric and is dead within days under the middle one.

- 10 *l. 91* Penelope's rebuke — "dog past all shame... you will wipe it off on your own head" — is queenly rage with an exact idiom of blood-guilt: the deed will be wiped clean on the doer. The mistress has just cursed her fosterling (18.322–323) in terms the gallows will honor.
- 11 *l. 104* She asks the poem's identity-formula herself — "What man are you, and from where?" — the question Telemachus put to Athena (1.170), Eumaeus to the beggar (14.187), Theoclymenus to Telemachus (15.264). The formula's greatest asking: wife to disguised husband, by the fire.
- 12 *l. 109* He answers "who are you?" with "what you are": the just-king simile — straight judgments, black earth bearing wheat and barley, trees heavy, flocks throwing firm young, the sea yielding fish, the people flourishing. It is the poem's fullest political theology (kingship as fertility), and he lays it on her: Penelope's fame is the fame of the good king. The compliment is also a report card — and a husband's thanks smuggled through a beggar's flattery.
- 13 *l. 124* Her reply opens with the bloom-destroyed lines she gave Eurymachus (18.251–253) — her standing preface — then modulates the suitor-catalogue of 1.245–248 into first person: "they woo me against my will, and wear this house away." The poem's fixed materials, re-keyed to the widow's own voice.
- 14 *l. 137* "They press the marriage on; and I wind out my skein of tricks" — *τολυπεύω*, a wool-working verb: to wind off into balls. Her metaphor for plotting is her craft; *μήτις* in this house spins. The line is her self-portrait as her husband's equal — he tells lies like truth, she winds stratagems like yarn.
- 15 *l. 141* The web story, told by the weaver herself (139–156 c. 2.94–110, where Antinous told it as an indictment). The two tellings are nearly verbatim — same quoted speech to the suitors, same three years, same betrayal — and opposite in genre: his was a complaint about female cunning; hers is a veteran's account of a defensive war, ending not in triumph but "against my will, under force." A suitor's ghost will tell it a third time in Hades (24.128–146); each teller's version is a verdict on the teller.
- 16 *l. 158* "My parents urge me hard to marry" — confirming Athena's claim at 15.16ff, which had seemed like the goddess's motivational invention. The pressure is real from every side now: parents, son, deadline. The poem quietly closes the gap between what Athena said and what is true.
- 17 *l. 163* "Not born of the oak in the old tales, nor of a stone" — the proverb for having ordinary human origins (already old when Hesiod used it). Her curiosity is warm and worldly: everyone comes from somewhere; produce your parents.
- 18 *l. 172* Crete again — the fifth Cretan tale (13.256ff, 14.199ff, 16.62 relayed, 17.523 relayed, now the full aria): ninety cities, five peoples, "tongue mixed with tongue" — the densest ethnography in Homer, true in every checkable detail. He builds the lie's floor out of the real world; the fiction stands only on the top course.
- 19 *l. 179* Minos "king by nine-year terms, great Zeus's intimate" (*ἐννέωρος... ἀριστήρ*): the nine-year kingship renewed in conference with Zeus — a glimpse of Bronze Age sacral

kingship. The liar gives himself the best pedigree in the Aegean: grandson of Zeus's confidant, brother of Idomeneus.

- 20 l. 183 "My famous name is Aethon" — "Blaze," "Burnt-brown." His third alias (unnamed to Eumaeus, "Epēritos" waits for Laertes at 24.306); this one, ominously, is a fire-name worn beside his own hearth.
- 21 l. 185 The masterstroke of the lie: he hosted Odysseus. He invents a twelve-day guest-friendship with himself, itemized — the harbor at Amnisus, the public barley, the oxen. He gives his wife the gift of her husband seen, fed, honored — a kindness folded inside an imposture, and reconnaissance: her grief at the story is the proof he came for.
- 22 l. 192 "The tenth dawn, or the eleventh" — the liar's calibrated vagueness: an honest witness is precise about scenery and hazy about numbers. The poem has already told us the technique's name (13.295, Athena admiring); here we watch the brushwork.
- 23 l. 203 "He made the many lies he told seem like the truth" (ἴσκει ψεύδεα πολλὰ λέγων ἐτύμοισιν ὁμοῖα) — the most self-referential line in Homer: it is what Hesiod's Muses say of themselves ("we know how to speak many lies like the truth"). Spoken over Odysseus mid-performance, it is the poet certifying his hero as a poet — and confessing what epic itself is made of.
- 24 l. 204 The snow simile: her face melts as the West Wind's snow melts under the East Wind's thaw, "and as it melts the rivers run full." Twenty years of winter breaking up in one listening. The simile's tenderness is geographic — high mountains, spring flood — as if her weeping watered the kingdom the just-king simile just described.
- 25 l. 211 "His eyes stood fixed as horn or iron" — while she melts, he petrifies; one marriage, two states of matter. Horn returns at 562 as the gate of true dreams — the eyes that will not weep are made of the same stuff as the gate truth comes through. "He wept for his wife in his heart" is literal: the tears happen; only their exit is closed, "with craft."
- 26 l. 215 "I think I shall put you to the test" — πειρήσασθαι: she uses the family verb. Odysseus tests everyone (his word at 16.305, 313); now his wife runs the procedure on him — demand verifiable detail, check against private knowledge. The clothes-test is flawless method: only she knows what she packed.
- 27 l. 228 The brooch: a golden hound throttling a dappled fawn that "strained with its feet to escape, even as it struggled." The ekphrasis is Odysseus in miniature — predator craft caught mid-kill, beauty made of applied violence — and, this night of all nights, a forecast: the hound is in the hall, the fawns are asleep in their own houses (cf. the lion's-lair simile, 4.335ff = 17.126ff).
- 28 l. 233 The tunic like "the skin that slips from a dried onion" — soft, glistening, close: the homeliest simile in Homer applied to a king's shirt, and instantly convincing for that reason. Only someone who had handled the garment would reach for the kitchen to describe it; she supplied the garment, and the description tells her so.
- 29 l. 246 Eurybates the herald: "round in the shoulders, dark-skinned, curly-headed" — the most particular physical description of any Greek in the poem, honoring a real companion (he appears in Iliad 2.184). Prized "for their minds ran matched": the detail no imposter would invent is the affection.



- 30 l. 250 "She recognized the tokens" — σήματα: the recognition-word, rehearsing for Book 23 where the σήματα will be the bed. The poem is running the machinery of recognition at half-power: tokens verified, husband confirmed dead by the evidence of his living presence.
- 31 l. 255 "It was I who gave him those clothes — I" — the test returns its result and it is worse than failure: the beggar's description proves he saw Odysseus in the very clothes she folded, pinned, and chose. The proof of contact becomes proof of loss ("I shall never welcome him again"). Grief by verification: the scene's cruelest turn, engineered by the husband who is its object.
- 32 l. 260 "Evil-Ilium, never to be named" (Κακοίλιον οὐκ ὀνομαστήν) — her coinage: Troy renamed as a curse, with the superstitious rider that saying the name feeds its power. She repeats it at 597. In her private theology the war has no name, only an epithet of hatred.
- 33 l. 270 The Thesprotian tale, third performance (14.316ff to Eumaeus; relayed to her at 17.526–527; now direct): Pheidon, the treasure, the oath, Dodona — stable in every strut, with the Phaeacian truth freshly built in. To his wife he adds what Eumaeus didn't get: Thrinacia, Zeus and Helios, the keel that carried him off the wreck — his real story, distributed to a fiction one island off.
- 34 l. 275 "Zeus and Helios were set at odds with him" — ὀδύσαντο: the name-verb (see 1.62, 5.340), planted inside the lie. Even his fictions pun on him; the "man at odds" narrates his own wreck under an alias and cannot keep his name's grammar out of it. The naming-scene forty lines ahead (407–409) will unpack the same verb in earnest.
- 35 l. 284 "Beyond all mortal men Odysseus knows the profitable turn" (κέρδεα) — the beggar praising Odysseus for the very trait currently deceiving the listener. The self-endorsement doubles as an excuse for delay (he stayed away to gather wealth) — planted so the real homecoming's poverty of explanation will have cover.
- 36 l. 303 The oath repeats his oath to Eumaeus (14.158–162) almost word for word — Zeus, the hearth of blameless Odysseus, and the dating-formula: "Within this very turning of the light... between this month's waning and the rising of the next." He swears by his own hearth, standing at it, and sets the deadline that the festival of Apollo (20.156, 276) will keep: tomorrow is the dark of the moon.
- 37 l. 309 The blessing-formula a third time (15.536–538, 17.163–165) — Telemachus, then Penelope to Theoclymenus, now Penelope to the beggar: the same courteous three lines each time, meeting prophecy — dynastic in Book 15, of return since — with structured disbelief. The family meets hope with a fixed liturgy: bless the speaker, refuse the content. Then her flat overrule: "Odysseus is not coming home; and you will get no passage" — hope's administrator denying both claims in one breath.
- 38 l. 317 From despair she pivots to hospitality's checklist — bath, bed, blankets, morning oil — and the reason (325–334) is the just-king simile handed back: guests carry fame; the blameless man's name travels. She answers his political theology with hers: her kingdom is conduct, its export is reputation, "men are creatures of a short day" and are remembered by what they served.

- 39 l. 325 "How will you learn of me... whether I stand out at all among women in mind and thoughtful counsel" — she wants the stranger to certify her μήτις, not her face. It is the exact wish her husband can grant and no one else fully could; the poem lets them audition for each other all night under assumed identities.
- 40 l. 344 The foot-washing condition: no young woman shall touch him — only an old one "who has endured in her spirit as much as I have endured." The sentence is a targeting instruction: it describes exactly one person in the house. He engineers his own recognition-risk — pride, tenderness, or the plan needing Eurycleia inside it; the poem lets all three stand.
- 41 l. 357 "Up now, watchful-minded Eurycleia" — Penelope lends the nurse her own epithet (περίφρων), a dignity the poem otherwise grants only the queen and the housekeeper Eurynome. Two watchful minds are about to share a room with the man neither can quite see.
- 42 l. 360 "Perhaps Odysseus by now is like him in his feet, like him in his hands... in misfortune mortal men age fast." She keeps walking to the edge of the truth and providing herself the railing: the resemblance is real, therefore explained. Her rationality is the disguise's best ally — Athena needs to intervene (479) only once all night; Penelope's good sense does the rest.
- 43 l. 363 Eurycleia's lament is addressed to the absent Odysseus — "Ah me, child, and I helpless for you" — over the head of the present one. She catalogues his piety, Zeus's ingratitude, and then turns the mockery of serving-women into a mirror: as these bitches taunt you, so some far country's maids must have taunted him. Every clause lands on its hidden target; the poem gives her forty lines of dramatic irony as devotion.
- 44 l. 380 "In body, in voice, in feet — to Odysseus": the strongest pre-recognition statement in the poem, from the woman who has known that body since its first hour. Voice — which Athena's wand never altered — is the tell no disguise covers. She sees it, says it, and hands it to him as a curiosity.
- 45 l. 383 His parry is perfect poise: "so they all say... we are very like each other." Confirm the observation, drain its danger — the resemblance becomes a known fact about two men, attested by witnesses he invents on the spot. The truth, filed under coincidence, with forged supporting papers.
- 46 l. 389 He swings toward the dark on instinct — one beat too late, and the poem knows it: the fear "that as she took hold she might mark the scar" arrives with the water already poured. For once the master of foresight has missed a variable: he asked for the one washer who bathed the leg ten thousand times.
- 47 l. 392 "At once she knew the scar" — and the poem, at the exact instant of contact, opens a seventy-five-line window onto Parnassus. The scar digression is the most famous narrative suspension in literature (Auerbach built *Mimesis* on it): between her fingers touching the scar and the shin hitting the basin, the poem inserts the scar's whole biography — grandfather, naming, hunt, wound, healing, homecoming. Recognition, the poem insists, is not a point but a depth: what Eurycleia touches is a story, so the story must be told.

- 48 l. 396 Autolycus, "who outdid all men in thievery and the oath" — sanctioned by Hermes himself. The grandfather's arts are the oblique oath and the profitable theft: Odysseus' μήτις has a maternal pedigree, god-given, two generations deep. The poem does not blush: the best man of his age descends from the best thief of his.
- 49 l. 401 Eurycleia laid the newborn on Autolycus' knees and asked for the name — the very woman now holding the leg the name grew into. The digression's frame is exact: the woman who asked for the name is his recognizer; Autolycus chose it, and she has been present at both ends of it.
- 50 l. 407 The naming: "Since I have come to this place at odds with many... let Odysseus, Man at Odds, be the name he carries." Autolycus names the child from his own condition (ὀδυσοάμενος — having incurred wrath, being at odds), the pun this translation has shadowed since 1.62 ("at odds with Odysseus") and 19.275 (ὀδύσαντο). The name is a grandfather's grudge made hereditary — a life sentence of friction with gods and men, handed down at supper. "Child of many prayers" (πολυάρητος, 404) was the alternative reading; the poem chose both: prayed-for and at odds — the whole man in two etymologies.
- 51 l. 416 Amphinthea's greeting — "kissed his head, and both his beautiful eyes" — is the family's fixed embrace: Eumaeus greeted Telemachus with it (16.15), Penelope her son (17.39). Three generations, one gesture; the digression roots the family's own formulas in the grandmother's arms.
- 52 l. 433 Dawn strikes the plowlands "out of the deep smooth stream of Ocean" as the hunt climbs Parnassus: the boyhood memory keeps epic time, with sunrise from Ocean and the mountain's windy folds. The digression is built like a miniature epic day — feast, sleep, dawn, aristeia, wound, healing, homecoming — Odysseus' whole life-pattern rehearsed in boyhood.
- 53 l. 439 The boar's lair — windproof, sunproof, rainproof, deep in dead leaves: the same three-fold impenetrability as the thicket where Odysseus slept on Scheria (5.478ff). The poem beds its hero and the beast in the same shelter, a generation apart: the boar is his older double, dug into the island of his blood.
- 54 l. 454 "Down in the dust he went, bleating, and the life flew out of him" — the boar dies in Irus' line (18.98: "he went down bleating in the dust"). Man and beast take the same formula at the two ends of the hero's fighting life: the boyhood hunt, the latest knockdown. The scar was bought with the same sentence it now interrupts.
- 55 l. 457 The incantation (ἐπασιδῆ) that stanches the black blood — the only spell in Homer. The sons of the thief-lord practice song-medicine: words that close wounds, in the family whose gift is words that open them. The poem's oldest magic is a bandage.
- 56 l. 467 The return from Parnassus is one syllable of contact: "she knew it under her fingers." Then the poem's most famous sound-effect — shin, basin, bronze, water: recognition as a kitchen accident, the clang the whole digression has been holding back. Homer routes the identity of his hero through an old woman's hands and a dropped foot-bath.

- 57 l. 474 "You are Odysseus — dear child! And I did not know you, not before I had handled all of him — my master." Touch as knowledge — she says it herself: not sight, not voice, handling. The nurse's epistemology is a lifetime of bathing, and her sentence stumbles between second and third person (you — him — my master) as the two men, patient and lord, snap into one.
- 58 l. 478 Athena turns Penelope's mind aside — the poem's most debated intervention. Eurycleia's eyes go to the queen; the queen cannot receive the look. Whether this protects the plan, or Penelope, or dramatizes what she cannot yet afford to know, the mechanics are stark: the recognition is contained by divine censorship, three feet from the wife it concerns.
- 59 l. 482 The throat-grip: the hand she nursed "at this breast of yours" closes on her windpipe while the other pulls her close — menace and embrace in one motion, the book's body-language for the whole disguise. And the threat is not idle: "I will not spare even you... that day I kill the other slave-women." He shows his nurse the executioner first and the child second; she takes both without flinching.
- 60 l. 492 Her answer opens with the household's own formula for shocking speech — "what a word has slipped the fence of your teeth!" (1.64's line, the family idiom) — then gives the vow: "I will hold like solid stone, like iron." The materials are his (his eyes at 211 were horn and iron); the nurse certifies herself in the metallurgy of her master's discipline.
- 61 l. 500 She offers the audit of the women (as she will deliver it at 22.417ff); he declines — "I will observe them well myself" — holding to the method Telemachus amended at 16.313ff: test in place, trust your own eyes, defer lists. Between the nurse's intelligence and his surveillance, the house's women are now bracketed by two watchers.
- 62 l. 507 "Covered the scar with his rags": the wound that just detonated the scene is tucked away under costume, and the interview resumes as if the clang had not happened. The rags — the poem's cheapest prop — are asked to hold down the poem's heaviest fact.
- 63 l. 513 "By day my one delight is weeping" — *τέρπεται*, the pleasure-verb, given to grief: mourning as her craft and recreation at once (cf. 15.399ff, "we two will take our pleasure in each other's grim sorrows"). Then the nights: the lying awake, "sharp anxieties crowding round my beating heart" — the poem's clinical picture of chronic grief, drawn by the patient.
- 64 l. 518 The nightingale: Pandareus' daughter, who killed her own son Itylus "in her blindness of mind" and sings for him always, "pouring, turning, threading her many-noted voice." Grief that became song, made of a mother's fatal error. Penelope reaches for the myth where a wrong choice kills a child — her exact terror: choose wrongly (stay, go, marry, wait) and destroy her son. The simile is a confession wearing plumage.
- 65 l. 524 The divided heart, in nearly her son's words (16.73–77: bed of her husband, voice of the people, best of the Achaeans) — mother and son carry the same fixed description of her dilemma. But hers adds what his omitted: the son himself now "prays me to go back home, chafing over the estate." The last brace holding her in the house has asked her to leave it.

- 66 l. 535 "Hear this dream of mine, and read it for me": she commissions an interpretation from the beggar — the dream already contains its own interpreter, who is also its subject, who is also the man she asks. The poem builds a hall of mirrors and sits the married couple down inside it.
- 67 l. 536 The twenty geese: "it warms me to watch them" (ἰαίνομαι) — and when the eagle kills them she weeps and wails *in the dream*, and checks on them, relieved, on waking. The famous crux: the suitors' deaths, forecast, are mourned. Perhaps the geese are not the suitors to her but the filled house itself — the waiting-life's furniture, wretched but hers, that revenge will sweep away with everything else. The dream knows what the plot does not admit: that even a rescue is a bereavement to the life it interrupts.
- 68 l. 547 "No dream but a waking sight" (οὐκ ὄναρ, ἀλλ' ὕπαρ ἐσθλόν): the eagle files its own vision under reality. The dream deposes that it is not a dream — the strongest available warrant, delivered inside the very form it disclaims. Her skepticism at 560ff answers this claim, not just the content.
- 69 l. 550 The eagle's exegesis borrows Menelaus' words (4.340 = 17.131): "I will let loose an ugly doom on all the suitors" — the deer-in-lion prophecy's exact clause, now spoken by the husband-bird in her sleep. The poem's prophecies have begun quoting each other; every channel — seer, omen, beggar, dream — now carries the same sentence.
- 70 l. 557 His reading ends in her own words: "not one shall slip out of death and the fates" = 17.547–548, her response to the sneeze-omen. Husband and wife now complete each other's death-sentences verbatim without knowing they share a text. The marriage of true minds, conducted entirely in formulas.
- 71 l. 562 The gates of horn and ivory — six lines that founded the West's dream-lore (Virgil took the gates for the Aeneid's most troubling exit). The Greek runs on two puns this translation can only shadow: dreams through ivory (ἐλέφας) *deceive* (ἐλεφαίρονται); dreams through horn (κέρας) *accomplish* (κράινουσι). Ivory-cheat, horn-fulfill: language itself sorting dreams by sound. Note what she is doing: armoring herself against the night's second true prophecy — and note his eyes at 211, "fixed as horn": the true gate has been looking at her all evening.
- 72 l. 571 "The dawn of the evil name" (δυσώνυμος) — the morning itself gets an epithet of hatred, like Evil-Ilium: her lexicon curses what it cannot prevent. Then, from the floor of her despair, she produces the poem's deus ex machina: the contest of the bow — announced to a beggar, deep in the night, on the eve of the dark of the moon.
- 73 l. 573 The axes "like the props of a ship on the stocks" (δρυόχους ὥς) — twelve in a row, the arrow threaded through: Odysseus' old trick-shot, his private gymnastics remembered by his wife in shipwright's language. Whatever the rig actually was (socket-rings? helve-eyes? — antiquity already argued), the poem's point is proprietary: only its inventor can repeat it, and she has just made it the bride-price.
- 74 l. 581 "This house of my marriage, this beautiful house, full of all that sustains life. I think I shall remember it even in my dreams." The saddest sentence she speaks — surrender phrased as a forwarding address for her dreams. Whether the contest is despair, intuition, or collusion below the level of knowledge (the debate is eternal), her

timing is the plot's salvation: she arms her husband on exactly the right night, for reasons she does not let herself examine.

- 75 *l. 585* "Odysseus of the many designs will be here first" — he backs the contest under his own full formulaic name, the disguise thinned to one layer of grammar: third person. Every word true; the sentence's speaker its only fiction. πολύμητις Ὀδυσσεύς endorsing the plan of πολύμητις Ὀδυσσεύς.
- 76 *l. 589* "If you were only willing... sleep would never settle on my eyes": the interview's almost-avowal. She has spent the night being charmed like the man in Eumaeus' singer-simile (17.518ff), and says so — then invokes mortal limits (the gods "have set a portion for each thing") and rises. The scene ends at the exact edge of what the plot can survive: one more hour and no wand could have held the marriage apart.
- 77 *l. 595* The bed of groaning, "forever stained with my tears" = her words to Telemachus (17.102–104), now with Evil-Ilium in the third line: her fixed nocturne. She describes the marriage bed to her husband as an instrument of grief — the same bed whose secret will remake it as proof of joy four books from now.
- 78 *l. 602* Lines 602–604 repeat 1.362–364 to the word — the refrain of all her nights, closing the greatest of them as it closed the first we saw: she climbs, she weeps for Odysseus, Athena seals her eyes. The poem ends its long night exactly where it began its first book — except that tonight the man she weeps for is downstairs, lying in the porch, planning sunrise.

## Odyssey — Book 20

*The night before; the omens of the last day; the ox-hoof; Theoclymenus  
sees the dark.*

- But noble Odysseus made his bed in the fore-hall:  
he spread an undressed oxhide down, and over it  
many fleeces of the sheep the Achaeans kept slaughtering,<sup>1</sup>  
and Eurynome threw a mantle over him where he lay.
- 5 There Odysseus lay awake, his heart devising  
evils for the suitors; and out of the hall came the women,  
the ones who all along had been sleeping with the suitors,  
setting each other laughing, trading their good cheer.<sup>2</sup>  
And the heart was roused in his breast,
- 10 and he weighed it long in his mind and in his heart —  
whether to spring after them and deal out death to each,  
or let them mix with the overweening suitors  
one final and last time. And the heart inside him snarled —  
as a bitch standing over her soft-boned pups,<sup>3</sup>
- 15 facing a man she does not know, snarls and is wild to fight:  
so his heart snarled within him, in outrage at their evil doings.  
But he struck his chest and called his heart to order:  
"Bear up, my heart. A more dog-vile thing you bore than this<sup>4</sup>  
the day the Cyclops, his force past holding, ate
- 20 my brave companions — and you endured it, till cunning  
led you out of the cave where you thought to die."  
So he spoke, reproving the dear heart in his breast;  
and his heart, in deep obedience, held fast  
and endured without a break. But the man himself turned this way and  
that.
- 25 As when a man before a great blazing fire  
turns a paunch packed full of fat and blood<sup>5</sup>  
this way and that, longing to have it roasted quickly,  
so he rolled from side to side, turning over  
how he could lay his hands on the shameless suitors,
- 30 one man against so many. And Athena came close to him,

- down from the sky; and in body she was like a woman;  
and she stood above his head and spoke to him:  
"Why awake again, most luckless of all men?"<sup>6</sup>  
Here is your house; here in the house is your wife,  
35 and your child — a son such as any man would pray for."  
Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
"Yes, goddess — all this you have said as it should be.  
But there is a thing my heart keeps turning over:  
how I am to lay hands on the shameless suitors —  
40 I, one man alone; and they always inside in a crowd.  
And this greater thing besides I keep turning over:<sup>7</sup>  
even if I kill them, by the will of Zeus and by yours,  
where do I run from what follows? Think that out for me, I say."  
Then the goddess answered him, gray-eyed Athena:  
45 "Hard man! A person will trust a weaker friend than me,<sup>8</sup>  
one who is mortal, and does not know such counsels;  
but I am a god, and I guard you through  
to the end of every labor. I will tell you outright:  
if fifty companies of mortal men stood round  
50 the two of us, hot to kill us in the fight,  
even so you would drive away their cattle and fat sheep.<sup>9</sup>  
Come — let sleep take you too. There is misery in watching  
all night awake. You will rise up out of your evils now."  
So she spoke, and poured down sleep upon his eyelids,  
55 and went back herself to Olympus, the shining goddess.  
And as sleep seized him, loosing the cares of his heart,  
loosing his limbs, his true-hearted wife awoke,<sup>10</sup>  
and wept, sitting up on her soft bed.  
And when she had had her fill of weeping,  
60 first to Artemis prayed that woman shining among women:  
"Artemis, sovereign goddess, daughter of Zeus — would that now<sup>11</sup>  
you would plant an arrow in my breast and take my life  
this very instant — or a storm-wind snatch me up  
and carry me off down the ways of gloom  
65 and fling me down where backward-flowing Ocean empties.  
As when the storm-winds carried off Pandareus' daughters:<sup>12</sup>  
the gods had destroyed their parents, and they were left



orphans in the halls; and shining Aphrodite reared them  
on cheese and sweet honey and pleasant wine,  
70 and Hera gave them beauty and good sense  
beyond all women, and pure Artemis their height,  
and Athena taught them the making of glorious work.  
But while shining Aphrodite was on her way to high Olympus  
to ask for the girls the crown of blossoming marriage —  
75 gone to Zeus who delights in thunder, for he knows all things well,  
the fortune and the misfortune of mortal men —  
meanwhile the snatching-winds carried the girls away  
and gave them over to the hateful Furies, to serve them.<sup>13</sup>  
So may the dwellers on Olympus blot me out of sight,  
80 or fair-braided Artemis strike me, that with Odysseus  
before my eyes I may pass even under the hateful earth,<sup>14</sup>  
and never gladden the mind of a lesser man.  
And yet an evil is bearable, when a person  
weeps through the days, grieved to the packed core of the heart,  
85 and the nights hold sleep at least — for sleep makes one forget  
everything, the good and the bad, once it has wrapped the eyelids —  
but to me the god sends evil even in dreams.  
For this very night one slept beside me — like him,<sup>15</sup>  
his very likeness as he was when he went with the army; and my heart  
90 rejoiced: I thought it no dream, but the waking truth at last."  
So she spoke; and at once Dawn of the golden throne came on.  
And noble Odysseus caught the sound of her weeping,  
and mused; and it seemed to him, in the drift of his heart,  
that she knew him already, and stood beside his head.<sup>16</sup>  
95 He gathered up the mantle and the fleeces he had slept in  
and set them on a chair in the hall; the oxhide  
he carried outside and laid down; and lifting his hands he prayed to  
Zeus:  
"Father Zeus — if you gods willed it, and brought me home  
over dry land and water, after all your hard usage,  
100 let someone of the people waking in the house speak me  
a word of omen; and outside, let another sign of Zeus appear."<sup>17</sup>  
So he prayed; and Zeus the counselor heard him,  
and at once he thundered out of gleaming Olympus,

- down from on high, out of the clouds. And noble Odysseus was glad.
- 105 And the word of omen came from a woman grinding at the mill,  
close by, where the mills of the shepherd of the people stood.  
Twelve women in all kept them turning,  
making barley meal and wheat flour, the marrow of men.<sup>18</sup>  
The others were asleep, their wheat all ground;
- 110 only one had not finished — the frailest one of all.  
She stopped her stone now, and spoke the word — a sign for her  
master:  
"Father Zeus, you who rule the gods and mankind:  
how loud you thundered out of the starry sky —  
and no cloud anywhere! You show this as a sign to someone.
- 115 Then accomplish now for wretched me the word I say:  
may the suitors, on this day, for the last and latest time,<sup>19</sup>  
take up their lovely feasting in the halls of Odysseus —  
the men who have loosed my knees with heart-grinding labor  
as I make their barley meal: may they sup now their last!"
- 120 So she spoke; and noble Odysseus rejoiced at the omen of her word<sup>20</sup>  
and at the thunder of Zeus. He told himself the guilty would pay.  
Now the other slave-women, gathering in the beautiful house of  
Odysseus,  
were kindling on the hearth the never-wearying fire.  
And Telemachus rose from his bed, a man like a god,  
125 and put on his clothes, and hung his sharp sword at his shoulder,  
and under his shining feet he bound the beautiful sandals,  
and took his strong spear, tipped with sharpened bronze,  
and paused on the threshold, and said to Eurycleia:  
"Dear nurse, have you honored the stranger in our house<sup>21</sup>  
130 with bed and food? Or does he lie untended, as he may?  
That is my mother's way — sensible woman though she is:  
she honors the worse of mortal men on impulse,  
and sends the better man away unhonored."  
Then watchful-minded Eurycleia answered him:
- 135 "Child, do not blame the blameless woman now.<sup>22</sup>  
He sat and drank his wine as long as he himself would;  
and bread — he said he hungered for none: she asked him.  
And when he began to think of rest and sleep,

- she told the slave-women to spread him a proper bed;  
 140 but he — like a man wholly wretched, out of luck —  
 refused to sleep on a bedstead under blankets:  
 on an undressed oxhide and the fleeces of sheep  
 he slept in the fore-hall. We laid a mantle over him ourselves."  
 So she spoke; and Telemachus went out through the hall,  
 145 spear in hand; two swift dogs followed with him,  
 and he went to the assembly-place, to the strong-greaved Achaeans.  
 And she called out to the slave-women, that woman shining among  
 women —  
 Eurycleia, daughter of Ops, Peisenor's son:<sup>23</sup>  
 "Come — to work! Some of you sweep the house, and briskly,  
 150 and sprinkle it, and lay the crimson coverings  
 on the well-made chairs; others take sponges  
 and wipe down all the tables, and rinse the mixing-bowls  
 and the wrought double-handled cups; and the rest of you away  
 for water at the spring — go quick, and quick back with it.  
 155 The suitors will not be long out of the hall this morning:  
 they will come very early. It is festival for everyone today."<sup>24</sup>  
 So she spoke; and they listened well and obeyed:  
 twenty went off to the spring of dark water,  
 and the others worked away skillfully about the house.  
 160 Then the Achaeans' serving-men came in, and split  
 firewood, well and skillfully; and the women came back  
 from the spring; and after them came the swineherd,  
 driving three fatted hogs, the best of all he had.  
 He left them to feed at large in the fine yard-fences,  
 165 and himself spoke to Odysseus, and his words were kind:  
 "Stranger — do the Achaeans look on you any better now,  
 or do they still dishonor you through the hall, as before?"  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 "Ah, Eumaeus, may the gods pay back the outrage  
 170 these men in their insolence keep devising —  
 reckless things, in another man's house. They have no share of shame."  
 So they spoke to one another of such things.  
 And Melanthius came up close to them, the goatherd,<sup>25</sup>  
 driving the goats that stood out in all the herds,

- 175 a dinner for the suitors; and two herdsmen followed with him.  
 He tethered the goats under the echoing porch,  
 and himself spoke to Odysseus, and his words were taunts:  
 "Stranger — still here? Still going to plague this house,  
 begging from the men? Still not out the door?"
- 180 I don't imagine, now, we two will settle this business  
 before we've tasted each other's fists. There is no decency  
 in the way you beg. And there are other feasts among the Achaeans."  
 So he spoke; and Odysseus of the many designs said nothing:  
 he only shook his head, silent, brooding evils deep in his heart.<sup>26</sup>
- 185 And a third came in upon them — Philoetius, a leader of men,<sup>27</sup>  
 driving a barren heifer for the suitors, and fat goats.  
 Ferrymen had brought them over — the ones who carry  
 other travelers too, whoever comes to them.  
 He tethered his beasts well under the echoing porch,
- 190 and came up close to the swineherd and asked him:  
 "Swineherd — who is this stranger, newly come  
 to our house? What men does he claim for his people?  
 Where are his family and his fathers' fields?  
 Poor devil — and yet, truly, in build he is like a lord, a king."<sup>28</sup>
- 195 But the gods sink far-wandering men in misery  
 when they spin hard sorrow even for kings."  
 He spoke, and coming up he gave him his right hand in welcome,  
 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words:  
 "Your health, father stranger! May happiness be yours<sup>29</sup>
- 200 in time to come — though now you are held fast in many evils.  
 Father Zeus — no other god is deadlier than you:<sup>30</sup>  
 you have no pity on men, though you begot them  
 yourself, for tangling them in misery and grinding pains.  
 I broke sweat when I saw him, and my eyes stand full of tears,<sup>31</sup>
- 205 remembering Odysseus: for he too, I think,  
 wears rags like these, and wanders somewhere among men —  
 if indeed he lives, and sees the light of the sun.  
 But if he is dead already, down in the house of Hades —  
 ah me, blameless Odysseus! — who set me over his cattle
- 210 when I was still a boy, in the land of the Cephallenians.  
 And now they are past all counting; no other man

could have a breed of broad-browed cattle bear richer, like standing wheat.<sup>32</sup>

And strangers order me to drive them in for them  
to eat! They care nothing for the son in the house,  
215 they do not tremble at the gods' watching eye: they are wild  
to divide up the goods of the master so long away.  
As for me, this thought keeps rolling over and over  
in the heart in my breast: it is a very bad thing,  
while the son lives, to go off to a country of strangers,  
220 cattle and all, to foreign men; but colder still to stay  
suffering here, sitting over cattle that others claim.<sup>33</sup>  
And long ago I would have run, fled to some other  
of the high-handed kings — for this is past all bearing —  
but still I think of that unlucky man: what if he came  
225 from somewhere, and made a scattering of the suitors through the  
house!"

Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
"Cowherd — since you seem no bad man and no fool,  
and I can see for myself that good sense has reached your heart,  
I will tell you something, and swear a great oath upon it:  
230 Now Zeus be my witness, first of the gods, and this table of friendship,<sup>34</sup>  
and the hearth of blameless Odysseus, to which I have come:  
while you are here, Odysseus will come home;  
and with your own eyes, if you wish it, you shall see  
the killing of the suitors who play lord and master here."

235 Then the cowherd answered him, the master of the oxen:  
"Ah, stranger, if only the son of Cronos would accomplish that word!  
Then you would learn my strength — and how my hands follow it."<sup>35</sup>  
And in the same way Eumaeus prayed to all the gods  
that Odysseus of the many designs might come home to his own house.

240 So they spoke to one another of such things.  
And the suitors, meanwhile, were framing death and doom  
for Telemachus — when a bird came by on their left hand:  
an eagle flying high, gripping a trembling dove.<sup>36</sup>  
And Amphinomus rose and spoke among them:  
245 "Friends, this plan of ours will not run smooth —  
the killing of Telemachus. Let us think of the feast."<sup>37</sup>

So spoke Amphinomus, and his word pleased them well.  
 They came into the house of godlike Odysseus  
 and laid their mantles down on the couches and chairs  
 250 and slaughtered big sheep and fat goats,  
 slaughtered sleek hogs and a heifer of the herd.  
 They roasted the innards and served them round, and mixed  
 the wine in the mixing-bowls; and the swineherd passed the cups,  
 and Philoetius, a leader of men, passed them bread  
 255 in beautiful baskets; and Melanthius poured the wine.<sup>38</sup>  
 And their hands went out to the good things spread before them.  
 But Telemachus — his craft at work — seated Odysseus<sup>39</sup>  
 inside the strong-built hall, beside the stone threshold,  
 setting him a battered stool and a little table;  
 260 he put a portion of the innards by him, and poured him wine  
 in a golden cup, and said to him:  
 "Sit here now among the men, and drink your wine.  
 The taunts and the fists of all the suitors — I myself  
 will hold them off you. This is no public house:  
 265 it is Odysseus' house — and he won it for me."<sup>40</sup>  
 And you, you suitors, hold your hearts back from insult  
 and fists, so no strife and quarreling break out."  
 So he spoke; and they all bit their lips and stared  
 in wonder at Telemachus, that he spoke so boldly.<sup>41</sup>  
 270 And Antinous spoke among them, Eupheithes' son:  
 "Hard as it is, Achaeans, let us take the word  
 of Telemachus — though how he threatens as he talks!  
 Zeus the son of Cronos would not have it; otherwise  
 we would have silenced him in the halls long since — so clear a  
 speaker."<sup>42</sup>  
 275 So spoke Antinous; but he took no heed of his words.  
 Now the heralds were leading through the town the holy hecatomb  
 of the gods; and the long-haired Achaeans gathered<sup>43</sup>  
 under the shady grove of Apollo who shoots from afar.  
 And when they had roasted the outer flesh and drawn it off,  
 280 they divided the portions and feasted the glorious feast;  
 and the serving-men set beside Odysseus a share  
 equal to the ones they drew themselves: for so ordered

Telemachus, dear son of godlike Odysseus.  
 And Athena would not let the lordly suitors  
 285 hold back from heart-stinging outrage — so that pain might sink  
 still deeper into Laertes' son Odysseus.<sup>44</sup>  
 There was among the suitors a man versed in lawlessness:  
 Ctesippus was his name, and his home was on Same;<sup>45</sup>  
 sure of his fabulous wealth, he had come  
 290 to woo the wife of Odysseus, the master so long away.  
 He now spoke out among the overweening suitors:  
 "Hear me, you lordly suitors, while I say a word.  
 The stranger has long had his portion — an equal one,  
 as is proper: it is not fine, and it is not just, to stint  
 295 the guests of Telemachus, whoever comes to this house.  
 But come — let me too give him a guest-gift, so he in turn<sup>46</sup>  
 can hand a prize to the bath-woman, or to some other  
 of the slaves in the house of godlike Odysseus."  
 So speaking, he snatched an ox-hoof out of the basket  
 300 where it lay, and hurled it with his thick hand. But Odysseus  
 dodged it with a quick tilt of his head, and smiled in his heart  
 a smile most sardonic; and it struck the well-built wall.<sup>47</sup>  
 And Telemachus lashed Ctesippus with his words:  
 "Ctesippus — count it clear profit for your own heart:  
 305 you missed the stranger. He dodged the throw himself.  
 Otherwise I would have run you through the middle with my sharp  
 spear,  
 and instead of a wedding your father would be busy here  
 with a funeral. So: let no man show his ugliness<sup>48</sup>  
 in this house of mine. For now I take note and I know each thing,  
 310 the good and the worse alike. Before, I was still a child.  
 But even so we endure it and look on:  
 the flocks slaughtered, the wine drunk down,  
 the bread — for it is hard for one man to check many.  
 Come then, do me no more evil in your malice.  
 315 But if you are set on killing me — me myself — with the bronze,  
 even that I would choose: it would be far better  
 to die than look on forever at these disgraceful doings:<sup>49</sup>  
 guests roughly handled, and men hauling the slave-women

- shamefully through the beautiful house."
- 320 So he spoke; and they all fell silent and still.  
 At last Agelaus spoke, Damastor's son:  
 "Friends — no man should take offense at a just word spoken,<sup>50</sup>  
 and answer it with wrangling and hard speech.  
 Do not knock the stranger about, nor any other
- 325 of the slaves in the house of godlike Odysseus.  
 But to Telemachus, and to his mother, I would say  
 a gentle word — if it might find favor with the hearts of both.  
 As long as the hearts in your breasts kept hope  
 that Odysseus of the many designs would come home to his own house,
- 330 no one could resent your waiting, or your holding off  
 the suitors in the halls: that was the better way  
 if Odysseus had returned, come back at last to his house.  
 But now it is plain that he is past returning.  
 Go then, sit by your mother, and lay it out for her:
- 335 marry the best man, the one who offers most —  
 so you may keep and enjoy all that was your father's,  
 eating and drinking, and she may keep another's house."<sup>51</sup>  
 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 "No, by Zeus, Agelaus — and by the sufferings of my father,
- 340 who far from Ithaca has perished, or still wanders:  
 I do not delay my mother's marriage. I urge her  
 to wed the man she chooses; and I offer gifts past counting.  
 But I am ashamed to drive her from the hall against her will  
 with a word of compulsion. May god never bring that to pass."<sup>52</sup>
- 345 So spoke Telemachus. And in the suitors Pallas Athena  
 set off unquenchable laughter, and knocked their wits askew.<sup>53</sup>  
 And now they were laughing with jaws no longer their own;  
 the meat they ate was dabbled in blood; and their eyes  
 brimmed full of tears; and the heart in them wanted to wail.
- 350 And godlike Theoclymenus spoke out among them:  
 "Wretched men — what evil is this you suffer? Night — your heads<sup>54</sup>  
 are shrouded in night, and your faces, and your knees beneath;  
 wailing has caught like fire; cheeks are streaming tears;  
 the walls are spattered with blood, and the fine crossbeams;
- 355 and the porch is full of ghosts — the courtyard full of them —



- ghosts hurrying down to Erebus, under the gloom; the sun  
has perished out of the sky, and an evil mist runs over everything."  
So he spoke; and they all laughed at him sweetly.<sup>55</sup>  
And Eurymachus, Polybus' son, began to speak among them:
- 360 "The stranger is raving — this new one, fresh from abroad.  
Quick, young men — see him out of the house and on his way  
to the assembly-place, since he finds it night in here."  
Then godlike Theoclymenus said to him:  
"Eurymachus, I ask no escort of you for my going.
- 365 I have eyes, and ears, and both my feet,<sup>56</sup>  
and a mind in my breast in no way meanly made.  
With these I am going out that door — for I see evil coming  
on you, evil no man will escape or dodge,  
no man of you suitors, you who in the house of godlike Odysseus
- 370 batter men with outrage and devise your reckless deeds."  
So speaking he went out of the well-settled house  
and came to Piraeus, who received him gladly.<sup>57</sup>  
And the suitors all, eyeing one another,  
went to work needling Telemachus, laughing at his guests;
- 375 and a man of the arrogant young men would say:  
"Telemachus, no man is unluckier in his guests than you.  
Look at this one you keep — this pawed-over vagrant<sup>58</sup>  
who wants his bread and wine, who has no skill for work  
and no strength either: a dead weight on the good earth.
- 380 And then the other one — he stood up to play the prophet!  
If you would listen to me, the profit is all yours:  
let us pitch your guests into a many-benched ship  
and send them to the Sicilians. There they would fetch you a worthy  
price."<sup>59</sup>  
So the suitors talked; but he took no heed of their words.
- 385 He watched his father in silence — waiting, always,<sup>60</sup>  
for the moment he would lay his hands on the shameless suitors.  
And she — she had set her beautiful chair across from them:  
Icarius' daughter, watchful-minded Penelope,  
and heard each man's word in the halls.<sup>61</sup>
- 390 For laughing they had made their dinner ready —  
a sweet meal and a hearty one, for they had slaughtered lavishly.

But no supper could ever be more graceless than the supper  
a goddess and a strong man were soon now to set  
before them. For they had begun it: the shameful devising was theirs.<sup>62</sup>

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 20

- 1 l. 2 The bed itself is an indictment: an undressed oxhide, and fleeces "of the sheep the Achaeans kept slaughtering" — bedding that arrives tagged with its provenance: the king lies down on the by-products of his own devoured estate. The mantle on top is Eurynome's small mercy.
- 2 l. 6 The disloyal women go out to the suitors "setting each other laughing" — past the master lying in the porch. The night audit he refused from Eurycleia (19.500ff) happens anyway, involuntarily: they file past his bed toward their own sentence.
- 3 l. 14 The bitch simile — his heart snarls over the household like a mother-dog over "soft-boned pups" facing a stranger. The tenderest guardian-image in the poem given to a rage for slaughter; what the heart wants to protect and what it wants to do are the same growl. This is the poem's only look inside Odysseus at war with his own organ of feeling.
- 4 l. 18 "Bear up, my heart. A more dog-vile thing you bore" — κύντερον, "more dog-like," snapping back at the dog-simile two lines up: the heart snarls like a bitch and is told it once endured something *doggier*. The self-address — struck chest, quoted speech to his own heart — became the archetype of self-command (Plato quotes it twice); the argument is a veteran's: we survived the cave by craft, we outlast this by craft.
- 5 l. 25 The paunch simile: he tosses like a blood-sausage being turned over a blaze, "longing to have it roasted quickly." The comparison is deliberately gross and deliberately chosen: it was the beggars' prize at 18.44–45 — paunch "packed full of fat and blood" — and now the man who won that contest is one, stuffed with heat and urgency, almost done. Homeric similes rarely joke; this one does, at its hero's expense.
- 6 l. 33 Athena's opening is a goddess's tease — "Here is your house; here is your wife" — as if the twenty-year problem were solved and the man merely forgetful. What she omits (the hundred and eight men between him and both) is exactly what he answers with.
- 7 l. 41 The second worry is the remarkable one: "even if I kill them... where do I run from what follows?" — the blood-feud. Odysseus is the only person in the poem planning past the climax: the suitors' kin, the vendetta arithmetic of a small island. Book 24 will prove the worry exactly right; Athena's answer here, as there, is essentially *I am the exit*.
- 8 l. 45 "Hard man!" — σχέτλιε, the same address she opened with at 13.293: her fond exasperation at a mortal who audits even a goddess's guarantees. The rebuke that follows ("a person will trust a weaker friend — a mortal one") is the closest the poem comes to Athena stating what she is to him.
- 9 l. 49 "If fifty companies of mortal men stood round the two of us... even so you would drive away their cattle and sheep." The promise is scaled in raids — not survival but *profit*: you would leave with the livestock. Athena knows her man; the reassurance is denominated in his own currency.

- 10 *l. 56* The stagger of the sleepers: as sleep takes him, she wakes. All night the house has held one waking griever at a time, husband and wife trading the watch without knowing it — the poem's image for the marriage itself these twenty years.
- 11 *l. 61* The prayer to Artemis expands the wish of 18.202–205 into the poem's darkest devotion: the arrow now, or the whirlwind — annihilation without burial, snatched off "down the ways of gloom" to the mouths of Ocean. She prays for the fate of the storm-taken, the worst end the Greek imagination offered a woman, in preference to "gladdening the mind of a lesser man."
- 12 *l. 66* The daughters of Pandareus — second tale from that house in a single night (the nightingale, 19.518ff, was their sister). Orphaned, fostered by four goddesses — Aphrodite's food, Hera's beauty and sense, Artemis' height, Athena's handwork — and, on the very day of their betrothal negotiations, carried off by the snatching-winds to serve the Furies. The myth is a machine for her meaning: divine care lavished for years, then annulled in an hour between promise and wedding — her own biography, read as a warning against hoping.
- 13 *l. 77* "The snatching-winds carried the girls away and gave them over to the hateful Furies": ἄρπυιαι — the harpies as functionaries of a transaction between storms and vengeance-spirits. The bureaucratic horror of it (girls "given over to serve") is the point: some fates are not deaths but permanent disappearances into service — which is also a description of slavery, the poem's other abyss.
- 14 *l. 80* "That with Odysseus before my eyes I may pass even under the hateful earth": the prayer's kernel — she will accept Hades if she can go down still *seeing* him (ὄσσομένη — with him before her mind's eye). Not reunion; just unreplaced. The alternative — a lesser man gladdened — is what this very day's contest offers, and this prayer is her true position on it.
- 15 *l. 88* The dream that torments her is a good one: Odysseus beside her "as he was when he went with the army" — young, and she "thought it no dream, but the waking truth at last" (ὑπᾶρ — the word of 19.547). The cruelty is in the waking; the accuracy is in the timing: a man like him *is* in the house tonight. Her dreams are now running ahead of her information.
- 16 *l. 93* He hears her weeping and half-dreams awake: "it seemed to him... that she knew him already, and stood beside his head." His fantasy and her dream reach for each other across the house — she dreamed him beside her; he imagines her beside him, *recognizing*. Two rooms apart, the marriage is dreaming symmetrically; only the plot holds the doors shut.
- 17 *l. 100* The double-omen prayer: a φῆμη (spoken omen) from someone waking indoors, and a τέρας of Zeus outside. He specifies the evidentiary standard — two independent channels — like the strategist he is; Zeus fills the order in reverse: thunder from a clear sky, then the mill-woman.
- 18 *l. 108* The mills, "the marrow of men" (μυελὸν ἀνδρῶν) — barley and wheat as civilization's bone-fill, ground by twelve women. Twelve: the number of the disloyal maids (22.424). The poem's arithmetic of the household keeps its books in dozens.

- 19 l. 116 The mill-woman's kledon — the frailest of the twelve grinders, the last one at the stone, is granted the poem's decisive curse: "may they sup now their last!" Her authority is her exhaustion ("who have loosed my knees") — the suitors' feast priced in one worker's body. Zeus thunders for her; the great revenge is countersigned at the bottom of the labor hierarchy.
- 20 l. 120 "Rejoiced at the omen of her word" — the kledon-formula of 18.117 again. Twice now the suitors' doom has been ratified by chance speech: their own blessing then, a slave's curse now. He "told himself the guilty would pay" — τίσασθαι: the ledger-verb; the day's business is now booked.
- 21 l. 129 Telemachus' morning question needles his mother in absentia — she honors the worse man, slights the better "on impulse" (ἐμπλήγηδην). It is camouflage (he must not seem to prize the beggar) laid over real grievance, and it is unjust; Eurycleia's correction (135ff) is precise: the guest got everything he would accept. The performance of casualness now runs even inside the family.
- 22 l. 135 "Do not blame the blameless woman" — Eurycleia's report is an innkeeper's docket: wine as long as he liked, bread declined and offered, bed refused, mantle laid over him anyway. The house's kindness is documented against the boy's slander; the nurse audits even her masters.
- 23 l. 148 Eurycleia gets her full formal genealogy — "daughter of Ops, Peisenor's son" — as she issues the day's work orders. The poem dignifies the head-of-staff with a patronymic at the exact moment the house is scrubbed for its own liberation: sweep, sprinkle, crimson coverings, sponges, rinsed bowls — the massacre's venue is being cleaned for it.
- 24 l. 156 "It is festival for everyone today" — the feast of Apollo, the archer-god, casually flagged by a housekeeper. The deadline sworn twice by the beggar (14.161–162 = 19.306–307: "between this month's waning and the rising of the next") lands today, the dark of the moon, Apollo's day: the bow's own god presides over the bow's return to work.
- 25 l. 173 Melanthius abuses the beggar again (17.217ff, the kick; now the fists-threat) — strikes entered in the record a day apart; his sentence (22.474ff) will be read against this docket. Odysseus answers with the fixed line of silence — the head-shake, the deep-brooded evils (= 17.465 = 17.491).
- 26 l. 184 The fixed line of endured insult — head shaken, silence kept, "brooding evils deep in his heart" — now in its third appearance (17.465 after the footstool, 17.491 the son's copy, here after Melanthius' taunt). The formula has become the beggar's standard receipt: abuse deposited, nothing said, interest accruing.
- 27 l. 185 "A third came in — Philoetius, a leader of men" (ῥαχμαὸς ἀνδρῶν, Eumaeus' own title): the cowherd, the poem's last major loyalist, introduced at dawn on the last day. The trio is now assembled — swineherd, goatherd, cowherd: loyal, traitor, loyal — the estate's whole moral range walking in with its animals.
- 28 l. 194 Philoetius reads the beggar in one look: "in build he is like a lord, a king" — then supplies the theology that explains the rags: the gods sink wanderers in misery "when they spin hard sorrow even for kings." He sees through the disguise to the *type* and

reasons correctly about the god-spun exception; no one in the poem gets closer on sight alone.

- 29 l. 199 His greeting repeats Amphinomus' toast word for word (18.122–123): "Your health, father stranger!..." — the loyal cowherd and the doomed half-decent suitor share one blessing-formula. The poem files them together deliberately: the two men in the hall who wished the beggar well — one will be armed by him, the other killed by his son.
- 30 l. 201 "Father Zeus — no other god is deadlier than you: you have no pity on men, though you begot them yourself." The boldest theological complaint in Homer — spoken not by a hero in a storm but by a herdsman upset about cattle. Philoetius arraigns Zeus for fathering men into misery, then goes straight on weeping about his master's rags: doctrine and devotion in one breath, the working man's metaphysics.
- 31 l. 204 "I broke sweat when I saw him" (ἰδὼν) — grief as a physical event: the cowherd sweats at the sight of a beggar because the beggar makes him *see* Odysseus in rags somewhere. His body recognizes what his mind dare not: the sweat is for the man in front of him.
- 32 l. 211 The herd report: broad-browed cattle come on "like standing wheat" — increase past counting, all of it requisitioned by "strangers" who "do not tremble at the gods' watching eye" (ῥῆτις — divine surveillance). Philoetius' complaint doubles as the estate's account-book: the wealth is intact, the extraction is total, the auditor is standing in front of him disguised.
- 33 l. 219 The loyalist's dilemma, stated exactly: flee with the herds to a foreign king (betray the son), or stay and serve the thieves (suffer). He has chosen the "colder" option — staying — held by one hypothesis: "what if he came from somewhere...!" Eumaeus' loyalty is love of persons; Philoetius' is loyalty *under stated analysis*, which the poem may rate even higher: he has done the math and stayed anyway.
- 34 l. 230 The oath to Philoetius = the oath to Eumaeus (14.158–160): Zeus, the table of friendship, the hearth of blameless Odysseus. The formula's third swearing (19.303–304 to Penelope between them), and this time the payoff is explicit: "with your own eyes, if you wish it, you shall see the killing of the suitors." Each loyalist is issued the same bond; redemption falls due before the day is out.
- 35 l. 237 "Then you would learn my strength — and how my hands follow it." Philoetius answers the oath with an enlistment; Eumaeus co-signs with a prayer. The muster is complete: the hall now holds four fighters, and only one of them knows it.
- 36 l. 242 The eagle-with-dove on the left — the same sign that blessed Telemachus' departure (15.525ff) now blocks his murder: omens keep intervening between the suitors and the boy. Amphinomus reads it instantly and correctly — his third and last decent act, once again the minimum: not "stop," only "not today; let us think of the feast." The feast he defers to is the one the mill-woman cursed.
- 37 l. 245 "This plan of ours will not run smooth" — συνθεύσεται, a racing word: the plot won't *run with us*. Amphinomus' idiom is a gambler's, and accurate: every start the suitors make now is scratched by heaven.

- 38 l. 253 The service of the last feast: Eumaeus passes cups, Philoetius the bread, Melanthius pours the wine. The staffing chart is the battle-plan in embryo — two loyalists and the traitor handling the suitors' food and drink; within hours the same three hands will hold the doors, the arms-store, and nothing.
- 39 l. 257 "His craft at work" (κέρδεα νωμῶν) — Telemachus seats his father inside the hall by the stone threshold, with a battered stool, a little table, an equal portion, and a golden cup: degradation staged to the eye, parity delivered in fact. The arrangement is tactical (the threshold is where the bow will be shot from) and filial in the poem's peculiar key — the son can honor his father only in the grammar of hospitality to a beggar.
- 40 l. 264 "This is no public house: it is Odysseus' house — and he won it for me." The plainest property-law sentence in the poem, spoken over the property's owner drinking from the golden cup. Every word doubles: the house is indeed not public, is indeed Odysseus', and the *he won it* (ἐκτήσατο) quietly asserts the acquisition ethic — this estate was earned, and its earner is present.
- 41 l. 268 Lips bitten, bold speech marveled at = 18.410–411 verbatim: the second time in two days the hall has had to swallow Telemachus whole. The formula's return marks the trend: each performance of authority is stronger, and the silences after them longer.
- 42 l. 273 Antinous' reply concedes everything in a sneer: "Zeus would not have it; otherwise we would have silenced him long since." The confession is casual and complete — only heaven's veto has kept Telemachus alive — and it is spoken as a complaint. The suitors now blame Zeus for their own unfinished murder; the theology is truer than they know.
- 43 l. 276 The town's festival procession — hecatomb through the streets, the people gathering in Apollo's shady grove — runs in parallel montage with the hall's last feast: outside, Ithaca worships the archer; inside, the archer's day is being kept another way. The cut back and forth is the poem's quiet liturgical joke.
- 44 l. 284 Athena's goad, verbatim from 18.346–348: the outrage must not slacken, "so that pain might sink still deeper." The goddess re-administers the dose on schedule — the second day running — topping up the rage this very day will spend. Divine cruelty as fuel logistics.
- 45 l. 287 Ctesippus, "a man versed in lawlessness" — ἀθεμίστια εἰδώς, the Cyclopes' adjective (9.106): the poem introduces its newest suitor with the vocabulary of monsters. Rich, from Same, and defined before he acts: what follows is not a lapse but a credential.
- 46 l. 296 The "guest-gift" speech is the suitors' cruelty at its most refined: a parody of xenia protocol — the stranger has had his portion, propriety demands I add a ξείνιον — with the gift an ox-hoof from the scrap basket. Where Antinous threw in rage and Eurymachus in drunken pique, Ctesippus throws as *satire*: the institution itself mocked. It is the escalation that matters: the abuse has become theater.
- 47 l. 301 The dodge and the smile: "a smile most sardonic" — σαρδάνιον, the first occurrence in literature of the word that became "sardonic." A smile in the heart, behind the face, at the moment a bone aimed at his head hits the wall: the whole disguise in one adverb. The etymology was debated even in antiquity (the Sardinian

herb that twists the mouth of the dying?); the poem's usage needs no botany — it is the smile of a man filing a debt.

- 48 *l. 307* "Instead of a wedding your father would be busy here with a funeral": Telemachus' threat runs on the same rails as the beggar's curse on Antinous (17.476, death "before any wedding") — marriage and burial as the two feasts a suitor might get. For Ctesippus the account settles at 22.285ff, when Philoetius' spear takes him — with a taunt about ox-hooves attached.
- 49 *l. 317* Lines 316–319 repeat, nearly word for word, what the disguised Odysseus said at 16.106–111: better to die than watch guests manhandled and slave-women hauled through the beautiful house. Telemachus was in the hut when his father said it; now he speaks it as his own in open hall. The father's ethic, overheard once, has become the son's public platform — the poem's way of showing an inheritance delivered.
- 50 *l. 322* Agelaus opens with Amphinomus' exact lines (18.414–417: no offense at a just word; hands off the stranger and the slaves) — the reasonable-suitor script now circulating as a formula. The decency of the doomed is interchangeable; the poem keeps showing that moderation without withdrawal is just politeness on the way to the same spear (Agelaus falls at 22.293).
- 51 *l. 334* Agelaus' proposal is the suitors' case in its best dress: the waiting was honorable while hope lasted; hope is gone; sit by your mother and settle the marriage — you keep the estate, she keeps another's house. It is reasonable, humane in tone, and rests entirely on one premise ("now it is plain that he is past returning") that is false by the width of the room.
- 52 *l. 341* Telemachus' oath — "by Zeus, and by the sufferings of my father" — swears by the very thing the room denies exists. His position is exact and unimpeachable: the marriage is urged, dowered, and un-forced; "I am ashamed to drive her out against her will." He has said it before (2.130ff); saying it *now*, with his father listening and the contest hours away, it becomes the last word on the subject the suitors will ever hear.
- 53 *l. 345* The Athena-maddened laughter — the most frightening lines in the poem. She "knocked their wits askew," and they laugh "with jaws no longer their own" (γναθμοῖσι ἀλλοτρίοισιν); the meat runs blood; their eyes fill with tears while the laughter continues; "the heart in them wanted to wail." Possession as comedy breaking down into grief — the body's future (bleeding, wept-over) surfacing through its present (feasting, laughing). The suitors experience their own deaths as a mood they cannot account for; 18.100's idiom ("died laughing") has begun to come literally true.
- 54 *l. 351* Theoclymenus' vision — the apocalypse of the noonday hall: night shrouding heads, faces, knees; wailing "caught like fire"; blood on walls and crossbeams; porch and courtyard packed with ghosts "hurrying down to Erebus"; the sun perished from the sky; the mist running over everything. Seven lines of second sight, every clause redeemed in Book 22 (the shrouded heads, the spattered walls, the following dusk). This is the seer's third and greatest utterance — after the omen (15.531ff) and the hearth-oath (17.155ff) — and the poem's only sustained prophetic *vision*: not a bird read but the thing itself seen — a sun perished at noon, which no dark of the moon can explain.



- 55 l. 358 "They all laughed at him sweetly" (ἡδὺ γέλασσαν) — the same "sweet" laughter that has run through their scenes since Book 2, now directed at a man describing their corpses. The possession-laughter of 345–349 has subsided into ordinary mockery: they have been shown the ending and find it funny. No damnation in the poem is more complete than this amusement.
- 56 l. 364 Theoclymenus' exit speech is the dignity of the functioning senses: "I have eyes, and ears, and both my feet, and a mind in no way meanly made" — inventory of a working prophet, walking out on his own equipment. He needs no escort *because he can see* — the precise faculty the room has just proven it lacks. His final sentence, evil "no man of you will escape or dodge," closes the seer's own tally of refused warnings: omen, thunder, vision, and the man who read them all.
- 57 l. 371 He goes to Piraeus — the same harbor-friend who took him in at 15.539ff. The seer's arc closes where it began: received by the one reliably hospitable man in the town. He exits the poem here, the only guest who saw everything and left before it happened — Ithaca's Cassandra, believed by no one and unbloodied.
- 58 l. 376 The anonymous suitor's résumé of the beggar — "no skill for work and no strength either: a dead weight on the good earth" (ἄχθος ἀρούρης, Achilles' own phrase of self-reproach, Il. 18.104) — grades the man who out-plowed and out-mowed their kind in his challenge-speech (18.366ff) and will string the great bow of the house within the day. The mockery inventory is exactly inverted; every clause is about to be refuted with a corpse.
- 59 l. 382 "Send them to the Sicilians — there they would fetch you a worthy price" (ἄξιον... ἄλφοι): the slave-sale idiom of Eumaeus' childhood (15.388, 429 — "he paid a worthy price") aimed now at Odysseus and Theoclymenus. Selling guests west into slavery is the suitors' final proposal on the subject of hospitality; the word "price" is the last item in their xenia file.
- 60 l. 385 "He watched his father in silence — waiting, always, for the moment": Telemachus' whole interior compressed to a gaze. The line is built of the plan's key words (16.274ff: endure, watch, wait for the sign); the discipline ordered in the hut is now visible as posture at the feast. Around him the hall laughs; the son is a cocked trigger politely passing bread.
- 61 l. 387 Penelope's chair, set "across from them" — she has positioned herself to hear every word in the hall: the taunts, her son's oath, the seer's vision. The queen sits through the last feast as its audience, in plain view and listening; whatever she knows or half-knows when she rises to fetch the bow, the poem has put her within earshot of everything.
- 62 l. 392 The closing sentence sets the two feasts side by side: the dinner they cooked "laughing" — sweet, hearty, lavish — and the supper "a goddess and a strong man were soon now to set before them," than which "none could ever be more graceless" (ἀχαρίστερον: without χάρις, grace, thanks, pleasure — the un-feast). The last clause is the poem's whole verdict on the revenge, delivered as table-manners: *they had begun it; the shameful devising was theirs*. Book 21 opens with the bow.



## Odyssey — Book 21

*The bow: pedigree, contest, recruitment, and the stringing.*

And now the goddess put it in her mind — gray-eyed Athena,  
in the mind of Icarius' daughter, watchful-minded Penelope —  
to set before the suitors the bow and the gray iron  
in the halls of Odysseus: the contest, and the beginning of the  
slaughter.<sup>1</sup>

- 5 She climbed the high stairway of her house  
and took the bent key in her strong hand —  
a beautiful key of bronze, with an ivory handle —<sup>2</sup>  
and went her way with her attendant women  
to the last storeroom. There the master's treasures lay:  
10 bronze, and gold, and iron wrought with labor.  
And there lay the backsprung bow, and the quiver  
for the arrows, with many groan-laden shafts inside —<sup>3</sup>  
gifts that a guest-friend gave him when they met in Lacedaemon:  
Iphitus, Eurytus' son, a man like the immortals.<sup>4</sup>  
15 The two had crossed paths in Messene,  
in the house of thoughtful Ortilochus. Odysseus  
had come to collect a debt the whole people owed him:  
for Messenian men had lifted sheep out of Ithaca —  
three hundred, with their herdsman — in their many-benched ships.  
20 For their sake Odysseus came that long road on embassy,  
a boy still, sent out by his father and the other elders.<sup>5</sup>  
And Iphitus came hunting horses — twelve mares  
he had lost, with hard-working mules at suck beneath them —  
the same mares that afterward became his death and doom,  
25 when he came to the strong-hearted son of Zeus,  
the man Heracles, that expert in great deeds,  
who killed him — a guest in his own house.<sup>6</sup>  
Ruthless: no shame before the gods' watching eye, nor for the table  
he himself had set the man; he killed him even so,  
30 and kept the strong-hoofed mares in his own halls.  
Asking after these, Iphitus met Odysseus, and gave him the bow

- that great Eurytus carried in the old days, and left  
to his son at his death in the high house.  
And Odysseus gave him a sharp sword and a strong spear —  
35 the start of a binding friendship; but they never knew  
each other's tables: before that, the son of Zeus killed  
Iphitus, Eurytus' son, that man like the immortals,  
who gave the bow. And noble Odysseus never  
took it with him going to war in the black ships:  
40 it stood in his halls at home, a memorial  
of a beloved guest-friend; on his own land he carried it.<sup>7</sup>  
And when she reached that storeroom, the shining among women,  
and stepped up on the oak threshold — which a carpenter once  
planed with skill and trued to the line,  
45 and fixed the doorposts in it, and hung the shining doors —  
at once she quickly loosed the thong from the hook,  
slid in the key, and shot back the bolts of the doors  
with a straight thrust. And they bellowed like a bull<sup>8</sup>  
at pasture in a meadow — so loud the beautiful doors  
50 bellowed at the key's stroke; and they flew open before her.  
She stepped up onto the high floor, where the chests  
stood full of clothing laid away in fragrance.  
Reaching up from there she took the bow off its peg,  
bright in the bow-case that enclosed it.  
55 And she sat down right there, with the case on her knees,  
and wept aloud, and shrill, and drew out the master's bow.<sup>9</sup>  
And when she had taken her fill of tear-heavy mourning,  
she went her way to the hall, to the lordly suitors,  
holding in her hand the backsprung bow and the quiver  
60 for the arrows, with many groan-laden shafts inside;  
and beside her handmaids carried the box where the iron  
lay in plenty, and the bronze: the master's gear of contest.  
And when she reached the suitors, shining among women,  
she stood beside the pillar of the close-built roof,  
65 holding her glistening veil before her cheeks,  
a trusted handmaid standing on either side,<sup>10</sup>  
and spoke at once among the suitors, and said her word:  
"Hear me, you lordly suitors, who have fastened on this house<sup>11</sup>

- to eat and drink your way through it without ever a pause,  
70 its master long gone; nor could you offer any other  
excuse in all this time, any word at all,  
except your lust to marry me and take me to wife.  
Well then, you suitors — come: here stands your prize before you.  
I set out the great bow of godlike Odysseus.
- 75 Whoever strings the bow most easily in his hands  
and shoots an arrow through all twelve axes —  
him I will follow, forsaking this house,  
this house of my marriage, this beautiful house, full of all  
that sustains life. I think I shall remember it even in my dreams."<sup>12</sup>
- 80 So she spoke, and told Eumaeus, the noble swineherd,  
to set the bow before the suitors, and the gray iron.  
In tears Eumaeus took them and laid them down;  
and the cowherd wept on his side, when he saw the master's bow.<sup>13</sup>  
And Antinous rebuked them, and spoke a word, and named them:
- 85 "Idiot rustics! — brains that stop at the day's end!"<sup>14</sup>  
Wretched pair, why are you streaming tears, and stirring up  
the heart in the woman's breast? Her heart lies deep enough  
in grief already, since she lost her dear husband.  
Sit and feast in silence — or take your bawling
- 90 outside, the two of you, and leave the bow right here,  
a trial for the suitors none will slip through: for I do not think  
this polished bow is going to be strung with ease.  
There is no man in this whole company  
such as Odysseus was. I saw him myself —
- 95 I remember it well — though I was still a witless child."<sup>15</sup>  
So he spoke; but the heart in his breast was hoping  
that he would string the bow and shoot through the iron.  
In fact he was to be the first to taste an arrow<sup>16</sup>  
from the hands of blameless Odysseus — the man he was dishonoring
- 100 that moment, sitting in his hall, and egging on all his companions.  
And the sacred strength of Telemachus spoke among them:  
"Ah — Zeus the son of Cronos has made me witless!"<sup>17</sup>  
My own dear mother — sensible as she is — declares  
she will follow another man and forsake this house;
- 105 and I laugh, and enjoy it, with my witless heart.

- Come then, you suitors — since here stands your prize:  
 a woman whose like there is not now in all Achaea,  
 not in holy Pylos, not in Argos or Mycenae,  
 not on Ithaca itself, not on the dark mainland —
- 110 but you know that yourselves. Why should I praise my mother?  
 Come — no dodges, no dragging it out; no more  
 hanging back from the stringing of the bow. Let us see it!  
 And I myself might make a trial of the bow as well:  
 for if I string it, and shoot through the iron,
- 115 then it would be no grief to me that my honored mother  
 should leave this house and follow another man — since I would stay  
 behind  
 man enough at last to lift my father's beautiful prizes."<sup>18</sup>  
 He spoke, and flung the crimson cloak from his shoulders,  
 rising to his full height, and put off the sharp sword from his shoulder.
- 120 First he set up the axes, digging one long trench  
 for all of them, trued to a line,  
 and stamped the earth firm round them. Amazement took every man  
 who watched — how squarely he set them, who had never seen it  
 before.<sup>19</sup>  
 Then he went and stood on the threshold and began to try the bow.
- 125 Three times he set it shaking, hot to draw it home;  
 three times he eased his force, hoping still in his heart  
 to string the cord and shoot through the iron.  
 And now, hauling a fourth time, his strength would have strung it —  
 but Odysseus shook his head, and checked him, keen as he was.<sup>20</sup>
- 130 And the sacred strength of Telemachus spoke among them again:  
 "Ah — so I will be a weakling and a coward all my days!  
 Or I am too young yet, and cannot trust my hands  
 to defend a man when someone picks a quarrel first."<sup>21</sup>  
 Come then, you who are stronger than I am —
- 135 come try the bow, and let us finish out the contest."  
 So speaking he set the bow away from him on the ground,  
 leaning it against the joined and polished panels,  
 with the swift arrow propped on the fine door-hook there,  
 and sat back down on the chair from which he had risen.
- 140 And Antinous spoke among them, Eupheithes' son:

- "Up, all you companions — in order, left to right,  
starting from where the wine is always poured."<sup>22</sup>  
So spoke Antinous, and his word pleased them well.  
And the first to rise was Leodes, the son of Oenops,  
145 who was their sacrifice-diviner, and always sat  
in the farthest corner by the beautiful mixing-bowl: to him alone  
their reckless outrages were hateful; he was indignant at all the  
suitors.<sup>23</sup>  
He now was first to take the bow and the swift arrow,  
and went and stood on the threshold and began to try the bow.  
150 He could not string it: long before that, hauling, his hands  
gave out — his soft, unhardened hands; and he said among the suitors:  
"Friends, I cannot bend it. Let another take it now.  
Many chief men this bow is going to strip<sup>24</sup>  
of life and breath — since truly it is better far  
155 to die than live on and miss the mark we gather here for  
day upon day, forever, waiting on hope.  
Now every man of you hopes, every heart is set  
on marrying Penelope, Odysseus' bedmate.  
But once he has tried the bow, and seen —  
160 well, let him woo some other fair-robed Achaean woman  
with his bride-gifts then, and seek her; and let this one  
marry the man who gives the most, and comes as her fate."  
So he spoke his say, and set the bow away from him,  
leaning it against the joined and polished panels,  
165 with the swift arrow propped on the fine door-hook there,  
and sat back down on the chair from which he had risen.  
And Antinous rebuked him, and spoke a word, and named him:  
"Leodes — what a word has slipped the fence of your teeth!<sup>25</sup>  
A dreadful word, a bitter one — I am angry just to hear it —  
170 that this bow, if you please, will strip our chief men  
of life and breath — because you cannot string it!  
No: your honored mother did not bear you the kind of man  
who has it in him to draw a bow and shoot;  
but the other lordly suitors will string it, and soon."  
175 So he spoke, and gave his orders to Melanthius the goatherd:  
"Look alive, Melanthius — light a fire in the hall,

- and set a big bench by it with a fleece on top,  
and bring out the great wheel of lard from the stores inside,  
so we young men can warm the bow, and grease it  
180 with the fat, and try it, and finish out the contest."  
So he spoke; and Melanthius quickly kindled the unwearying fire,  
and carried up the bench and set it there with a fleece on it,  
and brought out the great wheel of lard from the stores inside.  
With that the young men warmed the bow and made their trials — and  
still  
185 they could not string it: they fell far short of the strength it took.<sup>26</sup>  
But Antinous still held off, and godlike Eurymachus,  
the suitors' chiefs: in prowess they were far the best of them.<sup>27</sup>  
Now out of the house those two had gone together,  
the cowherd and the swineherd of godlike Odysseus,  
190 and after them Odysseus himself, the noble one, came out.  
And when they were outside the doors and the courtyard,  
he raised his voice and spoke to them with gentle words:  
"Cowherd — and you, swineherd — shall I say a thing to you,<sup>28</sup>  
or keep it to myself? My heart tells me to say it.  
195 What kind of men would you be, to fight for Odysseus,  
if he came from somewhere — like that, out of nowhere — some god  
bringing him?  
Would you fight for the suitors, or for Odysseus?  
Speak out, as your heart and spirit bid you."  
Then the cowherd answered him, the master of the oxen:  
200 "Father Zeus, if only you would accomplish this desire:  
that the man himself come back, and a god guide him home —<sup>29</sup>  
then you would learn my strength, and how my hands follow it!"  
And in the same way Eumaeus prayed to all the gods  
that Odysseus of the many designs might come home to his own house.  
205 And when he had proof of the true mind in both of them,  
he found words again, and said to them in answer:  
"He is home — here — I am the man myself. After suffering many  
pains,<sup>30</sup>  
I have come in the twentieth year to my fathers' land.  
And I know that of all my slaves, to you two only  
210 my coming is what you prayed for. Of the rest I have heard



- not one man praying that I come home again.<sup>31</sup>  
 So to you two I will tell the whole truth of what shall be.  
 If a god brings the haughty suitors down beneath my hands,  
 I will find wives for you both, and give you possessions,  
 215 and houses built near mine; and from that day  
 you shall be to me the companions and brothers of Telemachus.<sup>32</sup>  
 And come — I will show you a plain sign besides,  
 so you may know me for certain and trust it in your hearts:  
 the scar — the wound the boar dealt me with its white tusk  
 220 when I went to Parnassus with the sons of Autolycus."<sup>33</sup>
- So speaking, he drew the rags back from the great scar.  
 And when the two had seen it, and taken in each detail,  
 they wept, and threw their arms round thoughtful Odysseus,  
 and kissed his head and shoulders, welcoming him home;  
 225 and in the same way Odysseus kissed their heads and hands.<sup>34</sup>  
 And the light of the sun would have gone down on their weeping  
 had not Odysseus himself checked them, and said:<sup>35</sup>  
 "Enough of weeping and wailing — someone coming out  
 of the hall might see, and tell them there inside.
- 230 Go back in one at a time, not all together:  
 I first, you after. And let this be the signal:  
 all the others — all the lordly suitors — will refuse  
 to let the bow and quiver be given to me;  
 but you, noble Eumaeus, carry the bow up the hall  
 235 and set it in my hands; and tell the women  
 to bar the close-fitted doors of their quarters,  
 and if any one of them hears groaning or the crash of men  
 inside our walls, let her not run out,  
 but stay where she is, at her work, in silence.
- 240 And you, noble Philoetius: your charge is the courtyard gates —  
 bolt them with the bar, and quickly lash the fastening on."<sup>36</sup>  
 So speaking he entered the well-settled house  
 and went and sat on the stool from which he had risen;  
 and then the two slaves of godlike Odysseus came in too.
- 245 Eurymachus by now was handling the bow,  
 warming it this side and that at the glow of the fire —  
 and even so he could not string it. His proud heart groaned aloud,

- and bursting out in anger he spoke a word and named it:  
 "Damn it — here is a grief for me, for myself and for us all!
- 250 It is not the marriage I mourn so much, though that stings too:  
 there are plenty of other Achaean women, some right here  
 in sea-circled Ithaca, some in other towns.  
 No — it is that we fall so far short in strength  
 of godlike Odysseus that we cannot string
- 255 his bow. A disgrace for even men unborn to hear of!"<sup>37</sup>  
 Then Antinous answered him, Eupheithes' son:  
 "Eurymachus, it will not stand so — and you know it yourself.  
 Today, through all the land, is the feast of the god —  
 his holy day. Who could be bending bows? No —<sup>38</sup>
- 260 set it down and be easy. And the axes: why not leave them  
 standing, all of them? No one, I think, will carry them off —  
 no thief is coming into the hall of Laertes' son Odysseus.<sup>39</sup>  
 Come — let the cupbearer pour first-drops in the cups,  
 so we can make libation, and lay aside the curved bow;
- 265 and in the morning tell Melanthius the goatherd  
 to drive in goats, the pick of all his herds,  
 so we can lay thigh-pieces on the altar of Apollo, lord of the bow,  
 and then try the bow, and finish out the contest."  
 So spoke Antinous, and his word pleased them well.
- 270 And heralds poured water over their hands,  
 and young men crowned the mixing-bowls with drink  
 and served it round to all, with first-drops in the cups.  
 And when they had poured, and drunk as much as their hearts would  
 have,  
 Odysseus of the many designs, with craft in mind, spoke among them:
- 275 "Hear me, you suitors of the far-famed queen,  
 while I say what the heart in my breast commands.  
 To Eurymachus above all, and to godlike Antinous,  
 I make my plea — since he spoke this word too as it should be:  
 for now, let the bow rest; turn it over to the gods;
- 280 and in the morning the god will give the mastery to whom he will.<sup>40</sup>  
 But come — give me the polished bow, so among you  
 I can try my hands and my strength: whether the force  
 is still there, that once lived in my supple limbs,

- or wandering and neglect have destroyed it by now."<sup>41</sup>
- 285 So he spoke; and they were all outraged past measure,  
in dread that he would string the polished bow.<sup>42</sup>  
And Antinous rebuked him, and spoke a word, and named him:  
"You wretched stranger — not a grain of sense in you, not a trace!  
Is it not enough that you feast at your ease with us,  
290 the great ones — never stinted of the meal, listening in  
on all our speeches and our talk? No other stranger,  
no beggar, gets to listen to our speeches."<sup>43</sup>  
It is the wine that has you — the honey-sweet: it damages  
any man who gulps it wide-mouthed past his measure.
- 295 Wine — it was wine that maddened the Centaur, famous Eurytion,<sup>44</sup>  
in the hall of great-hearted Peirithous,  
on his visit to the Lapiths. And when the wine had maddened his wits,  
raving mad he did his evil in Peirithous' house;  
and grief seized the heroes, and they leapt up and dragged him  
300 out through the porch to the open air, and shore away  
his ears and nose with the pitiless bronze; and he, his wits  
destroyed, went off in his witless heart, hauling his ruin with him.  
From that came the feud between Centaurs and men;  
but he found the evil first for himself, heavy with wine.
- 305 Just so I proclaim great trouble for you, if you should string  
that bow. You will meet no kindness  
in this land of ours — we will pack you straight off in a black ship  
to King Echetus, the maimer of all mankind,<sup>45</sup>  
and out of his hands nothing will save you. Sit easy,  
310 drink, and do not set yourself against younger men."  
Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:  
"Antinous — it is not fine, and it is not just, to stint<sup>46</sup>  
the guests of Telemachus, whoever comes to this house.  
Do you think — if this stranger strings the great bow of Odysseus,  
315 trusting his hands and his own strength —  
that he will lead me home and make me his wife?  
He himself has no such hope in his breast."<sup>47</sup>  
Let none of you sit at the feast here grieving  
over that: it would not be seemly — no, and it is not thinkable."
- 320 Then Eurymachus, Polybus' son, answered her:

- "Daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded Penelope,  
it is not that we think he will lead you off — unthinkable —  
but we shrink from the talk of men and women:  
that one of the baser Achaeans may say someday,
- 325 'Men far weaker are wooing a blameless man's  
wife — and they cannot even string his polished bow;  
and then some other man, a wandering beggar, came  
and strung the bow with ease, and shot through the iron.'  
So they will say; and for us that would be shame heaped on shame."<sup>48</sup>
- 330 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:  
"Eurymachus — there is no fair fame in the land, and cannot be,  
for men who dishonor and devour the house  
of their better. Why count this thing your shame?<sup>49</sup>  
The stranger here is very tall, and firmly built,
- 335 and declares himself the son of a well-born father.  
Come — give him the polished bow. Let us see it.  
For I will say this outright, and it will be accomplished:  
if he strings it — if Apollo grants him that glory —  
I will dress him in a cloak and a tunic, fine clothing,<sup>50</sup>
- 340 and give him a sharp javelin, to keep off dogs and men,  
and a two-edged sword; and I will give him sandals for his feet,  
and send him wherever his heart and spirit bid him go."  
Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:  
"Mother mine — the bow: no Achaean has better right than I
- 345 to give it or to refuse it to whomever I will —  
not one of all who lord it through rocky Ithaca,  
nor in the islands over toward horse-grazing Elis:  
not one of them shall force me against my will, not even if I choose  
to give the stranger this bow outright, to carry off for good.
- 350 Go into the house and see to your own work,  
the loom and the distaff, and command your handmaids  
to go about their work. The bow belongs to men —  
to all men, and to me above all: mine is the power in this house."<sup>51</sup>  
In wonder, she went back into the house,
- 355 for she laid her son's clear-headed word to heart.  
Climbing to her upper room with her serving-women,  
she wept there for Odysseus, her dear husband, until

- gray-eyed Athena cast sweet sleep upon her eyelids.<sup>52</sup>  
 And the noble swineherd had taken up the curved bow and was carrying it —
- 360 and the suitors, all of them, burst out shouting through the halls;  
 and a man of the arrogant young men would say:  
 "Where are you carrying that curved bow, you pitiful swineherd —  
 you drifter? Soon enough, out with your pigs, alone, away from men,  
 the swift dogs you raised yourself will eat you — if Apollo
- 365 will only be gracious to us, and the other deathless gods."<sup>53</sup>  
 So they spoke; and he set the bow down where he stood, carrying it no further,  
 frightened, because the crowd of them was shouting through the halls.<sup>54</sup>
- But Telemachus, from the other side, called out his threat:  
 "Old father — carry the bow on. You will soon be sorry, obeying them all.
- 370 Watch out, or younger though I am I will chase you into the fields  
 pelting you with stones. In strength I am the better man.  
 If only I stood as far above all the suitors  
 in this house — in force of hands and strength —  
 I would soon send more than one of them off in misery,
- 375 out of our house: for they devise evils."  
 So he spoke; and all the suitors laughed at him sweetly,<sup>55</sup>  
 and let go their bitter anger against Telemachus.  
 And the swineherd carried the bow up the hall  
 and stood by thoughtful Odysseus and set it in his hands.
- 380 Then he called out the nurse Eurycleia and said:  
 "Telemachus commands you, watchful-minded Eurycleia:  
 bar the close-fitted doors of the women's hall,  
 and if any woman hears groaning or the crash of men  
 inside our walls, let her not run out,
- 385 but stay where she is, at her work, in silence."  
 So he spoke; and for her the word stayed wingless.<sup>56</sup>  
 And she barred the doors of the well-settled halls.  
 In silence Philoetius slipped out of the house  
 and barred the gates of the well-fenced courtyard.
- 390 Under the colonnade there lay a curved ship's cable

- of byblus fiber; with it he lashed the gates, and went back in,<sup>57</sup>  
 and went and sat on the stool from which he had risen,  
 with his eyes on Odysseus. And he was handling the bow already,  
 turning it round and round, testing it this way and that,  
 395 for worms that might have eaten the horn while its master was away.<sup>58</sup>  
 And a man would say, with a glance at his neighbor:  
 "Quite the connoisseur of bows! An expert eye — a thief's!<sup>59</sup>  
 No doubt he has bows like this one laid up at home —  
 or means to make one. Look how he turns it over,  
 400 this way and that — the vagrant schooled in trouble!"  
 And another of the arrogant young men would say:  
 "May all his profit in life come out exactly  
 as his luck in ever managing to string that thing!"<sup>60</sup>  
 So the suitors talked. But Odysseus of the many designs,  
 405 the moment he had hefted the great bow and eyed it everywhere —  
 as when a man skilled in the lyre and in singing  
 easily stretches a string around a new peg,  
 making the twisted sheep-gut fast at either end —  
 so without haste, without effort, Odysseus strung the great bow.<sup>61</sup>  
 410 Then his right hand took hold and tried the string,  
 and under his touch it sang sweet, like a swallow's voice.<sup>62</sup>  
 A great ache took the suitors; the color changed  
 in every face; and Zeus thundered loud, showing his signs.<sup>63</sup>  
 And much-enduring noble Odysseus was glad  
 415 that the son of crooked-counseled Cronos sent him an omen;  
 and he took up the swift arrow that lay bare on the table  
 beside him — the rest were stored inside the hollow quiver,  
 the ones the Achaeans were shortly going to taste.<sup>64</sup>  
 He set it on the bridge of the bow, drew back the string and the notched  
 butt  
 420 from the very stool where he sat, and let the arrow fly  
 with a straight aim, and did not miss a single axe —  
 from the first helve-ring clean on through: the arrow  
 heavy with bronze passed through and out. And he said to  
 Telemachus:<sup>65</sup>  
 "Telemachus — the guest who sits in your halls does not  
 425 disgrace you: I did not miss the mark, and I was not long

about stringing the bow. My strength stands yet unbroken —  
 not as the suitors' taunts would have it, in their disrespect.  
 But now it is time that supper too be made for the Achaeans,  
 while there is light — and after that, the other entertainments:  
 430 the dance and the lyre. For these are the garnish of a feast."<sup>66</sup>  
 He spoke, and signaled with his brows. And he slung on his sharp  
 sword,  
 Telemachus, the dear son of godlike Odysseus,  
 and closed his hand around his spear, and there beside him,  
 close by his chair, he stood — armed in the flashing bronze.<sup>67</sup>

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 21

- 1    l. 1 The opening names the double agency that runs the whole book: Athena puts it in Penelope's mind. Whose act is the contest? The line's last words refuse consolation: the bow is set out as "the contest, and the beginning of the slaughter" (ἀέθλια καὶ φόνου ἀρχήν) — prize and price in one breath. Whatever Penelope knows, the poem knows, and says so in line four.
- 2    l. 6 The key: bent, bronze, ivory-handled — the most lovingly detailed lock-hardware in ancient literature, and she takes it "in her strong hand" (χειρὶ παχείῃ), a formula elsewhere reserved for the thick hands of warriors (Ctesippus threw the ox-hoof with it, 20.299). The poem arms Penelope with an epithet before it arms her husband with the bow.
- 3    l. 12 "Groan-laden shafts" (στονόνεπτες ὀϊστοί) — the arrows carry their future tense in their epithet: freighted with the groans they will cause. Stored beside the treasures for twenty years, the quiver has been holding Book 22 in escrow.
- 4    l. 13 The bow's pedigree is a *xenia* tragedy in miniature: given by Iphitus in Lacedaemon — a guest-gift beginning a friendship the two men never got to use, because Heracles killed Iphitus *as a guest in his own house*, shameless "before the gods' watching eye, nor for the table he himself had set." The weapon that will punish the abuse of hospitality enters the poem wrapped in the paradigm crime against it. Even Heracles, son of Zeus, is filed here as *σχέτλιος* — the poem's morality outranks its heroes.
- 5    l. 20 Odysseus "a boy still," sent on embassy over a raid of three hundred sheep: the earliest datum in his biography besides the naming and the scar (19.393ff) — and it is debt-collection. The poem's economy is consistent from the cradle: he began his public life recovering stolen livestock, and today he finishes it the same way.
- 6    l. 27 The Heracles digression cuts both ways: it damns the guest-killer, and it quietly warns that even a hero's house can become an *abattoir* — which is what this house becomes by nightfall. The difference the poem insists on: Heracles killed his guest; Odysseus will kill the men who made themselves no guests at all.
- 7    l. 38 The bow never went to Troy: it stayed home, "a memorial of a beloved guest-friend," carried only on his own land. So the poem's climactic weapon is not war-gear but a relic of friendship — kept out of the epic's great war precisely so that it could wait here, domestic and sacred, for the war that matters: the defense of the house itself.
- 8    l. 48 The storeroom doors "bellowed like a bull at pasture" at the key's stroke: the house has a voice, and it lows like the herds everyone in it keeps stealing. Long shut, the room protests its opening — or announces it: the sound is a fanfare exactly as loud as an omen.
- 9    l. 55 She sits with the bow-case on her knees and weeps before drawing out "the master's bow" — the second time an object has stood in for the man (his clothes at 19.255ff; the bed still to come). She holds the bow as one holds a child or a corpse; then she carries it



to the suitors. The gesture contains the whole book: grief in the storeroom, statecraft in the hall.

- 10 *l. 63* The veil entrance, fourth and final performance (1.333–335; 16.415–416; 18.209–211): pillar, veil, two handmaids. Every prior entrance stopped something — a song, a plot, a mood. This one starts something: the formula that always marked her intervention in the men's world now delivers the instrument of its ending.
- 11 *l. 68* Her speech to the suitors is an indictment disguised as an invitation: you have eaten this house "without ever a pause," and in all these years could produce no pretext but wanting me. Then the terms, repeated verbatim from her midnight announcement (19.577–581), down to the sentence that broke on the beggar's ears: "I think I shall remember it even in my dreams."
- 12 *l. 75* "Whoever strings the bow most easily" — ῥῆϊτάτα: ease, not strength alone, is the criterion she sets, and ease is exactly how the poem stages the winner (409: "without haste, without effort"). Her contest specifies its victor in the adverb.
- 13 *l. 82* Eumaeus weeps taking the bow; Philoetius weeps at the sight of it. The two sworn men cry in public over their master's weapon minutes before they are recruited by their master's scar — grief as credentials, publicly filed. Antinous reads it as rustic sentimentality; the poem reads it as the muster-roll.
- 14 *l. 85* "Brains that stop at the day's end" (ἐφημέρια φρονέοντες) — Antinous' sneer at the herdsmen accidentally quotes the beggar's great doctrine (18.136–137: the mind of man is the day the father sends). What was wisdom in Odysseus' mouth is contempt in his: the suitor flings the poem's deepest anthropology as an insult at the men who will help kill him.
- 15 *l. 94* Antinous' memory — "I saw him myself... though I was still a witless child" — is the book's strangest tenderness: the ringleader is old enough to remember Odysseus, and the memory surfaces as awe ("there is no man in this whole company such as Odysseus was"). For one line he tells the truth about the house he is destroying; then he organizes the queue to take it.
- 16 *l. 98* The narrator hangs Antinous in open court: "he was to be the first to taste an arrow from the hands of blameless Odysseus." The tasting returns in the English at 418 for all of them (the Greek varies its verb). Twenty-one books of restraint, and the poem cannot keep its own secret the last three hundred-odd lines to the payoff — the prolepsis is a reader's mercy and a judge's sentence.
- 17 *l. 102* Telemachus' clowning — "Zeus has made me witless! ... I laugh, and enjoy it, with my witless heart" — is tactical: the armed conspirator plays the giddy boy so the room reads the day as farce. Under it, one true sentence stands at 110: "Why should I praise my mother?" — the son declining to auction his mother's worth to her buyers.
- 18 *l. 113* His secret motive, stated in the open where no one can hear it: if I string the bow, I could bear her leaving — the master's gear would still have a master in the house. The contest has a third contestant no one invited, playing for a different prize: not the bride but the succession — proof that the bow stays home whoever takes the wife.

- 19 *l. 120* The axes: one long trench, trued to a line, earth stamped firm — and amazement takes the room, "who had never seen it before." Never seen the trick, or never seen the boy do a man's engineering? Both: the set-up is itself a feat, executed from inherited instinct by a son who was an infant when the bow last sang. The stage crew for his father's masterpiece is his own blood.
- 20 *l. 128* The three pulls, and the fourth that "would have strung it — but Odysseus shook his head." The poem's quietest enormous moment: the succession is real — the boy is one haul from his father's equal — and it is deferred, not denied, by a headshake. Telemachus obeys an instruction no one else saw, swallowing the triumph of his life. The plot needs the bow in older hands today; the epilogue of the gesture is that someday it will not.
- 21 *l. 131* His cover-speech recycles his own words from 16.71–72 ("too young... cannot trust my hands to defend a man") — a self-description that was true then, deployed now as camouflage precisely because it no longer is. The poem lets us hear the difference between the sentence meant and the sentence performed.
- 22 *l. 141* "Left to right, starting from where the wine is poured" — Antinous organizes the failure procession with liturgical tidiness: sunwise, from the cupbearer's station, like a libation. The suitors do everything in feast-order to the end; the deaths, hours away, will begin with the man who set the rotation.
- 23 *l. 144* Leodes: the suitors' own diviner, seated "farthest in" by the mixing-bowl, the only one who hates their outrages. The poem builds an ethical gradient even inside the mob — and then makes its decent man's hands "soft, unhardened" priest's hands, first to fail. His plea at 22.310ff will cite exactly what the poem certifies here; Odysseus will answer that a diviner who stayed prayed daily for the master never to come home. Decency without departure, once again, saves no one.
- 24 *l. 152* Leodes' outburst is prophecy in its working clothes: "Many chief men this bow is going to strip of life and breath." He means it figuratively — the contest will kill their hopes and it were better to die than keep missing the mark. The diviner speaks truer than his own reading; the bow will take him literally.
- 25 *l. 168* Antinous answers the true prophecy with the household's shock-formula — "what a word has slipped the fence of your teeth!" (1.64's line, last used by Eurycleia to Odysseus' death-threat, 19.492). The formula for unspeakable words keeps attaching itself to speech that is exactly accurate.
- 26 *l. 184* The lard, the fire, the warming: the young men treat the great bow like a stiff boot — grease it, soften it, coax it. The technology of failure is lovingly itemized; what the bow wants is not fat but its owner. Meanwhile the two chiefs "held off" — rank as an excuse for postponing the test rank cannot pass.
- 27 *l. 186* "In prowess far the best of them" — the poem's flat concession that Antinous and Eurymachus are the real men of the company, granted at the moment both are dodging the trial. Best of the suitors is a measurement the bow is about to calibrate exactly.
- 28 *l. 193* The recruitment question is a masterpiece of operational caution: hypothetical ("if he came from somewhere"), theological ("some god bringing him"), binary, and

unsigned. He asks the two men to declare a side before revealing there is a side to declare. Philoetius answers with his 20.237 vow verbatim; Eumaeus with his standing prayer. Only then — "when he had proof of the true mind in both of them" — does the grammar change person.

- 29 l. 200 "That the man himself come back, and a god guide him home" — Philoetius unknowingly repeats Eumaeus' prayer at the fountain (17.243) word for word. The two loyalists have never coordinated; the formula system testifies that loyalty in this poem is one text with several readers.
- 30 l. 207 "He is home — here — I am the man myself" (ἔνδον μὲν δὴ ὅδ' αὐτὸς ἐγώ): the syntax stumbles homeward — *inside; this man; myself; I*. Four ways of saying the same noun, stacked, after twenty years of aliases. To his son he said "I am your father"; to his slaves he says "I am the man" — each audience gets the identity in the grammar it prayed in.
- 31 l. 209 "To you two only... Of the rest I have heard not one man praying that I come home." The intelligence file is cold: among all he has personally overheard in the disguise, the prayers for his return number two — and the loyalty roll he can vouch for is two herdsmen, a nurse, a son, and a wife. The killing, hours away, is scaled to that arithmetic.
- 32 l. 214 The promises: wives, possessions, houses built near his, and the title "companions and brothers of Telemachus." Nothing in Homer comes closer to a manumission scene — and what it offers is not freedom downward into mere liberty but elevation toward kinship: slave-brothers of the heir in everything but name. The poem's answer to the slavery it has documented so unflinchingly is not abolition (it cannot imagine that) but embrace.
- 33 l. 219 The scar again — shown now voluntarily, "so you may know me for certain": the wound Eurycleia found by accident becomes a credential presented on purpose. Same verse as 19.393: the boar, the white tusk, Parnassus, the sons of Autolycus. The body is the document; this is its third notarization (nurse, herdsmen; the fourth, for Laertes, waits at 24.331).
- 34 l. 223 The embrace is symmetrical: they kiss his head and shoulders, "and in the same way Odysseus kissed their heads and hands." The master kisses the slaves' hands — the hands he has just contracted for the fight. No other Homeric king kisses a slave; the poem spends the gesture here, where the class line matters most and holds least.
- 35 l. 226 "The light of the sun would have gone down on their weeping" — the same line that closed the father-son recognition (16.220). Reunions in this family run on past sundown unless someone stops them — there it was Telemachus, here Odysseus — happiness cut short on schedule. Grief-discipline is the family art: weep fully, then exactly stop.
- 36 l. 230 The orders, distributed by station: Eumaeus delivers the bow *against the room's will* and carries the word to Eurycleia to bar the women's hall; Philoetius bars the courtyard. Bow, women, gates — weapon, witnesses, exits. Twenty years of siegecraft compressed into three assignments — and the locking itself is done, as it should be, by the housekeeper's own hands (387).

- 37 l. 249 Eurymachus' grief is the truest sentence he ever speaks, arrived at for the vainest reason: "It is not the marriage I mourn so much... it is that we fall so far short of godlike Odysseus." The comparison is the disgrace — "for even men unborn to hear of." He has, for one moment, exactly measured himself; posterity got the report he feared, in this poem.
- 38 l. 258 Antinous' theology of postponement: it is the archer-god's holy day — "who could be bending bows?" The answer is sitting in the hall with the bow already promised to him. On Apollo's feast, Apollo's own instrument comes back to tune; the piety that defers the contest hands it to the one man the god's day fits.
- 39 l. 261 "No thief is coming into the hall of Laertes' son Odysseus" — Antinous reassures the room about the axes with the poem's finest unwitting joke: the man in the hall is not coming for the axes, is no thief (he owns them), and is the grandson of the greatest thief in Greece. Every clause wrong in a different direction.
- 40 l. 278 Odysseus seconds Antinous' motion — "since he spoke this word too as it should be" — praising the postponement he is about to make irrelevant. The courtesy is real strategy: by ratifying "tomorrow for the contest," he reframes his own request as no contest at all, just an old man's curiosity about his strength. The suitors' rules are always his best tools.
- 41 l. 282 "Whether the force is still there... or wandering and neglect have destroyed it" — the request wears the beggar's whole biography as its cover story, and it is also, under the mask, a true question. Twenty years, the sea, Calypso, the rags: the man does not entirely know what the trial will show. The poem lets the suspense be real even for its rigger.
- 42 l. 285 "In dread that he would string the polished bow": the room's fear has been gathering its evidence all along — the thighs and shoulders under the rags (18.66–74), Irus dropped with one careful blow. The dread is the truth in them that their mockery keeps down; they refuse him the bow because some animal part of every suitor has already recognized its owner.
- 43 l. 289 Antinous' catalogue of the beggar's privileges — he eats with "the great ones," he *hears our speeches* — offered as generosity, lands as evidence: the man has indeed heard everything. The suitor's boast of inclusion is the prosecution's exhibit list.
- 44 l. 295 The Centaur parable: Eurytion, wine-mad in Peirithous' hall, dragged through the porch, ears and nose shorn off — "he found the evil first for himself." Antinous means it as a warning to the drunk beggar; the poem means it as a mirror: a feast, an outrage, a mutilation in the doorway — it is Melanthius' exact fate (22.474ff) and the suitors' general one. He proclaims "great trouble for you if you string that bow"; the trouble is his, and the bow is already in the hall. The mythological threat is the book's most complete boomerang.
- 45 l. 308 Echetus again (= 18.85, the same verse): the offshore bogeyman-king as the suitors' all-purpose deterrent. Their imagination of punishment is always elsewhere, outsourced, someone else's hands; the punishment actually scheduled is local, in-house, and the man they are threatening holds its instrument.

- 46 l. 312 Penelope opens on Ctesippus' own line (20.294–295): "it is not fine, and it is not just, to stint the guests of Telemachus." The words that dressed an ox-hoof as a guest-gift come back washed — mock-courtesy re-minted as real justice, in the mouth of the woman of the house. The formula system runs its quiet court: the suitors' phrases keep being subpoenaed.
- 47 l. 317 "He himself has no such hope in his breast" — the poem's dramatic irony at its most delicious, and possibly its most double. She is right for the room's purposes (a beggar cannot mean marriage) and wrong in every other register: the stranger's whole hope is precisely to lead her home — he is already there. Whether some part of her says it *because* it can be said safely, the poem keeps sealed.
- 48 l. 324 Eurymachus' nightmare gossip — "a wandering beggar came and strung the bow with ease, and shot through the iron" — is an advance transcript of what is about to happen in this hall, accurate in every substance if not in wording. He drafts the case posterity will make and calls it the unbearable one. The poem grants him full authorship of his own disgrace: no bard said it better.
- 49 l. 331 Her retort dismantles the shame-logic at its root: men who "dishonor and devour the house of their better" have no fair fame left to protect — the reputational account they are guarding is already empty. It is the shortest complete moral audit of the suitors anyone delivers, and it comes from the person they propose to marry.
- 50 l. 338 The clothing-promise, final and fullest form: cloak and tunic, plus javelin, sword, sandals, and the fixed close "send him wherever his heart and spirit bid him go" (14.516–517 – 15.337–339 – 16.79–81 – 17.550 – now). The earlier promises clothed the beggar; Penelope's version arms him. She proposes, in open hall, to equip the stranger with weapons — one sentence before her son sends her upstairs and the equipping happens another way.
- 51 l. 350 Lines 350–353 repeat Telemachus' first assertion of manhood (1.356–359) with one word changed: *μῦθος* has become *τόξον* — "the word belongs to men" is now "the bow belongs to men." The poem measures the whole epic's arc in that substitution: in Book 1 the boy claimed speech; in Book 21 the man claims the weapon — and the claim's real content is operational: she must be out of the hall before the arrows. The famous line does its tender, brutal work twice at once — asserting the son's authority and saving the mother's life.
- 52 l. 354 Her exit = 1.360–364 entire, the refrain's last performance: wonder, the son's word laid to heart, the stairs, the weeping, Athena's sleep. She will sleep through the slaughter — the goddess's anesthesia, sparing her the hall she has managed for twenty years at the one hour it cannot be managed. When she next wakes, the poem will owe her a husband.
- 53 l. 362 The threat to Eumaeus — his own dogs will eat him among his pigs, "alone, away from men" — is the suitors' cruelty in its purest form: they curse the swineherd with the exact solitude in which his loyalty lives. The Apollo-clause tacked on ("if Apollo will only be gracious") keeps their piety current while they threaten a slave with dog-death on the god's feast day.

- 54 *l. 366* The plan's one wobble: Eumaeus, shouted at by the whole hall, sets the bow down mid-carry. The poem allows its most faithful man a moment of ordinary fear — a hallful of lords screaming at a slave — so that Telemachus can rescue the delivery, and so that we see the bow's last meters to its owner's hands are walked on courage, not script.
- 55 *l. 376* Telemachus saves the handoff with comedy: the mock-threat to stone the old swineherd back to the farm, the rueful wish to be stronger than the whole room. The suitors laugh "sweetly" — and their anger dissolves precisely as the bow completes its journey. He has learned to weaponize his own harmlessness: the boy-act buys the bow its last steps.
- 56 *l. 386* The wingless word, third flight (17.57; 19.29 and now, Eurycleia both these times): she obeys without a syllable and bars the doors. The formula for wordless obedience has become the sound of the trap closing — softly, on well-oiled hinges, with the housekeeper's own hands.
- 57 *l. 390* Philoetius bars the gates with a ship's cable of byblus — Egyptian papyrus rope, ocean gear. The sea that kept Odysseus from the house for ten years now lends its tackle to lock the house shut around his enemies: the poem's maritime half reaches ashore for one last knot.
- 58 *l. 393* The worm-check: the master turns his bow "this way and that," inspecting the horn for twenty years of beetle damage, in front of men who read the inspection as a vagrant's covetousness. It is the book's thesis in dumb-show: knowledge looks like presumption to those who cannot imagine the knower. He is not admiring the bow; he is auditing his own long absence.
- 59 *l. 397* "An expert eye — a thief's!" (ἐπίκλοπος): the mocker reaches for an insult and lands, blind, on genealogy — the man is Autolycus' grandson, heir of the master-thief "in thievery and the oath" (19.396). Taunt after taunt in this book lands as accidental documentary; the suitors have been right about him all day in every register but the one that counts.
- 60 *l. 401* The luck-wish — may his life's profit match his chance of stringing it — is the last kledon of the poem, and like all the others it executes exactly as worded: his profit and the stringing come out identical, both total. The suitors have now blessed him twice (18.112ff) and cursed him once, and every utterance has filed itself on his side of the ledger.
- 61 *l. 406* The stringing simile: as a singer stretches a new string on his lyre's peg — easy, familiar, both ends made fast — "so without haste, without effort, Odysseus strung the great bow." The poem's final self-portrait: bard and bowman are one craft, tension mastered into music. The man who told lies like truth (19.203, the poet's simile) now strings death like a lyre. Everything the Odyssey believes about skill — that its summit looks like ease — is in the two words ἄτερ σπουδῆς.
- 62 *l. 411* He plucks the string and it "sang sweet, like a swallow's voice": the bow speaks under its owner's thumb again, and the note is birdsong — and the swallow is the spring migrant, the bird that returns to the house it nested in. The whole homecoming compressed into an instrument-check; the room hears a chirp, the poem hears the year turning.

- 63 *l. 412* The triple response: the suitors' ache and change of color (their bodies, again, ahead of their minds — cf. 20.345ff); Zeus's thunder, second of the day (20.103), the god countersigning; and Odysseus "glad" — the same quiet joy he took in the kledones. Sky and flesh have both voted; only the arrow remains to publish the result.
- 64 *l. 416* The bare arrow on the table — singular, unquivered, lying in the open all through the feast like a loaded fact — "the rest... the ones the Achaeans were shortly going to taste" (in the English an echo of 98; the Greek varies its verb). The inventory is exact: one for the axes, the quiver for the house.
- 65 *l. 419* The shot: seated, from his stool, no stance, no rise — through all twelve, "from the first helve-ring clean on through." The contest specified ease (75); the champion performs it from a chair. Every failed suitor stood braced on the threshold; the owner does it sitting down, the way a man signs his name.
- 66 *l. 428* The coded speech: "supper... while there is light — and after that... the dance and the lyre: the garnish of a feast." Every noun is a codeword the room cannot read: the supper is the "graceless" one promised at 20.392–394; the lyre has just been strung; the dance is Book 22. He announces the massacre in the vocabulary of hospitality — the language the suitors abused for four years, handed back to them with its meanings loaded.
- 67 *l. 431* The nod — the eyebrow-signal the son has been watching for — and the final tableau: the father seated with the strung bow, the son standing at his shoulder "armed in the flashing bronze." No suitor has moved; the room still thinks it is at dinner. The book ends in the drawn breath between the omen and the arrow — Book 22 will name the target eight lines in.





## Odyssey — Book 22

*The slaughter in the hall.*

- But he stripped himself of his rags, Odysseus of the many designs,<sup>1</sup>  
 and leapt to the great threshold with the bow and the quiver  
 full of arrows, and poured out the swift shafts  
 there at his feet, and spoke among the suitors:
- 5 "So: that contest-past-all-contest is accomplished.<sup>2</sup>  
 Now for another mark — one no man has ever hit —  
 and I shall know if I strike it: if Apollo gives me that glory."  
 He spoke, and leveled the bitter arrow at Antinous.  
 And he — he was that instant lifting a beautiful cup,  
 10 a golden one, two-eared, turning it in his hands  
 to drink the wine; and slaughter was not in his thoughts:<sup>3</sup>  
 for who would think, among men at dinner, that one man  
 in the middle of many — however strong he might be —  
 would bring on him foul death and the black doom?
- 15 But Odysseus took aim at his throat, and shot,  
 and the point went clean on through the soft of the neck.  
 He sagged to one side; the cup dropped out of his hand  
 as the arrow hit; and at once a thick jet came  
 up through his nostrils — human blood; and quick, with a kick,  
 20 he shoved the table from him and spilled the food to the floor:  
 the bread and the roast meats fouled in it. And the suitors  
 broke into uproar through the house when they saw the man fallen;  
 up from their chairs they started, driven through the hall,  
 eyes darting every way along the well-built walls —
- 25 and nowhere was there a shield or a strong spear to seize.<sup>4</sup>  
 And they raged at Odysseus with words of fury:  
 "Stranger, you shoot at men — and it will cost you! No more contests  
 for you: now your own sheer destruction is certain.  
 The man you have killed was the very noblest of the young men  
 30 of Ithaca. For this the vultures will eat you — here."  
 So each man guessed: for indeed they thought he had killed  
 the man unwilling. The fools — they had not seen it yet:

that on every one of them the cords of death were fastened.<sup>5</sup>

Then, glaring from under his brows, Odysseus of the many designs replied:

35 "You dogs! You kept on saying I would never come home again<sup>6</sup>  
out of the land of Troy: and so you sheared away my house,  
and lay with my slave-women by force,  
and courted my own wife while I was still alive,  
fearing neither the gods who hold wide heaven

40 nor any vengeance of men, to come hereafter.  
Now on you — on all of you — the cords of death are fastened."  
So he spoke; and the pale terror took hold of them all,  
and every man peered round for a way to escape sheer destruction.  
Only Eurymachus found words, and answered him:

45 "If you are truly Odysseus of Ithaca, come home again,<sup>7</sup>  
then all you say is just — all the Achaeans have done,  
reckless things in plenty in the hall, in plenty on the land.  
But there he lies — the man to blame for everything:  
Antinous. He was the one who set these doings on —

50 not so much needing the marriage, or wanting it,  
but with another purpose, which the son of Cronos never granted:  
to be king himself in the land of well-built Ithaca,  
and to ambush your son and kill him.

Now he is killed, as was his portion. You — spare your own  
55 people; and we hereafter, making it good through the land,  
all that has been drunk and eaten in your halls,  
each of us bringing a payment of twenty oxen's worth,  
will pay you back in bronze and gold, until your heart  
is warmed. Till then, no one could blame your anger."<sup>8</sup>

60 Then, glaring from under his brows, Odysseus of the many designs replied:

"Eurymachus — not if you handed over all your patrimonies,  
everything you now have, and added more from elsewhere,  
not even so would I hold my hands back from the killing  
before the suitors had paid for the whole trespass."<sup>9</sup>

65 Now the choice lies before you: fight me face to face,  
or run — whoever can slip his death and doom.  
But I do not think one man of you escapes sheer destruction."

So he spoke; and their knees went slack where they stood, and their hearts.

And Eurymachus called out among them a second time:

70 "Friends — this man will not now hold his invincible hands.

He has the polished bow and the quiver: he will shoot from the smooth threshold until he has killed us all.

Then let our minds be on battle! Draw your swords, put up the tables against the arrows of quick death,

75 and let us all go at him in one body — see if we can shove him off the threshold and out of the doors, then through the town, and the alarm raised at once! Then this man would soon have shot his last."<sup>10</sup>

So speaking, he drew his sharp sword,

80 bronze, two-edged, and leapt at him with a blood-freezing yell. But in the same instant noble Odysseus let the arrow fly, and struck his chest beside the nipple, and drove the swift shaft into his liver. Out of his hand the sword dropped to the ground; he doubled over the table

85 and crumpled, sprawling across it, and spilled the food to the floor and the two-eared cup. His forehead beat the earth in his heart's agony; both feet kicked out, rattling the chair; and the mist poured down over his eyes.<sup>11</sup>

Then Amphinomus went for glorious Odysseus,

90 charging him head-on, his sharp sword drawn, to see if he might give way from the doors. But Telemachus was too quick: he caught him from behind with the bronze spear square between the shoulders, and drove it through his chest, and he fell with a crash, and struck the ground full with his forehead.<sup>12</sup>

95 And Telemachus sprang back, leaving the long-shadowed spear there in Amphinomus: for he feared that as he pulled the long spear out, some Achaean might rush in and cut him with a sword, or strike him as he stooped.

He ran, and came quickly to his dear father,

100 and standing close he spoke winged words:

"Father — now I will bring you a shield and two spears and a helmet all of bronze, fitted to your temples; and I will arm myself as I go, and give the swineherd

- the same, and the cowherd. Armored is better."
- 105 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 "Run — bring them, while I still have arrows to fight with,  
 or they will force me from the doors, one man alone."  
 So he spoke; and Telemachus obeyed his dear father  
 and went to the storeroom where the famous arms were lying.
- 110 He took out four shields, and eight spears,  
 and four bronze helmets thick with horsehair,  
 and came carrying them fast to his dear father.  
 He girded the bronze on his own body first,  
 and in the same way the two slaves put on the fine armor,  
 115 and they took their stand around Odysseus — the deep mind, the  
 shifting counsels.<sup>13</sup>  
 And he, so long as he had arrows to fight with,  
 kept aiming, and dropping suitors in his own house,  
 one man after another: they fell in heaps.  
 But when the arrows failed the master archer,  
 120 he leaned the bow against the doorpost of the strong-built hall,  
 to stand there by the shining entrance-wall,  
 and threw about his shoulders a shield of four hides,  
 and set on his mighty head a well-made helmet,  
 horsehair-crested, the plume nodding terror from the top,  
 125 and took up two strong spears, headed with bronze.<sup>14</sup>  
 Now there was a raised side-door in the well-built wall,<sup>15</sup>  
 and level with the top of the threshold of the strong hall  
 an exit to a passage, closed with well-fitted boards.  
 Odysseus set the noble swineherd to watch it,  
 130 posted close: it was the single way out.  
 And Agelaus spoke to them all, putting the word to everyone:  
 "Friends — could not someone climb through the side-door  
 and get word to the people, and the alarm be raised at once?  
 Then this man would soon have shot his last."
- 135 Then Melanthius the goatherd answered him:  
 "No way, Agelaus, Zeus-nurtured: the fine gates of the courtyard  
 are terribly near, and the mouth of the passage is cruel:  
 one man could hold it against all comers — any man with strength in  
 him.

- No — wait: let me bring you armor from the storeroom  
 140 to harness you. For it is in there, I am certain — nowhere else —  
 that Odysseus and his shining son have stowed the arms."<sup>16</sup>  
 So speaking, Melanthius the goatherd climbed up  
 through the smoke-vents of the hall to the storerooms of Odysseus,  
 and took out twelve shields, as many spears,  
 145 as many bronze helmets thick with horsehair,  
 and came back fast and gave them to the suitors.  
 And then the knees of Odysseus went slack, and his heart,  
 when he saw them buckling on the armor and brandishing  
 the long spears in their hands: the work now looked great to him.<sup>17</sup>  
 150 And quickly he spoke winged words to Telemachus:  
 "Telemachus — one of the women in the halls is stoking  
 the evil war against us — that, or it is Melanthius."  
 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 "Father, the fault is mine — my own, no other's —  
 155 I left the storeroom's close-fitted door  
 standing ajar. Their lookout was sharper than I was."<sup>18</sup>  
 Go, noble Eumaeus: close the storeroom door,  
 and find out whether it is one of the women doing this,  
 or Dolius' son Melanthius — he is the one I think it is."  
 160 So they spoke to one another of such things.
- And Melanthius the goatherd went again to the storeroom  
 to bring out more fine armor. But the noble swineherd marked him,  
 and quickly said to Odysseus, standing near:  
 "Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices —  
 165 there he goes again, that ruinous man, the one we guessed:  
 into the storeroom. Tell me straight out:  
 do I kill him — if I prove the better man —  
 or bring him here to you, to pay for the trespasses,  
 the many, that man has schemed in your house?"  
 170 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 "I and Telemachus will hold the lordly suitors  
 penned inside the hall, rage as they may.  
 You two: twist his feet and hands behind him,  
 throw him into the storeroom, tie boards fast at his back,  
 175 make a braided rope fast to him, and haul him

- up the tall pillar, up close to the roof-beams —  
 so that he lives on a long while, suffering hard pains."<sup>19</sup>  
 So he spoke; and they listened well and obeyed:  
 they went to the storeroom — the man inside did not see them —
- 180 and there he was, hunting armor in the room's far corner,  
 while the two of them stood waiting either side of the doorposts.  
 And as Melanthius the goatherd came over the threshold,  
 in one hand carrying a beautiful helmet,  
 in the other a broad shield, an old one, mottled with mildew —
- 185 the hero Laertes' shield, which he carried in his young days,  
 long since laid by, the stitches of its straps rotted out —<sup>20</sup>  
 the two of them sprang and seized him, and dragged him in by the hair,  
 and threw him to the floor for all his anguish of heart,  
 and bound his feet and hands with a heart-grieving knot,
- 190 wrenched hard behind him, through and through, as ordered  
 by Laertes' son, much-enduring noble Odysseus;  
 then they made a braided rope fast to him, and hauled him  
 up the tall pillar, up close to the roof-beams.  
 And taunting him you spoke, Eumaeus the swineherd:<sup>21</sup>
- 195 "Now you will keep watch indeed, Melanthius — the whole night  
 through,  
 stretched out on the sort of soft bed you deserve;  
 and the early-born one out of Ocean's streams will not  
 slip past you as she comes, on her golden throne, at the hour  
 you drive in goats for the suitors, to make their feast in the hall."
- 200 So he was left there, racked in the deadly binding;  
 and the two got into their armor, shut the shining door,  
 and went back to Odysseus — the deep mind, the shifting counsels.  
 There they stood, breathing fury: on the threshold  
 four men; inside the hall, many men, and good ones.
- 205 And now Athena, daughter of Zeus, came near them,  
 likened to Mentor in body and in voice.  
 Odysseus was glad at the sight of her, and said:  
 "Mentor — beat off ruin! Remember your old companion,  
 who did you good service — and you my own age-mate!"<sup>22</sup>
- 210 So he spoke, guessing it was Athena, rouser of armies.  
 And the suitors on their side bellowed through the hall,

- Agelaus, Damastor's son, first to threaten her:  
 "Mentor — don't let Odysseus talk you around  
 into fighting the suitors and defending him.
- 215 For here is how I think our purpose will be accomplished:  
 when we have killed these two, father and son,  
 you will be killed with them — for the things you are minded  
 to do in this hall. Your own head will pay the price.  
 And when the bronze has stripped the force from all of you,  
 220 everything you own, indoors and out,  
 we will pool with the goods of Odysseus. Your sons  
 we will not let live in your halls; your daughters  
 and your true-hearted wife will not walk free in the town of Ithaca."<sup>23</sup>  
 So he spoke; and Athena's heart grew angrier yet,  
 225 and she lashed Odysseus with words of fury:  
 "Odysseus — where is your strength gone? Where is the fight in you —  
 you who for Helen's sake, the white-armed, the nobly fathered,  
 nine years on end battled the Trojans without a break  
 and killed many men in the terrible fighting?
- 230 By your counsel the wide-wayed city of Priam was taken!  
 How is it that now, come home to your own house and goods,  
 face to face with the suitors, you whimper about being brave?<sup>24</sup>  
 Here, old friend — stand by me and watch the work,  
 and learn what kind of man, among enemy fighters,  
 235 Mentor, Alcimus' son, is at repaying kindness."  
 She spoke — and did not yet grant victory outright to either side,  
 but went on testing the strength and fight  
 of Odysseus and of his glorious son.  
 And she herself darted up to the roof-beam of the smoke-stained hall  
 240 and perched there — like a swallow, face-on.<sup>25</sup>  
 Now Agelaus, Damastor's son, rallied the suitors,  
 with Eurynomus, Amphimedon, Demoptolemus,  
 Peisander Polycctor's son, and Polybus the shrewd:  
 for these were far the best of the suitors in prowess,  
 245 of all who still lived and fought for their lives —  
 the rest the bow and the crowding arrows had brought down.  
 And Agelaus spoke to them all, putting the word to everyone:  
 "Friends — now this man's invincible hands will stop.

- Mentor has left him — after the empty boasting —  
 250 and they are alone at the outer doors.  
 So do not throw your long spears all together:  
 come — you six throw first, and see if Zeus  
 will grant that Odysseus be hit, and we win the glory.  
 The rest are no concern, once that man falls."<sup>26</sup>
- 255 So he spoke; and they all threw as he ordered,  
 hungry for it. And Athena made every cast come to nothing:  
 one man's spear struck the doorpost of the strong-built hall,  
 another's the close-fitted door itself,  
 another's ash shaft, heavy with bronze, slammed into the wall.
- 260 And when they had weathered the suitors' spears,  
 much-enduring noble Odysseus began among his men:  
 "Friends — now it is mine to say it: throw!  
 Into the crowd of the suitors — men wild to strip our corpses  
 on top of the wrongs they did before."<sup>27</sup>
- 265 So he spoke; and they all threw their sharp spears,  
 aiming straight ahead: Odysseus killed Demoptolemus;  
 Telemachus, Euryades; the swineherd, Elatus;  
 and the man in charge of the cattle killed Peisander.  
 All of those together bit the vast floor with their teeth,
- 270 and the suitors fell back into the deep of the hall;  
 and the others charged, and pulled their spears from the corpses.  
 Again the suitors threw their sharp spears,  
 hungry for it; and Athena made the many casts come to nothing:  
 one man's spear struck the doorpost of the strong-built hall,
- 275 another's the close-fitted door itself,  
 another's ash shaft, heavy with bronze, slammed into the wall.  
 But Amphimedon caught Telemachus on the wrist —  
 a graze: the bronze just broke the surface of the skin;  
 and Ctesippus, over the shield, scratched Eumaeus
- 280 on the shoulder with his long spear: it skipped and fell to earth.<sup>28</sup>  
 Then those around Odysseus — the deep mind, the shifting counsels —  
 threw their sharp spears into the crowd of the suitors:  
 and this time Eurydamas fell to Odysseus, sacker of cities;  
 Amphimedon to Telemachus; Polybus to the swineherd;
- 285 and then Ctesippus fell to the man in charge of the cattle,



struck full in the chest; and he crowed over him:

"Son of Polytherses — you lover of a good jeer! — never again  
give way to your folly and talk big. Leave the word  
to the gods: they are far stronger than you.

290 This is your guest-gift in return — to match the ox-hoof  
you gave godlike Odysseus once, when he begged through his own  
hall."<sup>29</sup>

So spoke the herdsman of the spiral-horned cattle. And Odysseus  
wounded Damastor's son, close in, with the long spear;  
and Telemachus wounded Leocritus, Evenor's son,

295 clean in the flank with his spear, and drove the bronze through:  
he pitched forward and struck the ground full with his forehead.  
And now Athena raised the aegis that wastes mankind,<sup>30</sup>

high from the roof; and their wits scattered in terror,  
and they stampeded through the hall like a herd of cattle

300 when the darting gadfly falls on them and whirls them wild  
in the season of spring, when the long days come in.

And the others — like vultures with hooked claws and curving beaks  
that come down out of the mountains on the smaller birds:  
these skim the plain, cowering away from the clouds,

305 but the vultures stoop and kill them; no defense,  
no flight — and men delight to watch the hunting:  
so those four, rushing the suitors through the house,  
struck them down left and right; and hideous groaning rose  
as heads were smashed, and the whole floor smoked with blood.

310 But Leodes ran in and caught Odysseus by the knees,  
and clasping them in supplication spoke winged words:

"By your knees, Odysseus — respect me, pity me!

I tell you I never said a word to any woman

in your halls, never did one reckless thing — no: I kept trying

315 to stop the others, the suitors, when one would do such things.

But they would not listen, would not hold their hands from evil,  
and so through their own recklessness they have met an ugly fate.

And I, their sacrifice-diviner, having done nothing,

am to lie down with them: no thanks, hereafter, for good service!"<sup>31</sup>

320 Then, glaring from under his brows, Odysseus of the many designs  
replied:

- "If you declare yourself their sacrifice-diviner,  
 then many a time, no doubt, you must have prayed in my halls  
 that the accomplishment of my sweet homecoming be far away —  
 that my dear wife go with you, and bear you children.
- 325 For that you shall not slip beneath a death that lays men low."<sup>32</sup>  
 So speaking, he took up in his strong hand a sword  
 that lay there — Agelaus had dropped it to the ground  
 as he was killed — and drove it through the middle of his neck:  
 and while he was still speaking, his head mixed with the dust.<sup>33</sup>
- 330 But the singer still dodged the black doom — Terpes' son,  
 Phemius, who sang among the suitors under compulsion.<sup>34</sup>  
 He stood with the clear lyre in his hands  
 close by the side-door, and his mind was split two ways:  
 whether to slip out of the hall to the great altar of Zeus
- 335 of the Courtyard, and sit there on the masoned stone  
 where Laertes and Odysseus had burned so many  
 thighbones of oxen — or rush forward and clasp Odysseus' knees.  
 And as he weighed it, this seemed to him the better way:  
 to take hold of the knees of Laertes' son Odysseus.
- 340 So he set the hollow lyre down on the ground  
 between the mixing-bowl and the silver-studded chair,<sup>35</sup>  
 and rushed forward himself and caught Odysseus by the knees,  
 and clasping them in supplication spoke winged words:  
 "By your knees, Odysseus — respect me, pity me!
- 345 On you yourself the grief will fall hereafter, if you kill  
 a singer — me — who sing for gods and for men.  
 I am self-taught: a god has planted in my heart<sup>36</sup>  
 all the pathways of song; and I am fit to sing beside you  
 as beside a god. Do not be hungry to cut my throat.
- 350 And Telemachus would tell you this — your own dear son:  
 that it was never by my will, never for want of mine,  
 that I came to your house to sing at the suitors' feasts:  
 they were more, and stronger — they marched me here by force."  
 And the sacred strength of Telemachus heard him,
- 355 and quickly spoke to his father, standing near:  
 "Stop! He is guiltless — do not cut him with the bronze.  
 And Medon the herald let us save as well, who always

- cared for me in our house when I was a child —  
 unless Philoetius has killed him already, or the swineherd,  
 360 or he met you as you stormed along the hall."<sup>37</sup>  
 So he spoke; and Medon heard him — a man of sensible mind —  
 for he lay cowering under a chair, wrapped up  
 in a fresh-flayed oxhide, dodging the black doom.  
 Up from under the chair he came at once, stripped off the oxhide,  
 365 and rushed forward and caught Telemachus by the knees,  
 and clasping them in supplication spoke winged words:  
 "Friend — here I am: myself! Hold back, and tell your father,  
 before in his overmastering strength he cuts me down with the sharp  
 bronze  
 in his rage at the suitor-men — the men who sheared away  
 370 his goods in the halls, and honored you not at all, the fools."<sup>38</sup>  
 And Odysseus of the many designs smiled at him and said:  
 "Take heart: this man has pulled you clear and saved you —  
 so you may know in your heart, and tell another too,  
 how doing good outruns doing evil, and by far.  
 375 Now out of the hall with you, and sit in the courtyard,  
 away from the slaughter — you and the singer of many songs —  
 while I finish in the house the work that I must."<sup>39</sup>  
 So he spoke; and the two of them went out of the hall  
 and sat down by the altar of great Zeus,  
 380 peering about on every side, expecting death each moment.  
 And Odysseus peered through his own house, for any man  
 still living, hiding there, dodging the black doom.  
 But he saw them all, the whole count of them, in blood and dust  
 fallen — so many, like fish that fishermen<sup>40</sup>  
 385 have hauled from the gray sea in the mesh of a net  
 onto the curved beach: heaped on the sand they lie,  
 all of them, aching for the waves of the sea,  
 and the shining Sun takes the life out of them:  
 so the suitors lay heaped on one another.  
 390 Then Odysseus of the many designs said to Telemachus:  
 "Telemachus — go, call me the nurse Eurycleia,  
 so I can tell her the word that is on my mind."  
 So he spoke; and Telemachus obeyed his dear father,

- and rattling the door he called the nurse Eurycleia:  
 395 "Up with you, and come, old woman born long ago —  
 you who are overseer of our serving-women in the halls.  
 Come: my father calls you; he has something to say."  
 So he spoke; and for her the word stayed wingless.<sup>41</sup>  
 She opened the doors of the well-settled halls  
 400 and came; and Telemachus led the way before her.  
 And she found Odysseus among the bodies of the slain,  
 spattered with blood and gore, like a lion<sup>42</sup>  
 that comes from feeding on an ox of the farmstead:  
 all his chest, and his cheeks on either side,  
 405 are bloody, and he is terrible to look in the face:  
 so was Odysseus spattered — feet, and hands above them.  
 And she — when she saw the corpses and the sea of blood,  
 she opened her mouth to raise the cry of triumph: such a work  
 she saw accomplished. But Odysseus checked her, and held her back,  
 410 hot as she was, and spoke winged words to her:  
 "In your own heart rejoice, old woman — and hold it in: no cries.  
 It is unholy to glory over slaughtered men.  
 These men the doom of the gods has broken, and their own ruthless  
 deeds:  
 for they honored nobody on this earth,  
 415 bad man or good, whoever came among them —  
 and so through their own recklessness they have met an ugly fate.  
 But come now, name me the women of the halls:  
 which of them dishonor me, and which are guiltless."<sup>43</sup>  
 Then the dear nurse Eurycleia answered him:  
 420 "Then I will tell you, child, the whole truth of it.  
 You have fifty serving-women in your halls —  
 slave-women we have taught to work their work,  
 to card the wool and to bear the lot of slavery.  
 Of these, twelve in all have walked the road of shamelessness:  
 425 no respect for me — none for Penelope herself.  
 Telemachus is only newly grown; his mother  
 would not let him give commands to the serving-women.  
 But come — let me climb to the bright upper room  
 and tell your wife. Some god has laid a sleep on her."<sup>44</sup>

- 430 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
 "Do not wake her yet. Tell them to come here —  
 the women who all this while contrived their shamelessness."  
 So he spoke; and the old woman went off down the hall  
 to carry word to the women and hurry them along.
- 435 And he called Telemachus to his side, and the cowherd,  
 and the swineherd, and spoke winged words to them:  
 "Begin carrying out the dead, and set the women to it;  
 and after that, the beautiful chairs and the tables —  
 have them cleaned with water and porous sponges.
- 440 And when you have set the whole house in order,  
 lead the serving-women out of the strong-built hall  
 to the spot between the roundhouse and the good courtyard fence,  
 and cut them down with the long swords, till you have stripped  
 the life from all of them, and they have forgotten Aphrodite —
- 445 the sweetness they took under the suitors, coupling in secret."<sup>45</sup>  
 So he spoke; and the women came in a huddle, all of them,  
 wailing terribly, the big tears streaming down.  
 First they carried out the corpses of the dead  
 and laid them under the portico of the well-fenced courtyard,
- 450 propping them against each other; and Odysseus commanded,  
 hurrying the work himself; and they carried them out — under force.<sup>46</sup>  
 And after that they cleaned the beautiful chairs and the tables  
 with water and porous sponges;  
 and Telemachus, with the cowherd and the swineherd,
- 455 scraped the floor of the strong-founded house  
 with hoes, and the slave-women carried the scrapings out of doors.  
 And when they had set the whole hall in order,  
 they led the serving-women out of the strong-built hall  
 to the spot between the roundhouse and the good courtyard fence,
- 460 and penned them in the narrow place, where there was no way out.  
 And clear-headed Telemachus began, and spoke among them:  
 "By no clean death will I take the lives of these —  
 these who poured their insults on my head,  
 on my own mother, and slept beside the suitors."<sup>47</sup>
- 465 So he spoke; and he made the cable of a dark-prowed ship  
 fast to a great pillar, and flung it round the roundhouse,

- stretched taut, up high, so no foot could reach the ground.  
 And as when thrushes with their long wings, or doves,  
 strike into a snare set up in a thicket,
- 470 heading in to roost, and a hateful bed receives them:  
 so the women held their heads in a row, and round every  
 neck a noose was laid, that they might die most pitiably.  
 They kicked out with their feet a little while — not very long.<sup>48</sup>  
 And Melanthius they dragged out through the porch and the courtyard:
- 475 they sliced away his nose and ears with the pitiless bronze  
 and tore out his genitals, raw meat for the dogs to share,  
 and lopped off his hands and feet in their fury of heart.<sup>49</sup>  
 Then they washed their own hands and feet  
 and went into the house to Odysseus: the work was accomplished.
- 480 And he spoke to the dear nurse Eurycleia:  
 "Bring sulfur, old woman — the cure of evils — and bring me fire,  
 so I can fume the hall with it. And bid Penelope  
 come down to me, with her attendant women;  
 and rouse all the serving-women in the house to come."<sup>50</sup>
- 485 Then the dear nurse Eurycleia answered him:  
 "Yes, my child — all this you have said as it should be.  
 But come, let me bring you clothes, a cloak and a tunic:  
 do not stand in your halls like this, with your broad shoulders  
 wrapped in rags. That would be a thing to blame."<sup>51</sup>
- 490 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
 "First of all: let there be fire for me in the hall."  
 So he spoke; and the dear nurse Eurycleia did not disobey,  
 but brought the fire and the sulfur; and Odysseus  
 fumed through and through the hall, the house, the courtyard.<sup>52</sup>
- 495 And the old woman went off up through the beautiful house of  
 Odysseus  
 to carry word to the women and hurry them along;  
 and out of the hall they came, torches in their hands,<sup>53</sup>  
 and they poured around Odysseus, and embraced him,  
 and kissed his head and his shoulders, welcoming him,
- 500 catching and clasping his hands; and a sweet longing seized him  
 to weep and to sob: for in his heart he knew them all.

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 22

- 1    *l. 1* The book opens on the shedding of the rags — γυμνώθη, "he was stripped bare": the disguise falls in a single verb, and the leap to the threshold follows in the same breath. Nine books of costume come off in half a line; the arrows pour out at his feet like the truth arriving all at once.
- 2    *l. 5* "That contest-past-all-contest is accomplished. Now for another mark — one no man has ever hit": the transition from game to war is announced as a change of target. The prayer-tag — "if Apollo gives me that glory" — keeps the archer-god's feast day in play: he asks the god of the day for the day's real event.
- 3    *l. 9* Antinous dies mid-luxury: the golden two-eared cup just raised in his hands, "and slaughter was not in his thoughts." The poem pauses to defend his obliviousness — who could imagine one man among so many? — and by defending it convicts the whole party: their safety-in-numbers was their moral arithmetic all along. The beggar's curse (17.475–476: death "before any wedding") and the narrator's sentence (21.98–100: first to taste an arrow) are both paid here, at the throat, through the soft of the neck.
- 4    *l. 24* "Nowhere was there a shield or a strong spear to seize" — the smoke-speech's payoff, one book late: the walls the suitors scan were emptied by two men in Book 19 under a golden lamp. The furniture of their doom was arranged while they slept at home.
- 5    *l. 31* The suitors' first theory — the beggar shot a man by accident — is a masterpiece of self-blindness, and the narrator files it under the poem's oldest word for them: νήπιοι, fools. The cords-of-death line (33) then returns in Odysseus' own mouth at 41 — the narrator's judgment become the executioner's sentence, re-inflected for the man who will carry it out.
- 6    *l. 35* "You dogs!" — the reveal-speech is an indictment in four counts: the house sheared away, the slave-women forced, the wife courted with the husband alive, and the double fearlessness — no fear of gods, no fear of men's vengeance to come. It is the poem's whole case-file read aloud in six lines; the verdict ("the cords of death are fastened") had already been delivered by the narrator. Note what he does not say: his name. The proof is the shot; identity here is competence.
- 7    *l. 45* Eurymachus' "if you are truly Odysseus" concedes and negotiates in one motion — every charge admitted ("all you say is just"), the blame posthumously assigned to Antinous, complete with a new theory (he wanted the kingship and the boy's death, not the bride), and then the offer: twenty oxen per man, bronze and gold "until your heart is warmed." It is the best speech available to a doomed man — and an exact repetition of his method with Penelope (16.434ff): soothe, flatter, redirect, lie.
- 8    *l. 54* "Now he is killed, as was his portion" — ἐν μοίρῃ: Eurymachus files his friend's corpse under destiny while it is still warm, the better to argue the account closed. The

suitors' solidarity dissolves at the first arrow; the second-in-command's eulogy for the first is a plea-bargain.

- 9 *l. 61* The refusal is absolute and financial: not all their patrimonies, "and added more from elsewhere," would stay his hands "before the suitors had paid for the whole trespass" (ὑπερβασίην ἀποτίσαι) — the payment metaphor turned back on the men offering payment. Restitution is refused because the debt is not denominated in oxen. Then the terms: fight or run — with the codicil that no one escapes. It is the only speech in the poem where Odysseus tells the complete truth about the immediate future.
- 10 *l. 70* Eurymachus' battle-order is tactically excellent — swords out, tables for shields, mass rush to shove the archer off the threshold, raise the town. It is exactly what might have worked, and the poem lets him say it before killing him mid-charge: the ablest suitor dies proving the analysis right — "this man will not now hold his invincible hands" — as prophecy, not plan.
- 11 *l. 79* Eurymachus' death lands on the furniture of his crimes: arrow in the liver, he doubles "over the table" and spills the food to the floor — dying across the banquet he ate for four years, kicking the chair, his forehead beating the ground. At 18.384–386 the beggar promised him the doors would be too narrow for his flight; he never reaches them — the table catches him first.
- 12 *l. 89* Amphinomus charges — and dies from behind, on Telemachus' spear, exactly as Athena bound him at 16.155–156 ("to be broken under the hands and spear of Telemachus"). The one suitor who was warned, believed the warning, and stayed anyway, is killed by the son of the man who tried to save him. The poem grants him a warrior's rush and no speech: his story was finished in Book 18; this is only the date falling due.
- 13 *l. 113* Telemachus arms first, then the two slaves, "and they took their stand around Odysseus." The four-man phalanx of the house: father, son, swineherd, cowherd — the loyalty audit of twenty books compressed into a defensive formation. The epithet-pair given Odysseus here (δαΐφρων ποικιλομήτης, "the deep mind, the shifting counsels") is the war-Odysseus of the Iliad, recalled to duty.
- 14 *l. 119* The transition from bow to spear: the bow — its work done — is leaned against the doorpost "by the shining entrance-wall," retired mid-battle like a tool returned to its rack, and the Iliadic panoply comes on piece by piece: four-hide shield, horsehair crest "nodding terror." The Odyssey's weapon yields to the Iliad's; the poem shifts genre in an arming-scene.
- 15 *l. 126* The side-door and the passage: the poem stops mid-battle for architecture, because the battle is architecture — one raised door, one cruel-mouthed alley, one man posted. Agelaus' sensible plan (raise the town) dies against a doorway; Ithaca's civic world stays sealed outside its own crisis until Book 24.
- 16 *l. 136* Melanthius' counter-proposal — armor from the storeroom — is the battle's one real reversal, and it comes from the household traitor who knows the house: he climbs "through the openings of the hall" (ῥῶγες — whatever exactly they were, he knows them). Twelve shields, twelve spears: the goatherd arms a dozen dead men and seals his own mutilation.



- 17 l. 147 "The knees of Odysseus went slack, and his heart" — the formula of terror-at-death, last applied to him amid the Book 5 storm and landing (5.297, 5.406). The sea's worst fear-line comes ashore here: the plan's single unraveling, armed suitors in his own hall, everything won and suddenly at stake again. "The work now looked great to him" — μέγα ἔργον: the same flat phrase as ever, doing enormous duty.
- 18 l. 154 "The fault is mine — my own, no other's": Telemachus' confession, instant and complete, in front of the men he armed by his lapse. No excuse, no deflection — the door left ajar named as his own. The poem has been growing this boy for twenty-one books; his manhood arrives not with the spear-kill at 93 but here, in the unforced admission of error under fire.
- 19 l. 173 The order for Melanthius: not death — storage. Trussed backward, boarded, hauled up the pillar "close to the roof-beams, so that he lives on a long while, suffering hard pains." The man who slept soft and ate at the suitors' table is hung in the rafters of the storeroom he looted, alive, to wait. Odysseus' cruelty is architectural: each punishment fitted to its crime's location.
- 20 l. 184 In Melanthius' hands as he is caught: Laertes' shield — "an old one, mottled with mildew... the stitches of its straps rotted out." The traitor is arrested holding the grandfather's rotted war-gear: three generations of the house in one object, dishonored twice over — by decay, and by the hands carrying it.
- 21 l. 194 The apostrophe, in its cruelest key: "And taunting him you spoke, Eumaeus the swineherd" — the poet's tender second-person address now introducing a torture-taunt. Eumaeus' mockery is built of dawn-formulas: the golden-throned early-born one will not "slip past" the trussed man — the loveliest lines in the poem's repertoire, recited to a man hanging in a storeroom. The gentle swineherd has a war voice; the poem does not pretend otherwise.
- 22 l. 208 Odysseus greets "Mentor" with a veteran's claim — remember your companion, we are age-mates — "guessing it was Athena." The double consciousness is the whole relationship: he plays the scene as written (an old friend asked for help) while trusting his guess that his interlocutor built the theater. Faith, in this poem, is continuing to act well in a play you believe you have seen through.
- 23 l. 216 Agelaus' threat to Mentor is the suitors' whole world-view in miniature: they will kill the old man for helping, pool his goods with Odysseus', kill his sons, and forbid his wife and daughters the town. Even now — their leaders dead, the archer revealed — their imagination runs on confiscation and the control of women. It is the last policy speech of the suitor regime.
- 24 l. 226 Athena's rebuke is the goddess's oldest trick — rage as fuel: where is the man of the nine years, of the wooden horse ("by your counsel the wide-wayed city of Priam was taken")? The taunt "you whimper about being brave" is unfair and deliberate, and it is also the poem's only direct set-piece linking this hall to Troy: the Iliadic résumé read out at the door of the dining room, to shame the hero into being himself.
- 25 l. 239 She tests, withholds victory, "and perched on the roof-beam — like a swallow, face-on." The bowstring sang "like a swallow's voice" at 21.411; now the goddess takes the same bird's shape above the killing. The swallow — house-bird, spring-bird, returner —

has become the emblem of the whole revenge: the small dark shape under the roof, singing that the year has turned.

- 26 *l. 251* Agelaus' fire-discipline — six at a time, concentrate on Odysseus, "the rest are no concern" — is sound doctrine, and the poem honors the suitors' best men with real tactics before Athena voids them. Every volley lands in doorpost, door, and wall: the house itself absorbs their war, as it absorbed their feasting.
- 27 *l. 262* Odysseus' counter-order is four words of Greek and a justification: they mean "to strip our corpses on top of the wrongs they did before" — even now, the offense is framed as the suitors' next planned outrage. The volley that follows is the battle's turn: four throws, four dead, the names ticked off in three tight lines.
- 28 *l. 277* The defenders' entire casualty list: a grazed wrist, a scratched shoulder. The poem permits the suitors two touches — enough to prove Athena is testing, not puppeteering — and no more. Amphimedon's graze will be his one mark on the story; his shade will retell this battle to Agamemnon in Book 24.
- 29 *l. 287* Philoetius kills Ctesippus and delivers the receipt: "This is your guest-gift in return — to match the ox-hoof you gave godlike Odysseus." The ξεινῆτιον-joke of 20.296 comes back with the same word and a spear behind it; the cowherd even appends the moral ("leave the word to the gods"). The poem's economy of insult is exact: mock hospitality once, and hospitality's ledger sends a herdsman to collect.
- 30 *l. 297* The aegis, raised "high from the roof" — no more testing: the rout. The two similes that follow split the scene by species: the suitors are herd-cattle scattered by the gadfly in lengthening spring days; the killers are hook-clawed vultures out of the mountains, and "men delight to watch the hunting." That last clause is the poem daring us to admit where we sit.
- 31 *l. 312* Leodes' plea carries the poem's partial warrant: 21.144–147 showed him alone hating the suitors' outrages. But only the indignation is certified — "I did nothing," "I tried to stop them" are his own claims, entered unwitnessed. His argument is the just man's: "no thanks, hereafter, for good service!" — the bitter proverb of the falsely lumped-in — and it is the book's hinge question: can presence alone convict?
- 32 *l. 322* The answer: yes. "If you were their diviner, you must often have prayed... that my sweet homecoming be far away." Odysseus convicts him not on acts but on office — the mob's chaplain prayed the mob's prayers — and on desire: "that my dear wife go with you." No evidence is offered; none, in this hall, is required. The head "mixed with the dust" while still speaking: the sentence outruns the plea mid-word. This is the killing the poem makes hardest to applaud, and it means to.
- 33 *l. 327* The sword is Agelaus' — dropped as he died. Odysseus does not even spend his own weapon on the diviner: the suitors' gear executes the suitors' priest. The economy is total now; everything in the hall has changed sides.
- 34 *l. 331* Phemius, "Terpes' son" — Delight's son, the poem's own trade fully pedigreed — who sang "under compulsion" (the narrator vouches; ἀνάγκη). His deliberation — Zeus's altar or Odysseus' knees — weighs sanctuary against supplication and picks the human option: in this hall today, the man is more present than the god.

- 35 l. 341 Before he begs for his life he puts down the lyre — "between the mixing-bowl and the silver-studded chair." Two lines of stage direction on which the whole scene turns: a man who sets his instrument down properly while expecting his own beheading has proved his vocation better than any plea. The poet saves the singer; first the singer saves the song.
- 36 l. 347 "I am self-taught: a god has planted in my heart all the pathways of song" — the most important sentence about poetry in Homer. Self-taught *and* god-planted: originality and inspiration claimed in one breath, no contradiction felt. Every argument about the poet's craft for the next three millennia is folded into this couplet, spoken by a man on his knees between corpses.
- 37 l. 357 Telemachus' interventions save the two spared lives of the massacre: the singer ("he is guiltless") and the herald who minded him as a child. The son's mercy-list is exactly as long as his evidence; the poem lets the boy who chose the maids' deaths also be the voice that stops two wrongful ones. Justice in this house runs through his testimony either way.
- 38 l. 363 Medon under the chair in a fresh-flayed oxhide — terror as low comedy, the herald hidden in the very upholstery of the feast. He springs out at the sound of his own reprieve. The poem, ankle-deep in blood, permits itself one clown-beat — and even that beat carries the theme: survival goes to those the household's children vouch for.
- 39 l. 372 Odysseus "smiled at him" — the first smile of the aftermath (the sardonic one at 20.301 came before the killing): this one real. His maxim to the spared — "doing good outruns doing evil, and by far" — is the massacre's official moral, delivered while the floor still smokes. He sends both survivors out to the altar: the god skipped for the knees now receives the saved.
- 40 l. 384 The fish simile: the dead heaped like a netted catch poured out on the sand, "aching for the waves of the sea, and the shining Sun takes the life out of them." The suitors die a second death in the image — gasping landward creatures who belonged to another element. It is the poem's pitiless pity: no blame in the simile at all, just bodies that wanted to live, expiring in the light. The sea-poem gives its land-battle a drowning in reverse.
- 41 l. 398 The wingless word, fourth and last (17.57; 19.29; 21.386): Eurycleia obeys the summons in silence. Every occurrence has attended a woman receiving instructions at the plot's hinges; the formula retires here, at the door between the massacre and the house of women.
- 42 l. 402 The lion simile for the man himself: blood to the cheeks, "terrible to look in the face." Eurycleia finds not her nursling but the predator of the deer-in-lair prophecy (4.335ff = 17.126ff) standing in its accomplished den. The poem has promised this lion since Sparta; it delivers him gore-fed, in his own dining room.
- 43 l. 412 The rebuke of the ologyge — the book's moral summit: "In your own heart rejoice, old woman — and hold it in: no cries. It is unholy to glory over slaughtered men." He does not deny the joy — he licenses it, inwardly — but the victory-shriek over corpses is forbidden as ὄσιν, sacrilege. Then the theology: "these men the doom of the gods has broken, and their own ruthless deeds" — two causes yoked in one breath, with the killer

grammatically absent. It is either the profoundest piety in the poem or its most sublime self-exculpation; the poem's answer is that they are the same sentence.

- 44 l. 422 The audit Eurycleia has waited three books to deliver (19.495ff): fifty women; twelve "walked the road of shamelessness." She adds the mitigation herself — Telemachus was too young to command them; the mistress kept the discipline. The nurse's arithmetic is careful and damning at once — and her move to wake Penelope is blocked again: the reunion must wait its own book.
- 45 l. 438 The orders sequence the horror with domestic precision: corpses out, furniture sponged, house set in order — *then* the women out between roundhouse and fence, "and cut them down with the long swords." The killing is scheduled like a chore at the end of the cleaning, and the sentence's stated target is memory itself: "till they have forgotten Aphrodite." The dead men dined; the women who slept are to be erased.
- 46 l. 447 The twelve carry out the bodies of their lovers, prop them against each other under the portico, sponge the chairs, scrape the floor — made to clean the scene of the massacre as their last work, with Odysseus "hurrying the work himself." The poem does not spare us the interval between sentence and execution; forced labor at your own gallows-site is part of the punishment, and the poem knows it.
- 47 l. 463 Telemachus overrides the sword: "By no clean death..." — καθαρῷ θανάτῳ: the sword is *clean*, and cleanness is more than they deserve for insults "poured on my head, on my own mother." The son escalates his father's sentence on his own authority — command exercised in his own right, as when he saved Phemius and Medon moments before. Mercy and cruelty have the same source in him: personal testimony. This is the poem's most terrible verse, and it belongs to the boy.
- 48 l. 469 The hanging: ship's cable, pillar, roundhouse; and the simile — thrushes or doves flying home to roost, striking the snare, "and a hateful bed receives them." Birds coming home; a bed — the imagery convicts and pities in the same breath (their crime was beds; their deaths are a perverted homecoming). Then the poem's most unflinching line and a half: heads in a row, nooses on every neck, "that they might die most pitifully. They kicked out with their feet a little while — not very long." No other ancient text ends an atrocity on so quiet a clock. The poem does not defend this; it makes us watch it, and the watching is the judgment it leaves to us.
- 49 l. 475 Melanthius' end: nose, ears, genitals to the dogs, hands, feet — outdoing the partial catalogues Antinous rehearsed as threats (Echetus' nose, ears, and genitals at 18.85ff; the Centaur's ears and nose at 21.299ff), executed by the household "in their fury of heart" (κεκοτῆότι θυμῷ — the poem noting, not endorsing, the rage). Every mutilation the suitors' side imagined for others lands on their collaborator, and more. The revenge's arithmetic more than closes; its humanity is left an open wound.
- 50 l. 482 Sulfur, "the cure of evils" (κακῶν ἄκος) — fire and brimstone as purification: the hall is fumigated like a sickroom. After the theology (413–414) and the executions, the pollution is treated as physical — burnable, ventable. The oldest chemistry of atonement: what blood makes unclean, sulfur smoke makes habitable.
- 51 l. 488 Eurycleia's first thought after Armageddon: he cannot stand around in rags — "that would be a thing to blame" (νεμεσσητόν). The nurse's propriety, absurd and

magnificent, reasserts the household's ordinary law over the extraordinary scene. His answer — fire first — is the last postponement of comfort in a life made of them.

- 52 *l.* 492 He fumes "the hall, the house, the courtyard" himself — the king as his own priest, smoking out his own pollution. The man who offered to keep the suitors' torches burning (18.316ff) as a beggar now carries the purifying fire as owner: his relationship to this house's flames has run lamptender, avenger, priest inside two days.
- 53 *l.* 497 The last lines belong to the loyal women: out of the hall with torches, pouring around him, kissing head, shoulders, hands — the family embrace-formula given to the whole faithful staff at once. "And a sweet longing took hold of him — to weep, to sob: for in his heart he knew them all." After one hundred and eight corpses, the book ends with the man undone not by killing but by recognition — every face known, twenty years of names intact. The slaughter needed disguise and iron; it is the housemaids who finally break him open.



## Odyssey — Book 23

*The bed; the test that Penelope wins; the long night held back.*

- And the old woman climbed to the upper room, laughing aloud,<sup>1</sup>  
 to tell her mistress that her own dear husband was in the house;  
 her knees were pumping fast, her feet stumbled with hurry.  
 She stood over Penelope's head and spoke to her:
- 5 "Wake, Penelope, dear child — so you can see  
 with your own eyes what you have longed for all your days!  
 Odysseus is here — he has come home — however late.  
 And he has killed the lordly suitors, the men who plagued  
 his house, and ate his goods, and bullied his son."
- 10 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered her:  
 "Dear nurse, the gods have made you mad. The gods can strike<sup>2</sup>  
 even the full of sense to foolishness,  
 and set the empty-headed on the road of wisdom:  
 they have unstrung you. Your mind was straight before.
- 15 Why do you mock me, when my heart is all one grief,  
 telling wild tales — and shake me out of the sleep,  
 the sweet sleep that had bound me, folding my eyelids under?  
 I have not slept so sound since the day Odysseus  
 went to look on Evil-Ilium, never to be named.<sup>3</sup>
- 20 Go on — down with you now, back to the hall.  
 If any other of my women had come to me  
 with news like this, and shaken me out of sleep,  
 I would soon have sent her packing back to the hall  
 and roughly. You — your old age spares you that, at least."
- 25 Then the dear nurse Eurycleia answered her:  
 "I do not mock you, dear child. It is true:  
 Odysseus is here — he has come home, just as I tell you —  
 the stranger, the one they all dishonored in the hall.  
 Telemachus knew long since that he was here,<sup>4</sup>  
 30 but kept his father's purposes hidden, cool of head,  
 till he should punish the violence of those overbearing men."  
 So she spoke; and Penelope, all joy, sprang out of bed

and clung to the old woman, tears spilling from her eyelids,  
and lifting her voice she spoke winged words to her:

- 35 "Come then, dear nurse — tell me truly:  
if he has really come home, as you say he has,  
how did he lay his hands on the shameless suitors —  
one man alone, when they were always in there in a pack?"  
Then the dear nurse Eurycleia answered her:
- 40 "I did not see, I did not ask. I heard only the groaning<sup>5</sup>  
of men being killed. We sat in the corner of our strong-built  
quarters, struck dumb — the close-fitted doors held us in —  
until the hour your son called me out of the hall,  
Telemachus: his father had sent him to call me.
- 45 And then I found Odysseus standing among the bodies  
of the slain; and they, around him, on the trodden floor  
lay heaped on one another. It would have warmed your heart —<sup>6</sup>  
Now they are all together at the courtyard gates,  
50 and he is purging the beautiful house with sulfur,<sup>7</sup>  
and has built a great fire; and he sent me to call you.  
Come with me now — so both of you can set your dear hearts  
in the way of gladness at last: you have suffered so much evil.  
Now, this time, the long desire is accomplished:
- 55 he has come himself, alive, to his own hearth; and he has found you  
and his son still in the halls; and the men who wronged him,  
the suitors — he has punished them all in his own house."  
Then watchful-minded Penelope answered her:  
"Dear nurse — no crowing yet. Hold back your laughter.
- 60 You know how welcome the sight of him would be  
to everyone in this house — most of all to me and to our son.  
But this tale cannot be true, not as you tell it:  
no — some one of the immortals has killed the lordly suitors,<sup>8</sup>  
outraged at their heart-stinging insolence and their evil deeds.
- 65 For they honored nobody on this earth,  
bad man or good, whoever came among them;  
so through their own blind folly they have suffered. But Odysseus —  
far away he has lost his homecoming, lost out of Achaea; he himself is  
lost."  
Then the dear nurse Eurycleia answered her:



- 70 "My child, what a word has slipped the fence of your teeth!<sup>9</sup>  
 Your husband is here — at his own hearthside — and you declare  
 he will never come home! Your heart was always unbelieving.  
 Come then — I will give you another sign, and a plain one:  
 the scar the boar dealt him long ago with its white tusk.
- 75 I found it as I washed him, and I wanted to tell you —  
 you yourself — but he clapped his hand across my mouth  
 and would not let me speak: his mind is full of cunning.<sup>10</sup>  
 But come. And I will stake my own life on it:  
 if I am deceiving you, kill me by the most pitiful death there is."
- 80 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered her:  
 "Dear nurse — the counsels of the gods who are forever:  
 it is hard for you to fathom them, sharp-witted as you are.<sup>11</sup>  
 But even so, let us go down to my son, so I may see  
 the suitors dead — and the man who killed them."
- 85 So speaking she went down from the upper room; and her heart  
 churned: should she question her dear husband from a distance,  
 or go to him, and take his head and hands, and kiss them?<sup>12</sup>  
 And when she came in, and crossed the stone threshold,  
 she sat down opposite Odysseus, in the light of the fire,
- 90 against the other wall. And he, by the tall pillar,  
 sat looking at the ground, waiting to learn whether  
 his strong-built wife would speak to him, once her eyes had seen.  
 But she sat a long while silent, wonder flooding her heart:  
 with her eyes now she would gaze at him, full in the face;
- 95 now fail to know him — in the bad clothes on his body.<sup>13</sup>  
 And Telemachus rebuked her, and spoke a word, and named her:  
 "Mother mine — no mother! — with your unbending heart,<sup>14</sup>  
 why do you hold apart from my father so? Why not  
 sit close beside him, and question him, and ask him everything?
- 100 No other woman would harden her heart like this,  
 and stand apart from a husband who, after suffering much,  
 came in the twentieth year to his own fatherland.  
 But your heart is harder than stone — as it has always been."  
 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:
- 105 "My child, the heart in my breast is stunned to stillness:  
 I cannot speak one word to him, cannot ask a question,

- cannot look him in the face. But if he is truly  
 Odysseus — if he has come home — then surely we two  
 shall know one another, and better than anyone: for we have  
 110 signs between us — hidden signs, that we two know and no one else."<sup>15</sup>  
 So she spoke; and much-enduring noble Odysseus smiled,<sup>16</sup>  
 and quickly he spoke winged words to Telemachus:  
 "Telemachus — let your mother test me in the halls  
 as she will: she will soon see more clearly.
- 115 Now, because I am filthy, and the clothes on my body are bad,  
 she holds me cheap, and will not yet say I am the man.  
 But we — let us think how this can come out best.  
 For a man who has killed even one man in the land —  
 one man, with few behind him to avenge him after —  
 120 goes into exile, leaving his kin and his fathers' country.  
 And we have killed the prop of the city — far the noblest  
 of the young men in Ithaca. Think on that, I say."<sup>17</sup>  
 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
 "You look to it yourself, dear father. Yours, they say,  
 125 is the best mind among mankind: no mortal man  
 could set himself against you there.  
 As for us — we are with you, blazing for it; and I say we shall not  
 come short in courage, such strength as is in us."<sup>18</sup>  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 130 "Then I will say how it seems best to me.  
 First: bathe yourselves, and put clean tunics on,  
 and tell the serving-women in the halls to dress;  
 and let the godlike singer, with the clear lyre in his hands,  
 lead us all in the steps of the playful dance —  
 135 so that anyone who hears it from outside will say, 'A wedding!' —<sup>19</sup>  
 a passer-by on the road, or one of our neighbors round about —  
 so that the wide rumor of the suitors' killing does not run  
 down through the town before we can get away  
 out to our orchard-farm among the trees. There, after,  
 140 we shall see what profit the Olympian puts into our hands."  
 So he spoke; and they listened well and obeyed.  
 First they bathed themselves, and put clean tunics on,  
 and the women dressed; and the godlike singer took up

- the hollow lyre, and woke in all of them the craving  
 145 for the sweetness of song and the blameless dance.  
 And the great house rang around them to the footfalls  
 of men at play and fair-belted women dancing;  
 and a man would say, hearing it from outside the house:  
 "So! Someone has married the much-wooed queen at last.  
 150 Hard woman — she had not the heart to keep her wedded  
 husband's great house through to the end, until he came."<sup>20</sup>  
 So a man would say. And they did not know how things stood.  
 And meanwhile, inside his house, great-hearted Odysseus  
 was bathed by the housekeeper Eurynome, and rubbed with oil,  
 155 and she put a beautiful mantle round him, and a tunic;  
 and over him, from the head down, Athena poured great beauty:  
 taller to look at, and broader, and down from his head  
 she made the locks flow in curls, like the hyacinth flower.  
 As when a man lays gold over silver — a craftsman  
 160 whom Hephaestus and Pallas Athena have taught  
 art of every kind, and he finishes works full of grace —  
 so she poured grace over his head and shoulders.<sup>21</sup>  
 Out of the bath he came, in build like the immortals,  
 and sat back down on the chair from which he had risen,  
 165 opposite his wife, and spoke his word to her:  
 "Strange woman! To you beyond all womankind<sup>22</sup>  
 the dwellers on Olympus gave an unyielding heart.  
 No other woman would harden her heart like this,  
 and stand apart from a husband who, after suffering much,  
 170 came in the twentieth year to his own fatherland."<sup>23</sup>  
 Well then, nurse — make me up a bed, so I can lie down  
 by myself at least. The heart in this one's breast is iron."  
 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:  
 "Strange man! I am not being proud, and I am not slighting you —  
 175 nor am I too much amazed. I know very well what you were  
 when you went from Ithaca on your long-oared ship."<sup>24</sup>  
 Well then — Eurycleia: make up the packed bedstead for him  
 outside the well-built bridal chamber — the bed he made  
 with his own hands. Move the packed bedstead out there for him,  
 180 and pile the bedding on: the fleeces, the cloaks, the shining blankets."<sup>25</sup>

- So she spoke — testing her husband. And Odysseus  
 flared out in anger at his true-hearted wife:  
 "Woman — that is a wounding word you have spoken!<sup>26</sup>  
 Who has set my bed somewhere else? That would be hard  
 185 even for a skilled workman — unless a god in person came  
 and set it down, at his easy will, in some other place:  
 no living mortal man, not one in his best young strength,  
 could lightly lever it aside. For a great sign is built  
 into that worked bed — and I made it: I, no other man.  
 190 A bush of olive grew inside the courtyard fence, long-leaved,  
 full-grown and flourishing, its trunk thick as a pillar.  
 Around it I built our chamber, and I worked at it till it was done —  
 close-set stone; and I roofed it well above,  
 and hung the jointed doors on it, close-fitting.  
 195 Then — and only then — I cut back the long-leaved olive's crown,  
 trimmed the trunk up from the root, and with the bronze I planed it  
 smooth all round, with skill, and trued it to the line:  
 a bedpost worked from the living tree. And I bored it all with the auger,  
 and starting from that post I planed out the bed, until I finished,  
 200 inlaying it with gold and silver and ivory,  
 and I stretched across its frame an oxhide strap, bright with crimson.<sup>27</sup>  
 There is our sign — I show it to you. What I do not know,  
 woman, is whether my bed still stands fast, or by now  
 some man has cut the olive off at the root and moved it."<sup>28</sup>  
 205 So he spoke; and her knees went slack where she sat, and her dear  
 heart,  
 as she recognized the tokens Odysseus described so surely;<sup>29</sup>  
 and bursting into tears she ran straight to him, and threw  
 her arms around Odysseus' neck, and kissed his head, and said:  
 "Do not be angry with me, Odysseus — you who in everything  
 210 understood the most of men. It was the gods who gave us sorrow —  
 the gods, who begrudged that we two, staying side by side,  
 should have the joy of our youth and come to the doorsill of old age.<sup>30</sup>  
 But do not be angry with me now, do not hold it against me  
 that at first, when I saw you, I did not welcome you like this.  
 215 For always the heart here in my breast kept shivering:  
 terror that some man would come and cheat me with his talk —

and men enough there are who plot such wicked profits.<sup>31</sup>  
 Not even Argive Helen, daughter of Zeus,  
 would have joined in love and bed with a man from another land  
 220 had she known that the warlike sons of the Achaeans  
 would carry her home again to her own dear country.  
 A god it was who stirred her to the shameful thing she did;  
 and not until too late did she lay to heart that folly,  
 the ruinous folly from which grief first came — to us as well.<sup>32</sup>  
 225 But now — now you have told over the plain tokens  
 of our own bed, which no other mortal has laid eyes on:  
 only you and I, and one single serving-woman,  
 Actoris, whom my father gave me when I first came here,  
 who kept the door of our close-built bridal chamber —  
 230 now you persuade my heart, unbending as it is."<sup>33</sup>  
 So she spoke; and in him she stirred a still greater longing to weep,  
 and he wept, holding the wife of his heart, the true, the steadfast.  
 And as when land shows welcome to men swimming for it —  
 men whose well-made ship Poseidon has smashed  
 235 on the open sea, driving it under wind and heavy wave,  
 and few of them swim clear of the gray sea to the shore,  
 their bodies caked with all the brine of it,  
 and glad at last they step on land, escaped from evil:  
 so welcome was her husband to her, as her eyes gazed at him,  
 240 and she could not once let her white arms go from his neck.<sup>34</sup>  
 And Dawn of the fingers of rose would have risen on their weeping,  
 had not the goddess thought of one thing more — gray-eyed Athena:  
 she held the long night back at the world's edge, and penned  
 gold-throned Dawn at Ocean, and would not let her yoke  
 245 her quick-footed horses that carry the light to men,  
 Lampus and Phaethon, the colts that draw the Dawn.<sup>35</sup>  
 And then Odysseus of the many designs spoke to his wife:  
 "Lady — we have not yet come to the end of every trial:  
 there is still to be one labor past all measure,  
 250 long and hard, and I must carry it through to the last.  
 For so the ghost of Teiresias prophesied to me  
 the day I went down into the house of Hades  
 seeking a homecoming for my companions and myself.

- But come, wife — let us go to bed, so that at last  
 255 we can lie down and take the sweetness of our sleep."<sup>36</sup>  
 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:  
 "Your bed is there for you whenever your heart  
 wishes it — now that the gods have brought you home  
 to your own well-built house and your fathers' land.  
 260 But since you have thought of it — since a god has put it in your heart  
 —  
 come, tell me the trial: for I shall hear of it later  
 anyway, I think, and it is no worse to know it now."<sup>37</sup>  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered her:  
 "Strange woman — why do you press me so, and order me  
 265 to speak? Well, I will tell it, and hide nothing.  
 Your heart will take no joy in it; no more does mine:  
 for he ordered me on through many towns of mortals yet,  
 traveling with a well-shaped oar in my hands,  
 until I come to men who know nothing of the sea,  
 270 men who eat no food that is mixed with salt,  
 who know nothing of red-cheeked ships,  
 nothing of well-shaped oars, which are wings for ships.  
 And he told me a sign, unmistakable. I will not hide it from you:  
 when another traveler, meeting me on the road,  
 275 says I carry a winnowing-fan on my shining shoulder,  
 then and there he ordered me to fix the oar in the earth  
 and offer fine victims to the lord Poseidon —  
 a ram, a bull, and a boar that has mounted sows —  
 and turn away home, and offer holy hecatombs  
 280 to the deathless gods who hold wide heaven,  
 to all of them, each in order. And death will come to me  
 from the sea, so gentle a death, and take me  
 worn down under sleek old age; and around me the peoples  
 will be prosperous. All this, he said, will be accomplished."<sup>38</sup>  
 285 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:  
 "If the gods are really bringing on a better old age,  
 then there is hope there will be an escape from our evils."<sup>39</sup>  
 So they spoke to one another of such things.  
 And meanwhile Eurynome and the nurse made up the bed

- 290 with soft coverings, under the light of blazing torches.  
 And when they had spread the packed bedstead, working quickly,  
 the old woman went away to her own room to sleep,  
 and Eurynome the chamber-woman led them on  
 their way to bed, a torch in her hands;
- 295 she brought them to the chamber, and went back. And they —  
 glad, they came to the rite of their own old bed.<sup>40</sup>  
 And Telemachus and the cowherd and the swineherd  
 rested their feet from the dance, and rested the women,  
 and lay down to sleep themselves through the shadowy halls.
- 300 And when the two had taken their fill of the loveliness of love,  
 they took their pleasure in words, telling each other everything:  
 she, the shining among women, all she had endured in the halls,  
 watching that deadly crowd of suitor-men  
 who on her account kept slaughtering so many beasts,
- 305 oxen and fat sheep, while the wine drained out of the jars by the vatful;  
 and Zeus-born Odysseus, all the sorrows he had dealt  
 to other men, and all he had toiled through in his own grief —  
 he told it all; and she delighted in the listening,  
 and no sleep fell upon her eyelids till he had told everything.<sup>41</sup>
- 310 He began with how he beat the Cicones first, and came  
 from there to the rich plowland of the Lotus-eaters;  
 and all the Cyclops did, and how he took the price from him  
 for the brave companions he had eaten without pity;  
 and how he came to Aeolus, who received him kindly
- 315 and sent him on — but it was not yet his portion to reach  
 his own dear country: the storm-wind snatched him up again  
 and drove him, groaning heavily, over the fish-filled sea;  
 and how he came to Telepylus of the Laestrygonians,  
 who destroyed his ships and all his strong-greaved companions —
- 320 all of them: Odysseus alone got clear in his black ship;  
 and he told her Circe's guile and her many wiles,  
 and how he went down into the dank house of Hades  
 to consult the ghost of Theban Teiresias,  
 in his many-benched ship, and saw all his companions,
- 325 and his mother, who bore him and reared him when he was little;  
 and how he heard the voice of the thronging Sirens,

and came to the Clashing Rocks, and dread Charybdis,  
 and Scylla, whom men have never yet slipped past unhurt;  
 and how his companions killed the cattle of the Sun;  
 330 and how Zeus who thunders on high struck the fast ship  
 with a smoking bolt, and his brave companions perished  
 all together — and he alone escaped the evil fates;  
 and how he came to the island of Ogygia and the nymph Calypso,  
 who kept him there, aching to have him for her husband,  
 335 in her hollow caves, and fed him, and kept promising  
 to make him deathless and ageless all his days —  
 yet she never persuaded the heart in his breast;  
 and how, after much suffering, he came to the Phaeacians,  
 who honored him from the heart, like a god,  
 340 and sent him home with a ship to his own dear country,  
 with gifts of bronze and gold and clothing in plenty.<sup>42</sup>  
 That was the last word he spoke, as the sweet sleep  
 that unstrings the limbs leapt on him, loosing the cares of his heart.<sup>43</sup>  
 Then the goddess thought of one thing more, gray-eyed Athena:  
 345 when she judged that Odysseus in his heart had taken  
 his fill of the bed of his wife, and his fill of sleep,  
 at once she roused the gold-throned early-born one out of Ocean,  
 to carry her light to mankind. And Odysseus rose  
 from the soft bed, and laid this charge on his wife:  
 350 "Lady — by now we have had our fill of trials,  
 the two of us both: you here, weeping over  
 my homecoming with all its cares, while Zeus and the other gods  
 nailed me in pain far from my own country, straining home.<sup>44</sup>  
 Now that we both have come to the bed we longed for,  
 355 you must care for the property I have inside the halls;  
 as for the flocks the overweening suitors wasted —  
 many I will raid back myself, and the Achaeans  
 will give the rest, until they fill up every fold.<sup>45</sup>  
 But now I am going out to the orchard-farm and its trees,  
 360 to see my noble father, who grieves for me so hard.  
 And on you, wife, I lay this charge — wise as you are:  
 with the rising sun the story will be out and running —  
 the suitors, the men I killed here in the halls.



Go up to the upper room with your attendant women  
 365 and sit there. Look at no one. Ask no questions."<sup>46</sup>  
 He spoke, and drew the beautiful armor over his shoulders,  
 and roused Telemachus and the cowherd and the swineherd,  
 and told them all to take up weapons of war in their hands.  
 They did not disobey: they harnessed themselves in bronze,  
 370 and opened the doors, and went out; and Odysseus led.  
 By now the light was over the earth; but Athena  
 hid them in night, and led them quickly out of the town.<sup>47</sup>

NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 23

- 1    *l. 1* Eurycleia climbs "laughing aloud" (καγχαλόωσα), knees pumping, feet stumbling — the poem gives the great announcement to an old woman's hurrying body. She has kept the secret since the basin clanged (19.478ff); the pent-up news practically carries her up the stairs.
- 2    *l. 11* Penelope's first response to the truth is a lecture on divine psychiatry: the gods can make the wise mad and the foolish sane, "they have unstrung you." Twenty years of discipline speak here — hope is an intoxicant she has learned to refuse at the door. And the sleep she resents being woken from was Athena's own (21.357–358): the goddess anesthetized her through the massacre; the nurse gets scolded for ending the anesthesia.
- 3    *l. 18* "I have not slept so sound since the day Odysseus / went to look on Evil-Ilium, never to be named" — her own coinage from 19.260 and 597, the war's curse-name, now marking the exact span of her insomnia: twenty years bracketed between his departure and this one drugged night. The best sleep of the war ends with the news the war is over.
- 4    *l. 29* Eurycleia's aside — Telemachus knew all along and "kept his father's purposes hidden, cool of head" — quietly files the son's achievement where it belongs: the boy who could not hold a thought in Book 1 has held the poem's biggest secret for six books.
- 5    *l. 40* "I did not see, I did not ask. I heard only the groaning of men being killed." The massacre from the women's quarters: shut doors, held breath, sound only. The poem has already shown us the slaughter from inside; one line now shows what it was from the other side of a door — the household's war experienced as pure audio.
- 6    *l. 46* "It would have warmed your heart —": the dash is the translation's; the Greek rounds off its clause before plunging into what she actually saw — Odysseus "like a lion" among the corpses (the simile she leaves at 22.402ff). Murray's text omits the next verse (49 — the numbering skips it): the gap falls, fittingly, in the middle of an old woman's breathless run-on.
- 7    *l. 48* The report ends in housework: everyone at the courtyard gates, the house being sulfured, a great fire going — the apocalypse rendered as a domestic status update. Then the summary that carries the poem's whole plot in three lines: he came, alive, to his own hearth; he found you and his son; he punished them all.
- 8    *l. 62* Her counter-theory — "some one of the immortals has killed the lordly suitors" — repeats Odysseus' own theology from 22.413–416 almost clause for clause (they honored nobody, good or bad; their folly destroyed them) while denying his existence. Wife and husband explain the same corpses the same way before they have exchanged a word: the poem's proof of like minds, run as dramatic irony. Her closing line — "lost" twice in one breath (ῥλεσε... ῥλετο) — is grief's grammar: the homecoming lost, the man lost.
- 9    *l. 70* The tooth-fence formula (1.64; 3.230; 5.22; 19.492; 21.168) — now the nurse to the queen, on the poem's last unspeakable utterance: the husband is at his hearth and the

wife says he will never come. And then the trump: the scar, offered secondhand, with the story of the clapped hand and the poem's driest tribute — "his mind is full of cunning" — and her own life staked on it. Penelope declines even this: washing-water evidence is not bed evidence.

- 10 *l. 75* "He clapped his hand across my mouth" — Eurycleia finally gets to tell the story the throat-grip suppressed (19.479ff), and softens it in the telling; the terrifying seizure has become a hand on the lips. The nurse edits her master's violence into charm; loyalty writes the memoir.
- 11 *l. 81* "The counsels of the gods... hard for you to fathom, sharp-witted as you are" — her courteous agnosticism: even conceding a wonder happened, its author is unproven. Then the pivot the whole book turns on: she will go down not to greet a husband but "to see the suitors dead — and the man who killed them." Observer's language; the inspection tour of a woman who has been fooled by every hope for twenty years.
- 12 *l. 85* Her deliberation on the stairs — interrogate from a distance, or go kiss his head and hands? — is the poem's standard decision-formula, and it dissolves unresolved into 93: she does neither. She sits in the firelight opposite him and does not speak. The strongest scene-setting in the poem is two chairs, one fire, and silence.
- 13 *l. 93* The flicker: "now she would gaze at him, full in the face; / now fail to know him — in the bad clothes on his body." Recognition strobes — face says yes, rags say no — and the poem holds her honestly in between. This is the same double vision the disguise has forced on everyone (Philoetius saw "a king in ruin," 20.194); only she refuses to resolve it on insufficient data.
- 14 *l. 97* "Mother mine — no mother!" (μήτηρ ἐμή, δύσμητερ): Telemachus coins an insult inside the address — the un-mothering mother, "heart harder than stone." His indignation is the plot's own impatience made audible; and the poem sets it up precisely so that her answer can rebuke the poem itself: there are things two people know that no one else can hurry.
- 15 *l. 108* Her manifesto: "we have signs between us — hidden signs, that we two know and no one else" (σήμαθ'... κεκρυμμένα). The recognition-scenes so far have all run on public tokens — a scar any nurse can wash. Penelope announces a higher protocol: cryptography with a key-pair of exactly two holders. It is the most rigorous epistemology in the poem, and it belongs to the person with the most to lose from error.
- 16 *l. 111* Odysseus *smiles* — his third smile (the sardonic one, 20.301; at Medon, 22.371), and the warmest: the champion of tests, recognizing a fellow professional at his own game. "Let your mother test me" — πειράζειν, the family verb — and his serene "she will soon see more clearly" is wrong in the most instructive way possible: he assumes the obstacle is his rags. He is about to learn otherwise.
- 17 *l. 118* In the very middle of the reunion-in-suspension, the strategist reroutes to consequences: the blood-feud arithmetic (one killing means exile — and we killed "the prop of the city"). His worry of 20.41–43 returns with the body count now actual. The poem keeps insisting: the massacre has a morning after, and Odysseus is the only person planning for it.

- 18 l. 124 Telemachus' answer is the son's whole arc in four lines: yours is the best mind among men — and we will follow "blazing." Deference and ferocity, correctly distributed. The boy who needed Athena to imagine a father now hands his father the planning and reserves only the courage for himself.
- 19 l. 133 The sham wedding: bathing, dressing, the lyre, dancing "so that anyone who hears it from outside will say, 'A wedding!'" The cover story is chosen with a jeweler's irony — the house must counterfeit the exact event the suitors died failing to force, on the night the real marriage resumes. The lie, as always in this poem, is made of truth.
- 20 l. 149 The passer-by's verdict: "Someone has married the much-wooed queen at last. Hard woman — she had not the heart to keep her husband's great house through to the end." The poem lets an anonymous voice speak the town's whole uncomprehending cruelty — wrong in every fact, and in the fiction's frame *also right*: there is a wedding tonight. Penelope is convicted of infidelity by gossip at the very hour her twenty-year fidelity completes itself; the poem files the injustice without comment, "and they did not know how things stood."
- 21 l. 156 Lines 157–162 repeat the beautification of 6.230–235 word for word — the hyacinth curls, the gold-over-silver craftsman taught by Hephaestus and Athena. The ledger's oldest promised echo, paid at last: the glow first applied for Nausicaa on the beach is reapplied for Penelope by the fire. Same divine cosmetics, two women, sixteen books apart — and this time the audience it is aimed at will not be moved by appearances at all, which is the joke and the point.
- 22 l. 166 "Strange woman!" (δαίμονή) — the same baffled vocative he has thrown at the beggar Irus (18.15) and the maid Melantho (19.71), now softened by helplessness into wonder, and she will hand it straight back at 174: "Strange man!" (δαίμόνιε). The couple's first exchange in twenty years opens with the identical word in both mouths — matched blades, courteously crossed.
- 23 l. 168 His complaint repeats Telemachus' rebuke of 100–102 verbatim — "No other woman would harden her heart..." Father and son, unaware, share one text about her (as father and son shared the silence-formula at 17.465/491). What neither man grasps: the sentence is a compliment. No other woman *would* — that is precisely the specification of Penelope.
- 24 l. 174 Her reply is a masterpiece of cool: not proud, not slighting — and then the sentence that springs the trap while sounding like a concession: "I know very well what you were / when you went from Ithaca." *What you were* — twenty years ago; whether this is that man is exactly the open question, and she has designed the examination while he was being handsome at her.
- 25 l. 177 The trap in nine words: "make up the packed bedstead for him / *outside* the well-built bridal chamber — the bed he made." One moved preposition. The order is given to Eurycleia — the servant who knows it cannot be obeyed — over the head of the man being tested. If he embraces the bed's mobility, he is a stranger; only the builder knows it cannot leave the room. She has invented the security question whose answer cannot be researched: it can only be *remembered from inside the marriage*.

- 26 l. 181 "So she spoke — testing her husband" (πόσιος πειρωμένη): the poem names the maneuver with the family verb and awards her the round in the same line — *her husband*: the narrator has already graded the test she is still administering. And Odysseus — the man who dodged an ox-hoof without blinking — "flared out in anger" (ὄχθήσας). The one provocation in twenty-four books that breaks his control is a piece of furniture in the wrong place.
- 27 l. 190 The bed-speech is the poem's deepest image doing its work at last: the living olive — the tree of Athena, of the thicket he slept in on Scheria, of the stake that blinded the Cyclops — planed and trued into a bedpost still rooted in the earth, the chamber built around it, the whole house in effect grown from the marriage at its center. The σῆμα is architectural: this marriage cannot be moved without cutting it off at the root — which is precisely what he now, in anguish, asks whether some man has done. The rage and the proof are the same thing: only the builder could be this hurt.
- 28 l. 202 "There is our sign" — and then the question that hands her the victory: he does not know; she does. For one line the omniscient strategist stands fully exposed — every operational secret of the poem was his, and the last secret of all is hers to confirm. The bed-test reverses twenty-four books of information flow in a single couplet.
- 29 l. 205 Her knees go slack (the death-and-desire formula, 18.212, 22.68) "as she recognized the tokens Odysseus described so surely" — the identical line that ended the clothes-test at 19.250. Same verse, transformed: there the tokens proved contact with a dead man and produced grief; here they prove the man himself, and produce the run across the room. The formula system saves its finest rhyme for the marriage.
- 30 l. 209 Her apology begins with the gods, not herself: they "begrudged that we two, staying side by side, / should have the joy of our youth and come to the doorsill of old age." The grievance is stated as a couple's — *we two* — the grammar already repaired. Note where the blame lands: not on him for leaving, not on her for doubting; on heaven, for the stolen middle of a marriage.
- 31 l. 215 The defense proper: "always the heart in my breast kept shivering — terror that some man would come and cheat me with his talk." Given the poem she is in — where her actual visitor has spun false autobiography after false autobiography since he landed — her paranoia is simply accuracy. The test was not coldness; it was the only sane response to a world (and a husband) made of plausible fictions.
- 32 l. 218 The Helen defense: even Helen "would not have joined in love and bed with a man from another land / had she known" — the poem's most argued-over lines. Penelope reaches for the worst woman in the family archive and extends her the same analysis she demands for herself: error under deception, "a god stirred her" — and from Helen's ruin "grief first came — to us as well." It is not exoneration; it is jurisprudence: judge the deceived by what they knew. She acquits Helen provisionally in the course of explaining why she refused to become her.
- 33 l. 225 The certificate: the bed's tokens are known to "you and I, and one single serving-woman, Actoris" — her dowry-servant, doorkeeper of the bridal chamber, presumably long dead. The key-pair had one trusted witness, chosen by her father before the marriage began. "Now you persuade my heart, unbending as it is" — ἀπηνέα, the very

adjective her son threw at her (97): what he called cruelty was the tempering; the unbending heart is why the certification means anything.

- 34 l. 233 The reversed simile — the poem's most celebrated: land welcome to swimmers, Poseidon-wrecked, brine-caked, "glad at last they step on land" — and the swimmer is *her*: "so welcome was her husband to her." Twenty years of his shipwrecks are handed to the wife who never left the island; the poem declares her voyage equal — the house was her open sea, the suitors her storm, and the man in her arms the shore. One marriage, one simile, both survivors in it.
- 35 l. 241 Athena stops the sunrise: night held "at the world's edge," Dawn penned at Ocean, her named colts — Lampus and Phaethon, "Shiner" and "Blazer" — kept from the yoke. The goddess who has scheduled every hour of this plot now bends the cosmos itself for the reunion: the poem's single most romantic use of divine machinery, spending a miracle not on battle but on time to talk.
- 36 l. 248 In the held night he chooses honesty at its most expensive: before the bed, the future — "we have not yet come to the end of every trial." The man of managed information gives his wife, unprompted, the one piece of bad news he could have kept for years: Teiresias' final errand. After the bed-test, full disclosure is the marriage's new constitution — and this clause is its first enactment.
- 37 l. 257 Her response to "there will be more suffering" is the poem's definition of her: "Your bed is there for you whenever your heart wishes it" — then, "tell me the trial: I shall hear of it later anyway... no worse to know it now." No wail, no plea; the intelligence-officer's preference for early data. They are two of a kind to the last exchange: he tests, she tests; he discloses, she debriefs.
- 38 l. 267 The prophecy retold: lines 269–284 repeat Teiresias' words from 11.122–137 nearly verbatim — the salt-less eaters, the winnowing-fan mistake, the planted oar, Poseidon's ram and bull and boar, and the death "from the sea, so gentle... under sleek old age," the peoples prosperous around him. The poem's strangest and most beautiful prophecy is spoken twice: once in Hades to the hero, once in bed to the wife. Marriage, in this poem, is where the underworld's secrets are finally filed.
- 39 l. 286 Her verdict on the oar-journey and the gentle death: "If the gods are really bringing on a better old age, / then there is hope there will be an escape from our evils." Conditional, guarded, exact — hope granted an *if* clause and nothing more. The last sentence Penelope speaks in the poem is in her native grammar: optimism under audit.
- 40 l. 295 "Glad, they came to the rite of their own old bed" (λέκτροιο παλαιού θεσμών ἵκοντο) — θεσμός; ordinance, institution, rite. The bed has a *law*, and they return to it as to a ritual long suspended. The Alexandrian critics Aristophanes and Aristarchus marked this line as the "end" (τέλος) of the Odyssey — the poem's true destination reached, with everything after it epilogue. Whatever one decides about Book 24, the ancient judgment honors what this line is: the sentence the whole epic sailed toward.
- 41 l. 300 The night's second act is narrative: love first, then "they took their pleasure in words" — the same verb of delight (τερπέσθην). She tells her siege; he tells his wanderings; "she delighted in the listening, and no sleep fell upon her eyelids till he had

told everything." The marriage of the poem's two great storytellers resumes as an exchange of stories — and the poem quietly makes listening the final act of love.

- 42 *l. 310* The précis (310–341): the *Odyssey* summarizes itself in bed — Cicones to Calypso to Phaeacia, one adventure per breath, in narrative order rather than the poem's own folded telling. What the summary drops is instructive: no Cretan tales, no beggar-craft — the fictions go unmentioned in the marriage's audit; and Calypso's offer of immortality is included with its refusal ("she never persuaded the heart in his breast") — the one clause in the whole catalogue addressed, quietly, to the listener beside him: he was offered forever, and chose this bed.
- 43 *l. 342* "That was the last word he spoke, as the sweet sleep / that unstrings the limbs leapt on him" — the teller falls asleep inside his own telling, mid-story delivered, the poem's narrator-hero finally unconscious at the exact moment his tale is fully told. The *Odyssey's* image of consummation is not the love-making — it is a man allowed, at last, to stop narrating.
- 44 *l. 350* The morning speech opens with the marriage's balance-sheet: "we have had our fill of trials, / the two of us both" — her weeping and his detention entered side by side, ἀμφοτέρω, both. The poem's final settlement of its double plot: both sufferings on the same page, in the same sentence.
- 45 *l. 355* And immediately: inventory. Guard the property; the wasted flocks "many I will raid back myself, and the Achaeans / will give the rest, until they fill up every fold." The morning after the miracle, Odysseus is doing agricultural arithmetic — raid-economics (Athena's own idiom, 20.49–51) as pillow-talk. The poem's realism about restoration: even resurrection has a livestock ledger.
- 46 *l. 361* His last orders to her — upstairs, the women, see no one, ask nothing — prescribe the posture the poem has always found her in, re-assumed for one more morning. The poem's tenderest structural rhyme: she returns to the upper room exactly as always, except that now the waiting has a fixed end and a known face.
- 47 *l. 371* The book's final image: full daylight over the earth, and Athena hiding four armed men in a portable night, leading them out of town. The goddess who held back one dawn now carries darkness into another — the poem's last stage-management, walking the plot toward Laertes' orchard with the light switched off. Book 24 will open in the other darkness, among the ghosts.





## Odyssey — Book 24

*The second Nekyia; Laertes and the trees; the peace of Ithaca.*

- And Hermes of Cyllene was calling out the souls<sup>1</sup>  
of the suitor-men. He held in his hands the rod,  
beautiful, golden, with which he charms men's eyes  
to sleep, whose eyes he wills, and wakes others from their slumber;  
5 with this he set them moving and led them, and they followed,  
squeaking.  
As when bats in the corner of a wondrous cave<sup>2</sup>  
flit squeaking, when one drops off  
the chain of them clinging to the rock and to each other:  
so these went with him, squeaking; and Hermes  
10 the kindly led them down along the dank ways.  
Past the streams of Ocean they went, past the White Rock,<sup>3</sup>  
past the gates of the Sun and the country of dreams,  
and soon they came to the meadow of asphodel,  
where the souls have their dwelling — the phantoms of the worn-out  
dead.<sup>4</sup>  
15 There they found the soul of Achilles, Peleus' son,  
and of Patroclus, and of blameless Antilochus,  
and of Ajax, who was first in beauty and in build  
of all the Danaans after the blameless son of Peleus.<sup>5</sup>  
These were gathered around Achilles; and close to them  
20 came the soul of Agamemnon, Atreus' son,  
grieving; and around him others were gathered — all who died  
beside him in Aegisthus' house, and met their fate.  
And the soul of Peleus' son spoke to him first:  
"Son of Atreus, we used to say that you, of all  
25 the hero-men, were dear to Zeus who delights in thunder  
all your days — because you were lord over many strong men  
in the land of the Trojans, where we Achaeans suffered.  
And yet it was to you that ruinous doom  
would come so early — the doom no man born escapes.  
30 If only, in the fullness of the honor you were lord of,<sup>6</sup>

you had met your death and fate in the land of the Trojans:  
 then all the Achaeans together would have made your tomb,  
 and you would have won great fame for your son hereafter.  
 As it was, your portion was to be caught by the most pitiful of deaths."

35 Then the soul of Atreus' son answered him:

"Blessed son of Peleus, Achilles like the gods,  
 who died at Troy, far from Argos — and around you the others  
 fell, the best of the sons of Trojans and Achaeans,  
 fighting over your body; and you in the swirl of the dust

40 lay great in your greatness, your horsemanship forgotten.<sup>7</sup>

And we fought the whole day through, and would never  
 have ceased from the fighting, had Zeus not stopped us with a storm.  
 And when we had carried you out of the battle to the ships,  
 we laid you on a bier, and cleansed your beautiful body

45 with warm water and with oil; and over you the Danaans  
 shed many hot tears, and cut their hair.

And out of the sea your mother came, with the deathless sea-women,  
 when she heard the news; and a cry went up over the deep,  
 unearthly — and trembling took hold of all the Achaeans.

50 They would have sprung up then and fled to the hollow ships,  
 had not a man held them back, one deep in old wisdom:  
 Nestor, whose counsel had shown truest long before.

With good will toward them he spoke out and said:  
 'Hold, Argives! Do not run, young men of the Achaeans!

55 It is his mother coming out of the sea, with the deathless  
 sea-women, to look on the face of her dead son.'

So he spoke, and the great-hearted Achaeans checked their flight.  
 And around you stood the daughters of the old man of the sea,  
 mourning piteously; and they wrapped you in imperishable clothing.

60 And the Muses, all nine, answering voice to lovely voice,<sup>8</sup>  
 sang the dirge. Not one Argive could you have seen  
 unweeping then, so keen was the clear Muse's song.  
 Seventeen days together, nights and days alike,  
 we mourned you — deathless gods and mortal men;

65 on the eighteenth we gave you to the fire, and around you  
 slaughtered fat sheep in plenty and spiral-horned cattle.  
 You burned in the clothing of the gods, in oil in plenty

- and in sweet honey; and many Achaean heroes  
 moved in armor around your burning pyre,  
 70 men on foot and horsemen, and a great roar went up.  
 And when the flame of Hephaestus had made an end of you,  
 at dawn we gathered your white bones, Achilles,  
 into unmixed wine and oil. Your mother gave  
 a golden two-eared jar — a gift of Dionysus,<sup>9</sup>  
 75 she said, and the work of famous Hephaestus.  
 In that lie your white bones, shining Achilles,  
 mingled with the bones of dead Patroclus, Menoetius' son,  
 and apart lie Antilochus', whom you honored beyond  
 all your other companions after Patroclus died.  
 80 And over them all we heaped a great and blameless tomb —  
 we, the sacred army of Argive spearmen —  
 on a jutting headland over the broad Hellespont,  
 so it might be seen far off, from the open sea,  
 by men now living and by men to come.<sup>10</sup>  
 85 And your mother asked the gods for prizes of great beauty  
 and set them in the middle of the field, for the best of the Achaeans.  
 You have stood by now at the funeral games of many  
 heroes — when a king has died, and the young men  
 belt themselves and make ready for the prizes —  
 90 but had you seen those, your heart would have wondered most:  
 what beautiful prizes the goddess set out in your honor,  
 silver-footed Thetis. For you were most dear to the gods.  
 So not even in death did you lose your name: forever,<sup>11</sup>  
 among all mankind, your fame will be noble, Achilles.  
 95 But I? What joy of it had I, when I had wound the war to its end?  
 On my homecoming Zeus devised a wretched death for me  
 at the hands of Aegisthus and my accursed wife."  
 So they spoke to one another of such things.  
 And the guide came near them, the slayer of Argus,  
 100 leading down the souls of the suitors Odysseus broke;<sup>12</sup>  
 and the two, amazed, went straight toward them at the sight.  
 And the soul of Agamemnon, Atreus' son, knew  
 the dear son of Melaneus, far-famed Amphimedon:  
 for he had been his guest-friend, with his home in Ithaca.

- 105 The soul of Atreus' son spoke to him first:  
 "Amphimedon, what has happened to you, that you plunge under the  
 dark earth,  
 all of you picked men, all of an age? A man choosing  
 the best in a city could not have chosen better.  
 Did Poseidon break you in your ships,  
 110 raising cruel winds and long waves?  
 Or did enemies on land destroy you  
 while you were cutting out their cattle and fine flocks of sheep,  
 or as they fought for their city and their women?"<sup>13</sup>  
 Answer what I ask: I declare myself your guest-friend.
- 115 Do you not remember when I came to your house there,  
 with godlike Menelaus, to urge Odysseus  
 to follow with us to Ilium on the well-benched ships?  
 A whole month it took us to cross all that wide sea,  
 and hard work to win over Odysseus, sacker of cities."<sup>14</sup>
- 120 Then the soul of Amphimedon answered him:  
 "Most glorious son of Atreus, Agamemnon lord of men,  
 I remember all of it, Zeus-nurtured, as you tell it;  
 and I will recount to you everything, fully and truly —  
 the evil end of our death, how it was brought to pass.
- 125 We were courting the wife of Odysseus — of the man so long away.  
 She neither refused the marriage she loathed, nor would she make an  
 end,  
 plotting for us death and the black doom;<sup>15</sup>  
 no — here is another trick her heart devised:  
 she set up a great loom in the halls and wove at it,  
 130 fine-threaded, beyond all measure wide, and told us straightway:  
 'Young men, my suitors — since noble Odysseus is dead,  
 wait, though you burn for my wedding, till I finish  
 this cloth — let my spinning not be wasted on the wind —  
 a shroud for the hero Laertes, against the day  
 135 the ruinous doom of death that lays men low will take him:  
 let no Achaean woman in the land hold it against me  
 that a man who won so much should lie without his winding-sheet.'  
 So she spoke, and our proud hearts were persuaded.  
 Then every day she wove at the great loom,

- 140 and every night she unwove it by torchlight.  
 Three years her trick escaped us, and she kept the Achaeans persuaded;  
 but when the fourth year came, as the seasons rolled on,  
 the months waning away, the long tale of days accomplished,  
 then one of her women, who knew it all, told us,
- 145 and we caught her unweaving the shining web.  
 So she finished it — against her will, under force.<sup>16</sup>  
 And when she had shown us the robe — the great web woven  
 and washed — and it shone like the sun or the moon,<sup>17</sup>  
 just then some evil god brought Odysseus from somewhere
- 150 to the border of the land, where the swineherd had his house.  
 There came also the dear son of godlike Odysseus,  
 back in his black ship out of sandy Pylos;  
 and the two of them plotted an evil death for the suitors  
 and came to the famous town — Odysseus
- 155 later; it was Telemachus who led the way before him.  
 The swineherd brought the master, in bad clothes on his body,  
 in the likeness of a beggar, wretched and old,  
 leaning on a stick, with miserable clothing on his body;  
 and not one of us could know him for the man he was,
- 160 breaking on us suddenly like that — not even the older men —  
 no: we went at him with ugly words, and with things thrown.  
 And he for a while endured it in his own halls,  
 pelted and taunted, with an enduring heart;  
 but when the mind of Zeus who bears the aegis roused him,
- 165 with Telemachus he lifted the beautiful armor away  
 and stowed it in the storeroom and shot the bolts,  
 and then — his cunning at work — he ordered his wife<sup>18</sup>  
 to set before the suitors the bow and the gray iron,  
 the contest for us star-crossed men, and the beginning of the slaughter.
- 170 And not one of us could stretch the string  
 of that strong bow: we fell far, far short of it.  
 But when the great bow came into Odysseus' hands,  
 then all of us together shouted out threats  
 not to give him the bow, however much he pleaded;
- 175 only Telemachus urged him on and commanded it.  
 And he took it in his hand, much-enduring noble Odysseus,

and strung the bow with ease, and shot through the iron,  
 and went and stood on the threshold, and poured out the swift arrows,  
 glaring terribly — and he shot Antinous the king.  
 180 And then he sent his groaning shafts into the others,  
 aiming straight ahead; and they fell in heaps.  
 It was plain some god was their helper in the fight:  
 for storming down the hall in their fury they killed  
 left and right, and hideous groaning rose  
 185 as heads were smashed, and the whole floor smoked with blood.  
 So we perished, Agamemnon — and even now  
 our bodies lie uncared-for in the halls of Odysseus:<sup>19</sup>  
 for the friends in each man's house do not yet know —  
 the ones who would wash the black gore from our wounds  
 190 and lay us out with wailing; for that is the portion of the dead."

Then the soul of Atreus' son answered him:  
 "Blessed son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices —<sup>20</sup>  
 truly you won a wife of great excellence!  
 How sound the mind of blameless Penelope,  
 195 Icarius' daughter! How faithfully she kept the memory  
 of Odysseus, her wedded husband! And so the fame of her excellence  
 will never perish; and the deathless ones will make  
 a song for those on earth, a song of grace, for steady-hearted Penelope  
 —<sup>21</sup>

not like the daughter of Tyndareus, who plotted evil,  
 200 who killed her wedded husband: a song of loathing  
 she will be among mankind; and she brings hard fame  
 on all women — on womankind, even on those who do right."<sup>22</sup>  
 So the two of them spoke to one another of such things,  
 standing in the house of Hades, under the hidden places of the earth.<sup>23</sup>  
 205 And the others — when they had gone down from the city, they soon  
 reached  
 the beautiful well-worked farm of Laertes, which Laertes himself  
 had won long ago, when his labors for it were many.<sup>24</sup>  
 There was his house, and running all around it the sheds  
 where the bound slaves ate, and sat, and slept —  
 210 the ones whose labor did his will.  
 And in the house was an old Sicilian woman, who cared

- for the old man devotedly, out on the farm far from the town.  
 And there Odysseus spoke to the slaves and to his son:  
 "You now — go inside the well-built house,  
 215 and slaughter for dinner, right away, the best of the pigs;  
 and I will make a trial of my father —<sup>25</sup>  
 whether he will know me, whether his eyes will make me out,  
 or fail to know a son so long away."  
 So speaking he handed the slaves his weapons of war.  
 220 They went quickly on into the house; and Odysseus  
 moved up toward the fruited orchard, testing.  
 And going down into the great garden he found no Dolius,  
 none of the slaves, none of the sons: they had gone off  
 gathering fieldstones for the orchard wall,  
 225 and the old man had led them the way.  
 So he found his father alone in the well-worked orchard,  
 spading round a young tree — in a filthy tunic,  
 patched, disgraceful; round his shins he had bound  
 stitched leggings of oxhide, to fend off the scratches,  
 230 and gloves on his hands because of the thorns; and on his head  
 he wore a goatskin cap — feeding his sorrow.<sup>26</sup>  
 And when much-enduring noble Odysseus saw him —  
 broken with old age, the great grief packed inside him —  
 he stopped beneath a towering pear tree, and wept.<sup>27</sup>  
 235 Then he weighed it in his mind and in his heart:  
 to kiss his father, and hold him, and tell him everything —  
 how he had come, how he had reached his fathers' land —  
 or question him first, and test him through and through.  
 And as he weighed it, this seemed to him the better way:  
 240 to try him first with words that bite.  
 With this in mind, noble Odysseus went straight up to him.  
 He was holding his head down, spading round his tree,  
 and standing beside him his shining son spoke to him:  
 "Old man — no lack of skill in you at tending  
 245 an orchard! Everything is beautifully kept: not one thing —  
 no plant, no fig tree, no vine, no olive,  
 no pear tree, no vegetable bed — goes untended in this garden.  
 But another thing I will say — and do not take anger into your heart:

- you — you are not well kept. Hard old age is on you,  
 250 and with it you are shabby with grime, and clothed in disgrace.  
 It cannot be for idleness that your master neglects you;  
 and there is nothing of the slave to be seen in you,  
 in your face or your stature: you look like a kingly man.<sup>28</sup>  
 You look like one who, after his bath and his dinner,  
 255 should sleep on softness: for that is the right of the old.  
 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:  
 Whose slave are you? Whose orchard do you tend?  
 And tell me this too, honestly, so that I may know it:  
 is this land we have come to truly Ithaca, as that man  
 260 told me who met me on the road just now —  
 not too well furnished in the wits: he had not the patience  
 to tell me everything or hear out my question  
 about a guest-friend of mine — whether he lives still,  
 or is dead by now, and down in the house of Hades.  
 265 For I will tell you this; mark it and hear me:  
 I once played host, in my own dear country, to a man  
 who came to our place; and never has another mortal  
 of all the far-come strangers been more welcome in my house.  
 He declared his stock was out of Ithaca; he said  
 270 his father was Laertes, Arceisius' son.  
 So I brought him to the house and gave him welcome,  
 warm and openhanded — the house had plenty in it —  
 and I gave him gifts of friendship, such as fitted:  
 seven talents of well-worked gold I gave him,  
 275 a mixing-bowl all silver, worked with flowers,  
 twelve single cloaks, as many coverlets,  
 as many beautiful mantles, tunics with them,  
 and besides all this, four women skilled in blameless  
 handwork, good-looking ones — his own choice, whichever he  
 would."<sup>29</sup>  
 280 And his father answered him, weeping:  
 "Stranger, you have come indeed to the land you ask for —  
 but violent men hold it now, men lost to decency.  
 The gifts you showered on him — the countless gifts — were wasted.  
 If you had found him alive in the land of Ithaca,



- 285 he would have sent you off well matched in gifts,  
 well hosted too: that is the law, for whoever begins the kindness.<sup>30</sup>  
 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:  
 how many years is it since you hosted him —  
 that guest of yours, that luckless man — my son, if he ever was:<sup>31</sup>
- 290 my ill-starred son? Whom, far from his friends and his fathers' land,  
 either the fish have eaten in the sea, or on dry ground  
 he has become the spoil of beasts and birds; and his mother  
 never shrouded and mourned him, nor his father — we who bore him;  
 nor did his richly dowered wife, steady-hearted Penelope,  
 295 keen over her own husband on the bier, as was fitting,  
 or close his eyes: and that is the portion of the dead.<sup>32</sup>  
 And tell me this too, honestly, so that I may know it:  
 What man are you, and from where? Where are your city and your  
 parents?<sup>33</sup>  
 And where is the fast ship standing that brought you here
- 300 with your godlike companions? Or did you come a passenger  
 on another's ship, which set you down and went on?"  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 "Then I will tell you everything exactly.  
 I am from Alybas, where I have my famous house:
- 305 son of Apheidas, the son of lord Polypemon;  
 my own name is Eperitus. But a god<sup>34</sup>  
 drove me wandering here from Sicania, against my will,  
 and my ship stands off the fields, away from the town.  
 As for Odysseus — this is now the fifth year
- 310 since he went from there, and left my country —  
 the ill-starred man! And yet the birds were good when he set out:  
 on the right; and I rejoiced in them as I sent him off,  
 and he rejoiced as he went. And the heart in both of us hoped  
 we would meet again as guest-friends, and give each other shining  
 gifts."<sup>35</sup>
- 315 So he spoke; and a black cloud of grief closed over the old man:  
 with both hands he scooped up the scorched gray dust  
 and poured it down over his white head, sobbing thick and fast.<sup>36</sup>  
 And the heart of Odysseus was shaken; up through his nostrils  
 shot the sharp sting of tears — his father before his eyes.<sup>37</sup>

- 320 He sprang to him, and caught him in his arms, and kissed him:  
 "Father — I am he. I myself, the man you ask for,<sup>38</sup>  
 come home in the twentieth year to my fathers' land.  
 Stop now — no more weeping, no more tears and mourning.  
 For I tell you this — and the need to hurry is very great:
- 325 I have killed the suitors in our own halls;  
 I have punished their heart-stinging outrage and their evil deeds."  
 Then Laertes answered him and said:  
 "If you are truly Odysseus — my son — come home,  
 tell me some sign, some plain one, so I can believe."<sup>39</sup>
- 330 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 "First — this scar: see it with your own eyes —  
 where the boar dealt me its white tusk, on Parnassus,  
 the time I went there. It was you who sent me — you and my honored  
 mother — to Autolycus, her dear father, to collect
- 335 the gifts he promised me, and nodded to, when he came here.<sup>40</sup>  
 And then — come — let me tell you the trees in the well-worked  
 orchard  
 you gave me once. I was begging you for each of them,  
 a little boy, trailing you through the garden. We wound  
 among these very trees, and you named them one by one:
- 340 you gave me thirteen pear trees, and ten apple trees,  
 and forty fig trees; and you named fifty rows of vines  
 as mine to come, each one ripening in its own turn —  
 clusters of every kind hanging along them —  
 whenever the seasons of Zeus came down and weighed them low."<sup>41</sup>
- 345 So he spoke; and the old man's knees went slack where he stood, and  
 his dear heart,  
 as he recognized the tokens Odysseus described so surely.<sup>42</sup>  
 He threw his arms around his dear son — and fainting  
 he was caught against him by much-enduring noble Odysseus.  
 And when he had got his breath, and the spirit gathered back into his  
 heart,
- 350 once more he found his words, and answered:  
 "Father Zeus — you gods are still there on high Olympus,<sup>43</sup>  
 if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage!  
 But now the terror in my heart is this: that soon

- the men of Ithaca will all come here against us,  
 355 and send out messengers everywhere, to every Cephallenian town."  
 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
 "Courage. Do not let that trouble the heart in your breast.  
 Come — let us go to the house that stands here by the orchard:  
 I sent Telemachus ahead there, with the cowherd  
 360 and the swineherd, to make the meal as quickly as they can."  
 So the two of them talked, and made their way to the beautiful house.  
 And when they came to the well-settled house,  
 they found Telemachus and the cowherd and the swineherd  
 carving meat in plenty and mixing the sparkling wine.  
 365 Meanwhile the great-hearted Laertes, in his own house,  
 was bathed by the Sicilian serving-woman, and rubbed with oil,  
 and she threw a beautiful cloak around him; and Athena  
 came and stood close by, and filled out the limbs of the shepherd  
 of the people: taller than before she made him, and broader to the eye.  
 370 Out of the bath he came; and his dear son wondered at him,  
 seeing him face to face like the deathless gods,<sup>44</sup>  
 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to him:  
 "Father — surely one of the gods who are forever  
 has made you finer to look at, in beauty and in stature!"  
 375 Then Laertes the clear-headed answered him:  
 "If only — father Zeus, Athena, Apollo! —<sup>45</sup>  
 such a man as I was when I took Nericus, the strong-built  
 citadel on the mainland cape, lording it over the Cephallenians —  
 such a man, in armor, I had stood beside you yesterday  
 380 in our own house, and beaten at the suitor-men:  
 then I would have unstrung the knees of many of them  
 there in the halls — and the heart in you would have been glad!"  
 So they spoke to one another of such things.  
 And when the others had finished their work and made the meal,  
 385 they sat down in order on the benches and the chairs,  
 and were just putting their hands to the food, when up came  
 the old man Dolius, and with him the old man's sons,<sup>46</sup>  
 tired out from their field-work: their mother had gone out  
 and called them — the old Sicilian woman, who raised them  
 390 and tended the old man devotedly, now that age had hold of him.

- And when they saw Odysseus, and their hearts took it in,  
they stopped in the hall, astounded. But Odysseus  
fastened on them with gentle words and said:  
"Old man — sit down to dinner, and all of you, forget your wonder.
- 395 We have been waiting in the hall a long while, eager  
to put our hands to the bread, expecting you every minute."  
So he spoke; and Dolius came straight at him, both arms  
spread wide; and he caught Odysseus' hand and kissed it at the wrist,<sup>47</sup>  
and lifting his voice he spoke winged words:
- 400 "Dear master — since you have come home to us who longed for you  
and had given up believing, and the gods themselves have brought you:  
health, and all joy to you, and may the gods give you happiness!  
But tell me this thing truly, so that I may know it:  
does watchful-minded Penelope know already
- 405 that you are home — or shall we send a messenger?"<sup>48</sup>  
Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:  
"Old man, she knows already. Why should you be busied with that?"<sup>49</sup>  
So he spoke; and Dolius sat back down on the polished stool.  
And in the same way the sons of Dolius, around famous Odysseus,
- 410 pressed his hands and welcomed him with words,  
and sat down in order beside Dolius their father.  
So they were busy with dinner in the house.  
But Rumor the messenger went darting through the city everywhere,<sup>50</sup>  
crying the hateful death and doom of the suitors.
- 415 And the people heard it all at once, and gathered  
from every side, with groans and wailing, before the house of Odysseus.  
Each family carried its dead out of the house, and buried them;  
and the dead of the other cities they sent home,  
laying each man aboard the fishermen's fast ships,<sup>51</sup>
- 420 and they went in a body to the assembly-place, grieving at heart.  
And when they were assembled, all gathered together,  
Eupeithes rose among them and spoke:  
for a grief there was no forgetting lay upon his heart —<sup>52</sup>  
for his son, Antinous, the first man noble Odysseus killed;
- 425 weeping for him he rose and spoke among them:  
"Friends — a monstrous work this man has wrought against the  
Achaean!

Some he led off in the ships — many men, and brave ones —  
and he lost the hollow ships, and lost the people;<sup>53</sup>  
and some he has killed on his return — far the best of the  
Cephalenians.

- 430 Come then — before he can get away quickly to Pylos,  
or to shining Elis, where the Epeians hold power —  
let us move! Or we hang our heads in shame forever after.  
This is a disgrace even for men unborn to hear of,<sup>54</sup>  
if we do not take vengeance on the murderers of our sons  
435 and our brothers. For me — there would be no sweetness left  
in living: I would rather die at once and be among the perished.  
Move — before they get across the water and away from us!"  
So he spoke, weeping; and pity took hold of all the Achaeans.  
But now Medon came up to them, and the godlike singer,  
440 out of the halls of Odysseus, for sleep had let them go;  
they stood in the middle of them; and amazement took every man.  
And Medon, whose mind knew wisdom, spoke among them:  
"Hear me now, men of Ithaca. Not without the will  
of the deathless gods did Odysseus devise these things.  
445 I myself saw a deathless god, who stood  
close beside Odysseus, and looked in all things like Mentor;  
and this deathless god now showed in front of Odysseus,  
heartening him — and now he stormed the hall,  
stampeding the suitors; and they fell in heaps."<sup>55</sup>  
450 So he spoke; and the pale terror took hold of them all.  
And the old hero Halitherses spoke among them,  
Mastor's son — for he alone saw before and behind:<sup>56</sup>  
with good will toward them he spoke out and said:  
"Hear me now, men of Ithaca, hear what I say.  
455 By your own fault, friends, these things have come to pass:<sup>57</sup>  
you would not listen to me, nor to Mentor, shepherd of the people,  
and make your sons leave off their reckless folly —  
your sons who did a monstrous work in their wicked blindness,  
shearing away the goods and dishonoring the wife  
460 of a man of the first rank, saying he would come home no more.  
So now — let it rest here. Do as I say:  
do not march. Some of us may draw the evil down on his own head."

- So he spoke; and more than half leapt up  
 with a great battle-shout — but the rest stayed there in a body:<sup>58</sup>
- 465 for the word did not please them in their hearts; it was Eupheithes  
 they followed; and they rushed at once for their weapons.  
 And when they had cased their flesh in the flashing bronze,  
 they gathered in a body before the wide-spaced town;  
 and Eupheithes led them, in his folly:
- 470 he was sure he would avenge the killing of his son — and he was never  
 to come back again: he was to meet his own fate there.<sup>59</sup>  
 And now Athena spoke to Zeus, the son of Cronos:  
 "Father of us all, son of Cronos, highest of the mighty,  
 answer me when I ask: what is your mind hiding now within?
- 475 Will you push on with evil war and the terrible battle-din,  
 or set the two sides now in friendship?"<sup>60</sup>  
 Then Zeus who gathers the clouds answered her:  
 "My child, why do you ask me? Why question me on this?  
 Was it not you who framed this plan yourself —
- 480 that Odysseus should come home and pay those men in full?  
 Do as you will. But I will tell you what is fitting.  
 Now that noble Odysseus has paid the suitors out,  
 let them cut faithful oaths — he to be king all his days —  
 and let us, for our part, set a forgetting of the killing
- 485 of sons and of brothers. Let them love one another  
 as before; and let wealth and peace be there in plenty."<sup>61</sup>  
 So speaking he stirred Athena — eager long before —  
 and down she went darting from the peaks of Olympus.  
 Now when they had put from them the desire for honey-hearted food,
- 490 much-enduring noble Odysseus began among them:  
 "Someone go out and look — in case they are close, and coming."  
 So he spoke; and a son of Dolius went out, as he ordered,  
 and stood on the threshold, and saw them — all of them — near,  
 and quickly he spoke winged words to Odysseus:
- 495 "Here they are — close! Quick — to arms!"  
 Up they sprang and got into their armor —  
 the four around Odysseus, and the six sons of Dolius;  
 and with them Laertes and Dolius got into armor too,  
 gray though they were: fighters because they must be.<sup>62</sup>

- 500 And when they had cased their flesh in the flashing bronze,  
they opened the doors and went out; and Odysseus led.  
And near them came the daughter of Zeus, Athena,  
likened to Mentor in body and in voice;  
and much-enduring noble Odysseus was glad at the sight of her,  
505 and quickly he spoke to Telemachus his dear son:  
"Telemachus — now you will learn it for yourself, standing where  
men fight it out, and the best are sorted from the rest:  
shame nothing of your fathers' line. In strength and manhood  
we have excelled from of old across the whole earth."<sup>63</sup>
- 510 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:  
"You will see me, if you care to look, dear father, in this temper  
shaming nothing of your line — as you have said."  
So he spoke; and Laertes exulted, and cried out:  
"What a day this is for me, dear gods! Great is my joy:  
515 my son and my son's son are striving over excellence!"<sup>64</sup>  
And gray-eyed Athena came and stood by him and said:  
"Son of Arceisius — far the dearest of all my companions —<sup>65</sup>  
pray to the gray-eyed girl, and to Zeus her father,  
then swing the long-shadowed spear up, and let it fly."
- 520 So spoke Pallas Athena, and breathed great strength into him;  
and he prayed then to the daughter of great Zeus,  
and swung the long-shadowed spear up, and let it fly,  
and struck Eupheithes through the bronze-cheeked helmet:  
the helmet did not stop the spear; the point drove through,  
525 and he fell with a crash, and his armor clattered upon him.<sup>66</sup>  
And Odysseus and his shining son fell on the front-fighters,  
hacking with swords and double-pointed spears;  
and they would have destroyed them all, cut them off from  
homecoming,  
had not Athena, daughter of Zeus who bears the aegis,  
530 cried out with her voice, and checked the whole array:  
"Hold back, men of Ithaca, from grinding war —  
separate now, quickly, and without blood!"<sup>67</sup>  
So spoke Athena; and the pale terror seized them:  
out of their frightened hands the weapons flew,  
535 and all fell on the ground at the goddess's cry,

and they turned toward the city, aching to live.<sup>68</sup>

And terribly then cried out much-enduring noble Odysseus,

and gathering himself he swooped like a high-flown eagle.

But then the son of Cronos let fly his smoking bolt,

540 and it fell in front of the gray-eyed one, the great Father's daughter.<sup>69</sup>

And then gray-eyed Athena said to Odysseus:

"Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices,

hold! Stop the strife of leveling war —

for fear the son of Cronos be angered with you: Zeus of the wide voice."

545 So spoke Athena. He obeyed — and his heart was glad.<sup>70</sup>

And a sworn peace between the two sides, for all days to come,

was set by Pallas Athena, daughter of Zeus who bears the aegis,

likened to Mentor in body and in voice.<sup>71</sup>



NOTES TO ODYSSEY — BOOK 24

- 1    *l. 1* Hermes as soul-guide — only here in Homer does he perform the office that later Greece made his title (psychopompos). The rod is his rod from 5.47–48, in the same two lines: the wand that lulls and wakes the eyes of men now herds the suitors to Erebus. One instrument, both ends of the poem: enchantment and death were always the same tool.
- 2    *l. 6* The bat simile: souls squeak like bats in a cave's corner when one drops off the clinging chain. The suitors — feasters, shouters, throwers of stools — are reduced to a sound: τρίζειν, the thin squeak. No underworld image in Homer is more contemptuous or more pitiful; the men who filled a hall now cannot fill a whisper.
- 3    *l. 11* The itinerary of the dead: Ocean's streams, the White Rock, the gates of the Sun, the country of dreams. The poem's far geography files its last report — and "the country of dreams" (δῆμον οὐείρων) lies on the road to death, one stop before the asphodel: Penelope's gates of horn and ivory (19.562ff) were border-crossings of this same land.
- 4    *l. 14* "The phantoms of the worn-out dead" — εἰδωλα καμόντων: the dead as *the exhausted*, images of men who labored. The Odyssey's underworld was always a place of fatigue rather than fire; its last visit keeps the accent.
- 5    *l. 15* The quartet: Achilles, Patroclus, Antilochus, Ajax — the Iliad's heart, waiting together, with Ajax's grudge (11.543ff) apparently outlived. The second Nekyia opens the poem's final ledger: before Odysseus' triumph can close, it must be measured once more against Troy's dead.
- 6    *l. 30* Achilles' condolence inverts the first Nekyia: there (11.488ff) he spurned the consolations of glorious death — better a hired hand alive than king of the dead. Here he wishes Agamemnon had died at Troy for the tomb's and the son's sake. Death has not changed his mind; the two speeches agree — nothing redeems dying, but since die you must, the funeral and the fame are all that can be salvaged.
- 7    *l. 39* "You in the swirl of the dust / lay great in your greatness, your horsemanship forgotten" — the Iliad's own line for Cebriones (Il. 16.775–776), re-spent on Achilles himself. The most beautiful epitaph in Greek: sheer size outlasting skill, the body still magnificent when everything it knew is gone.
- 8    *l. 60* The Muses — all nine, "answering voice to lovely voice" — sing the dirge: their only full appearance in Homer. Poetry's patronesses attend the funeral of poetry's subject; epic sings at its own hero's burial. Agamemnon's report is the closest the tradition comes to describing its own birth: grief, organized into antiphonal beauty, until no Argive could keep from weeping.
- 9    *l. 73* The golden amphora, "a gift of Dionysus... the work of famous Hephaestus": wine-god's gift, smith-god's craft, holding the mixed bones of Achilles and Patroclus. The Iliad's promise (23.83ff, Patroclus' request) is confirmed kept, by a witness speaking from the far side of every death involved.

- 10 l. 80 The tomb on the Hellespont headland, "seen far off, from the open sea, by men now living and by men to come" — fame as coastal navigation-mark. Achilles' immortality is architectural and real: sailors will steer by his death. This is the exact glory Agamemnon envies — a sightline — and the contrast with his own unmarked murder is the speech's engine.
- 11 l. 93 The exchange's two verdicts, set side by side: "not even in death did you lose your name" — and "But I? What joy of it had I...?" The poem's oldest pairing (fame against homecoming) is settled by the dead themselves: Achilles won the name and lost everything; Agamemnon wound up the war and was butchered at dinner. Between them stands the absent third term — the man who got home *and* will get the song — about to be announced by the arriving shades.
- 12 l. 99 The suitors arrive in Hades as their killer makes his way out to his father's farm. The poem's two final locations — asphodel and orchard — run in deliberate parallel: the dead explaining downward, the living replanting above.
- 13 l. 109 Agamemnon's guesses at how a hundred picked men died — shipwreck, cattle-raid, war for a city and its women — are the heroic economy's complete menu of respectable deaths. The truth (shot at dinner for eating another man's house) fits no category he can imagine; the suitors managed to die in a way the *Iliad* has no word for.
- 14 l. 115 Agamemnon's memory: a month's voyage and "hard work to win over Odysseus" — the tradition of the reluctant draftee (the madness feigned at the plow, in the cycle) surfacing for a moment. The man who had to be dragged from his wife is the one whose wife crowned his homecoming — while the king who mustered him got the knife; the poem lets the connection stand unspoken.
- 15 l. 126 Amphimedon's version adds a motive the poem never showed: Penelope delayed "plotting for us death and the black doom." From below, her stalling reads as premeditated murder — the web, the bow, all one design with her husband. The dead man's error (he also has Odysseus *ordering* her to set the contest, 167–168) is the famous crux: the last retelling of the plot is subtly wrong exactly where Penelope's independence was the truth. The suitors die as they lived — unable to imagine that her choices were her own.
- 16 l. 128 The web-story's third and last performance (2.94ff, Antinous' complaint; 19.139ff, her own account; now the victims' obituary). Same lines, third key: what was outrage in the suitor's mouth and stratagem in hers is here elegy — the trick that measured out their deaths retold by its objects, verbatim, under the earth. The poem's most repeated passage is repeated once per perspective; the formula system as a rotating court.
- 17 l. 147 Only this telling shows the finished shroud: "it shone like the sun or the moon." Laertes' burial-cloth, woven as a delaying fiction, emerges as a masterpiece — and the man it was woven for is alive in his orchard, about to be found by the son whose absence the weaving mourned. The web outlived its pretext into pure beauty — still a shroud, still waiting for its old man, but woven free of its trick; the poem gives the suitors' shade the honor of reporting it.
- 18 l. 167 "His cunning at work — he ordered his wife": wrong. Athena moved her (21.1ff), and the poem was explicit that Odysseus learned of the contest only as it happened.

Amphimedon's reconstruction is rational, coherent, and false — the standing lesson of the *Odyssey* applied posthumously: the plausible story is not the true one. Agamemnon's great praise of Penelope (192ff) is built on this flawed brief and is still correct — the rare case of a right verdict from wrong findings.

- 19 l. 186 "Even now our bodies lie uncared-for" — the shade's complaint is settled before the book ends: at 417–419 the families bury them. The poem allows the dead their grievance and then quietly closes it, as if even the underworld's paperwork must be filed before the epic can end. "That is the portion of the dead" (γέρας θανόντων) — the phrase Laertes will use of the unmourned Odysseus at 296: burial rites as the one inheritance no one should lose.
- 20 l. 192 The macarism: "Blessed son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices — truly you won a wife of great excellence!" Agamemnon's last word in literature is a beatitude for another man's marriage. The ceremonial vocative (Calypso spoke it first, 5.203) is bent from "Zeus-born" to "Blessed" — ὀλβιε: the poem's final ranking of its hero's fortunes puts the wife above the war-fame.
- 21 l. 196 "The deathless ones will make a song for those on earth, a song of grace, for steady-hearted Penelope." The *Odyssey* names itself: this poem is the song the gods made for Penelope. Twenty-three books were framed as the hero's; the poem's own certificate of contents, issued in Hades by the poem's greatest victim of marriage, is made out in her name.
- 22 l. 199 And the counter-song: Clytemnestra as "a song of loathing" (στυγερὴ ἀοιδή). The double frame that opened the poem (1.32ff, Aegisthus) closes it: two wives, two songs. But Agamemnon cannot stop there — "she brings hard fame on all women, even on those who do right." His last clause slanders the sex in the very breath that crowns its best member; the poem lets the bitterness stand, uncorrected, as the residue of his story — and its distance from Odysseus' own conclusions is the measure of the two marriages.
- 23 l. 203 Farewell to the dead: "standing in the house of Hades, under the hidden places of the earth." The poem leaves them mid-conversation — Achilles unconsolated, Agamemnon still explaining, the suitors still fresh — and surfaces for good. No judgment scene, no punishment: Homer's underworld remains a place where the dead simply go on talking about what happened.
- 24 l. 205 Laertes' farm, "which Laertes himself had won long ago, when his labors for it were many" — κτεάτισσεν: acquired, earned. The estate is self-made, like the bed, like the orchard walls his slaves are out gathering stones for. Father and son hold things because they worked them; it is the ground of the whole coming scene.
- 25 l. 216 "I will make a trial of my father" — πειρήσομαι, the family verb, one last time. The most debated decision in the poem: why test a broken old man? The poem's own answers stand in layers: testing is his identity (he tested wife, son, slaves, father — everyone but the dog); recognition in this epic must be earned through σήματα or it is worthless; and the deliberation at 235–240 shows the alternative fully considered — kiss him and tell everything — and set aside. What the poem does not do is defend him; it lets the cruelty and the method be one thing, visibly, to the end.

- 26 l. 226 Laertes' costume: patched filthy tunic, stitched oxhide leggings, thorn-proof gloves, goatskin cap — the poem inventories it like armor. A king dressed below his own slaves, "feeding his sorrow": grief as deliberate self-abasement, the exact mirror of his son's chosen rags — Laertes' worn for years, Odysseus' for days. The recognition scene is two disguises meeting.
- 27 l. 232 Odysseus weeps under the pear tree before he can speak — the plan nearly dies at the sight of the old man. The pear tree is one of *the* trees (340); he cries under his own inheritance. Then the deliberation formula, and the coldest choice in the poem: "to try him first with words that bite" (κροτούσις). The heart breaks and the method proceeds anyway; that is Odysseus, complete, in three lines.
- 28 l. 244 The tease is built on the book's true paradox: the orchard immaculate, the orchardist ruined — "everything is beautifully kept... you — you are not well kept." And inside the cruelty, the recognition that keeps escaping the disguise's victims all poem: "nothing of the slave to be seen in you... you look like a kingly man" (Philoetius' exact perception of the beggar, 20.194). The son does to the father what the world did to him: sees the king through the wreck and asks the wreck to explain itself.
- 29 l. 266 The last false autobiography — a guest-tale of hosting Odysseus five years past, with a gift-list (gold, silver bowl, cloaks, four women) itemized in the same breath as 19's inventions. It is aimed, like the tale to Penelope, at producing evidence of grief; and it works instantly and terribly.
- 30 l. 283 "The gifts you showered on him — the countless gifts — were wasted": Laertes answers a fiction with the deepest law of the poem — reciprocity broken by death. He grieves, in the middle of everything, for the *guest*: the stranger's gifts can never now be returned, "and that is the law, for whoever begins the kindness." Even destroyed, the old king's first thought is the *xenia*-ledger.
- 31 l. 289 "My son, if he ever was" — εἴ ποτ' ἔην γε: Penelope's identical phrase (19.315), and Telemachus' before her (15.268). Son, wife, father — three members of one family have reached for the same broken-grammared doubt: whether the past itself was real. It is the poem's formula for grief so long it corrodes memory backward.
- 32 l. 290 The unmourned-corpse fantasy: fish in the sea or beasts and birds on land, no shroud from the mother, no keening wife, no closed eyes. Laertes has rehearsed his son's missing funeral in exact liturgical detail for years — the same nightmare Telemachus voiced (1.161ff) and Eumaeus (14.133ff). The family's shared image of the worst is precisely what the poem has spent 24 books preventing.
- 33 l. 298 The identity-question formula — "What man are you, and from where?" — asked for the last time in the poem, by the oldest asker, of the son it has pursued since Telemachus first put it to a disguised god at 1.170. The poem retires its oldest question here, where the answer will finally be given un-disguised.
- 34 l. 304 The last alias is a rebus of the truth: Eperitus ("Man of Strife" — the contested one) son of Apheidas ("Unsparing") son of Polypemon ("Much-Suffering"), from Alybas (echoing ἀλάομαι, "wander"), driven from Sicania "against my will." Read the genealogy straight and it confesses: a much-suffering, unsparing, strife-marked wanderer. Five

books of fictitious selves end with a name-chain that is nothing but his own biography in etymological drag.

- 35 l. 309 "The fifth year... and the birds were good when he set out: on the right" — the fiction's cruelest instrument: dated hope with favorable omens attached. It is calibrated to make the old man compute — five years, good birds, no return — and it does; the grief-cloud closes over him on schedule. The tester has measured the exact dose that will break the subject.
- 36 l. 315 The dust: both hands, the scorched gray handfuls, poured over the white head, "sobbing thick and fast." The oldest mourning gesture in the epic tradition (Achilles at Il. 18.23ff), performed by a father over a living son standing an arm's length away. It is the strongest image in the book, and the experiment's result: grief confirmed genuine — at the price of causing it.
- 37 l. 318 "Up through his nostrils shot the sharp sting" — *δριμὸν μένος*: grief as physiology, the acrid rush before tears. The tester's system fails at last: not at the rags, not at the weeping, but at the dust on the white head. Every other test in the poem ran to completion; this one is aborted by the experimenter's own body.
- 38 l. 321 "Father — I am he. I myself, the man you ask for": the poem's last self-revelation, and its shortest. To the son: "I am your father." To the slaves: "I am the man himself." To the father, the plainest of all — *κεῖνος ἐγώ*: *that man — I*. The pronoun the whole poem has been hiding is handed over bare.
- 39 l. 328 Laertes, shattered, mid-grief, his son's arms around him, still says: "tell me some sign, some plain one, so I can believe." The family method holds at its weakest link — no recognition without evidence, not even here. Odysseus' father is the final proof of where Odysseus came from.
- 40 l. 331 The scar's fourth and last showing (Eurycleia, the herdsmen, now the father) — this time with its provenance spoken to the man who was part of it: "It was you who sent me — you and my honored mother." The wound's biography (19.393ff) is finally recited to its origin; the *σῆμα* completes its circuit through the whole family.
- 41 l. 336 The trees: thirteen pear, ten apple, forty fig, fifty rows of vines "each one ripening in its own turn." The poem's final recognition-token is not a wound or a bed but an inheritance recited — a little boy trailing his father through the garden, begging for each tree, and the father naming them one by one. Proof of identity is here proof of having been loved as a child, in countable units still standing and bearing. No recognition in literature is gentler, and none more secure: only the boy who was given the trees can number them.
- 42 l. 345 Knees slack, tokens recognized — the identical couplet that felled Penelope (23.205–206), which itself repeated the clothes-test line (19.250). Wife, then father: the family falls to the same two verses, one by one. The formula system's last great rhyme; and this time the recognized man must catch the recognizer bodily — the father faints into the son's arms, the poem's final embrace of the generations.
- 43 l. 351 Laertes' theology, restored in one clause: "you gods are still there on high Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid." Divine existence proven by executed justice — the old

man's faith was not lost but suspended pending evidence, like everything else in this family. And his second sentence is already tactical (the town will come): joy, theology, and threat-assessment in a single breath. He is Odysseus' father.

- 44 l. 365 Laertes bathed, oiled, cloaked, and filled out by Athena — the family glow-up's last recipient (Odysseus 6.229ff and 23.156ff, Penelope 18.190ff, Telemachus 2.12ff). The son "wondered at him, seeing him face to face like the deathless gods": the man found in rags and goatskin at noon stands god-like by dinner. The restoration of the house is rendered, as always in this poem, cosmetically — grace poured over those it reclaims.
- 45 l. 376 "If only — father Zeus, Athena, Apollo!" — the wish-formula's final firing (Menelaus 4.341, relayed 17.132; Telemachus 18.235), now from the grandfather, wishing himself into yesterday's battle with his Nericus-taking strength. Guest-friend, grandson, grandfather: the same optative wish has crossed the poem to land at last inside the family, its grammar of longing uniform down the line.
- 46 l. 387 Dolius — father of Melanthius and Melantho, though the poem breathes no word of it here. The old man greets his master with open arms while his son lies mutilated and his daughter hanged in the town house. Whether Homer suppresses the connection, or the Dolius of the farm was always distinct in the tradition, the silence sits like a held breath over the scene: the loyal father of the disloyal children asks after Penelope's happiness.
- 47 l. 397 Dolius kisses Odysseus' hand "at the wrist" — the precise clasp Penelope remembered of her husband's farewell (18.258). The gesture-vocabulary of the house passes through its oldest servant intact.
- 48 l. 400 Dolius' question — does Penelope know, "or shall we send a messenger?" — is the old retainer's protocol-mind at work: the mistress must be informed. The last words spoken about Penelope in the poem are a servant's worry for her feelings.
- 49 l. 406 "Old man, she knows already. Why should you be busied with that?" — clipped, faintly amused, and the poem's final line concerning its heroine: *she knows already*. As epitaphs for Penelope go, the accidental one is perfect.
- 50 l. 413 Rumor ("Ὀσσα) as messenger — the divine personification that sped news at 1.282–283 now runs the massacre through the town. The poem's information-economy closes its books: the secret held by disguise, oath, locked doors, and a faked wedding-dance is finally released as pure Ossa, everywhere at once.
- 51 l. 417 The burials — each family carries out its own, the foreign dead shipped home on fishermen's boats — quietly answer Amphimedon's complaint (186–190) before the assembly even meets. The poem does its last logistics: every corpse routed, every household in mourning, the stage cleared for the question of what the living will do about it.
- 52 l. 423 "A grief there was no forgetting" — ἄλαστον πένθος — lies on Eupheithes' heart. Mark the word: the peace sixty lines away will be built on ἐκλησις, *forgetting*, imposed by the gods (485). The book stages its final conflict as a duel between two nouns: the grief that cannot forget and the amnesty that commands it.

- 53 *l. 427* Eupheithes' indictment reaches back past the suitors to the fleet: "he lost the hollow ships, and lost the people" — the twelve ships' companies of twenty years ago (9.159), never before charged to Odysseus' account on Ithaca. The town's whole ledger is opened: two generations of sons dead in this man's wake. The poem does not rebut the charge — it is true — and Eupheithes' grief is real; his own unpaid debt (saved from the mob by Odysseus, 16.424ff) is the one entry he omits.
- 54 *l. 433* "A disgrace even for men unborn to hear of" — Eurymachus' shame-formula from the bow-contest (21.255), now in the father's mouth: the same posterity-panic that kept the suitors failing publicly at the bow drives their fathers to the vendetta. The idiom is hereditary, and it kills in both generations.
- 55 *l. 442* Medon's eyewitness theology — "I myself saw a deathless god... like Mentor" — is precisely accurate reportage, for once believed. The herald saved for good deeds spends his reprieve on the truth, and "the pale terror" (the Nekyia's fear-formula, now loose above ground) does what argument could not.
- 56 *l. 451* Halitherses, "who alone saw before and behind" — the seer whose eagle-reading the suitors mocked in Book 2 (2.157ff) with Eurymachus' "many birds fly about under the sun." His verdict now: "By your own fault, friends" — the fathers indicted for not curbing the sons, the poem's collective-responsibility clause. His counsel splits the city: more than half spring up at his word and quit the field, and it is the remnant that stays with Eupheithes and arms. After god, omen, massacre, and confession, the majority can at last be persuaded; the poem's last word on crowds is quieter than its reputation.
- 57 *l. 455* "By your own fault" (ὕμετέρη κακότητι) — the assembly-scene of Book 2 replayed with the accusations reversed: there Telemachus blamed the fathers' sons; here the seer blames the sons' fathers, and the same men shout both times. Ithaca's civic machinery has learned exactly nothing — which is why the ending must be imposed from above.
- 58 *l. 463* The split: "more than half" rise at the seer's word and go home; the rest, unpersuaded, arm and march. The poem is unsentimental about the peace it is about to declare — already chosen by the many, it must still be enforced on the last armed few by divine amnesia. Utopia does not conclude the Odyssey; a managed settlement does.
- 59 *l. 469* "Eupheithes led them, in his folly... never to come back: he was to meet his own fate there." The narrator's death-notice formula, served on the vendetta's leader before the march begins — as it was served on Antinous (21.98ff). Father and son get identical advance obituaries, one book apart: the house of Eupheithes is the poem's control experiment in how grief without wisdom breeds in place.
- 60 *l. 472* The last Olympian scene mirrors the first: Athena raising Odysseus' case with Zeus (1.44ff), now raising its epilogue — "war, or friendship between the two?" The poem's entire action is bracketed by this daughter managing this father; and his answer here — "was it not you who framed this plan yourself? Do as you will" — is the same amused delegation that launched Book 1. The Odyssey is, first to last, Athena's project with Zeus's countersignature.
- 61 *l. 477* The settlement's terms: oaths cut, Odysseus king "all his days," and — the extraordinary clause — "let us set a forgetting of the killing of sons and of brothers" (ἐκλήσιν θέωμεν): whether a literal blotting of memory or an amnesty in the word's

oldest sense, a laying-down of the grievance, the text does not say. The poem of memory — whose hero is saved by remembering, whose heroine proves love by remembering, whose recognition-tokens are all memories — ends by prescribing an ordained forgetting, however administered, as the price of civil peace. "Let them love one another as before; and let wealth and peace be there in plenty": the most beautiful and most troubling sentence of political theology in Homer, and the poem offers it without irony as what it costs to stop the cycle.

- 62 l. 496 The muster: twelve — Odysseus' four, Dolius' six, and the two old men, "gray though they were: fighters because they must be" (ἀναγκαῖοι πολεμισταί). The house's whole remaining manhood, from grandfather to field-hand's sons, in one rank. Against them, the town. The poem's last battle-roster is a family and its farm.
- 63 l. 506 The father's last instruction: "shame nothing of your fathers' line. In strength and manhood we have excelled from of old across the whole earth." Not tactics — lineage. And the son's answer deploys his whole arc in one cool sentence: *watch, if you care to*. The boy who needed a goddess to imagine his father now invites his father to spectate.
- 64 l. 513 Laertes' cry — "What a day this is for me, dear gods! Great is my joy: my son and my son's son are striving over excellence!" The poem's final happiness is the grandfather's: three generations armed in one line, competing in ἀρετή. For this one line the Odyssey becomes what the Iliad never could: an epic in which the generations survive to stand together. It is the book's true summit, and the poem places it — with perfect judgment — in the mouth of the man who had been digging round a tree in a goatskin cap that morning.
- 65 l. 517 "Son of Arceisius — far the dearest of all my companions": Athena's tenderness for the old man, addressed by the grandfather-patronymic, admitted to the company of her ἑταῖροι. She scripts his aristeia — pray, swing, throw — and breathes the strength in. The poem grants its last kill to its oldest fighter.
- 66 l. 520 Laertes' single throw kills Eupheithes through the bronze-cheeked helmet. The symmetry is the poem's last arithmetic: Antinous, first-killed, was Eupheithes' son; now Antinous' father falls to Odysseus' father. Grief against grief, father against father — the vendetta's own logic executed once, exactly. It is the last kill the poem narrates, though father and son fight on until Athena calls the halt (526–544); the old man who missed yesterday's battle (379–382) gets his one spear-cast in compensation.
- 67 l. 528 "They would have destroyed them all, cut them off from homecoming" — ἀνόστους: made *nostos*-less. The poem's ultimate curse-word, nearly inflicted by its own hero on his neighbors. Athena's cry — "separate now, quickly, and without blood!" (ἀναίμωτῇ) — arrives one death too late to be literal; the word is aspiration, not description, and the poem knows it.
- 68 l. 533 The pale terror's last seizure: weapons fly from hands at a goddess's voice, and the townsmen turn for home "aching to live" (λιλαίόμενοι βιότοι). The suitors were never once described as aching to live; their fathers, at the last moment, are — and are spared for it. Wanting life, in this poem, has always been the beginning of deserving it.
- 69 l. 537 And Odysseus does not stop. He cries out terribly and swoops "like a high-flown eagle" — the omen-bird of his own return (15.161ff, 19.538ff, 20.243) become the man



himself, stooping on the routed. It takes Zeus' thunderbolt, dropped at Athena's feet, to check him: heaven must interdict its own champion, in the last forty lines, to keep the poem from ending as the Iliad. The war-reflex twenty years deep does not switch off; it is *commanded* off.

- 70 l. 541 The final address is the full ceremonial vocative, one last time: "Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices — hold!" The title that summoned him to councils and stratagems all poem long is used, at the end, to tell him to stop. "He obeyed — and his heart was glad" (χαῖρε δὲ θυμῷ): the last interior note of the Odyssey is relief — the man of wrath and craft glad, at the end, to be prevented. Of all the poem's homecomings, this is the innermost one: permission to stop fighting, received with joy.
- 71 l. 546 The coda: the sworn peace "for all days to come," set by Pallas Athena "likened to Mentor in body and in voice." The poem ends not on the couple, not on the family, but on the polity — pacified by oath and enforced forgetting — and its very last line is a disguise: the goddess wearing, to the end, the borrowed shape of an old Ithacan friend. The Odyssey closes as it worked: divinity in a familiar face, and the future held together by a carefully constructed appearance. Whatever the Alexandrians thought of Book 24, the poem's final image is its signature — μῆτις, wearing a human face, making peace stick. The song the gods made for Penelope, and for the man at odds, is complete.

# INDEX OF NAMES AND PLACES

Every named person, god, people, and place in the poem, with a pronunciation (*Say:*), epithets, aliases, kin, and line citations. Pronunciations give the traditional anglicized reading; stress falls on the capitalized syllable.

**Achaea** (Ἀχαιῶ) · PLACE — *Say:* uh-KEE-uh

The Greek mainland, the Achaeans' homeland, named in passing as the country Odysseus's men and Penelope's suitors alike measure their exile or their marriages against.

**Refs:** 11.166, 11.481, 21.107, 23.68.

*See also:* Achaeans.

**Achaeans** (Ἀχαιοί) · PEOPLE — *Say:* uh-KEE-unz

The poem's default name for the Greeks who sailed to Troy and for their descendants on Ithaca and elsewhere; interchangeable throughout with Argives and Danaans. Invoked constantly as the collective audience, army, or assembly against which individual action is measured.

*Epithets:* "the long-haired Achaeans" (κάρη κομόωντες Ἀχαιοί, 1.90); "the strong-greaved Achaeans" (ἔυκνήμιδες Ἀχαιοί, 2.72); "the bronze-shirted Achaeans" (χαλκοχίτωνες Ἀχαιοί, 1.286).

*Also called:* Argives; Danaans — synonyms for the same host, metrically convenient variants, not distinct peoples.

**Refs:** 1.90, 1.239, 1.272, 1.286, 2.7, 2.72, 3.79, 3.100, 3.137, 4.106, 4.330 ...and throughout. Books 1–24.

*See also:* Achaea, Troy.

**Acheron** (Ἀχέρων) · PLACE — *Say:* AK-uh-ron

One of the underworld's rivers, named at the meeting of the waters where Circe directs Odysseus to perform the rites that summon the dead.

**Refs:** 10.513.

*See also:* Aeaea.

**Achilles** (Ἀχιλλεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* uh-KIL-eez

Greatest of the Achaeans at Troy, remembered throughout the poem as the standard against which other heroes and other deaths are measured. His ghost, met in the underworld, rejects Odysseus's consolations: he would rather serve as a hired hand to a landless man than rule over all the dead (11.486ff). In the underworld's final scene his shade is reunited with the ghosts of the newly dead suitors, hearing of Odysseus's homecoming vengeance.

*Also called:* "Aeacides," son of Peleus and grandson of Aeacus (11.471, 11.538); "the blameless son of Peleus."

*Kin:* son of Peleus.

**Refs:** 3.106, 3.109, 3.189, 4.5, 8.75, 11.467, 11.471, 11.478, 11.482, 11.486, 11.538, 11.546, 11.558, 24.15, 24.19, 24.36, 24.72, 24.76, 24.94. Books 3–4, 8, 11, 24.

*See also:* Ajax, Antilochus, Agamemnon.

**Actoris** (Ἀκτορίς) · MORTAL — *Say:* ak-TOR-is

## INDEX OF NAMES AND PLACES

Penelope's slave-woman, given to her by her father when she first came to Ithaca; she alone knew the secret of the bedchamber door, and Penelope cites her as the one living witness who could confirm the bed's construction — though by the time of the recognition scene she is dead.

**Refs:** 23.228.

*See also:* Penelope.

**Adreste** (Ἀδρήστη) · MORTAL — Say: uh-DRES-tee

One of Helen's handmaids in Sparta, who sets out her reclining chair when Helen enters the hall to greet Telemachus.

**Refs:** 4.123.

*See also:* Alcippe, Alcandre.

**Aeaea** (Αἶαῖα) · PLACE — Say: ee-EE-uh or ay-EE-uh

Circe's island, where Odysseus's crew lands after the Laestrygonian disaster; the ship returns there after the underworld voyage before the final sailing past the Sirens and through the strait of Scylla and Charybdis.

**Refs:** 9.32, 10.135, 11.70, 12.3, 12.268, 12.273.

*See also:* Acheron.

**Aeetes** (Αἰήτης) · MORTAL — Say: ee-EE-teez

Sorcerer-king of Aea, son of Helios and brother of Circe; named as a genealogical marker of Circe's fearsome bloodline and, in Book 12, as one whose home the sun rises from in Circe's directions.

*Kin:* son of Helios; brother of Circe.

**Refs:** 10.137, 12.70.

*See also:* Aeaea, Helios, Circe.

**Aegae** (Αἰγαί) · PLACE — Say: EE-jee

Poseidon's seat beneath the sea, where he keeps his glittering golden palace; named as the god descends to watch Odysseus's raft from the mountains of the Solymi.

**Refs:** 5.381.

*See also:* Poseidon.

**Aegisthus** (Αἰγισθος) · MORTAL — Say: ee-JIS-thus

Son of Thyestes and cousin to Agamemnon; while Agamemnon fights at Troy he seduces Clytemnestra, murders the king at his homecoming feast, and rules Mycenae for years until Orestes kills him in vengeance. Zeus opens the poem citing him (1.29–43) as proof that mortals bring ruin on themselves "beyond their portion," and Nestor and Menelaus both retell the story to Telemachus as the poem's standing counter-example to Odysseus's own return.

*Epithets:* "blameless Aegisthus" (ἄμύμων Αἰγισθος, 1.29); "Aegisthus of the crooked counsels" (Αἰγισθος δολόμητις, 1.300).

*Kin:* son of Thyestes; paramour of Clytemnestra.

**Refs:** 1.29, 1.35, 1.42, 1.300, 3.194–198, 3.235–310 (Nestor's telling), 4.518–537, 11.389, 11.409, 24.22, 24.97. Books 1, 3–4, 11, 24.

*See also:* Agamemnon, Orestes.

**Aegyptius** (Αἰγύπτιος) · MORTAL — Say: ee-JIP-tee-us

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Aged Ithacan, bent with years, who opens the assembly Telemachus calls in Book 2; his own son Antiphus had sailed to Troy with Odysseus and was later killed by the Cyclops.

*Kin:* father of Antiphus.

**Refs:** 2.15.

*See also:* Antiphus.

**Aeolus** (Αἰολός) · GOD — *Say:* EE-oh-lus

Warden of the winds, son of Hippotes; he hosts Odysseus for a month and sends him off with the storm winds bound in a leather bag, keeping only the West Wind free to carry the ships home. His men's greed opens the bag within sight of Ithaca, and when the storm blows them back to his island a second time, Aeolus refuses to help further, certain the gods hate his guest.

*Kin:* son of Hippotes.

**Refs:** 10.1–60, 11.237, 23.314. Books 10–11, 23.

*See also:* Odysseus.

**Aeson** (Αἴσων) · MORTAL — *Say:* EE-son

Son of Tyro and Cretheus, named among Tyro's sons in the underworld catalogue; father of Jason in the wider tradition, though the poem itself says no more of him.

*Kin:* son of Tyro and Cretheus; brother of Pheres and Amythaon.

**Refs:** 11.259.

*See also:* Amythaon.

**Aethon** (Αἶθων) · MORTAL — *Say:* EE-thon

The false name Odysseus gives himself in the fictitious autobiography he tells Penelope in Book 19, claiming to be the younger brother of Idomeneus of Crete who once hosted the real Odysseus storm-driven at Amnisus.

**Refs:** 19.183.

*See also:* Amnisus, Odysseus.

**Aetolians** (Αἰτωλοί) · PEOPLE — *Say:* ee-TOH-lee-unz

The people of the mainland stranger who once cheated Eumaeus with a false tale about Odysseus, the memory of which makes the swineherd wary of the next wandering beggar's story.

**Refs:** 14.379.

*See also:* Eumaeus.

**Agamemnon** (Ἀγαμέμνων) · MORTAL — *Say:* ag-uh-MEM-non

Overlord of the Achaean host at Troy, elder son of Atreus and brother of Menelaus. Murdered by Aegisthus and Clytemnestra at his homecoming, his shade meets Odysseus in the underworld (11.387ff) and his fate is retold by Nestor, by Proteus through Menelaus, and finally by his own ghost again in Book 24 — the poem's recurring paradigm of the ruined return, set against Odysseus's own.

*Epithets:* "shepherd of the people" (ποιμὴν λαῶν, 3.156).

*Also called:* "son of Atreus" / "Atreides" — but so is Menelaus; the referent is Agamemnon in the underworld and homecoming-paradigm scenes, Menelaus in the Telemachy (see canon.md).

*Kin:* son of Atreus; husband of Clytemnestra; father of Orestes; brother of Menelaus.

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**Refs:** 1.30, 3.143–164, 3.234–264, 4.532–584, 8.77, 9.263, 11.168, 11.387–397, 13.384, 14.70–497, 24.20–186. Books 1, 3–4, 8–9, 11, 13–14, 24.

*See also:* Aegisthus, Menelaus, Orestes.

**Agelaus** (Ἀγέλαος) · MORTAL — Say: aj-uh-LAY-us

Son of Damastor and one of the leading suitors in the final fight in the hall; he urges the others on and is among the last killed, cut down by Odysseus after Athena's aegis turns the tide.

*Kin:* son of Damastor.

**Refs:** 20.321, 20.339, 22.131, 22.136, 22.212, 22.241, 22.247, 22.327. Books 20, 22.

*See also:* Antinous, Eurymachus.

**Ajax** (Αἴας) · MORTAL — Say: AY-jaks

Two heroes share the name. The greater Ajax, son of Telamon, was second only to Achilles among the Achaeans at Troy; in the underworld his shade alone refuses to speak to Odysseus, still raging over the contest for Achilles's armor that Odysseus won against him (11.543–553). A second, lesser Ajax, son of Oileus, drowns at sea on the voyage home after boasting he escaped the gods' will — the wreck Menelaus recounts hearing of from Proteus (4.499).

*Kin:* the greater, son of Telamon; the lesser, son of Oileus.

**Refs:** 3.109, 4.499, 11.469, 11.543–553, 24.17. Books 3–4, 11, 24.

*See also:* Achilles, Agamemnon.

**Alcandre** (Ἀλκάνδρη) · MORTAL — Say: al-KAN-dree

Egyptian woman, wife of Polybus of Thebes, who gave Helen a silver basket among the gifts the couple brought back from Egypt.

**Refs:** 4.126.

*See also:* Adreste, Alcippe.

**Alcimus** (Ἄλκιμος) · MORTAL — Say: AL-sih-mus

Father of Mentor, named once when Mentor's household is identified during the suitors' final assault.

*Kin:* father of Mentor.

**Refs:** 22.235.

*See also:* Mentor.

**Alcinous** (Ἀλκίνοος) · MORTAL — Say: al-SIN-oh-us

King of the Phaeacians on Scheria and Odysseus's last host before Ithaca. He receives the shipwrecked stranger, presides over the games and feast at which Odysseus is moved to tell his wanderings, and sends him home asleep on a Phaeacian ship laden with gifts — the act for which Poseidon later turns that ship to stone.

*Epithets:* "great-hearted Alcinous" (μεγαλήτωρ Ἀλκίνοος, 6.17); "the sacred strength of Alcinous" (ιερόν μένος Ἀλκινόοιο, 7.167).

*Kin:* son of Nausithous (himself a son of Poseidon), brother of Rhexenor; marries his niece Arete; father of Nausicaa and Laodamas.

**Refs:** 6.12–17, 6.139–303, 7.10–346 (the reception and the genealogy), 8.2–421 (games and feast). Books 6–9, 11, 13.

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*See also:* Arete, Nausicaa, Poseidon.

**Alcippe** (Ἀλκίππη) · MORTAL — *Say:* al-SIP-ee

One of Helen's handmaids in Sparta, who brings a rug of soft wool as Helen enters to greet Telemachus.

**Refs:** 4.124.

*See also:* Adreste, Alcandre.

**Alcmaeon** (Ἀλκμαίων) · MORTAL — *Say:* alk-MEE-on

Son of the seer Amphiaraus, named alongside his brother Amphilocheus in Theoclymenus's account of his own ancestry.

*Kin:* son of Amphiaraus.

**Refs:** 15.248.

*See also:* Amphiaraus, Amphilocheus.

**Alcmene** (Ἀλκμήνη) · MORTAL — *Say:* alk-MEE-nee

Wife of Amphytrion; lying with Zeus, she bore Heracles. Named among the great women's shades Odysseus meets in the underworld, and invoked earlier by Antinous as a byword for the cunning of legendary women, in his backhanded praise of Penelope's web-trick.

*Kin:* wife of Amphytrion; mother of Heracles by Zeus.

**Refs:** 2.120, 11.266. Books 2, 11.

*See also:* Amphytrion.

**Alector** (Ἀλέκτωρ) · MORTAL — *Say:* uh-LEK-tor

Spartan whose daughter marries Megapenthes, Menelaus's son, in the double wedding feast under way when Telemachus arrives at Sparta.

**Refs:** 4.10.

*See also:* Menelaus.

**Aloeus** (Ἀλωεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* uh-LEE-us or al-OH-yoos

Putative father, by marriage to Iphimedeia, of the giant twins Otus and Ephialtes — though Iphimedeia claims she lay with Poseidon himself. Named in the underworld catalogue of famous women.

*Kin:* husband of Iphimedeia.

**Refs:** 11.305.

*See also:* Poseidon.

**Alpheus** (Ἀλφειός) · PLACE — *Say:* al-FEE-us or AL-fee-us

The great river of Elis, treated as a god in its own right; ancestor, several generations back, of Ortilochus and so of the Spartan house that hosts Telemachus.

**Refs:** 3.489, 15.187.

*See also:* Achaea.

**Alybas** (Ἄλυβας) · PLACE — *Say:* AL-ih-bas

The distant town Odysseus invents as his home when he tests Laertes in disguise at the poem's end, claiming to be one Eperitus, son of Apheidas, from Alybas.

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**Refs:** 24.304.

*See also:* Apheidas.

**Amnisus** (Ἀμνισός) · PLACE — *Say:* am-NY-sus

Cretan harbor by the cave of Eileithyia, where in the fictitious Aethon-tale Odysseus tells Penelope the storm once drove the real Odysseus ashore on his way to Troy.

**Refs:** 19.188.

*See also:* Aethon.

**Amphiarus** (Ἀμφιάραος) · MORTAL — *Say:* am-fee-uh-RAY-us

Seer and warrior, son of Oicles, beloved of Zeus and Apollo; he dies at Thebes, brought down by a woman's bribe (the necklace given his wife to persuade him into the fatal expedition). Named in Theoclymenus's account of his own descent from the seer's line; father of Alcmaeon and Amphilocheus.

*Kin:* son of Oicles; father of Alcmaeon and Amphilocheus.

**Refs:** 15.244, 15.253. Book 15.

*See also:* Alcmaeon, Amphilocheus, Amythaon.

**Amphilocheus** (Ἀμφίλοχος) · MORTAL — *Say:* am-FIL-oh-kus

Son of the seer Amphiarus, named alongside his brother Alcmaeon in Theoclymenus's ancestral catalogue.

*Kin:* son of Amphiarus.

**Refs:** 15.248.

*See also:* Amphiarus, Alcmaeon.

**Amphimedon** (Ἀμφιμέδων) · MORTAL — *Say:* am-FIM-uh-don

Son of Melaneus and one of the suitors killed in the hall; his ghost, arriving in the underworld among the newly dead, narrates the whole courtship and slaughter to the shade of Agamemnon in Book 24 — the poem's last long retelling of its own climax.

*Kin:* son of Melaneus.

**Refs:** 22.242, 22.277, 22.284, 24.103–120. Books 22, 24.

*See also:* Agamemnon, Antinous.

**Amphinomus** (Ἀμφινόμος) · MORTAL — *Say:* am-FIN-oh-mus

Son of Nisus and the least brutal of Penelope's suitors, well-spoken enough that Odysseus, in disguise, tries to warn him away from the household's doom — advice he cannot bring himself to heed, since Athena has bound him to die by Telemachus's spear.

*Kin:* son of Nisus.

**Refs:** 16.351–406, 18.119–424, 20.244–247, 22.89–96 (his death). Books 16, 18, 20, 22.

*See also:* Antinous, Eurymachus.

**Amphion** (Ἀμφίων) · MORTAL — *Say:* am-FY-on

Two men share the name. One, son of Zeus and Antiope, co-founds and walls Thebes with his brother Zethus (11.262). The other, son of Iasus, ruled Minyan Orchomenus and was father of Chloris, Nestor's mother (11.283).

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**Refs:** 11.262, 11.283. Book 11.

*See also:* Antiope.

**Amphithea** (Ἀμφιθέη) · MORTAL — Say: am-FITH-ee-uh

Wife of Autolycus and Odysseus's grandmother; she embraces him with joy when he arrives at his grandfather's house as a boy, in the tale of the boar-hunt that gave Odysseus his scar.

*Kin:* wife of Autolycus.

**Refs:** 19.416.

*See also:* Anticleia.

**Amphitrite** (Ἀμφιτρίτη) · GOD — Say: am-fih-TRY-tee

The sea personified as goddess, wife of Poseidon; invoked in descriptions of the deep waters  
Odysseus must cross, especially in the storm off Scheria.

*Kin:* wife of Poseidon.

**Refs:** 3.91, 5.422, 12.60, 12.97. Books 3, 5, 12.

*See also:* Poseidon.

**Amphitryon** (Ἀμφιτρίτων) · MORTAL — Say: am-FIT-ree-on

Mortal husband of Alcmena and Heracles's putative father, named alongside his wife in the underworld catalogue of famous women.

*Kin:* husband of Alcmena.

**Refs:** 11.266, 11.270. Book 11.

*See also:* Alcmena.

**Amythaon** (Ἀμυθάων) · MORTAL — Say: am-ih-THAY-on

Son of Tyro and Cretheus, named among her sons in the underworld catalogue of women.

*Kin:* son of Tyro and Cretheus; brother of Aeson and Pheres.

**Refs:** 11.259.

*See also:* Aeson, Amphiaras.

**Andraemon** (Ἀνδραίμων) · MORTAL — Say: an-DREE-mon

Father of Thoas, named only as a patronymic in the fictitious Trojan-War anecdote Odysseus tells  
Eumaeus in disguise: Thoas, Andraemon's son, is the one who jumps up to carry a message  
from a dream.

*Kin:* father of Thoas.

**Refs:** 14.499.

*See also:* Aetolians.

**Anticleia** (Ἀντίκλεια) · MORTAL — Say: an-tih-KLEE-uh or an-tih-KLY-uh

Odysseus's mother, who died of grief in his long absence without learning of his fate; her shade is  
the first Odysseus recognizes in the underworld, and their failed embrace — his arms closing  
three times on empty air — is one of the poem's starkest images of loss.

*Kin:* daughter of Autolycus; wife of Laertes; mother of Odysseus.

**Refs:** 11.85.



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*See also:* Laertes, Amphithea.

**Anticlus** (Ἀντίκλος) · MORTAL — Say: AN-tih-klus

Achaean hidden with Odysseus inside the wooden horse; when Helen, circling it, calls out in the voices of their wives, Anticlus alone is on the point of answering, and Odysseus clamps his hands over the man's mouth to save them all.

**Refs:** 4.286.

*See also:* Odysseus.

**Antilochus** (Ἀντίλοχος) · MORTAL — Say: an-TIL-oh-kus

Nestor's son and Achilles's close friend, killed at Troy; recalled in Nestor's own account of the war's losses and named among the shades gathered around Achilles in the underworld.

*Kin:* son of Nestor.

**Refs:** 3.112, 4.187, 4.202, 11.468, 24.16, 24.78. Books 3–4, 11, 24.

*See also:* Achilles, Ajax.

**Antinous** (Ἀντίνοος) · MORTAL — Say: an-TIN-oh-us

Son of Eupheithes and the most violent of Penelope's suitors; with Eurymachus he leads them, openly hostile where Eurymachus is smooth. He masterminds the ambush laid for Telemachus's return (4.660ff, 16.363–418) and hurls a stool at the disguised Odysseus in the hall (17.462ff), the worst outrage of the beggar-baiting.

*Kin:* son of Eupheithes.

**Refs:** 1.383–389, 2.84–321, 4.628–773, 16.363–418, 17.374–500, 18.34–292, 20.270–275, 21.84–269. Books 1–2, 4, 16–18, 20–21.

*See also:* Eupheithes, Eurymachus, Penelope.

**Antiope** (Ἀντιόπη) · MORTAL — Say: an-TY-oh-pee

Daughter of Asopus; lying with Zeus she bore Amphion and Zethus, the twin founders of Thebes. Named in the underworld catalogue of women.

*Kin:* mother of Amphion and Zethus by Zeus.

**Refs:** 11.260.

*See also:* Amphion.

**Antiphates** (Ἀντιφάτης) · MORTAL — Say: an-TIF-uh-teez

Two men share the name. One is the Laestrygonian king who wrecks Odysseus's fleet, hurling a boulder-sized rock and seizing a scout for his dinner before his people sink all but one ship (Book 10). The other is a mortal seer, son of Melampus's grandson Mantius, named in Theoclymenus's ancestral catalogue as father of Oicles (Book 15).

**Refs:** 10.106, 10.114, 10.199, 15.242, 15.243.

*See also:* Amphiarus.

**Antiphus** (Ἀντίφος) · MORTAL — Say: AN-tih-fus

Two men share the name. One is Aegyptius's son, who sailed with Odysseus to Troy and was later killed and eaten by the Cyclops Polyphemus. The other is a loyal old Ithacan, a companion of Odysseus's father from the beginning, who sits with Mentor and Halitherses as Telemachus slips away from the suitors.

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**Refs:** 2.19, 17.68. Books 2, 17.

*See also:* Aegyptius, Polyphemus.

**Apeire** · PLACE — *Say:* uh-PY-ree

The land from which Nausicaa's nurse Eurymedusa was carried off in ships, long before entering the Phaeacian royal household.

**Refs:** 7.8, 7.9.

*See also:* Scheria.

**Apheidas** (Ἀφείδας) · MORTAL — *Say:* uh-FY-das

Invented father — "son of lord Polypemon" — in the false identity Odysseus gives himself when he tests Laertes in disguise, claiming to be Eperitus of Alybas.

**Refs:** 24.305.

*See also:* Alybas.

**Aphrodite** (Ἀφροδίτη) · GOD — *Say:* af-roh-DY-tee

Goddess of love, here daughter of Zeus and Dione; her one extended appearance is Demodocus's song at the Phaeacian feast, caught in bed with Ares by Hephaestus's invisible net and displayed to the laughing gods (8.267–362). Elsewhere she is invoked chiefly as a standard of beauty, for Helen, Penelope, and Nausicaa alike.

*Epithets:* "laughter-loving Aphrodite" (φιλομμειδῆς Ἀφροδίτη, 8.362).

**Refs:** 4.14, 4.261, 8.267–362, 17.37, 18.193, 19.54, 20.68–73, 22.444. Books 4, 8, 17–20, 22.

*See also:* Ares, Hephaestus.

**Apollo** (Ἀπόλλων) · GOD — *Say:* uh-POL-oh

Archer-god of the silver bow, invoked as a standard of deadly and beautiful skill throughout — Odysseus prays men could shoot like him, Telemachus is compared to him, and it is on Apollo's own festival day that the suitors are slaughtered. Demodocus sings that Apollo warned Agamemnon of coming strife between Odysseus and Achilles at Troy.

*Also called:* Phoebus (3.279, 8.79, 9.201).

**Refs:** 3.279, 6.162, 7.65, 8.79–339, 9.198–201, 15.245–526, 17.132–494, 18.235, 19.86, 20.278, 21.267–364, 22.7, 24.376. Books 3–4, 6–9, 15, 17–22, 24.

*See also:* Artemis.

**Arceisius** (Ἀρκείσιος) · MORTAL — *Say:* ar-SEE-see-us

Odysseus's grandfather and father of Laertes; the line "son of Arceisius" marks Laertes's own royal descent, and Odysseus later prays to Zeus by his grandfather's name before the final battle with the suitors' kinsmen.

*Kin:* father of Laertes; grandfather of Odysseus.

**Refs:** 4.756, 14.181, 16.118, 24.270, 24.517. Books 4, 14, 16, 24.

*See also:* Laertes, Odysseus.

**Ares** (Ἄρης) · GOD — *Say:* AIR-eez

War-god, Aphrodite's lover in Demodocus's song, caught with her in Hephaestus's net and shamed before the gods (Book 8); elsewhere invoked as the standard of ferocity in battle and the eponym of martial vigor.

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**Refs:** 8.115–355, 8.517, 11.537, 14.216, 15.169, 16.269. Books 8, 11, 14–16.

*See also:* Aphrodite, Hephaestus.

**Arete** (Ἀρήτη) · MORTAL — *Say:* uh-REE-tee

Queen of the Phaeacians, Alcinous's wife and niece; Athena tells Odysseus his whole reception depends on winning her favor, and it is Arete who first recognizes the clothes she wove as the ones she gave Odysseus, prompting the question of his identity.

*Kin:* daughter of Rhexenor; wife of her uncle Alcinous.

**Refs:** 7.54–66, 7.141–335, 8.423–438, 11.335, 13.57–66. Books 7–8, 11, 13.

*See also:* Alcinous, Nausicaa.

**Arethusa** (Ἀρέθουσα) · PLACE — *Say:* a-ruh-THOO-zuh

Spring by Raven's Rock where Eumaeus's pigs drink, named in the description of the swineherd's stading.

**Refs:** 13.408.

*See also:* Eumaeus.

**Aretus** (Ἄρητος) · MORTAL — *Say:* uh-REE-tus

One of Nestor's sons at Pylos, who helps prepare the bath and the chariot for Telemachus's visit.

*Kin:* son of Nestor.

**Refs:** 3.414, 3.440.

*See also:* Antilochus, Peisistratus.

**Argives** (Ἀργεῖοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* AR-jyvz or AR-gyvz

One of the poem's three interchangeable names for the Greek host at Troy, alongside Achaeans and Danaans — from Argos, the Peloponnesian homeland of the expedition's leaders. It carries no separate ethnic sense from the others; the poet reaches for whichever fits the meter.

**Refs:** 1.61, 3.133, 4.184, 8.578, 11.369, 11.500, 17.119, 19.125, 24.61 ...and throughout. Books 1–4, 8, 10–12, 15, 17–19, 23–24.

*See also:* Achaeans, Danaans, Argos.

**Argo** (Ἀργώ) · OTHER — *Say:* AR-goh

The ship "known to all," Jason's vessel returning from Aeetes' land; among all ships that have ever tried the Wandering Rocks, it alone got through, and only because Hera favored Jason. Circe cites it to Odysseus as the sole precedent for surviving that passage.

**Refs:** 12.70.

*See also:* Charybdis, Scylla.

**Argos** (Ἄργος) · PLACE — *Say:* AR-gos

The Peloponnesian city and region ruled by the house of Atreus — distinct from Argus the hound, though the two names collide in English. It anchors the Achaean world geographically: Menelaus's Sparta and Agamemnon's Mycenae both fall within its orbit, and "Argive" derives from it.

**Refs:** 1.344, 3.180, 4.99, 4.726, 15.80, 15.239, 18.246, 21.108, 24.37. Books 1, 3–4, 15, 18, 21, 24.

*See also:* Argives, Agamemnon, Menelaus.

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**Argus** (Ἄργος) · OTHER — Say: AR-gus

Odysseus's old hound, raised as a pup and left behind when his master sailed for Troy. Neglected and dying on a dung-heap outside the hall, he alone among the household recognizes the beggar-disguised Odysseus — he lays back his ears and wags his tail, and the moment he has seen his master again, "the doom of black death took him" (17.326). Not to be confused with the Argus of "slayer of Argus," Hermes's epithet for a different, giant figure (see Hermes).

**Refs:** 17.292 (introduced), 17.300, 17.326 (dies), 24.99 (recalled). Book 17.

*See also:* Hermes, Odysseus, Eumaeus.

**Ariadne** (Ἀριάδνη) · MORTAL — Say: a-ree-AD-nee

Daughter of Minos of Crete; Theseus carries her off from Crete toward Athens but never wins his joy of her — Artemis kills her first, on the island of Dia, on Dionysus's word. Odysseus glimpses her shade among the heroines in the underworld.

**Refs:** 11.321.

*See also:* Crete, Minos (see Cnossus).

**Arnaeus** (Ἀρνάϊος) · MORTAL — Say: ar-NEE-us

The real name of the beggar everyone in Odysseus's hall calls Irus, given him by his mother at birth.

**Refs:** 18.5.

*See also:* Antinous.

**Artacia** (Ἀρτακίη) · PLACE — Say: ar-TAY-shee-uh

The spring in the land of the Laestrygonians, where Odysseus's men meet the giant king's daughter drawing water — the first contact before the slaughter of the fleet.

**Refs:** 10.108.

*See also:* Cicones.

**Artemis** (Ἄρτεμις) · GOD — Say: AR-tuh-mis

Virgin archer-goddess, sister of Apollo; the poem invokes her chiefly as the sender of sudden, painless death to women — Penelope prays for such an end more than once, and the phrase recurs of dead heroines. She also kills Ariadne on Dionysus's word (11.324) and lends her form and grace to similes for Nausicaa and Penelope alike.

*Epithets:* "of the golden shafts" (4.122 and elsewhere).

**Refs:** 4.122, 6.102, 6.151, 11.172, 11.324, 15.410, 17.37, 18.202, 19.54, 20.60. Books 4–6, 11, 15, 17–20.

*See also:* Apollo, Penelope, Nausicaa.

**Arybas** (Ἀρύβας) · MORTAL — Say: AR-ih-bas

A rich Phoenician named in Eumaeus's life-story — his old nurse's homeland belonged to Arybas before Phoenician traders and a treacherous nursemaid carried the boy Eumaeus off into slavery.

**Refs:** 15.426.

*See also:* Eumaeus.

**Asopus** (Ἀσωπός) · GOD — Say: uh-SOH-pus

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A river-god, father of Antiope, whom Zeus loves; their sons Amphion and Zethus later found and wall the city of Thebes. Named as Odysseus catalogues the heroines in the underworld.

**Refs:** 11.260.

*See also:* Cadmeians.

**Asphalion** (Ἀσφαλίων) · MORTAL — *Say:* as-FAL-ee-on

An attendant of Menelaus in his Spartan hall, mentioned once as he serves at the feast.

**Refs:** 4.216.

*See also:* Menelaus.

**Asteris** (Ἀστερίς) · PLACE — *Say:* AS-tuh-ris

A small islet in the strait between Ithaca and Same where the suitors lie in wait to ambush Telemachus's ship on his return from Pylos and Sparta.

**Refs:** 4.846.

*See also:* Antinous.

**Athena** (Ἀθήνη) · GOD — *Say:* uh-THEE-nuh

Daughter of Zeus and Odysseus's divine patron; the intelligence behind the whole plot. She wins his release from Calypso at the gods' council, rouses Telemachus to act and sail, guides him to Pylos and Sparta, transforms and shields Odysseus on Ithaca, fights at his side in the hall, and imposes the final peace between him and the suitors' kin. More than any other god she moves in disguise — as Mentos, as Mentor, as unnamed mortals.

*Epithets:* "gray-eyed Athena" (γλαυκῶπις Ἀθήνη, 1.44).

*Also called:* Pallas / Pallas Athena; "daughter of Zeus." *Disguises:* Mentos, in Book 1; Mentor, from 2.267 on — canon.md's rule distinguishes the goddess-in-disguise from the mortal Mentor, a real Ithacan who also speaks as himself.

*Kin:* daughter of Zeus.

**Refs:** 1.44, 1.80, 1.118, 2.267, 3.12, 4.289, 4.502 ...and throughout. Books 1–9, 11, 13–24.

*See also:* Zeus, Odysseus, Telemachus, Mentor.

**Athens** (Ἀθῆναι) · PLACE

City of Erechtheus, whom Athena once guarded in his own temple there; named as a waypoint on legendary voyages, including Theseus's flight with Ariadne.

**Refs:** 3.278, 3.307, 7.80, 11.324. Books 3, 7, 11.

*See also:* Athena, Ariadne.

**Atlas** (Ἀτλας) · GOD — *Say:* AT-lus

The Titan who "knows the depths of every sea" and grips with his own hands the tall pillars that hold earth and heaven apart; father of Calypso, whose island prison for Odysseus he thereby stands behind.

*Epithets:* "the deadly-minded" (1.52).

*Kin:* father of Calypso.

**Refs:** 1.52, 7.245.

*See also:* Calypso.

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**Atreus** (Ἀτρεΰς) · MORTAL — *Say*: AY-tree-us or AY-troos

King of Mycenae, father of Agamemnon and Menelaus; his name recurs constantly as the patronymic "son of Atreus," which the poem applies to either brother depending on scene (Menelaus in the Telemachy, Agamemnon in the underworld and homecoming-paradigm passages — see canon.md).

*Kin*: father of Agamemnon and Menelaus.

**Refs**: 1.36, 3.156, 3.193, 4.51, 4.316, 9.263, 11.397, 15.51, 17.104, 24.20, 24.121 ...and throughout. Books 1, 3–5, 9, 11, 13–15, 17, 19, 24.

*See also*: Agamemnon, Menelaus.

**Autolycus** (Αὐτόλυκος) · MORTAL — *Say*: aw-TOL-ih-kus

Odysseus's maternal grandfather, "who outdid all men in thievery and the oath" — a gift from his patron Hermes. He names the infant Odysseus at Ithaca ("Man at Odds," playing on the hero's name), and years later, when the grown Odysseus visits Parnassus to claim his promised gifts, a boar gores him on the hunt, leaving the scar by which Eurycleia later recognizes him.

*Kin*: father of Anticleia, maternal grandfather of Odysseus.

**Refs**: 11.85, 19.394, 19.399, 19.403, 19.405 (names him), 19.414, 19.437, 19.466 (boar hunt and scar), 21.220, 24.334. Books 11, 19, 21, 24.

*See also*: Odysseus, Anticleia, Eurycleia, Hermes.

**Autonoe** (Αὐτονόη) · MORTAL — *Say*: aw-TON-oh-ee

One of Penelope's handmaids, named once among those who attend her.

**Refs**: 18.182.

*See also*: Penelope.

**Boethous** (Βοηθός) · MORTAL — *Say*: boh-EE-thoh-us

Father of Eteoneus, Menelaus's herald and attendant at Sparta; named only in the patronymic.

**Refs**: 4.31, 15.95, 15.140.

*See also*: Menelaus.

**Cadmeians** (Καδμεῖοι) · PEOPLE — *Say*: kad-MEE-unz

The Thebans, people of Cadmus; named as Oedipus's subjects in the underworld catalogue of heroines.

**Refs**: 11.275.

*See also*: Cadmus, Asopus.

**Cadmus** (Κάδμος) · MORTAL — *Say*: KAD-mus

Legendary founder of Thebes, father of Ino (later the sea-goddess Leucothea); named once in Ino's introduction as she rises to save Odysseus's raft.

**Refs**: 5.333.

*See also*: Cadmeians.

**Calypso** (Καλυψώ) · GOD — *Say*: kuh-LIP-soh

The nymph, daughter of Atlas, who holds Odysseus for seven years on her island Ogygia, wanting him for her husband and offering him immortality if he stays. Zeus at last sends Hermes to

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compel his release; she yields, bitterly, and helps him build the raft that carries him toward Scheria.

*Epithets:* "shining among goddesses" (δῖα θεάων, 5.77).

*Also called:* "daughter of Atlas"; her name plays on the Greek for "the Concealer."

*Kin:* daughter of Atlas.

**Refs:** 1.14, 4.557, 5.14, 5.116, 5.180, 5.263, 7.245, 9.29, 12.389, 23.333. Books 1, 4–5, 7–9, 12, 17, 23.

*See also:* Atlas, Odysseus, Hermes.

**Cassandra** (Κασσάνδρα) · MORTAL — Say: kuh-SAN-druh

Priam's daughter, taken by Agamemnon from fallen Troy; Clytemnestra kills her over

Agamemnon's body at the homecoming feast. Agamemnon's shade recalls her death-cry as the most pitiful sound of that slaughter.

**Refs:** 11.422.

*See also:* Agamemnon, Clytemnestra.

**Castor** (Κάστωρ) · MORTAL — Say: KAS-tor

The name Odysseus invents for his own false father in the Cretan lie he tells Eumaeus and later Penelope — "son of Hylax," a rich Cretan (11.300). Distinct from the mortal Castor, Helen's brother and one of the Dioscuri (Leda's sons by Tyndareus), whom the poem also names but never conflates with the fictional figure.

*Also called:* "son of Hylax" (in Odysseus's lie).

**Refs:** 11.300, 14.203.

*See also:* Odysseus, Crete.

**Cauconians** (Καύκωνες) · PEOPLE — Say: kaw-KOH-nee-unz

A people of the western Peloponnese, named once as Athena (disguised as Mentor) claims she must visit them to collect a debt, her cover for leaving Telemachus at Pylos.

**Refs:** 3.366.

*See also:* Athena, Nestor.

**Centaurs** (Κένταυροι) · OTHER — Say: SEN-tawrz

The half-horse creatures whose most notorious member, Eurytion, gets drunk at Peirithous's wedding feast among the Lapiths and runs wild — the Lapiths mutilate and drive him out.

Antinous cites the tale as a warning against wine's power just before the disguised Odysseus strings the bow.

*Also called:* "the Centaur" = Eurytion, the exemplary offender.

**Refs:** 21.295, 21.303.

*See also:* Antinous.

**Cephalenians** (Κεφαλλῆνες) · PEOPLE — Say: sef-uh-LEE-nee-unz

Odysseus's own subjects, named for his mainland and island holdings collectively; mustered by Telemachus for the boar-hunt scar story's setting and again as Odysseus's fighting men in the final battle with the suitors' kin.

**Refs:** 20.210, 24.355, 24.378, 24.429. Books 20, 24.

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*See also:* Odysseus, Ithaca.

**Chalcis** (Χαλκίς) · PLACE — *Say:* KAL-sis

A stream in Elis that Telemachus and Peisistratus pass on their overnight sail back from Pylos, avoiding Nestor's son Noemon's territory.

**Refs:** 15.295.

*See also:* Crouni.

**Charybdis** (Χάρυβδις) · GOD — *Say:* kuh-RIB-dis

The devouring whirlpool paired with Scylla in the strait Odysseus must run; three times a day she sucks down and spews up the sea, and Circe warns that no ship caught in her draw escapes. Odysseus loses his raft and nearly his life to her on the return past the strait after his crew eats the Sun's cattle, clinging to a fig tree until the mast and keel resurface.

**Refs:** 12.104, 12.235, 12.428, 12.436, 12.441, 23.327. Books 12, 23.

*See also:* Scylla, Crataeis.

**Chios** (Χίος) · PLACE — *Say:* KY-os or KEE-os

An island off the Ionian coast on the sea-route the Achaean fleet debates at its stormy, divided departure from Troy — part of Nestor's account of who sailed which way home.

**Refs:** 3.170, 3.171, 3.172.

*See also:* Nestor.

**Chloris** (Χλωρίς) · MORTAL — *Say:* KLOR-is

Youngest daughter of Amphion of Orchomenus; Neleus marries her for her beauty with bride-gifts beyond number, and she bears him Nestor, Chromius, Periclymenus, and the much-courtèd Pero. Seen among the heroines in the underworld.

*Kin:* wife of Neleus, mother of Nestor, Chromius, Pero.

**Refs:** 11.281.

*See also:* Nestor, Chromius, Neleus.

**Chromius** (Χρομῖος) · MORTAL — *Say:* KROH-mee-us

A son of Neleus and Chloris, brother of Nestor, named in the underworld genealogy of the Pylian house.

*Kin:* son of Neleus and Chloris, brother of Nestor.

**Refs:** 11.286.

*See also:* Nestor, Chloris.

**Cicones** (Κίκονες) · PEOPLE — *Say:* sih-KOH-neeZ

Thracian allies of Troy at Ismarus, Odysseus's first landfall on the way home. He sacks their city, but lingers too long over the plunder; the Cicones rally their inland neighbors and rout his men on the beach, costing six men from each ship — the wanderings' first loss and first lesson in restraint ignored.

**Refs:** 9.39, 9.47, 9.59, 9.66 (the raid and rout), 9.165, 23.310. Books 9, 23.

*See also:* Odysseus.

**Cimmerians** (Κιμμέριοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* sih-MEER-ee-unZ



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A people who live at the edge of Ocean, wrapped always in mist and cloud and never seen by the sun — the poem places the entrance to Hades in their sunless land.

**Refs:** 11.14.

*See also:* Hades (underworld).

**Circe** (Κίρκη) · GOD — Say: SUR-see

Witch-goddess of Aeaea, daughter of Helios; she drugs Odysseus's men and turns them to swine — bodies of pigs, minds unchanged — until Hermes's counter-herb and Odysseus's drawn sword force her to restore them and take him to her bed instead. He stays a year; she then tells him how to reach the underworld and, on his return, warns him of Scylla, Charybdis, and the Sirens.

*Epithets:* "of the lovely braids" (ἐυπλόκαμος, 10.221 and elsewhere); "the dread goddess."

*Kin:* daughter of Helios.

**Refs:** 9.31, 10.136, 10.221, 10.241 (the transformation), 10.480, 11.8, 12.9, 12.273, 23.321. Books 8–12, 23.

*See also:* Helios, Hermes, Odysseus.

**Cleitus** (Κλεῖτος) · MORTAL — Say: KLY-tus

Grandson of the seer Melampus, carried off by Dawn for his beauty — a brief mythic aside in the genealogy Theoclymenus gives of his own seer's line.

**Refs:** 15.249, 15.250.

*See also:* Theoclymenus.

**Clymene** (Κλυμένη) · MORTAL — Say: KLIM-uh-nee or kly-MEE-nee

One of the heroines Odysseus glimpses among the crowd of women's shades in the underworld, named without further story.

**Refs:** 11.326.

*See also:* Ariadne.

**Clymenus** (Κλύμενος) · MORTAL — Say: KLIM-uh-nus

Father of Eurydice, Nestor's wife; named only in Nestor's household genealogy at Pylos.

*Kin:* father of Eurydice, Nestor's wife.

**Refs:** 3.452.

*See also:* Nestor.

**Clytemnestra** (Κλυταιμνήστρα) · MORTAL — Say: kly-tem-NES-truh

Agamemnon's wife; she takes Aegisthus as her lover while her husband is at Troy and joins him in murdering Agamemnon at his homecoming feast, killing Cassandra too. Agamemnon's shade holds her up to Odysseus as the standing warning against trusting a wife — the counter-exemplar the poem sets Penelope against.

*Also called:* "of the crooked counsels" (11.422).

*Kin:* wife of Agamemnon, mother of Orestes.

**Refs:** 3.266, 11.422, 11.439. Books 3, 11.

*See also:* Agamemnon, Aegisthus, Cassandra, Orestes, Penelope.

**Clytius** (Κλυτίος) · MORTAL — Say: KLIT-ee-us

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Father of Piraeus, the Ithacan friend who houses Theoclymenus for Telemachus; named only in the patronymic.

**Refs:** 15.540, 16.327.

*See also:* Theoclymenus.

**Clytoneus** (Κλυτόνηος) · MORTAL — *Say:* kly-TOH-nee-us

A son of Alcinous and Arete; he wins the footrace at the Phaeacian games in Book 8.

*Kin:* son of Alcinous and Arete.

**Refs:** 8.119, 8.123.

*See also:* Alcinous, Nausicaa.

**Cnossus** (Κνωσός) · PLACE — *Say:* NOS-us or kuh-NOS-us

Minos's capital on Crete, named once as the setting Odysseus invokes in the Cretan lie he tells Penelope.

**Refs:** 19.178.

*See also:* Crete, Ariadne.

**Cocytus** (Κωκυτός) · PLACE — *Say:* koh-SY-tus

A river of the underworld, a branch of the Styx, named by Circe as she gives Odysseus directions to the entrance of Hades.

**Refs:** 10.514.

*See also:* Cimmerians.

**Constellations** · OTHER

The stars Odysseus steers by on his solitary raft-voyage from Ogygia, watching them as Calypso instructed: the Wain (the Bear), which alone never bathes in Ocean, Boötes, and the Pleiades, along with Orion. The same star-lore returns as Odysseus lies sleepless before the contest of the bow.

*Also called:* the Wain / the Bear; Boötes; the Pleiades.

**Refs:** 5.272, 5.273, 20.18. Books 5, 20.

*See also:* Calypso.

**Crataiis** (Κραταιίς) · GOD — *Say:* kruh-TAY-is

Mother of Scylla, named once by Circe in her warning as she describes the monster's lineage.

*Kin:* mother of Scylla.

**Refs:** 12.124.

*See also:* Charybdis.

**Creon** (Κρέων) · MORTAL — *Say:* KREE-on

Theban king, father of Megara, whom Heracles marries; named in the underworld catalogue of heroines as Odysseus sees Megara's mother-in-law's line.

*Kin:* father of Megara.

**Refs:** 11.269.

*See also:* Cadmeians.

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### **Cretans** (Κρήτες) · PEOPLE

The people of Crete, whose polyglot, many-cited island and seafaring reputation make it Odysseus's favorite backdrop for the false identities he improvises for Eumaeus, the suitors, and Penelope alike.

**Refs:** 14.205, 14.234, 14.382, 19.176. Books 14, 19.

*See also:* Crete, Odysseus.

### **Crete** (Κρήτη) · PLACE

The great southern island, "ninety cities" and many peoples according to Odysseus's own description; it furnishes the recurring setting of the elaborate false autobiographies he tells Athena, Eumaeus, and Penelope on Ithaca, always with a plausible Cretan pedigree.

**Refs:** 3.191, 3.291, 11.323, 13.256, 14.199, 14.300, 16.62, 19.172, 19.338. Books 3, 11, 13–14, 16–17, 19.

*See also:* Cretans, Cnossus, Ariadne.

### **Cretheus** (Κρηθεύς) · MORTAL — Say: KREE-thee-us

Husband of Tyro, who bears him Aeson, Pheres, and Amythaon even as she secretly bears Poseidon's sons Pelias and Neleus; named in the underworld catalogue as Odysseus meets Tyro's shade.

*Kin:* husband of Tyro; father of Aeson, Pheres, Amythaon.

**Refs:** 11.237, 11.258.

*See also:* Chloris, Nestor.

### **Cronos** (Κρόνος) · GOD — Say: KROH-nos

The Titan father of Zeus, Poseidon, Hades, and Hera; almost every occurrence of his name in the poem is the patronymic "son of Cronos," meaning Zeus. Cronos himself never appears as an actor, only as the genealogical root behind the ruling generation of gods.

*Also called:* "son of Cronos" / Cronion = **Zeus** (see canon.md).

*Kin:* father of Zeus, Poseidon, Hades, Hera.

**Refs:** 1.45, 3.88, 9.552, 12.399, 16.291, 21.415, 24.539. Books 1, 3–4, 8–22, 24.

*See also:* Zeus, Poseidon, Hades.

### **Crouni** (Κρουνοί) · PLACE — Say: KROO-nee

A spring-place in Elis, named alongside Chalcis as a landmark Telemachus's ship passes on the night-run home from Pylos.

**Refs:** 15.295.

*See also:* Chalcis.

### **Ctesippus** (Κτήσιππος) · MORTAL — Say: tih-SIP-us

A suitor from Same, "versed in lawlessness," rich and arrogant; he hurls an ox-hoof at the disguised Odysseus as a mocking "guest-gift," but misses — Telemachus rebukes him for it on the spot (20.288, 20.303–304). In the hall fight he wounds Eumaeus with a spear-graze before Philoetius kills him, crowing over the body and calling it payment for the ox-hoof (22.279, 22.285).

*Also called:* "son of Polythereses."

**Refs:** 20.288, 20.303, 20.304, 22.279, 22.285. Books 20, 22.

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*See also:* Antinous, Odysseus, Philoetius.

**Ctesius** (Κτήσιος) · MORTAL — Say: TEE-see-us

Eumaeus's father, king of Syrie, named once in the swineherd's life-story as the father whose household the Phoenician nursemaid betrayed.

**Refs:** 15.414.

*See also:* Eumaeus, Arybas.

**Ctimene** (Κτιμένη) · MORTAL — Say: TIM-uh-nee

Odysseus's younger sister, raised alongside Eumaeus in Laertes' house; the swineherd recalls her in the same breath as Odysseus among the children he tended before her marriage sent her off to Same.

*Kin:* sister of Odysseus.

**Refs:** 15.363.

*See also:* Eumaeus, Laertes.

**Cyclopes** (Κύκλωπες) · GOD — Say: sy-KLOH-peeZ

The lawless one-eyed race Odysseus's crew meets in Book 9 — herdsmen with no assemblies, no laws, no ships, "trusting in the deathless gods" though they scorn Zeus outright. Polyphemus, Poseidon's son, is one of them; his blinding and the curse he calls down on Odysseus drive the rest of the poem's wanderings. Their island neighbors a fertile, uninhabited isle the poem surveys with a colonist's eye.

**Refs:** 1.71, 6.5, 7.206, 9.106–125 (the ethnography), 9.166, 9.275, 9.399, 9.510. Books 1, 6–7, 9.

*See also:* Polyphemus, Poseidon.

**Cydonians** (Κυδώνες) · PEOPLE — Say: sih-DOH-nee-unz

A people of western Crete, named in the false Cretan tale Odysseus spins for Penelope and again by Eumaeus's tale of Crete.

**Refs:** 3.292, 19.176.

**Cyllene** (Κυλλήνη) · PLACE — Say: sih-LEE-nee

The Arcadian mountain sacred to Hermes; the poem opens Book 24 with the god leading the suitors' souls out from its heights.

**Refs:** 24.1.

*See also:* Hermes.

**Cyprus** (Κύπρος) · PLACE

The island of Aphrodite's Paphian shrine, where the goddess is bathed and anointed after her exposure with Ares; it also figures in the beggar-Odysseus's invented travels, where he claims a king named Dmetor once hosted him.

**Refs:** 4.83, 8.362, 17.442–448.

*See also:* Aphrodite, Dmetor.

**Cythera** (Κύθηρα) · PLACE — Say: sih-THEER-uh

Island off Cape Malea; a fierce north wind drives Odysseus's ships past it and off course toward the Lotus-eaters.

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**Refs:** 9.81.

**Damastor** (Δαμάστωρ) · MORTAL — Say: duh-MAS-tor

Father of the suitor Agelaus, named only in the patronymic "Agelaus, Damastor's son" that recurs through the hall-fighting of Book 22.

**Refs:** 20.321, 22.212, 22.241, 22.293.

See also: Agelaus.

**Danaans** (Δαναοί) · PEOPLE — Say: DAN-ay-unz or DAN-uh-unz

One of the poem's three interchangeable names for the Greek host at Troy, alongside Achaeans and Argives; used freely in the underworld catalogue of heroes and in Nestor's and Menelaus's reminiscences.

**Refs:** 1.350, 4.278, 4.725, 5.306, 8.82, 11.470, 11.526, 24.18, 24.45.

See also: Achaeans, Argives.

**Dawn** (Ἥως) · GOD

Personified daybreak, whose rising opens nearly every day of the action in the poem's fixed formula: "with fingers of rose," "the early-born," coming "on her fair throne" or "the golden throne." She marks time rather than acts in it, but her recurrence is the poem's clock, from the Telemachy through the wanderings to the final battle's dawn.

*Epithets:* "with fingers of rose" (ῥοδοδάκτυλος Ἥως, 2.1); "the early-born" (ἡριγένεια, 2.1); "on her fair throne" (ἐύθρονος Ἥως, 6.48); "Dawn of the golden throne" (χρυσόθρονος Ἥως, 10.541).

**Refs:** 2.1, 5.1, 6.48, 8.1, 9.76, 10.144, 12.4, 13.18, 17.1, 19.428, 23.241, 23.244, 23.246 ...and throughout. Books 2–6, 8–10, 12–20, 23.

See also: Helios.

**Deiphobus** (Δηίφοβος) · MORTAL — Say: dee-IF-oh-bus

Trojan prince, Paris's brother; Helen recalls circling the wooden horse with him among the Trojans who tried to draw out the hidden Greeks, and Odysseus's shade-companions recall the fighting before his house on the night Troy fell.

**Refs:** 4.276, 8.518.

See also: Helen.

**Delos** (Δῆλος) · PLACE — Say: DEE-los

Apollo's sacred island; Odysseus tells Nausicaa that only there, beside the god's altar, has he seen a young palm to match her beauty.

**Refs:** 6.162.

See also: Apollo, Nausicaa.

**Demeter** (Δημήτηρ) · GOD — Say: dih-MEE-tur

Grain-goddess; the poem recalls, in a list of goddesses who loved mortal men, that she lay with Iasion in a thrice-plowed field, for which Zeus struck him with the thunderbolt.

**Refs:** 5.125.

**Demodocus** (Δημόδοκος) · MORTAL — Say: dih-MOD-oh-kus

The blind bard of the Phaeacian court, "honored among the people," to whom a god gave song "beyond all others." He sings the quarrel of Achilles and Odysseus, the adultery of Ares and

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Aphrodite, and the fall of Troy by the wooden horse — the last song moving Odysseus to tears and forcing his identity into the open.

*Epithets:* "the trusted singer" (ἐρίηρος ἀοιδός, 8.62).

**Refs:** 8.44 (Alcinous calls for him), 8.106, 8.254–262, 8.472–487 (the Troy song), 8.537, 13.28. Books 8, 13.

*See also:* Alcinous, Phaeacians.

**Demoptolemus** (Δημοπτόλεμος) · MORTAL — Say: dee-mop-TOL-uh-mus

A suitor; one of the hall's best fighters, he joins Agelaus's rallied volley against Odysseus in Book 22 and is killed by Odysseus's own spear in the return cast.

**Refs:** 22.242, 22.266.

*See also:* Agelaus, the suitors.

**Deucalion** (Δευκαλίων) · MORTAL — Say: dyoo-KAY-lee-on

Son of Minos and father of Idomeneus, named in the elaborate false Cretan genealogy the disguised Odysseus gives Penelope.

**Refs:** 19.180, 19.181.

*See also:* Idomeneus.

**Dia** (Δία) · PLACE — Say: DEE-uh

The sea-ringed island (later identified with Naxos) where Artemis kills Ariadne on Dionysus's testimony, in the underworld catalogue of women.

**Refs:** 11.325.

*See also:* Dionysus.

**Diocles** (Διοκλῆς) · MORTAL — Say: DY-oh-kleez

Lord of Pherae, son of Ortilochus; he hosts Telemachus and Peisistratus overnight on both legs of their journey between Pylos and Sparta.

**Refs:** 3.488, 15.186.

*See also:* Telemachus, Peisistratus.

**Diomedes** (Διομήδης) · MORTAL — Say: dy-oh-MEE-deez

Son of Tydeus, the Argive hero; Nestor names him among the few who reached home safe from Troy, a foil to the disasters the poem is otherwise cataloguing.

*Also called:* "son of Tydeus."

**Refs:** 3.181.

**Dionysus** (Διόνυσος) · GOD — Say: dy-oh-NY-sus

The wine-god; in the underworld catalogue his testimony is cited as the cause of Artemis's killing of Ariadne on Dia, and in Book 24 Agamemnon recalls that Thetis's golden funeral urn for Achilles's bones was Dionysus's gift, made by Hephaestus.

**Refs:** 11.325, 24.74.

*See also:* Ariadne, Achilles.

**Dmetor** (Δμήτωρ) · MORTAL — Say: DMEE-tor or DEE-tor

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"Son of Iasus," the invented king of Cyprus in one of the beggar-Odysseus's fictitious travel tales, who supposedly hosted him after a shipwreck.

**Refs:** 17.443.

*See also:* Cyprus.

**Dodona** (Δωδώνη) · PLACE — *Say:* doh-DOH-nuh

Site of Zeus's oracular oak grove in Epirus; the disguised Odysseus twice claims (to Eumaeus and to Penelope) to have gone there to learn from the god's leaves whether to return openly or in secret.

**Refs:** 14.327, 19.296.

*See also:* Zeus.

**Dolius** (Δολίος) · MORTAL — *Say:* DOH-lee-us

Laertes's old slave and gardener, father of Melanthius and Melantho; the poem never voices the connection between the loyal old man and his disloyal, executed children. He greets the returned Odysseus with tears and a kiss at the wrist — the same clasp Penelope remembered from his departure — and arms himself with his six sons and Laertes for the final skirmish.

*Kin:* father of Melanthius and Melantho.

**Refs:** 4.735, 17.212, 18.322, 22.159, 24.222, 24.387–411 (the reunion), 24.497–498 (arming for battle). Books 4, 17–18, 22, 24.

*See also:* Laertes, Melanthius, Melantho.

**Dorians** (Δωριέες) · PEOPLE — *Say:* DOR-ee-unz

One of the several peoples inhabiting Crete, named in the disguised Odysseus's account of the island's mixed population.

**Refs:** 19.177.

**Dulichium** (Δουλίχιον) · PLACE — *Say:* dyoo-LIK-ee-um

An island near Ithaca, home to the largest single contingent of Penelope's suitors; named repeatedly alongside Same and Zacynthus as the suitors' home islands.

**Refs:** 1.246, 9.24, 14.335, 14.397, 16.123, 16.247, 16.396, 18.127, 19.131, 19.292.

*See also:* the suitors.

**Dymas** (Δύμας) · MORTAL — *Say:* DY-mus

A Phaeacian sea-captain "famed for ships"; Athena takes the shape of his daughter, a girl Nausicaa's own age, to visit Nausicaa in her sleep and set the laundry expedition in motion.

**Refs:** 6.22.

*See also:* Nausicaa, Athena.

**Earth** (Γαῖα) · GOD

Personified Earth, invoked with Heaven and the waters of Styx in the gods' most solemn oath — the oath Calypso swears to Hermes and Poseidon swears at his own council.

*Also called:* Gaia.

**Refs:** 5.184, 7.324, 11.576.

*See also:* Zeus, Poseidon.

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**Echeneus** (Ἐχένηος) · MORTAL — Say: ek-uh-NEE-us

The eldest of the Phaeacian lords, "elder-born beyond the others," whose counsel the court heeds: he prompts Alcinous to raise the suppliant Odysseus from the hearth-ashes in Book 7, and later speaks up again in the assembly that hears Odysseus's tale.

**Refs:** 7.155, 11.342.

*See also:* Alcinous, Phaeacians.

**Echephron** (Ἐχέφρων) · MORTAL — Say: eh-KEF-ron

A son of Nestor, present at the sacrifice and feast when Telemachus arrives in Pylos.

**Refs:** 3.413, 3.439.

*See also:* Nestor.

**Echetus** (Ἐχετος) · MORTAL — Say: EK-uh-tus

The proverbial mainland ogre-king, "the maimer of all mankind," whom the suitors repeatedly threaten to ship the beggar-disguised Odysseus and Irus off to for mutilation — their favorite image of outsourced cruelty.

*Epithets:* "the maimer of all mankind" (βροτῶν δηλήμονα πάντων, 18.85).

**Refs:** 18.85, 18.116, 21.308.

*See also:* Irus.

**Egypt** (Αἴγυπτος) · PLACE

The land — and, in the Greek, also the river, i.e. the Nile — of Menelaus's long detour home; he is becalmed there and must trap Proteus before the god will release him. Odysseus's fictitious tales to Eumaeus and the suitors likewise send his invented self raiding and stranded in Egypt.

**Refs:** 3.300, 4.127, 4.351, 4.355 (Menelaus's detour), 4.477, 4.483, 4.581, 14.247, 14.257, 14.275, 17.426, 17.448. Books 3–4, 14, 17.

*See also:* Menelaus, Proteus, Egyptians.

**Egyptians** (Αἰγύπτιοι) · PEOPLE

The people of Egypt, encountered both in Menelaus's true account of his detour and in Odysseus's invented raiding tales.

**Refs:** 4.83, 4.229, 14.264, 14.286, 17.433.

*See also:* Egypt.

**Eidothea** (Εἰδοθέη) · GOD — Say: eye-doh-THEE-uh

Sea-nymph, daughter of Proteus; pitying the stranded Menelaus, she tells him how to ambush and hold her shape-shifting father until he answers his questions.

**Refs:** 4.366.

*See also:* Proteus, Menelaus.

**Eileithyia** (Εἰλειθυία) · GOD — Say: eye-lih-THY-uh or eye-LEE-thee-uh

Goddess of childbirth, invoked in the underworld catalogue as the power who eased Alcmena's and other heroines' labors.

**Refs:** 19.188.

**Elatus** (Ἐλατος) · MORTAL — Say: EL-uh-tus



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A suitor; killed by the swineherd Eumaeus in the fighting of Book 22, in the same volley that fells Demoptolemus and Peisander.

**Refs:** 22.267.

*See also:* Eumaeus, the suitors.

**Elis** (Ἠλῖς) · PLACE — Say: EE-lis

Region of the western Peloponnese, home of the Epeians; named as a place of horse-pasture Odysseus once visited and as a landmark in the suitors' geography.

**Refs:** 4.635, 13.275, 15.298, 21.347, 24.431.

*See also:* Epeians.

**Elpenor** (Ἐλπηνώρ) · MORTAL — Say: el-PEE-nor

The youngest of Odysseus's crew, "no great fighter, no steady mind on him" — he sleeps off wine on Circe's roof, wakes at the crew's departure, and falls to his death. His unburied shade meets Odysseus first in the underworld, ahead even of Teiresias, and begs for burial and an oar planted over his grave; Odysseus keeps the promise to the letter on returning to Aeaea.

**Refs:** 10.552, 11.51, 11.57 (his shade, first to appear), 12.10 (the funeral). Books 10–12.

*See also:* Circe.

**Elysium** (Ἠλύσιον) · PLACE — Say: ih-LIZ-ee-um or ih-LIZH-ee-um

The deathless plain at the world's edge that Proteus promises will be Menelaus's afterlife, in place of death, because he is Zeus's son-in-law through Helen.

*Also called:* the Elysian plain.

**Refs:** 4.563.

*See also:* Menelaus, Proteus.

**Enipeus** (Ἐνιπέυς) · GOD — Say: ih-NY-pee-us

A river(-god) of Thessaly; Tyro loves him, haunting his beautiful streams, and Poseidon takes his likeness to lie with her at the river's mouth, fathering Pelias and Neleus.

**Refs:** 11.238, 11.240.

*See also:* Poseidon.

**Epeians** (Ἐπειοί) · PEOPLE — Say: eh-PEE-unz

The people of Elis in the western Peloponnese, named among the lands Odysseus's herds and reputation reach.

**Refs:** 13.275, 15.298, 24.431.

*See also:* Elis.

**Epeius** (Ἐπειός) · MORTAL — Say: eh-PEE-us

Builder of the wooden horse, "with Athena's help," celebrated in Demodocus's song and recalled again by Odysseus's shade-companions in the underworld.

**Refs:** 8.493, 11.523.

*See also:* Demodocus.

**Eperitus** (Ἐπρίτος) · MORTAL — Say: eh-PEE-rih-tus

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The false name Odysseus gives Laertes in their reunion, part of a last testing lie built from a genealogy of speaking names — "son of Apheidas, son of Polypemon," from an island city evoking wandering — before he abandons the disguise and reveals himself with the scar and the orchard trees.

**Refs:** 24.306.

*See also:* Laertes, Odysseus.

**Ephialtes** (Ἐφιάλτης) · MORTAL — *Say:* ef-ee-AL-teez

Giant brother of Otus, son of Poseidon and Iphimedeia; the two grew nine fathoms tall in nine years and piled Ossa on Olympus and Pelion on Ossa to storm heaven, before Apollo killed them short of manhood.

**Refs:** 11.308.

*See also:* Otus, Poseidon.

**Ephyra** (Ἐφύρη) · PLACE — *Say:* EF-ih-ruh

A town on the Greek mainland; Odysseus is remembered (by Antinous, recalling Odysseus's own past, and again in Telemachus's cover story) as having gone there seeking deadly arrow-poison.

**Refs:** 1.259, 2.328.

**Epicaste** (Ἐπικάστη) · MORTAL — *Say:* ep-ih-KAS-tee

Homer's name for the mother of Oedipus (later tradition's Jocasta): she unknowingly marries her own son, and when the gods reveal it she hangs herself, while Oedipus goes on ruling Thebes in grief, "hounded by a mother's Furies." Odysseus sees her shade in the underworld catalogue of women.

*Also called:* Jocasta (later tradition's name).

**Refs:** 11.271.

*See also:* Oedipus.

**Erebus** (Ἐρεβος) · PLACE — *Say:* ER-uh-bus

The nether darkness of the dead; the shades Odysseus summons rise from it, and the phrase recurs as the underworld's name through the Nekyia and again in the second, ghost-led descent of the suitors' souls in Book 24.

**Refs:** 10.528, 11.37, 11.564, 12.81, 20.356.

*See also:* Hades.

**Erechtheus** (Ἐρεχθεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* eh-REK-thee-us

Earthborn king of Athens, into whose rich temple Athena withdraws when she leaves Scheria after the games.

**Refs:** 7.81.

*See also:* Athena.

**Erembi** (Ἐρεμβοί) · PEOPLE — *Say:* eh-REM-by

A far-off people Menelaus names among those he visited on his long detour home, grouped with the Ethiopians, Sidonians, and Libyans as the outer edge of his wanderings.

**Refs:** 4.84.

*See also:* Menelaus.

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**Eriphyle** (Ἐριφύλη) · MORTAL — Say: er-ih-FY-lee

A woman of the underworld catalogue, condemned in the poem's one open moral judgment there: she "took precious gold as the price of her own husband," betraying Amphiaraus to his death for a bribe.

**Refs:** 11.326.

**Erymanthus** (Ἐρύμανθος) · PLACE — Say: er-ih-MAN-thus

An Arcadian mountain; the simile comparing Nausicaa among her handmaids to Artemis hunting names it as one of the goddess's ranges.

**Refs:** 6.103.

*See also:* Nausicaa.

**Eteoneus** (Ἐτεωνεύς) · MORTAL — Say: et-ee-OH-nee-us

Son of Boethous, Menelaus's attendant at Sparta; he greets Telemachus and Peisistratus at the gate and later announces the disguised Odysseus's arrival on Ithaca's shore.

*Also called:* "son of Boethous."

**Refs:** 4.22, 4.31, 15.95.

*See also:* Menelaus.

**Ethiopians** (Αἰθίοπες) · PEOPLE — Say: ee-thee-OH-pee-unz

"The remotest of men," split into two peoples at the world's eastern and western edges; Poseidon is feasting among them when the gods' council decides Odysseus's release, and Menelaus visits them on his detour.

**Refs:** 1.22, 1.23, 4.84, 5.282, 5.287.

*See also:* Poseidon.

**Euanthes** (Εὐάνθης) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-AN-theez

Father of Maron, the priest of Apollo whose potent wine Odysseus carries into the Cyclops's cave.

**Refs:** 9.197.

*See also:* Cyclopes.

**Euboea** (Εὐβοία) · PLACE — Say: yoo-BEE-uh

The long island off the Greek mainland; Nestor recalls the fleet's fast crossing there on the way home from Troy, and the Phaeacians cite it as the farthest sail their ships have ever made, ferrying Rhadamanthys.

**Refs:** 3.174, 7.321.

*See also:* Phaeacians.

**Eumaeus** (Εὐμαίος) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-MEE-us

The loyal swineherd, "a leader of men," once a stolen prince of Syrie sold into slavery as a child and raised in Laertes's house. He shelters the disguised Odysseus, unknowingly hosts and feeds him at length, tells his own story of abduction, and stands with Philoetius at Odysseus's side in the slaughter of the suitors.

*Also called:* "the swineherd."

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*Epithets:* "the noble swineherd" (δῖος ὑφορβός, 14.3); "the swineherd, a leader of men" (συβώτης, ὄρχαμος ἀνδρῶν, 14.22).

*Kin:* son of Ctesius, king of Syrie.

**Refs:** 14.55 (his hut, first), 14.360, 14.440, 15.325, 15.486, 16.7, 16.464, 17.199, 17.579, 21.80, 21.234, 22.157, 22.279 (the slaughter) ...and throughout. Books 14–17, 20–22.

*See also:* Odysseus, Philoetius, Melanthius.

**Eumelus** (Εὐμηλος) · MORTAL — *Say:* yoo-MEE-lus

Husband of Iphthime, Penelope's sister, and lord of Pherae; Athena shapes a dream-phantom in Iphthime's likeness to comfort the weeping Penelope, naming Eumelus only to place her.

*Kin:* husband of Iphthime, Penelope's sister.

**Refs:** 4.798.

*See also:* Penelope.

**Eupeithes** (Εὐπείθης) · MORTAL — *Say:* yoo-PY-theez

Antinous's father, an Ithacan noble. When word of the suitors' slaughter reaches the town he rouses the assembly to arms, weeping over his son's death, and leads the suitors' kinsmen out to avenge them — against Halitherses' and Medon's warnings. Laertes, with Athena guiding his throw, spears him through the helmet before Athena halts the fighting and imposes the peace that closes the poem.

*Kin:* father of Antinous.

**Refs:** 1.383, 4.660, 16.363, 18.42, 20.270, 21.140, 24.422 (rouses the assembly), 24.465, 24.469, 24.523 (killed by Laertes' spear). Books 1, 4, 16–18, 20–21, 24.

*See also:* Antinous, Halitherses, Laertes.

**Euryades** (Εὐρύαδης) · MORTAL — *Say:* yoo-RY-uh-deez

One of the suitors; Telemachus kills him with a spear-throw in the general volley of Book 22, alongside Odysseus's killing of Demoptolemus and Eumaeus's of Elatus.

**Refs:** 22.267. Book 22.

*See also:* the suitors, Telemachus.

**Euryalus** (Εὐρύαλος) · MORTAL — *Say:* yoo-RY-uh-lus

A young Phaeacian noble, "the equal of man-destroying Ares," second only to Laodamas in looks. At the Book 8 games he goads the grieving Odysseus, calling him a profit-minded trader with no gift for contests; Odysseus answers with an angry speech and a record discus-throw. Shamed by Alcinous's rebuke, Euryalus makes amends with a fine sword and a gracious apology.

*Kin:* son of Naubolus.

**Refs:** 8.115 (rises for the games), 8.127 (wrestling), 8.140 (taunt), 8.158, 8.396–400 (apology and gift). Book 8.

*See also:* Alcinous, Laodamas, Phaeacians.

**Eurybates** (Εὐρυβάτης) · MORTAL — *Say:* yoo-RIB-uh-teez

Odysseus's herald at Troy, described in the disguised Odysseus's tale to Penelope as round-shouldered, dark-skinned, and curly-haired — a man Odysseus honored above his other companions for his good sense.

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**Refs:** 19.247. Book 19.

*See also:* Odysseus.

**Eurycleia** (Εὐρύκλεια) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-rih-KLEE-uh or yoo-rih-KLY-uh

Odysseus's old nurse, bought by Laertes in her youth and honored in his house like a wife, though he never touched her bed. She raised both Odysseus and Telemachus, manages the women's quarters, and — washing the disguised beggar's feet — recognizes Odysseus by the boar-scar on his thigh (19.401); he seizes her throat and swears her to silence. She later helps identify the executed slave-women and rouses Penelope after the slaughter.

*Also called:* "the Nurse" (μῃᾱ, the household's address for her); daughter of Ops, son of Peisenor.

**Refs:** 1.429, 2.361, 4.742, 17.31, 19.357, 19.401, 19.491 (the scar), 20.128–148, 22.391–492, 23.25–39, 23.69, 23.177. Books 1–2, 4, 17, 19–23.

*See also:* Odysseus, Telemachus, Penelope, Laertes.

**Eurydamas** (Εὐρυδάμας) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RID-uh-mus

A suitor; falls to Odysseus's spear in the fighting of Book 22.

**Refs:** 18.297, 22.283. Books 18, 22.

*See also:* the suitors.

**Eurydice** (Εὐρυδίκη) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RID-ih-see

Nestor's wife, youngest daughter of Clymenus; she bathes Telemachus at Pylos.

**Refs:** 3.452. Book 3.

*See also:* Nestor.

**Eurylochus** (Εὐρύλοχος) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RIL-oh-kus

Odysseus's second-in-command and kinsman by marriage. He leads the party that finds Circe's house and alone escapes her drugging, then talks Odysseus into landing on Thrinacia against Tiresias's and Circe's warnings; when the crew starves, he persuades them to slaughter the cattle of Helios — the crime that dooms the whole company. He earlier balks openly, pleading with Odysseus not to go back for the trapped men (10.244–271).

**Refs:** 10.205–207 (chosen by lot), 10.232 (stays outside, suspecting a snare), 10.244–271 (confrontation), 12.278–297 (Thrinacia landing), 12.339–352 (urges the slaughter). Books 10–12.

*See also:* Odysseus, Circe, Helios.

**Eurymachus** (Εὐρύμαχος) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RIM-uh-kus

Son of Polybus and, with Antinous, a leader of the suitors — smoother-tongued than Antinous but no less rapacious, and secretly courting the maid Melantho. He answers first when Odysseus reveals himself, tries to shift the blame to the dead Antinous, then rallies the suitors to rush the archer; Odysseus's arrow takes him through the liver, the second suitor to die.

*Kin:* son of Polybus.

**Refs:** 1.399–413, 2.177–209, 15.17, 16.434, 18.244–396, 20.359–364, 21.186 (fails to string the bow), 21.245–331, 22.44–61 (answers Odysseus), 22.69 (death). Books 1–2, 4, 15–18, 20–22.

*See also:* Antinous, Penelope, the suitors.

**Eurymedon** (Εὐρυμέδων) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RIM-uh-don

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King of the overweening Giants in the Phaeacians' deep genealogy; his people destroyed themselves and him, but his daughter Periboea bore Nausithous to Poseidon — making him the Phaeacians' maternal great-grandfather.

*Kin:* father of Periboea (mother of Nausithous by Poseidon).

**Refs:** 7.58. Book 7.

*See also:* Giants, Nausithous, Alcinous, Poseidon.

**Eurymedusa** (Εὐρυμέδουσα) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-rih-muh-DOO-suh

An old woman brought from Apeire as a prize of honor for Alcinous; she nursed Nausicaa and serves now as her chamber-keeper.

**Refs:** 7.8. Book 7.

*See also:* Nausicaa, Alcinous.

**Eurymus** (Εὔρυμος) · MORTAL — Say: YOO-rih-mus

Father of the seer Telemus, who foretold Polyphemus's blinding at Odysseus's hands.

**Refs:** 9.509. Book 9.

*See also:* Polyphemus.

**Eurynome** (Εὐρυνόμη) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RIN-oh-mee

Penelope's housekeeper, trusted with news and errands in the household's last days — she comforts Penelope after Antinous strikes the beggar, helps bathe and dress her before she faces the suitors, and attends the recognition of Odysseus.

**Refs:** 17.495 (adds her word after Antinous's blow), 18.164–178, 19.96–97, 20.4, 23.154–293. Books 17–20, 23.

*See also:* Penelope, Eurycleia.

**Eurynomus** (Εὐρόνομος) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RIN-oh-mus

A suitor, son of Aegyptius; he is among the ringleaders Agelaus rallies for the last stand in the hall.

*Kin:* son of Aegyptius.

**Refs:** 2.22, 22.242. Books 2, 22.

*See also:* Aegyptius, the suitors.

**Eurypylus** (Εὐρύπυλος) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RIP-ih-lus

Son of Telephus; a strikingly handsome Trojan ally, killed at Troy by Achilles's son Neoptolemus, whose exploit Odysseus recounts to the shade of Achilles.

*Kin:* son of Telephus.

**Refs:** 11.520. Book 11.

*See also:* Neoptolemus, Achilles.

**Eurytus** (Εὔρυτος) · MORTAL — Say: YOO-rih-tus

The archer of Oechalia who rivaled the gods themselves at the bow and died for it, killed by Apollo in his anger. His great bow, kept afterward by his son Iphitus, eventually reaches Odysseus as a guest-gift and becomes the weapon of the suitors' slaughter.

**Refs:** 8.224–226 (Odysseus declines to rival him), 21.14 (the bow's pedigree), 21.32, 21.37. Books 8, 21.

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*See also:* Iphitus, Heracles.

**Evenor** (Εὐήνωρ) · MORTAL — *Say:* eh-VEE-nor

Father of the suitor Leocritus.

*Kin:* father of Leocritus.

**Refs:** 2.242, 22.294. Books 2, 22.

*See also:* the suitors.

**Furies** (Ἐρινύες) · GOD

The avenging spirits who enforce the deepest taboos — oaths, the claims of parents, and the rights of suppliants and beggars. Telemachus fears his mother's curse would summon them if he expelled her against her will; Epicaste's death bequeaths Oedipus "a mother's Furies"; the poem invokes them elsewhere against those who wrong parents or mistreat beggars and suppliants.

*Also called:* the Erinyes.

**Refs:** 2.136, 11.280, 17.475, 20.78. Books 2, 11, 17, 20.

*See also:* Oedipus (Epicaste).

**Geraestus** (Γεραιστός) · PLACE — *Say:* juh-REE-stus

The Euboean headland where storm-driven Achaean ships find safe landfall on the voyage home from Troy, as Nestor tells it.

**Refs:** 3.177. Book 3.

*See also:* Nestor.

**Giants** (Γίγαντες) · PEOPLE

A lawless mythic race; their king Eurymedon fathered Periboea, the Phaeacians' ancestral mother by Poseidon, before destroying his own reckless people and himself. Alcinous also cites the Giants and the Cyclopes as beings who, like the Phaeacians, live close to the gods.

**Refs:** 7.59, 7.206, 10.120. Books 7, 10.

*See also:* Eurymedon, Phaeacians.

**Gorgon** (Γοργώ) · OTHER — *Say:* GOR-gon

The monstrous severed head Odysseus fears Persephone might send up from Hades against him, driving him back to his ship at the end of the underworld visit.

**Refs:** 11.635. Book 11.

*See also:* Persephone.

**Gortyn** (Γόρτυν) · PLACE — *Say:* GOR-tin

A city in Crete, near the rocks off which a squadron of Menelaus's ships is wrecked on the way home from Troy.

**Refs:** 3.294. Book 3.

*See also:* Menelaus.

**Graces** (Χάριτες) · GOD

Attendant goddesses of beauty; they bathe and anoint Aphrodite at Paphos after her exposure with Ares, and their gift of grace is invoked elsewhere as what the gods lend to human charm.

*Also called:* the Charites.

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**Refs:** 6.18, 8.364, 18.194. Books 6, 8, 18.

*See also:* Aphrodite.

**Gyrae** (Γυραῖ) · PLACE — *Say:* JY-ree

The rocks where Poseidon drowned the lesser Ajax, son of Oileus, as Proteus tells Menelaus.

**Refs:** 4.501, 4.507. Book 4.

*See also:* Proteus, Menelaus.

**Hades** (ᾍδης) · GOD — *Say:* HAY-deez

Lord of the dead; by extension "the house of Hades" names the underworld itself, the destination the poem holds over every mortal peril and the setting of Odysseus's Book 11 consultation with Tiresias and the shades of the dead, including his mother and his old companions from Troy.

**Refs:** 3.410, 4.834, 6.11, 9.524, 10.502 (Circe's directions), 11.47–634 (Odysseus among the dead), 12.21, 14.208, 23.252, 24.204 ...and throughout. Books 3–4, 6, 9–12, 14–15, 20, 23–24.

*See also:* Persephone, Tiresias.

**Halitherses** (Ἀλιθήρσης) · MORTAL — *Say:* hal-ih-THUR-seez

The old Ithacan seer, unmatched at reading birds, who interprets the eagle-omen at the Book 2 assembly as doom for the suitors and repeats the same warning — unheeded — when Eupheithes musters the suitors' kin in Book 24.

*Also called:* son of Mastor.

**Refs:** 2.157 (reads the eagle-omen), 2.253, 17.68, 24.451 (repeats the warning). Books 2, 17, 24.

*See also:* Eupheithes, Mentor.

**Halius** (Ἅλιος) · MORTAL — *Say:* HAL-ee-us

A son of Alcinous, one of the Phaeacian dancers who perform the ball-dance for Odysseus in Book 8.

*Kin:* son of Alcinous.

**Refs:** 8.119, 8.370. Book 8.

*See also:* Alcinous, Laodamas.

**Hebe** (Ἥβη) · GOD — *Say:* HEE-bee

Goddess of youth, daughter of Zeus and Hera; wife of the deified Heracles, who feasts among the immortals while his phantom appears to Odysseus in the underworld.

*Kin:* daughter of Zeus and Hera; wife of Heracles.

**Refs:** 11.603. Book 11.

*See also:* Heracles, Zeus, Hera.

**Helen** (Ἑλένη) · MORTAL — *Say:* HEL-un

Menelaus's wife, whose abduction caused the Trojan War; now restored to Sparta, sharing rule with her husband. In the Telemachy she is a gracious, knowing hostess — recognizing Telemachus by his likeness to his father, telling her own tale of Odysseus's spying mission into Troy, and dosing the wine with a drug against grief. Shades and mortals elsewhere invoke her name as the war's cause and, in the underworld, the standard against which Agamemnon's murder is measured.



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**Refs:** 4.12, 4.121–130, 4.219 (the drugged wine), 4.296–305, 11.438, 15.58–171 (her parting gift to Telemachus), 17.118, 22.227, 23.218. Books 4, 11, 14–15, 17, 22–23.

*See also:* Menelaus, Agamemnon.

**Helios** (ἥλιος) · GOD — Say: HEE-lee-os

The sun-god, who sees and hears all things. His sacred cattle graze untouched on Thrinacia until Odysseus's starving, storm-bound crew — over Eurylochus's oath and Odysseus's warning — slaughter them; Helios demands vengeance from Zeus, who wrecks the ship and drowns every man but Odysseus. Father of Circe.

*Also called:* Helios Hyperion; the Sun.

**Refs:** 1.8, 8.271, 10.138, 12.128–133, 12.263–274 (the warning), 12.343–398 (the slaughter and its portents), 19.275, 23.329. Books 1, 8, 10–12, 19, 22–24.

*See also:* Eurylochus, Circe, Zeus.

**Hellas** (Ἑλλάς) · PLACE — Say: HEL-us

Northern Greece; paired with "mid-Argos" as a stock phrase for the Greek mainland as a whole.

**Refs:** 1.344, 4.726, 4.816, 11.496, 15.80. Books 1, 4, 11, 15.

*See also:* Achaeans.

**Hellespont** (Ἑλλήσποντος) · PLACE — Say: HEL-uh-spont

The strait near the mound of the Achaean dead, cited in the underworld as the site of Achilles's tomb-monument, visible to sailors from far out at sea.

**Refs:** 24.82. Book 24.

*See also:* Achilles.

**Hephaestus** (Ἥφαιστος) · GOD — Say: hih-FES-tus or hih-FEE-stus

The lame smith-god. In Demodocus's Book 8 song he traps his wife Aphrodite and her lover Ares in an invisible net of his own forging and summons the gods to witness their shame — the poem's comic double of its own plot of craft catching strength. He also forged the golden handmaids and other wonders of his own house.

*Epithets:* "the famous god of the two strong arms" (περικλυτὸς ἀμφιγυῖεις, 8.300); "Hephaestus of the many designs" (Ἥφαιστος πολύφρων, 8.297).

*Kin:* husband of Aphrodite.

**Refs:** 4.617, 6.233, 7.92, 8.268–359 (the snare of Ares and Aphrodite), 15.117, 23.160, 24.71–75. Books 4, 6–8, 15, 23–24.

*See also:* Aphrodite, Ares.

**Hera** (Ἥρα) · GOD — Say: HEER-uh or HAIR-uh

Wife of Zeus, mother of Hebe; named chiefly in passing epithets and formulas rather than acting directly in the poem.

*Kin:* wife of Zeus; mother of Hebe.

**Refs:** 4.513, 8.465, 11.604, 12.72, 15.112–180, 20.70. Books 4, 8, 11–12, 15, 20.

*See also:* Zeus, Hebe.

**Heracles** (Ἡρακλῆς) · MORTAL — Say: HER-uh-kleez

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The great hero, son of Zeus; his phantom appears among the dead in Book 11 — Heracles himself feasts deified among the gods, married to Hebe — recalling his labor of fetching the Hound of Hades. Earlier in the poem he is remembered as the guest-killer who murdered Iphitus for his mares, and as an archer who, like Eurytus, "rivalled the immortals with the bow."

**Refs:** 8.224 (Odysseus declines to rival him), 11.267 (his mother Alcmene, among the shades), 11.601 (his phantom in the underworld), 21.26 (kills Iphitus). Books 8, 11, 21.

*See also:* Hebe, Iphitus, Eurytus.

**Hermes** (Ἑρμῆς) · GOD — *Say:* HUR-meez

Messenger of the gods. Sent by Zeus, he carries the gods' decree to Calypso that frees Odysseus from her island (5.28–54); later he waylays Odysseus on the way to Circe's house and gives him the herb moly, which blunts her drugs (10.277–307). He also ferries the suitors' souls to the underworld in Book 24 and is named repeatedly, with Athena, as Odysseus's divine benefactor.

*Epithets:* "the slayer of Argus" / "the guide, the slayer of Argus" (Ἀργεΐφόντης).

**Refs:** 1.38–42, 1.84, 5.28–54 (sent to Calypso), 5.85–195, 8.323–335, 10.277–307 (gives the moly), 11.626, 14.435, 16.471, 24.1–9 (leads the suitors' ghosts). Books 1, 5, 8, 10–12, 14–16, 19, 24.

*See also:* Zeus, Calypso, Circe.

**Hermione** (Ἑρμιόνη) · MORTAL — *Say:* hur-MY-oh-nee

Daughter of Menelaus and Helen, sent off in marriage to Achilles's son Neoptolemus in the same season Telemachus visits Sparta.

*Kin:* daughter of Menelaus and Helen.

**Refs:** 4.14. Book 4.

*See also:* Menelaus, Helen.

**Hippodamia** (Ἱπποδάμεια) · MORTAL — *Say:* hip-oh-duh-MY-uh

One of Penelope's household maids, named among the women at the feast in Book 18.

**Refs:** 18.182. Book 18.

*See also:* Penelope.

**Hound-of-Hades** · OTHER

The monstrous hound of the underworld — Heracles's last and hardest labor was to drag it up out of Hades, with Hermes and Athena as his escorts, as his phantom recalls to Odysseus.

*Also called:* Cerberus.

**Refs:** 11.623, 11.625. Book 11.

*See also:* Heracles, Hades.

**Hylax** (ῥΥλαξ) · MORTAL — *Say:* HY-laks

The grandfather Odysseus invents for himself in the false Cretan genealogy he spins for Eumaeus.

**Refs:** 14.203. Book 14.

*See also:* Eumaeus.

**Hypereia** (ῥΥπέρεια) · PLACE — *Say:* hy-puh-RY-uh

The Phaeacians' former home, near the overbearing Cyclopes, before Nausithous led them to Scheria.

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**Refs:** 6.4. Book 6.

*See also:* Phaeacians, Nausithous, Scheria.

**Hyperesia** (ὑπερησία) · PLACE — *Say:* hy-puh-REE-see-uh

A town named in the pedigree of the seer Theoclymenus recites to Telemachus.

**Refs:** 15.254. Book 15.

*See also:* Theoclymenus.

**Iardanus** (Ἰάρδανος) · PLACE — *Say:* ee-AR-duh-nus

A river in Crete, near the Cydonians, named in Odysseus's tale of Menelaus's storm-driven ships.

**Refs:** 3.292. Book 3.

*See also:* Crete.

**Iasion** (Ἰασίων) · MORTAL — *Say:* eye-AY-see-on

A mortal loved by Demeter, who lay with him in a thrice-plowed field; Zeus struck him dead with a lightning-bolt on hearing of it — the example Calypso cites of the gods' jealousy toward goddesses who take mortal lovers.

**Refs:** 5.126. Book 5.

*See also:* Calypso, Zeus.

**Iasus** (Ἰάσος) · MORTAL — *Say:* EYE-uh-sus

Name of two different fathers in the poem: father of Amphion of Orchomenus (named among the underworld shades) and, separately, father of Dmetor, king of Cyprus, whom Odysseus invents as his master in a false tale.

**Refs:** 11.283, 17.443. Books 11, 17.

*See also:* Dmetor.

**Icarius** (Ἰκάριος) · MORTAL — *Say:* ih-KAIR-ee-us

Penelope's father; she is repeatedly addressed as "daughter of Icarius." His household is the standing alternative the suitors keep threatening to send her back to, should Telemachus give up the fight for his mother's hand.

*Kin:* father of Penelope.

**Refs:** 1.329, 2.53, 2.133, 4.797, 11.446, 16.435, 18.159, 19.375, 20.388, 21.2, 24.195. Books 1–2, 4, 11, 16–21, 24.

*See also:* Penelope.

**Icmalius** (Ἰκμάλιος) · MORTAL — *Say:* ik-MAY-lee-us

The craftsman who made Penelope's inlaid, silver-and-ivory chair.

**Refs:** 19.57. Book 19.

*See also:* Penelope.

**Idomeneus** (Ἰδομενεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* eye-DOM-uh-nyoos or eye-DOM-ih-nee-us

The Cretan king who led his people to Troy; a stock figure in the disguised Odysseus's invented tales, in which Odysseus claims to have hosted him on Crete, or to be his kinsman.

**Refs:** 3.191, 13.259, 14.237, 14.382, 19.181–192. Books 3, 13–14, 19.

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*See also:* Crete.

**Ilus** (Ἴλος) · MORTAL — Say: EYE-lus

Lord of Ephyra whom the young Odysseus visited seeking a lethal poison for his arrows; Ilus refused it, fearing the gods' displeasure, though another host — Anchialus, father of Mentes, the guise in which Athena tells the story — gave it to him out of love. Athena recalls the episode wishing that such an Odysseus might fall upon the suitors.

*Also called:* son of Mermerus.

**Refs:** 1.259, 1.262. Book 1.

*See also:* Athena.

**Ino** (Ἰνώ) · GOD — Say: EYE-noh

A sea-goddess, once mortal, daughter of Cadmus; she pities the shipwrecked Odysseus in Poseidon's storm, rises from the waves as a shearwater, and gives him her immortal veil to bind beneath his chest as a charm against drowning, telling him to abandon the raft and swim for the Phaeacians' shore.

*Also called:* Leucothea, the White Goddess.

**Refs:** 5.333–461 (gives Odysseus the veil, reclaims it). Book 5.

*See also:* Poseidon, Phaeacians.

**Iolcus** (Ἰωλκός) · PLACE — Say: eye-OL-kus

The city of Pelias, from which the Argo sailed; named in the underworld catalogue of women in the story of Tyro and Pelias.

**Refs:** 11.256. Book 11.

*See also:* Hades.

**Iphicles** (Ἰφικλῆς) · MORTAL — Say: IF-ih-kleez

Owner of the prized cattle in the underworld tale of Pero and the seer Melampus: Neleus would give his daughter Pero only to the man who could drive off Iphicles' cattle from Phylace, a feat the seer's brother undertook and, after a year's imprisonment, achieved.

**Refs:** 11.290, 11.296. Book 11.

*See also:* Hades.

**Iphimedeia** (Ἰφιμέδεια) · MORTAL — Say: if-ih-muh-DY-uh

Wife of Aloeus who claimed to have lain with Poseidon; she bore him two short-lived sons, the giant Aloadae, seen among the shades in the underworld catalogue of women.

*Kin:* wife of Aloeus; lover of Poseidon.

**Refs:** 11.305. Book 11.

*See also:* Poseidon.

**Iphitus** (Ἰφίτος) · MORTAL — Say: IF-ih-tus

Son of Eurytus; he meets the young Odysseus in Messene while searching for lost mares, and the two exchange guest-gifts — Iphitus giving Odysseus his father's great bow, Odysseus giving a sword and spear. Heracles later kills Iphitus in his own house for those same mares. The bow, kept at home as a memorial of the friendship, becomes the instrument of the suitors' deaths in Book 21.

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*Kin:* son of Eurytus.

**Refs:** 21.14 (the gift of the bow), 21.22 (killed by Heracles), 21.31–37. Book 21.

*See also:* Eurytus, Heracles.

**Ipphime** (Ἰφθίμη) · MORTAL — *Say:* if-THY-mee

Penelope's sister, daughter of Icarius and wife of Eumelus of Pherae. Athena shapes a phantom in her likeness and sends it to Penelope's bedside to still her fear for Telemachus, a comfort she gives but does not stay to explain.

*Kin:* daughter of Icarius; sister of Penelope; wife of Eumelus.

**Refs:** 4.797.

*See also:* Penelope, Athena.

**Irus** (Ἴρος) · MORTAL — *Say:* EYE-rus

The town beggar of Ithaca, born Arnaeus but nicknamed Irus by the young men for running their errands; big-bodied and gluttonous but without strength. He tries to drive the disguised Odysseus from his own porch and the suitors stage a boxing match between them for sport; Odysseus, holding back his full strength, breaks his neck-bone with one blow and drags him out by the hall door.

*Also called:* Arnaeus (his given name).

**Refs:** 18.6, 18.25, 18.38, 18.56, 18.73, 18.75, 18.88, 18.95, 18.233, 18.239, 18.333, 18.334, 18.393.

*See also:* Odysseus, Antinous.

**Ismarus** (Ἰσμαρος) · PLACE — *Say:* IS-muh-rus

The city of the Cicones on the Thracian coast, the first landfall of Odysseus's homeward voyage. His men sack it, kill the men, and divide the plunder; lingering to feast against his orders costs them a counterattack and six men per ship.

**Refs:** 9.40, 9.198.

*See also:* Cicones, Maron.

**Ithaca** (Ἰθάκη) · PLACE — *Say:* ITH-uh-kuh

Odysseus's rugged island kingdom west of the Greek mainland, the goal of the whole poem's homeward drive. It is the seat of his household, Penelope's twenty-year vigil, and the suitors' occupation of his hall, and the poem's structure alternates between the Telemachy and Apologoi abroad and the long return to it in Books 13–24.

*Epithets:* "sea-circled Ithaca" (ἀμφιάλος Ἰθάκη, 1.386); "rocky Ithaca" (Ἰθάκη κραναή, 1.247).

**Refs:** 1.18, 1.57, 1.88, 2.25, 4.555, 9.21, 9.531, 11.480, 13.97, 13.212, 14.98 ...and throughout. Books 1–4, 9–24.

*See also:* Odysseus, Penelope, Telemachus, Laertes.

**Ithacus** (Ἰθακος) · MORTAL — *Say:* ITH-uh-kus

Eponymous founder of Ithaca; with Neritus and Polyctor he is remembered as builder of the town's fountain, which the disguised Odysseus and Melanthius pass on the road.

*Kin:* named alongside Neritus and Polyctor.

**Refs:** 17.207.

*See also:* Ithaca.

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**Itylus** (Ἴτυλος) · MORTAL — Say: IT-ih-lus

The young son killed, by mishap, by his own mother Aedon, who mourns him forever as the nightingale; Penelope compares her own divided heart to Aedon's song as she debates whether to stay or leave Odysseus's house.

*Kin:* son of Aedon.

**Refs:** 19.522.

*See also:* Penelope.

**Jason** (Ἰήσων) · MORTAL — Say: JAY-sun

Leader of the Argonauts; his ship Argo, "whom all minds know," is named as the one vessel ever to have passed safely between the Wandering Rocks, sailing home from Aeetes — the single precedent Circe cites when she steers Odysseus toward Scylla and Charybdis instead.

**Refs:** 12.72.

*See also:* Circe, Aeetes.

**Lacedaemon** (Λακεδαίμων) · PLACE — Say: las-uh-DEE-mun

The region of which Sparta is the city, Menelaus and Helen's home; Telemachus and Peisistratus drive there by chariot from Pylos, and it recurs as the byword for Menelaus's court throughout the Telemachy.

**Refs:** 3.326, 4.1, 4.313, 5.20, 13.414, 15.1, 17.121, 21.13.

*See also:* Menelaus, Sparta.

**Laerces** (Λαέρκης) · MORTAL — Say: lay-UR-seez

The goldsmith Nestor summons to gild the horns of the heifer sacrificed to Athena at Pylos.

**Refs:** 3.425.

*See also:* Nestor, Athena.

**Laertes** (Λαέρτης) · MORTAL — Say: lay-UR-teez

Odysseus's aged father, who has withdrawn in grief to his farm in the hills, refusing to set foot in town while the suitors despoil his son's house. He appears throughout the poem as a measure of Odysseus's long absence, and in Book 24 Odysseus reveals himself to him in the orchard, naming the very trees his father once gave him as a boy — the poem's last and gentlest test of identity, restoring him briefly to youth and armor for the final skirmish.

*Kin:* son of Arceisius; father of Odysseus by Anticleia; grandfather of Telemachus.

**Refs:** 1.189, 1.430, 4.111, 9.19, 11.405, 16.118, 22.185, 22.336. Books 1–2, 4–5, 8–24.

*See also:* Odysseus, Anticleia, Telemachus.

**Laestrygonians** (Λαιστρυγόνες) · PEOPLE — Say: lees-trih-GOH-nee-unz

A race of cannibal giants ruled from the city of Lamus; when Odysseus's fleet puts in at their harbor, they hurl boulders down from the cliffs, sink the ships, and spear the crews like fish, destroying eleven of his twelve vessels at a stroke — the single worst loss of the wanderings.

**Refs:** 10.82, 10.106, 10.119, 10.199, 23.318.

*See also:* Antiphates, Lamus.

**Lampetie** (Λαμπετή) · GOD — Say: lam-PEE-shee

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Nymph, daughter of Helios and Neaera, who with her sister Phaethusa herds and guards the Sun's sacred cattle on Thrinacia; she carries word to her father when Odysseus's starving men slaughter the herd.

*Kin:* daughter of Helios; sister of Phaethusa.

**Refs:** 12.132, 12.375.

*See also:* Helios, Phaethusa.

**Lampus** (Λάμπος) · OTHER — *Say:* LAM-pus

One of the two colts — with Phaethon — that draw the chariot of Dawn as she rises on the day of the bow-contest.

**Refs:** 23.246.

*See also:* Dawn.

**Lamus** (Λάμος) · PLACE — *Say:* LAY-mus

Founder-eponym of Telepylus, the Laestrygonian city, "where herdsman hails herdsman" at the meeting of night and day.

**Refs:** 10.81.

*See also:* Laestrygonians.

**Laodamas** (Λαοδάμας) · MORTAL — *Say:* lay-OD-uh-mus

Son of Alcinous and Arete, foremost of the young Phaeacian athletes; he urges the shipwrecked Odysseus to join the games at Book 8's contest and, when Odysseus balks, needles him toward the discus-throw that proves his strength.

*Kin:* son of Alcinous and Arete; brother of Nausicaa.

**Refs:** 7.170, 8.117, 8.119, 8.130, 8.153, 8.207, 8.370.

*See also:* Alcinous, Arete, Nausicaa, Phaeacians.

**Lapiths** (Λαπίθαι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* LAP-iths

The people who, at Peirithous's wedding feast, fought and defeated the drunken Centaurs — the paradigm Odysseus (disguised) invokes when he predicts Antinous's ruin.

**Refs:** 21.297.

*See also:* Antinous.

**Leda** (Λήδη) · MORTAL — *Say:* LEE-duh

Mother, by Tyndareus, of Castor and Polydeuces; Odysseus glimpses her shade among the heroines paraded before him in the underworld.

*Kin:* mother of Castor and Polydeuces.

**Refs:** 11.298.

*See also:* Odysseus.

**Lemnos** (Λήμνος) · PLACE — *Say:* LEM-nos

The island home of Hephaestus, named in the song Demodocus sings of Ares and Aphrodite's adultery — Hephaestus departs for Lemnos, the affair he leaves to catch is exposed by the sun-god.

**Refs:** 8.283, 8.294, 8.301.

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*See also:* Hephaestus, Aphrodite.

**Leocritus** (Λεώκριτος) · MORTAL — *Say:* lee-OK-rih-tus

Son of Eenor; a suitor who mocks Mentor and breaks up the Book 2 assembly, unwittingly prophesying his own side's ruin — a prophecy the poem fulfills when Telemachus's spear takes him through the flank in the slaughter.

*Kin:* son of Eenor.

**Refs:** 2.242, 22.294.

*See also:* Mentor, Telemachus, the suitors.

**Leodes** (Λεώδης) · MORTAL — *Say:* lee-OH-deez

Son of Oenops; the suitors' soothsayer and sacrificer, and — the poem insists — the one among them who genuinely hated their outrages and tried to stop them. He clasps Odysseus's knees and begs by that innocence, but Odysseus convicts him on his office, not his acts — as their diviner he must have prayed for the suitors' success — and beheads him mid-plea.

*Kin:* son of Oenops.

**Refs:** 21.144, 21.168, 22.310.

*See also:* Odysseus, the suitors.

**Lesbos** (Λέσβος) · PLACE — *Say:* LEZ-bos

The island where a young Odysseus once wrestled and beat Philomeleides; Nestor, Menelaus, and the disguised Odysseus himself all cite the crossing at Lesbos as a landmark of sea-judgment.

**Refs:** 3.169, 4.342, 17.133.

*See also:* Odysseus.

**Leto** (Λητώ) · GOD — *Say:* LEE-toh

Mother of Apollo and Artemis by Zeus; invoked as the mother of the archer-twins and, in the underworld catalogue, as the goddess whose assault by Tityus earns him eternal punishment.

*Kin:* mother of Apollo and Artemis (by Zeus).

**Refs:** 6.106, 11.318, 11.580.

*See also:* Apollo, Artemis.

**Libya** (Λιβύη) · PLACE

The North African land Menelaus describes as endlessly rich in flocks, where lambs are born horned and ewes may lamb three times a year; Eumaeus's false Cretan tale also passes through it.

**Refs:** 4.85, 14.295.

*See also:* Menelaus, Eumaeus.

**Lotus-eaters** (Λωτοφάγοι) · PEOPLE

A gentle people whose flower-food erases all wish for home; three of Odysseus's scouts taste it and must be dragged weeping back to the ships and bound under the benches — the wanderings' first lesson in what threatens the return.

**Refs:** 9.84, 9.91, 9.92, 9.96, 23.311.

*See also:* Odysseus.



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**Maera** (Μαῖρα) · MORTAL — Say: MEE-ruh

A heroine Odysseus glimpses among the shades of famous women in the underworld.

**Refs:** 11.326.

*See also:* Odysseus.

**Maia** (Μαῖα) · GOD — Say: MY-uh or MAY-uh

Nymph, mother of Hermes by Zeus; named when Eumaeus's tale touches the god's lineage.

*Kin:* mother of Hermes (by Zeus).

**Refs:** 14.436.

*See also:* Hermes.

**Malea** (Μαλέα) · PLACE — Say: muh-LEE-uh

The stormy cape at the southern tip of the Peloponnese where homeward-bound fleets are scattered; it drives Odysseus off course to the Cicones and Lotus-eaters and recurs in Nestor's, Menelaus's, and Amphimedon's accounts as the place where fair voyages turn to disaster.

**Refs:** 3.288, 4.515, 9.80, 19.187.

*See also:* Odysseus.

**Mantius** (Μάντιος) · MORTAL — Say: MAN-tee-us

Son of the seer Melampus, father of Polyphides and Cleitus, in the genealogy Theoclymenus recites of his own line of seers.

*Kin:* son of Melampus; father of Polyphides and Cleitus.

**Refs:** 15.242, 15.249.

*See also:* Melampus, Theoclymenus.

**Marathon** (Μαραθών) · PLACE — Say: MAR-uh-thon

Attic town Athena passes on her way to Athens, named in the brief itinerary of her flight from Scheria after guiding Odysseus's ship.

**Refs:** 7.80.

*See also:* Athena.

**Maron** (Μάρων) · MORTAL — Say: MAY-ron

Son of Euanthes, priest of Apollo at Ismarus; Odysseus and his men spared him and his family out of reverence when they sacked the town, and in gratitude he gives Odysseus the potent, richly diluted wine that will later fell the Cyclops.

*Kin:* son of Euanthes.

**Refs:** 9.197.

*See also:* Ismarus, Polyphemus, Apollo.

**Mastor** (Μάστωρ) · MORTAL — Say: MAS-tor

Father of Halitherses, the Ithacan elder and seer.

*Kin:* father of Halitherses.

**Refs:** 2.158, 24.452.

*See also:* Halitherses.

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**Medon** (Μέδων) · MORTAL — Say: MEE-don

The herald of Odysseus's house; he warns Penelope of the suitors' ambush plot against Telemachus, and in the slaughter he is spared, along with the singer Phemius, at Telemachus's plea — the herald "who always cared for me when I was a child," found cowering under a chair wrapped in an oxhide.

**Refs:** 4.677, 4.696, 4.711, 16.252, 16.412, 22.357, 22.361, 24.439, 24.442.

*See also:* Phemius, Telemachus, Penelope.

**Megapenthes** (Μεγαπένθης) · MORTAL — Say: meg-uh-PEN-theez

Menelaus's son by a slave-woman, born late to him since the gods gave Helen no more children after Hermione; he is married off in the same double wedding-feast that greets Telemachus's arrival at Sparta.

*Kin:* son of Menelaus (by a slave-woman).

**Refs:** 4.11, 15.100, 15.103, 15.121.

*See also:* Menelaus.

**Megara** (Μεγάρα) · MORTAL — Say: MEG-uh-ruh

Daughter of Creon and wife of Heracles; Odysseus sees her shade among the famous women paraded before him in the underworld.

*Kin:* daughter of Creon; wife of Heracles.

**Refs:** 11.269.

*See also:* Odysseus.

**Melampus** (Μελάμπος) · MORTAL — Say: muh-LAM-pus

The seer-ancestor of Theoclymenus's line. To win his brother a bride — Neleus's daughter — he stole the cattle of Iphiclus and was caught and bound for a year in bitter chains at Phylacus's hall; he escaped with the cattle, drove them to Pylos, paid off Neleus, and won the woman for his brother before founding a new line in Argos.

**Refs:** 15.225, 15.231.

*See also:* Mantius, Theoclymenus, Neleus.

**Melaneus** (Μελανεύς) · MORTAL — Say: mel-uh-NEE-us

Father of Amphimedon, one of the suitors; named in Amphimedon's shade's account of the massacre in the underworld.

*Kin:* father of Amphimedon.

**Refs:** 24.103.

*See also:* Amphimedon.

**Melanthius** (Μελάνθιος) · MORTAL — Say: muh-LAN-thee-us

Dolius's son, the treacherous goatherd who insults the disguised Odysseus, arms the suitors from Odysseus's own storeroom during the final battle, and is caught in the act carrying Laertes' mildewed old shield. Odysseus and Eumaeus truss him and hang him alive from a roof-beam to suffer through the fighting; after the suitors fall he is dragged out and mutilated — nose, ears, hands, feet, and genitals torn away.

*Kin:* son of Dolius.

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**Refs:** 17.212, 17.247, 17.369, 20.173, 21.176, 22.135, 22.159, 22.182, 22.474.

*See also:* Odysseus, Eumaeus, Dolius, Melantho.

**Melantho** (Μελανθώ) · MORTAL — *Say:* muh-LAN-thoh

An insolent slave-woman in Odysseus's household and Eurymachus's mistress; she taunts the disguised Odysseus and is later hanged with the other disloyal slave-women.

**Refs:** 18.321, 19.65.

*See also:* Eurymachus, Melanthius, Odysseus.

**Memnon** (Μέμνων) · MORTAL — *Say:* MEM-non

Son of Dawn, a Trojan-war ally killed at Troy; Odysseus names him, alongside Achilles, as one of the great dead when he flatters Achilles's shade in the underworld.

*Kin:* son of Dawn (Eos).

**Refs:** 11.522.

*See also:* Achilles.

**Menelaus** (Μενέλαος) · MORTAL — *Say:* men-uh-LAY-us

King of Sparta, Helen's husband, and younger brother of Agamemnon; Telemachus visits him in Book 4 to ask news of his father, and Menelaus recounts his own storm-tossed detour to Egypt and his wrestling-match with Proteus, who told him of Odysseus stranded on Calypso's island. He is the referent of "son of Atreus" / "Atreides" in the Telemachy, as opposed to Agamemnon elsewhere.

*Epithets:* "fair-haired Menelaus" (ξανθὸς Μενέλαος, 1.285); "Menelaus of the great war-cry" (βοῆν ἄγαθὸς Μενέλαος, 3.311).

*Also called:* "son of Atreus" / "Atreides" (context-dependent; Menelaus in the Telemachy, Books 3–4, 15).

*Kin:* son of Atreus; brother of Agamemnon; husband of Helen; father of Hermione and Megapenthes.

**Refs:** 1.285, 3.141, 4.2, 4.147, 4.235, 4.316, 4.561 (Proteus's news of Odysseus), 15.5, 15.87. Books 1, 3–4, 8, 11, 13–15, 17, 24.

*See also:* Helen, Agamemnon, Telemachus, Proteus.

**Menoetius** (Μενοίτιος) · MORTAL — *Say:* muh-NEE-tee-us

Father of Patroclus, Achilles's close companion; named when Agamemnon's shade describes the two men's bones mingled in a single golden urn after Achilles's funeral.

*Kin:* father of Patroclus.

**Refs:** 24.77.

*See also:* Achilles.

**Mentes** (Μέντις) · MORTAL — *Say:* MEN-teez

Chieftain of the Taphians and a guest-friend of Odysseus's line; Athena takes his shape to visit Telemachus at the poem's opening, urge him to call the assembly, and set him sailing for news of his father.

**Refs:** 1.105, 1.180, 1.418.

*See also:* Athena, Telemachus.

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**Mentor** (Μέντωρ) · MORTAL — Say: MEN-tor

Odysseus's companion, entrusted with his whole household when he sailed for Troy. He alone speaks up for Telemachus at the Book 2 assembly, rebuking the people's silence — and Athena repeatedly borrows his exact shape and voice afterward (2.268, 22.206, 24.503), so that "Mentor" in later scenes is the goddess herself in his likeness rather than the man.

*Kin:* Odysseus's steward-companion.

**Refs:** 2.225 (the real Mentor, speaking for himself), 2.268 (Athena first as Mentor), 3.22, 4.654, 17.68, 22.206, 22.235, 24.446, 24.503, 24.548.

*See also:* Athena, Odysseus, Telemachus.

**Mermerus** (Μέρμερος) · MORTAL — Say: MUR-muh-rus

Father of Ilus of Ephya, the poison-dealer Odysseus once sought out; named only in that genealogical aside.

*Kin:* father of Ilus.

**Refs:** 1.259.

*See also:* Odysseus.

**Mesaulius** (Μεσαύλιος) · MORTAL — Say: muh-SAW-lee-us

A slave Eumaeus bought with his own means, from Taphian traders, while his master was away — his private property rather than part of the household stock.

**Refs:** 14.449, 14.455.

*See also:* Eumaeus.

**Messene** (Μεσσήνη) · PLACE — Say: muh-SEE-nee

The region where a young Odysseus, sent to collect a debt, first met and befriended Iphitus, who gave him the bow he keeps at home ever after.

**Refs:** 21.15.

*See also:* Odysseus, Iphitus.

**Mimas** (Μίμας) · PLACE — Say: MY-mus

The headland opposite Chios that marks a turn on the sailing route Nestor recounts from the fall of Troy.

**Refs:** 3.172.

*See also:* Nestor.

**Minos** (Μίνωας) · MORTAL — Say: MY-nos

King of Crete in his lifetime, "shining son of Zeus"; in the underworld Odysseus sees him seated with a golden scepter, delivering judgment among the dead as they plead their cases before him.

*Kin:* son of Zeus.

**Refs:** 11.322, 11.568, 17.523, 19.178.

*See also:* Odysseus, Zeus.

**Moly** (μῶλυ) · OTHER — Say: MOH-lee

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The god-given herb, black-rooted with a milk-white flower, that Hermes gives Odysseus to make him proof against Circe's drug before he confronts her.

**Refs:** 10.305.

*See also:* Hermes, Circe.

**Moulius** (Μούλιος) · MORTAL — *Say:* MOO-lee-us

Herald of the suitor Amphinomus, briefly named in his master's service.

**Refs:** 18.423.

*See also:* Amphinomus.

**Muses** (Μοῦσαι) · GOD

The nine goddesses of song, invoked by the narrator in the poem's opening line ("Sing to me, Muse...") and, in Agamemnon's account of Achilles's funeral, appearing in the story itself: all nine sing the dirge over his body, "answering voice to lovely voice" — poetry's patronesses mourning poetry's own hero.

**Refs:** 1.1, 8.63, 8.480, 24.60, 24.62.

*See also:* Demodocus, Achilles.

**Mycenae** (Μυκῆνη) · PLACE — *Say:* my-SEE-nee

Agamemnon's city; Nestor recounts that Aegisthus ruled there seven years after murdering Agamemnon, before Orestes returned to kill him. Telemachus later invokes it, with Pylos and Argos, as a byword for a woman's fame in praising Penelope.

**Refs:** 3.305, 21.108.

*See also:* Agamemnon, Orestes, Mycene.

**Mycene** (Μυκῆνη) · MORTAL — *Say:* my-SEE-nee

A heroine of the old days, "of the lovely crown," named beside Tyro and Alcmene in the catalogue of legendary women; the eponym of Agamemnon's city Mycenae.

**Refs:** 2.120.

*See also:* Mycenae.

**Myrmidons** (Μυρμιδόνες) · PEOPLE — *Say:* MUR-mih-donz

Achilles's Thessalian people, named when his kingdom and son Neoptolemus are discussed in the Telemachy and the underworld.

**Refs:** 3.188, 4.9, 11.495.

*See also:* Achilles.

**Naiads** (Νηϊάδες) · GOD — *Say:* NY-adz or NAY-adz

The water-nymphs of the sea-cave sacred at the head of the harbor of Phorcys in Ithaca, where Odysseus once offered them hecatombs and where the Phaeacians lay him, still asleep, with his treasure on his return. Athena cites the cave's exact details to prove to Odysseus that he is truly home, and his first act on recognizing Ithaca is to pray to these "nymphs of the springs, daughters of Zeus."

*Also called:* "the nymphs" (generic).

**Refs:** 13.104, 13.348, 13.356, 14.435, 17.240.

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*See also:* Ithaca, Phorcys.

**Nausicaa** (Ναυσικάα) · MORTAL — Say: naw-SIK-ay-uh

Daughter of Alcinous and Arete, out washing linens with her handmaids when she finds the shipwrecked, naked Odysseus on the shore (Book 6). She guides him to her parents' hall with tact and self-possession, and is the last woman he meets before Penelope; Odysseus's parting blessing to her (6.180ff) is one of the poem's tenderest speeches. She reappears briefly at the Book 8 games.

*Epithets:* "white-armed Nausicaa" (Ναυσικάα λευκώλενος, 6.101).

*Kin:* daughter of Alcinous and Arete; sister of Laodamas.

**Refs:** 6.17 (first, "daughter of great-hearted Alcinous"), 6.25, 6.49, 6.101, 6.186, 6.213, 6.251, 6.276, 7.12, 8.457, 8.464.

*See also:* Alcinous, Arete, Phaeacians, Scheria.

**Nausithous** (Ναυσίθοος) · MORTAL — Say: naw-SITH-oh-us

Former king of the Phaeacians, son of Poseidon and Periboea, who led his people away from the Cyclopes' neighborhood and settled them on Scheria. Father of Rhexenor and Alcinous; already dead by the time of Odysseus's visit, but Alcinous cites his father's old warning that Poseidon resents the Phaeacians' habit of ferrying every stranger home unharmed (8.564–566) — the warning that comes true against Odysseus's own ship.

*Kin:* son of Poseidon and Periboea; father of Rhexenor and Alcinous.

**Refs:** 6.7, 7.56–63 (the genealogy), 8.564.

*See also:* Alcinous, Poseidon, Periboea, Scheria.

**Neaera** (Νέαира) · GOD — Say: nee-EE-ruh

A nymph named only once, by Helios as the mother of the herdswomen who tend his cattle and sheep on Thrinacia — Phaethusa and Lampetie.

*Kin:* consort of Helios.

**Refs:** 12.133.

*See also:* Helios.

**Neion** (Νήϊον) · PLACE — Say: NEE-on

A height on Ithaca above the harbor, named in passing as Telemachus's ship sets out and again in the muster for the suitors' funeral ambush.

**Refs:** 1.186, 3.81.

*See also:* Ithaca.

**Neleus** (Νηλεύς) · MORTAL — Say: NEE-lee-us

Former king of Pylos, father of Nestor; son of Poseidon and Tyro, who bore him and his twin Pelias in secret. He is already gone by the poem's present, but his house still stands: his daughter Pero was won by a suitor who first had to drive off the cattle of Iphicles, and several of his other sons are named among Nestor's dead brothers.

*Kin:* son of Poseidon and Tyro; father of Nestor, Chromius, Periclymenus, Pero, and others.

**Refs:** 3.4, 3.79, 3.202, 3.247, 3.409, 3.465, 11.254–257 (birth), 11.281–288 (Pero and the cattle-feat), 15.229–237.

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*See also:* Nestor, Pero, Pelias, Tyro.

**Neoptolemus** (Νεοπτόλεμος) · MORTAL — Say: nee-op-TOL-uh-mus

Achilles's son, fetched from Scyros to fight at Troy; in the underworld Odysseus tells Achilles's ghost of his son's courage and success in the war — news meant to comfort a father who cannot know it himself.

*Kin:* son of Achilles.

**Refs:** 11.506.

*See also:* Achilles, Peleus.

**Nericus** (Νήρικος) · PLACE — Say: NER-ih-kus

A mainland town that Laertes once captured while he was still king in his strength, recalled in the poem's closing book as a measure of the old man's former vigor.

**Refs:** 24.377.

*See also:* Laertes.

**Neriton** (Νήριτον) · PLACE — Say: NER-ih-ton

The tall, wooded mountain that dominates Ithaca's skyline, named as a landmark visible from the sea and invoked in similes of visibility and height.

**Refs:** 9.22, 13.351.

*See also:* Ithaca.

**Neritus** (Νήριτος) · MORTAL — Say: NER-ih-tus

One of the legendary founders associated with Ithaca, named once and distinct from the mountain Neriton that bears a similar name.

**Refs:** 17.207.

*See also:* Ithaca, Neriton.

**Nestor** (Νέστωρ) · MORTAL — Say: NES-tor

Aged king of Pylos, son of Neleus, and the sole surviving elder statesman of the generation that sailed to Troy. Telemachus visits him first in his search for news of his father (Book 3); Nestor cannot say what became of Odysseus but retells the Achaeans' quarrelsome breakup after Troy and Agamemnon's murder at length, then sends Telemachus on to Sparta with his son Peisistratus as escort. Telemachus recalls the visit again to Penelope in Book 17, and Agamemnon's shade recalls Nestor's steadying counsel at Achilles's funeral in Book 24's retelling of Troy.

*Epithets:* "Gerenian Nestor the horseman" (Γερήνιος ἵππότης Νέστωρ, 3.68).

*Kin:* son of Neleus; father of Peisistratus, Antilochus (dead at Troy), Thrasymedes, and others.

**Refs:** 1.284, 3.17–79 (the arrival and sacrifice), 3.102–474 (his long telling), 4.21, 11.286, 11.512, 15.4–202 (Telemachus's departure) ...and throughout Books 3–4, 15, 17, 24.

*See also:* Neleus, Peisistratus, Telemachus, Pylos.

**Nisus** (Νίσος) · MORTAL — Say: NY-sus

Lord of Dulichium and father of the suitor Amphinomus, named only to identify his son.

*Kin:* father of Amphinomus.

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**Refs:** 16.395, 18.127, 18.413.

*See also:* Amphinomus.

**Noemon** (Νοήμων) · MORTAL — *Say:* noh-EE-mon

An Ithacan, son of Phronius, who lends Telemachus the ship for his secret voyage to Pylos and later unwittingly tips off the suitors that he has gone.

*Also called:* "son of Phronius."

**Refs:** 2.386, 4.630, 4.648.

*See also:* Telemachus, the suitors.

**Ocean** (Ὠκεανός) · PLACE

The great river that the poem imagines encircling the flat world; beyond its stream lie the sunless land of the dead and other far horizons. Odysseus crosses it to reach the underworld (Book 10–11), and it recurs as a boundary-marker in similes and geography throughout.

**Refs:** 4.567, 5.275, 10.139, 10.508–511, 11.13–21, 11.158, 11.639, 12.1, 19.434, 20.65, 22.197, 23.244–347, 24.11.

*See also:* the underworld, Persephone.

**Odysseus** (Ὀδυσσεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* oh-DIS-ee-us or oh-DISS-yoos

King of Ithaca, son of Laertes, husband of Penelope, father of Telemachus; the poem is his homecoming. Detained by Calypso, wrecked on Scheria, he tells the Phaeacians his ten years of wandering (Books 9–12) — the Cicones, the Lotus-eaters, Polyphemus (whom he blinds and tricks with the name "Nobody"), Circe, the underworld, the Sirens, Scylla and Charybdis, and Thrinacia — then sails home alone, disguised by Athena as a beggar, to test his household, win the bow-contest, and slaughter the suitors before revealing himself to Penelope and Laertes.

*Epithets:* "much-enduring noble Odysseus" (πολύτλας δῖος Ὀδυσσεύς, 5.171); "Odysseus of the many designs" (πολύμητις/πολύφρων Ὀδυσσεύς, 1.83, 2.173); "noble Odysseus" (δῖος Ὀδυσσεύς, 1.196); "Odysseus, sacker of cities" (πτολίπορθος Ὀδυσσεύς, 8.3).

*Also called:* "Nobody" (Οὔτις), the trick-name given to Polyphemus in Book 9.

*Kin:* son of Laertes and Anticleia; husband of Penelope; father of Telemachus.

**Refs:** 1.21 (opening line), 1.48, 1.196, 2.173, 3.163 ...and throughout every book, 1–24.

*See also:* Penelope, Telemachus, Laertes, Athena, Calypso, Polyphemus.

**Oechalia** (Οἰχαλία) · PLACE — *Say:* ee-KAY-lee-uh

The city ruled by Eurytus, the great archer whose bow Odysseus later strings; named once in the catalogue of that bow's history.

**Refs:** 8.224.

*See also:* Eurytus.

**Oedipus** (Οἰδίπους) · MORTAL — *Say:* EE-dih-pus or ED-ih-pus

Named in the underworld as the son and unwitting husband of Epicaste (Jocasta), who hanged herself in horror once the truth of their marriage came out; Odysseus sees her ghost among the heroines.

*Kin:* son and husband of Epicaste.

**Refs:** 11.271.



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*See also:* the underworld.

**Oenops** (Οἶνοψ) · MORTAL — *Say:* EE-nops

Father of the suitor Leodes, named only to identify his son.

*Kin:* father of Leodes.

**Refs:** 21.144.

*See also:* Leodes, the suitors.

**Ogygia** (Ὠκυγίνη) · PLACE — *Say:* oh-JIJ-ee-uh

Calypso's remote island, "the navel of the sea," where Odysseus spends seven years before the gods intervene to send him home.

**Refs:** 1.85, 6.172, 7.244–254, 12.448, 23.333.

*See also:* Calypso.

**Oicles** (Οἰκλής) · MORTAL — *Say:* OY-kleez

Father of the seer Amphiaraus, named in Theoclymenus's genealogy.

*Kin:* father of Amphiaraus.

**Refs:** 15.243–244.

*See also:* Theoclymenus, Amphiaraus.

**Olympus** (Ὀλύμπος) · PLACE — *Say:* oh-LIM-pus

The gods' mountain seat, set above weather and mortal change; the site of the divine councils that open and close the poem's action (1.102, 24.351–488) and the standing address of the immortals throughout.

**Refs:** 1.102, 3.377, 6.42–240, 8.331, 10.308, 11.315, 12.337, 14.394, 15.43, 18.180, 19.43, 20.55–103, 23.167, 24.351–488.

*See also:* Zeus, Athena.

**Onetor** (Ὀνήτωρ) · MORTAL — *Say:* oh-NEE-tor

Father of Phrontis, the Sparta-bound helmsman Menelaus lost off Sunium, named only in that aside.

*Kin:* father of Phrontis.

**Refs:** 3.282.

*See also:* Menelaus.

**Ops** (Ὀψ) · MORTAL — *Say:* OPS

Father of Eurycleia, Odysseus's old nurse; the patronymic recurs every time she is formally introduced. He is himself "Peisenor's son" — a different Peisenor from the Ithacan herald of Book 2 (see Peisenor).

*Kin:* father of Eurycleia.

**Refs:** 1.429, 2.347, 20.148.

*See also:* Eurycleia, Peisenor.

**Orchomenus** (Ὀρχομενός) · PLACE — *Say:* or-KOM-uh-nus

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The Minyan city of legendary wealth, twice invoked in the underworld book as a byword for riches — once by Tyro's line, once ranked alongside Egyptian Thebes.

**Refs:** 11.284, 11.459.

*See also:* the underworld.

**Orestes** (Ὀρέστης) · MORTAL — *Say:* oh-RES-teez

Agamemnon's son, who avenges his father's murder by killing Aegisthus; the gods and Athena repeatedly hold him up to Telemachus as the model of the heir who acts, the poem's counter-example to Telemachus's own hesitation.

*Kin:* son of Agamemnon and Clytemnestra.

**Refs:** 1.30, 1.40, 1.298, 3.306, 4.546, 11.461.

*See also:* Agamemnon, Aegisthus, Telemachus.

**Orion** (Ὠρίων) · MORTAL — *Say:* oh-RY-un

The great hunter: Dawn once loved and carried him off, until the gods' envy brought Artemis's arrows down on him in Ortygia; in the underworld his ghost still strides the asphodel meadow driving the beasts he killed in life. Also named as the constellation Calypso tells Odysseus to watch by.

**Refs:** 5.121–123, 5.274, 11.310, 11.572–574.

*See also:* Ortygia, Artemis, the underworld.

**Ormenus** (Ὀρμενος) · MORTAL — *Say:* OR-muh-nus

Father of Ctesius in Eumaeus's account of his own ancestry, named only there.

*Kin:* father of Ctesius.

**Refs:** 15.414.

*See also:* Eumaeus.

**Orsilochus** (Ὀρσίλοχος) · MORTAL — *Say:* or-SIL-oh-kus

Son of Idomeneus in the false tale Odysseus spins for Athena on the Ithacan shore, claiming to have killed him in an ambush over war-spoils.

*Kin:* (in the lying tale) son of Idomeneus.

**Refs:** 13.260.

*See also:* Odysseus, Idomeneus.

**Ortilochus** (Ὀρτίλοχος) · MORTAL — *Say:* or-TIL-oh-kus

Son of the river-god Alpheus and father of Diocles of Pherae, the host who lodges Telemachus and Peisistratus on their road to and from Sparta.

*Kin:* son of Alpheus; father of Diocles.

**Refs:** 3.489, 15.187, 21.16.

*See also:* Diocles, Peisistratus.

**Ortygia** (Ὀρτυγίη) · PLACE — *Say:* or-TIJ-ee-uh

The island where Artemis's gentle arrows struck down Orion; named again in Eumaeus's account of his distant homeland.

**Refs:** 5.123, 15.404.

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*See also:* Orion, Artemis.

**Ossa** (Ὀσσα) · PLACE — Say: OS-uh

One of the two mountains — with Pelion — that the giants Otus and Ephialtes piled on Olympus in their assault on heaven.

**Refs:** 11.315.

*See also:* Otus, Pelion, Olympus.

**Otus** (Ὀτος) · MORTAL — Say: OH-tus

Giant son of Iphimedeia and Poseidon, twin of Ephialtes; the pair grew to monstrous size and beauty and piled Ossa on Olympus and Pelion on Ossa to storm heaven, before Apollo destroyed them young.

*Kin:* son of Iphimedeia (by Poseidon); twin of Ephialtes.

**Refs:** 11.308.

*See also:* Ossa, Pelion, Olympus.

**Paeon** (Παιών) · GOD — Say: pee-EE-on

The physician of the gods, invoked by Helen in an aside about Egyptian medicine as the source of healing skill.

**Refs:** 4.232.

*See also:* Helen.

**Pandareus** (Πανδάρειος) · MORTAL — Say: pan-DAIR-ee-us

Father of the nightingale-woman Aedon, whose grief at accidentally killing her own son is the simile for Penelope's sleepless sorrow (19.518), and father too of the daughters swept off by the storm-winds after the gods orphaned them (20.66).

*Kin:* father of Aedon and of the storm-snatched daughters.

**Refs:** 19.518, 20.66.

*See also:* Penelope.

**Panopeus** (Πανοπέυς) · PLACE — Say: puh-NOP-ee-us

A Phocian town, named as a landmark near which the giant Tityus lies stretched out in torment in the underworld.

**Refs:** 11.581.

*See also:* the underworld, Tityus.

**Paphos** (Πάφος) · PLACE — Say: PAF-os or PAY-fos

Aphrodite's sacred precinct on Cyprus, where she withdraws after her affair with Ares is exposed, to be bathed and anointed by the Graces.

**Refs:** 8.363.

*See also:* Aphrodite.

**Parnassus** (Παρνησός) · PLACE — Say: par-NAS-us

The mountain where young Odysseus hunted with his uncles and took the boar-gash on his thigh that becomes his identifying scar, recognized first by Eurycleia and later by Laertes.

**Refs:** 19.394–466, 21.220, 24.332.

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*See also:* Odysseus, Eurycleia, Autolycus.

**Patroclus** (Πάτροκλος) · MORTAL — Say: puh-TROH-klus

Achilles's closest companion at Troy; his ghost appears beside Achilles's in the underworld, and the two share a single funeral mound, their ashes mixed as they had asked.

*Kin:* companion of Achilles.

**Refs:** 3.110, 11.468, 24.16, 24.77–79.

*See also:* Achilles, the underworld.

**Peirithous** (Πειρίθοος) · MORTAL — Say: py-RITH-oh-us

Lapith king and companion of Theseus, seen among the famous women's train of shades that Odysseus does not linger to describe; also the host in whose hall the drunken Centaur Eurytion committed his outrage, the paradigm of wine-fueled violence cited against the suitors.

*Kin:* companion of Theseus.

**Refs:** 11.631, 21.296–298.

*See also:* Theseus, the underworld.

**Peisander** (Πείσανδρος) · MORTAL — Say: py-SAN-der

Son of Polyctor, one of the suitors; struck dumb with fear at the first killings and cut down by Philoetius in the hall-fight.

*Also called:* "son of Polyctor."

*Kin:* son of Polyctor.

**Refs:** 18.299, 22.243, 22.268.

*See also:* the suitors.

**Peisenor** (Πεισήνωρ) · MORTAL — Say: py-SEE-nor

Two different men share this name in the poem: an Ithacan herald of "clear-headed counsel" who attends the Book 2 assembly (2.38), and — a generation earlier — the father of Ops and so the grandfather of Eurycleia, invoked whenever she is introduced by her full patronymic (1.429, 2.347, 20.148).

**Refs:** 1.429, 2.38, 2.347, 20.148.

*See also:* Ops, Eurycleia.

**Peisistratus** (Πεισίστρατος) · MORTAL — Say: py-SIS-truh-tus

Nestor's youngest son, still unwed in his father's halls, who shares a bed with Telemachus at Pylos and drives him on by chariot to Sparta and back, a steady companion through the Telemachy's second half.

*Kin:* son of Nestor.

**Refs:** 3.36, 3.400–415, 3.454, 3.482, 4.155, 15.46–48, 15.131, 15.166.

*See also:* Nestor, Telemachus.

**Pelasgians** (Πελασγοί) · PEOPLE — Say: puh-LAZ-jee-unz

One of the several peoples of Crete named in Odysseus's account of that island's mixed population to Penelope.

**Refs:** 19.177.

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*See also:* Crete.

**Peleus** (Πηλεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* PEE-lee-us

Father of Achilles; in the underworld Achilles's ghost anxiously asks Odysseus for news of him, and Odysseus can only say he has heard nothing — a father's fate left open, unlike his son's, whose death and glory Odysseus can report in full.

*Kin:* father of Achilles.

**Refs:** 5.310, 8.75, 11.467–494 (Achilles's ghost), 11.505 (Odysseus has no news of him), 11.551–558, 24.15–36.

*See also:* Achilles, Neoptolemus.

**Pelias** (Πελιάς) · MORTAL — *Say:* PEE-lee-us or PEL-ee-us

Son of Tyro and Poseidon, twin of Neleus, who became king in Iolcus; named in Tyro's genealogy among the underworld shades.

*Kin:* son of Poseidon and Tyro; twin of Neleus.

**Refs:** 11.254–256.

*See also:* Neleus, Tyro.

**Pelion** (Πήλιον) · PLACE — *Say:* PEE-lee-on

The mountain of "shivering leaves" that the giants Otus and Ephialtes piled atop Ossa in their attempt to storm heaven.

**Refs:** 11.316.

*See also:* Ossa, Otus, Olympus.

**Penelope** (Πηνελόπεια) · MORTAL — *Say:* puh-NEL-uh-pee

Odysseus's wife, daughter of Icarius, who holds off 108 suitors for twenty years through grief, guile, and the unraveled weaving-trick, never certain her husband still lives. She tests the disguised beggar's knowledge of Odysseus, sets the axe-contest that only he can win, and — even after the suitors' deaths — makes Odysseus prove himself with the secret of their marriage-bed before she accepts him.

*Epithets:* "watchful-minded Penelope" (περίφρων Πηνελόπεια, 1.329); "steady-hearted Penelope" (ἑχέφρων Πηνελόπεια, 4.111).

*Also called:* "daughter of Icarius."

*Kin:* daughter of Icarius; wife of Odysseus; mother of Telemachus.

**Refs:** 1.223, 1.329, 4.111, 4.675–830 (learns of the ambush), 16.409–459, 18.159–285 (before the suitors) ...and throughout Books 1–2, 4–5, 11, 13–24.

*See also:* Odysseus, Telemachus, Icarius, Eurycleia.

**Periboea** (Περίβοια) · MORTAL — *Say:* per-ih-BEE-uh

Mother of Nausithous by Poseidon, named once in the Phaeacian royal genealogy Alcinous recites.

*Kin:* consort of Poseidon; mother of Nausithous.

**Refs:** 7.57.

*See also:* Nausithous, Poseidon.

**Periclymenus** (Περικλύμενος) · MORTAL — *Say:* per-ih-KLIM-uh-nus

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A son of Neleus, named among Nestor's brothers in Tyro's line of descendants seen in the underworld.

*Kin:* son of Neleus; brother of Nestor.

**Refs:** 11.286.

*See also:* Neleus, Nestor.

**Perimedes** (Περιμήδης) · MORTAL — *Say:* per-ih-MEE-deez

One of Odysseus's crewmen, steady at his side holding the sacrificial sheep during the underworld rite in Book 11 and named again performing the same office in Circe's instructions recalled in Book 12.

**Refs:** 11.23, 12.195.

*See also:* Odysseus.

**Pero** (Πηρώ) · MORTAL — *Say:* PEE-roh

Neleus's daughter, "a wonder of mortals," courted by every neighboring man; her father would give her only to whoever could drive off the cattle of mighty Iphicles, a feat her suitor Melampus's brother eventually undertakes.

*Kin:* daughter of Neleus.

**Refs:** 11.287.

*See also:* Neleus.

**Perse** (Πέρση) · GOD — *Say:* PUR-see

An Oceanid, daughter of Ocean, who bears Circe and Aeetes to Helios — named once in Circe's own genealogy as Odysseus's crew land on her island.

*Kin:* daughter of Ocean; consort of Helios; mother of Circe and Aeetes.

**Refs:** 10.139.

*See also:* Circe, Helios, Ocean.

**Persephone** (Περσεφόνη) · GOD — *Say:* pur-SEF-oh-nee

Queen of the dead, invoked alongside Hades in the underworld rite (11.47) and the power who marshals the ghosts of the great heroines to come drink the blood and speak with Odysseus (11.213–226). She is the one who could, if she chose, send the Gorgon's head against him — the fear that finally drives him from the underworld.

*Epithets:* "dread Persephone" (11.47, 10.491–564).

**Refs:** 10.491–564, 11.47, 11.213–226, 11.385, 11.634.

*See also:* Hades, the underworld.

**Perseus** (Περσεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* PUR-see-us

A son of Nestor, named among his brothers greeting Telemachus at Pylos.

*Kin:* son of Nestor.

**Refs:** 3.414, 3.444.

*See also:* Nestor.

**The Phaeacian competitors** · MORTAL

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The young Phaeacian noblemen — Acroneus, Ocyalus, Elatreus, Nauteus, Prymneus, Anchialus, Eretmeus, Ponteus, Proreus, Thoon, Anabesineus, Amphialus, Euryalus, and Alcinous's sons Laodamas, Halius, and Clytoneus among them — who rise together and compete in the running, wrestling, jumping, and discus at the Book 8 games.

**Refs:** 8.111–129.

*See also:* Alcinous, Laodamas, Phaeacians, Scheria.

**Phaeacians** (Φαίηκες) · PEOPLE — Say: fee-AY-shunz

The seafaring people of Scheria, ruled by Alcinous and Arete, and Odysseus's last hosts before Ithaca. Renowned above all peoples for shipcraft, they receive the shipwrecked stranger, stage the games and feast at which he tells his wanderings, and finally carry him home asleep aboard one of their crewless ships — the passage for which Poseidon punishes them by turning the returning ship to stone within sight of their own harbor.

*Epithets:* "the Phaeacians of the long oars, men famed for ships" (Φαίηκες δολιχήρετμοι, ναυσίκλυτοι ἄνδρες, 8.191).

**Refs:** 5.35, 6.3, 6.195, 7.11, 7.39, 8.5, 8.191, 8.386 ...and throughout. Books 5–8, 11, 13, 16, 19, 23.

*See also:* Alcinous, Arete, Nausicaa, Scheria, Poseidon.

**Phaedimus** · MORTAL — Say: FEE-dih-mus

King of Sidon in Phoenicia and a host of Menelaus on his travels; he gives Menelaus the silver mixing-bowl, rimmed with gold and the work of Hephaestus, that Menelaus later presents to Telemachus as a parting gift.

**Refs:** 4.617, 15.117.

*See also:* Menelaus, Phoenicia.

**Phaedra** · MORTAL — Say: FEE-druh or FAY-druh

A heroine whose shade Odysseus glimpses in the underworld's catalogue of famous women, named in the same line as Procris and Ariadne.

**Refs:** 11.321.

*See also:* Procris.

**Phaestus** (Φαιστός) · PLACE — Say: FEE-stus or FES-tus

A town on Crete, named as the place by whose reef Menelaus's fleet is wrecked on the voyage home from Troy.

**Refs:** 3.296.

**Phaethon** · OTHER — Say: FAY-uh-thon

One of the two colts, "Shiner" and "Blazer," that draw the chariot of Dawn; Athena holds him and his yoke-mate short of the sky when she prolongs the night of Odysseus and Penelope's reunion.

**Refs:** 23.246.

**Phaethusa** ("Shining") · GOD — Say: fay-uh-THOO-suh

One of the two nymphs, with her sister Lampetie, whom Helios sets to guard his cattle and sheep on Thrinacia.

*Kin:* daughter of Helios and Neaera.

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**Refs:** 12.132.

*See also:* Helios.

**Pharos** · PLACE — *Say:* FAIR-os or FAR-os

The island just off the mouth of Egypt where Poseidon becalms Menelaus's fleet for twenty days; there, guided by Eidothea, Menelaus ambushes and questions Proteus.

**Refs:** 4.355.

*See also:* Proteus, Menelaus.

**Pheae** · PLACE — *Say:* FEE-ee

A coastal town of the western Peloponnese, passed by Telemachus's ship on the night-sail back from Pylos.

**Refs:** 15.297.

**Pheidon** · MORTAL — *Say:* FY-don

King of the Thesprotians in the fictional wanderings Odysseus tells Eumaeus and, later, Penelope: he takes the castaway in without price, swears an oath over libation that the real Odysseus is alive and en route home with treasure, and has a ship readied for his passage.

**Refs:** 14.316, 19.287.

**Phemius** · MORTAL — *Say:* FEE-mee-us

Son of Terpes, the bard kept at the suitors' hall; the narrator twice stresses he sings for them "under compulsion." When Odysseus and Telemachus cut down the suitors, Phemius pleads for his life on that same ground and is spared.

*Also called:* "Terpes' son" (patronymic).

**Refs:** 1.154, 1.337, 17.262, 22.331.

*See also:* Telemachus.

**Pherae** · PLACE — *Say:* FEE-ree

A waypoint on the chariot road between Pylos and Sparta, where Telemachus and Peisistratus lodge with Diocles both going and returning; also the name of a separate Thessalian town, home of Eumelus.

**Refs:** 3.488, 4.798, 15.186.

**Pheres** · MORTAL — *Say:* FEE-reez

Son of Tyro and Cretheus, named among Tyro's sons in the underworld catalogue of heroines.

*Kin:* son of Tyro and Cretheus.

**Refs:** 11.259.

**Philoctetes** · MORTAL — *Say:* fil-ok-TEE-teez

The great archer of the Trojan War, son of Poias; Nestor confirms he came home safe, and Odysseus, boasting of his own skill with the bow, admits only Philoctetes surpassed him at Troy.

*Kin:* son of Poias.

**Refs:** 3.190, 8.219.

*See also:* Poias.

**Philoetius** · MORTAL — *Say:* fil-EE-tee-us



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The loyal cowherd, "a leader of men," who arrives on the household's last day driving cattle for the suitors' table. He reads through Odysseus's beggar-disguise to guess at a king in ruin, weeps over his master's bow, and once sworn to the cause bars the courtyard gates, arms himself, and kills the suitor Ctesippus with a spear-taunt answering Ctesippus's earlier ox-hoof insult.

**Refs:** 20.185, 20.227, 20.254, 21.193, 21.240, 21.388, 22.359.

*See also:* Eumaeus, Odysseus.

**Philomeleides** · MORTAL — *Say:* fil-oh-muh-LY-deez

King of Lesbos whom Odysseus once out-wrestled on a challenge, on the voyage back from Troy — a feat of strength Menelaus and, later, Odysseus's own disguise-tale each recall.

**Refs:** 4.343, 17.134.

**Phoenicia** · PLACE — *Say:* fih-NISH-uh

The Levantine trading coast, home of the Sidonians; source of the fine goods that pass through the poem's gift-economy, and also of the traders who steal Eumaeus as a child.

**Refs:** 4.83, 14.290.

*See also:* Phoenicians.

**Phoenicians** (Σιδώνιοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* fih-NISH-unz

The seafaring traders and slavers of Sidon. They bring fine goods to courts across the poem's world, and a treacherous Phoenician woman, nurse to Eumaeus's childhood household, sells him into slavery — the same people who deal honestly in luxury goods and dishonestly in people.

**Refs:** 13.272, 14.288, 15.415, 15.417, 15.419, 15.473.

*See also:* Phoenicia, Eumaeus.

**Phorcys** · GOD — *Say:* FOR-sis

A sea-god, "lord of the barren salt sea"; his daughter Thoosa lies with Poseidon and bears Polyphemus. Ithaca's principal harbor, where the Phaeacians set the sleeping Odysseus ashore, is called by his name, and the text twice describes it as belonging to "the old man of the sea" — a description of Phorcys, distinct from Proteus's own fixed epithet.

*Kin:* father of Thoosa (by whom Poseidon fathers Polyphemus).

**Refs:** 1.72, 13.96, 13.345.

*See also:* Polyphemus, Poseidon.

**Phronius** · MORTAL — *Say:* FROH-nee-us

Father of Noemon, the young Ithacan who lends Telemachus the ship for his voyage to Pylos.

*Kin:* father of Noemon.

**Refs:** 2.386, 4.630, 4.648.

**Phrontis** · MORTAL — *Say:* FRON-tis

Son of Onetor and Menelaus's helmsman, unmatched at steering a ship through storm-winds; Apollo kills him at the tiller off holy Sunium on the voyage from Troy, and Menelaus stops there to bury him.

*Also called:* "son of Onetor" (patronymic).

*Kin:* son of Onetor.

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**Refs:** 3.282.

*See also:* Menelaus.

**Phthia** · PLACE — *Say:* FTHY-uh or THY-uh

Achilles's homeland in Thessaly; in the underworld Odysseus tells Achilles's shade that his son is honored fully "through Hellas and Phthia."

**Refs:** 11.496.

*See also:* Achilles.

**Phylace** · PLACE — *Say:* fih-LAY-see

The town of Phylacus in the tale of the seer Melampus, who is held captive there a year for attempting to steal Iphicles's cattle before he is released and drives the herd to Pylos.

**Refs:** 11.291, 15.236.

*See also:* Phylacus.

**Phylacus** · MORTAL — *Say:* FIL-uh-kus

Lord of Phylace and owner of the cattle at the center of the Melampus tale; Melampus is imprisoned in his halls for a year before winning the herd.

**Refs:** 15.231.

*See also:* Phylace.

**Phylo** · MORTAL — *Say:* FY-loh

Helen's handmaid in Sparta, who brings her silver workbasket and wool when she joins Menelaus and their guests.

**Refs:** 4.125, 4.133.

*See also:* Helen.

**Pieria** · PLACE — *Say:* py-EER-ee-uh

The mountain over which Hermes swoops down from Olympus on his way to Calypso's island, Ogygia.

**Refs:** 5.50.

*See also:* Hermes, Calypso.

**Piraeus** · MORTAL — *Say:* py-REE-us

Son of Clytius and one of Telemachus's trusted companions on the voyage from Pylos; Telemachus entrusts him with Theoclymenus and his gifts, and Piraeus shelters and honors the seer through the poem's later books, receiving him again after Telemachus warns him off the perilous house.

*Epithets:* "famous for the spear" (δοῦρικλυτός, 15.544).

*Kin:* son of Clytius.

**Refs:** 15.539, 15.540, 15.544, 17.55, 17.71, 17.74, 17.78, 20.372.

*See also:* Theoclymenus, Telemachus.

**Planctae** · PLACE — *Say:* PLANK-tee

The Wandering (or Clashing) Rocks, the crashing hazard that only the Argo ever passed safely; Circe warns Odysseus off that route in favor of Scylla and Charybdis, and Odysseus later

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summarizes the choice for Penelope.

*Also called:* the Wandering Rocks; the Clashing Rocks.

**Refs:** 12.61, 23.327.

*See also:* Scylla, Charybdis, Circe.

**Poias** · MORTAL — Say: POH-yas

Father of the archer Philoctetes.

*Kin:* father of Philoctetes.

**Refs:** 3.190.

*See also:* Philoctetes.

**Polites** · MORTAL — Say: poh-LY-teez

A crewman of Odysseus, "closest and dearest" of all his companions, who first urges hailing the singer at the loom in the woods of Aeaea — the discovery that leads the men into Circe's house.

**Refs:** 10.224.

*See also:* Circe.

**Polybus** · MORTAL — Say: POL-ih-bus

The name covers four distinct men: Eurymachus's father, invoked throughout as "Polybus' son" (1.399, 16.345); a skilled Phaeacian craftsman who made the ball used in Alcinous's games (8.373); an Egyptian of Thebes, husband of Alcandre, who gives Helen her silver basket (4.126); and a suitor killed by Eumaeus in the hall-fight (22.243, 22.284).

**Refs:** 1.399, 4.126, 8.373, 16.345, 22.243, 22.284.

*See also:* Eurymachus.

**Polycaste** · MORTAL — Say: pol-ih-KAS-tee

Nestor's youngest daughter; she bathes and dresses Telemachus at Pylos, the guest-honor after which he rises "with the body of an immortal."

*Kin:* daughter of Nestor.

**Refs:** 3.464.

*See also:* Nestor.

**Polyctor** · MORTAL — Say: poh-LIK-tor

The name covers two men: one of the legendary founders of Ithaca, commemorated with Ithacus and Neritus in the fountain by the town's edge; and, separately, father of the suitor Peisander, named among the suitors' four best fighters.

**Refs:** 17.207, 18.299, 22.243.

**Polydamna** · MORTAL — Say: pol-ih-DAM-nuh

An Egyptian woman, wife of Thon, who gives Helen the potent grief-erasing drug she mixes into the wine at Sparta.

**Refs:** 4.228.

*See also:* Helen.

**Polydeuces** · MORTAL — Say: pol-ih-DYOO-seez

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The immortal twin, brother of Castor; seen by Odysseus in the underworld among Leda's sons, the pair share life and death turn about, a day each, an honor equal to the gods'.

*Kin:* son of Leda and Tyndareus; brother of Castor.

**Refs:** 11.300.

**Polypemon** · MORTAL — *Say:* pol-ih-PEE-mon

"Much-Suffering" — the invented grandfather in the fictitious genealogy Odysseus gives Laertes before revealing himself: Eperitus, son of Apheidas, son of Polypemon. The invented names, read for their etymology, spell out Odysseus's real story.

**Refs:** 24.305.

*See also:* Laertes.

**Polyphides** · MORTAL — *Say:* pol-ih-FY-deez

Seer son of Mantius; Apollo makes him a great prophet, and he fathers Theoclymenus.

*Kin:* son of Mantius; father of Theoclymenus.

**Refs:** 15.249, 15.252.

*See also:* Theoclymenus.

**Polyphemus** (Πολύφημος) · GOD — *Say:* pol-ih-FEE-mus

The one-eyed Cyclops, son of Poseidon and the nymph Thoosa. Odysseus and his men are trapped in his cave on the voyage home, and he devours several of them before Odysseus gets him drunk, blinds his single eye with a fire-hardened stake, and escapes lashed under the rams' bellies — tricking him first with the false name "Nobody." His dying curse, that Odysseus reach home late, ruined, and in another's ship, sets Poseidon's wrath in motion for the rest of the poem.

*Also called:* "the Cyclops"; deceived by "Nobody" (Οὔτις), Odysseus's alias.

*Kin:* son of Poseidon and Thoosa (daughter of Phorcys).

**Refs:** 1.69, 9.296, 9.319, 9.403, 9.407, 9.475, 9.502, 9.548. Books 1–2, 9–10, 12, 20, 23.

*See also:* Poseidon, Phorcys, Odysseus.

**Polythereses** · MORTAL — *Say:* pol-ih-THUR-seez

Father of the suitor Ctesippus; named only when Philoetius, having just killed his son, taunts the corpse as "son of Polythereses."

*Kin:* father of Ctesippus.

**Refs:** 22.287.

**Pontonous** · MORTAL — *Say:* pon-TON-oh-us

Alcinous's herald and wine-steward on Scheria, who mixes and serves the feast at the king's command and seats the disguised Odysseus among the guests.

**Refs:** 7.179, 7.182, 8.65, 13.50, 13.53.

*See also:* Alcinous.

**Poseidon** (Ποσειδῶν) · GOD — *Say:* poh-SY-dun

God of the sea and Odysseus's chief divine antagonist, brother of Zeus. Enraged when Odysseus blinds his son Polyphemus, he curses him to a late, ruined homecoming and spends the poem

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harrying him — wrecking his raft off Scheria, and, after the Phaeacians finally see him home, turning their returning ship to stone in sight of harbor as punishment for defying him. He is absent from the gods' council that frees Odysseus, visiting the Ethiopians, and is reconciled only after that final blow lands.

*Epithets:* "the earth-shaker" / "shaker of earth" (ἐνοσίχθων/έννοσίγαιος, 1.74); "who holds the earth" (γαίήοχος, 1.68); "with the blue-black hair" (κυανοχαίτης, 3.6).

*Kin:* son of Cronos, brother of Zeus; father of Polyphemus (by Thoosa) and, through Nausithous, ancestor of the Phaeacian royal line.

**Refs:** 1.20, 1.68, 1.74, 5.366, 8.322, 9.526, 9.528, 13.159, 23.234. Books 1, 3–9, 11, 13, 23–24.

*See also:* Polyphemus, Zeus, Phaeacians, Nausithous.

**Priam** · MORTAL — *Say:* PRY-am

King of Troy against whom the Achaeans fought for nine years and whose city they finally sacked — the war and its sack recur throughout the poem as the shared backdrop of every veteran's story; one of his daughters is glimpsed among the pitiful voices Odysseus hears in the underworld, and Athena invokes his fallen city to shame Odysseus into battle-rage before the suitor-fight.

**Refs:** 3.107, 3.130, 5.106, 11.421, 11.533, 13.316, 14.241, 22.230.

*See also:* Troy.

**Procris** · MORTAL — *Say:* PROK-ris

A heroine seen by Odysseus among the famous women of the underworld, named beside Phaedra and Ariadne.

**Refs:** 11.321.

*See also:* Phaedra.

**Proteus** (Πρωτεύς) · GOD — *Say:* PROH-tee-us

The shape-shifting sea-god of Egypt, Poseidon's seal-herding "under-servant." Menelaus, on Eidothea's advice, ambushes him disguised in sealskins and holds him fast through his transformations until he answers truly — the poem's one god forced bodily into telling the truth, who reveals the fates of the Achaean captains and Menelaus's own promised end in Elysium.

*Epithets:* "the unerring Old Man of the Sea" (γέρων ἄλιος νημερτής, 4.349).

**Refs:** 4.365, 4.385.

*See also:* Menelaus, Poseidon.

**Psyria** · PLACE — *Say:* SY-ree-uh

An islet in the eastern Aegean, weighed as a routing option — keeping it to the left, past Chios — when the fleet debates the crossing home from Troy.

**Refs:** 3.171.

**Pylians** · PEOPLE — *Say:* PY-lee-unz

Nestor's people, the folk of sandy Pylos; they crowd the shore for Poseidon's festival when Telemachus arrives, and Telemachus meets them again on his return leg.

**Refs:** 3.59, 15.216, 15.227.

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*See also:* Pylos, Nestor.

**Pylos** (Πύλος) · PLACE — Say: PY-los

Nestor's kingdom on the western Peloponnese, "sandy Pylos." Athena, disguised as Mentor, guides Telemachus there on the first leg of his search for news of his father; Nestor receives him at a beachside festival for Poseidon, tells his own homecoming and recalls Agamemnon's death, and sends him on to Sparta with Peisistratus. Telemachus passes through Pylos again on his voyage home, evading the suitors' ambush.

**Refs:** 1.93, 2.214, 3.4, 3.182, 3.485, 4.599, 15.193, 15.541. Books 1–5, 11, 13–17, 21, 24.

*See also:* Nestor, Pylians, Telemachus.

**Pyrphlegethon** · PLACE — Say: pir-ih-FLEJ-uh-thon

"Fire-blazing" — one of the underworld's rivers, a branch of the Styx that, with Cocytus, pours into Acheron at the rock where Circe directs Odysseus to make his offerings to the dead.

**Refs:** 10.513.

*See also:* Circe.

**Pytho** · PLACE — Say: PY-thoh

Delphi, seat of Apollo's oracle. Agamemnon consults it before Troy, in the prophecy Demodocus later sings, and it recurs as the site near which Apollo punishes Tityus for assaulting Leto on the road there.

**Refs:** 8.80, 11.581.

*See also:* Apollo.

**Rhadamanthus** · MORTAL — Say: rad-uh-MAN-thus

Fair-haired judge of the dead, dwelling at the world's edge in Elysium — the painless afterlife Proteus promises Menelaus for having married Helen. The Phaeacians once ferried him, in a single day, to visit the giant Tityus, proof of their ships' supernatural speed.

**Refs:** 4.564, 7.323.

*See also:* Menelaus, Proteus, Phaeacians.

**Rheithron** · PLACE — Say: REE-thron

The Ithacan harbor, under wooded Neion, where "Mentes" — Athena in disguise — says her ship lies at anchor.

**Refs:** 1.186.

*See also:* Athena.

**Rhexenor** · MORTAL — Say: rek-SEE-nor

Son of Nausithous and brother of Alcinous; he dies young, "still without a son," leaving his daughter Arete, whom Alcinous then marries.

*Kin:* son of Nausithous; brother of Alcinous; father of Arete.

**Refs:** 7.63, 7.64, 7.146.

*See also:* Alcinous, Arete, Nausithous.

**Rumor** (Ῥοσση) · GOD

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News personified, said to travel from Zeus and reach mortals with no visible source. Athena invokes her to Telemachus as one possible way to learn his father's fate; at the poem's close, Rumor herself runs through Ithaca's streets crying the suitors' slaughter.

*Also called:* Ossa.

**Refs:** 1.282, 2.216, 24.413.

*See also:* Zeus.

**Salmones** · MORTAL — *Say:* sal-MOH-nee-us

Father of Tyro, named when her shade introduces herself to Odysseus in the underworld.

*Kin:* father of Tyro.

**Refs:** 11.236.

**Same** · PLACE — *Say:* SAY-mee or SAH-mee

An island of Odysseus's Ithacan realm, also called Samos; grouped with Dulichium and Zacynthus in the poem's roll-call of his kingdom, it supplies twenty-four of the suitors, including the wealthy, lawless Ctesippus.

*Also called:* Samos.

**Refs:** 1.246, 9.24, 16.123, 16.249, 20.288.

*See also:* Ithaca, Ctesippus.

**Scheria** (Σχέρια) · PLACE — *Say:* SKEER-ee-uh

The Phaeacians' island, Odysseus's last stop before Ithaca. Athena calls it sea-ringed and set apart from other mortals at the world's edge — the setting of Books 6–13, where Nausicaa finds the shipwrecked stranger and Alcinous sends him home laden with gifts.

*Also called:* the land of the Phaeacians.

**Refs:** 5.34, 6.8, 7.79, 13.160.

*See also:* Alcinous, Nausicaa, Phaeacians.

**Scylla** (Σκύλλα) · GOD — *Say:* SIL-uh

A six-headed, twelve-footed monster lairing in a cliff-cave opposite Charybdis, daughter of Crataeis. Circe directs Odysseus to hug Scylla's crag rather than risk Charybdis's whirlpool; as the ship passes, Scylla snatches six companions from the deck — the poem's bitterest arithmetic, "far better to mourn six... than all together" (12.109–110).

*Kin:* daughter of Crataeis.

**Refs:** 12.85–101 (her lair and anatomy), 12.108–125 (Circe's counsel), 12.223–261 (the killing), 12.310, 12.430, 12.445, 23.328 (retold to Penelope).

*See also:* Charybdis, Circe, Odysseus.

**Scyros** (Σκύρος) · PLACE — *Say:* SKY-ros

The island where Achilles hid the young Neoptolemus; Odysseus recalls fetching the boy from there to fight at Troy, in his account to the shade of Achilles.

**Refs:** 11.509.

*See also:* Neoptolemus, Achilles.

**Sicania** (Σικανία) · PLACE — *Say:* sih-KAY-nee-uh

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Sicily, named as the edge of the known world in the last of Odysseus's false identities — the disguise he wears to test his father Laertes in Book 24.

**Refs:** 24.307.

*See also:* Sicilians, Laertes.

**Sicilians** (Σικελοί) · PEOPLE — Say: sih-SIL-yunz

The people of Sicania; the word also names a particular old servant of Laertes' household, a Sicilian slave-woman who tends him on his farm and helped raise Dolius's children.

**Refs:** 20.383 (suitors threaten to sell Theoclymenus and Piraeus to the Sicilians), 24.211, 24.366, 24.389.

*See also:* Laertes, Dolius.

**Sidon** (Σιδών) · PLACE — Say: SY-don

The Phoenician city; source of the silver mixing-bowl King Phaedimus gives Menelaus (4.615–619, 15.117–119), and, by her own account, the birthplace of the Phoenician nurse who kidnaps the child Eumaeus.

**Refs:** 13.285, 15.425.

*See also:* Sidonians, Eumaeus.

**Sidonians** (Σιδόνιοι) · PEOPLE — Say: sy-DOH-nee-unz

The people of Sidon in Phoenicia, famed for craftwork; Menelaus names their king Phaedimus as the giver of his finest guest-gift, a silver mixing-bowl "the work of Hephaestus."

**Refs:** 4.84, 4.618, 15.118.

*See also:* Sidon, Menelaus.

**Sintians** (Σίντιες) · PEOPLE — Say: SIN-tee-unz

The wild-tongued people of Lemnos to whom Ares withdraws after Hephaestus's snare exposes his affair with Aphrodite — named once, in passing, in Demodocus's song.

**Refs:** 8.294.

*See also:* Ares, Hephaestus, Aphrodite.

**Sirens** (Σειρῆνες) · GOD — Say: SY-runz

Two singers whose song promises knowledge and fame but lures listeners to a meadow heaped with the bones of the dead. On Circe's instruction Odysseus has his men bind him to the mast and stop their own ears with wax, so he alone hears the song and lives to tell it.

**Refs:** 12.39–52 (Circe's warning), 12.158–200 (the passage), 23.326 (retold to Penelope).

*See also:* Circe, Odysseus.

**Sisyphus** (Σίσυφος) · MORTAL — Say: SIS-ih-fus

One of the great sinners Odysseus sees punished in the underworld, condemned to shove a boulder up a slope forever, only to watch it roll back down each time he nears the crest.

**Refs:** 11.593–598.

*See also:* Tantalus, Tityus.

**Solymi** (Σόλυμοι) · PEOPLE — Say: SOL-ih-my



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An eastern people whose hills give Poseidon, returning from the Ethiopians, his vantage point for spotting Odysseus's raft near Scheria — the sighting that triggers the storm of Book 5.

**Refs:** 5.283.

*See also:* Poseidon.

**Sparta** (Σπάρτη) · PLACE

Menelaus's city in Lacedaemon; Telemachus's second stop on his journey, after Pylos, where Menelaus and Helen tell him of Proteus's report on Odysseus, and where Peisistratus escorts him there and back.

**Refs:** 1.93, 2.214, 4.10 (Menelaus's wedding-feast), 11.460, 13.412 (Athena's errand to fetch Telemachus).

*See also:* Menelaus, Helen, Telemachus.

**Spinners** (Κλωθεε) · GOD

"Destiny and the grave Spinners" — personified Fates who spin a man's thread at birth. Alcinous invokes them once, promising Odysseus safe passage only as far as the beach; what happens after is theirs, already spun.

*Also called:* the Fates.

**Refs:** 7.197.

*See also:* Zeus.

**Stratius** (Στράτιος) · MORTAL — *Say:* STRAT-ee-us

One of Nestor's sons at Pylos, present at the sacrifice to Athena that opens Telemachus's visit; he and Echephron lead the sacrificial heifer by the horns.

*Kin:* son of Nestor, brother of Peisistratus and Thrasymedes.

**Refs:** 3.413, 3.439.

*See also:* Nestor, Thrasymedes.

**Styx** (Στύξ) · PLACE — *Say:* STIKS

The river of the underworld by which the gods swear their most binding oath. Calypso swears by "the down-dripping water of Styx" that she means Odysseus no harm; Circe cites it among the gods' great oaths.

**Refs:** 5.185, 10.514.

*See also:* Calypso, Circe.

**Sunium** (Σοῦνιον) · PLACE — *Say:* SOO-nee-um

The Attic headland where Apollo's "gentle arrows" strike down Phrontis, Menelaus's helmsman, delaying the fleet's homeward voyage — from Nestor's telling of the Returns.

**Refs:** 3.278.

*See also:* Menelaus, Nestor.

**Syrie** (Συρία) · PLACE — *Say:* SEE-ree

Eumaeus's home island, said to lie "above Ortygia, where the turnings of the sun are" — a near-paradise of no famine and no sickness, where he was born a prince before Phoenician traders and his own nurse sold him into slavery.

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**Refs:** 15.403.

*See also:* Eumaeus.

**Tantalus** (Τάνταλος) · MORTAL — *Say:* TAN-tuh-lus

Punished in the underworld by hunger and thirst that can never be satisfied: the water recedes when he stoops to drink, the fruit lifts out of reach when he grasps for it. Odysseus sees him among the great sinners.

**Refs:** 11.582–589.

*See also:* Sisyphus, Tityus.

**Taphians** (Τάφιοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* TAF-ee-unz

Seafarers and slave-raiders of the island Taphos; their chief Mentès is the shape Athena wears to visit Telemachus in Book 1, and Taphian pirates are blamed for an old raid on the Thesprotians that once brought Eupèithes to Ithaca as a fugitive.

**Refs:** 1.105 (Athena as Mentès), 1.181, 1.419, 14.452, 15.427, 16.426 (Eupèithes' history).

*See also:* Mentès, Taphos, Athena.

**Taphos** (Τάφος) · PLACE — *Say:* TAF-os

The island home of the Taphian seafarers, and of Mentès, the guise Athena takes to visit Telemachus.

**Refs:** 1.417.

*See also:* Taphians, Mentès.

**Taygetus** (Ταῦγετος) · PLACE — *Say:* tay-IJ-uh-tus

A mountain of Laconia, named in the simile that compares Nausicaa among her handmaids to Artemis hunting "down long Taygetus" among her nymphs.

**Refs:** 6.103.

*See also:* Nausicaa, Artemis.

**Telamon** (Τελαμών) · MORTAL — *Say:* TEL-uh-mon

Father of the greater Ajax, named only by patronymic when Odysseus meets his son's unforgiving shade in the underworld.

*Kin:* father of Ajax.

**Refs:** 11.543, 11.553.

*See also:* Ajax.

**Telemachus** (Τηλέμαχος) · MORTAL — *Say:* tuh-LEM-uh-kus

Odysseus's son, an infant when his father sailed for Troy, and the poem's other protagonist, who comes of age across its length. Sore at heart among the suitors in Book 1, he is roused by Athena to call an assembly and sail to Pylos and Sparta for news of his father; he returns in time to help hide the hall's weapons, spring the trap on the suitors, and fight at Odysseus's side through the slaughter and the final peace.

*Epithets:* "clear-headed Telemachus" (Τηλέμαχος πεπνυμένος, 1.213); "godlike Telemachus" (Τηλέμαχος θεοειδής, 1.113).

*Kin:* son of Odysseus and Penelope.

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**Refs:** 1.113 (first named), 1.345–359 ("mine is the power in this house"), 2.1–14 (calls the assembly), 3.14ff (Pylos), 4.1ff (Sparta), 16.155–234 (reunion with his father), 19.1–52 (hides the arms), 22.90ff (fights in the hall), 24.505–515 (armed beside his father) ...and throughout. Books 1–24.

*See also:* Odysseus, Penelope, Athena, Mentor.

**Telemus** (Τήλεμος) · MORTAL — *Say:* TEL-uh-mus

Son of Eurymus, a seer among the Cyclopes who long ago foretold that Odysseus would blind

Polyphemus — a prophecy Polyphemus recalls, too late, as Odysseus's ship pulls away.

*Also called:* son of Eurymus.

**Refs:** 9.509.

*See also:* Polyphemus.

**Telephus** (Τήλεφος) · MORTAL — *Say:* TEL-uh-fus

Father of Eurypylus, the Mysian hero Odysseus tells Achilles's shade about, killed at Troy fighting on the Trojan side.

*Kin:* father of Eurypylus.

**Refs:** 11.519.

*See also:* Eurypylus, Achilles.

**Telepylus** (Τηλέπυλος) · PLACE — *Say:* tuh-LEP-ih-lus

The Laestrygonian stronghold, city of King Lamus, where the giant cannibals destroy all of Odysseus's ships but one, spearing his men in the harbor like fish.

**Refs:** 10.82, 23.318 (retold to Penelope).

*See also:* Laestrygonians.

**Temese** (Τεμέση) · PLACE — *Say:* TEM-uh-see

The copper-trading port Athena, disguised as Mentès, claims to be sailing toward with a cargo of iron — a rare glimpse of the poet's own Iron Age trade inside the poem's Bronze Age fiction.

**Refs:** 1.184.

*See also:* Mentès, Taphians.

**Tenedos** (Τένεδος) · PLACE — *Say:* TEN-uh-dos

The island off Troy where the homeward-bound Greeks first put in and sacrifice, in Nestor's account of the fleet's disastrous, divided departure.

**Refs:** 3.159.

*See also:* Nestor, Troy.

**Terpes** (Τέρπης) · MORTAL — *Say:* TUR-peeZ

Father of Phemius, the Ithacan singer forced to perform for the suitors; named only by patronymic as Phemius pleads for his life before Odysseus in the slaughter.

*Also called:* Terpius.

*Kin:* father of Phemius.

**Refs:** 22.330.

*See also:* Phemius.

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### **Thebes** (Θῆβαι) · PLACE

Two cities share the name in the poem: Boeotian Thebes of the seven gates, founded by Amphion and Zethus and later ruled by Oedipus, and the site of Amphiaraus's death; and Egyptian Thebes of the hundred gates, the fabulously wealthy city of Alcandre and Polybus, source of a silver basket given to Helen. Tiresias, whom Odysseus consults in the underworld, is repeatedly called "the Theban."

**Refs:** 4.126 (Egyptian Thebes), 11.165, 11.263–275 (Boeotian Thebes founded), 12.267, 15.247 (Amphiaraus), 23.323 (Tiresias "the Theban").

*See also:* Tiresias, Zethus, Amphiaraus.

### **Themis** (Θέμις) · GOD — Say: THEM-is

Goddess of order and assembly, who "seats and dissolves" the gatherings of men; Telemachus swears by her, alongside Zeus, when he begs the Ithacan assembly for a fair hearing.

**Refs:** 2.68.

*See also:* Zeus, Telemachus.

### **Theoclymenus** (Θεοκλύμενος) · MORTAL — Say: thee-oh-KLIM-uh-nus or thee-oh-KLY-men-us

A fugitive seer, great-grandson of Melampus, who has killed a man in Argos and begs passage on Telemachus's ship at Pylos. He accompanies Telemachus home, reads a hawk-and-dove omen as proof that Odysseus's line will rule Ithaca, and later, at the height of the suitors' feasting, sees a vision of blood and death that the suitors laugh off.

*Epithets:* "godlike Theoclymenus" (Θεοκλύμενος θεοειδής, 15.271).

**Refs:** 15.256–286 (meets Telemachus), 15.508–534 (the hawk omen), 17.151 (prophecy to Penelope), 20.350–363 (the vision of doom).

*See also:* Telemachus, Melampus.

### **Theseus** (Θησεύς) · MORTAL — Say: THEE-see-us

The Athenian hero, named twice in the underworld's catalogue of the illustrious dead: once as the man who carried off Ariadne and lost her to Artemis, once among the "glorious children of the gods" Odysseus hoped, but failed, to see.

**Refs:** 11.322, 11.631.

*See also:* Ariadne, Pirithous.

### **Thesprotians** (Θεσπρωτοί) · PEOPLE — Say: thes-PROH-shunz

The mainland people, and land, that Odysseus repeatedly invents as the setting of his most recent adventures in the false tales he tells on Ithaca — claiming news there of a living, treasure-laden Odysseus about to sail home under King Pheidon's escort.

**Refs:** 14.315–316, 14.334, 16.65, 17.526, 19.271, 19.287–291 (the fullest telling, to Penelope).

*See also:* Odysseus, Penelope.

### **Thetis** (Θέτις) · GOD — Say: THEE-tis or THET-is

Sea-goddess, mother of Achilles; Agamemnon's shade recalls her rising from the sea with her sister Nereids to mourn her son and set out the funeral games' prizes.

*Kin:* mother of Achilles.

**Refs:** 24.92.

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*See also:* Achilles.

**Thoas** (Θόας) · MORTAL — *Say:* THOH-as

Son of Andraemon, a warrior Odysseus invents as a companion in the false night-ambush tale he tells Eumaeus.

*Also called:* son of Andraemon.

**Refs:** 14.499.

*See also:* Eumaeus.

**Thon** (Θών) · MORTAL — *Say:* THON

The Egyptian husband of Polydamna, who gave Helen the drugs "that undo grief and anger" — the nepenthe she mixes into the wine at Sparta.

*Kin:* husband of Polydamna.

**Refs:** 4.228.

*See also:* Helen.

**Thoosa** (Θόωσα) · GOD — *Say:* thoh-OH-suh

A sea-nymph, daughter of Phorcys, who bore Polyphemus to Poseidon in her sea-caves — the reason Poseidon's grudge against Odysseus, for blinding his son, runs so deep.

*Kin:* daughter of Phorcys; mother of Polyphemus by Poseidon.

**Refs:** 1.71–73.

*See also:* Polyphemus, Poseidon.

**Thrace** (Θρήικη) · PLACE

The northern land Ares flees to after Hephaestus's snare exposes his affair with Aphrodite — named once, in Demodocus's song.

**Refs:** 8.361.

*See also:* Ares, Cicones.

**Thrasymedes** (Θρασυμήδης) · MORTAL — *Say:* thras-ih-MEE-deez

A son of Nestor at Pylos; he sits beside his father and brother Peisistratus when Telemachus arrives, and strikes the axe-blow at the sacrifice to Athena the next morning.

*Kin:* son of Nestor, brother of Peisistratus and Stratius.

**Refs:** 3.39, 3.414, 3.442, 3.448.

*See also:* Nestor, Stratius.

**Thrinacia** (Θρινακίη) · PLACE — *Say:* thrih-NAY-shuh

The island of Helios's sacred cattle, guarded by his daughters Phaethusa and Lampetie. Both Tiresias and Circe warn Odysseus to leave the herds untouched; his starving crew kill them anyway, and Zeus destroys the ship for it — the disaster that leaves Odysseus alone.

**Refs:** 11.107 (Tiresias's warning), 12.127–137 (Circe's warning), 19.275 (recounted to Penelope).

*See also:* Helios, Tiresias, Circe.

**Thyestes** (Θυέστης) · MORTAL — *Say:* thy-ES-teez

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Brother of Atreus and father of Aegisthus; blown off course, Menelaus lands by chance at the border of the country that was once Thyestes' — now Aegisthus's — on the very day of Agamemnon's murder.

*Kin:* brother of Atreus; father of Aegisthus.

**Refs:** 4.517–518.

*See also:* Aegisthus, Atreus, Agamemnon.

**Tiresias** (Τειρεσίας) · MORTAL — Say: ty-REE-see-us

The blind seer whose ghost, alone among the dead, keeps his understanding after drinking the sacrificial blood in the underworld. He gives Odysseus the poem's central prophecy: the danger from Poseidon, the warning about Thrinacia's cattle, the slaughter of the suitors to come, and a strange final journey inland with an oar, ending in a "gentle" death from the sea.

*Also called:* "the Theban."

**Refs:** 10.492, 10.524–540 (Circe sends him there), 11.90–151 (the prophecy), 12.267, 23.251–284, 23.323 (retold to Penelope).

*See also:* Odysseus, Circe, Thrinacia.

**Tithonus** (Τιθωνός) · MORTAL — Say: tih-THOH-nus

The mortal husband of Dawn, granted endless life but not endless youth; the book of Odysseus's shipwreck near Scheria opens with Dawn rising from his bed, a pointed frame for the immortality Calypso has just been ordered to give up.

*Kin:* husband of Dawn (Eos).

**Refs:** 5.1.

*See also:* Calypso.

**Tityus** (Τιτυός) · MORTAL — Say: TIT-ee-us

A giant, son of Earth, punished in the underworld for assaulting Leto: he lies sprawled over nine acres while two vultures forever tear at his liver. Alcinous also cites him as proof of how far the Phaeacians' ships can sail in a day.

*Kin:* son of Earth (Gaia).

**Refs:** 7.324 (Alcinous's boast), 11.576–581 (his punishment).

*See also:* Leto.

**Trojans** (Τρῶες) · PEOPLE

The people of Troy, the Achaeans' enemy in the ten-year war underlying the whole poem; they recur throughout the recollections of Nestor, Menelaus, and Helen, and in Odysseus's own tales of the horse and the sack.

**Refs:** 1.237, 3.85–100, 4.243–275 (Helen's and Menelaus's dueling tales), 8.503–520 (the wooden horse), 11.383–547 (the underworld), 22.228, 24.27–38 (Agamemnon's shade).

*See also:* Troy, Achaeans, Helen.

**Troy** (Τροίη) · PLACE

The sacked city, also called Ilium, whose ten-year siege and fall stand behind the whole poem: the war Odysseus and the other Achaean leaders fought, and the wreck of homecomings it produced. The poem opens with its sack (1.2); the Apologoi, the underworld, the Telemachy,

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and Demodocus's songs all keep returning to it, and Penelope names it, in her own coinage, "Evil-Ilium, never to be named" (19.260, 597).

*Also called:* Ilium.

**Refs:** 1.2, 2.172, 3.130ff (Nestor's Returns), 4.99, 8.499–520 (Demodocus's horse-song), 9.39, 11.169 (Anticleia), 24.27ff ...and throughout. Books 1–24 *passim*.

*See also:* Trojans, Achaeans, Agamemnon, Menelaus.

**Tydeus** (Τυδεύς) · MORTAL — Say: TY-dee-us

Father of Diomedes, named only by the patronymic "son of Tydeus" as Nestor and Menelaus recall him among the Achaean leaders at Troy and inside the wooden horse.

*Kin:* father of Diomedes.

**Refs:** 3.167, 4.280.

*See also:* Diomedes.

**Tyndareus** (Τυνδάρω) · MORTAL — Say: tin-DAIR-ee-us

The mortal husband of Leda; in the underworld's catalogue of heroines she is named as his wife and, by him, the mother of Castor and Polydeuces. Agamemnon's shade later calls Clytemnestra "the daughter of Tyndareus" in bitter contrast to Penelope.

*Kin:* husband of Leda; father, in the poem, of Castor and Polydeuces.

**Refs:** 11.298–299, 24.199.

*See also:* Leda, Clytemnestra.

**Tyro** (Τυρώ) · MORTAL — Say: TY-roh

Daughter of Salmoneus, who fell in love with the river Enipeus; Poseidon took the river's shape to lie with her, and she bore him Pelias and Neleus — making her, through Neleus, ancestress of Nestor's whole line. Antinous cites her among the legendary women whose cunning still falls short of Penelope's.

*Kin:* daughter of Salmoneus; mother of Pelias and Neleus by Poseidon.

**Refs:** 2.120 (Antinous's comparison), 11.235–259 (her story in full).

*See also:* Poseidon, Nestor.

**Winds** (Ἄνεμοι) · GOD

The four winds appear both as ordinary weather and, at key moments, as personified agents:

Aeolus's bagged winds, the storm Poseidon raises against Odysseus's raft, the squall that wrecks the crew off Thrinacia. Athena can still their courses or rouse a single fair one at will.

*Also called:* Boreas (North Wind), Notos (South Wind), Euros (East Wind), Zephyrus (West Wind).

**Refs:** 5.295–332 (Poseidon's storm, all four at once), 9.67, 10.25 (Aeolus's bag), 12.325–426 (Thrinacia), 14.253, 19.200 ...and throughout. Books 2–5, 7, 9–10, 12–14, 19.

*See also:* Aeolus, Poseidon, Athena.

**Zacynthus** (Ζάκυνθος) · PLACE — Say: zuh-SIN-thus

A wooded island of Odysseus's realm, named among Ithaca's neighbors and among the islands whose leading men count themselves Penelope's suitors.

**Refs:** 1.246, 9.24, 16.123, 19.131.

## INDEX OF NAMES AND PLACES

*See also:* Ithaca, Dulichium, Same.

**Zethus** (Ζῆθος) · MORTAL — *Say:* ZEE-thus

Son of Zeus and Antiope; with his brother Amphion he founded and walled seven-gated Thebes.

He is also, in Penelope's nightingale simile, the father of Itylus, the son his wife killed by mistake — the myth Penelope reaches for to describe her own divided heart.

*Kin:* son of Zeus and Antiope; brother of Amphion.

**Refs:** 11.262–263, 19.523.

*See also:* Thebes, Amphion.

**Zeus** (Ζεύς) · GOD — *Say:* ZOOS

Father of gods and men, and the poem's guarantor of xenia, oaths, and the plot's overall justice.

He opens the poem musing on Aegisthus as proof that mortals bring ruin on themselves

"beyond their portion" (1.32–43), approves Athena's plan to bring Odysseus home, restrains

Poseidon's grudge within limits, and at the end sanctions both the killing of the suitors and the amnesty that follows.

*Epithets:* "Zeus who gathers the clouds" (νεφεληγερέτα Ζεύς, 1.63); "Zeus of the wide voice"

(εὐρύοπα Ζεύς, 2.146); "(Zeus) who thunders on high" (ὕψιβρεμέτης, 5.4); "aegis-bearing Zeus"

(αἰγιόχοιο Διός, 3.42).

*Also called:* "son of Cronos" / "Cronion" — but "Cronos" alone names the Titan father, per canon.

*Kin:* son of Cronos; father of Athena, Apollo, Artemis, Hermes, Aphrodite (here by Dione), Ares.

**Refs:** 1.28–43 (Aegisthus speech), 1.63–79 (council on Odysseus), 5.21–42 (dispatches Hermes),

12.415–419 (destroys the ship), 13.128–158 (Poseidon and the Phaeacian ship), 24.477–486

(sanctions the peace) ...and throughout. Books 1–24.

*See also:* Athena, Poseidon, Hera.